

Edited by

M. ASADUDDIN

PREMCHAND

the complete short stories

VOLUME 3



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the complete short stories VOLUME 3

Edited with an Introduction by M. Asaduddin

Translated from the Hindi and Urdu by M. Asaduddin and others

Foreword by Harish Trivedi



PENGUIN BOOKS

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PENGUIN BOOKS

THE COMPLETE SHORT STORIES: VOLUME 3

Premchand (1880–1936), considered one of the greatest fiction writers in Hindi, was born Dhanpat Rai in Lamahi, a small village near Benares. He wrote in Urdu under the name Nawab Rai and changed it to Premchand when his collection of short stories, *Soz-e Watan*, was seized for sedition in 1909. In a prolific career spanning three decades, Premchand wrote fourteen novels, two plays, almost 300 short stories and several articles, reviews and editorials. He edited four journals, and also set up his own printing press. Though best known for his stories exposing the horrors of poverty and social injustice, he wrote on a variety of themes with equal felicity—romance, satire, social dramas, nationalist tales, and yarns steeped in folklore.

M. Asaduddin is an author, critic and translator in several languages. His books include *Premchand in World Languages: Translation, Reception and Cinematic Representations*; *Filming Fiction: Tagore, Premchand and Ray*; *A Life in Words*; *The Penguin Book of Classic Urdu Stories*; *Lifting the Veil: Selected Writings of Ismat Chughtai*; *For Freedom's Sake: Manto*; and (with Mushirul Hasan) *Image and Representation: Stories of Muslim Lives in India*. He has been a Fulbright Scholar-in-Residence at Rutgers University, New Jersey, USA, and a Charles Wallace Trust Fellow at the British Centre for Literary Translation at the University of East Anglia, Norwich, UK. He is a regular speaker at literary festivals, and his translations have been recognized with the Sahitya Akademi Award, and the Katha and A.K. Ramanujan awards for translation, as well as the Crossword Book Award.

Advance Praise for the Volumes

‘Not having access to all of Premchand’s stories has always been a cause of frustration to his readers. The publication now of the entire, admittedly huge, corpus of his short stories is very welcome. Premchand—in spite of occasional challenges—remains a true colossus of Indian literature. The sheer variety, with its hypnotic power, and the vastness of his output is staggering. It is impossible to arrive at any kind of assessment of modern Indian literature without taking full account of Premchand. Then, his fiction as a living source and commentary on the social, political and rural India of the early part of the twentieth century is valuable and relevant even today. These four volumes deserve a place on the bookshelf of every lover of modern fiction, in India or elsewhere’

SHAMSUR RAHMAN FARUQI
well-known critic, poet and novelist in Urdu

‘Premchand’s fiction draws from his vast experience of the conflicts of village life, of caste tensions, of excessive revenue demands and the never-ending chain of debts entailed by these. If these are grim tales, they are both deepened and lightened by his psychological insight, his irony and humour, and the broad canvas on which they are drawn, which links country and city in a manner unknown in Hindi–Urdu fiction writing before him. To present this rich corpus, drawn exhaustively from both Urdu and Hindi originals, the vast majority made available in English for the first time, is a pioneering feat for which the translators are to be congratulated’

VASUDHA DALMIA
professor emerita of Hindi and Modern South Asian Studies, University of California, Berkeley

‘At once an extraordinary feat of scholarship and an immense labour of love, this collection gives us the complete corpus of Premchand’s short stories in English translation for the first time. It thus allows readers without access to either or both of Premchand’s languages of composition, Urdu and Hindi, insight into one of the greatest writers of India’s modernity—indeed, into the making of modern India. Most importantly, as the rich and informative Introduction to this translation states, the stories bear witness to Premchand’s “secular and inclusive” view of the Indian nation. Premchand’s socialism, his realism, his role in the fashioning of a modern prose style in two languages, his searing insights into caste and gender politics, his sympathy for the oppressed, for the labouring poor, even for working animals, make him a writer from whom we still have much to learn. If this remarkable collaborative enterprise brilliantly led by M. Asaduddin helps us to do so, its purpose will be served’

SUPRIYA CHAUDHURI
professor emerita, Department of English, Jadavpur University, Kolkata

‘It is a valuable work, especially for foreign readers who cannot read the original text in Hindi or Urdu. This complete translation of Premchand’s short stories must be welcomed as a major contribution to the accessibility to modern Indian literature. Being considered one of the foundational figures of modern Indian literature, Premchand deserves this kind of ambitious work on him, which will find him his rightful place in world literature’

PHILIPPE BENOÎT
Sanskritist and professor of Bengali, National Institute for Oriental Languages and Civilizations, Paris

‘Premchand is one of the most famous—perhaps the most famous—Hindi authors. Many of his short stories have been translated into a wide array of languages. And yet, when one looks at these selections it appears that the translators tended to choose a particular set of stories regarded as

Premchand's masterpieces, ignoring the rest. The present collection aims to present the full picture, displaying Premchand at different stages of his life, in different moods, displaying changing attitudes with regard to the functionality of literature. For the first time, readers of English will be able to appreciate Premchand's story-telling in all its facets and fullness'

CHRISTINA OESTERHELD
professor of Urdu, University of Heidelberg, Germany

'Premchand was greatly popular with an earlier generation of Russian readers. This anthology will certainly enhance his visibility to an international audience and make him popular with the new generation of Russian readers and scholars of Indian literature'

GUZEL STRELKOVA
professor of Hindi, Moscow State University, Moscow

For
Jamia Millia Islamia,
a university that has nurtured composite culture, secular nationalism and pluralism for 100 years

Foreword

During the birth centenary celebrations of Premchand (1880–1936), he was described as one of the *panch devata,* that is, one of the five gods, or (to put it more plausibly in English and also perhaps a bit more secularly!) one of the five iconic figures of modern Indian literature.[1] This was high praise indeed, for each one of the twenty-four languages of India which are recognized and honoured by the Sahitya Akademi can boast of several outstanding writers in the modern period. The foremost of these probably still is Rabindranath Tagore, best known for his lyrical and transcendentally spiritual poetical works and, of course, for being the first, and so far the only, Indian to win the Nobel Prize for literature. But of those following behind him, Premchand stands as tall as any other writer.

Premchand wrote in both Urdu and Hindi, which made him an inheritor of two distinct literary traditions and also gave him a far wider readership than writers in other languages could aspire to. He wrote in the popular genres of the novel and the short story, and he practised a simple and candid style which had a direct emotive effect. He set his fiction in both cities and villages, often bringing the two Indias into poignant juxtaposition, most pointedly in his last novel, *Godaan* (1936), and in other novels and numerous short stories too throughout his career. After experimenting early in his career with a few short stories set in the historical past (which he used allegorically for a present patriotic purpose), he wrote as a rule on contemporary themes of immediate social and political relevance. He marched with the times, responding to successive waves of public events and movements with a creative openness that wasn't bound by blind allegiance to any ideology. The scope of his understanding and the range of his sympathies were wide enough to encompass each aspect of the impact of colonial rule and of the nationalist movement for freedom in its many

dimensions. His heart beat with the heart of the nation. As the Marxist Hindi critic Namwar Singh says:

> Premchand was the unique epic-chronicler [*maha-gathakar*] of our struggle for freedom and it will be no exaggeration to say that he occupies in this regard an unrivalled place in the whole of Indian literature. If one wanted to find in any one Indian writer the very pulse of Indian life, its struggles and its setbacks, its sorrows and its anguish, in all their depth and all their wide scope, over a period of three decades right from the Partition of Bengal in 1905–06 up to 1936, when he passed away, then, notwithstanding the fact that we have Rabindranath Tagore, we have Sarat Chandra, we have Subrahmanya Bharati, we have V.S. Khandelkar, we have Kanhaiyalal Maniklal Munshi, and we have as well Dr Mohammad Iqbal, I would like to name Premchand, for he is the one writer we have in whose works the immortal saga of our struggle for independence has been narrated in all its fullness.[2]

And yet, it would be to underestimate Premchand to think of him only, or even primarily, as a chronicler of what was perhaps the most vitally transformative phase in the history of modern India. For he was, like a true artist, concerned first and foremost with human beings and the daily, ordinary lives they led. If these lives were impacted by larger historical forces, as indeed they inescapably were, Premchand's focus remained on the human characters rather more than on the forces shaping them, and it was in this indirectness that the greatness of his achievement lies. His eventful narratives of the nation were above all else compassionate tales of humanity.

Life and Times: Sedition and 'Premchand'

Premchand was born in Lamahi, a village which now stands virtually on the outskirts of Benares, of Kayastha parents, which meant that he would culturally be more inclined to Urdu than Hindi. His mother died when he was eight, his father remarried shortly afterwards, and Premchand first went to school in Gorakhpur where his father, a postal clerk, was then posted. Premchand's real name was Dhanpat Rai Shrivastav, but he was fondly called Nawab, a prince, and he published his early writings under the name 'Nawab Rai'. In his early teens he read voraciously *Tilism Hoshruba* (in Urdu, published from 1883 onwards in numerous volumes amounting to

thousands of pages) and similar *dastaan* tales of what may now be called the old school of Arabian magic realism.

Premchand passed his matriculation examination (class 10) in 1898, and began a long career as a teacher and school administrator, during which he passed as a 'private' or non-formal candidate the Intermediate examination (class 12) in 1916 and the BA in 1919, with English literature, Persian and history as his subjects. In 1921, he resigned government service at the call of Gandhi during the Non-Cooperation Movement. He had, between 1915 and 1924, moved away from Urdu to begin writing in Hindi which Gandhi had in 1918 declared to be the *rashtra bhasha*, the national language. During the salt satyagraha called by Gandhi in 1930, his (second) wife, Shivrani Devi, courted arrest and spent two months in jail. In 1923 Premchand had bought a press and started the publishing house Saraswati Press but in the absence of a regular income, he served two stints as the editor of the Hindi journal *Madhuri* in Lucknow, in 1924–25 and again from 1927 to 1932. Meanwhile, he started a journal of his own, *Hans* (The Swan, vehicle of Saraswati, the muse of literature), in 1930, and then taken over another journal, *Jagaran* (Awakening), in 1932. Premchand returned to Benares to spend the last four years of his life back in Lamahi where he had built a bigger pukka house which still stands, and from where he commuted to his press in Benares. On 8 October 1936, at the age of fifty-six, he died of a stomach ailment that had long afflicted him. He had published in Urdu and Hindi thirteen novels, including one left unfinished, and what are now reckoned to be close to 300 short stories.[3]

At least four novels by Premchand are counted as being among the greatest written in Hindi: *Sevasadan* (1919; The Abode of Service), *Rangbhumi* (1925; tr. as *The Playground*), *Karmabhumi* (1932; Field of Action), and *Godaan* (1936; tr. as *Godaan* and also as *The Gift of a Cow).* It has long been a matter of debate whether Premchand was a greater novelist than a short story writer and, though scholars may prefer the weightier and more complex novels, popular opinion has favoured the more accessible and immediately affective short stories. A brief account is given below of a

few highlights and turning points in Premchand's career as a short story writer.

Premchand published his first collection of five short stories in 1908, *Soz-e Watan* (in Urdu: The Dirge of the Nation), and it met with an unexpectedly hot reception. The stories were all patriotic, which the British government promptly interpreted to be seditious, and Premchand, who was then serving as a sub-deputy inspector of schools, was summoned to appear before the district magistrate who asked him to confirm that he was the author of the book which had been published under his pen name 'Nawab Rai', told him to burn all the copies and never to write anything like that again. He then added, 'Thank your stars that you are a servant of the British Empire. Had these been Mughal times, both your hands would have been chopped off.'[4] What was chopped off, however, was the name 'Nawab Rai', and it was then that the new pen name 'Premchand' was born, under the oppressive shadow of British censorship and as a subterfuge against its vigilance. This was only the first of Premchand's many brushes with authority, for in the 1930s he was required time and again to deposit a security of Rs 1000 at the slightest whiff of sedition in anything that he published in his two journals.

Urdu and Hindi

A more significant turning point came when Premchand decided to change his linguistic horses in midstream and cross over from writing in Urdu to writing in Hindi. This profound makeover began in 1914 and, through a long and assiduous process, culminated in 1924, when Premchand revised and rewrote his Urdu novel *Chaugan-e Hasti* (Life as a Game) in Hindi as *Rangbhumi* (1925; The Playground). He gave two reasons for making this transformation. Publishers were hard to find in Urdu, while they were plentiful in Hindi and paid substantially more. Besides, Premchand felt out of place in the Urdu cultural milieu; as he asked in a moment of despondency in a letter to an Urdu editor in 1918, 'Has any Hindu ever made a success of writing in Urdu that I will?'[5] The facts seem to support him, for in one count by a British literary historian in 1928, of about 250

writers he treated in his work, only eight were Hindus and none of them was regarded as being of the first rank.

Be that as it may, Premchand, by beginning to write in Hindi, entered a wider and apparently more congenial cultural ambience in which even the semantic resonances seemed to conform more closely to his vision of the world. The very titles of several works from this transitional period bear this out. The novel titled *Bazar-e Husn* (written in 1917 in Urdu; The Market-Place of Beauty) was published first in Hindi as *Sevasadan* (1919; The Abode of Service). The short story published in Urdu as 'Panchayat' (May–June 1916; The Jury of Five Elders) was published in Hindi as 'Panch Parameshwar' (June 1916; The Five Elders as [the voice of] God), and 'Brahm ka Swang' in Hindi (1920; Pretending to be Brahm or God) was toned down in Urdu to become 'Nok-Jhonk' (1923; Banter).[6] It must be added that Premchand never wholly abandoned Urdu, for till the end he wrote in it a few of his short stories, most notably 'Kafan' (1935), and also lectures and essays, including his presidential address to the first conference of the All-India Progressive Writers Association (1936), in which he quoted verse four times, each time in Persian. When his host Sajjad Zaheer remarked that the Urdu in his speech had become a little ponderous (*saqeel*), Premchand laughed his loud laugh and said he thought he would show everyone that he was a '*Kayastha ka bachcha*' (son of a Kayastha), implying that his Urdu could be as high-flown as any Muslim's!

Realism and Idealism

Another important development in Premchand's career is believed to have taken place in the last few years of his life, when he wrote some stories in which his realism was not irradiated by his usual optimistic outlook. Throughout his career, in both his novels and his short stories, his protagonists had been inspired by the abiding values of truth, mutual trust, goodwill, cooperation and service to others. In moments of adversity and crisis, they were motivated by an idealism which led them to acts of selfless sacrifice, or to a change of heart involving an admission of past errors and deep repentance in which all conflict and dissonance were dissolved into a

compassionate harmony. Premchand seemed to have been a firm believer in what the English poet John Keats, in a memorable phrase, called 'the holiness of the heart's affections and the truth of imagination'.[7]

Premchand similarly said that a good short story offered 'a vivid and heart-touching depiction of an episode, a glimpse of the soul'. In another essay, he described his own mode of writing fiction, or indeed his whole vision of life, as *adarshonmukh yatharthvad*,[8] that is, idealistic realism or, more accurately, ideal-oriented realism. Some of his best-known and best-loved short stories are shining examples of this possibly naive-seeming and sentimental but in fact resolutely principled view of life in which goodness, virtue and self-realization are ultimately bound to prevail over all misunderstanding and temporary ill will.

Yet, in his last few years, Premchand wrote some stories which seem devoid of such a hopeful tenor and are instead inconclusive or even bleak. To cite just the best known of them, in 'Poos ki Raat' (1930; A Winter Night), a farmer falls asleep on his night-long watch over his ripening harvest, wakes up in the morning to find it devoured and destroyed by a herd of nilgai, but as he walks back home, he tells himself that he would at least not have to freeze any more by passing night after night out in the open. In 'Sadgati' (1930; Gone to Heaven, made into a film by Satyajit Ray), a poor low-caste man is cruelly worked to death by a Brahmin priest, with the latter excusing himself in the end by saying that after death in a Brahmin's service, the wretched man would surely go to heaven. And in 'Kafan' (1935; The Shroud), a father and son end up in a drinking house in a city, carousing in an only-too-rare carnivalesque moment, quite oblivious of the son's young wife who has died in childbirth the night before and still lies unmourned and uncremated back in the village.

These are deeply unsettling works, and commentators on Premchand have been at a loss as to what to make of them. Some have suggested that Premchand was here at last moving out of the shadow of Gandhi and of traditional values to a kind of radical progressive position. As there is not a trace of resistance or rebellion against the system or even the particular oppressor in any of these stories (as there is not in Premchand's last novel,

Godaan, either), some others have suggested that Premchand had in the end grown weary of his own idealism and become a little cynical. Another way of looking at these few stories, which are so striking partly because they go against the grain of the rest of Premchand's career, may be to suggest that in them, Premchand was experimenting with something new and beginning to develop a 'late style' (in Edward Said's formulation in his late and indeed posthumous book)[9] as many other masters had done as they advanced in years. Premchand died at the age of fifty-six, and one can only speculate on what and how he would have gone on to write had he been granted, say, ten more years. We may anyhow note that the last two short stories Premchand published in his lifetime, 'Do Bahnen' (August 1936; Two Sisters) and 'Rahasya' (September 1936; The Secret), are both as full of Premchand's signature vocabulary of *seva*, *tyag* and *daya* (service to others, sacrifice and compassion) as anything he wrote at any time in his career.[10]

Translating Premchand: The Two Originals

Premchand's short stories began to be translated in his own lifetime into other Indian languages, including Gujarati, Bengali, Marathi and Tamil, as well as into English, German and Japanese. The first volume of a selection of his short stories in English translation was published in 1946 by Gurdial Malik and, as M. Asaduddin has shown, about a dozen other selections have been published since then by translators both Indian and American. As most of the translators have gone in for the same 'best' stories, the total number of short stories translated into English remains a small fraction of the oeuvre.[11]

Translation is sometimes slandered as being a losing game by those who do not pause to reflect on what is gained, for without translation, however inadequate, we would not have access to an alien author or work at all. What comes across especially well in English in the case of Premchand is his irreducibly humane content and his gripping, even enchanting, narrative voice. With the very first sentence of a novel or a story by him, we enter a parallel universe of his creation, which compels utter credibility and full engagement. His diction is simple, especially in the frequent dialogues, his

sentences are short—sometimes too short to sound natural in English—and even in those of his tales which have a parable-like ending, the specificity of realistic notation remains undiminished. On the other hand, his authorial passages of both a narrative and discursive kind exploit fully the expressive resources of the language he uses and are so felicitously modulated as to stretch the capabilities of the best translators. Premchand's penchant for using idiomatic phrases presents a difficulty and so do culture-specific terms, as with translating any writer.

But a difficulty that may be unique to Premchand arises from the fact that whether one translates him from Hindi or Urdu, the original text may well turn out to be always already translated—from the other language! It is now possible to say with certainty which of the two versions of a story was first published, and in the great majority of the cases it is clear that the version first published was also the first to be written. But this priority may not always indicate primacy, for if the second, translated version turns out to be different in significant respects, it would be inept to reject it altogether. Though the early translations from Urdu into Hindi were mostly done by Premchand himself, we have firm evidence, for example, that the final manuscript of the Hindi *Rangbhumi* was translated into Urdu by another person who demanded a rate that Premchand thought to be exorbitant. In any case, all his works throughout his life in both Hindi and Urdu were published under Premchand's own name with no mention of a translator and are treated by the common reader as being equally original.

A good English translation then must take both the Hindi and the Urdu versions into account and in the case of each notable variation, reconcile them if possible or at least opt for whichever seems more apt. As I have argued elsewhere, it must be one translation rendered out of two originals. The issues involved here may be quickly illustrated through the one story that I have myself contributed to these volumes, 'A Special Holi' (Volume 2). Its title in Hindi is 'Vichitra Holi' (published in 1921) and in Urdu 'Ajeeb Holi' (1928), which may look quite similar but have different connotations, especially when we read the story. It depicts all the servants of a British sahib staging a rebellion against him on the carnivalesque day

of Holi when he is out hunting, and they indulge in riotous merriment by drinking his wine, dancing on his dining table and singing lusty Holi songs. They are punished and slink away when Mr Hunter returns, but they have had their day of glorious liberation. Now this, as Premchand narrates, is more a *special* Holi, in a positive sense, than a *strange* Holi, in a quizzical or suspicious sense, and the Hindi title is closer to the mark. Elsewhere in the story, Hindi words seem more apt in some places but Urdu words in some other places, and in this transitional phase of his career from Urdu to Hindi, Premchand even seems to waver here and there between Hindi usage and Urdu usage, mixing up, for example, the verbs that would go with *arpan* (dedication) and *qurbani* (sacrifice).[12]

The Present Volumes

In this respect, a major new beginning is made with the translations in these four volumes, for the translators had access to both the Hindi and the Urdu versions. Besides, the notes at the end indicate the major variations between the two texts and provide the publishing details of both the versions. The Introduction by M. Asaduddin, a multilingual scholar, provides an erudite and comprehensive overview of Premchand's career, and his thematic and stylistic range. His archival researches have resulted in the discovery of two whole stories which were so far known to have been published but could not be traced, and also of sections 2 and 3 of a third story of which only the first section was available. This edition of translations of Premchand thus goes a bit beyond even the most comprehensive editions of his works so far published in either Hindi or Urdu and gives a new meaning to the phrase 'Found in Translation'!

But the outstanding feature of these volumes is, of course, the fact that they present in English translation close to 300 stories that Premchand wrote. Such an enormous project must have initially seemed audacious, and then been full of difficulties, problems and heartaches during its long gestation. But a team of sixty translators, occasionally interacting together in workshops, finally realized the plan with Professor Asaduddin himself

leading from the front by translating, I am given to understand, no less than 100 stories all by himself.

So far as I know, this is an unprecedented project of its kind and scale in the history of translations into English in India, for not even the great Rabindranath Tagore has had all his short stories (which number seventy-nine, as collected in the three volumes of his *Galpa-Guchchha*, that is, 'Bunch of Stories') translated into English, much less in a uniform edition like this one. As this fleet of four ships, this argosy laden with some of the best writing produced in India in the modern period and now made available in a global language, is launched by a major international publisher upon the seven seas, one hopes that it will succeed in flying the flag of Indian literature far and wide and win for it a new and wider circulation.

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Harish Trivedi

Introduction

> ‘Premchand stands supreme as the iconic fiction writer of Urdu and Hindi, and to read and re-read him over and over again is to understand better ourselves and our society’[1]—Harish Trivedi

Premchand is generally regarded as the greatest writer in Urdu and Hindi, both in terms of his popularity and the range and depth of his corpus. His enduring appeal cuts across class, caste and social groups. He was not only a creative writer in Urdu and Hindi, but he also fashioned modern prose in both languages and influenced several generations of writers. The fact that his works were published in more than two dozen Hindi and Urdu journals[2] simultaneously attests to his extraordinary reach to the wide audience that formed his readership. Many of his readers encountered modern Urdu and Hindi novels and short stories, and indeed any literary forms, for the first time through his writings. Premchand’s unique contribution to the formation of a readership—and, in turn, to shaping the taste of that readership—has yet to be assessed fully. Few or none of his contemporaries in Urdu–Hindi have remained as relevant today as he is in the contexts of the Woman Question (*Stree Vimarsh*), Dalit Discourse (*Dalit Vimarsh*), Gandhian Nationalism, Hindu–Muslim relations and the current debates about the idea of India that is inclusive of all groups and denominations, irrespective of caste and creed. Francesca Orsini, who has worked on the Hindi public sphere, says pertinently: ‘His strong social conscience and radical politics, which brought him closer and closer to socialism, were rooted in an utterly secular and inclusive view of the Indian nation, which makes him a particularly valuable and rare role model these days.’ (Orsini 2003, xxvi)

However, despite his pioneering and iconic status, studies on Premchand have remained woefully inadequate because his entire corpus was or is still

not available in either Hindi or Urdu, not to speak of English. Researchers had to remain content with only one of the corpuses (either Urdu or Hindi) accessible to them. This is also true of his short stories. Till today, the entire corpus of his short stories is not to be found in any of the versions. Fortunately, it is now being made available in English by combining and assimilating both the archives. Moreover, some new materials not accessible so far either in Hindi or Urdu are being made available for the first time in English. These twin advantages—in addition to the fact that the entire corpus is now being made available in English in a reliable chronological order[3]—should make the reading of Premchand more fruitful, exciting and enjoyable and give a new fillip to Premchand studies. There is a need to revisit Premchand in the light of the new materials that have been discovered, mainly, though not exclusively, through the efforts of Kamal Kishore Goyanka, and some more new materials that are presented in this anthology.

Premchand as a Short Story Writer: Beginnings

Premchand pioneered modern short story writing in Urdu and Hindi. The Urdu short story, or *afsana* (sometimes called *mukhtasar afsana* to distinguish it from longer fictional works), can be seen as a continuity of the fictional tradition that existed in Urdu for several centuries—that is, literature consisting of *qissa*, *hikayah*, *dastaan*, and so on, which drew upon the Perso-Arabic narrative tradition on the one hand and the Indian tradition of storytelling as one finds in works like the *Panchatantra*, *Hitopadesha* and the Jataka tales on the other. The short story proper in Urdu, however, emerged only in the opening decade of the twentieth century. By that time, novels and short stories were familiar conventions, having already been established in Bengali at the hands of Bankim Chandra Chatterjee, Rabindranath Tagore and Sarat Chandra Chatterjee. These Bengali writers are being invoked here because Premchand had read all of them in translation and drew inspiration from them. In fact, he began his writing career by translating Tagore. Of course, his staple readings were the medieval-style romances in Urdu and Persian popular at the time,

particularly the writings of Ratan Nath Dhar Sarshar and Abdul Halim Sharar.

The atmosphere of dastaan and historical romances hangs heavy on Premchand's early stories. But he soon grew out of that phase and made his work more socially relevant by giving it the hard, gritty texture of realism. His art of storytelling became a vehicle for his socially engaged agenda of social reform and ameliorating the condition of the deprived and oppressed sections of society. However, that does not mean he was mainly concerned with the content and external circumstances of his characters and not with their inner worlds. Like all great writers, he took interest in unravelling the mental processes of his characters and the psychological motivations of their actions. As he says:

> My stories are usually based on some observations or personal experience. I try to introduce some dramatic elements in them. I do not write stories merely to describe an event. I try to express some philosophical/emotional reality through them. As long as I do not find any such basis I cannot put my pen to paper. When this is settled, I conceive characters. Sometimes, studying history brings some plots to mind. An event does not form a story, as long as it does not express a psychological view of reality.[4] (My translation)

In the stories he has written—which number close to 300—one finds different modes and points of view, which he adopted by employing an array of narrative devices. An overwhelming number of his stories are written in the third person or omniscient narrative mode and a far lesser number in the first person. He makes extensive use of dialogue, using different registers of Urdu and Hindi in addition to dialects, colloquialisms, idioms and speech patterns specific to a caste, class or community. He also uses the technique of interior monologue and multiple points of view in quite a few stories. The salient point is that even though Premchand was mainly concerned with the content of his stories, to the extent of sometimes making them formulaic and predictable, he certainly did engage with the stylistic aspects too. And in this respect, he was influenced by both Indian —specifically Bengali—and foreign writers.

Sources

The subject matter of Premchand's stories has been taken from Indian history and mythology, Indo-Muslim cultural history, contemporary society, and his own wide readings of literature from across the world, particularly English, Russian and French literature, from which he translated into Urdu and Hindi. The early decades of the twentieth century in India were exciting times, marked by the stirrings of change in society, particularly in its transition from a predominantly feudal and patriarchal society to a more democratic and modern one. From the third decade, the movement for independence gained momentum. Premchand had a journalist's curiosity of the quotidian and the contemporary. He was extraordinarily alive to the goings-on around him and made the events and issues the subject matter of his stories.[5] There is hardly any issue relevant to the India of that time that he did not touch in his fiction. From a reading of his short stories it is quite possible to recreate the society of that time, with all its quirks, contradictions and superstitions, as well as the prevalent reformist and intellectual climate, particularly in the northern part of the country.

Themes

Premchand began his career as a short story writer with the publication of *Soz-e Watan* (The Dirge of the Nation, 1908), written under his pen name, Nawab Rai. It is a collection of five stories wherein he wrote on patriotism in a mode that can be called revivalist or revisionist, much in the vein of Bankim Chandra Chatterjee, whom he imitated in matters of style as well.[6] The patriotism and the hatred against invaders displayed in these stories made the colonial government ban the book, and Premchand barely escaped with a sharp reprimand from the magistrate. This was his first encounter with colonial censorship but not his last. He had to battle with censorship that tried to cripple him both as a writer and an editor of magazines later in life, without much help from anyone. What is pertinent to note here is that a strain of patriotism ran through stories such as 'The Rarest Pearl in the World' ('Duniya ka Sab se Anmol Ratan'), 'Sheikh Makhmoor', 'Rani Sarandha', and 'Raja Hardaul', which were written either in the dastaanesque mode or in the mode of historical romances, sometimes both.

He continued to write in this vein for some time before he moved gradually to the realist mode, which was preferred by writers in many other Indian languages.

'A Well-bred Daughter' ('Bade Ghar ki Beti') is the first story to depict the family drama of an average, middle-class Indian family written in the realistic mode. He wrote a large number of stories throughout his career in this mode and on this theme. This and 'Family Break-up' ('Algojhya') are two classic stories about the Indian joint family that is held together by the ideal of sacrifice, where individual aspirations are subordinated to what is good for the family. A joint family in a village provides an ideal for Premchand whereby peasants can avoid dividing their landholding into smaller units. The breaking up of a family is an immensely painful affair in Premchand's stories, bringing social disgrace and opprobrium to those involved. However, between the two stories mentioned above, Premchand wrote a large number of stories about the daily life of smaller families in villages and small towns where he dealt with different aspects of family life: conjugal tiffs and strife, domestic cruelty, struggle for survival amidst limited means and penury, polygamy, rivalry between mother-in-law and daughter-in-law for domination in the house, the phenomenon of co-wives and the plight of stepchildren, conflict between legitimate aspirations and meanness of opportunities, the cycle of debt that ruins families, and so on.

Premchand felt a deep affinity with the common man and his natural sympathy was towards the oppressed and deprived sections of society. No writer before him in Urdu or Hindi, and possibly other Indian languages, had depicted the lives of underdogs, untouchables and marginalized sections with such depth and empathy. Throughout his life, 'Premchand did not let go of his unsentimental awareness of the grim realities of rural life, of life at the bottom of the economic scale' (Amrit Rai 1982, ix). The oppressors and oppression came in many forms—they may be priests or zamindars, lawyers or policemen, or even doctors, all of whom held society in their stranglehold. Rituals pertaining to Hindu marriages and deaths were so exploitative and oppressive that these events were often robbed of their dignity and joy and spelt the ruin of families. Premchand began his career

by exposing the corruption of the Hindu priestly class in his novel *Asraar-e Muavid* (Mysteries of the House of Worship, 1903–05), and then continued the tirade in many of his stories. In the story 'Babaji's Feast' ('Babaji ka Bhog') he depicts the greed of a Brahmin who has no compunction in robbing a poor family of its meagre means, and in 'The Funeral Feast' ('Mritak Bhoj') he showed how the predatory and parasitical Brahmins drive another Brahmin woman to destitution and her daughter to suicide. In a series of stories where the central character is Moteram, a Brahmin priest, Premchand exposes with rare courage the rapacity, hollowness and hypocrisy of the Hindu priestly class, which earned him the ire and venom of a section of high-caste Hindus, even culminating in a lawsuit for defamation. But he remained undaunted and went on exposing the many oppressive customs prevalent in society.

But his most trenchant critique was reserved for caste injustice, whereby people on the lowest rung of the Hindu caste system, and beyond the pale of the caste system, were considered untouchable and were compelled to live a life of indignity and humiliation. The upper-caste Hindus treated them worse than animals and this injustice was institutionalized through the social sanction of the caste system. Stories such as 'Thakur's Well' ('Thakur ka Kuan'), 'Salvation' ('Sadgati'), 'The Shroud' ('Kafan'), 'Temple' ('Mandir'), 'The Woman Who Sold Grass' ('Ghaaswali') and 'One and a Quarter *Ser* of Wheat' ('Sawa Ser Gehun') constitute a devastating indictment of the way upper-caste Hindus have treated Dalits for generations. They demonstrate that Dalits were subjected to daily humiliation and this humiliation stemmed from the fact that Dalit inferiority had become embedded in the psyche of the members of the Hindu upper castes, who have developed a vast repertoire of idioms, symbols and gestures of the verbal and physical denigration of Dalits over centuries. Grave injustice and the inhuman treatment of Dalits have become normalized, and cause no revulsion in society. Despite criticism from a few Dalit ideologues who level some rather irresponsible charges against Premchand for depicting Dalits in a certain way, the stories above—some of which have been rendered into films—have contributed significantly in

raising awareness about the injustice perpetrated against the most vulnerable section of society. In this respect, as Vasudha Dalmia suggests, Premchand was much ahead of his time: 'In his fiction, written over the three decades in the early century, Premchand presented what academic scholarship was to face squarely only towards the close of that century.'[7]

A considerable number of his stories deals with the plight of women. Premchand was deeply sensitive to the suffering of women in a patriarchal society where they had no agency and lived their lives according to the whims and fancies of the men on whom they were dependent—husbands, fathers, brothers or even close or distant male relatives. Women were expected to be docile, submissive and self-effacing, sacrificing their lives for the well-being of the family. Girls were treated as a curse on the family and the parents of girls were subjected to all kinds of humiliation and indignities while their marriages were arranged. Parents were sometimes compelled to marry off their nubile and very young daughters to old men just to unburden themselves of the responsibility and shame of being saddled with an unmarried daughter. The practices of *kanya vikray* (sale of a daughter in marriage), even *kanya vadh* (killing of a girl child), were prevalent. In his essays and editorials, Premchand made a strong plea for the abolition of the evil practices that made the life of women unbearable. He advocated divorce in extreme circumstances, and supported the wife's claim to own half the husband's property in case of divorce and inherit the property in case of the husband's death.[8] He also wrote in favour of the Sarda Bill which aimed at raising the minimum marriage age for girls. In a large number of stories, such as 'Tuliya' ('Devi'), 'Sati', 'The Goddess from Heaven' ('Swarg ki Devi'), 'Return' ('Shanti'), 'Godavari's Suicide' ('Saut'), 'The Thread of Love' ('Prem Sutra'), 'Two Friends' ('Do Sakhiyaan'), 'The Lunatic Lover' ('Unmaad'), and so on, he sheds light on the plight of women in an oppressive, patriarchal system. Through the immortal characters of old women like Chachi in 'Holy Judges', the old aunt in the eponymous story, and Bhungi in 'A Positive Change' ('Vidhwans'), he shows how difficult life was for old women in a society that was known to respect its elderly members. The fate of widows, who

were considered inauspicious and were expected to renounce all joys of life, was even worse, as shown in ‘Compulsion’ (‘Nairashya Leela’), ‘The Condemned’ (‘Dhikkar’) and ‘A Widow with Sons’ (‘Betonwali Vidhva’).

However, there is a certain ambivalence in his depiction of women and their status as equal partners in marriage.[9] Some of the stories were radical for his time, yet he was unable to imagine a fully independent and empowered woman with her own agency and subjectivity, as Tagore did, for example, in ‘Wife’s Letter’ or ‘Chitra’.[10] In the entire Premchand oeuvre of short stories there are only three single women—Miss Padma of the eponymous story, Miss Khurshed of ‘Disgrace’ (‘Laanchan’) and Miss Joshi of ‘Faith’ (‘Vishwas’). While Miss Padma, despite her education and economic independence, seems inadequate as a woman, deprived of a family life and bereft and regretful after a failed live-in relationship, Miss Khurshed is depicted as enjoying to the hilt her single status as a woman, and even sharing a deeply emotional relationship with another woman, Dr Leela. Miss Joshi starts off as a social butterfly, with the high and mighty kowtowing to her, but after several years of a live-in relationship with Mr Johri, pines for the bliss of domestic life with Mr Apte. However, there are so many female characters in Premchand’s stories, portrayed from different points of view, that any kind of generalization will be undesirable. The labels ‘pro-feminist’ and ‘anti-feminist’ are not very helpful in understanding Premchand’s stories either, as these labels inevitably carry the elements of reductionism inherent in them. To some, the very fact that Premchand could imagine women outside the marriage bond and as capable of finding fulfilment in a career was radical enough, if not too radical, for his time. Similarly, despite his sympathy with widows and his support for widow remarriage, there is a certain uneasiness in depicting a widow who has an equal claim to bodily pleasures and comforts. Widows in Premchand’s stories seem to find fulfilment only in the ideals of service, devotion and self-effacement. Indeed, in the entire corpus of his short fiction there are no more than two widow marriages[11] and both of them end disastrously.

As stated earlier, Premchand began his career as a short story writer by writing stories of patriotism in a somewhat revivalist mode. Later in life when he came under Gandhi's influence and showed deep involvement in India's struggle for independence, to the extent of giving up his government job, he wrote a string of nationalist stories dealing with the adoption of indigenous or swadeshi products, the boycott or even burning of foreign goods, picketing outside alcohol shops, giving up government jobs and embracing a life of social service, among other things. Some of them, like 'A Strange Holi' ('Ajeeb Holi') and 'Resignation' ('Isteefa'), show the discomfiture of British colonial officials at the hands of Indians and the sudden conversion of Indian loyalists or servants of the British Raj into patriotic Indians who jealously protect their honour and are devoted to the cause of Independence. Some of these stories, as also some others, have been criticized for a kind of contrived and easy plot resolution through the 'change of heart' device. Apart from the above two, there are stories like 'The Wine Shop' ('Sharab ki Dukaan'), 'Maiku and the Congress Volunteer' ('Maiku'), 'An Audacious Act' ('Dussahas'), 'Role Reversal' ('Patni se Pati'), 'The Night of the New Moon' ('Amavas ki Raat'), 'A Daughter's Possessions' ('Beti ka Dhan'), 'The Call of Dawn' ('Baang-e Sahar'), 'The Bankruptcy of the Bank' ('Bank ka Diwala') and 'The Salt Inspector' ('Namak ka Daroga') where this device has been used to drive a point home, or as an easy way out of various tricky situations. This is true of some of his peasant stories as well where the writer finds it 'safer' to use the 'change of heart' of the oppressive zamindar as the convenient device for plot resolution rather than showing the oppressed peasants finding solidarity among themselves and ranging against the zamindars for collective radical action.[12] He also uses suicide as a device for plot resolution for women faced with social opprobrium, something which might seem melodramatic and an easy way to arrive at a denouement but on closer analysis seems to be historically accurate. In Indian society, this kind of honour suicide is quite rampant even now, as newspapers and television channels will testify.

Premchand's love for the countryside is evident in his fictional and non-fictional writings. He has written several extremely evocative stories such as 'Holy Judges', 'The Story of Two Bullocks' ('Do Bailon ki Katha'), 'Idgah' and 'Atmaram', which depict the pristine village life of simplicity, honesty and quiet contentment. In fact, his fictional corpus, if read uncritically, would lend itself to an easy binary between country life and city life, one good and the other almost irredeemably evil. Yet, we have to recognize that he does not depict country life as an idyll shorn of all evils. There are stories such as 'A Positive Change' ('Vidhwans'), 'A Home for an Orphan' ('Grihdaah') and 'Road to Salvation' ('Mukti Marg') that de-romanticize and demystify village life and depict the author's awareness of the imperfections and blind spots in the supposed idyll.[13] Thus, the apparent binary that seems to work in the case of some novels and stories cannot be stretched beyond a point.

Premchand's deep interest in the simple life of peasants extended to his love for animals, particularly draught animals, treated most cruelly in India. Very few writers have depicted such an intimate bond between animals and human beings. Premchand depicts animals as endowed with emotions just as human beings are, responding to love and affection just as human beings do, and are fully deserving of human compassion. Often, the duplicity, cruelty and betrayal in the human world is contrasted with the unconditional love and loyalty displayed by animals towards their masters and those who care for them. It is a heart-wrenching moment, as shown in 'Money for Deliverance' ('Muktidhan') and 'Sacrifice' ('Qurbani'), when a peasant has to part with his animals because of want and destitution. The deep compassion with which animal life has been depicted in 'Holy Judges' ('Panchayat'), 'Reincarnation' ('Purva Sanskar'), 'The Story of Two Bullocks' ('Do Bailon ki Katha') and 'The Roaming Monkey' ('Salilani Bandar'*)* are treasures of world literature. Stories such as 'Turf War' ('Adhikar Chinta') and 'Defending One's Liberty' ('Swatva Raksha'), written in a humorous and symbolic vein, show how a dog fiercely protects his turf and how a horse defeats all the machinations of human beings to make him work on a Sunday, which is his day of rest, rightfully earned after

working for six days of the week! In ‘The Roaming Monkey’ the author shows how a monkey earns money by performing tricks of different kinds and thus looks after the wife of his owner, nurturing her and bringing her back from the brink of lunacy. In ‘The Price of Milk’ (‘Doodh ki Qeemat’) we have the spectacle of goats feeding a baby with milk from their own udders, thereby saving its life. The baby has been denied milk by its own mother because she considers it a *tentar*, an ‘evil’ child destined to be the cause of death of one of her parents or another member of the family, and wishes it dead. In ‘A Daughter’s Possessions’ (‘Beti ka Dhan’) Sakkhu Choudhury finds tears streaming down the eyes of his oxen in his moments of grief when the zamindar is going to evict him from his home, and when his own sons are totally indifferent to his plight. In the story ‘Two Brothers’ (‘Do Bhai’) the narrator contrasts the greed and lack of empathy of the elder brother, Krishna, for his younger brother, Balaram, whose property he wants to grab, with the deep bond between two bullocks, one of whom refuses to touch any food for three days when the other is separated from it.

Several very popular stories of Premchand deal with Hindu–Muslim relations. He was deeply interested and invested in a cordial relationship between Hindus and Muslims, a fact which is evident in both his fictional and non-fictional writings. He had no doubt that the independence and progress of the country depended substantially on the harmonious relationship between these two dominant religious groups in India. Early in his life he was introduced to Muslim culture and Islam through his study of Persian and Urdu and the maulvi who taught him. He was also familiar with the ideals of Hinduism, the orthodox variety as well as the reformist trend of the Arya Samaj to which his family owed allegiance. This, coupled with his inherently secular temperament, provided him a unique vantage point from which he could write fairly and fearlessly about both communities in an even-handed way. In fact, he was the only writer of his generation in any Indian language, not excepting Tagore, to write about the external and internal lives of the members of both communities with an insight, empathy and intimacy that have not been matched since. I cannot think of any other Indian writer who possessed that kind of vision. During his lifetime, the

relationship between Hindus and Muslims went through particularly volatile and turbulent phases, but he was always unwavering in his belief in pluralism and kept the faith. Stories like 'Holy Judges', 'Idgah', 'The Greater Pilgrimage' ('Hajj-e Akbar'), 'Temple and Mosque' ('Mandir aur Masjid'), 'The Prophet's Justice' ('Nabi ka Niti Nirvaah'), 'Forgiveness' ('Kshama') and essays such as 'Islamic Civilization' ('Islami Sabhyata'[14]) demonstrate his deep knowledge of Islamic culture and the intimate lives of Muslim families, and how the daily lives of Hindus and Muslims were intertwined, particularly in the countryside. Towards the end of the second decade of the twentieth century when Hindu–Muslim relations were at their lowest ebb, Premchand wrote the play *Karbala*, on a deeply emotional subject for Muslims, to cement the bonds of Hindu–Muslim unity.

Premchand seems immensely relevant in today's India when history is being sought to be rewritten and Muslims are constantly cast in the role of the 'other' and held accountable for all the real and imagined atrocities of Muslim rulers of the past. In his own time, he saw with bewilderment how 'Whenever a Muslim king is remembered, we evoke Aurangzeb' (Premchand 1985:5), a remark that reverberates with contemporary resonance, indicating the agenda of some people who always sought to frustrate any attempt at a broader understanding and reconciliation between these two communities. He was opposed to religious sectarianism and orthodoxy in any form. This will be evident if one reads his stories in the Moteram series and a story like 'Holy War' ('Jihad') where he anticipates what goes today by the misleading and erroneous name of 'Islamic' terror. In this context, Syed Akbar Hyder's comments seem particularly apt:

> Premchand archives Hindu–Muslim relationship in mutually respectable terms that move beyond Aurangzeb and his times into a temporal zone reflecting a more pluralistic Islam . . . By ideologically fracturing religious communities, he undermines the antagonistic communal bifurcation within the colonial milieu that posited Hindu and Muslim as age-old enemies whose scriptures determined their mode of thinking and living. (Hansen and Lelyveld, 2005, 276)

Evolution in Premchand's Art of Storytelling

Premchand's art of storytelling evolved through his career encompassing three full decades, as did his language and vocabulary. As he evolved from a dastaanesque to a realistic mode, his language also changed in register and vocabulary, and the patches of purple prose likewise dwindled. Moreover, as he slowly moved from Urdu to Hindi, but still continued to write or translate in both languages (or forms or *shaili*, as some would characterize it), his language underwent visible changes. And later in life, when he became a strong advocate of Hindustani, his endeavour was to craft a language that would be equally intelligible to the votaries of both Hindi and Urdu. He also moved from the earlier dense, lush narrative style incorporating multiple registers and a variety of characters as in 'Holy Judges', 'The Sword of Loyalty' ('Khanjar-e Wafa'), 'Atmaram', 'Idgah', and so on, to a leaner, pared down narrative style focusing on one or two events and involving fewer characters. The earlier expansiveness was replaced by intensity of experience. The idealistic, sometimes even prescriptive, nature of his work evolved into a more robust and mature understanding of life's pitiless ironies and unpredictability that did not always conform to poetic justice. Amrit Rai's remark in this context seems the most pertinent:

> In the year 1933–34, Premchand wrote several stories such as 'Manovritti', 'Doodh ka Dam', 'Balak', 'Naya Vivah' . . . which are entirely new from the point of view of both content and form . . . there isn't in these later stories . . . a dense and tightly woven web of events as in the stories of an earlier phase. They have, instead, just a single focus of interest, just one little point to make, an unremarkable enough state of mind to describe, the author's own way of observing a fleeting glimpse of truth or beauty—and this is presented in an informal and conversational manner . . . (Amrit Rai 1982, 311)

Language Issues: Urdu versus Hindi

As indicated in the opening paragraph of this Introduction, a comprehensive understanding of Premchand's stature as a writer demands that the reader is able to access his stories in both versions. One great advantage of this anthology is that it points to differences in the two versions of a story. These differences are sometimes trivial, at other times substantial, and provide added insights into the stories and expand their textuality.[15]

Premchand began his career writing in Urdu and he produced a substantial volume of work in his first twelve years as a writer (1903–15)—five novels and close to four dozen stories to be precise—before he thought of writing in Hindi. His transition from Urdu to Hindi was gradual, though irreversible, given the social and political circumstances and the publishing scenario of the time.

Now, the question is, are the Hindi and Urdu versions of his stories exact replicas of each other? Not always and not necessarily. Premchand knew this too well, as he was aware of the changes that he made along the way. In a letter to Imtiaz Ali Taj, the dramatist, translator and editor in Urdu, he mentioned that he changed entire scenes while translating the text from one version to the other. As usually happens with writer-translators, whenever they translate their own work, the creative impulse often takes over so that translation often turns into rewriting. In Premchand's stories one finds many minor changes that were done either for stylistic embellishments, or for the difference in perceived readership, or, quite probably, for the space constraints in the journal in which the stories were going to be published.

There is another dimension to this issue. It was not always Premchand himself who translated his work between Urdu and Hindi. Often, he took help from others, which might have meant he had the time to look over it only cursorily. Several translators, most notably Iqbal Bahadur Verma 'Saher', are known to have helped Premchand in preparing versions of stories both in Hindi and Urdu. Their style now passes off as Premchand's style. His younger son, Amrit Rai, excavated several stories in Urdu of which there were no Hindi versions. Amrit Rai published such stories in a two-volume anthology with the appropriate title *Gupt Dhan* (Hidden Treasure). In its Introduction he writes about the kind of changes he has effected while transferring the stories from one version to the other:

> I thought it unfair to Hindi readers to publish these stories in their original form. So I clothed them in Hindi, in the style of Munshiji, as far as it was possible for me. How far I have succeeded in this effort to not only preserve the soul of the story but the language and style as well will be judged by you. As for me, I feel satisfaction in the thought that I have pulled all my resources in this endeavour.[16] (My translation)

It is both significant and debatable why Amrit Rai felt it necessary for the stories to undergo changes for the sake of intelligibility and readability in Hindi. Had the two languages changed so much within twenty-five years of Premchand's death that they needed to be interfered with? This also brings up the questions of ethics and authorship. Does anyone, be it even the writer's own son, have the right to tamper with the original works of a writer to make them suitable for a particular readership?

How radical these changes sometimes were can be illustrated through the two versions of his famous story 'A Night in the Month of Poos' ('Poos ki Raat'). The story is about a poor, destitute peasant, Halku, who is in permanent debt to the village moneylender. Halku spends the severe winter nights in the field to save the harvest from marauding beasts. But ultimately, he is unable to save the crop when a horde of wild beasts descends on the field one night and despoils the harvest. In the Hindi version, which was first published in the journal *Madhuri* (May 1930), the story ends on a note of apparent relief for Halku, who decides to move away from the life of a peasant by becoming a worker in a factory. However, in the Urdu version, which was published later in *Prem Chaleesi 2* (1930), Premchand has added a section at the end where Halku ponders over the travails of peasant life but nevertheless decides to stay a peasant. Taking on the job of a day labourer, he thinks, would mean an insult to the land and to his forefathers who were peasants. So he resolves to stay a peasant whatever the challenges. Thus, the two endings of the story admit two radically different interpretations. It is clear that the Urdu version is not simply an expanded version of the Hindi, but it radically alters the perspective of the protagonist. In the Hindi version of the story Halku comes across as yielding to the pressures of being a peasant and surrendering to the fate of a wage-earner, whereas the Urdu version stresses his strong resistance to any such shift in his career. He confronts the challenges of a peasant's life, standing face-to-face with total ruin as the marauding animals destroy his harvest, but none of it can destroy his spirit. He is convinced that he should continue to be a peasant to carry on the legacy of his forefathers. Thus, while the Urdu version maintains the status

quo in Halku's life, the Hindi version envisages his transformation into a factory worker. Changes of the kind signalled above, with variations and different degrees of emphasis, can be found in a number of Premchand's short stories.

'Atmaram' is a story that presented Premchand with the problem of cultural untranslatability. It was built on the Hindu philosophical concept of maya and *moha*,[17] and Premchand must have found that these concepts were not easily translatable in Urdu. The story is about a devout village goldsmith, Mahadev, who, disenchanted by his own children, becomes attached to a parrot which he symbolically named Atmaram. The story plays on the popular belief that *atma*, or the soul, is like a bird which flies out at the time of death. Mahadev's religious and spiritual inclinations are demonstrated by his constant chanting of two lines of a popular bhajan: *Sat gurudutt Shivdutt daata/Ram ke charan mein chitt laaga*. The villagers could identify him from a distance hearing the sound of the bhajan. It so happens that one of his sons accidentally opens the cage one day and the parrot flies out. When Mahadev finds the cage empty, his heartbeat stops for a moment. All his attempts to tempt the parrot back into the cage bear no fruit. The parrot sits on the cage and flies about it, but cannot be made to enter the cage. Mahadev continues his effort. The climax of the story shows this tug of war between Mahadev and the parrot effectively:

> [The parrot] would come and sit on the top of the cage and now sit at the door of the cage and look at the bowls for food and water, and then fly off. If the old man was moha incarnate, the parrot was incarnate maya. This went on till evening descended. The struggle between maya and moha was lost in darkness.
>
> **Hindi:** [Tota] kabhi pinjre par aa baithta, kabhi pinjre ke dwar par baith apne daanapani ke piyalion ko dekhta, aur phir urh jata. Buddha agar murtiman moha tha, tau tota murtimayi maya. Yahan tak ki shaam ho gayi. Maya aur moh ka ye sangram andhakar mein vilin ho gaya.
>
> **Urdu:** [Tota] kabhi pinjre par aata, kabhi pinjre ke darwazey par baith kar apne daanapani ki piyalion ko dekhta, aur phir urh jata, magar joonhi Mahadev uski taraf aata woh phir urh jata. Buddha agar paykar-e hawas tha, tau tota daayre aarzoo. Yahan tak ke shaam-e siyah ne hawas aur arzoo ki is kashmakash par parda dhal diya.

One would understand that Urdu words like *hawas* and *aarzoo* cannot adequately represent the philosophical concepts of maya and moha and Premchand must have realized this fact of cultural untranslatability. Similarly, the constant chanting of the bhajan *Sat gurudutt Shivdutt daata/Ram ke charan mein chitt laaga* would befit the genius of the Hindi language more than Urdu and appeal to someone brought up in the tradition of Hindu religion more than anyone else. That Premchand himself was conscious of this is evidenced by the fact that the story was originally intended for the journal *Kahkashan* published from Lahore. But as the story got written Premchand realized that it was probably not suitable for the predominantly Muslim readership of *Kahkashan*. He wrote to the editor, Imtiaz Ali Taj:

> I have recently written another story, 'Atmaram'. I am sending it to *Zamana*. It has turned out to be so utterly Hindu that it is not suitable for *Kahkashan*. You may call yourself a Hindu but your readers certainly are not Hindu.[18]

This statement, however, appears to be at odds with the entire version of the Urdu story which Premchand seems to have written with far greater relish than the Hindi version. The Urdu version is longer by two dense pages—ten pages compared to the Hindi version's eight. The rhetorical flourishes, the deployment of metaphor and simile, the idiomatic turns of phrase—all these make the Urdu version more urbane, supple and enjoyable than the Hindi one which seems somewhat stark and dull in comparison. Thus, reading the short stories in both Hindi and Urdu reveals several interesting facts.

In many cases, the Urdu version is longer than the Hindi version, showing the use of traditional rhetorical embellishments. This would encourage us to speculate that: (a) Urdu was Premchand's first love and, as he professes in his essay 'Sahitya ka Uddeshya', it came more naturally to him than Hindi. (b) As a language, Urdu lends itself to finer and more intimate shades of feelings and emotions in Premchand's hand in a way that Hindi does not; in comparison, Hindi is somewhat bare and unadorned. (c) In the Urdu versions one can find virtuoso passages, passages of purple prose designed to dazzle readers into an admission of the author's full

control and command over the language. It is interesting to think about whether there is an organic relationship between theme and language form, whether language determines subject matter and styles or, at least, whether language and themes are intimately connected. Alok Rai says, 'It seems as though some utterances can be made most felicitously in Hindi and some in Urdu. What lies behind this—history, social and cultural predisposition or literary traditions? This can be a subject for research'[19] (Alok Rai and Mushtaq Ali, 2002: ii; my translation). He further says that the communalization of these two languages is evident, as one can see that in Hindi if the characters are given Hindu names, in Urdu they are given Muslim names.[20] I would argue that the reasons for the differing versions should be traced in the different readerships that Premchand was addressing. And these two readerships were different not only in their religious practices and cultural traditions and cultural symbols, but also in their class differences, in their reading habits, and the literary traditions they inherited. To quote Alok Rai again: 'Only a deeper study will reveal what was thought to deserve utterance in what tradition and what was considered redundant. One can see the emerging mental disposition of that period hidden in these differing utterances.'[21] (Alok Rai and Mushtaq Ali, op cit., my translation)

Premchand in English

In an article, 'Nirmala Translated: Premchand's Heroine in English Dress', Rupert Snell raises the question, 'Is Premchand translatable?' and then answers quickly, 'In a word—no: the subtext of purity borne by the very title "Nirmala" is denied to those who access this novel only through English' (Snell 2001, 307). Snell rightly underlines the fact that all the linguistic and cultural resonances evoked by a word or phrase cannot be transferred to the target language. But this is the translator's challenge—not to produce a 'perfect' translation, which is an impossibility, but to gesture towards a universe of possibilities, of cultural nuances invested in the original text. Snell further surmises that few readers would be moved by Premchand if they were to read him only in English, a proposition that one

finds contestable. After all, the most widely read fiction writers in contemporary times—Orhan Pamuk, Milan Kundera, Haruki Murakami—are read overwhelmingly in their English translations rather than the original languages, and readers are still profoundly moved by them.[22]

Snell's proposition will not hold good for a multilingual country like India, where the richness of literature in many languages is accessed through English. The question one really needs to address concerns the kind of English that is employed to ensure that the voice of the original author is not drowned in what Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak characterizes as '. . . a sort of with-it translatese, so that literature by a woman in Palestine begins to resemble, in the feel of its prose, something by a man in Taiwan.'[23] Any apparent unevenness and angularity should be retained, and cultural nuances must be preserved and not flattened out. In contemporary India, where the largest archive on Indian literatures and their interrelationships are being created not in any Indian language but in English, the importance of translation in this language cannot be overemphasized. In the multilingual classrooms and literary meets and festivals in India, English often acts as an ice-breaker and a catalyst for entry into the multilingual world, which is the Indian reality. English is also being moulded for this purpose by writers who are writing originally in English and translators who are translating works from Indian languages into English.[24]

Premchand has been translated by a number of translators with differing degrees of competence and success. Elsewhere, I have dealt comprehensively with the history of Premchand translations in English and the challenges thereof.[25] Most of the challenges articulated in the essay—like the varying registers of the original, irregular punctuation, instability of the meaning of words and phrases in the original, and allusiveness—are valid for this anthology too. Premchand's world is culturally so rich that any translator will have to grapple with the phenomenon of cultural untranslatability. Not to speak of English, sometimes one finds that the cultural resonances of the phrases even in Hindi and Urdu are not the same. Gregory Rabassa, the famed translator from Spanish, has pointed to this phenomenon succinctly as follows: A 'language will load a word down with

all manner of cultural barnacles . . . bearing it off on a different tangent from a word in another tongue meant to describe the same thing.' (Rabassa 2005, 6). Attempts have been made to preserve these 'cultural barnacles' rather than eliminate them, even if it means straining the idiom in English. Inevitably, it has involved a series of particular, contingent judgements and ad hoc decisions that could not always be anticipated. These decisions have also differed from story to story. And that is why there are sentence structures and turns of phrases which might seem infelicitous in English but will give the reader some clue to the linguistic varieties and speech patterns of the characters in the original and the ways in which some ideas are expressed in it. Rather than assimilating the foreignness and cultural specificity of the original in a universalist idiom, attempts have been made to preserve both linguistic and cultural nuances, allowing the English to attain a certain measure of both readability and 'bi-culturality'.

Premchand was writing at a time when the protocols of style, including punctuation, in both Urdu and Hindi were not yet settled. The editorial endeavour here has been to bring the text in line with the modern conventions of prose writing in English. That involved changes in the format of dialogue writing, the appropriate use of quotation marks, the use of italics for both interior monologue where characters internalize their thoughts, and emphasis, and splitting or joining paragraphs. Short, choppy sentences that come in a string without subjects or subordinating clauses in Hindi or Urdu have sometimes been joined together to make coherent, intelligible sentences in English. The Roman script has the advantage of having letters in both lower and upper cases and modern computer technology has made it easier to write the script in bold or italics for varying purposes that have been used discreetly. Translators are, after all, interpreters of the text they are translating, and if a certain device of the Roman script was helpful in expressing the intended meaning of the original, they were encouraged to use this device to bring the text in line with modern prose. However, such instances are minimal and have been resorted to only after careful reflection.

A Plea for Humility

Premchand scholarship is very much a work in progress. Textual research on him has remained bogged down by the lack of availability of original manuscripts. Scholars have tried to gather works from journals and magazines in Urdu and Hindi, and in the process committed errors because of logistical or linguistic inadequacy.[26] These journals and magazines often operated on a shaky and tight budget and had very little or no editing rigour. Mistakes of the calligrapher, compositor or proofreader often went unchecked and undetected, and thus became part of the text. All this makes it difficult to arrive at a definitive version of the text. On our part, too, there is no claim to finality, only an assertion that all efforts have been made to collate texts from different sources to arrive at the final version. We request discerning scholars and readers to bring any errors and inadequacies in our versions to our notice, however grave or trivial they may be, so that they can be corrected in later editions.

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M. Asaduddin

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A Mentor's Advice

Pandit Chintamani was so fed up of family squabbles and the dearth of invitations that he considered renouncing the world. When he vowed to become a wandering ascetic, his best friend, Pandit Moteram Shastri, gave him this advice, 'Friend, I've closely known quite a few godly mahatmas. Now, when they arrive at some gentleman's door, they don't cower or stretch out their hands for alms and do not blurt out hypocritical blessings such as "May God keep you in good health, may you always be happy!" This is the way of beggars. Real ascetics yell out their presence when they reach anyone's door so that people inside the house sit up with a start and come running to see what's happened. I know two or three such utterances that you can learn and yell out on such occasions.

'Gudri Baba used to say, "If one dies, five will die!" When they heard this clarion call, people would fall right at his feet. Siddh Bhagat had a fine slogan: "Eat, drink and be merry but watch out for the holy man's stick." Nanga Baba would say, "Give or make others give me alms, feed me, let me drink, and then put me to sleep." Just remember, your prestige and the way you'll be treated depend a lot on your slogan. What else can I tell you? Don't forget, you and I have been together for a long time, have feasted on hundreds of meals together. Whenever we were at a feast together, we competed to devour one dish more than the other. It won't be the same without you! May God always provide you with the choicest food!'

Chintamani didn't like any of the utterances. He said, 'Think of a special slogan for me.'

'All right—how's this one: "If you don't give to me, I'll pile on you."'

'I like it, but if you'll allow me, I'd like to make it shorter.'

'Go right ahead.'

'Can we have it as follows: "Give or I'll run you into the ground"?'

Moteram leapt with joy! 'By God, that's unparalleled! Devotion has sharpened your knowledge. Splendid! Now try to yell it out once so that we can see how you perform.'

Chintamani stuck his fingers in his ears, concentrated all his energy and yelled, 'Give or I'll run you into the ground!' The noise was so deafening that even Moteram sat up with a start. Scared, bats flew away from the trees in dismay and dogs began to bark.

Moteram said, 'Friend, your cry made my heart tremble. I have never heard a clarion call like this. It was like the roar of a lion. Now that your slogan has been decided, I have a few other things to tell you, so listen to me attentively. The language of holy men is quite different from our ordinary speech. We address some people as "*aap*" and others as "*tum*". But the holy men address everyone—big or small, rich or poor, old or young—as "*tu*". Treat elderly people with respect. Also remember never to use simple Hindi, you'll be exposed if you do. Use difficult Hindi. For example, to say "Ma, give me something to eat" is not the style of the holy man. A genuine mahatma will say it like this: "Mother, organize a feast for me, you will earn a lot of merit."'

'Friend,' Chintamani said, 'I can't praise you enough. You've helped me so much.'

His advice given, Moteram left. Chintamani set out on his way. Shortly he saw a crowd of holy men with matted hair sitting in front of a bhang and hashish shop. They were smoking hashish. When they saw Chintamani, one of the holy men blurted out his slogan: 'Move along, move along fast, or else, I'll make you burst.' Another holy man thundered, 'We've come . . . no more worry.'

While the sound was still echoing in the skies, a third mahatma roared: ‘From Bengal I come/A country seen by no one/Fill my cup at once.’

Chintamani could not restrain himself. He burst out with, ‘Give or I’ll run you into the ground!’

As soon as they heard this, the sadhus welcomed him heartily. At once, the chillum was refilled and the task of igniting it was assigned to Pandit Chintamani. He was in a dire state. If he didn’t accept the pipe, his secret would be out.

Helpless, he took the chillum, but someone who has never smoked hashish cannot draw smoke even if he tries hard. He closed his eyes and tried to draw with all his strength. The chillum fell from his hands, his eyes popped out, he foamed at the mouth but no cloud of smoke issued from his mouth and neither did the chillum come alive. This clumsiness was enough make him an outcast in the society of the sadhus. Some of them advanced on him angrily, caught him by his hands and pulled him up.

‘A curse on you!’ said one.

‘Aren’t you ashamed of yourself? Pretending to be a sadhu!’ said another.

Deeply embarrassed, Panditji left the spot and sat down near a confectioner’s shop. The sadhus began to sing this hymn to the accompaniment of tambourines:

This world is an illusion, beloved, the world is an illusion.
Sacred and profane are lies—that’s the practical wisdom
Beloved, the world is all illusion.
Cursed are those who forbid us hashish and bhang
Beloved, the world’s an illusion.

Translated from the Hindi by M. Asaduddin



The Mantra

1

There was magic in Pandit Leeladhar Choubey's words. Whenever he stood on a podium and showered the nectar of his voice on the audience, the souls of all those who listened were satiated and charmed, almost as if they had been intoxicated. Choubeyji's speeches carried little substance and even the wordplay was not very beautiful. Its effect, however, was not dulled even by repetition. On the contrary, it became more effective upon repetition, like the blows of a hammer. I do not believe this but those who listen to him claim that he has memorized just one speech and repeats it verbatim in every assembly, though in a different style. Praising the Hindu community was the prime characteristic of his speeches. The moment he ascended a podium, he charmed everybody by his encomiums to the glory of ancient India and to the immortal fame of the ancestors. For instance:

> 'Good people! Whose eyes will not overflow with tears after listening to the tale of our utter degradation? When we remember our ancient glory, it becomes doubtful if we are the same people or we have changed. One who could formerly challenge a lion to a duel now searches for a rat hole when he sees a mouse. There must be a limit to this decline. Why look far off when we can talk about Emperor Chandragupta's reign? A famous Greek historian records that in that age, doors were never locked here, thefts were unheard of, there was no promiscuity, documents had not been invented, lakhs were exchanged on mere chits, and judges passed their time swatting flies! Good people! In those days, no man died young. (Applause) I repeat, in those days, no man died young. A son passing away before his father was an unprecedented

—in fact, impossible—event. In this age, how many such parents can be found whose hearts have not been blighted by the demise of a youthful son? It is not the same India any more. India has come undone.'

Such was Choubeyji's style. He kindled people's nationalistic pride by lamenting the present fallen and pitiable condition, and singing paeans to the prosperity and glory of the past. It was for this accomplishment that he was counted as one among the leaders. In particular, he was considered the flag-bearer of the Hindu Sabha. Among the Sabha's followers, there was none as enthusiastic, as competent or as diplomatic. It can be said that he had devoted his life to the Sabha's cause. Surely, he was not wealthy. At least this is what people believed, but he did have the invaluable gems of courage, patience and wisdom, and all this had been dedicated to the Sabha. In fact, he was the life of the *shuddhi* movement. He believed that the rise and fall, and the life and death of Hindu society was predicated on this very question. There could not be a way other than shuddhi for the resurgence of Hindus. The panacea for the moral, physical, psychological, social, economic and religious ills of the community was dependent on the success of this very movement, and his body and mind were both industriously engaged in it. He was especially competent at collecting donations. God had granted him that special knowledge by which even stones could be turned pliable. His dealings with misers were like the strokes of a blunt knife—the gentlemen learnt a lesson they'd never forget! In this matter, he employed all kinds of persuasion, enticement, punishment and deceit. So much so that he even considered robbery and theft to be forgivable, if undertaken in the interest of the nation.

2

It was the summer season and Panditji was making preparations for a sojourn in a cool, hilly region. It would be an outing, and if the opportunity arose, he could collect some donations too. Whenever he desired a tour, he would set out with a group of friends as a deputation. Who loses anything if out of a collection of one thousand rupees, half was spent on his tours? By

this arrangement, the Hindu Sabha also received some money. None would be collected but for his efforts! This time around, Panditji decided to take his family along. His financial condition, which was hitherto a cause for concern, had become quite stable since the emergence of the shuddhi movement.

How can the devotees of community welfare have the good fortune of experiencing the pleasure of living in peace? In fact, they were born to wander around aimlessly. There was word about the *Tablighi*s wreaking havoc in the Madras province. Village after village of Hindus was embracing Islam. The maulvis were promoting the Tablighi movement with great fervour. If the Hindu Sabha did nothing to stop this current, the entire province would be emptied of Hindus. It would be impossible to spot a single Hindu!

All hell broke loose in the Hindu Sabha. Immediately, a special session was convened and the problem was presented before the leaders. After much deliberation, it was decided that Choubeyji must be entrusted with this responsibility. He must be requested to proceed to Madras at once and rescue the converted brothers.

It only needed to be said once. Choubeyji, who had anyway dedicated himself to the service of the Hindu community, gave up the idea of a mountain tour and agreed to visit Madras. With tears in his eyes, the Hindu Sabha minister requested him, 'Sir, you alone can shoulder this responsibility. God has granted these powers to you alone. There is no man in this great India, except you, who can be of help during such a calamity. Have pity on the fallen condition of the community.' Choubeyji could not decline this prayer. A group of volunteers was promptly constituted and it set out under Panditji's leadership. A grand farewell feast was given in his honour, a charitable rich man presented him with a purse, and thousands gathered at the railway station to bid him farewell.

Writing an account of the journey is not required. At every major station on the way, the volunteers were welcomed with honour. At many places, purses were presented. The Ratlam principality gifted an awning. A motor car was given by the Baroda principality so that volunteers would not have

to suffer walking on foot. By the time they reached Madras, the volunteers' group had collected many other useful things, apart from a substantial sum.

In Madras, the Hindu Sabha camped in an open ground far from habitation. The national flag was raised above the camp. The volunteers put on their uniforms, local wealthy tycoons sent provisions for a feast and tents were pitched. The hustle bustle was such that it seemed as if a king were camping there.

3

It was eight o'clock at night. Close to a settlement of untouchables, the camp of the volunteers was glittering under the gaslights. Many thousands had gathered, amongst whom most were untouchables. Separate burlap seating was laid out for them. The Hindus of higher castes were seated on carpets. Pandit Leeladhar's invigorating lecture was on. 'You are the children of the same seers who could create a new world beneath the heavens! The very same to whose justice, wisdom and intellect the entire world bows today.' Suddenly, an old untouchable man rose and questioned, 'Are we too children of the same seers?'

Leeladhar replied, 'Without doubt! The blood coursing through your veins is of the very same seers, and even though the cruel, hard-hearted, thoughtless and narrow-minded Hindu society of today looks down upon you with disdain, you are not inferior to any Hindu, no matter how superior he might consider himself to be.'

The old man countered, 'Then why does your Sabha not remember us in its programmes?'

Leeladhar said, 'The Hindu Sabha was founded just sometime ago, and they can be proud of whatever they have achieved in this short period. The Hindu community has woken up after centuries of slumber, and the time is nigh when, in India, no Hindu will think of another Hindu as inferior, and all will think of all as brothers. Lord Rama had embraced Nishada, who was a tribal, and accepted the half-eaten berries of Shabari, an untouchable—'

The old man countered again, ‘If you are really the children of such great beings, why do you so wholly believe in the separation of the high and the low?’

Leeladhar tried to explain, ‘Because we have fallen. Ignorance has made us forget those great souls.’

The old man continued, ‘So now that your slumber is broken, will you eat with us?’

Leeladhar responded, ‘I have no objection.’

The old man was not done yet, and threw another challenge, ‘Will you have your daughter marry my son?’

Leeladhar, trying to save his face, said, ‘Until you change your birth rituals, until your lifestyle has undergone a transformation, we cannot establish marital relations with you. Give up meat eating, give up alcohol drinking, accept education. Only then can you mingle with high-caste Hindus.’

Finally the old man burst out, ‘We know many such high-born Brahmins who stay inebriated day and night, and do not eat a morsel without meat, and there are many who are also completely illiterate, but I see you dining with them. You will never refuse to have marital relations with them. When you yourself are wallowing in ignorance, how can you uplift us? Even now your heart is full of pride. Go and reform your soul for a few more days. You cannot uplift us even if you try. So long as we are part of the Hindu community, our foreheads will remain stained with the mark of inferiority. However learned we become, however genteel we become, you will think of us as inferior as you do now. The conscience of Hindus has died and arrogance has taken its place! Now we are taking refuge in that god whose followers are ready to embrace us as we are today. They do not demand that we join them by giving up our culture. Whether we are good or evil—they are calling out to us in our present condition. If you are high-born, stay high. We have no need of flying high.’

Leeladhar made a feeble attempt, ‘Such words from a child of the seers astonish me. It was the seers who separated the varnas. How can you erase that?’

The old man fired the last salvo, ‘Don’t heap ignominy on the seers. All this false ritualism was invented by you people. You accuse us of drinking alcohol but you prostrate yourself before drunkards. You cringe from us because we eat meat, but you supplicate yourself before beef eaters. Only because they are more powerful than you! Today if we were to become kings, you would stand before us with folded hands. In your religion, the powerful is superior, and the powerless inferior. Is this your religion?’

Having said this, the old man left the gathering and many other people followed him. Only Choubeyji and some members of his group were left on the stage, like a recital’s echo hanging in the air long after the performance has concluded.

4

When the Tablighis heard of Choubeyji’s arrival, they were worried, anxious and determined to keep him away from the people. Choubeyji’s name was known far and wide. The Tablighis knew that if he persisted there, all their own efforts would become futile. *He should not be allowed to plant his feet there.* The maulvis started thinking of a solution. After much debate, fuss and argument, it was decided that this kafir had to be assassinated. There was no shortage of men eager to earn such merit. The gates of paradise would open for such a man, the virgins of paradise would bless him, the angels would collect the dust of his feet as kohl, the Prophet will bless him with prosperity, and the godly would embrace him, calling him their dear friend. Two strong young men promptly assumed the responsibility.

It was past ten o’clock in the night. Silence spread across the Hindu Sabha camp. Only Choubeyji was awake in his tent, writing a letter to the minister of the Hindu Sabha. ‘The greatest requirement here is that of money. Money! Money! Money! Send as much as you can. Send out deputations for collections, dig into the pockets of rich moneylenders, or beg. The unfortunate here cannot be uplifted without money. Unless a school is opened, a hospital is established, or there is a library, how will

they believe that the Hindu Sabha is concerned about their welfare? If I can manage even half of what the Tablighis are spending, the standard of Hindu religion will fly high. Just speeches will not do the trick. Only blessings are not enough for survival.'

Suddenly he heard someone's footsteps and was startled. Raising his eyes, he saw two men standing there. Suspicious of them, Panditji inquired, 'Who are you? Why have you come here?' The response came, 'We are angels of Israel. We have come to capture your soul. Israel has summoned you.'

Panditji, who was otherwise a very strong man, could have pushed them to the ground with just one shove. In the morning, his breakfast comprised three quarters of semolina pudding and two litres of milk. For lunch he laced his dal with a quarter measure of ghee, and in the evening, he consumed hemp with milk, mixed with a *ser* of cream and half a ser of almonds. Then he ate a heavy dinner because after that he would not eat anything till morning. The crowning glory was that he never walked even one step! What pleasure if a palanquin could be arranged! It would feel as if his bed was flying through the air. If nothing, at least the buggy was there, although there were very few buggy drivers in Kashi who, when they saw Choubeyji, did not declare, 'The buggy is already hired.' In a wrestling mud pit, such a man could tire out an opponent just by lying flat on the ground and not moving at all. On occasions that required agility and swiftness, he proved to be a turtle out for a walk in the sand.

Panditji spied the door from the corner of his eye. There was no opportunity to escape. This infused some courage into him, courage which comes when the threshold of fear is breached. He reached for his cane and thundered, 'Get out of here!'

An attack of canes began even before he could complete his words. Panditji fell down unconscious. His enemies approached him for inspection and, finding no sign of life, took the mission to be accomplished. They had not planned to loot the place but what harm was there in reaching out for things when there was no one to question it? Whatever they could find, they gathered, and set off.

5

In the morning, when the old untouchable man strolled past the camp, there was absolute silence there. Not a soul could be seen! Even the tents had vanished! He wondered what the matter was. Everything had disappeared overnight, just like Aladdin's castles. Not even one of those who'd feasted on semolina pudding in the morning and churned hemp in the evening could be seen. As he went closer and peeped into Pandit Leeladhar's tent, his heart seemed to stop beating! Like a corpse, Panditji was lying on the ground. Flies buzzed around his mouth and blood had clotted in his hair like the colours of a painter's brush. His clothes too were soaked with blood. He understood that Panditji's companions had killed him and gone their own way. Suddenly, a cry of agony escaped Panditji mouth. The old man thought, 'There is still some life left.' The old man ran back to his village and gathered some men to carry Panditji to his own house.

Then began the dressing and nursing. The old man sat next to Panditji all day and night. His family members too busied themselves with serving Panditji and the villagers extended help in whatever capacity they could. They would argue, 'Which dear one of his is here? Familiar or stranger, we are the only ones. He came here to uplift us, otherwise what reason did he have to come here?' Panditji had taken ill many times at home too, but his family had not nursed him with such dedication. The whole family of the old man . . . in fact the whole village had devoted itself to Panditji's service. Selfishness that comes with civilization had not yet strangled the feeling of serving guests as if it was a religious duty. Even today the rustic shaman hurries and covers five or ten miles on foot to cure snakebites, even on a dark, overcast winter night. He does not double his fee or demand a ride. The old man even cleaned Panditji's natural waste, ignored his reprimands, and begged the entire village for milk for Panditji. And he did all this without ever complaining about it. If his family neglected Panditji while he was away, he would scold everybody when he returned.

Panditji recuperated after a month and it was only then that he came to know the extent of their beneficence. He realized, 'It was these people's

efforts that saved me from the jaws of death, otherwise was I not already dead? The people whom I considered lowly and whose uplift I took up as my responsibility are far greater than me. In a situation like this I would have just sent the patient to a hospital and prided myself on my dutifulness, and would have believed that I had brought glory to ancestors like Dadhichi and Harishchandra.' Every hair on his body blessed these godlike people.

6

Three months passed in this manner. Neither the Hindu Sabha nor Panditji's family sought any news of him. The Sabha mouthpiece shed tears on his death and praised his work. A fund was instituted to collect money for building a memorial to him. His own family gave up the matter after some mourning.

Far away, Panditji was fortifying his body on a diet of milk and ghee. His face was flushed with a greatly rejuvenated blood flow and his body too became healthy. The country climate achieved what at one time could not be achieved by cream and butter. Although he was now not as presentable as before, he did become doubly swift and agile. There was no trace of the earlier sloth that was caused by obesity. New life was infused into him.

Winter had begun. Panditji was making preparations for returning home. Meanwhile, the village was struck by plague and three men fell sick. The old Chaudhuri was among them. Their families fled, abandoning them. Abandoning patients suffering from diseases, considered to be a curse of the goddess, was a custom in that village. Saving them was tantamount to confronting the gods, and where could they flee after such confrontation? How could they dare to snatch away God's chosen ones? They tried to take Panditji along with them but he refused. He decided to stay put in the village and try and save the sick. In such a situation, how could he abandon the man who had pulled him out of the jaws of death? Beneficence had awakened his soul. On the third day, when the old man regained consciousness and found Panditji standing next to him, he said, 'Sir, why have you come here? The gods have summoned me to them. There is no

way I can live any more. Why should you put your own life in danger? Have mercy on me. Leave.'

This had no effect on Panditji. He would go to the three patients by turns and treat their tonsils or tell them stories from the Puranas. There were provisions, utensils and other such things lying about in the houses abandoned by their owners. Panditji used these to concoct potions and feed them. At night, when the patients slept and the entire village felt eerie and haunted, Panditji had visions of ferocious beings. Out of fear, his heartbeat would rise, but his resolve to stay back was not weakened. He had decided that either he would save these men or sacrifice himself for them. When the patients' condition did not improve even after three days of nursing, Panditji was greatly worried. The town was ten miles away. There were no railways around, the road passed through the wilderness and there was no other transport available. Panditji was also concerned about what might happen to the patients if they were left alone. A hapless Panditji was greatly troubled. Finally, on the fourth day, when dawn was still a quarter of the night away, he left for the city on foot and reached there at about ten in the morning. He had to face great difficulty in obtaining medicines from the hospital, where the authorities were charging obnoxious rates from the rustic villagers for the medicines. Why would they give it to Panditji for free? Addressing his assistant though it was intended for Panditji, the doctor said, 'The medicine is not ready.'

Panditji pleaded, 'Sir, I have come from very far. Many people are lying sick. Without the medicine, all of them will perish.'

The assistant replied with irritation, 'Why are you bothering me? I've told you the medicine is not ready, nor can it be prepared in such a hurry.'

Panditji pleaded again, abasing himself, 'Sir, I am a Brahmin. May God make your children live long. Have mercy. May your glory last long.'

How can a corrupt worker have the quality of mercy? They are vassals to money. The more Panditji pleaded with him, the more annoyed he became. Never in his life had Panditji demeaned himself in this manner. At that moment, he did not have even a dime with him. If he had known that there would be such great difficulty in obtaining the medicine, he would have

begged and collected some money from the villagers. Poor Panditji stood there helpless and perturbed, thinking about what he should do now. Suddenly the doctor came out of the bungalow. Panditji leapt and fell at his feet and spoke in a pitiful voice, ‘O friend of the fallen! Three men of my house are sick with the plague. I am very poor, Sir. Please give some medicine.’

The doctor was used to such poor people coming to him every day. Someone falling at his feet or crying and prostrating himself before him was nothing new. If he showed compassion on this scale, then his own worth would be reduced to that of the medicines. Where, then, would all the luxury come from? However evil, though, he was at heart, he did talk sweetly. Pulling back his feet, he said, ‘Where is the patient?’

Panditji told him, ‘They are at home, Sir. How could I get them so far?’

The doctor expressed irritation. ‘The patient is at home and you have come to get the medicine? How funny! How can I prescribe a remedy without seeing the patient?’

Panditji realized his mistake. How *could* the disease be diagnosed without seeing the patient? But it was not easy to get all the three patients so far. If the villagers helped, palanquins could be arranged. But here he had to accomplish everything on his own strength. There was no hope of getting help from the villagers. Let alone extending any help, they behaved as if they were his enemies. They feared that the rascal was going to invite some calamity by escalating confrontation with the gods. If it had been some other man, they would have killed him long ago. They, however, had developed affection for Panditji, which is why they had spared his life.

Although Panditji did not have the audacity to say anything further after hearing the doctor’s response, he gathered himself and said, ‘Sir, can nothing be done now?’

The doctor informed him, ‘You can’t get medicine from the hospital. I can give some from my own stock but that will be charged.’

Panditji asked, ‘How much will this medicine cost, Sir?’

The doctor told him the price—ten rupees—and added that this medicine would be more beneficial than the one from the hospital. He said, ‘There

the medicine is old. The poor go there and get the medicine. Whoever is destined to live lives; whoever is destined to die dies. None of my concern. The medicine I will give you is the real thing.'

Ten rupees! At that moment, ten rupees seemed equivalent to ten lakh rupees to Panditji. Although he was used to spending such amounts every day on hemp and weed, now he was desperate for just a dime. He had no hope of getting credit from anyone. Although it was possible that begging, of course, might get him something, there was no way he could get ten rupees so quickly. For half an hour, he stood there in confusion. He could not think of any way other than begging but he had never had the occasion to beg. Of course, he had collected donations, even thousands on a single round, but this was different. There was a singular pride in collecting donations as a protector of the faith, a servant of the community and a rescuer of Dalits. Accepting donations was a favour done to donors. But here he must stretch out his palm like beggars, must plead and bear insults. Someone might taunt, 'You are so healthy. Why don't you labour? Aren't you ashamed of begging?' Someone else might say, 'Go cut some grass. I will give you a good wage.' Nobody would believe him to be a Brahmin. If only he had his silk coat and his turban with him, or even a saffron scarf, he could pull off an act. He could pretend to be an astrologer and entrap any rich merchant, and he was anyway quite accomplished in that art. But here he had none of this. Even all his clothes had been robbed. If he stood in a field and delivered a delightful speech, then perhaps he would get a few devotees but this did not occur to him at all because when adversity strikes, even the brains get stunted. He could prove the magic of his words from a podium in an ornate enclosure standing in front of a desk decorated with flowers. But who would listen to his speeches when he was in such a terrible condition? People would think it was the gibberish of a madman.

The afternoon, however, was fading. There was no time for much deliberation. If it got late and dusk fell, it would be impossible to return at night. Who knows what might happen to the patients then? He could not wait in that state of indecision any more. There was no way other than

begging, no matter how much he was humiliated or how much insult he would have to tolerate.

He reached the marketplace and stood in front of a shop but could not gather enough courage to beg for anything. The shopkeeper asked, 'What do you want?'

Panditji replied, 'What's the going rate for rice?'

At the next shop, however, Panditji turned more cautious. The trader was seated on a mattress. Panditji stood before him and recited a hymn from the Bhagavad Gita. The rich trader, amazed at his clear intonation and sweet voice, inquired, 'Where are you from?'

Panditji told him, 'I have come from Kashi.'

Panditji then proceeded to explain the ten signs of dharma and elaborated so well on the hymn that the trader was captivated. He requested, 'Sir, please accept my invitation and grace my house with your presence.'

A selfish man would have readily accepted the proposal but returning to the village was a more pressing concern for Panditji. He declined, saying, 'No, Sir, I do not have the time.'

The trader persisted with his request. 'Sir, you must grant me at least this much.'

When the trader could not get Panditji to agree to stay, he became pensive and said, 'Then how may I serve you? Command me. Your voice was not enough to satiate me. Should you arrive here again, bless me with your presence.'

Panditji answered, 'If you respect me so much, I will surely come.'

He then stood up, his lips having been sealed by hesitation. He thought, *The respect and welcome was extended only because I concealed my selfish motives. His eyes will turn away as soon as I express any want. Maybe he will not reject it outright, but there will be no more respect*. He descended the steps and stood on the street for a moment, pondering, *Where can I go now*? Meanwhile, the winter day was fading like the wealth of a debauchee. He was getting frustrated with himself. *Unless I beg from somebody, why would anyone give me anything? Does anyone know my heart? Gone are the days when rich men worshipped Brahmins. I must quit the hope that*

some good man will come and place the money in my hands. He proceeded with slow steps.

Suddenly, the trader called after him, 'Panditji, please wait.' Panditji stopped, thinking, *Surely he is coming to request me once again to visit his house. Why could he not have brought a one-rupee note? Wonder what he wants from me at home*.

But when the trader actually placed a gold coin at his feet, Panditji's eyes welled up with tears of gratitude, and he said to himself, 'Really? The world still has real saintly men, otherwise would this earth not sink into the abyss?' At this moment, even if he had been asked for a litre or two of his own blood for the trader's well-being, he would have given it gladly. With his throat overwhelmed with happiness, he said, 'This was not required, Sir! I'm not a monk! I'm your servant.'

The trader replied politely and respectfully, 'My lord, please accept this. This is not charity, but a gift. Even I can tell a man's character. Many mendicants, hermits and servants of the nation and the faith keep visiting, but I don't know why my heart never feels any devotion for them. Getting rid of them becomes my only concern. I sensed from your hesitation that this is not your profession. You are learned and holy but in the midst of a crisis. Accept this lowly gift and bless me.'

7

When Panditji left for the village after collecting the medicines, his heart was jumping with joy, celebration and victory. Even Lord Hanuman would not have been so happy at finding the *sanjivani* herb. Panditji had never experienced such true happiness. His heart had never felt such lofty emotions.

Very little of the day was left. The sun god was running to the west with unstoppable speed. Was He too running to give medicine to some patient? Running with great speed, He hid behind a hill. Panditji picked up his pace, as if he was determined to catch up with the sun god.

Darkness fell very soon, and a star or two became visible in the sky. The destination was still ten miles away. Just as a housewife, upon seeing dark clouds, rushes to retrieve goods spread out for drying, Leeladhar too started running. He was not scared of travelling alone but of straying from the path because of the darkness. On both sides of the road, he was quickly leaving behind several hamlets. At this hour, Panditji found these villages to be balmy. He noticed the great pleasure with which people were warming themselves around bonfires.

Suddenly, he spotted a dog. God knows where he came from and how he came to be walking on the trail ahead of him. Panditji was startled but in a moment he recognized the dog. He was Moti, the old Chaudhuri's dog. Panditji said to himself, 'How has he come out so far from the village today? Does he know that I am coming with medicines and does not want me to lose my way? Who is the knowledgeable one here?' When he called out 'Moti' just once, the dog wagged his tail but did not halt. He did not want to waste time introducing himself. Panditji realized that God was with him and it was He who was protecting him. Now he was confident of reaching home safely.

Panditji reached home just as the clock was about to strike ten.

The illness was not fatal but it was Panditji's fortune to be of help. Three weeks later, all three patients recovered. Panditji's fame spread far and wide. He had rescued these men by waging a fierce battle against Yama, the god of death. He had achieved victory even over the gods. He had proved that the impossible could be made possible. He himself was now looked upon as God. People now came from far and wide to see him, but Panditji did not derive as much pleasure from his fame as from seeing the patients walk around in health.

The Chaudhuri said to him, 'Sir, you truly are God. We could not have survived had you not come here.'

Panditji replied, 'I didn't do anything. It is all God's mercy.'

The Chaudhuri said, 'Now we will never let you leave. Go get your wife and children also.'

Panditji agreed, ‘Yes, I am of the same opinion. Now I can’t leave you and go from here.’

8

Having found the battlefield vacant, the mullahs had been exercising great influence in the nearby villages. Village after village was converting to Islam. Meanwhile, the Hindu Sabha had also withdrawn. No one was courageous enough to venture this way, though sitting afar, people were firing ammunition at Muslims. How to avenge Panditji’s murder was their gravest concern. Officials were being regularly petitioned that the matter be investigated and the response was always that the assassins had not been traced. The collection for Panditji’s memorial also continued unabated in the meantime.

But this new light left the mullahs pale. A god who could resurrect the dead, who could sacrifice his own life for the welfare of his devotees, had incarnated in the village. This accomplishment, this potion, this miracle was not available to the mullahs. How could vacuous arguments of paradise or fraternity counter such glowing beneficence? Even Panditji was now not the same Panditji who had been arrogant about his caste and learning. He had learned to respect the Shudras and the Bhils. Embracing them did not make Panditji cringe any more. It was only when they had found darkness at home that they had turned to the Islamic light. Now that their own houses were flushed with the light of the sun, why would they need to go elsewhere? Sanatan dharma emerged victorious. Temples were being built in every village and conch shells and bells could be heard at dawn and dusk in these temples. People’s conduct started changing on its own. Panditji did not make anyone pure. Now even the name of the ritual, shuddhi, embarrassed him. He questioned himself, *What purification can I accord to them? Let me first purify myself. I cannot insult such pure and sacred souls with the pretence of shuddhi*.

This was the mantra that he learned from the Chandals and it was through the power of this mantra that he achieved success in protecting his own

religion.

Panditji is still alive, but now he lives with his whole family in that very province, with those very Bhils.

Translated from the Hindi by Vikas Jain



The Thread of Love

1

There are a few men in the world who derive as much pleasure from other people's praise of their wives' beauty as from hearing of their own fame. The number of such men is increasing with the spread of Western culture. Pashupatinath Varma belonged to this category. He would gloat with happiness and pride when people praised his wife, who was an exemplary beauty, and said, 'Oho! What unmatched beauty! What heavenly beauty!'

It was evening and the car was ready. Varmaji was about to set out for a drive but Prabha was not very keen on it. Seated in a chair, she was reading a novel.

Varmaji said, 'So you're still reading?'

'I don't feel like going out at this hour.'

'No, dear! It will be an atrocity if you don't come. It is my wish that people outside should also see this luscious beauty of yours.'

'No. It is not my wish. The glow of my beauty is for you alone and I want to show this only to you.'

'No. I am not so blinded by selfishness. When you walk outside, I want to hear people say, "What a charming portrait! What a fortunate man Pashupati is!"'

‘*You* might want that, but I do not. So it is decided then that I am not going anywhere today! You don’t go either. We will both walk in our own garden. You can lie down on the lush grass next to the pond, and I will play the lute, and make a garland of flowers for you. I will play hide and seek with you in the moonlight.’

‘No, no, Prabha. We must go today. You promised Krishna that we would meet today. She must be waiting for us. She will be very upset if we do not visit.’

Hai! That Krishna! Again and again, that same Krishna! Every day this name flew out of her husband’s mouth like a spark and incinerated Prabha to ashes.

It was only now that Prabha realized why he was so eager to go out today! She explained it to herself, *This is why he was pleading with me to do up my hair. All this preparation was only for a rendezvous with that slut Krishna!*

In a firm voice, she declared, ‘Go if you wish, I will not.’

Varmaji replied, ‘Fair enough, I will go alone.’

2

After Pashupati left, Prabha felt as if the garden was closing in on her to devour her. Her gentle heart started burning in the fire of jealousy. She thought, *He must be promenading with Krishna. That Krishna, whose flowing tresses are like the coils of a cobra, whose eyes are full of venom! Why do men have such blunt brains? Has Krishna’s coquetry charmed him so much? Even the soles of my feet are more beautiful than her face. All right, I have borne a child and she is still a maiden, so what? But I should find out what they are talking about*.

With this thought, she went to her mother-in-law and said, ‘Amma, it scares me to be alone at this hour. Let’s go somewhere.’

The mother-in-law loved her greatly, so she agreed to go along. They got the carriage ready and set out. Prabha’s make-up gave the impression that

she was very happy, even though a fierce rage was burning within her. But she hid her anger by beginning to sing in a sweet voice.

The carriage was racing through a charming grove now. The pleasant shade of tall trees fell on both sides of the road. The well-bred horses of the carriage were tip-tapping, moving forward with heads and tails raised in pride. Looking ahead, Prabha said to herself, 'Aha! That, in front, is Krishna's bungalow, the one with rose bushes on all four sides.' To her, those blooms felt like cruel thorns piercing her heart. She cast a cursory glance at the bungalow. Pashupati could not be seen but Krishna and her sister, Maya, were strolling in the garden. The carriage had just gone past the bungalow when the two sisters called out to Prabha and, within a moment, both the girls raced to the gate, running and jumping like does. The carriage came to a halt.

Krishna said smilingly to the mother-in-law, 'Ammaji, leave Prabha with us for an hour or so today. You can take her back when you return from the ride.' With that the sisters pulled Prabha out of the carriage. How could the mother-in-law refuse? When the carriage left, the sisters took Prabha to the garden and sat her down on a bench. Prabha hesitated to talk to them. She tried to converse with a smile on her face because she did not want to express the feelings of her heart. Her heart, however, stayed hesitant.

Throwing a sharp glance at Prabha's sari, Krishna said, 'Sister, did you buy this sari recently? Its pink colour does not suit you. Why didn't you get some other colour?'

Prabha replied, 'It was his choice. What could I do?'

Both the sisters laughed uproariously. Then Maya said, 'What can one say about that gentleman's taste? It's different from the entire world. He just passed by. The turban on his head was redder than this sari.'

Suddenly, Pashupati, on his way back from the ride, passed that way. When he saw Prabha with the sisters, he wanted to stop the car. He thought it indecent to meet them by himself, which is why he had wanted Prabha to come along with him. Earlier, while going on the ride, he could not bring himself to stop there despite summoning much courage. Now, when he saw

Prabha there, he had a great desire to visit the house, but hearing the resonant laughter of the sisters, he hesitated and did not get out of the car.

The three elegant ladies sat in silence for some time. Then Krishna said, 'Pashupati Babu wants to come here, but cannot because of embarrassment. It is my view that relatives should not have such hesitation between them. As far as I am concerned, I think this social code is nasty. What do you think, Prabha?'

Prabha said mockingly, 'This is injustice on the part of society.'

Prabha, who was at this moment staring at the ground, had such disgust in her eyes that it transformed the sisters' banter into shamefaced silence. A fiery glance darted from her eyes and burnt down their drollery and slut-like behaviour which had pierced her loyal heart like arrows—her heart which had no place for anybody other than her husband.

When Maya noticed that Prabha was full of rage, she rose from the bench and said, 'Come, let us walk. It is surely better than sitting here.'

Prabha did not rise, but the sisters started strolling in the garden. It was then that Prabha's attention was drawn to their clothes and jewellery. Maya was wearing a pink sari of fine Bengal silk, with numerous pleats. She was carrying a silk parasol in her hand, which she had kept open to shield herself from the dying rays of the sun. Krishna's attire was similar, though her sari was yellow, and her curly hair, escaping the sari, was frolicking on her cheeks and forehead.

Just one look at these women made Prabha realize that neither of them loved her husband. A debauchery-like obsession with fun and banter would bring not only infamy to them but also disrepute to her simple-minded husband. She swore to herself that she'd save her dear bumblebee from these poisonous flowers and, come what may, she wouldn't let him hover around them. These flowers only have beauty and fragrance but not a bit of nectar.

The moment Prabha returned home, she went to the room where her daughter, Shanta, was playing in her nanny's lap. Her eyes welled up at the sight of her young, full-of-life, doll-like daughter's face. Overcome by motherly affection, she picked up the child, as if protecting her from some

ferocious beast. In that moment of unbearable agony, she said suddenly, ‘My child! There are people who want to snatch your father away from you! Hai! Will you now become an orphan? No, no! If I have my way, I will save him with these feeble hands of mine.’

From that day Prabha immersed herself in depressive thoughts and emotions. Imagining the impending calamity, she’d sometimes be overcome by fear and cry out. A vision floated before her eyes. A vision of the imminent disaster which was hurtling towards her, but her daughter’s lisping words and the pure light of her eyes would calm her turbulent heart. Prabha would then take the girl in her lap and the sweet smile which played on the thin, pink lips of her child would scatter away all of her worries and fears. The glint of hope in the child’s trusting eyes would assure her.

Hah! Unfortunate Prabha! Do you even know what is going to befall you?

3

It was a moonlit summer night and the faint, cool glow of the seventh-day moon spread across the world. Holding a branch of a jasmine tree and leaning against its trunk, Pashupati was gazing steadily at Maya’s room. The door was open. In the quiet of the night, the rustle of their saris, mingled with the sweet voice of the two maidens, faded into the sky before reaching his ears. Suddenly, the sisters came out of the room and walked straight towards where Pashupati was standing. As they approached the tree, Krishna was startled to see Pashupati’s shadow and exclaimed, ‘Look, sister, what do we have here?’

Pashupati stepped forward and stood before them. Krishna recognized him and said harshly, ‘What are you doing here? Tell me, why are you here? Quick!’

Pashupati lost his bearings. He forgot all the amorous lines that he had memorized for this occasion. Collecting himself, he said, ‘Nothing, darling. This evening when I was passing by your house, I heard you telling your

sister that you would sit under this tree to savour the moonlight. I also . . . to say something to you . . . at your feet . . . to surrender . . .'

A naughty twinkle escaped Krishna's eyes when she heard this and, with a hint of a mocking smile, she said, 'Look, Mister, you are acting weird today. Please get up from my feet and whatever you want to say, say quickly, and shed all your tears in one second. I don't like those who stammer and stutter while imploring. Say whatever you wish to say . . . So you won't speak up? All right, time's up. I am leaving.'

Krishna walked away. Maya followed her. Pashupati stood fixed for a moment, and then he followed them. It was as if he was a needle drawn naturally towards a magnet.

Suddenly, Krishna stopped and said, 'Listen, Pashupati Babu, this evening while I was talking to Prabha, I understood that she does not approve of us meeting.'

Pashupati said, 'Don't even talk of Prabha.'

Krishna chastised him, 'Why should I not? Is she not your wife? At this hour, leaving her alone at home, what have you come to say? That I should not speak of her?'

Pashupati replied, 'No. To tell you that this harsh separation is now unbearable!'

Krishna laughed uproariously and said, 'You seem to be proficient at this art. Love! Surrender! Fiery separation! Where have you learnt these words from?'

Pashupati tried to answer, 'Krishna, I love you so much that I am going insane.'

'Why do you not love Prabha?'

'I am your devotee.'

'But why do you forget that you are Prabha's master?'

'To you, I'm a slave.'

'I don't want to hear such things.'

'You'll have to hear everything I say. I'll do whatever you want.'

'And what if Prabha comes to know of all this?'

‘If she does, so be it. I am prepared for everything. I’ll die if you do not look at me with mercy.’

‘Don’t you think of your wife when you say such things?’

‘I don’t want to be her husband. I was created to be your slave. The fragrance that is emanating from that pink sari of yours is all that my life is. These tiny, beautiful feet of yours are my life. Your laughter, your vision, your every limb is my life. I was born only for you.’

Finally, Krishna had to shut him up, saying, ‘My ears are now tired of hearing all this. I do not have time for this lecture and this prosaic poetry. Come Maya, I am feeling cold. Let’s go and sit inside.’

Darkness spread before Pashupati’s eyes when he heard these cruel words. But even now his heart wanted him to fall at Krishna’s feet and narrate his love story in even more poignant words. The sisters, however, had reached their room by this time and shut the door. There was nothing left for Pashupati to do except feel disheartened and return home.

Krishna went back to her room and, feeling somewhat exhausted, sat down in a chair and reflected, ‘Prabha will make a mountain out of a molehill if she hears this. It will become the talk of the town and we won’t be able to show our faces anywhere. And all this because of some harmless banter! But there is no doubt that Pashupati’s love is true. Whatever he says, he says it from his heart. He will desert Prabha if I give him even the slightest hint. He is not in control of himself, he is ready to do whatever I command. But no, Prabha, don’t worry, I won’t let you down. You’re much beneath me. It’s not a matter of pride for my peerless beauty that I win a contest against one without beauty, like you. Unfortunate Pashupati! Whatever was destined for you has already happened. I pity you, but what can be done!’

4

One letter had already been discovered. This was the second letter that Prabha found in the pocket of her husband’s coat. What kind of letter? Ah! Reading the letter, Prabha felt a fire rising in her body. She explained to

herself, *So it can be said that now he belongs to Krishna. Without doubt. It is shameful for me to live any more! When life affords me no pleasure any more, why should I not cast away this burden?* The Pashupati who hadn't had an iota of interest in poetry had now turned into a poet and wrote letters to Krishna in verse. To divert her husband's attention, Prabha did whatever she could, but the torrent of love could not be stopped and in that torrent today, Prabha's life-boat was tossing away aimlessly.

It was without doubt that Prabha truly loved her husband. Surrender, however, is appeased by surrender alone. It cannot tolerate neglect and callousness. A sentiment of rebellion rose in Prabha's heart. She lost her self-pride. Innumerable pledges would take shape in her heart but she would end up crying over her helplessness and humiliation. Ah! Everything that she had had been snatched from her and she had no friend, no companion in the world!

These days Pashupati was obsessed with dressing up, getting a new suit almost every day. Seeing him combing his hair in front of the mirror, tears would flow from Prabha's eyes, and she would complain to herself, *All this preparation is for that bitch!* This anxiety stung her like a venomous snake. She would scan every word and action of her husband with a fine eye. So many things that had earlier gone unnoticed now appeared suspicious to her. She couldn't sleep at night. Sometimes she would inspect Pashupati's pockets, and at other times, read the letters kept on his table. Her days and nights were occupied by this recce.

She would reflect, 'Should I be deprived of love? Can I not be his darling? Life is not immortal and youth too will last only a few years. Will I have to live my life abandoned by him? O cruel man, you have betrayed me. You have turned your eyes away. But your greatest sin is that you have shown me the tarnished way of life. Can't I also betray you and enjoy the pleasure of blemished love? Even if it is watered by my tears, can I not make a pleasure garden for myself? There is a curly-haired young man in the house across, who looks amorously at me whenever he has the opportunity. Can I not claim domination over his heart by just one dart of love? What wrong would I have committed if I avenged your callousness in

this manner? Why, after all, did I surrender my life to my husband? Only so that I could live happily; to desire and to be desired and be the empress in the kingdom of love. But ah! All those desires are now wallowing in dust! What is left for me now? Who will mourn if I were to die today? No! They will light lamps and celebrate. Krishna will laugh and say, "Now it's only you and me. There is no hurdle, no thorn between us."'

Ultimately, Prabha got carried away in a torrent of such tainted sentiments. Her nights were now sleepless and hopeless, and a storm of blighted emotions rose up inside her with a fierce intensity. She could never love any other man. This business happens only once in a lifetime. But she could surely become somebody's darling, which required only a sweet smile and a sidelong glance. And when she becomes somebody's sweetheart, how pleasurable will the thought be that she has avenged her husband's infidelity! With what pride, what satisfaction, and what joy will she then look at his face!

It was evening and Pashupati was out for a drive. Prabha went up to the terrace and looked at the house across. The curly-haired young man was looking towards her terrace. Prabha, today, for the first time, looked smilingly at the young man. He too smiled and lowered his eyes, as if signalling that he was a seeker of her favours. Prabha looked around with pride, as if wanting to tell Pashupati, *You think that your falling at that slut's feet causes no injury to my heart. You love her, so I too will frolic with him. Why? You don't like this? You can't bear to see this scene with an undisturbed mind? Why does your blood boil? I am doing exactly what you've done!*

Ah! If Pashupati had known how his hard-heartedness had transformed the heart of this goddess-like, loyal woman, would he not be filled with remorse about his deeds? Would he not be ashamed of his deeds?

Prabha gestured to the young man, saying, 'Today we shall meet in that field on the eastern side,' and descended from the terrace.

Prabha's heart then felt a sort of curiosity which was also mixed with the joy of revenge. She went to her room and began putting on her best jewellery. In another moment, she emerged from her room wearing a light-

green silk sari and was about to set out, when Shanta called, ‘Amma, where are you going? I will also come along.’

Prabha immediately picked up the child in her lap and, as she held her in a close embrace, her motivations changed. What boundless faith, what innocent love, what unadulterated love flowed from her eyes! That moment reminded her of a mother’s obligations. Could she let her desire for romantic love trample upon her motherly affection? Could she sacrifice her motherly duty over a raging desire for revenge? Could she decimate that girl’s future, that girl’s life, for her own momentary pleasure? Two drops of tears rolled down Prabha’s eyes. She answered her own question, ‘No. Not at all. I can bear anything for my dear child.’

5

A month went by. Prabha had been trying to forget her worries, but Pashupati would bring up Krishna every day in their conversation on some pretext or the other. Sometimes he would mockingly say, ‘If you allow it, Prabha, then may I marry Krishna?’ Except for crying, how else could Prabha respond to this?

Finally, one day, Pashupati said to her beseechingly, ‘What can I say, Prabha? The image of that beautiful maiden does not leave my eyes. She has utterly ruined me.’ Saying this, he smote his forehead several times. This made Prabha’s heart stir with pity. His condition was akin to a patient who knew that death was at hand but whose desire to live grew every day. Prabha loved her husband despite all this and, in keeping with her womanly spirit, she would try to think of excuses that would make her forget his sins and forgive him.

One day Pashupati came home late at night. All through the night he kept murmuring, ‘Krishna! Krishna!’ in his sleep. Prabha heard the yowling cry of her lover and cried silently all night. Just cried and cried!

The morning found Prabha standing with a glass of milk for Pashupati, while he fell at her feet, pleading, ‘Prabha, I have a plea for you. Only you can save me or I will die. I know that hearing this will cause great pain to

you, but have mercy on me. I will never forget this benevolence of yours. Have mercy on me.'

Prabha began to tremble. In her heart, she knew what Pashupati wanted to say. She drew back in fear, kept the glass of milk on the table and, with trembling hands, covered her face which had turned pale. Nevertheless, Pashupati blurted it all out. The blaze of desire could no longer be contained, it had to burst forth. He had decided to marry Krishna. He'd keep her in a separate house and spend two nights with Prabha and then one with Krishna.

Prabha did not cry when she heard this; rather, she stood rooted to the spot. She felt as if something was choking her throat and she could not breathe.

Pashupati resumed, 'Prabha, you do not know that I have never loved you the way I do today. I can't be separated from you. I will love you all my life just as I do now, but Krishna will turn out to be the cause of my death. You alone can rescue me. Don't abandon me in her hands, my love!'

Doomed Prabha! Your permission is being sought to slaughter you! Either you will bow your head or raise it in self-pride and declare, 'I cannot accept such a deplorable proposal!'

Prabha, however, did neither. She fell unconscious on the floor. When she came to, she said, 'Very well, as you wish, but excuse me! I will go to my mother's house. Give me my Shanta.'

Crying, she went in to get Shanta and came out of the room holding the child close. Pashupati, with his head bowed in shame and guilt, followed her and said, 'Do as you wish, Prabha, and what can I say, but dear Prabha, promise that you will forgive me.' But Prabha did not reply to this and continued towards the gate. Pashupati then stepped forward, held her and, repeatedly kissing her tear-soaked cheeks, said, 'My love, do not forget me. Your memory shall always reside in my heart. Give me your ring. I will keep it close to my heart as a memento to soothe this fire. For God's sake, Prabha, do not abandon me, do not be angry with me . . . stay with your mother for a week. Then I will come and fetch you.'

Prabha extricated herself from Pashupati's hands and, holding her daughter's hand, proceeded towards the car. She didn't listen to what he was saying or give a reply.

6

'Amma, why are you laughing?'

'No, nothing.'

'What are those yellowed old pages in your hand?'

'These are receipts of outstanding debts.'

'But they look like old letters.'

'No, no.'

The fact was that Prabha did not want to reveal the truth to her fourteen-year-old adolescent daughter. They were indeed receipts of bad debts. She had found those old letters in the pages of a book today. They resembled petals that lose their hue and fragrance when kept in books for a long time. Despite this, they reminded Prabha of the days of bliss and for this reason, they remained invaluable to her.

Shanta understood that her mother was doing something she would rather not talk about. Delighted that her sorrowful mother had forgotten her sorrow that day and thinking that it would be better for her to stay in that state of happiness for as long as possible, she went out of the house on some pretext. Left alone in the room, Prabha started reading the letters again.

Ah! So much had happened in those fourteen years! So many forgotten memories flooded that forsaken one that it opened the founts of pleasure and pain together.

After Prabha had left, Pashupati had tried his best to marry Krishna, but she did not consent to it. In a state of hopelessness and rage, Pashupati left for Europe as an agent of some company. There he remembered Prabha. For some days, he kept writing letters full of pleas for her pardon and promises to come home shortly to meet her, wishing to drown the old bitterness in this new current of love. The tormented heart of the loyal Prabha once again

felt glimmers of hope and her wilted desires grew! This too, however, was a game of fate. Before long, the gallant Pashupati found himself in a new love trap and his letters stopped. Today in her hand Prabha had the letters that her husband had sent from Europe, when the wounds of despair were fresh. What sweet talk! What pleasing promises! Only later had she found out that Pashupati had married an English girl. Prabha felt as if she had been struck by lightning. Her heart was broken to pieces. All her desires were thwarted. Her frail body could not bear this blow. She caught a fever and nobody had any hope that she would survive. She herself wished for death and it seemed as if death had entwined her like a serpent. Death, though, does not visit on summons. The fever abated and Prabha resumed her life of hopelessness.

7

One day Prabha came to know that Pashupati has returned from Europe and that the Englishwoman was not with him. In fact, she was the reason for his return. The woman had stayed his companion for twelve years and then eloped with a young Englishman. This horrid and terribly cruel blow had broken Pashupati's back. He quit his job and returned home. His face had changed so much that even his friends could not recognize him when they met in the marketplace. He looked like an old man walking with a bent back. His hair too had turned grey.

After his return, one day Pashupati sent for Shanta, and she started visiting him regularly. Her heart bled for him when she saw his condition.

Meanwhile, proposals for Shanta's marriage started coming in. But Prabha's experience of her own married life forced her to reject these proposals. She would think, *What if she ends up the same way I have?* She felt that if Shanta were to be married, she would not find any peace at this later stage in her life, and even in death, she would agonize over her daughter. But finally, a proposal came from such a good family that Prabha could not say no to it. The family was extremely well-to-do and the boy too was promising. Prabha had to give her consent. The father's consent, too,

was required. Prabha wrote a letter to Pashupati about this and sent Shanta herself to deliver it. As Shanta left with the letter, Prabha went into the kitchen to attend to the cooking. All kinds of dreadful thoughts came to her mind. In the smoke rising from the stove, she detected a vision. In that vision, she saw that Shanta's thin lips were parched and that she was trembling and just as Prabha had fallen into her mother's lap after leaving her husband's house, similarly, Shanta too had collapsed into her own mother's lap.

8

Pashupati was spellbound when he read Prabha's letter. He lit his cigarette and drew hard on it.

Then he stood up and started pacing around the room, sometimes biting his moustache, sometimes scratching his salt-and-pepper-beard.

Suddenly, he came and stood close to Shanta and, in a trembling voice, said, 'How can I say "no" to a family that your mother has approved? She must have consented after much thought. May God bless you with eternal bliss. The only regret I have is that when you go to your own house, your mother will be left alone. There will be nobody to wipe her tears. Think of a way by which your mother's agony is relieved and I too do not wander around aimlessly. You alone can think of such a solution. It is possible that I would not have been able to tell you of my heart's feelings out of shame and embarrassment, but now that you are leaving, I have no choice but to cast aside my hesitation. Your mother loves you and will never deny your request. Tell her of my condition which you have seen with your own eyes. Go. May you have boundless fortune!'

Shanta clung to her father's breast, weeping. And this prematurely aged man, after having borne the consequences of his depravities, was now shedding tears of remorse and guilt, wetting Shanta's hair.

Could the loyal Prabha deny Shanta's plea? This thread of love brought the two broken hearts together.

Translated from the Hindi by Vikas Jain



The Basis of Life

1

There was not a single young man as well built as Mathura in the whole village. He was around twenty years old. His whiskers were just starting to show. He would take the cows to graze, drink some milk, do his exercises and practise wrestling and then spend the rest of the day roaming around the market playing his flute. He was married but had no children yet. The household had many arable fields to its name. He had many brothers older than him as well as younger. All the brothers worked together in the fields. The whole family was proud of Mathura. He would get the best food and had to do the minimum amount of work.

Whenever he needed money for undergarments and loincloth, it was given to him immediately. The whole family wanted Mathura to become a great wrestler and beat his competitors in the ring. All this pampering had gone to his head and made him impudent. Not caring about the cows straying into other people's fields, Mathura would just be busy working out in the wrestling arena. If anyone ever complained, Mathura's demeanour would change quickly. In a thundering voice he would say, 'Do whatever you want.' No matter what, Mathura would never leave his wrestlers' arena to look after his cattle and nobody dared to confront him because of his stature. They just pulled long faces.

It was summer. The lakes and ponds had dried up. A severe *loo* was howling. It just so happened that a bull appeared in the village and consorted with the cows. He would spend his whole day with the cows. But during the night he would enter the village to indulge in all sorts of mischief. He would butt the oxen tied to the stumps with his horns. He would gore a wall under construction or upset a household's pile of garbage. By day the farmers worked hard to grow vegetables and irrigate the lands, but by night the bull would destroy all those fields. He was beaten with sticks and driven out of the village many times but he kept reappearing. People couldn't figure out how to solve this problem. The bull couldn't harm Mathura's cows as his house was located in the middle of the village. An uproar erupted in the village but Mathura was not bothered at all.

Finally, when matters came to a head, the people surrounded Mathura and said, 'Brother! Tell us, should we stay in the village or should we leave? What is the use of staying here when our fields are no longer our own? These cows of yours will be the end of us and here you are engrossed in your own world. If God has given you power and strength, you should use it to protect others. You should not grind us up and eat us. The bull comes because of your cows and it's your duty to chase him away. But you turn a deaf ear as if it's none of your concern.'

Mathura's heart bled for them. A strong and powerful person can often have deep sympathies. He said, 'All right, go, today I will chase away the bull.'

One man said, 'Chase him away as far as possible, otherwise he will come back again.'

Placing his stick on his shoulder, Mathura replied, 'Now he will never come back again.'

2

It was a scorching afternoon and Mathura was chasing the bull away. Both were drenched in sweat. The bull kept trying to return to the village. But

Mathura, sensing his intention, would not allow him to come back. Every now and then the bull would become mad with anger and turn around to attack Mathura. But Mathura just continued to hit him back with the stick until the bull fled again. Sometimes both ran into the fields of *arhar* lentils and sometimes they ran into the bushes. Mathura's feet were now bleeding from running on the arhar stumps. His dhoti had got caught in the bushes and was torn. But Mathura was blind to everything but his task of chasing the bull away. Village after village would come and go. Mathura had decided that he would not rest till he had chased the bull away across the river. His throat became parched and his eyes reddened. Sparks seemed to fly off his body. He was breathless but he did not rest for a moment.

Only after running for over two hours did he catch sight of the river. This was the place where it would be decided who would win and who would lose. It was here that both had to display their fighting skills. The bull was thinking that if he went into the river, Mathura would surely kill him. He would stake his life on returning to the village. Mathura thought that if the bull returned to the village, all his hard work would be in vain and the whole village would make fun of him. Both were waiting for an opportunity. The bull wanted to run fast leaving Mathura behind and return to the village. But Mathura gave him no opportunity to do so. Mathura had put his life on the line. A little mistake could cost him his life, so much so that he would not stand again if his foot slipped. Finally, the human prevailed over the animal. The bull was left with no option but to plunge into the river. Mathura went after him and beat him so much that his lathi broke.

3

Now Mathura was very thirsty. He bent down and began swallowing water as though he was going to drink up the whole river. In his whole life he had neither liked water much nor drunk so much of it. Who knows whether he drank five or ten litres. But the water was warm, so his thirst was not quenched. Again he leaned into the river and drank until there was hardly

any space left inside him, even to breathe. Then he put his wet dhoti across his shoulders and started for home.

He had hardly walked five or ten steps when he started getting stomach cramps. He thought it may have happened because he had run all the way to the river. He thought the pain would subside after some time. But the pain only grew more severe and it became difficult for him to walk further. He sat under a tree. He writhed in pain and rubbed his body against the ground. Restless, he would sometimes press his stomach, then stand up and sit down again. But the pain grew worse. In the end he started groaning and crying out but who was there to pay any attention to his wailing? There was not a single village in sight. Neither man nor animal could be seen. Finally, in the stillness of the afternoon, after much writhing and wailing, Mathura succumbed to death. We can endure the worst mishap but we cannot put up with the slightest change in our daily routine. That giant-like youth who could chase a bull for many miles could not endure the assault of the elements. Who knew that his race with the bull would turn out to be a race for death? Who knew that it was death that was chasing him in the form of a bull? Who knew that water, without which life ceased to exist, would work as poison for him?

In the evening Mathura's family members started searching for him. When they saw him, it seemed as if he were taking eternal rest.

One month passed. The villagers were preoccupied with their own affairs. After much weeping and wailing, Mathura's family members consoled themselves. But how could the unfortunate widow stop her tears? The curtains of her eyes may fall but her heart would weep continuously. 'How can I survive in this house now? For what should I live?' Only saints or vagabonds can live for themselves. How would Anupa have known this art? She needed a purpose in her life. She wanted a reason that would give meaning to her life and of which she would feel proud. Nobody in the family was willing to get her remarried. They thought it would defame them. But that wasn't the only reason. The family was even more reluctant to get her remarried because of her skills: she was an expert at housework, clever at bargaining and an admirably beautiful woman. On the other hand,

Anupa's parents were trying their best to match her up with someone. When they succeeded in finding a good household for her, Anupa's brother came for the ritual farewell to send her to her second husband's home.

Panic spread in the whole household. They said, 'We will not let her leave this house.' Stubbornly Anupa's brother said he would not rest till he saw his sister remarried. Men from the entire village gathered and a panchayat was called. It was decided that Anupa should be given the discretion to choose. She could leave if she desired, or she could continue living in the same house. Her in-laws were sure that Anupa would not agree to remarry so quickly. She had often said so.

But when asked this time, she said she was ready to go. Finally preparations were made for her departure. A palanquin was ready. Women from the whole village came to catch a glimpse of it. Anupa stood up and fell at her mother-in-law's feet and pleaded with folded hands. She said, 'Amma! Forgive me if I have hurt you through any of my utterances. My heart yearned to live here forever but God's will is different.'

She uttered these words and fell silent.

Her mother-in-law was overwhelmed with compassion. She blessed her, 'Daughter! Stay happy wherever you go. If we had not been ill-fated, nothing would have compelled you to leave this house. God has given us everything. But we are helpless before what He has deprived us of. The whole problem would have been solved had your brother-in-law been of a suitable age. If your conscience permits, you consider him as your own. Nurture and raise him. I will get you engaged to him once he grows up.' She asked her youngest son, Vasudev, 'Son! Will you marry your sister-in-law?'

Vasudev was not more than five years old, but he was getting married now. It was already settled. He exclaimed, 'Then will she not go to that other house?'

'No, when she's going to be married to you, why would she go?'

'Then I will marry her.'

'All right! Ask her if she will marry you.'

Vasudev went and sat in Anupa's lap and blushed while asking, 'Will you marry me?'

And he started giggling. But Anupa's eyes brimmed with tears. Hugging Vasudev, she asked her mother-in-law, 'Amma, are you speaking from your heart?'

'God knows my intention.'

'Is he mine from today?'

'Yes, the whole village stands witness to it.'

'Then tell my brother to return home, I will not accompany him.'

Anupa needed a reason to live and now she had it. Service fills human life with emotions and becomes the reason for living.

Anupa started nurturing Vasudev with devotion. She would massage him with different unguents and oils. She would dip rotis in milk and feed him. Whenever she went to bathe in the pond, she would not only take Vasudev with her but also give him a wash. He would accompany her to the fields. Within a few days he grew so attached to her that he would not leave her even for a second. He even forgot his mother. Anupa was the only one he would ask if he wanted to eat something. If he got beaten in the fields, he would come weeping to Anupa. Only Anupa could make him go to bed and make him rise. When he fell ill, it was only Anupa who would take him to Badlo Ved's house and make him have the medicines.

Men and women throughout the village shook their heads in wonder on seeing the keenness of her love. Earlier, nobody would believe her. They thought she would tire of it after a year or two and would find another way to go on. After all, how long could she pin her hopes on this child? But all these conjectures were proved wrong. Nobody saw Anupa deviating from her aim. Where the waters of selfless love flow, the heart harbours no place for sexual desires. Sexual desires can tempt only those who are heartless, hopeless and without purpose. A thief can do his work in darkness—not in daylight.

Vasudev too had a passion for physical exercise. He resembled Mathura in his facial features and physique. He started going to the wrestlers' arena. The tune of his flute would echo in the fields.

Thirteen years passed. Preparations began for the engagement of Vasudev and Anupa.

4

But Anupa was not the same person who had seen a husband in Vasudev fourteen years ago. The wifely emotion had been replaced by maternal love and affection. For days now Anupa could be seen drowning in deep thought. Her heart was sinking as the day of their engagement neared. Imagining such a drastic change in her life would set her heart throbbing. She blushed at the thought of marrying a person she had nurtured as a son.

The drums were beating at the door. All the relatives had arrived. There was ceremonial singing in the house. It was the day of their engagement. Anupa gathered her courage and told her mother in law, 'Amma, I am dying of embarrassment.'

Astonished, her mother-in-law asked, 'Why, daughter? What's the matter?'

'I don't want to go through with this engagement.'

'What are you saying, daughter? Preparations have been made. What will people say if they hear this?'

'Let them say what they want, I will continue to live with the same name with which I have been living for fourteen years. I thought that a woman cannot live without a man but God has kept my character unblemished. When my days of youth are over, why should I care? Find a girl for Vasudev and get him engaged. I will bring up his children just the way I brought him up.'

Translated from the Urdu by Shaifta Ayoub



Qazzaqi

1

Among all my childhood memories, the most abiding is that of Qazzaqi. It has now been forty years since I last beheld him but I can still picture him quite clearly in my mind's eye. In those days, I lived with my father in a tehsil in the district of Azamgarh. Qazzaqi was an exceptionally buoyant man of the Pasi caste, who was also very courageous and dynamic. Every day he would bring us the post, stay over for the night and depart the following morning, carrying back a bagful of letters which needed to be delivered. The same evening, he would return with post that required distribution. All day long, I would await his arrival eagerly. At four o'clock sharp, impatient for him to arrive, I would go out on to the street and soon he would appear, carrying a staff on his shoulder, the bells on it ringing, running at a high speed. He was a tall and well-built young man, with a tanned complexion. His body was so perfectly sculpted that even the most meticulous artist couldn't possibly find fault with it. His small moustache set off his well-shaped features to advantage. He would run even faster after he caught sight of me, the bells on his staff ringing more noisily—my own heart would beat even louder with gladness at his arrival. I would dart across to meet him and, in a moment, Qazzaqi's shoulder would become my throne. That seat was the paradise of my naive aspiration. Perhaps even

those who dwelt in paradise would not have experienced the same level of happiness that I did sitting atop the broad shoulders of Qazzaqi. The whole world would suddenly become small and meaningless to my mind and when he would sprint away, carrying me on his shoulders, I felt I was flying on a winged horse.

By the time he arrived at the post office, Qazzaqi would be sweating profusely, but he was not in the habit of resting. He would deposit his bag and set out immediately with us towards a field. Sometimes he would play with us; at other times he would sing us *birhey* or tell us stories. He had a large repertoire of tales about burglary and larceny, murders and massacres, ghosts and banshees. I always listened to him with rapt attention, spellbound by the tales. The thieves and bandits of his stories were true heroes who stole from the wealthy to help the poor and the deprived. Rather than looking down upon them, I began to hold these men in high esteem.

2

One day, Qazzaqi was late. The sun had set but he was not to be seen. I felt rather lost and waited by the road, eyes wide, but the familiar face was nowhere in sight. I strained my ears to hear the jingle of the bells on his staff but that cheerful resonance was not to be heard. As darkness overcame daylight, my hope began to fade. Every time someone came from that direction, I would ask expectantly, ‘Is Qazzaqi on his way?’ but they either did not listen to me or merely moved on with a nod.

Suddenly, I heard the familiar jingle. In the darkness that engulfed everything around me, I could perceive only ghosts—even the sweets stacked upon the mantle shelf in my mother’s room were avoidable after dark. Despite the ghosts that cluttered my mind, I darted in the direction of the sound. Yes! It was Qazzaqi. The moment I set eyes on him, my impatience gave way to annoyance. At first, I began to hit him. Then I stood sulking a little distance away.

Qazzaqi chuckled and said, ‘I have brought something for you but if you hit me, I will not give it to you.’

Gathering my courage, I responded, ‘Okay, go, don’t give it—I do not want it.’

‘If I show it to you, you will surely grab it with both hands.’

My annoyance melted into curiosity. ‘All right, show it to me.’

‘Come, get on my shoulder—let us run away, it is rather late already—Babuji must be upset.’ I turned around and retorted, ‘First show me what you have brought!’ Had Qazzaqi not been concerned with the fact that he had got delayed, had it been possible for him to stay back even a minute longer, he might have got the better of me. He showed me what he was holding close to his heart—it had an elongated head and eyes that shone brightly. I snatched it out of Qazzaqi’s hands. It was a young deer. Ah! Who can measure the elation I felt at that moment? I have cleared many difficult examinations since then; I have been bestowed with high-ranking positions and decorated with the title of Rai Bahadur. But the ecstasy that I experienced at that moment still remains unparalleled. I carried it in my arms and, cherishing its supple and fragile body, darted towards our house. I had quite forgotten that Qazzaqi was so late. ‘From where did you get this?’ I asked him.

‘Bhaiya, there is a wood, a little distance away where deer dwell in large herds. I wanted to give you a fawn if I could lay my hands on one. Today, I saw this fawn in the herd. As I dashed towards it, the rest of the deer made a speedy escape. This one too tried to escape but could not keep pace with the adults. I grabbed it. That is why I am so late.’

The two of us arrived at the post office chatting. Babuji did not see me—neither did he see the fawn. He had eyes only for Qazzaqi. Beside himself with rage, he asked, ‘Why are you so late today? The postbag is long overdue! What can I do with it now that the post has already been sent out? Why are you so late? Answer me!’

It seemed as though Qazzaqi had lost his voice.

Babuji continued to berate him, ‘Perhaps you are no longer interested in your work. You are, after all, a mere low-caste. You get two square meals a day, now that has turned your head, has it? Perhaps you will come to your senses only when you are weak and dying of hunger.’

Qazzaqi did not utter a word.

Babuji only got angrier. He continued his tirade. ‘Put the postbag down and head straight home. The swine has come in so late with the post. But does the delay affect you at all? No! You will get employed as a manual labourer wherever you choose. But I am liable to be held responsible for your lapse. I am answerable.’

Qazzaqi looked as though he would burst into tears and said, ‘Sarkar, I will never be late again.’

‘Why are you so late today? Answer me!’

Qazzaqi had no answer. I too seemed to have lost my voice. Babuji was very short-tempered. He had to work exceedingly hard. That is why he got so cross so easily. I avoided him and he too never expressed any affection for me. He came home only twice during the day, for his meals, spending an hour each time. For the rest of the day he worked at the post office. He had put in several requests for an assistant, which had gone unheard and unheeded. The outcome was that even on holidays, Babuji would work. Only mother knew how to deal with his foul temper. But how could she come to the office? Poor Qazzaqi was fired in the dictatorial manner attributed to Nadir Shah of Afghanistan, while I stood and watched! His staff, cummerbund and turban were confiscated and he was issued marching orders to be enforced with immediate effect. Ah! At that time I longed to be in possession of the proverbially gold-rich Lanka which I could generously offer Qazzaqi, so that he would never feel the pinch of removal from service and father would know that Qazzaqi had not suffered so much as a scratch. That would teach my father a lesson! Qazzaqi was just as proud of his cummerbund as a soldier is of his sword. His hands trembled as he began to unfasten it. All the while, the root cause of his misfortunes, that tender living thing, was hidden away, seated ever so comfortably on my knees as though it were nestled in its mother’s lap. As Qazzaqi began to leave, I too got up, following him step by step. When he reached the door to my house, he spoke, ‘Bhaiya, go home. It is getting dark.’ I stood there quietly, trying exceptionally hard to fight back the flood of tears that threatened to break loose any moment. Again he addressed me, ‘Bhaiya, I

am not going far away. I will come again sometime and together we will run with you on my shoulders. Babuji has fired me but surely he will not prevent me from playing with you! I will not leave you and go anywhere. Bhaiya, go inside and tell Amma that Qazzaqi is taking leave. Will she forgive his shortcomings?'

I ran into the house but instead of saying anything to my mother, I burst out crying. Mother came out of the kitchen and asked, 'What is the matter, son? Has somebody hit you? Has Babuji said something? Wait till your father gets home. Let me find out. He always seems to be beating you—don't cry, son, and don't ever go to him again!'

I made a huge effort and managed to control myself and uttered, 'Qazzaqi . . .' My mother thought Qazzaqi had hit me. '*Achha*, let him come,' she threatened. 'I will ensure he is removed from service immediately. How dare he hit my darling boy when he is merely a *harkara*? I will have his turban and staff confiscated right now. *Wah!*'

Immediately I corrected her, 'No, Qazzaqi did not hit me. Father fired him. He confiscated his turban and his staff. Even his cummerbund has been taken away.'

'Your father was wrong to do that. The poor fellow works quite conscientiously. Why did your father dismiss him?'

'Qazzaqi got late today.' Having said that, I put the fawn down for my mother to see. There was no fear of his running away within the house. My mother had not set eyes on it as yet. The moment she did so, she became thoroughly perturbed. She dashed forward and caught hold of my hand, fearing that the petrified animal would bite me! On the one hand I was crying hysterically and, on the other, I burst out laughing at her confusion.

'Oh! This is the young one of a deer! From where did you get it?'

I narrated the entire episode of the fawn and its dreadful consequence from start to finish. 'Mother, this fawn runs so fast that no one could have ever caught it. It can run as fast as the wind. Qazzaqi chased it for about four or five hours—only then did he manage to catch hold of it for me. Mother, nobody in the whole world can run as fast as Qazzaqi. That is why he got late—but Babuji dismissed the poor man and took away his

cummerbund, turban and staff. What will he do now? He will go hungry and die.'

'Where is Qazzaqi?' asked mother. 'Bring him to me.'

'He is waiting outside. He says, "Request Ammaji to forgive my shortcomings."' All this while, mother had been making light of what I had been saying. Perhaps she thought that Babuji had merely reprimanded Qazzaqi. On hearing my last statement, however, she realized that Babuji had actually discharged Qazzaqi from service. She went out immediately and began calling out, 'Qazzaqi . . . Qazzaqi . . .' but there was no sign of him. I called out to him again and again; I wept and called out his name but in vain.

I had my dinner. Children do not go hungry even when they are crestfallen, especially if *rabri* is placed before them. However, as I lay in bed, thoughts whirled in my head till late into the night: if I were in possession of a hundred thousand rupees, I would give it to Qazzaqi and tell him to say nothing to Babuji. The poor man was going to die of hunger. Would he come tomorrow? Why should he come now? But he said he would come again. I would get him to eat with me tomorrow. I fell asleep building such castles in the air.

3

I spent the next day looking after the fawn. First I gave it a name—Munnoo. Then I introduced it to my friends and classmates. In just a day it had become so attached to me that it followed me everywhere. In the same span of time it became the central thing in my life. In the palace of my dreams that I intended to build at some point in the future, there would be a separate room for the fawn. I also intended to have a bed and phaeton for it.

By the time it was evening, however, I abandoned everything and stood on the road waiting for Qazzaqi to come. All the odds were against his arrival but somehow, something made me believe that he would come. All of a sudden it occurred to me that he could be dying somewhere for want of food. I went inside. Mother was lighting the lamps. Quietly, I took out some

flour in a basket and, dropping some along the way as I ran out, I reached the road. Hardly had I done so when I saw Qazzaqi coming towards me. He carried a staff; on his waist he wore a cummerbund and on his head was a turban. I ran over to him and threw my arms around his waist and, in undisguised surprise, I inquired, 'From where did you get the cummerbund and the staff, Qazzaqi?' He lifted me in his arms and, raising me on to his shoulders, he replied, 'Of what use was that cummerbund, Bhaiya? It was the cummerbund of servitude. This one is a cummerbund of my own making. At first I was in the employ of the government but now I am at your service!'

As he was saying this, his eyes fell upon the flour basket kept right there. 'What is this flour for, Bhaiya?' he asked. A little embarrassed, I responded, 'I have brought it for you. You must be hungry. What did you eat today?' I could not see Qazzaqi's eyes, for I was seated on his shoulders, but yes, from the tone of his voice I could judge that he was overwhelmed. 'Bhaiya, how can I eat chapati? There is neither salt nor dal and no ghee either.'

I felt thoroughly ashamed. He was right. How could the wretched man eat dry chapatis? But how could I procure salt, dal and ghee? Now my mother would be in the kitchen. With immense good fortune I had managed to make off with the flour. (I was quite ignorant of the fact that my theft had already been discovered, given away by the trail of flour on the floor.) How could I get hold of these three things now? My mother would never give them to me if I requested her. She made me grovel for hours for every paisa that I asked for—why would she give me all these things? All of a sudden it struck me that I had several annas and paise in my school bag. As a child, I took great pleasure in collecting small sums of money—I do not know when I grew out of this habit. Had the practice persisted, perhaps I wouldn't be as hard-pressed for funds as I am today. Babuji never expressed any fondness for me but he ensured that he kept my pockets warm, possibly because he was so busy all the time that he wanted to rid himself of me. He must have thought that this was the easiest way. Were he to refuse, he ran the risk of my crying or throwing tantrums. He pre-empted the consequence and avoided the hazard. Mother's disposition was quite the reverse. She

never felt threatened by my crabbiness. Perhaps because she could continue with her household chores despite my tantrums. A man can lounge in bed all day long and listen to someone crying but any raucousness can be disturbing while one is engrossed in making mathematical calculations. Mother loved me very much but the instant anybody made a reference to money, her humour underwent a radical change. I did not have any books but I did own a bag in which I kept a few forms from the post office, folded over like a book. I wondered if the money I had would suffice for the purchase of dal, salt and ghee. After all, I could not clutch all of it in my fist. Having thought about all this, I addressed Qazzaqi, 'If you put me down, I will fetch you some dal and salt. But do you promise to visit me every day?'

'Bhaiya, why would I refuse to come if you fed me every day?'

Instantly I responded, 'I will provide you with food every day.'

'Then I will visit you every day.'

I got down from my perch and ran into the house to fetch the money I had. Were I in possession of the Kohinoor diamond, I would not have hesitated to offer it to Qazzaqi if it ensured his daily visits.

With a great deal of astonishment, Qazzaqi asked me, 'From where did you get so much money, Bhaiya?'

Proudly, I responded, 'It is mine!'

'Your mother will beat you. She will accuse me of having tricked you into giving it to me. Bhaiya, you can purchase some sweets with this money and put the flour back in the urn. I will not die of hunger. I will use my hands—I can work. How can I die of hunger?'

Over and over again I told him that the money was mine and that he could take it, but he refused. He strolled around with me for a long time; he sang songs for me, then dropped me home and went away. He also left behind the flour basket at the door.

Scarcely had I stepped into the house when my mother yelled at me, 'You thief, where have you taken the flour? Now you are learning to steal as well! To whom have you given the flour? Tell me at once or I will skin you alive!'

As the saying goes, my nani died the instant I heard my mother's angry words. I was in serious trouble. Mother was like a lioness when she was angry. I mumbled, 'I have not given it to anybody.'

'Haven't you taken out the flour? Look how much flour lies strewn all over the courtyard.' However much she reprimanded me or cajoled me, I could not bring myself to utter a word. The dilemma that lay ahead of me was so serious that I felt oppressed by its gravity. I could not even summon up the courage to ask her why she was so angry. The basket lay outside the door but I did not have the courage to bring it in either. In other words, I had lost all power to act—my legs would not carry me any longer. Suddenly Qazzaqi called out, 'Bahuji, the flour is outside, at the door. Bhaiya had taken it to give it to me.'

My mother immediately went to the door. She did not observe purdah for Qazzaqi. Whether or not she spoke to him I do not know, but she returned with the empty basket. Then she went into the storeroom, took out something from the chest and walked back to the door. I noticed that her fist was closed. I could not stand there waiting any longer. I followed my mother. She called out to him several times but Qazzaqi had already left. Putting on an air of courage, I offered to go and seek him out but, bolting the door, my mother asked with a resigned air, 'Where will you look for him in the dark? He was here just now. I asked him to wait till I got back. I wonder where he disappeared so quickly! He is a very diffident person. He was not willing to take the flour but I insisted and turned it over in his scarf. I feel very sorry for him. I wonder whether the poor fellow has any food to eat. I brought some money for him. I wonder where he could have gone.'

Now I summoned up some courage. I narrated the entire story of my theft. When parents interact with intelligent children at their level rather than as their seniors, they are able to exert greater influence. They can deliver better instructions too.

'Why didn't you ask me? Wouldn't I have given Qazzaqi some flour?' asked mother.

I made no reply but thought instead, *Right now you are filled with pity for Qazzaqi, so you will give him whatever you feel. Had I requested some*

charity, you would certainly have beaten me up instead. However, I was now relieved that Qazzaqi would not go hungry; that mother would give him something to eat every day and that he would take me out for a jaunt day after day.

I spent the following day playing with Munnoo. In the evening I went out and stood by the road. It grew dark but Qazzaqi was not to be seen anywhere. Silence engulfed the roadside and soon the lamps were lit but Qazzaqi did not come. I returned home crying. 'Why are you crying, son?' asked mother. 'Didn't Qazzaqi come by?'

I began to cry even more loudly. Mother held me close. I got the feeling that she too was moved to tears. 'Be quiet, son. Tomorrow I will send a harkara to look for Qazzaqi,' she said. I fell asleep crying softly to myself.

The following morning, as soon as I awoke, I said to mother, 'Send for Qazzaqi!'

'I have sent someone already, son. Qazzaqi should be on his way,' replied mother.

Happy once again, I began to play. I was certain that my mother would do as she had promised. She had dispatched a harkara early in the morning. At about ten o'clock when I returned home with Munnoo, I learnt that Qazzaqi had not been found in his house. Instead, his wife had been weeping because apparently he had not returned home. She feared that he had run away.

Nobody can understand what tender hearts children have; they are unable to express their feelings in words. Often, they are also unable to judge exactly what it is that is bothering them; which thorn it is that is pricking their hearts, or what it is that makes them cry every now and again. Why is it that they sit by themselves, crestfallen and unable to take an interest in playing? I found myself in such a state. I would keep going into the house and then coming out again to stand by the roadside. My eyes searched for Qazzaqi. Where had he disappeared? Had he run away somewhere?

That evening, I stood by the road looking rather lost. Suddenly, I saw Qazzaqi in one of the lanes. Yes, it was Qazzaqi. I ran towards him, calling out his name as I used to, but found no trace of him anywhere. I wondered

where he had disappeared. I looked around from one end of the lane to the other, but couldn't even catch his scent.

I went home and told my mother. I got the feeling that my experience had moved her to distraction.

Qazzaqi was not seen anywhere for the next two or three days. I too began to forget him. Little children are very likely to exhibit a great deal of affection at one point in time but they are also likely to become uncaring in another. They may be extremely fond of a particular toy but they may also break it as easily once they have tired of it.

About ten or twelve more days passed. It was afternoon and Babuji was having lunch. I was busy tying brass anklets on to Munnoo's legs. A woman covered in a veil walked in and stood in the courtyard. Her clothes were grimy and tattered but she was fair-skinned and attractive.

'Bhaiya, where is Bahuji?' she asked.

I went up and asked, 'Who are you? What are you selling?'

'I am not selling anything. I have brought you these lotus seeds. Bhaiya, you are very fond of lotus seeds, aren't you?' I looked longingly at the cloth bundle she held in her hands and asked, 'From where have you brought me these? Can I see them?'

'Your harkara has sent them for you, son,' she responded.

I jumped with joy and asked her, 'Qazzaqi?'

The woman nodded in reply and began to open the bundle. Just then, mother came out of the kitchen; the woman immediately bent down and touched her feet in reverence. 'Are you Qazzaqi's wife?' asked mother.

The woman bowed her head in response.

'What does Qazzaqi do for a living these days?' asked mother.

The woman began to cry and replied, 'Bahuji, since the day he returned from your place with the flour, he has been ill. He constantly calls out for *bhaiya*. All his affection is reserved for bhaiya. He calls out "Bhaiya, bhaiya" every now and again and dashes towards the door. I wonder what has gone wrong with him. Bahuji, one day he slipped out of the house without saying a word to me; he hid in a lane and kept watching bhaiya for

a long time. When bhaiya spotted him, he slipped away quietly. He is ashamed to come in front of you.'

'Didn't I tell you that, mother?' I interrupted.

'Do you have anything to eat at home?'

'Yes, Bahuji, by your blessings, we are not hard-pressed for food. Today he awoke and walked up to the pond. I kept asking him not to go out as he was sure to catch a chill in the wind. But he did not listen to me. His legs tremble with weakness now. He waded into the pond and plucked out these lotus seeds for you and asked me to give them to you, Bhaiya. You are very fond of lotus seeds, he said. He asked me to inquire after you.'

I took out the lotus seeds from her bundle and merrily began to munch on them. My mother glared at me but I ignored her. I didn't have the patience to wait.

'Tell him that we are all well,' said mother, and I added, 'Also tell him that I have sent for him. If he does not come, I will never speak to him again. That's a promise.'

By this time Babuji had had his lunch and come out. Wiping his hands and his face with a towel, he conveyed his message, 'And tell him that Babuji has restored him to service. He must join as soon as possible or Babuji will be forced to employ someone else.'

The woman picked up the cloth and left. Mother called out to her but she did not look back. Perhaps mother wanted to give her some flour and pulses.

'Have you really restored him to service?' asked mother.

'Obviously! I would not send for him in jest. I had written the report for his restoration to the service on the fifth day itself.'

'That is wonderful.'

'This is the only antidote to his ailment.'

4

When I awoke early the following morning, I saw Qazzaqi walking towards us supporting himself with a lathi. He had grown frail and emaciated. He

had aged in such a short span of time—as though a verdant tree had withered and become stump-like. I ran towards him and hugged his waist. He kissed my cheeks and tried to lift me up so that he could put me on to his shoulders but he wasn't able to do it. Instead, he went down on his fours and I jumped on to his back. In this way Qazzaqi crawled to the post office, with me riding piggyback. At that time, I could not contain my happiness but Qazzaqi might have been even happier than I was.

'Qazzaqi, your service has been restored. Make sure you are never late again!'

Qazzaqi fell at my father's feet, crying uncontrollably.

I was not destined to savour the pleasure of the company of both Qazzaqi and Munnoo at the same time. When Munnoo came, Qazzaqi moved out of my life, and when Qazzaqi came back to me, Munnoo slipped out of my hands. I miss Munnoo immensely to this day. Munnoo always ate out of my plate; he never ate anything until I sat down to eat. He was very fond of boiled rice; however, only if it was laced liberally with ghee did he feel sated. He also always slept and woke up with me. He was so particular about hygiene that he always went outside, in the field nearby, to relieve himself. He loathed stray dogs and made it impossible for any to enter our house. The moment he set eyes on one, he would chase it out immediately, even if it meant leaving his meal.

Having left Qazzaqi at his work in the post office, I returned home for my meal; Munnoo too joined me. Hardly had I eaten two or three morsels when we spotted a large, ferocious-looking stray dog in the courtyard. Immediately, Munnoo stopped eating and chased it out. Dogs can become as meek as mice when they are on unfamiliar ground. The ferocious-looking animal took to his heels the moment he saw Munnoo. Munnoo ought to have returned, his mission having been accomplished. However, this particular dog was the angel of Munnoo's death. Not content with merely chasing him out of the compound, Munnoo pursued him into the field nearby. Perhaps Munnoo did not realize that there, on neutral ground, he could never have the upper hand—he could never get the better of the fierce animal. Munnoo and the ferocious-looking dog were now on a level

playing field. He had chased so many dogs out of our compound that perhaps he had begun to overestimate his own power. He had also forgotten perhaps that within the household limits, the owner's rights too go a long way in providing shelter and security. Hardly had the two animals reached the field when the dog turned around and attacked Munnoo, snapping at his neck with his hardy canine jaws. Poor Munnoo was not even able to utter a sigh. I ran out on hearing the commotion made by the neighbours, but it was too late. Munnoo lay dead and the ferocious-looking dog was nowhere to be seen.

Translated from the Urdu by Fatima Rizvi



Disgrace

1

Had there been a creature on this earth with eyes that could look deep into the heart of human beings, there would be very few who would be able to look straight into his eyes. This was especially true about Mahila Ashram's Jugnubai. She was a poor and old illiterate woman who gave the impression of being very simple and easygoing at first sight. But just as a clever proofreader's eyes are trained to focus on errors, her eyes were trained to see only faults in others. There was no woman in the city whose secrets she didn't know. Her astuteness and cunning were hidden behind the facade of her short and stout figure, her grey hair, round face, chubby cheeks and small eyes. But when she made someone the target of her tongue-lashing, her figure turned rigid, her eyes dilated, and her tone became shrill. She walked as slowly and stealthily as a cat, but when she heard her prey approaching, she was ready to pounce upon it. Her job was to look after the women of the Mahila Ashram, but they trembled at her sight. Her presence spelt such terror that the moment she entered a room, the joyful mood prevailing there got transformed into one of melancholy. All the cheerful sounds vanished as though the dark secrets of their past lives were etched on her face. Dark secrets! Who wouldn't wish to keep their past lives caged like some dreadful creature? Just as the rich lose their sleep for fear of

thieves, those who are honourable guard their honour jealously. The creature, the size of an insect to begin with, grows gigantic and strong with each passing day and begins to terrify us. If it were simply about saving their own honour, most of the women might have found the courage to berate Jugnu. But there were attacks on all those related to them. Everyone including parents, in-laws, maternal or paternal relatives had to be guarded. Who could defend a fortress that had so many chinks in its walls? It was better to surrender in such a situation. Many skeletons of the past lay buried in Jugnu's mind which she dug out at will. The moment any woman started boasting or bragging about herself, a frown appeared on Jugnu's forehead. Just one stern look from Jugnu was enough to petrify the bravest of them. But it was not as if the women hated her. They met her eagerly and treated her with respect. To slander one's neighbour has remained a perennial pastime for human beings and Jugnu had ample material for it.

2

There was a high school by the name of Indumati Mahila Pathshala in the district. Miss Khurshed had joined it recently as the headmistress. There was no meeting place or clubs for women in the city. Miss Khurshed visited the ashram one day. There was no woman in the ashram as highly educated as the visitor. She received a cordial welcome. It became known on the very first day that Miss Khurshed's coming had infused new life into the ashram. She met them with such warmth and spoke on such interesting subjects that all the women were charmed. She sang beautifully. She was an excellent orator and her acting skills had been appreciated in London. It was an honour to have such an accomplished lady visiting the ashram. Her complexion was fair, with a tinge of pink, her cheeks soft. She had ravishing eyes and her coiffure was of the latest fashion. Her body was so shapely it seemed as though it had been cast in a mould. There could not be a more bewitching picture of beauty.

As she was leaving, Miss Khurshed took Mrs Tandon, who was the chairperson of the ashram, aside and asked her, 'Who's this old woman?'

Jugnu had entered the room several times, scrutinizing Miss Khurshed with her keen eyes just as a horse rider scrutinizes a new mare.

Smiling, Mrs Tandon replied, ‘She does odd jobs here. Do you want me to call her?’

Miss Khurshed thanked her and said, ‘No, it’s all right. She looks crafty. And it seems as if she’s not a servant but the mistress of this place.’

Mrs Tandon was already cross with Jugnu. She often mocked her widowed state. She slandered her before Miss Khurshed as much as she could, and cautioned her to stay clear of her.

‘She must be an awful woman,’ said Miss Khurshed grimly. ‘That’s why all the women are scared of her. Why don’t you throw her out of the job? A witch like her shouldn’t stay here another day!’

Mrs Tandon expressed her helplessness. ‘How can I throw her out? Life will become difficult. Our fate rests in her hands. You will come to know of her qualities in a few days. And you might turn out to be one of her admirers. Don’t ever talk to a man in front of her. She has her informers spying on us from everywhere. She ferrets out all the secrets from servants and takes all the letters from the postman and reads them. She even entices girls into revealing the stories of their households. The witch would have been better off joining the secret service instead of working here.’

Miss Khurshed looked troubled, as though she was worried about solving this problem. A moment later she said, ‘Well, I’ll set her right. Upon my word, I’m going to throw her out.’

‘Throwing her out will do no good. It won’t stop her from wagging her tongue. In fact, she will then slander with a vengeance.’

‘I’ll shut her up, my friend, you will see. A pennyworth of a woman, acting like a queen. I can’t stand this,’ Miss Khurshed replied calmly.

When she was gone, Mrs Tandon called Jugnu and said, ‘Did you see the new Miss Sahib? She’s the principal here.’

‘What’s there to see?’ retorted Jugnu spitefully. ‘I’ve seen plenty of such damsels. Shameless creature.’

Mrs Tandon said in a low voice, ‘She’s going to eat you raw. Beware of her. She told me before leaving that she’s going to set you right. I thought I

must caution you lest you say something stupid in front of her.'

Jugnu's tongue was like a sword. 'Don't caution me. Warn her instead! I swear by my father, I'll ban her entry to this place. If she has been around the world, I've seen enough of this world too.'

'I only wanted to forewarn you, the rest is your concern,' said Mrs Tandon, patting her on the back.

'Just watch how I make her dance to my tune,' said Jugnu. 'Why hasn't she married yet? She must be about thirty, isn't she?'

'She says she doesn't want to marry at all. She doesn't want to lose her freedom and be a slave to a man,' Mrs Tandon egged her on.

Jugnu rolled her eyes and said, 'Come on, no one must've cared for her. I've seen many such spinsters. They enjoy life while they can, and then no one looks at them!'

Just then several girls turned up and the conversation came to an abrupt end.

3

Early the next morning Jugnu showed up at Miss Khurshed's bungalow. Miss Khurshed had gone out for a walk. The steward asked Jugnu, 'Where have you come from?'

'I live nearby, son. Where does your *memsahib* hail from? You must be an old servant of hers,' said Jugnu ingratiatingly.

'She's from Nagpur. I lived there too. I've been with her for the past ten years,' answered the steward.

'I'm sure she's from a reputed family. Her manners are so decent.'

'It's not so much because of her family but a stroke of luck. Her mother still gets an amount of thirty rupees from the Mission. As she was good in studies, she received a scholarship and went abroad. That's how her fortune changed for the better. She's now going to call her mother here. But I don't think that old woman will agree. They don't get along well as my mistress doesn't go to church.'

'She seems to be quite haughty,' Jugnu egged the steward on.

‘No, she’s very pious. It’s just that she doesn’t go to church. Are you looking for work? If you want, you can get a job here. She needs a maid.’

‘No, son. What work can I do at this age? The lady who lived in this bungalow earlier took great care of me. I thought I should give the new lady my blessings.’

‘She is not the kind who needs blessings. Such people get on her nerves. She chides those who come begging to her. She says that those who don’t work have no right to live. You’d better be on your way.’

‘So, she doesn’t believe in any religion. Well, how can she have pity for the poor then?’

Jugnu had found ample material to build castles in the air. She was now armed with several facts—Miss Khurshed didn’t belong to a reputed family, didn’t get along well with her mother, and she was not at all religious. To come by so much information in just one incursion was a real stroke of luck for her.

Before leaving, she asked the steward one last question, ‘What does her husband do?’

The steward smiled and said, ‘How could she have a husband when she hasn’t married yet?’

Faking surprise, Jugnu exclaimed, ‘What! Is she still unmarried? People will jeer at someone like her in our society.’

‘Different people have different customs. In their society, many women remain unmarried their entire lives.’

Jugnu replied with a show of piety, ‘I have come across many such unmarried women. In our community, if anyone adopts such a style of life it causes an uproar. But in their community, no one seems bothered. People can do whatever they like.’

At that moment Miss Khurshed returned. Winter had set in. Miss Sahib was wearing an overcoat over her sari. She held an umbrella in one hand and her puppy’s chain in the other. Exercising in the salubrious morning air had turned her cheeks fresh and red. Jugnu bowed and greeted her, but Miss

Khurshed pretended not to have seen her. When she went in, she asked her steward instantly, ‘What is this woman doing here?’

Untying her shoelaces, the steward replied, ‘She’s a beggar, my lady, but quite sensible. I asked her if she’d work here, but she refused. She was inquiring about your husband. When I told her you were not married, she was surprised and justifiably so. Child marriage is rampant among the Hindus.’

‘What else did she say?’ Miss Khurshed demanded.

‘Nothing else, Madam.’

‘Well, send her to me.’

4

When Jugnu stepped inside the room, Miss Khurshed rose from her seat and welcomed her. ‘Do come in, Maaji. I had just been out for a walk. I hope everything is going well at your ashram.’

Jugnu stood holding the back of a chair. She replied, ‘Everything is fine, Madam. I thought I should come here and give you my blessings. I’m your servant. You can call me whenever you want. It must be lonely for you here.’

‘I enjoy being with my students at the school. They’re like my own daughters,’ said Miss Khurshed.

Jugnu nodded with motherly affection and said, ‘You’re right, Ma’am, but there can be no one like one’s family. There can be no substitute for one’s own family.’

Suddenly, a bright, handsome young man, attired in a silk suit, entered the room, his shoes making a creaking sound. Miss Khurshed seemed overjoyed at his sight and rushed to welcome him. When she saw this, Jugnu hid herself in a corner.

Miss Khurshed hugged the young man and gushed, ‘Darling, I had been waiting for you for so long.’ (To Jugnu) ‘Maaji, you can go now. Come again later. This is my best friend, William King. We’ve studied together for many years.’

Jugnu went out of the room quietly. The steward was standing there. She asked him, ‘Who’s this young lad?’

‘I’ve set eyes on him for the first time,’ replied the steward, nodding his head. ‘Perhaps she’s got tired of living as a spinster. What a smart young fellow!’

‘They hugged each other with such passion that I felt embarrassed. Even married couples do not kiss that way. They clasped each other. The lad was somewhat hesitant when he saw me, but your mistress, she seemed to have gone crazy!’

‘It’s quite awkward!’ said the steward in a tone that suggested some ill omen.

Jugnu went straight to Mrs Tandon’s house, while Miss Khurshed and the young man were still talking.

Miss Khurshed guffawed heartily and said, ‘You’ve played your part very well, Leela. That old woman was really stunned.’

‘I was afraid she would see through it,’ Leela said apprehensively.

‘I was sure she’d land up today. I saw her in the veranda from a distance and informed you. It will be a lot of fun in the ashram today. I wish I could hear the women gossip. Trust me, everybody is going to believe her.’ Miss Khurshed seemed pleased with the way her plan had gone.

‘You’re getting yourself into this mess too willingly!’

‘I love acting. It’s just a prank. That old witch has caused enough misery. I want to teach her a lesson. Come again tomorrow at the same time in the same style. She’s going to be here again. She will be dying to know what is going on here. Well, I’ll inform you when she arrives. Come like a chivalrous hero.’

5

That day Jugnu didn’t have a moment’s respite in the ashram. She recounted the whole story to Mrs Tandon. Mrs Tandon came running to the ashram and passed on the news to the other women. Jugnu was sent for to

confirm it. Whoever came in heard Jugnu narrate the story. New details were added with each narration. By the time it was midday, the story had spread far and wide in the cultured circles of the city.

One lady inquired, 'Who's this young man?'

Mrs Tandon replied, 'It seems they studied together. They must have been friends since then. And I was wondering why she's still a spinster . . . at this age. The secret is now open.'

'Whatever you say, the lad is a smart one,' Jugnu said.

'This is how our educated sisters behave!' Mrs Tandon sermonized.

'I could guess everything just by looking at his face. My hair hasn't turned grey for nothing.'

'Go there again tomorrow,' Mrs Tandon prompted her.

'Why wait for tomorrow, I'll go tonight.'

But she needed a good reason to pay a visit at night. Mrs Tandon sent her to bring a book. Jugnu reached Miss Khurshed's bungalow at nine o'clock at night. It was sheer coincidence that Leelavati was already there. She said, 'The old crone is after your life.'

Miss Khurshed replied, 'Didn't I tell you that she wouldn't be able to rest? Go and get ready for the act. I'll keep her engaged in conversation. Act like a drunk man mouthing gibberish. Ask me to elope with you. Just behave as if you are not in your senses.'

Leela was a doctor in a missionary hospital. Her bungalow was nearby. When she was gone, Miss Khurshed called Jugnu in.

Handing a note to her, Jugnu said, 'Mrs Tandon has asked me to fetch this book. I got a little late coming. I wouldn't have bothered you at this hour but she's going to demand this book first thing in the morning tomorrow. Her monthly income runs into thousands, but she's too stingy to part with a penny. Even beggars are turned away empty-handed from her door.'

Miss Khurshed looked at the chit and replied, 'I don't have this book right now. Take it in the morning. I want to talk to you about something. Sit here, I'll be back in a minute.'

She went into another room and came out after a quarter of an hour wearing a beautiful silk sari. She had worn some perfume and powdered her face. Jugnu's eyes dilated when she looked at her. Such make-up! *Perhaps the lad was coming to see her*, she thought. That must be why she was getting all dressed up. Why else would an unmarried girl beautify herself at the time of going to bed? For Jugnu, the solitary reason for a woman's make-up was to seduce the husband. Dressing up was taboo for an unmarried woman.

Miss Khurshed had barely settled in her chair when the creaking of shoes was heard and a moment later, William King made his entry. His eyes seemed intoxicated, and his clothes reeked of liquor. He clasped Miss Khurshed to his chest audaciously and started kissing her cheeks.

Miss Khurshed tried to extricate herself from him and said, 'Don't touch me. You're drunk.'

King pressed her even more tightly and said, 'You'll drink with me tonight, my darling. Yes . . . you must. And then . . . we will sleep in each other's arms. You can enjoy love's intense moments only when you're drunk. See it for yourself.'

Miss Khurshed hinted at the presence of Jugnu so he'd see her. But King was in a state of ecstasy. He didn't look at Jugnu at all.

In fake rage, Miss Khurshed extricated herself from him. 'You're not in your senses at this moment. Why are you being so crazy? I'm not running away from you.'

'So far, I have met you secretly like a thief. But now, I'll visit you openly.'

'You're absolutely crazy. Don't you see who else is sitting in this room?'

King seemed to have been taken aback and said hesitantly, 'When did this old woman come in? Why have you come here, you old witch? Vamp! Are you here to spy on us? To disgrace us? I will strangle you. Wait! Where are you running off to? I'm going to kill you.'

Jugnu rushed out of the room like a cat and took to her heels while peals of laughter shook the entire room.

Jugnu made straight for Mrs Tandon's house. It was difficult for her to hold the news inside. But Mrs Tandon had gone to sleep. Despairingly she knocked at several other doors, but no one answered her call. The poor woman had to spend her entire night in such restlessness it was as if she was taking care of a sobbing child. She landed up at the ashram early next morning.

Mrs Tandon came after half an hour. When she saw her, Jugnu turned her face away.

'Did you call on me last night?' asked Mrs Tandon. 'My servant told me this morning.'

Jugnu replied tonelessly, 'It's the thirsty that goes to the well, not the other way round. You abandoned me after throwing me into the fire. I'd have been dead yesterday if God had not saved me.'

Mrs Tandon asked eagerly, 'Why? What happened? Now say something. Why didn't you wake me up? You know very well that I go to bed early.'

'Your servant didn't even allow me to enter the house. How could I wake you up? You should have considered the fact that if I had gone there, I would certainly come back to you. What harm would it have caused you if you had gone to sleep a little later? But you just didn't care.'

'Anyway, what happened there? Did Miss Khurshed attack you?'

'It wasn't her. It was her lover who came after me. He lunged at me with bloodshot eyes and shouted, "Get out!" Before I could move, he pulled out a whip and almost ran after me. If I hadn't run away from there, he would have peeled off my skin. And that whore just sat there watching the show. They are very close to each other. It's a sin to look at such shameless creatures. Even whores aren't so shameless.'

Soon, other women also joined them. Everyone was dying to hear the story. Jugnu's tongue-lashing went on unabated. All the women heard the account with great relish. They wanted to know every little detail. They left their chores and forgot to even eat and drink. They weren't satisfied with hearing the account just once and so they heard it again and again with renewed pleasure.

In the end, Mrs Tandon declared, ‘It is not proper for such women to visit the ashram. Each one of us must ponder over this issue.’

‘We don’t want to lower the dignity of this ashram,’ said Mrs Pandya in support. ‘I say, such a woman does not deserve to be the principal of any institution.’

Mrs Bangda asserted, ‘Jugnubai is right. It’s a sin to even look at such a woman. We should make it clear to her that we do not want her to visit this ashram.’

As this debate raged on, a motorcar stopped in front of the ashram. Miss Khurshed and William King were seated inside.

Jugnu gaped and pointed King out. The entire group of women rushed to the window to have a glimpse.

Miss Khurshed stepped out of the car and walked towards the ashram’s door. All of them went back to their places hurriedly.

Miss Khurshed stepped into the room. No one uttered a word of greeting. Miss Khurshed looked at Jugnu boldly, smiled and said, ‘I hope you didn’t hurt yourself last night, Baiji.’

Jugnu had seen many bold women in her life, but such brazenness astonished her. She was as bold as brass.

Jugnu said sternly, ‘If you didn’t have enough, you can have him beat me now. I’m right here.’

‘He has come to apologize to you for his misconduct. He was drunk last night,’ replied Miss Khurshed.

Jugnu looked at Mrs Tandon and then turned back and said, ‘You were no less drunk either.’

Miss Khurshed understood the sarcasm and said, ‘I’ve never drunk in my entire life. Don’t make such allegations against me.’

Jugnu hit the floor with her staff and said, ‘There are other things more intoxicating than liquor. It must be the effect of that. Why are you concealing him? Let all the women see his face.’

‘His face is one in a million!’ Miss Khurshed said in a mischievous tone.

Mrs Tandon became apprehensive and said, ‘No, there’s no need to bring him in here. We don’t want to disgrace the ashram.’

‘He needs to come in so that things are clarified. Why do you pass a one-sided judgement?’ Miss Khurshed argued.

‘There’s no court case going on here,’ Mrs Tandon said, making light of the matter.

Miss Khurshed asserted, ‘Wow! My honour is at stake here and you say that it’s no court case. Mr King will present himself before you and you will have to hear him out.’

Except for Mrs Tandon, everyone else was curious to see King. No one objected.

Miss Khurshed went to the door and called out loudly, ‘Hey, come in here.’

The door of the car opened and Miss Leelavati came out, smiling. She was wearing a silk sari.

The whole ashram was dumbstruck. The ladies looked at Leelavati, stupefied.

Jugnu’s eyes flashed. She demanded, ‘Where have you hidden him?’

Miss Khurshed jested, ‘I made him vanish by magic. Go and check the vehicle.’

Jugnu rushed to the car and, when she didn’t find anything after a thorough search, she returned disappointed.

Miss Khurshed asked her, ‘Why, did you find anyone?’

Jugnu retorted, ‘What do I know of such trickery? (Staring at Leelavati) You are throwing dust into our eyes by making a man wear a sari. This is the fellow I was talking about.’

‘Do you recognize him?’ asked Miss Khurshed.

‘Of course I do. Do you think I am blind?’

Mrs Tandon intervened, ‘Jugnu, you’re talking rubbish. She is Dr Leelavati.’

Jugnu waggled her finger and said, ‘Oh, come on, this is no Leelavati. He doesn’t even feel ashamed of wearing a woman’s dress. Weren’t you there at her house last night?’

Leelavati was amused and said, ‘I never said I was not. I’m Leelavati right now. But at night I turn into William King. What’s the big deal?’

It was now that the truth dawned on the ladies. Laughter spread everywhere. If some clapped their hands, others hugged Dr Leelavati, while others patted Miss Khurshed's back to show their appreciation. The melee went on for several minutes. Greatly embarrassed, Jugnu became mute. Never had she been made such a fool of before. Never had she suffered such ignominy.

Mrs Mehra admonished her, 'What have you to say now, old maid? Aren't you embarrassed?'

Mrs Bangda said, 'This is how she slanders everyone.'

'But you also believed whatever she said,' said Leelavati in an accusatory tone.

In this chaos, no one noticed Jugnu slinking away. When she realized what kind of turmoil she had been caught in, she thought it better to make herself scarce. She slipped out through the back door and escaped through the narrow lanes.

Miss Khurshed said, 'Let's ask her why she was after my life.'

Mrs Tandon called out for her but there was no sign of Jugnu. Searches were conducted, but Jugnu could not be traced.

No one ever saw Jugnu's face again in the city. It is still remembered as a memorable and hilarious incident in the history of the ashram.

Translated from the Hindi by M. Asaduddin



The Tonga Driver's Reflections

This writer once had the opportunity to travel a long distance in Allahabad in a cart. The fifty-year-old cart driver, Miyan Jumman, was a chatterbox. He enthralled me with stories throughout the journey. For the benefit of the readers, I'm presenting his life and anecdotes.

1

Jumman: Tell me, Babuji, are you looking for a tonga? *Well, he isn't even looking in this direction . . . He is looking for an ekka*. You are welcome! I agree an ekka is less expensive but it will ruin your lower back. Babuji, the road is bad; travelling in an ekka will be painful. You must have read in the newspaper that yesterday as many as four ekkas overturned on the road. Long live the municipality! It will stop ekkas permanently. Lorries and cars spoil the road, and *ekkawala*s bear the brunt. Soon, passengers will fly in aeroplanes; then ekkawalas will have enough space on the road. No one will then look at the lorries; you'll find them only in museums. They are the kings of the road. Oh, Sir, they have made it difficult for us to move around. They have pushed us to the edges, as though the road belongs only to them. Now they swagger, but let the aeroplanes come! Sir, why doesn't the government take money from these car owners and repair the roads? Why doesn't it impose a fourfold tax on petrol? They call their cars 'taxis', so they shouldn't mind paying a tax! My old woman says, 'You abandoned the

ekka and bought a tonga. But now the tonga is of no use. Buy a car.' I silenced her with my reply: 'Should I depend on a machine and not on my limbs?' Now let me tell you another fact. It happened just the other day. Kallan's car hit a tree, killing him on the spot. In a moment, his wife became a widow and his ten children orphans. Hujoor, I am a poor man. I manage to look after my children. What more do I want? I have been driving a cart for the last forty years. The few years left of my life will be spent holding this whip in my hand. So consider this, if the ekka or the tonga breaks down or the horse falls, you are still left with something in your hand. Contrary to this, if a car is involved in a crash, no one will buy the iron carcass even for two rupees! Hujoor, a horse will take you to your destination no matter what. You can't say this about cars which you often see stalled on the road. In such situations, the passengers are forced to walk the rest of the way. A horse is always under control and it always brings profit. There is little comfort in a car. But in a tonga, the passenger sleeps, I sleep, the horse also sleeps, but we still reach our destination. The noise of motorcars can burst your eardrums, and the driver feels as if he is working on a grinding wheel.

2

Let me tell you, Sir, women use tongas and ekkas heartlessly. The other day, seven or eight women came and asked how much I'd charge to go to Triveni. Sir, our rates are fixed. It's not like a Whiteway company shop where you could purchase stuff on 'sale' four times a year! Pay us according to the rate card, and we will bless you. I am not talking about you, Sir. You may not pay me at all once in a while, and that's fine. But these women pay us only eight annas where one full rupee is due. Sir, we work for the sahibs. A gentleman always behaves like a gentleman, and a woman always behaves like a woman! On the pretext of purdah we are asked to stand at a distance and then dozens of passengers including children get on to the ekka or tonga. Once the *kamani* of my ekka snapped, and the ekka stopped right there. Believe me, as many as thirteen women

stepped out of it. I, a poor man, was in great trouble. Sir, everyone is surprised at how these women sit, one upon another. Even the tonga groans in pain under their weight. They make children sit on their knees, and put babies on the children's laps, making the tonga look like a circus ground. Despite this, they do not want to give full wages. Earlier, when the purdah was observed, one talked to the male members and got one's wages. Since the fair started on Exhibition Ground, the purdah fell by the wayside. Women started travelling all by themselves and we started losing money. But Allah protects us. This loss is balanced out at the end of the year. One mighty blow from the blacksmith is stronger than a hundred feeble blows from the goldsmith. Last month, one woman rode the tonga for two hours. She paid me just eight annas and ran into her house. I looked at the tonga to find that she had left her gold pendant there. I called out to her from behind but she simply said, 'I won't give a paisa more,' and shut the door on my face. I stared at the door for a couple of minutes and then left the spot. My wages stayed with her and her pendant with me.

3

Let me tell you what happened yesterday. A couple of Swarajists hired my tonga from Katra to the railway station. They asked me to drive fast and shouted '*Gandhiji ki jai*' throughout the journey. Some big sahib was coming from somewhere far. People had gathered outside the station in large numbers, and there were processions. They jumped like puppets on my tonga, and when they reached the station, they gave me only four annas. I demanded full wages but they didn't pay any heed to my requests, and continued to shout 'Gandhiji ki jai'.

I shouted, 'What about my belly? You used my tonga like the theatre stage to dance and jump, and now you don't want to pay the wages!' I kept shouting but they disappeared in the crowd. I feel people have gone crazy. They want to attain Swaraj with such behaviour! Oh, Sir, there is a strange wind blowing. They don't reform themselves but want Swaraj. They should first mend their ways. They invited my boy to join them. He gathered a lot

of clothes and was going to set them on fire. I first argued with him, ‘I am a poor man. How can I buy new clothes?’ When he didn’t listen to me, I gave him a good thrashing. Sir, when the time comes, we cart drivers will bring about Swaraj. It will never come riding in motorcars! First, give me my full wages and then ask for Swaraj!

Sir, women are women, we cannot argue with them. We have to accept whatever they give. But there are some fake gentlemen who are far worse than even women. They inspect our number before getting on to the carts, and if anything falls from the cart because of their carelessness, they blame us. On top of that, they expect us to stay quiet when they pay us less. Once, a fake sahib went to the viceroy’s office on my cart, muttering ‘Well, well’ all the way. He left me outside the gate, saying he’d be back in a minute. Since that day I have been waiting for him to show up. If I ever set my eyes on him again, I will give him a piece of my mind, whatever the consequences!

4

Now the times have changed and so have the people. God knows where courtesy has disappeared. It has vanished at the speed of a motorcar. Sir, it is only people like you who patronize cart drivers and give them proper regard. Otherwise we are treated as the lowest creatures. We are abused and jeered at.

Yesterday two fellows were walking on the road. I asked, ‘Tonga?’, to which one of them replied, ‘No, we’re in a hurry.’ The other fellow asked me, ‘Where can we get a taxi?’

Now, Sir, this is a small town. I can take you anywhere in a matter of minutes, but they wanted me to tell them where they could get a taxi. Can there be anything more absurd than this? Spare a thought for my mare and my children. The charge is just fourteen annas an hour. Dear Sir, how I wish someone would hire me for twenty-four hours! There are a few gentlemen who try to act smart with me. I have been doing this job for forty years. Just one look at the passenger, and I can guess what’s going on in his mind. Pay

me money and see how my mare grows wings. One gentleman bargained for a long time and hired the tonga on an hourly basis. That too, at a lower rate than the one set by the government. You see, the cart drivers get a raw deal when the municipality fixes the rate, but some people want to pay us even lower than that. I also foolishly accepted the lower rate. The tonga went for some distance and then began to move at the speed of a funeral procession. He goaded me to hurry up. When I told him that it was a day of fasting, and my mare would be out of breath, he retorted, 'Okay then, your hours will be long.'

My master, I want that you should always be sitting in my tonga, and I should be taking you around.

5

There was a clerk in the sahib's office, who lived in Katra. Believe me, his waist was as wide as three yards. Cart drivers would slink away when they saw him. He had broken many ekkas. Despite his bulk, he would jump so dexterously that he never hurt himself. Of all the cart drivers, only I dared to ferry him. And he paid well, God bless him.

Once I was driving Erdu's ekka when this clerk ran into me. 'Can you take me to my office?' he asked.

'I have got late today.'

He sat on the ekka and said, 'I see that your horse is just a skeleton.'

I answered, 'Sir, it's not my horse. You give me double wages. If you so desire, I can fix an ekka with my tonga and then take you around.'

6

Let me tell you another story. One sethji hired the ekka. He bought vegetables and so on from the *sabzi mandi* and then asked me to drop him at the station. Expecting good tips, I drove my mare at breakneck speed. God knows I gave a good thrashing to my mare that day. My hands began

to ache. We barely made it on time for the train. When we reached, he gave me just a quarter, a *chawanni*.

I asked him, 'What's this?'

He said, 'Your wages. Show me the rate chart.'

I said, 'You were in a hurry. I thrashed my mare to bring you to the station on time.'

Sethji retorted, 'Well, you got relieved earlier. And you didn't take the blows on yourself!'

I requested him, 'Please have some pity on this beast!'

This softened him a little. 'Yes, this poor animal must be treated kindly,' he said, and plucked out four leaves of cabbage from his basket, fed the mare and went on his way. It was a joke for him. But I had to bear the brunt. It upset the mare's digestion. How the times have changed! People no longer care about others. Manners and customs have changed. When I ask for wages, they respond, 'You're the master. Rob us as much as you can.' Sethji would feed halva and jalebi to his animals but he'd break our necks. There were times when passengers fed us sweets in addition to paying proper wages!

7

Even in such times, once in a while you do come across real gentlemen! Listen to this—once several passengers sat in my tonga from Kashmiri Hotel. I had driven a small distance and, as we reached Kydganj, the passenger sitting in the front got down much before the roundabout and paid me fourteen annas. Then the passenger sitting at the back got off and paid fourteen annas. But the third one did not get down. I said, 'Sir, we have reached the roundabout.' There was no reply. I requested the second passenger to bring him down. He groped around and discovered that the fellow was dead drunk.

He asked me, 'What now?'

I said, 'It's simple. Take him to the police station. If there's no one to claim him, you can take full possession of the booty.'

So, my dear Sir, in this profession you get to see a new spectacle every day. There was a time when purdah was observed. Carpets would be laid, a canopied passage would be made and then the ladies would sit on the carts. Now, it's all changed. Purdah has disappeared on the pretext that passengers feel suffocated. It's not that I have abandoned the ekka with a happy heart. Everyone insisted, 'Leave the ekka, bring a tonga.' They didn't care for the comfort. Now they do not care about their own lives and clamour for motorcars and taxis. Well, Sir, it doesn't make much of a difference to me. I will live for just a few days more. I will see whatever spectacle passes before my eyes!

Translated from the Urdu by M. Asaduddin



Ramleela

1

It's been ages since I went to the Ramleela. Today I laugh at men in short black kurtas, high-hemmed pyjamas and ugly monkey masks running around and whooping: they don't entertain me any more. The *leela* at Kashi is world famous. It is said that people come from far-off places to attend it. Even I went with great expectations but found no difference between it and any other leela in a backward village. Yes, the paraphernalia in the Ramnagar leela are good. The masks of the rakshasas and monkeys are of brass as are the maces; perhaps the crowns of the Nawasi brothers are of gold. But apart from these, it's the usual hoo-ha and nothing else. Still, people turn up in lakhs.

But there was a time when even I enjoyed Ramleelas. Enjoy is too slight a word. That enjoyment was no less than obsession. Coincidentally, in those days the ramleela ground was only a little distance from home and the house where the actors dressed was next to ours. Dressing up the actors began at two in the afternoon. I used to reach there at noon itself and the energy with which I ran small errands is many times more than that with which I run around for my pension. In one room the princess was put into costume. Her body was plastered with yellow paste, her face powdered and then daubed with spots of red, green and blue. The whole forehead, brows,

cheeks and legs were similarly coloured. Only one person was skilled at this job. He took turns at grooming all three characters. My work was to bring in pots of water, grind the colours and keep the fan turning. After running these errands, when the chariot rolled out, I sat behind Ramchandra, and oh the elation, the pride, the romance! I don't get that now even when I take my seat in the white sahib's durbar. Once when the home-member of the organizing committee approved one of my suggestions, I felt a similar feeling of elation, pride and romance. Yes, when my eldest son was nominated for the post of chief collector, similar waves of joy passed through me: but then, there is a vast difference between that and the other childlike flippancy. It was like being in heaven.

It was the day of the *Nishad-nauka-leela*. I was drawn by a few boys into a game of *gilli-danda* and didn't go to see the make-up. The chariot rolled out but I didn't give up my game. I had to take my wager. Leaving the wager was a sacrifice greater than I could ever make. Had it been a simple matter of drawing a wager, I would have left long ago; but to challenge and tease the opponent is an entirely different matter. Well, the wager was finally completed. If I wanted, I could have dawdled for a little longer; there were a number of opportunities too, but I didn't avail of them and straightaway ran to the canal. The chariot had just reached the bank. In the distance, I saw the boatman paddling in the barge. I ran but it was difficult to pass through the mass of people. Finally, when with all my strength I parted the crowd and reached the bank, Nishad had already let the barge adrift. I had such faith in Ramchandra! Not worrying about my own studies, I had tutored him so that he would not fail his exams. Although older, he studied in a class lower than me. And that same Ramchandra who was sitting in the barge turned his face away, as if he didn't know me at all. Sometimes the role one plays takes on the character of the person. How can one whose eye is always fixed on his devotees overlook me? Heartbroken, I started jumping like a calf at its first yoking, running towards the canal once, then returning in search of a sympathizer; however, everyone was entranced in their own tune and no one lent a ear to my sobs of grief. I have

faced a number of upheavals ever since but nothing so great as the sorrow I felt then.

I decided that I would never talk to Ramchandra again, never offer him anything to eat; however, as soon as the barge crossed the canal and turned towards the bridge, I ran on board as if it were no matter.

2

Well, Ramleela got over. It was already time for the Ascension but for some reason it was being postponed. Perhaps sufficient funds had not been collected. These days no one even asked about Ramchandra. We were neither allowed to go home nor was food arranged for us. A serving of raw grain was sent from Chaudhuri Sahib's house only at three in the afternoon. For the remainder of the day no one even offered water. In spite of this, my devotion was unwavering. He was still the same Ramchandra in my eyes. If I found any food at home, I took it to Ramchandra. The delight I found in feeding him was greater than having eaten myself. When I found a fruit or sweetmeat, I ran passionately to the *chaupal*. If Ramchandra wasn't there, I would look all around for him, not resting until he had eaten.

Well, the day of the Ascension arrived. A large tent was erected on the Ramleela grounds. It was gloriously decorated. A band of prostitutes had also arrived. Ramchandra's chariot left in the evening and he was offered an *aarti* at every door. Based on their piety some people offered currency notes and some coins. My father was in the police: he sought blessings without making an offering. The shame I felt then cannot be expressed. Coincidentally, I had a rupee on me. My uncle had visited us before Dussehra and presented me with this gift. I had saved the rupee but couldn't spend it even on Dussehra. I immediately placed the rupee on the offertory plate. Father looked at me in anger. He said nothing but the look on his face showed that my audacity had stained his honour. The rounds were completed just before ten. The offertory plate was filled with notes and coins. I can't say with surety but there must have been four to five hundred rupees on the plate. Chaudhuri Sahib had spent a little more than that. He

was concerned that somehow two hundred more rupees should be collected, the easiest means according to him being a performance by the prostitutes. When the men settle down and the mehfil mellows, Abadijan grabs the patrons' wrists and makes such gestures that the men are shamed into paying their way out of it. Abadijan and Chaudhuri Sahib were trying to reach an agreement. Coincidentally, I was listening to these two people converse. Chaudhuri Sahib must have thought: *What will this lad understand?* But here I was intelligence personified and so understood the whole story.

Chaudhuri said, 'Abadijan, this is high-handedness. This is not our first dealing, is it? God willing, you will always continue to visit here. It's just that the collections are too little this time, or I would not have pleaded with you like this.'

Abadi replied, 'You are trying your landlord tricks on me but you should know that nothing will come out of it. *Wah*! I collect the money and you curl your mustachios! Good way of making money, isn't it? With this, you will be a king in a few days and zamindari will be a trifle before that. Why not open a brothel tomorrow! By God, you will swim in money.'

'You are joking . . . I don't have words.'

'But you bully me as well. I make the likes of you dance on my fingertips.'

'What do you want then?'

'Half the collections will be mine, half yours. Let's shake on it.'

'So be it.'

'All right, first hand over a hundred rupees. You might start making excuses later.'

'Wah! An advance!'

'And why not? Do you think I'll let go of my fee? I salute your logic. Wonderful!'

'You've set your eyes on double the fee, have you?'

'Oh, rest the thought! These hundred rupees are not going anywhere. Have mad dogs bitten me that I should resort to petty thievery and slip my hand into other people's pockets?'

Chaudhuri didn't stand a chance and had to kneel before Abadi. The dance commenced. Abadijan was extremely enchanting; she was young and pretty on top of that. And her coquettish gestures were so enchanting that even I was intoxicated. She had a knack for understanding men. Everyone she sat in front of had something to offer. I doubt if anyone gave her less than five rupees. She sat in front of father too. I was crushed with shame. When she grabbed his wrist, I cringed. I was convinced that father would push her hand away or even shoo her away but what was this? God! Were my eyes fooling me? Father was laughing through his moustache. I hadn't seen such a gentle smile on his face before. Desire was dripping from his eyes. Every pore of his body was aroused. God, however, preserved my honour. Look, my father has released his wrist from Abadi's gentle grasp. Huh! What now? Abadi put her arms around his neck. Now father would definitely thrash her. The witch had no sense of shame.

A gentleman smiled and said, 'Your lentils won't cook here, Abadi. Seek other doors.'

This gentleman spoke my mind, but I don't know why father looked at him with distaste and fidgeted with his moustache. He said nothing but the shape of his mouth shouted it out aloud—'You merchant, what would you know? Here lives are sacrificed for opportunities such as these. The truth about money! Use it according to your desires. If I can't pay more than you, I won't show my face. Great surprise! Oh earth, why didn't you open up? Sky, why didn't you part? Why did death not come to me?'

Father put his hand into his pocket. He took out something, showed it to Sethji and gave it to Abadijan. He looked so proud it seemed as if he had just defiled the grave of Haatim. Here was father who, when he saw me make an offering of a coin, stared as if he would tear me to bits. Abadijan saluted father with an expansive smile and moved on; I couldn't sit still any longer. My head was bent with shame. If I had not witnessed this scene, I would have had no issue. I always reported to mother what I heard out of doors. But in this case, I kept the matter hidden. I knew that it would upset her.

The songs continued through the night. Drumbeats reached my ears. I thought, *let's go and see*, but I couldn't gather my courage. How would I show anyone my face? If anyone mentioned father, what would I do?

Ramchandra's farewell was scheduled for the morning. On rising from bed, I rubbed my eyes and ran towards the stage, fearing that Ramchandra had left. When I reached, I saw the cart of the courtesans preparing to depart. A number of men stood around with smiles on their faces. I didn't raise my eyes. I walked straight to Ramchandra. Lakshman and Sita were crying. Ramchandra, his arms around them, was comforting them. I asked Ramchandra in a quivering tone, 'Is your farewell over?'

'Yes,' he said. 'And what a farewell! Chaudhuri Sahib said, "Go on, it's over."'

'Didn't you get money and clothes?'

'Not yet. Chaudhuri Sahib says, "We don't have any balance right now. Come later and collect your fee."'

'Nothing at all?'

'Not a penny. He says, "We have saved nothing." I had thought that if I got some money, I would buy a few books. Nothing! Didn't even pay our travel expenses. He said, "How far is it? Walk home."'

I was so angry I felt like roughing up Chaudhuri Sahib. Money for the prostitutes, everything for the drivers, nothing for poor Ramchandra and his friends! Men who had showered ten, twenty rupees on Abadijan didn't have even a few annas for them. Even father had spared a coin for Abadijan. Let's see what he had for Ramchandra. I ran to father. He was getting ready for office. Spotting me, he said, 'Why are you roaming around? Wandering during your study hours?'

I said, 'I went to the stage. Ramchandra was leaving. Chaudhuri Sahib gave him nothing.'

'And why are you worrying yourself about it?'

'How will they go home? They don't even have money for the journey.'

'Didn't he give them anything to cover their expenses? It's very wrong of Chaudhuri Sahib.'

‘If you give me two rupees, I will pass it on to them. That might be enough to get them home.’

Father looked at me sternly and said, ‘Go, read your books. I have no money.’

Saying this, he sat on his horse. From that day, my respect for father diminished. I never cared about his scolding. My heart said, *You have no right to advise me*. I shrank from his sight. I did exactly the opposite of what he said. Of course, the loss is mine but then, my conscience had been touched by revolutionary ideas.

I had two annas on me. I took the money and with great shame gave them to Ramchandra. The joy he felt on seeing the coins was enough for me. He broke down, as if a long-drawn thirst had been quenched.

The idols took the two paise and left. Only I remained to assist them out of the hamlet.

After seeing them off, my eyes were moist but my heart was filled with warmth.

Translated from the Hindi by Shalim M. Hussain



An Invitation

1

Pandit Moteram Shastri entered his house caressing his paunch lovingly, and proclaimed at the top of his voice, ‘The python exerts no labour; the birds do not work, but Saint Maluka has affirmed that the Lord Ram takes care of one and all.’

Sona smiled and asked, ‘Do you bring cheerful tidings?’

Shastriji struck a pose and exclaimed, ‘I have baited a prize catch today! I struck at it so accurately that no scope of escape remained. We have received an invite for a feast for the entire family! The entire family! Everybody will be awestruck at how much food I can wolf down.’

Sona replied, ‘I hope you have not been cheated once again. Are you absolutely sure of the invite?’

Moteram twirled his moustache and remarked, ‘Do not say such ominous things. It is after many prayers and pleas that such an auspicious occasion has come our way. You better make the necessary preparations instead.’

‘But of course! I will make the required preparations. Do I have to be told that? After all, I am not a greenhorn—but . . . has the whole family been invited?’

‘How else shall I put it? The entire household has been invited. If you haven’t yet understood the meaning of that, you may ask me to explain

myself once again. It isn't possible for ordinary people to fathom the utterances of the judicious! Were that possible, there would have been no need for people like us. The fact of the matter is that Her Highness, the Rani of Muradpur is keen to feed seven Brahmins. It is up to me to decide who will accompany me to the feast. When Algooram Shastri, Beniram Shastri, Chediram Shastri, Bhawaniram Shastri, Phenkooram Shastri and Pandit Moteram Shastri are all available in this household, then the need to look out for other Brahmins does not arise.'

Sona replied, 'You have named only six. Who is the seventh Brahmin?'

'Make use of your common sense.'

'Bring home a potful of food.'

'Once again you have suggested something that threatens to destroy our reputation. Tch . . . tch—should I bring home a pot of food? How can one compare eating at the residence of the person who makes the sacrifice with carrying home the food to eat it here instead? Listen here, the seventh gentleman is Pandit Sona Ram Shastri.'

'Oh, come on! You are leading me on. How can I go there?'

'It is on occasions such as this that one feels the requirement of sound judgement. Intelligent people are excellent at bending the circumstances to their will while the foolish ones weep over their destiny. What is the difference between Sona Devi and Sonaram? Only that of clothing. Drape your sari like mine. Put on my vest and swathe a sheet over it. I will wrap a turban around your head. What more is required to convert you from Sona Devi to Pandit Sona Ram?'

Sona laughed and exclaimed, 'But I would feel embarrassed.'

'All you have to do is sit and eat—I will do the talking.'

Sona thought about the sweetmeats and exclaimed, 'What fun we shall have!'

'There is no scope for delay. You must begin the preparations right away.'

'How many sachets of the digestive crush should I make?'

'That I do not know. But you must ensure that we make an impact with our eating.'

‘Ah! I forgot about one thing! What should I do about my toe rings?’

Moteram knitted his brow and remarked, ‘Take them off and put them away. What else can you do with them?’

‘Never! No matter what happens, I will never take off my toe rings!’

Moteram thought for a while, then said, ‘No problem! Keep them on. The Almighty God will help us overcome this too! Make sure you wrap a great deal of cloth around your feet. I will explain that this particular Panditji suffers from elephantiasis. Doesn’t that sound first-rate?’

Sona looked at her husband with a great deal of admiration and said, ‘After all, you are an educated man.’

2

That evening Panditji sent for his five sons and began to explain, ‘Boys! It is important to have complete understanding of the issue at hand before taking the plunge. If Her Highness the Rani inquires about your paternity, please make sure you do not mention my name. Imagine how embarrassing it would seem if she learnt that a scholar like me was playing such a crass trick on her. All of you must forget for a while that you are my children. There is no dearth of names in this wide world. Think of a nice name and let her know that. There is nothing shameful about changing your last name either.’

Algooram responded, ‘You can suggest our names.’

‘Agreed! Listen. The name of Algooram’s father is Pandit Keshav Pandey. Make sure you do not forget! Beniram is the son of Pandit Munger Das Jha—take care you remember that! Chediram, your father’s name is Damdi Tiwari—do not fail to bear that in mind. Bhawani! You can say that you are the son of Gangoo Pandey. All will be lost if you fail to commit that to memory! Son, Phenkooram, you can memorize Seturam Pathak. Now I think there is no problem. Let me ask you once more. Algoo, what is your father’s name?’

Algoo: ‘Pandit Keshav Pandey.’

Moteram: ‘Quite right! Now Beniram, what is your father’s name?’

Beniram: ‘Damdi Tiwari.’

Chediram: ‘Really? How nice! That is my father’s name!’

Moteram was exasperated. ‘What a shame! Despite being the son of a pandit, you cannot remember a simple name. Your father’s name is Munger Das Jha. Repeat that fifty times—Munger Das Jha, Munger Das Jha . . .’ Pandit Moteram Shastri was putting his sons’ capacity to recall in this manner to test when his most excellent friend Chintamaniji knocked on the door.

Pandit Moteram felt so shaken that he lost his bearings. He was about to send off his sons when Pandit Chintamani walked into the house. The two of them were bosom buddies, thick as thieves. They usually enjoyed their banquets together. But today, Pandit Moteram was avoiding the usual practice of taking Pandit Chintamani with him for the feast. Were he to do that, he would have been forced to leave behind one member of his own family, and Pandit Moteram was not prepared to make such an enormous sacrifice. However, when Pandit Chintamani beheld the congregation, he smelt a rat and observed, ‘Brother, it seems you have played a masterstroke all by yourself.’

Pandit Moteram put on a dejected look and responded, ‘Friend, what are you suggesting? Have I ever had opportunity to enjoy a feast and not requested you to accompany me? I do not understand whether the times have changed or whether my own fortunes are in a state of disarray. Nowadays nobody seems to bother to offer a feast even in jest.’

‘Why are all the boys gathered here?’

‘I was giving them lessons.’

Chintamani was not satisfied. He addressed Pandit Moteram’s youngest son, Phenkoo, ‘Son, what have you been studying?’

Afraid that his son would spill the beans, Pandit Moteram broke in, ‘Ho! He studies nothing. He merely plays all day long.’

However, this charge was quite intolerable for Phenkooram. Bursting into tears, he blurted out, ‘Father needlessly complains that I do not study and play all day long instead. I remember the name Pandit Seturam Pathak.’

Moteram glared at Phenkooram and ordered him, ‘Go and play outside.’

‘Why are you scolding me unnecessarily? I am continuously saying Pandit Seturam Pathak.’

Pandit Moteram was beside himself with exasperation. He rose in order to strike Phenkoo but Chintamani lunged forward, held his hand and asked, ‘Old man! What are you trying to hide?’

‘Nothing! You become suspicious at the slightest provocation.’

Pandit Chintamani’s suspicions deepened. However, he could not figure out the meaning of Pandit Seturam Pathak despite doing his best. He took leave of Pandit Moteram but did not return to his own residence in the hope that perhaps he would get to learn something. He began to walk up and down the road instead. Just then, Phenkooram came out of his house. Chintamani held his hand gently and inquired, ‘Who has invited you, son?’

Somehow or other, quite inadvertently, Pandit Moteram got wind of this. Startled, he rushed out of his house. The moment Pandit Chintamani set eyes on him, he picked up Phenkooram in his arms and began to run. Pandit Moteram knew that the cat would soon be out of the bag. He chased Pandit Chintamani, calling out, ‘Why are you carrying away the child? You crook of a man! Chintamani, I am warning you—your actions do not merit any recompense! Never again will I take you out with me to enjoy a feast. If you wish yourself well, put the child down at once.’ But Pandit Chintamani had no ears for Moteram. He continued running with the child. Pandit Moteram was a portly man. It was quite impossible for him to run even a short distance. However, putting on a great show of courage, he pursued Chintamani, tottering like an overweight buffalo, muttering curses and inanities. Accidentally, Pandit Moteram’s loincloth came loose. His legs got entangled and he stumbled and fell. When Chintamani looked over his shoulder and beheld the scene, he stopped running and asked Phenkooram, ‘Come, son, tell me who has invited you to the feast. I will reward you with sweets.’

‘We’ve been invited to the rani’s palace.’

‘What is the name of her estate?’

‘I do not know that. All I know is that she is a rani.’

There were several of them in the city. Panditji contemplated making the rounds of all their palaces. Throngs of people would have gathered wherever a feast had been organized. He would know the place. With this in mind, he retracted and went up to Pandit Moteram, carrying Phenkoo in his arms. Pandit Moteram was lying there groaning in pain. Anxiously, he asked Moteram, 'Friend, how did you fall? There isn't a pothole anywhere around, is there?'

'How does that matter to you? Take the boy and ask him whatever remains to be known.'

'I will not do anything as crass as that. I was merely trying to play a prank but you seem to have got the wrong idea. Come, get on your feet. Yaar, in the name of Lord Ram, I speak the truth. I have not asked your son anything.'

'You are lying.'

'By the holy thread I wear, I am speaking the truth.'

'You can very well drown yourself in the River Ganga before you make your promise, but I will not believe you.'

'Had anyone else said that, I would have dared him to a contest.'

'Then come along.'

'Go and take your wife's permission first! I wager a claim to coach you for the next ten years.'

Pandit Moteram could not digest this insult. He sat up immediately and the two of them engaged in a serious intellectual debate. Both were chanting the Hanuman Chalisa with a passionate zest, as two tins clanging in a mêlée.

'Most powerful Bikram Bajrangi.'

'Let not the paranormal subdue us.'

'Hail the Lord Hanuman!'

'May the Lord preserve our reverence.'

Moteram retorted, 'This is not a part of Lord Hanuman's prayer.'

'I have fashioned this on my own. My knowledge is not dependent on rote like yours. I can compose many more verses.'

‘Hey! If I get down to composing verses, I can write up to a hundred thousand verses a day.’

The two accomplished men were bragging away gloriously about their superior attributes when somebody walked up to Chintamani’s house and complained about their zealous squabble. Pandit Chintamani had three wives. All three held great sway over the entire neighbourhood. Panditji had given his wives very syrupy, amusing names. The eldest was called ‘Imarti’, the second ‘Gulab Jamun’ and the youngest ‘Mohan Bhog’. However, their dispositions were quite the reverse. They did not exemplify any sweetness—to the extent that it was better by far to experience a great affliction than bear their ill tempers. Everyone was afraid of them. The moment they heard of the quarrel, all three of them made for Pandit Moteram’s residence. The youngest wife was somewhat slimmer than the two older women—she beat them to the place. The moment he set eyes on her, Pandit Moteram was completely nonplussed. Immediately, he sensed that his fortunes were at their lowest ebb. In a state of utter confusion, he made a dash for his house. Chintamani threw him a challenge, ‘Why are you running away? You must enjoy the taste of this before you go.’ As he ran, Moteram called back, ‘I have lost, brother, I have lost.’

3

At about eight o’clock, having finished his prayer ceremony and his bath, Pandit Moteram said to his wife, ‘We should not delay any further. Is the sachet of the digestive crush ready?’

‘I have been waiting with it for some time now. You seem quite oblivious of your surroundings. Why do you spend so much time praying at night when there is no one to watch you?’

‘You do not understand. One should always go late for dinner so that the host gets the feeling that Panditji has forgotten about the invitation to the feast. Come, let me provide the boys with some of the digestive drug as well.’

‘I gave it to them this morning.’

‘I hope no one has fallen asleep!’

‘Who can fall asleep today? They are all ravenously hungry. I have just sent for a penny of some gram. They are all upstairs, eating. (You can even hear them quarrelling over it among themselves.)’

‘I feel like wringing your neck. There was no need to send for the gram. How will they ever have their fill at the feast if they have already eaten at home?’

‘What could I do? All of them were crying.’

‘You should have let them cry. Crying would ensure that their bellies remained empty. In fact, it would have made them hungrier.’

Just then the rani’s emissary called out at the door, ‘Panditji, the rani is waiting for you. Make haste and bring the others along with you.’

Panditji looked at his wife pompously and exclaimed, ‘Now, this is what I call an invite!’ Then, coming out of his house, he said to the rani’s envoy, ‘Had you been delayed any further, I would have left to listen to the sermons—I had quite forgotten about the feast. You may leave; I will soon be on my way.’

4

Pandit Moteram arrived at the Rani’s palace with his wife clad in the garb of a man and his children in tow after nine o’clock. Her Highness the Rani welcomed Panditji into her residence, touched his feet with veneration, smiled and asked, ‘From where did you get so many children?’

‘What could I do? I searched the entire neighbourhood in vain. No Brahmin was prepared to accompany me as they were all otherwise employed. With great difficulty I could manage to gather their sons. Isn’t that so, Phenkooram? What is your father’s name?’

‘Pandit Seturam Pathak.’

‘This child appears quite bright and gifted.’

When the other children heard the rani speak in such glowing terms about Phenkooram, they began to acquaint her with the names of their fathers even without being asked. The containers full of food were placed in

front and the steward began placing the silverware on the plate one by one. Pandit Moteram thought about Pandit Chintamani. Had he been present, they could have had great fun together. How could they ensure that they had had their fill without giving each other competition? In any case, it was not possible to eat more than a square meal without being provoked into a contest! He expressed his thoughts to his wife, but she retorted, 'What has gone wrong with you today? Why do you wish to call him now?'

'After all, I need someone to give me competition!'

'Do you think I will fall short of providing competition?'

'You do not understand. You are family. But he spurs me on to eat more and more. Were Chintamani to arrive at this point of time, I could perform wonders.'

Having said this, Pandit Moteram addressed the Rani. 'My dear friend Pandit Chintamani is a very learned man. With your permission, I would like to invite him to join us for this feast. It just occurred to me that I had forgotten to inform him about it.'

'You may certainly invite him if you wish.'

'Yes, Your Highness! I will run across in a jiffy.'

'You can take my motorcar.'

The motorcar was prepared and Moteram set out for Chintamani's residence. Pandit Chintamani sat dejectedly in the courtyard. He had been cheated by his best friend. His mouth watered as he thought about the finest victuals that Moteram would devour rapaciously. Again and again he would tell his wives, 'Oho! What succulent *imarti*s he would be having. Now, laddus filled with dry fruits would be served. Alas! Moteram will enjoy every one of these delicacies all by himself.' Just then, Moteram shouted out for Chintamani. Chintamani's oldest wife, Imarti Devi, who was quite annoyed by the nocturnal intrusion, called back, 'Who is the felon who bothers us so late at night?'

'Do not curse me. It is I.'

'I will thrust live coals into your mouth, you crook. How can I know who you are? Tell me your name.'

'Don't you recognize my voice? It is I . . . your brother-in-law.'

‘Death be upon you! He claims to be my brother-in-law. Indeed!’

‘It is I . . . your brother-in-law—Moteram Shastri.’

Imarti Devi opened the door and said to Moteram, ‘Oh, it’s you! Why didn’t you say your name earlier? You spoke up only after so much abuse had been heaped upon you.’

‘Chintamani, my friend! Come along. I have come to take you with me. There is a feast at Her Highness the Rani’s palace.’

‘You did not bother to take me with you earlier and now you have come to heap insult upon injury after the feast is done!’

‘Oh no! My friend, the feast has not started yet. I have come to take you with me. Hurry up! Today I will outdo you in the eating.’

‘Oh, you poor, unfortunate fellow! How can you surpass me in the eating? There is nobody in the entire town that can do that!’

‘Old man, I have spent a great many years practising the art of ingestion. Provisions upon provisions may be depleted but my urge will never be satiated. Remember only this that having had your fill, you can never stand on your own feet. You have to be carried home, stretched out on a cart.’

‘So, what’s the big deal about that? I have always had to be carried home like the dead, on a hearse. I burp so loudly that one would imagine a cannonball had been fired. In fact, once the plainclothes police forcibly conducted an investigation at my residence!’

‘You are lying! Nobody can burp like that!’

‘Why not? You can come over and listen for yourself. You will surely take to your heels in fear!’

5

The motorcar stopped in front of Her Highness the Rani’s palace and the two worthy gentlemen disembarked. Each one of them only thought about how he would outshine the other in creating an impression on Her Highness the Rani. Together, they advanced towards her. Being slimmer than Moteram, Chintamani walked a few paces ahead but Moteram began to run.

Chintamani began to run as well. Finally, Moteram began panting and pleaded, ‘Stop! Old fellow! I have a thorn in my foot.’

‘Rid yourself of it then. Meanwhile, let me carry on.’

Moteram made many excuses but Chintamani would hear none of them. He stopped and caught his breath only upon reaching the rani’s chamber. Her Highness the Rani was seated inside. Panditji entered and announced his arrival, ‘Hail, hail Jasoda, mother of the babe Lord Krishna!’

‘Who is it?’

‘Your Highness, it is I, Pandit Chintamani. You have invited me for the feast.’

‘I see! It is Pandit Chintamani, and where is Pandit Moteram Shastri?’

‘Your Highness, he has fallen behind by a few paces. He can never match up to my speed. He is, in fact, my apprentice.’

‘Is he training under your supervision?’

‘How shall I put it, Your Highness? Modesty is what defines a Brahmin —all my trainees are my teachers.’

Just then, Pandit Moteram reached the scene, huffing and puffing in fatigue. Her Highness the Rani came out of her chamber with both the priests in tow. The steward began the service. Sona Devi and her children were quite famished by now. Chintamani began to narrate verses from the Ramayana. Moteram thought very hard about how to match up to him with a suitable recitation. However, his hungry belly would not permit him to come up with either an appropriate sacred verse or an apt couplet to match with Chintamani’s. Feeling quite crushed, he began to recite *‘Ram bhaj, Ram bhaj, Ram bhaj re man’* rather noisily. Chintamani was forced to raise his voice too. Moteram raised his voice to a deafening pitch. Just then, the preparations for the grand feast began. All the staff became alert—one brought the gong, another, the clock, one the conch and another, the trumpet. Pandit Chintamani grabbed the tray laden with the items required for the prayer service. In his heart of hearts, Pandit Moteram began to regret his decision. He did not get a chance to approach the rani. The prayer service came to an end. Something transpired between Pandit Chintamani and Her Highness the Rani. The feast was about to commence when all of a

sudden, the rani's pet dog dashed into the kitchen. Pandit Moteram could sense the ground slip beneath his feet. Her Highness exclaimed, 'How did the dog manage to get in here? What a pity! All our efforts have been reduced to a cipher. Now the kitchen will have to be cleaned out and sanctified!'

Moteram tried to console the rani, 'Never mind, Your Honour!'

Sona blurted out, 'It is well past midnight and now this problem has befallen us!'

Moteram said, 'We should make a move now.'

Rani said, 'Of course! I regret having put you through all this trouble. This wretched dog has ruined everything. The steward will distribute all the foodstuff among the sweepers. But yes, these two children are very young. Why should they go hungry? We have some leftover provisions. Phenkooram, would you like to have some sweets?'

Phenkoo replied, 'Why do you think we had come here?'

Rani said, 'Sure! Tell me the truth, else you will not get any sweets. What is your father's name?'

Moteram got panicky. 'Now let's go—it's getting late!'

Chintamani butted in, 'How does it matter? Let him answer her.'

'Be quiet or else—' Moteram thundered.

Rani said, 'Why do you feel so offended? What's wrong with asking a name? Come, Phenkooram, tell me the truth. What is your father's name? You will be given plenty of sweetmeats. Come, son, tell us your father's name—else you will not be given any sweets at all!'

Softly, Phenkooram uttered a name. Moteram ticked him off rather loudly.

Rani reprimanded him, 'Why are you scolding him? He is only a child.'

Moteram sounded really offended. 'These are the signs of the time. People invite Brahmins over to their homes and choose to insult them.'

Chintamani challenged him, 'Why do you feel affronted by this?'

Moteram threatened him, 'Enough, be quiet! Or else, I will be provoked to vent my anger on you. You have no clue about the identity of your parents, but you pose as a Brahmin.'

‘You can say whatever you may please. I am no Brahmin—I am only from a low caste. But you are the kind of Brahmin who doesn’t even know the fundamental principles of his religion. It is obligatory for a Brahmin to observe austere control over his temper.’

‘Hey you, you are a slave to your hunger.’

‘Haven’t I already conceded you are bigger, better and superior while I am merely your diminutive. I am the dog that feeds on the scraps by your doorway. Is there anything more you would like me to add?’

Rani intervened, ‘Do not say such things, Pandit Chintamani. You are a venerable man who maintains his calm despite being subjected to the grossest insults.’

Pandit Moteram threatened Pandit Chintamani menacingly before returning home, ravenously hungry and parched with thirst, his wife and children in tow. He blighted his fortunes as he walked along. Back at Her Highness the Rani’s palace, Chintamani was enjoying a sumptuous feast. He sat cross-legged and took great pleasure in his repast. The Rani served him herself. Chintamani burped loudly and remarked, ‘Your Honour, you have seen how dishonourable a man he is—he even dressed his wife up in the attire of a man.’

‘Today, I have taught him a lesson that he will never forget for the rest of his life.’

Stroking his belly lovingly, Chintamani replied, ‘I honour your superior intellect.’

Translated from the Urdu by Fatima Rizvi



Violence Is the Supreme Religion

1

There are a few people in this world who are ever ready to serve even if they are nobody's retainer; who, even though they have no work of their own, have no time to call their own. Jaamid belonged to this category of people. He was completely carefree, counting no one as his friend or foe. Someone had only to speak to him with a smile and he would be his willing slave. Gratuitous work gave him joy. If someone fell ill in the village, he would be there to minister to the patient. Request him and he would rush to the hakim in the middle of the night; in his search for rare medicinal herbs he would comb the remotest corners. It was impossible for him not to react when he saw some poor soul being oppressed. Then, even if he were to be killed by someone, he would remain firm in his purpose. Scores of such incidents had presented themselves before him. His run-ins with the police constable were a regular occurrence. That is why people considered him to be a fool. And rightly so, too. How could anyone call a person who, seeing someone with a heavy load grabbed and carried the load himself, or rushed to help set up someone's thatched roof or ran miles to put out a fire, sane? In brief, no matter how much others benefited from his gestures, he did not stand to gain at all; so much so that for every morsel of food that he ate, he

was dependent on others. He was no doubt a fool but others were concerned about him.

2

He was chastised by everyone—why are you ruining your life? You are always ready to die for others but does anyone care for you? If you were to fall ill today, there would be no one to offer you a drop of water. As long as you continue to serve others, people will continue to give you food in charity. When you fall upon bad times, no one will even turn to look at you.

It was then that Jaamid's eyes opened to reality. He possessed nothing, neither utensils nor any money to pay the house rent. He woke up from his sleep one day and just walked away. He reached a city after two days. It was a big city with buildings that touched the sky. Streets that were broad and clean. Markets bustling with life. Mosques and temples, if not more than the residential quarters, were certainly not few in number. In his village, there was neither a temple nor a mosque. Muslims would pray on a raised platform. Hindus would offer their prayers at the foot of a tree. Jaamid was intrigued and excited when he saw the importance given to religion in the city. To him no material wealth could match the worth of one's religion. He thought, *These people are so religious, so truthful. They must be so compassionate, enlightened and sympathetic that even the Lord must have acknowledged this.* Jaamid looked at all the passers-by with respect and bowed his head in reverence. Everyone here seemed to be divine-like to him.

He roamed around the city all day, and towards evening, tired, he went and sat down on the dais of a temple. The temple was a massive one with a gleaming golden dome. The precincts of the sanctum sanctorum were inlaid in marble but the courtyard outside was littered with heaps of cow dung and garbage. Jaamid could not tolerate dirt; seeing the state of the temple, he could not control himself. He looked around hoping to lay his hands on a broom. Had he got one, he would have cleaned the courtyard. But there was

no broom in sight. Helpless, he started cleaning the platform with the garment he was wearing.

Soon a bunch of temple devotees assembled. They saw Jaamid sweep the dais and started talking amongst themselves.

'Must be a Musalman!'

'Maybe a sweeper.'

'No, a sweeper does not sweep with his shirt-front. Seems like a madman.'

'Hope he is not a spy from the other side.'

'No, he appears to be a poor man.'

'Must be a disciple of Hassan Nizami.'

'*Aji*, he must be cleaning in the hope of getting some cow dung. He must be a kilnworker. (To Jaamid) Hey, do not take home the cow dung, understand? Where do you stay?'

'I am a traveller from afar, Sahib. What will I do with the cow dung? I saw this temple of the Lord and came in and sat down. There was garbage lying around. I thought—religious-minded people must be coming here and so I started sweeping the place.'

'You are a Musalman, aren't you?'

'The Lord is the Lord of everyone—be it Hindu or Musalman.'

'Do you believe in the Lord?'

'Who does not believe in Him, Sahib? If I do not believe in the one who brought me into this world, then who will I believe in?'

The devotees started talking—

'He is a rustic!'

'Let's trap him; he should not be allowed to get away!'

3

Jaamid was ensnared. Good care was taken of him. He was given a well-ventilated house to live in. He was served sumptuous meals twice a day. A few people always surrounded him. Jaamid vividly remembered some devotional songs. His voice, too, was melodious. He would go to the temple

every day and sing hymns. What more can be said when devotion is combined with a harmonious voice? People were deeply moved by his devotional songs. Many would come to the temple only to hear him sing. Everyone believed that God had specially chosen this prey and sent it to them.

One day a number of people assembled at the temple. Mats were laid out in the courtyard. Jaamid's head was tonsured. He was given new clothes to wear. There was a havan. Sweets were distributed by Jaamid. He was overwhelmed by the love and the secular tendencies of his benefactors. 'These people are so hospitable. How much care they have taken of a poor outsider like me! This is called true religion.' Never in his life had he received so much respect. That vagabond youth who had often been called a fool was being regarded here as a precious crown by the devotees. Scores of people would visit the temple merely to get a glimpse of him. Many tales of his profound wisdom were circulated. The newspapers reported the purification of a very learned maulvi at the temple. The simple, straightforward Jaamid could not understand why he was being honoured. He would do anything for these religious-minded compassionate people. He would recite prayers every day, sing devotional songs. For him, this was not a novelty. In his village, too, he would always sit down to listen to the Satyanarayan *katha*, and sing devotional songs. The only difference was that in the village, no one gave him any importance; out here, everyone was his devotee.

One day, while Jaamid was sitting with some disciples reading a Purana, he saw a well-built youth, who was wearing a *janeyu* and had a tilak on his forehead, beat up a weak old man on the street ahead. The old man cried in pain, tottered on his feet and beseeched, 'Maharaj, forgive me for my mistake.' But the youth with the tilak showed him no mercy. Jaamid's blood boiled in anger. He could not remain untouched by such a scene. He quickly jumped outside and confronted the youth. 'Brother, why do you beat the old man? Don't you have any pity for him?'

The youth replied, 'I will beat him till I break his bones.'

'Why don't you tell me what his mistake is after all?'

‘His hen entered our house and has littered the whole place.’

‘So did he teach his hen to go and mess up your house?’

The old man pleaded, ‘I swear I always keep the hen covered under a basket. Today I was careless. I keep telling him, Maharaj, forgive me. But he doesn’t accept my apologies. He has almost beaten me to death.’

‘I have not yet killed you but I will do that now. I will kill you, dig a pit and bury you.’

Jaamid intervened, ‘Brother, if you plan to dig a pit and bury him, then you, too, will not remain standing. Understand? If you raise your hand once more against him, then it won’t be good for you.’

The youth was intoxicated by his strength. He was about to slap the old man once again. But before he could raise his hand, Jaamid had clasped him by the scruff of his neck. The two men jostled. Jaamid was a strong young man. When he tried to push the youth down, the latter immediately fell into a heap. The moment he fell down, the worshippers, who were till now sitting inside the temple as mute spectators, pounced on Jaamid and rained blows on him. Jaamid could not fathom why he was being beaten. No one had asked him for an explanation. ‘No one questions this youth with the tilak. Whoever comes by only thrashes me.’ Finally, he was knocked out. Then the people started talking amongst themselves.

‘He has betrayed us.’

‘To hell with his community! One should never expect any good from the Muslims. Birds of a feather will always flock together. A crook will always remain a crook. He was sweeping the temple. No one would even turn to look at him. He barely had a stitch of cloth to cover him. We gave him respect, made an animal into a man. Yet he could not become one of us.’

‘Their religion is founded on betrayal.’

Jaamid lay by the side of the street all night, writhing in pain. He was not saddened by the beating. He had experienced such torment many times in the past. He was surprised and upset by the fact that the people who had showered him with so much respect all this while had suddenly turned against him and treated him with such indignity. *Where did all their hospitality disappear today? I am the same man. I have not done anything*

wrong. I only did what all of us ought to do in similar circumstances. Why, then, did they all spring on me and attack me? Why did the gods turn into demons?

Such thoughts perplexed him all night. Early the next morning, he got up and left that place. Jaamid had barely covered a little distance when he met the same old man. When he saw him, the old man said, 'I swear to God, you saved my life yesterday. I heard that those cruel people thrashed you mercilessly. I ran away as soon as I got the opportunity. Where were you all this time? Out here, people have been waiting anxiously all night to meet you. The Qazi Sahib had gone out in the night to look for you but he could not find you. Yesterday the two of us were alone. So the enemies could beat us. It was time for prayer; all our folks were in the mosque. If they had got a mere whiff of the event, a thousand lathi-wielding supporters would have turned up. Then they would have really been taught a lesson. I swear to God, from today I have begun to tend to three scores of hens. Let me see what the Pandit Maharaj will now do. I swear to God, the Qazi Sahib has told me that if that brat so much as frowns at me then I should rush across and let him know. That boy will have to either leave his home and run or remain to find all his bones broken.'

The old man escorted Jaamid to the doorstep of Qazi Zorawar Hussain. The Qazi was getting ready to say his prayers. The moment he saw Jaamid, he ran to embrace him and said, 'By God, these eyes were searching for you everywhere! You have single-handedly crushed so many non-believers! And why not? The blood of believers runs in your veins. What is the truth about these infidels? I heard that they were all set to purify you. But you upset all their plans. Islam needs devotees like you. With zealots like you, Islam will flourish. The only mistake was that you did not have the patience to wait for a month. You should have allowed yourself to get married and then we could have watched the fun. You could have brought with you a young bride and her dowry free of cost. By God! You acted in haste.'

Throughout the day, there was a steady stream of visitors. Everyone was keen to have a glimpse of Jaamid. Everyone lauded his courage, valour and zest for his faith.

4

It was late at night. The flow of visitors had dwindled. Jaamid had begun to learn the Holy Scriptures from the Qazi. The Qazi had vacated the adjacent room for Jaamid. He had just finished a lesson with the Qazi and was getting ready to go to bed. Suddenly, he heard a tonga stop outside the door. The disciples of the Qazi Sahib would often visit him. Jaamid thought that a disciple had arrived. He came downstairs and saw a lady alight from the tonga. While she stood in the veranda, the tongawala brought down her luggage.

The lady looked at the house and said, 'No, Sir. I remember it very well. This is not his house. Perhaps you have forgotten.'

The tongawala replied, 'Madam refuses to believe me. I have told you that the Babu Sahib has shifted his residence. Please go upstairs.'

The woman hesitated and said, 'Why don't you call out for him? Do call.'

'Madam, why should I call when I know this is the sahib's house? Why call uselessly? The poor man must be resting. His rest will be disturbed. Be assured there is no danger. Come, let's go upstairs.'

The lady climbed the stairs. The tongawala followed, carrying her belongings. Jaamid remained silent downstairs. He could not understand this mystery.

The Qazi had appeared on the terrace when the tongawala's voice was heard. When he saw the woman, he shut all the windows of his room, took down the sword that hung on the wall and stood by the door.

The woman had only just climbed the stairs and was about to step on to the terrace, when she saw the Qazi Sahib and hesitated. She was going to turn back when the Qazi Sahib leapt forward, grasped her arm and dragged her to his room. Meanwhile, Jaamid and the tongawala had both reached the terrace. Jaamid was dumbstruck by the scene before him. The mystery became all the more mysterious. This ocean of knowledge, this storehouse of justice, this treasury of principles, faith and morality was now violently attacking an unknown woman! He entered the Qazi Sahib's room with the

tongawala. Qazi Sahib was holding both hands of the woman. The tongawala locked the door.

The woman looked at the tongawala with bloodshot eyes and said, 'Why did you bring me here?'

Brandishing his sword, the Qazi Sahib said, 'Sit down and relax. Everything will soon be made clear to you.'

The woman challenged him, 'You look like a maulvi to me. Has the Lord taught you to abduct other people's wives and daughters, lock them up in your home and dishonour them?'

'Yes. It is the order of the Lord that infidels be brought to the path of Islam in any possible way. If they do not come willingly, then they can be forced.'

'If your own wife or daughter was similarly abducted and dishonoured, what would you do?'

'It happens all the time. We will deal with you just as you deal with us. Besides, we do not dishonour you, only admit you to our Faith. When you embrace Islam, your honour increases, it does not diminish. The Hindu community has taken an oath to wipe us out. They wish to erase us from this land. Muslims are being drawn away from their religion through fraud, temptation and force. So, should a Musalman sit silently and watch helplessly?'

'No Hindu can ever do such harm. It is possible that the lower castes, fed up with your notorious ways, have resorted to such means to avenge themselves. But even now no true Hindu appreciates such a path.'

Qazi Sahib thought for a while and said, 'True, in the past Muslim miscreants did indulge in such mischief. The genteel folk considered this indecent and did their best to put a stop to it. With the rise in education and culture, such misdemeanours would have surely disappeared. But now the entire Hindu community seems to be waiting to devour us. What other path is left for us? We are weak, so out of compulsion we have to deceive in order to survive. But why are you so worried? You will face no difficulties here. No other faith cares for its women as much as Islam does. And Muslim men are ready to lay down their lives for their women. You will be

married off to Jaamid, my young friend standing before you. You will just lead a life of leisure.'

The woman responded, 'I have only contempt for you and your religion. You are dogs. You seem to have nothing else to do. It would be better if you let me go. Otherwise, I will start screaming and your true colours will be revealed.'

'Open your mouth and you will be killed. Just remember that.'

'Life has no meaning when one's honour is lost. You can take my life, not my honour.'

'Why are you being so unnecessarily stubborn?'

The woman went near the door and said, 'Do as I say, open the door.'

Jaamid had stood in silence all this while. As the woman reached the door and the Qazi Sahib was about to hold her arm to pull her towards him, Jaamid immediately unlocked the door and said to the Qazi Sahib, 'Please let her go.'

Qazi Sahib said angrily, 'What nonsense are you talking?'

'Nothing much. Only this, it is better to let the lady go.'

The Qazi Sahib still held on to the woman's hand and the tongawala came forward to hold her. Jaamid pushed the Qazi Sahib with a shove and, clutching the woman's hand, rushed out of the room. The tongawala jumped to stop them, but Jaamid pushed him aside with such force that he fell flat on his face. In a few moments, Jaamid and the woman were both out on the street.

Jaamid asked her, 'Where is your house?'

'In Ahiyaganj.'

'Come. I will escort you there.'

'I am very grateful to you for this assistance. I will never forget your goodness. Today you have saved me from being dishonoured. Otherwise I would have lost everything. I have now realized that there are good and bad people everywhere. My husband's name is Pandit Rajkumar.'

Just then a tonga could be seen coming down the street. Jaamid helped the woman in. As he was about to mount the tonga, the Qazi threw a lathi at

him from above. The stick hit the tonga. Jaamid jumped in and they were soon on their way.

It was not difficult to locate Pandit Rajkumar's house in Ahiyaganj. Just as Jaamid called out his name, he came out of his house, looking very flustered. He saw his wife and said, 'Where were you, Indira? I could not find you anywhere at the railway station. I got a little delayed getting there. Where were you held up?'

Indira stepped into her home and said, 'It is a long story. Just let me catch my breath and then I will tell you. Believe only this, had this Musalman not helped me today, I would have lost my honour.'

The pandit was now even more anxious to hear the whole story. He went into the house with Indira but was out in a moment to tell Jaamid, 'Bhai Sahib, perhaps you will think I am lying. But in your appearance right now I see an image of my God. I do not have any words to express my sincere thanks. Please, come in and sit down.'

Jaamid replied, 'No, thank you. I must take your leave now.'

'How can I reciprocate such a noble gesture?'

'I can only appeal to you not to take revenge for this atrocious action on any poor Musalman. That is my only request.'

Jaamid walked away into the darkness of the night and left the city behind him. Its poisonous air choked him. He wanted to escape from the city as quickly as possible and reach his village. There, Faith meant compassion, love and tolerance. Religion and the adherents of religion filled him with repugnance.

Translated from the Hindi by Alpana Neogy



The Excommunicated

1

Pandit Gyanchandra looked at Govindi wistfully and said, ‘I have no sympathy for such brutes. There is a limit to barbarity! How can he abandon his wife with whom he has spent three years of his life for such a trivial reason?’

Govindi looked down and asked, ‘What happened?’

‘Nothing! Do such things need reasons? Their complaint is that Kalindi has a sharp tongue. Her tongue was not sharp for three years, but suddenly it became sharp! He might have seen some new bird. It was important to make the cage empty for her. So he came up with this complaint. If I had my way, I would have shot such scoundrels dead. I have talked to her on many occasions. I have not seen a more cheerful woman.’

‘Did you try to talk to him about this?’

‘Such people aren’t convinced by words. He is a man who only understands kicks. We should spend our life with the one we have got married to, whether she is good or bad. My opinion is that we should be compassionate even if we find that she is not from a good family.’

Govindi looked at him with tearful eyes and said, ‘Such people are indeed rare.’

‘I don’t understand how we can throw a person with whom we have laughed for so many days, whose memories have filled our hearts, out of our home! At least he should have sent her to a safe place and made arrangements for her livelihood. The heartless fellow has banished her from the house like a dog. The poor woman is sitting outside the village and crying. Who knows where she will go! Perhaps there is no one in her parents’ home either. Nobody in the village goes near Som Dutt out of fear. Who can trust such a short-tempered man! A man who cannot be faithful to his wife—how can he love others? My eyes filled with tears seeing her condition. I felt like saying, “Come to my home, sister”, but then, Som Dutt would have been after my life.’

‘Why don’t you try to convince him once more? If he doesn’t understand, bring Kalindi here.’

‘Shall I go?’

‘Yes! But if Som Dutt flies into a rage, try and ignore him.’

Gyanchandra hugged Govindi and said, ‘You have so much kindness in your heart, Govindi. Okay, I am going. If Som Dutt doesn’t agree, I will bring Kalindi along. She must not have gone too far.’

2

Three years passed, Govindi became the mother of a child. Kalindi was still in this home. Her husband had got married again. A sisterly love had developed between Govindi and Kalindi. Govindi would always console her. She never looked upon Kalindi as an outsider who was living off her, but Som Dutt didn’t like Kalindi staying with them at all. He did not dare to take any legal action. What could he do in such circumstances? He was always on the lookout for an opportunity to embarrass Gyanchandra.

It was evening. The scorching wind of the summer had not yet subsided. Govindi had gone to fetch water from the Ganga. She was enjoying the quiet solitude of the riverside. Suddenly, she saw Som Dutt approaching. Govindi quickly hid her face in the corner of her sari, picked up the pitcher and was about to walk away when Som Dutt appeared in front of her and

said, ‘Stop, Govindi! There is something I want to discuss with you. I wanted to ask whether I should talk to you or to Gyan.’

‘Talk to him,’ Govindi said quietly.

‘My heart wants that as well, but I feel pity for you. The day I divulge your secret to Gyanchandra, you’ll have to quit that house immediately. I have made a thorough investigation into your past. Who was your father? What was your mother’s status? I know the entire story. Do you think he will allow you to stay in his house after hearing this story? No matter how liberal he is, he won’t swallow this disgrace.’

Govindi started shivering with fear and said, ‘When you already know everything, what can I say? Do what suits you. I’ve never done you any harm.’

‘You’ve made it impossible for me to show my face anywhere in the village, and now you have the audacity to ask what harm you have done to me! You’ve sheltered Kalindi for the past three years! I know how you made me suffer. I’ve been planning this for three years: how I can punish you for the pain and agony you’ve inflicted on me. Now, I’ve got my chance at revenge. I shall never let this opportunity slip out of my hands at any cost.’

‘If you want that I shouldn’t live here, I’ll leave this place right away. But, I beg of you, please don’t say anything to him.’

‘Where will you go?’

‘There is always the Ganga, if I don’t find any other shelter.’

‘No, Govindi, I’m not that stone-hearted. I only want you to banish Kalindi from your home. I want nothing else. I’m giving you three days’ time to think it over. If on the third day Kalindi doesn’t get out of your home, you’ll face the consequences!’

After Som Dutt left, Govindi stood there like a statue, holding the pitcher in her hand. She was faced with a tough decision, and all because of Kalindi! There was no space for both of them in the house—only one could stay. Should she sacrifice her house for Kalindi’s sake, a house which was like heaven to her? Kalindi was all alone. Her husband had abandoned her. She could go anywhere. But where could Govindi go, leaving her dear

children and adorable husband? But what could she say to Kalindi? Could she banish someone she had treated like her own sister? Her child was attached to Kalindi; Kalindi too adored the child. How could she turn that abandoned woman out of this house too? But what option did she have except for this? Now her life was dependent on the mercy of a ruthless and cruel man. Could she place her trust in her husband's love? Gyanchandra was a kind and generous man, and of sound judgement but could his love bear the blow of humiliation, taunts and excommunication?

3

Govindi and Kalindi began to have small differences from that day. Now it was rare that both of them sat together. When Kalindi called her for food, Govindi would reply, 'Please, you go ahead, I will have it later.' Earlier Kalindi would play with the baby all day. He came to his mother only to be breastfed. But now, Govindi always kept the child with her. A wall stood between them. Kalindi wondered why Govindi was angry with her. She could not think of any reason. She was scared that Govindi might be having second thoughts about keeping her there any longer. That was her constant fear, and Govindi was no less worried than her. She wanted to break her bond with Kalindi, but her heart broke when she saw her dejected face. She couldn't say anything to her. She could not utter harsh and critical words. She herself might break down at the time of Kalindi's departure. She might even try and stop her.

Three days passed in this state of uncertainty. Kalindi was not turned out of the house. On the third evening, Som Dutt kept waiting at the riverbank for a long time. Finally, it got dark, but he still kept waiting with his eyes fixed on the riverbank.

It was ten o'clock at night and Gyanchandra had not come back. He was never that late. Govindi was worried. Where was he today? Her heart was trembling with apprehension.

Suddenly, she heard the sound of the door opening. Govindi came running into the living room but she froze when saw her husband's face. It

wore a smile of self-abnegation. Destiny had chosen a simple person like him to play tricks on. Was the mystery worth his tears? Mysteries were for fun, not for shedding tears.

Gyanchandra did not look at Govindi. He carefully placed his clothes on the clotheshorse, took off his shoes, sat on the floor and started turning the pages of the book.

Govindi asked apprehensively, 'Why are you so late today? The food is getting cold.'

Gyanchandra gazed at the floor and said, 'Please have your dinner. I've already eaten at a friend's home.'

Govindi got the hint but said a moment later, 'Please eat a little.'

'I'm not hungry at all.'

'Then, I'm also going to sleep.'

Now Gyan looked up at Govindi and said, 'Why? Why won't you eat?'

She could not say anything else; she felt a big lump in her throat.

Gyan came closer to her and said, 'I'm telling the truth, Govindi, that I've eaten at a friend's house. Please go and have your dinner.'

4

Govindi's mind was overwhelmed with anxiety, doubts and despair as she lay on her bed. If she had turned Kalindi out, she wouldn't have faced this difficulty. But, this inhuman behaviour was impossible for her. Even in her current situation, she didn't regret her decision. She didn't worry too much about Gyanchandra's reprimand. The same Gyanchandra who had always taken pride in his civility and piety, seemed to have cut her out of his life with such cruelty! There was no anger against him in her heart, not even the slightest grudge. Only one thought was uppermost in her heart—how could she leave this house now? She had been the mistress of this house until now because she was the object of her husband's love. Now she had been deprived of his love, and had thus forfeited her right to stay in his house. How could she show her face to her husband now? She knew that Gyanchandra wouldn't utter a single word against her, but would he be able

to love her after knowing everything about her? Not at all! She had no idea why he had chosen to remain silent for now. The storm would break in the morning. He might be a person of sound judgement, but even he wouldn't like to be ostracized by society. There was no dearth of women in this world. Thousands of women would be ready to take her place. *Who cares for me? It is insulting to stay here any longer. After all, he wouldn't use a club to turn me out of his home. Only a hint should be enough for a decent person*.

Feelings of the heart cannot remain hidden, even if one doesn't utter a single word. But seeing her baby sleeping calmly made her totally helpless. How could she leave this child who was her life?

She took the child in her arms and wept. How happily they had spent three years! She had thought they would spend the rest of their lives like this, but it was not written in her fate that she should enjoy such happiness. Words filled with agony came out from her heart: *Oh God! If this is the condition you wanted to keep me in, why did you not do this three years ago? I would have thanked you if my life had come to an end then. You have ruined the garden of paradise where I have spent three years of happiness.* Alas! The plant she had watered with love was now being crushed under the feet of a ruthless fate. She remembered Gyanchandra's love and affection and broke into tears. Those sweet memories tortured her heart.

She controlled herself as Gyanchandra appeared suddenly. She prepared her heart for the hardest of comments, but there was no sign of anger on Gyanchandra's face.

'Haven't you slept yet? Do you know what the time is? It's past twelve.'

'You haven't slept either.'

'If I don't sleep, you will also not sleep? If I don't eat, you will also not eat? If I fall sick, you will also fall sick? Why is that? I was preparing a birth almanac. I will have to give it by tomorrow. Tell me, what have you been doing?'

There was so much simple affection in those words. There was no trace of reprimand in those beautiful words. Could deceitfulness be so serene? Perhaps Som Dutt had not yet attacked her with his thunderbolt. *Maybe he*

had not got an opportunity today, but if that was so, why did he come so late? Why did he not eat his dinner? His eyes were red. He did not talk to me. He did not even look at me. Was it possible that his anger had abated? No, it's beyond the realm of possibility. Was it that Som Dutt had mercy on me? Can grass grow on stone? Govindi could not decide anything and so got busy in her mundane life, much like a homeless traveller who sleeps under the shade of a tree without a care in the world. His lack of resources makes him carefree. Similarly, Govindi felt free from her worries now.

She smiled and said sweetly, 'I was waiting for you.'

As she said this Govindi's throat choked. Could a bird fluttering inside a hunter's net sing melodious songs? Gyanchandra sat on the cot and said, 'False excuse! You normally go to sleep by this hour.'

5

One week passed, but Gyanchandra still did not ask Govindi anything. There was no change in his behaviour either. If there was any change in his behaviour, it was for the better. He was kinder, more loving and gentler than before. He had never shown so much respect for Govindi earlier. Though he was considerate, Govindi was watchful of his feelings towards her. She still had her misgivings. Now she had no doubt at all that Som Dutt had ignited the fire.

Who knew whether the embers would die out after falling on wet wood or if they would fall on dried leaves of the forest and create a wildfire. Well, the fire began to spread and showed its ill effects within a week.

Gyanchandra worked as a moneylender's accountant. The moneylender sacked him unceremoniously. An alternative option for livelihood for him was a Brahmin's job of collecting alms from his disciples. The disciples also began to abandon him one by one. People stopped visiting his house. The fire spread further but Govindi did not even hear a word of reproach from Gyanchandra. He would not have cared at all about this social boycott if it had not closed the doors of his livelihood. Govindi understood everything but could not say anything because of her sense of guilt. She

was the cause of her husband's miserable condition. It was a matter of great shame for her. But how could she sacrifice her life? How could she liberate herself from this greed for life? She could not utter a word even though her heart went out to her husband at this difficult hour. The cruelty of fate reached its height when, one day, Kalindi landed up at Som Dutt's place. The woman for whom they had suffered so much had finally betrayed her. When Gyanchandra heard of it, he merely smiled. But Govindi could not bear this blow easily. Unkind words came out of Govindi's mouth for Kalindi. Gyanchandra said, 'It is futile to curse her, darling. It's not her fault. God is testing us. In this situation we have to be patient and must not expect anything from anyone.'

The feeling Govindi had kept suppressed in her heart suddenly burst out.

She folded her hands and stood in front of her husband like a culprit and said, 'I am the reason for all your adversity. I am the real culprit in the family. Why don't you send me to a place where no one can see my face? I'm telling the truth—'

Gyanchandra did not allow Govindi to say another word. He hugged her and said, 'Darling, don't hurt me with such words. For me, you are still as pure as you were when I accepted you as my wife in the presence of God. I didn't know you at that time. Now every pore of my body and soul has been illuminated with the light of pure love. Forget about the mockery and the taunts, even the hardest blow of fate cannot deter me from my vow. If we sink, we will sink together and if we float, we will float together. The core responsibility of my life is towards you. The world cannot simply understand this.'

Govindi felt as though a god had appeared in front of her. She had never felt such respect and devotion for her husband. Her head rose high with pride and a heavenly glow appeared on her face.

6

Prosperity can ignore humiliation and social boycott. Lack of prosperity makes them fatal. Gyanchandra stayed at home the entire day. He didn't

have the courage to go out of his home. As long as Govindi had some pieces of jewellery, they didn't have to worry about food. But the situation got worse when they ran out of that. Sometimes they had to go without food. To whom could they tell their tale of woe? Who did they have as friends or to call their own?

Govindi had not been too healthy earlier but now, because of starvation and stress, she grew even weaker than before. Earlier she would buy milk for her child, but now she could not afford it. The child was growing weaker by the day, as if he was afflicted by some disease. He would just lie in bed the whole day now gazing at his mother wistfully. Perhaps, he understood the situation even with his child's intelligence. He never demanded anything. His childish innocence and playfulness had taken the shape of a hopeless wait. It broke the hearts of the parents to see their child in this condition.

It was evening. In the dark house, lost in her worries, Govindi was sitting near her child. There were clouds in the sky, the gusts of wind were stabbing the half-naked body of the child like arrows. He had not eaten anything the whole day. There was nothing to eat. Hunger made the child restless. Either he didn't wish to cry or he had lost the strength to do even that. In the meantime, Gyanchandra returned home with oil he had bought from the oilman and Govindi lit the lamp. Govindi had a fright when she saw the child's face in the dim light of the lamp. It had turned pale, his eyelashes had drooped. Feeling nervous, she took the child in her arms. His body was cold. She screamed, 'Oh God! What has happened to my child?' Gyanchandra looked at the child's face, heaved a deep sigh and intoned, 'God, will you show all your mercy only to us?'

'Ah! My child has fainted out of starvation. Is there no one who can give him two drops of milk?' She handed over the child to her husband and went to fetch milk from Kalindi's home.

Who except God knew the ignominy she felt begging for milk from Kalindi, who had not bothered to find out what had happened to them during the last six months? It was the boy for whom Kalindi had been ready to lay down her life. But she had hardened herself so much towards him that

she hadn't cared to send even a glass of milk for him, despite having several milch cows in her house. It was to her that Govindi was rushing in the dark night to beg for milk.

Kalindi was holding a lamp in her hand and supervising the milking of the cows in her courtyard. Earlier, to become the mistress of the house she had fought with her husband's second wife. The status of a maid had not been acceptable to her. Now she had become the mistress after accepting the position of a maid. She came out when she saw Govindi and asked in surprise, 'What has happened, sister? How did you manage to come here in this rain?'

Govindi said hesitatingly, 'Lala is starving, Kalindi! He has eaten nothing the whole day. I have come here to take some milk.'

Kalindi went in and then came out holding a pail of milk and said, 'Take as much as you want, Govindi! There's no dearth of milk. Lala must have started walking. I often feel like coming to see him. But I don't have permission to go. If I want to fill my belly, I will have to follow commands. You didn't send any word, otherwise I would have got milk sent for him. I've been missing Lala so much since I came here. Does he ever ask about me?'

Kalindi handed the pail of milk to Govindi. Tears started streaming down Govindi's eyes. She had not expected Kalindi to treat her with such kindness. Now she realized that she was the same merciful woman she had been before. She wasn't the least bit different.

'Sister, what will I do with so much milk? Just pour some in the jug.'

'Please take it. Everybody, whether child or adult, drinks milk. Don't think that because I have left your home, I have forgotten you. With God's grace, there is no dearth of anything here. You just have to tell me. Of course, I can't go to your house. I am helpless. Bring Lala to the riverbank tomorrow. I wish to see him.'

Govindi took the pot of milk and set out for home. She was filled with pride and joy. The moment she stepped inside the gate she said, 'Please show me the lamp, else the milk might spill.'

Gyanchandra showed her the lamp. Govindi took the boy in her lap and tried to feed him milk but the boy didn't take more than a drop. He raised a hiccup and breathed his last.

A piteous cry rose from the house. The neighbours were startled. But when they realized that the sound was coming from Gyanchandra's home, nobody stirred. Husband and wife kept crying the whole night. In the morning, Gyanchandra took the corpse and set out for the cremation ground. Hundreds of people saw him, but nobody went near him.

7

People regard family prestige as the greatest thing in the world. They sacrifice even their lives for it. Gyanchandra had lost the things he was proud of. The pride and self-esteem instilled in him by tradition had already disappeared to some extent. After his son's death they disappeared altogether. He believed that God had punished him for his bad deeds. He still believed Govindi to be innocent. He did not utter a harsh word to her, nor did he harbour any ill thoughts about her in his mind. He had no doubt that it was only cruel fate that had spelt his ruin.

Now, this house made him restless. It seemed as if somebody had taken the life out of this house. The child was no longer there for the mother to tell stories to, to give a massage and to make halva for in the morning. Now, there was a looming emptiness everywhere. It seemed as though someone had taken the heart out of things. The playfulness of the child had made them forget every pain, disgrace and difficulty. They had found the meaning of their lives in taking care of the child. Now their lives were overtaken by darkness.

If there are such people whose strength and courage come to the fore at the time of adversity, there are also those who lose their nerve and get demoralized, listless and dispirited when faced with difficulties. Gyanchandra was educated and capable; he could have managed a good job in the city if he had tried hard. The salary might have been modest, but it would have been enough for their daily meals. But his lack of confidence

stood in the way of such an initiative. ‘Where shall I go? Who knows me in the city? There are very few who know me, and why would they care for me?’ And then, how could he go in his present condition? He didn’t have decent clothes to cover his body. It was also necessary to make arrangements for Govindi before leaving. He had no means to do that. His days passed in these worries. He even hesitated before leaving the house. Govindi had to take on the responsibility of earning their daily bread herself. The poor woman stitched children’s dresses during the day and at night ground grains for others. Gyanchandra saw everything and cursed himself.

One day, while eating his meal, Gyanchandra smiled self-deprecatingly and said to Govindi, ‘There is no other shameless man in this world like me. A self-respecting person would prefer death to living off his wife.’

Govindi frowned and said, ‘I touch your feet, please don’t talk like this in front of me. All this is happening because of me.’

‘You committed a grave sin in your previous life, Govindi, which is why you got an unworthy husband like me. You are living the life of a widow even when I am alive. Shame on me for such a life!’

‘Let me die if you ever utter such words again! My life achieved its goal after I devoted myself to you. I consider it the reward for the good deeds of my previous life that I got you as my husband. Happiness and sorrow come in every person’s life. My only prayer to God is that He keep you safe.’

‘May God fulfil your wishes! Grind more grains.’

‘I don’t mind grinding grains.’

‘Ha, ha, go on grinding grains! When did I stop you? If you do not grind grains, how can I sit at home and eat without a care in the world? Well, I see there is ghee in the dal today. Okay! Now good days have come again for me. My difficulties seem to be over. In this village there are many girls from high-caste families. They don’t care for anything else other than their clothes and jewellery. They do not bother if their husbands steal or rob. You don’t have that quality. You are not from a high-caste family. What a strange world! It doesn’t care for real goddesses. They are branded as “blots on the family”. Did you hear something? Som Dutt is inciting the tenants

not to pay me rent. He's telling them that I can't do anything. Tell me, how can I pay the zamindar?'

'I will talk to Som Dutt about it. Why should they refuse to pay the rent? Is it a joke?'

'No, Govindi, don't go to meet that wicked fellow. I don't want even his shadow to fall on you. Let him do his worst. I will see how just God is!'

'Why don't you go and meet the tenants? Let them not come to our home, let them not drink water served by us. But how can they refuse to pay the money they owe us?'

'Great! There's nothing simpler than this. They will claim that they have already paid me. The whole village will take their side. Now I am an outcaste in the village. I've eaten a good meal today. Now, I can also claim to be rich. I'm enjoying life without moving my limbs. I'm telling you the truth—I'm not worried about you. If I go away, even to a foreign land, you will be able to look after yourself.'

'You don't need to go anywhere.'

'Who is going? Have I been bitten by dog that I shall go and do hard work when this luxury is available to me? You are truly a goddess, Govindi!'

After having his meal Gyanchandra went out. When Govindi returned from the kitchen after lunch, Gyanchandra was not there. She thought he had gone somewhere. Today, she felt somewhat light-hearted after talking to her husband. He was probably thinking about going out in search of a job. She felt hopeful. Yes, she didn't understand the point of his sarcasm. Never before had he talked in this tone. What was he thinking today?

It was winter. She had some clothes to stitch. Govindi sat in the sun and started stitching. It got dark after some time. Gyanchandra had not returned yet. She lit the lamp and started making preparations for dinner. Kalindi had given her some milk. Govindi was not hungry; she now ate just once during the day. Yes, she had to make rotis for Gyanchandra. There was milk at home; he could eat the rotis with milk. She had just come out of the kitchen after cooking when Som Dutt called out from the courtyard, 'Where is Gyanu?'

‘He has gone out,’ replied Govindi.

‘Was he wearing his clothes?’

‘Yes, he was wearing his black waistcoat.’

‘Was he wearing his shoes?’

Govindi’s heart started pounding. She said, ‘Yes, he was wearing shoes too. Why are you asking?’

Som Dutt thrashed his hand about with full force and exclaimed, ‘O Gyanu, oh!’

Govindi said in fright, ‘What has happened to him? Why don’t you tell me?’

‘I’m just coming from the police station. They have found his dead body. He was run over by a train. O Gyanu! Why didn’t death come to a murderer like me?’

Govindi did not utter another word. With her last sigh, her life went out. In a moment, many women of the village gathered. Everyone said, ‘She was a goddess, a sati.’

Early in the morning, two corpses were taken out from the village. One was covered with a silk *chunri* while the other was covered with a silk shawl. Som Dutt was the only upper-caste man from the village who had joined the funeral procession, the rest were men from the lower castes. He had organized the cremation ceremony. He was beating his chest again and again, and shouting loudly, ‘Gyanu! O Gyanu!’

Translated from the Hindi by M. Asaduddin



The Head Clerk

After 365 days, many hours and many minutes of endless and tireless running around, I finally landed at my destination. I saw Badey Babu, the head clerk. The ball of earth had completed its revolution around the ball of fire. Now you are also convinced of my proficiency in geography. Don't think of this as a metaphor. Badey Babu had the heat and fire of the afternoon sun, whereas, what was I? A handful of dirt. Badey Babu looked at me and smiled. Ah, the smile of great people! My half-dead body began to tremble. I felt like falling at his feet. I am not a kafir, nor a follower of Ghalib,[1] I believe as much in the presence of heaven as in my dark home. If angels had descended to conduct me to heaven, I would not have experienced the great joy I felt on witnessing the gleaming smile of Badey Babu. My eyes lit up like a field of mustard flowers in bloom. The heart and mind became like a garden. My imagination began building castles as tall as the structures in Egypt. Chairs, curtains and *khus* coolers[2] decorated the room. A crowd of aspirants stood at the door. Badey Babu sat grandly facing them like God fulfilling His worldly duties by giving each one his share. A flood of gifts and favours went on but I did not look up, as if I had nothing to do with it.

All of a sudden, a tiger-like roar caused a minor quake in my imaginary castles—'What do you want?' Ah, that innocence! One can sacrifice the innocence and artlessness of the world's beauties for it. Three hundred and

sixty-five days, many hours and many minutes have gone by banging on this unresponsive door. Even the stone of the threshold has worn down to the ground. Half the toys of Idu Bisati's shop and half of Govardhan halvai's sweets have been offered at this door, and yet I am asked, 'What do you want!'

But no, I am being unfair. Grossly unjust. Beside a mind which is preoccupied night and day by important national, economic and cultural matters, which is burdened by dockets, circulars, orders, directives, plans and so on, where does a clay puppet like me stand? A mosquito may consider itself an elephant but the bull's horns remain unaware of it. In a servile voice, I answered, 'Huzoor, I have come to kiss your feet.'

Badey Babu thundered again, 'What do you want?'

This time my hair stood on end. By God's grace, I am a brave man. When I was in college, my physique, courage and daring were much talked about. I was the captain of the hockey team, the vice captain of the football team and one of the star players of the cricket team. The marks of my bowling remain on the bodies of many Englishmen. Possibly, a few (two to four) of them still walk around on crutches or crawl. The *Bombay Chronicle* and the *Times* were full of praise for my bowling prowess. But this time, Badey Babu's roar made my body tremble. In a shaking voice, I said, 'I have come to kiss huzoor's feet.'

Badey Babu stuck out his slippered feet and said, 'With pleasure. Here, my feet are ready for you. Kiss them as many times as you like. There is no limit. You can make me promise that I will not count. Carry on until your mouth gets tired. Can there be a greater chance of good fortune for me? What other people achieve after prayer, meditation and self-control, I have obtained sitting here without any effort. *Wallah*, am I lucky. Better still, bring your friends, acquaintances and intimate relatives as there are no restrictions here.'

The oppressive behaviour of Badey Babu under the cover of humour may have made him feel proud. Curse the fate that made me a beggar at this door. I felt like pulling his big feet and teaching him a lesson he would remember for the rest of his life for mocking unfortunate people. If

misfortune does not oppress you, does not make you conscious of humiliation, why should it be called ‘misfortune’? There was a time when I had laughed at and hurt other people. At that time, Badey Babus had no value in my eyes. I had left many Badey Babus crying. There was no professor who did not turn pale on seeing me. Even those who earned thousands of rupees were under my thumb. What did these clerks matter to me? Gone are those days. I repented having uttered the words ‘feet-kissing’. But it was imperative to convey my plea. I had come with a firm resolve not to turn away from his door without receiving something. It was a tug of war between my patience and Badey Babu’s feigned ignorance. In a meek voice, I said, ‘Huzoor, I am a graduate.’

‘Thank you, a thousand times,’ Badey Babu laughed. Like a vessel which had boiled over. There was no trace of thunder or severity in his voice. After all, how long would my pleas go unheard? My ears were eagerly waiting to hear those words which would have gladdened my soul. But, ah, the disappointment that my ears felt, even the mountain-digging Farhaad[3] would not have experienced! It was not a smile, but a cruel joke on my fate. He pronounced, ‘This is a matter of great pleasure, for what can give greater pleasure to both the country and the community? It is my heartfelt desire that every youth of the country becomes a graduate. A graduate’s entry into any sphere of life will lead to progress in that field—be it national, economic, cultural or religious. If there was not such a pathetic dearth of graduates in the country, the Non-Cooperation Movement would not have died so quickly. Else, how could these money-minded leaders, these wolves in disguise, traitors and opportunists get the chance to commit such dacoities? How could religious discourse become a mere pretext for the propagator of faith? It is necessary for a graduate to differentiate between truth and falsehood, to have a broad vision and the ability to weigh the pros and cons. I’m almost intoxicated with happiness when I see graduates. By the grace of God, you are a very good example of your kind, absolutely up-to-date! This shervani comes from the world of Barkat & Co. The shoes must be from Dawson. And why not? People like you have raised the standard of life of the community and, very soon, it will reach its

peak. You have a Blackbird too, and a West End wristwatch as well. Without doubt, the community's problems do not require a Khwaja Khizr.[4] It will no longer plead with him.'

Alas, what a fate! If I knew that this shervani, fountain pen and wristwatch would become the target of a joke, I would not have taken the obligation of friends. I had gone to seek freedom from prayers, and fasting became my albatross. I had read in books that the appearance of poverty is a declaration of failure and an invitation to humiliation. Experience too said the same. How heartlessly I have reproached beggars in tatters. Whereas, when a person who looks like a saint, with dishevelled shoulder-length hair, a golden *amama* tied proudly at a crooked angle on his head, wearing a sandalwood-coloured long kurta, comes into the room, I am compelled to show him respect and, in spite of thousands of doubts about his piety arising in my mind, the smallest amount gifted to him is enough to feed a dozen beggars. It is an old adage—the worse the dress, the better the alms. But today this was proved wrong. I remembered my wife's admonition before leaving—'Why are you going like this to be humiliated? He will obviously realize that all this display is borrowed. If you are so rich, why have you come to my door, he'll ask!' At that time, I thought my wife's advice to be short-sighted and uncivilized. Now, I realized that even uncivilized women sometimes speak sense. But what's the point of regretting it now? I said in all humility, 'Sir, please look after me as well.'

Badey Babu looked at me as if I were an animal from another planet and said in a reassuring tone, 'God will look after you. He is the provider of all. Since the beginning of the world, all poets, hakims and saints have taught us to have faith in God, and we forget their teachings and instructions. However, I shall not be niggardly in giving you good advice. You should publish a newspaper. Believe me, you don't need to be highly educated for this and by God's grace you are a graduate. Write health prescriptions for savoury ointments and styptic pills. You can get thousands of such prescriptions in the great book of knowledge *Tib-e-Akbar*. Go to the library and copy them, and publish them under a new name in the newspaper. You might have read books on the science of sex. If you haven't, then read them

once and write about the ways to enjoy marital bliss in your newspaper. The more frequently sexuality is mentioned by different names, the better it is. Then watch how doctors, professors and deputy collectors become your devotees. You must take care that this work is conducted in the manner of a hakim. There is a subtle difference between the ways of a businessman and a hakim. A businessman praises his wares only, while a hakim uses definitions and maxims in order to impart the colour of knowledge to his writings. People dislike hearing a trader being lauded, whereas a hakim's praise creates confidence. If you require further knowledge and understanding in this matter, then the magazine *Darvesh* is there for you. In case you have trouble in this work, present yourself in the service of Swami Shraddhanand and express your readiness for purification. Then see how you are welcomed. I advise you not to show your willingness for purification immediately. On the first day, borrow some books on the Hindu religion. Go back after a week with a few objections. But the objections should be ones that can be readily answered. This will assure Swamiji of your desire for research and knowledge. *Bas*, it's profit all the way. After this, write one or two essays or a series of them opposing Islam in a Hindu magazine, and your problem of food and livelihood is solved. There is an easier prescription. Join a religious preaching mission and try to ensnare a Hindu woman, especially a young widow. You will be surprised to see how easily she'll fall in love with you. You will prove to be a beacon of light in her dark existence. She will not oppose it, rather, she'll embrace Islam eagerly. Bas, you will have entered the ranks of martyrs. If you continue working with caution, you will lead your life comfortably. With one fare, you will achieve both religious and worldly salvation. Janaab, you'll be a leader. Wallah, within a week you will be counted among the famous people and be regarded as the true follower of Islam. Thousands of simple Muslims will regard you as the boatman of the drowning boat of religion. Then, except for God, no one else will know what you receive and where it goes, and you know that God never reveals secrets. It is surprising you have not looked at these opportunities. I have become old and cannot learn anything new, otherwise I would have become the leader of leaders by this time.'

The searing mockery in these utterances singed my body. My eyes began to spit fire. My patience seemed to desert me. Like the dervish whose curse rebounds on his own head (or a beggar whose anger turns upon himself), I stood there with a bowed head. All the arguments and pleas that I had meticulously selected over the past few days lay quietly within me. In spite of thinking hard, I could not bring forth any new facet to my mind. By the grace of God, I am neither foolish nor dull-witted, and have a good mind. Such deep deliberations could have produced a good ghazal. But, it was temperament which did not fight back. By chance I put my hand in my pocket and suddenly remembered that I had also brought a voluminous packet of recommendation letters. Hope blossomed on my face. Holding the sheaf of letters in my hand, I said, 'Huzoor, these are a few letters; be gracious enough to see them.' Badey Babu took the bundle, kept it on the table and, casting a cursory look at them, said, 'Why had you hidden these pearls till now?'

A tumult of the happiness of hope filled my heart. My tongue, which had been locked, became free. With gusto I said, 'The grandeur and splendour of your honour held me in such awe and cast such magic over me that I completely forgot about these letters. Without adding salt or pepper, I would like to inform huzoor truthfully that I did not try hard or approach someone for these recommendations. I didn't do any running around for them.'

Badey Babu smiled and said, 'Even if you had spent your entire energy running around for them, I would not have chided you. Without doubt, you are a lucky person to receive this rare thing without asking; consider it the passport for life's journey. *Wah*, by God's grace, you are fortunate to have so many great patrons. You are intelligent, straightforward and truthful, frank, and obedient too. *Uff-oh*, there is no limit to your virtues. I swear by God, you are full of internal and external merits. You have all the qualities of understanding, sobriety, truthfulness, cautiousness, nobility, respectability, courage. You are worthy of being kept in an exhibition so that the world can look at you with wondering eyes and bite its fingers in astonishment. Today I must have got up and seen the face of a good person to have been able to meet a saint like you. These qualities will take you to

the pinnacle of fame. A government job is not worthy of the grandeur of a virtuous person like you. How can you find this acceptable! A man becomes an animal as soon as he enters these precincts. Tell me, can you accept this? Never, under no circumstances.'

I asked with trepidation, 'Janaab, please elaborate and explain these words. What is your intention in saying that a man becomes an animal?'

Badey Babu frowned and said, 'This is no complex matter whose meaning needs to be elaborated. It appears that I should make a few corrections in my style of speaking. The most important and essential attribute for aspirants to this circle is intelligence. I can't say whether what I want to convey is explained by this word or not. The English word for this is "intuition"—to understand the real meaning of signs. For example, if *sarkar bahadur*, that is, the district commissioner, has a complaint that the income tax collection in your area is low, then it is your duty to increase it indiscriminately. Don't bother about the public. The increase in revenue depends on your intelligence. A mild threat will do the job and the income tax will double, or even triple. Certainly, you would not find it acceptable to sell your conscience like this.'

I understood that I was being tested and spoke with the passion and fervour of a lover, 'I don't consider this selling your conscience; it is the obligation of one's work. My conscience is not so delicate.'

Badey Babu looked at me with appreciation in his eyes and said, 'Well done! I was expecting this reply from you. You appear promising to me. However, perhaps you may not accept the second condition. For an aspirant to this circle, the second condition is that he has to forget himself. Can you understand what I am saying?'

I spoke in a subdued voice, 'Janaab will be troubled, but please explain this again?'

Wrinkling his forehead, Badey Babu said, 'Janaab, I don't like this explaining time and again. I cannot express my thoughts in simpler terms. To forget oneself is a common phrase. To erase one's ego, to destroy one's being, to annihilate one's personality. You must wipe out Indianism from your vocabulary, behaviour and deportment. It is important that the effects

of your religion, behaviour and culture disappear. I can perceive from your face that you have not understood my meaning. Listen, you are probably a Muslim. Perhaps you are firm in your convictions. Are you strict about prayer and fasting?'

I answered with pride, 'I am as firm about these things as any priest. I have not missed any prayer. Except for the times when I have been ill.'

Badey Babu said smiling, 'This is revealed through your good manners. However, once you enter this sphere, you will have to cut and choose your beliefs and symbols. Here, your religion will acquire the outer garb of religiosity. By mistake even if you do not bow your head before others, it does not matter. By mistake even if you do not get involved in brawls about *zakaat*, it is no matter. But, here you will have to be in the forefront to petition in the name of religion and make others willing too. If your district has two Hindu deputy collectors and only one Muslim, then it will be your duty to prepare the wealthy people of the community to send a deputation to His Excellency the Governor. If you come to know that the municipality has passed a proposal for relocating the shops of butchers outside the city, then it is your duty to incite the leaders of the community to break the heads of the municipality. Whether sleeping or awake, sitting or standing, you have to constantly sing the refrain of sectarian love. For example, if you find a less than reasonable number of Muslim students in the exam results, then you have to immediately dash off an anonymous letter to the chancellor saying that the matter should be dealt with sternly. All these matters come under the heading of intuition. You will neither be instructed clearly nor will it be suggested indirectly to you to do these things. All this will depend on your intelligence. If you possess this competence, then one day, you will surely reach a high position. As far as possible, you will have to write and speak in English. Without this the rulers will not be happy with you. But, your voice should constantly be raised in support and promotion of the national language. You can embezzle donations for newspapers with pleasure or read borrowed books, even though you may have to apologize for their torn state while returning them, but support for language must be done regularly in a forceful manner. To elaborate, you have to sing the tune

of your provider. Your talk, work and heart should be engaged in maintaining and strengthening the welfare of your master. If you think you can serve the community through service to your master, then it is a lie, insanity, foolishness. You must have understood my meaning. Tell me, can you forget yourself to this extent?'

It took me a little time to answer him. The truth is that I am a man and a twentieth-century man. It is true I am not very enlightened but I am not completely unaware. I too want to see my country and community at its peak. I have read history and have come to the conclusion that there is only one religion in the world and its name is suffering. The present face of religion has no other being except sectarianism. Circumcision or *choti* does not change anyone. I don't consider it at all necessary to have a church, mosque or temple for puja. Yes, I believe that it is important to do something to suppress pride and selfishness. Not because I would then progress or achieve salvation but only because I would hate to wrest the rights of others. I have my ample share of self-pride. I can shine your shoes if it pleases me but I cannot tolerate authoritarianism. I consider it shameful to be in subjugation. My blood boils when I see a poor man becoming a victim of exploitation. I feel it is better to die than live under subjugation. But thought cannot conquer circumstances. The worry of livelihood is the greatest of all. Seeing the merciful eyes of Badey Babu turned towards me after so many days, I could only bow my head, what else could I do? I said, 'Janaab, please have faith in me. Rest assured, I will not leave anything undone in my service to the master.'

'You'll have to destroy your self-respect.'

'Agreed.'

'All feelings of dignity have to be put on hold.'

'Agreed.'

'Work as an informer.'

'Agreed.'

'Then, bismillah, from tomorrow your name will be written in the list of aspirants.'

I had presumed I would be given a position the next day. After accepting such humiliation, I would be free from the worry of livelihood. Now reality dawned. It was forced out of my mouth, 'And when will I get a position?'

Badey Babu laughed, the same heart-rending laugh whose main feature was humiliation. 'Janaab, I am not an astrologer or a fakir, it is better to ask this question to an *auliya*. My work is to spread the *dastarkhwan*. Whether the food will be served and passed down your throat, I can't predict.'

Disappointed, I told him, 'I was expecting greater kindness.'

Badey Babu got up from his chair and said, 'By God, you are a dull-witted fellow. Your mind is full of chaff. Do you think it's a small matter that the dastarkhwan has come before you? The fun of waiting counts for nothing in your eyes. A man can spend more than a lifetime waiting. Every day you go to the court, you are accosted by favour-seekers. You become acquainted with the staff. You have golden opportunities for settling matters and fixing deals. Or tutor the sons of rulers. If you can learn the art of buried talismans, then it will be to your great advantage. Learn some hakimi practices. Make friends with intelligent goldsmiths because you will often require their services. The women of the ruling class will fulfil their needs through you. But there is a more effective strategy than these formulas. If you have this talent, then surely the interval of waiting could be considerably reduced. You can put together things of recreation for the rulers.'

Badey Babu looked at me slyly and smiled. I could not understand what he meant by things of recreation. But I was afraid of asking him because if Badey Babu got angry, matters could worsen again. In a restless state, I stared at the ground.

Badey Babu could discern my bewilderment but this time he did not frown with displeasure. No, there was a hint of sympathy in his tone. He said, 'It's not possible that you have not strolled down this market.'

Embarrassed, I answered, 'No, Huzoor, this humble servant is totally unfamiliar with this path.'

Badey Babu replied, 'Then you will have to wander down this path. Even the rulers have eyes and ears. After a long day of mental fatigue, it is

natural that their dispositions incline towards recreation in the night. If you can arrange a beautiful face for the eyes and melodious music for the ears at low prices, or are able to then—'

Somehow, a trifle sharply, I retorted, 'Do you mean to say I will have to act as a pimp in the flesh market?'

Badey Babu answered, 'Why are you getting upset? If you have not understood this obvious fact till now, then is the fault mine or of your intelligence?'

My body burned as if on fire. I felt like giving Badey Babu two or four punches of jujutsu, but I recalled the lack of basic amenities at home. I remembered the waiting eyes of my wife and the hungry faces of my children. Swallowing down the sea of humiliation in my throat, I said, 'No, I am not upset. I am incapable of such disrespect. (With tear-filled eyes) Necessity has wiped out my self-respect. Please list my name among the aspirants. Whatever circumstances dictate, I'll do, and till my last breath I'll remain obliged to you.'

Translated from the Hindi by Tasneem Shahnaaz



Why Do People Marry?

Why people get married is a complex question. Of course, it is considered necessary for procreation. But in contemporary times this is not the only reason. Rather, it has become the prescribed custom for a civilized life. Nevertheless, when I asked people reasons for their marriage, they came up with such varied answers that I was left dumbfounded. I am enumerating these responses for the delight of readers.

One gentleman opined that he got married when he was too young and the responsibility lay squarely with his parents. Another vain gentleman felt that he got married because of his physical beauty. A third gentleman said that a munshi sahib lived close to his house, and he had married his daughter out of sympathy. One fellow wanted a son as progeny, so he married. But unfortunately, seven daughters have been born to him so far without any news of a son. He says, 'It's all my wife's mischief. She wants to foil my plan.' One gentleman did not know how to spend his wealth, so he got married. Another gentleman said he was always besieged by his relatives, so he married to get out of their clutches. He is now living in peace. His relatives don't come to his house any more. Another gentleman said he was tired of giving presents at other people's weddings, so he got married to receive gifts in return.

I have serially recorded the responses I got below:

1. My father-in-law was a wealthy man who just had one daughter as his heir. So, my father got me married to her.
2. All my forefathers have married. So I had to marry too.
3. By nature, I am taciturn and an introvert. So I could not say ‘no’.
4. My father-in-law made a great show of his wealth. So my parents promptly agreed to my marriage with his daughter.
5. There was a dearth of servants. Even if I came by a good one, he wouldn’t last. Then, good cooks are rare to find. I got rid of this problem after marriage.
6. I wanted to take an insurance policy for which I needed a nominee.
7. I got married because of my father’s pique. My father-in-law was not agreeing, but my father took it up as a challenge. Thus I got married. My father-in-law had to agree finally.
8. My in-laws are from a reputed family. So my parents wanted to forge an alliance with them.
9. I could not afford a good education on my own. So I had to marry.
10. Our marriage was fixed by our parents even before my birth or the birth of my wife.
11. My father got me married because other people wanted it.
12. I married to continue the family line.
13. After my mother’s death there was no one to look after the house. I had to marry out of compulsion.
14. My sisters were lonely. So I married.
15. Since I lived alone, I had to lock my house before leaving for work. So I married.
16. My mother made me take an oath that I’d get married. So I did.
17. I needed someone to look after the children of my first wife. So I got married.
18. My mother had a premonition that she was going to die. She wanted to see me married before her death. It’s been ten years since I got married, but with God’s grace my mother is still with us.
19. I wanted to know how it feels to get divorced. So I married.

20. I got married because I was sick most of the time and there was no one to look after me.
21. My marriage was a sheer coincidence.
22. That year had many auspicious days for marriage.
23. If I did not marry, there would have been no one to ask about my well-being.
24. I've courted trouble by getting married.
25. I could not disobey my wealthy uncle.
26. I was getting old. If I hadn't married promptly, there would have been no chance later.
27. I got married as an act of public service.
28. My neighbours were harbouring suspicions about me. So I got married.
29. A doctor compelled me to get married.
30. No one appreciated my poems.
31. I was losing my teeth and my hair was greying. So I had to marry.
32. Married people were given better salaries in the army. So I got married.
33. No one could bear my anger. So . . .
34. You cannot have a better supporter for your deeds than your wife. So I married.
35. I'm wondering why I got married.
36. Marriage was in my destiny.

Thus, there were as many opinions as there were people.

Translated from the Urdu by M. Asaduddin



Sati

1

Mulia's husband, Kallu, comes nowhere close to her in good looks. Then why is it that Mulia is happy and satisfied but Kallu anxious and doubtful?

Mulia has a cowrie shell that nobody would care about. But Kallu has a gem that could have hundreds of buyers. He is especially cautious of his cousin Raja. He is handsome, a playboy, a glib talker who knows how to charm women. So Kallu does not allow Mulia to go out of the house. He cannot tolerate anybody eyeing her. He now works hard day in and day out to provide Mulia the comforts she deserves. He wonders what merit he might have gained in his previous birth to have the good fortune of a wife like her in this birth. He is willing to sacrifice himself for her. He gets distraught if Mulia has so much as a headache. Mulia too feels the same for him. She yearns for him like a fish caught in a net until he comes back from work. There are so many young men in the village who try to flirt with her. But she considers her ugly Kallu far better than any of them.

One day Raja said, 'Bhabhi, my brother is not worthy of you.'

Mulia said, 'He was destined to be my husband, so how could I have found you?'

When he heard this, Raja thought that he had finally got the opportunity to impress Mulia. He said, 'Destiny faltered there.'

Mulia smiled and said, ‘Well! If it did, then surely it will rectify its mistake.’

Raja was speechless.

2

Kallu brought a cotton sari for Mulia on the festival of Teej. He wanted to buy a nice sari for her, but did not have enough money for it, and the shopkeeper refused to give it on credit. Raja too wanted to test his fate. He brought a beautiful *chundari* for Mulia.

Mulia said, ‘I have already got a sari.’

Raja said, ‘I have seen it. That is why I got this for you. That sari is not worth your beauty. Bhaiya gets economical in such matters. He just buys the cheapest stuff available.’

Mulia subtly mocked him, ‘Why don’t you make him understand this?’

But Raja felt flattered. Drunk on arrogance, he replied, ‘An old parrot cannot be made to learn.’

‘I like my cotton sari.’

‘Wear this chundari once, it will look wonderful on you.’

‘If one is happy wearing coarse cotton, why would a beautiful chundari attract her? Had your bhaiya liked the chundari, he would have got one for me himself.’

‘Do not show this to him.’

Mulia was amazed. ‘Should I take it without even asking him?’

‘Why do you need to ask? Wear it in his absence, when he goes out to work. I could see you then.’

Mulia laughed aloud and said, ‘That is never going to happen, Devarji. He will get very angry if he sees it. You take it away.’

Raja pleaded with her, ‘If you do not accept this, I will poison myself.’

Mulia put the sari in the alcove and said, ‘All right, happy now?’

Raja held her by her finger and said, ‘Bhaiya is not here now, wear it!’

Mulia went inside and wore the chundari. She looked as beautiful and radiant as a flower.

Raja held out his hands to her. ‘I feel like running away with you.’

Mulia teased him saying, ‘You know what will happen to your brother after that?’ She shut the door on Raja’s face. He felt as if somebody had snatched the plate from his hands right after serving the choicest delicacies.

3

Mulia wanted to show the chundari to Kallu but could not muster the courage to do it. She was afraid of his reaction. Why did she take the chundari? She was angry with herself. However, she justified her decision immediately—Raja would feel bad if she didn’t. She had worn the chundari for only a moment. It was not an issue, it only made Raja feel good.

Something was gnawing at her heart. Why *did* she take the chundari? Was she cheating on Kallu? She was upset by the very thought of it. She tried to calm herself—this could not be cheating. She had not said anything to Raja. There was nothing wrong with laughing with someone if it made him happy. She had not crossed her limits.

Kallu asked her later in the day, ‘What did Raju come for today?’

Mulia shivered with fear. She gave an excuse for Raju’s presence—he had come to ask for tobacco.

Kallu knitted his brows and said, ‘Don’t let him enter the house. He is not a good man.’

‘I told him there was no tobacco at home. So he went away.’

Kallu said heatedly this time, ‘Why are you lying? He did not come for tobacco.’

‘What else then?’

‘Whatever it was, it was not for tobacco. He knows I do not have tobacco at home. In fact, I went to his house to ask for it.’

Mulia went pale with fear. The colour drained from her cheeks. She lowered her head and said, ‘How would I have known his intentions?’

It was Teej today and all worshippers were to remain awake through the night. Mulia too was preparing for the puja, but not very enthusiastically. She went about it mechanically.

She was anxious, as if her face had been blackened. She had fallen in the eyes of Kallu. Her life had no meaning now. It was anchorless. She thought —*Why did God give me such beauty? Had I been ugly, Raja would never have approached me. I would not have seen this day. Had I been unattractive and dark-complexioned, I would have been happier and at ease. My heart would not have been so restless. Those who want to encash their beauty flourish from it. Here, my beauty has destroyed everything.*

She fell asleep thinking these thoughts. She dreamt that Kallu had died and Raja was forcibly entering the house for her. An old woman had come from somewhere and was asking Mulia—'Why did you kill Kallu?' Mulia was saying while crying—'Mother, I have not killed him.' The old woman said—'Yes! You did not kill him with a knife and dagger. But you were not loyal to your husband and so he died.'

Mulia opened her eyes suddenly, waking up from the dream. Kallu was asleep in the courtyard. She started crying and ran to him. Apprehensive, Kallu asked her, 'Mula! Why are you crying? Are you afraid? Don't worry, I am awake.'

Mulia replied, 'I have committed a crime. Please forgive me.'

Kallu sat up and said, 'What is it? Why are you crying?'

'Raja had not come to ask for tobacco. I was lying.'

Kallu laughed, 'I knew it.'

'He had brought a chundari for me.'

'So you gave it back to him?'

Mulia shivered as she said, 'I took it. He threatened to poison himself if I did not take it.'

Kallu fell like a lifeless being on to the bed. He said, 'This beauty is beyond me. God has made me ugly, so how can I become attractive?'

Even if Kallu had thrown Mulia into a cauldron, she would not have suffered as much pain as she did now.

Kallu was very dejected after the incident. No enthusiasm and happiness remained in his life. He forgot how to laugh and talk. He had misunderstood Mulia and felt that she had cheated on him. Mulia's admission had deeply stung his heart. Now, his home was just another place to eat and sleep, and Mulia merely a machine to serve food. His sources of pleasure were limited to his frequent visits to a tavern and drugs.

Mulia was deeply frustrated seeing Kallu in such a state. She wanted to erase the feeling of distrust from his heart, and so she served him with all the care and love she had to offer. She tried her best to keep him happy, but it bore no fruit. The more she tried to pacify him, the more anxious he got, like a fish caught on a hook.

Fortunately, the British officer under whom Raja worked as a cook was transferred and Raja went away with him. Otherwise, chances of one killing the other were high.

A year passed like this.

One day, Kallu returned home with a fever. Next day, there were spots all over his body. Mulia thought it was measles, so she started praying to the goddess. However, the spots turned into boils after four or five days. It was found later that he was suffering from syphilis.

The disease was the result of Kallu's unhealthy lifestyle and sexual escapades.

His condition worsened as the boils filled up with pus, which reeked. Mulia treated Kallu with what she could afford in the village but his condition deteriorated with each passing day. She tried to compensate for the absence of medicine with her immense love and selfless service to Kallu. She had to work harder now to run the house as well.

Kallu was reaping the fruits of his sins. Mulia effaced herself completely while she looked after him. She had just one source of satisfaction, which was that Kallu's misunderstanding was gradually disappearing because of all her effort. He regained his trust in Mulia, that she was still his—*his* wife. If he got well now, he would hide her in his heart and worship her.

One morning, when Mulia was helping Kallu wash his face and giving him his medicine while fanning him, he said to her with tearful eyes,

‘Mulia! I must have done some good work in my previous birth to have got a wife like you. I would not exchange you for the world’s biggest empire.’

Mulia covered his mouth with her hands and said that she would cry if he said such things to her. ‘It’s my good luck that I have got a husband like you.’ She put her arms around his neck and hugged him.

She said, ‘God has punished me for my sins.’

Kallu asked her curiously, ‘Tell me the truth, Mula. What happened between you and Raja?

Mulia was shocked. ‘There was nothing between the two of us. Let God punish me if there was something between us. He had given me a chundari. I took it from him and burnt it. I have not spoken to him since then.’

Kallu sighed in relief. ‘I misunderstood you. I doubted your fidelity, Mulia. I had lost my senses. I blamed you and indulged in sinful acts. I am paying for my sins now.’

He started crying and narrated his misdeeds to Mulia as she listened. She too was crying. She would have poisoned herself had she not been worried about her husband.

5

After some months, when Raja returned home on leave, he learnt about Kallu’s deadly disease. He felt very happy and started visiting his house on the pretext of tending to Kallu.

Kallu turned his face whenever he saw Raja. But this did not deter Raja from visiting three or four times a day.

One day Raja stood at the door of the kitchen and asked Mulia, ‘Bhabhi! Won’t you still have mercy on me? You are so indifferent. You kept running away from me while I was yearning for you. Bhaiya will not get well now. His condition has become critical. Why are you ruining your life with him? Your flower-like body is all dried up. Come with me; let us relish the pleasures of life. This youth will not be around forever. See, I have brought these earrings for you. Wear them once for my sake.’

Mulia did not even look at them. Keeping her eyes on the stove, she said, ‘Lala, I will touch your feet, please leave me alone. Don’t do this to me. You are the one who brought this tragedy upon us. You are my enemy. Are you not ashamed to say your bhaiya is not worth anything now? I like him more than before now. Had I not been around, he would have married again. Today, he is dependent on me. If I betray him in this hour of need, I will be the greatest sinner.’

Raja laughed, ‘You speak like one who, after he spills his curry, says he always preferred it like that.’

Mulia lifted her head and told him firmly, her eyes bright now, ‘What do you say, Lala? You are nothing in comparison to my husband, not even the dust of his feet. A man does not become handsome just by wearing bright clothes and bearing good looks. I do not consider any other man as my husband’s equal.’

Kallu called to her. ‘Mula! Give me some water.’ Mulia ran to him with water. The earrings lay in the courtyard, rejected.

Raja quickly picked them up and left the house in anger.

6

Kallu’s disease worsened. Had he received proper treatment, he would have recovered, but what could Mulia have done on her own? Poverty and disease are not the best companions.

The final call for Kallu came at last. When Mulia came to attend to Kallu after her housework, she saw him taking laboured breaths. She trembled with fear and asked, ‘How are you feeling?’

Kallu looked at her tearfully, folded his hands and lowered his head.

He bade farewell to the world. Mulia rested her head on his chest and wept bitterly. She was deeply hurt and words from her heart trickled like drops of blood—*Could you not see us together even this way, God! And people call you just and kind! Did you bring us into this world to toy with our lives? Is it a game for you? You were not so callous! Oh God!*

She called out to her Kallu, ‘You have left me alone, who will call me Mula now? For whom shall I pull out water from the well? For whom will I make food? Whom will I feed and fan now? You have taken away my happiness, my only pleasure. Why not take me with you!’

The entire village gathered there. Everyone tried to pacify her but Mulia could not regain her calm. She was broken. ‘All this happened because of me.’ She could not forget her sorrow. Had God given her the strength, her husband, the centre of her life, would not have left her like this.

Preparations were made for the last rites.

7

Six months have passed since Kallu died. Mulia earns her own living now, eats and stays at home. She does not get any respite from the day’s hard work. But yes, she often cries during lonely nights.

Meanwhile, Raja’s wife had also passed away. He started roaming around the village like a loafer just days after her death. Earlier, he was at least fearful of the domestic scuffle. Now, there was no one to stop him. This time when he returned on leave, he went straight to Mulia’s house and said, ‘Bhabhi, will you not fulfil my desire now or is there still something left to be done? Bhaiya is no more. Even my wife has died. I have forgotten her. How long will you bemoan his absence?’

Mulia looked at him with hatred and said, ‘Your bhaiya is no more but nothing has changed for me. His memories are still with me. His love and his face are still alive in my heart. His voice still rings in my ears. He is as alive for me now as he was earlier. He might have died for you but I see him sitting in front of me just as before. Earlier, we were still different bodies. Now, he has entered my soul and come closer to me than ever before. We have become one.’

She said, ‘No one bothers about food in a fully stocked home; its importance is only realized when the house is empty. The rich do not care for the wads of money lying in their treasury but the poor worship every single penny they have. A poor man holds on to every cowrie for fear of

losing it. God has not given you a heart, you see! So you do not know the importance of a spouse's company. It has not been more than six months since your wife passed away and here you are, a loose bull. Had you died instead of her, would she too have gone to seek solace in someone else's arms? I know for sure, had I died, my husband would have cried for me throughout his life. Wives die for such husbands and become satis. People like you can only lick from half-eaten plates. It is your fate. Lick it! But beware, don't you dare step into my house after this day, otherwise you will lose your life for sure! Just get out!'

Her face was so radiant and her words so cutting that Raja did not dare speak a word in response. He stepped out of the house quietly.

Translated from the Hindi by Bharti Arora



The Symphony of the Soul

1

It was midnight. And there was the riverbank. The stars in the sky were motionless while their reflections flickered with the tide. The alluring and life-giving notes of a paradisiacal melody overwhelmed the hushed and sombre spectacle in a manner that inundates the heart with aspirations, or saddens the countenance.

Queen Manorama had been initiated into a spiritual life by her preceptor that day. After the day's fast and oblations, she had gone into a deep slumber. Suddenly, her eyes opened and the pleasant notes reached her ears. She became restless like a moth at the sight of a lamp; she grew impatient, just as the ant does on catching the whiff of sugar. She got up and went out of the palace, evading the glances of the gatekeepers and watchmen.

There were briers on the riverbanks, and steep slopes. Frightening animals and their dreadful voices. There were corpses too and the thought of their presence was even more terrifying. Manorama was a living image of delicacy and tenderness. But the allure of that mellifluous music dragged her into a state of trance. She was oblivious to all dangers.

She kept walking for hours, to the extent that even the river appeared to impede her path.

2

Manorama looked around helplessly. At the bank, she observed a ferry. She went near it and said, ‘Ferryman, I need to go to the other side; this enchanting melody has touched me.’

The ferryman replied, ‘I cannot sail the boat at night. The wind is violent and the waves are sinister. It’s risky.’

Manorama said firmly, ‘I am Queen Manorama. Unfasten the anchor and I shall pay you handsome wages.’

The ferryman responded, ‘In that case, I definitely cannot release the boat. Queens are prohibited from entering this river.’

Manorama said, ‘I beseech you, Chaudhuri. Quick, untie the boat. My spirit seems to be drawn towards that place.’

The ferryman asked, ‘What shall my reward be?’

Manorama answered, ‘As you wish.’

The ferryman said, ‘You tell me. How would a rustic know what to ask for? What if I demand something that does not suit your reputation?’

Manorama said, ‘My necklace is exceedingly precious. I will give it to you as a reward.’ She took off the chain from her neck, its radiance illuminating the expression of the ferryman—that stern, dark face, distinguished by the wrinkles upon it.

At once, Manorama felt a greater proximity to the melodious sound. It seemed as if some learned man, in a wave of blissfulness, was filling the silent night with music while sitting by the river. The queen’s heart started throbbing. Ah! What an enchanting tune it was! She said impatiently, ‘Boatman, delay no more; untie the boat for I cannot hold my patience any further.’

The ferryman replied, ‘What shall I do with this necklace?’

Manorama said, ‘Those pearls are real.’

The ferryman quipped, ‘That makes it even worse. My spouse will wear it on her neck and show it to her neighbours. This will only provoke their jealousy. Should a thief happen to see it, it will only aggravate his envy. My

desolate hut will be robbed in broad daylight. People will accuse me of theft. No, I don't want this necklace.'

Manorama said, 'I will give you whatever you ask for. But do not delay any more. I have now reached the end of my tether. I don't have the strength to wait any further. Every note of this symphony stirs something deep within my soul.'

The ferryman asked, 'Why don't you give me a better bargain?'

Manorama said, 'You heartless one! You want to keep me occupied in this conversation. You neither accept what I offer to you nor demand anything yourself. You are oblivious to what is happening inside me. I could sacrifice everything for this spiritual substance.'

The ferryman said, 'What else can you give?'

Manorama answered, 'I have nothing more valuable than this. However, if you unfasten the boat now, I promise to give you my royal palace, something that you too might have seen sometime. It is constructed of pure marble and is incomparable in the whole of India.'

The ferryman laughed and said, 'What comfort could I possibly experience by staying in that palace? Rather, my kith and kin will soon become my arch-enemies. Even on this pitch-dark night, I am not scared in my ferry. The windstorm keeps blowing while I remain on it. But that mansion will surely devour me during the day itself. A mere corner of it could accommodate my entire family. Besides, where shall I get my men from, my retinue? Where shall I get assets to fill the house? How will I get them cleaned and repaired? Its flower gardens will wither, jackals will howl in its fields, and pigeons and martins shall build their nests in its garrets.'

All at once, Manorama leapt up in a trance-like state. It seemed as if the music had come close to her. Its pulchritude and rapture were more pronounced—like the lamp that grows more resplendent when the taper is kindled. Earlier, it captivated the mind, now it had acquired intensity. Distraught, Manorama said, 'Alas! Why don't you ask for something yourself? Ah! How dispassionate a tune it is, how intoxicating! I can't restrain myself any more. The degree of anxiousness that the water contains while flowing down the slope, the extent to which the breath remains

uneasy for air, the magnitude of impatience with which the fragrance persists in order to disappear, is equivalent to my restlessness for that celestial music. That music has the jollity of a merle, the anguish of a cuckoo, the consternation of a blackbird; it contains the potency of cascades, the strength of a storm! It contains everything that ignites the vitality of judgement, placates the spirit and sanctifies the conscience. Ferryman, even a moment's delay now is like a torture to death. Untie the boat immediately. Take me to the flower from which this fragrance emanates, the lamp to which this splendour belongs. Though I cannot see him, the composer of this melody seems to be sitting nearby.'

The ferryman replied, 'Your mansion is of no use to me, my shanty is much more endearing.'

Manorama said, 'Alas! Then what on earth shall I give you? This isn't mere music. It symbolizes the sanctity of this monumental place, the aroma of all the flower groups, the lusciousness of all melodies, the essence of all states. Unhook the ferry. Till the time I live, I shall serve you, fill water for you, and sweep your cottage clean. Yes, I shall pick the pebbles of your path, embellish your hut with flowers and massage the legs of your wife. Dear ferryman, had I been in possession of a hundred lives, I would have offered them all for the sake of this symphony. For God's sake, do not disappoint me. The last jot of my patience has already run dry. My desire is congealed now; my head now lies at your feet.' Manorama, in a state of delirium, went near the ferryman and fell at his feet. It seemed as if the music was approaching her while illuminating her spirit like a glowing lamp. She was thrilled. She started dancing in a state of ecstasy. It appeared as if she was flying through the air. She could see the stars twinkling in the sky. An emotion of an unsung melody descended upon her, and that same stimulating music, that same captivating tune started flowing from her mouth. Those same droplets of elixir started dripping from her lips. She herself was the source of that symphony. Those reverberations from the other side of the river, those life-nurturing notes were coming out from *her* mouth.

Manorama's countenance irradiated like the moon, and her eyes exuded affection.

Translated from the Hindi by Shailendra Kumar Singh



The Tree of Love

1

After King Indranath's death, his enemies bore down so heavily on Prince Rajnath that he had to escape with his life and seek refuge with an old servant, the *jagirdar* of a small village. The prince was peace-loving and jolly by nature: he loved to perform miracles in the field of verse rather than in warfare. The joy he got by sitting under a tree with fellow poets, engrossed in poetry, was unrivalled by hunting or presiding over the court. He would have willingly sacrificed a number of kingdoms for the peace he found in this little village surrounded by hills. The scenic beauty of the hills, the soothing greenery, the music of waterfalls, the sweet chirping of birds, the bounding of deer, the bleating of lambs, the childlike simplicity of the village folk, the bashful mischief of the maidens! These were all new to him, but what enchanted him more than anything was the jagirdar's young daughter Chanda.

Chanda did the housework all by herself. She had never had the good fortune of playing in her mother's lap. She was always occupied with serving her father. She was to be married the same year but the arrival of the prince had led to new emotions and aspirations sprouting in her mind. It was as if all her expectations of her future husband had turned to flesh and

blood. For the prince, she was his ideal woman incarnate, but he thought, *If only I were so fortunate!* Chanda too sighed, *Oh, the chasm between us!*

2

It was an afternoon in the month of Jeth. The mud-tiled house heated up like a brick kiln. The prince, used to *khus*-lined windows and underground cooling chambers, was so agitated that he left the house and sat under the dense shade of a tree. Suddenly he noticed Chanda carrying a pot of water from the river. The burning sand below, the scorching sun above! The *loo* seared one's body. Not even one squirming with thirst would dare go to the river in such weather. Why then did Chanda go to fetch water? After all, there was enough at home.

The prince rushed to her and, trying to wrestle the pot from her head, said, 'Give this to me and run to the shade. Why do you need the water now?'

Chanda didn't let go of the pot. Straightening the loose end of her sari, she said, 'How come you are here at this hour? Has the heat driven you out?'

'Give me the pot or I will snatch it from you.'

Chanda smiled, 'It isn't appropriate for princes to carry pots.'

The prince grabbed the pot by its mouth and said, 'I have suffered enough for being a prince. Chanda, now I am ashamed of calling myself one.'

Chanda said, 'Look, the heat has troubled you and you, in turn, are bothering me. Release the pot. I assure you, it is water for the puja.'

'Will water for the puja be contaminated if I carry it?'

'Fine, if you are so adamant, take it.'

The prince carried the pot and walked ahead. Chanda followed. When they reached the garden, Chanda stopped by a small plant and said, 'Here is the deity I worship. Put the pot down.'

The prince was surprised, 'But where's the deity, Chanda?'

Chanda sprinkled water on the plant and said, 'This is my deity.'

Watered, the dried leaves of the plant turned green, as though they had opened their eyes.

The prince asked, ‘Did you plant it, Chanda?’

Gently securing the plant to a stick stuck upright at its base, Chanda said, ‘Yes, I started watering it on the day of your arrival. This used to be a toy house for my dolls. I planted it here to shade my dolls from the heat. Then the daily grind of household duties made me forget it completely. On the day you came, I don’t know why I remembered this plant. I came and saw that it had dried up. I immediately sprinkled water on it and, slowly, it began to come alive. I have been tending to it ever since. Look how green it is now.’

She looked up at the prince and said, ‘I may forget everything else but I never forget to water this plant. You are its life-giver. Your arrival saved it or else it would have withered away. This is a memento of your auspicious arrival. Just look at it: it seems as if it is smiling. I believe that it talks to me. I tell you, sometimes it cries, sometimes it laughs, sometimes it frets; feeling the water you have fetched, its happiness knows no bounds. Every leaf is grateful to you.’

It seemed to the prince that the plant was a little playful child. Just like a child who, on being kissed, spreads out his or her arms to climb into the mother’s lap, the plant seemed to spread its arms towards him. Chanda’s love shone through every atom of its being.

Chanda’s house was well-stocked with agricultural tools. The prince picked up a hoe and erected a circular embankment around the plant. Then he took a spade and softened the earth inside the embankment. The plant seemed to liven up even more.

Chanda said, ‘Do you hear what it says?’

The prince smiled, ‘It says, it wants to sit on Amma’s lap.’

‘No. It says—let not this surfeit of love be forgotten.’

But the prince had yet to pay for being a royal heir. Somehow, his enemies got wind of his whereabouts. While old Kuber Singh, on the advice of his well-wishers, was in the process of arranging Chanda's marriage with the prince, the enemy troops were closing in on the prince. The prince had arranged herbs and flowers around the plant to create the semblance of a little garden. It was now his duty to water the plant. One dawn, he was walking to the river to fetch water when a group of ten to twelve men ambushed him. Kuber Singh ran towards them with a sword but his enemies knocked him down. What could the unarmed prince do? Holding his *kanwar*, he asked, 'Why are you after me? I have left everything behind.'

The leader said, 'We have orders to take you with us.'

'Can your master not bear to see me even in this state? Well, if you are to do your duty, hand over Kuber Singh's sword. I will fight to the death for my freedom.'

In reply, the soldiers bound him tight, sat him on a horse and made off. The kanwar remained on the ground.

At about the same time, Chanda came out of the house. She saw the fallen kanwar and the enemies bearing the prince away. She ran a few steps and then, like a wounded bird, fell down. Darkness stretched before her eyes.

Suddenly, her eyes fell on the body of her father. Panicking, she got up and rushed to him. Kuber was not dead yet. There was some life in his eyes.

Seeing Chanda, he murmured, 'Beti . . . Prince!'

He could say nothing more; life left him and the word 'prince' conveyed his intent.

4

Twenty years passed. The prince couldn't escape his prison.

The fort stood on a hill, and the surrounding landscape comprised a series of hills for as far as the eyes could see. However, he had no hardship there. Servants, food, clothes, walks and hunting—no dearth of anything. But who could quell the perpetual fire of separation that burnt in the prince's heart?

There were no more hopes in his life, there was no light. If there remained any desire, it was to undertake a pilgrimage to that shrine of love where he had been granted everything a man could ask for. Yes, his only wish was to return to that land of holy memories and perish on the banks of the river. The same riverbank, the tree groves, and Chanda's small, pleasant home—all these constantly swam around his eyes. It was as if his life resided in the plant they had watered together. Would that day come when he could see the leafy boughs of the plant? Who knows whether it was still there or had withered away? Who might be tending to it? After all, Chanda would not remain unmarried all this while. *Though unlikely, she may not even remember me. Perhaps when she misses home and comes back, the sight of the plant may remind her of me.* He could lay down his life to see that land but even this wish was not granted.

Ah! An era passed; sorrow and dejection had stamped out his blooming youth. There remained no light in his eyes, no strength in his feet. What was life if not a terrible nightmare? There seemed no end to this utter darkness. His life now depended on that sweet dream which he had dreamt long ago. He wanted to live that dream again. Would all his desires die then, would nothing remain? All eternity, future, all his endless worries dissolved in this one dream.

The prince's guards did not worry about him any more. In fact, they began to pity him. Only one man kept watch at night and the rest slept a sleep of oblivion. They didn't suspect that the prince could escape. One night, even the solitary guard dozed beside his gun. It was as if sleep was crouching in a corner like a dangerous beast that pounced once the man lay down. The prince heard his deep breathing. His heart pounded. An opportunity had come his way at long last. He stood up but his feet started trembling. He didn't have the courage to walk down the veranda. What if the guard woke up? He could resort to violence. The soldier's sword lay beside him, but then, love is the enemy of hatred. The prince shook the guard, who woke up surprised. Even the remaining suspicion vanished from the guard's mind and the next time he fell asleep, he soon began snoring.

When the guard woke up in the morning, he peeped into the prince's room.

There was no trace of the prince.

In fact, the prince was riding on horses of wind, at the speed of imagination, to the abode where he had dreamt his sweet dreams.

The fort was searched, scouts were sent out, but the prince was not found.

5

Inaccessible mountain roads, imprisonment in anonymity, pursued by messengers of death and the impossibility of dodging them! This pilgrimage towards love took the prince many months. When the journey ended, the prince had nothing but love to goad him on. After a daylong ride, when the prince finally reached the place, it was already sunset. There was no trace of the hamlet. Except a few rundown huts, nothing remained of the settlement. That cottage, which had once shone with the light of love, which had once been the temple of their hopes and prayers, was broken just like their dreams. The mute ruins narrated their own silent tale of woe. Seeing the hut, the prince ran towards it shouting, 'Chanda! Chanda!' He banged his head against a column as if it were an idol and, holding on to the broken walls, sobbed his heart out. Oh fate! He had come from afar only to weep! The constant longing to weep had tormented him for many days but now, oh, the heavenly bliss of crying! Could all the happiness of the world compare to these tears?

He left the house. Out in the field stood a tree with its new leaves unfurled as if to greet him. This was the plant the two of them had planted twenty years ago. The prince ran and embraced the tree as a father would his motherless child. This was the symbol of love, of that imperishable love which had only blossomed during the long interval. The prince's heart felt like enveloping the tree so that not a breath of air could disturb it. On each of the leaves was imprinted the memory of Chanda. Had he heard the sweet chirping of a bird? There was no strength in his hands, his body crumbled

with hunger, thirst and fatigue. But he still climbed the tree with the agility of a monkey. He looked around with pride from the uppermost branch. This was the Eden of his wishes. The scene was overwhelmed with Chanda's essence. There, in those distant blue mountains, Chanda was singing. Chanda was floating in the russet boats of the sky. And it was Chanda who chuckled, sitting on the golden sunbeams. The prince thought, if only he had been a bird, he could have spent his life sitting on the boughs.

When it was dark, the prince climbed down, cleared some space and slept on a bed of leaves. This was the golden dream of his life, ah! This renunciation! Now, he wouldn't forsake the refuge of the tree, not even for the throne of Delhi.

6

In that gentle, benign moonlight, a bird alighted on a branch and started singing a song soaked in sorrow. It seemed as though the tree was swaying in tune. The silent night was shaken by this gloomy tune. The prince's heart started contorting as though it would burst. The song was pierced with the arrows of grief and separation. Ah, bird! Even you must have been separated from your partner or else, how can so much pain, so much gloom, so much agitation, enter your song? The prince's heart was torn asunder; each tune pierced his heart like an arrow. He couldn't sit still. He sat up and, in a state of stupor, rushed into the hut and then back to the tree. Where was the bird? It couldn't be seen.

When the bird stopped singing, the prince fell asleep. In his dream, the same bird appeared before him. When the prince looked closely, he saw that it was not a bird at all but Chanda, yes, Chanda herself.

The prince asked, 'Chanda, where has this bird come from?'

Chanda said, 'I am that bird.'

'You, a bird? Were you the one singing?'

'Yes, my love, I was singing. An era has passed in mourning.'

'Where's your nest?'

‘In the hut where you used to sleep. I made my nest with the cords of your cot.’

‘And where is your partner?’

‘I am alone. The pleasure Chanda gets in remembering her lover, in weeping for him—that peace is absent in pairing. I will live in solitude and die in solitude.’

‘Can I not turn into a bird?’

Chanda left. The prince’s sleep was broken. The sky was rouged with dawn and the bird sat on a branch near the prince’s bed and continued singing. But now, there was no grief in its song, no lament; there was happiness, adulation, innocence in it; no tearful strains of separation, but the sweet music of reunion. The prince started wondering what the secret behind the dream was.

7

In the morning the prince made a broom and started sweeping the hut. He couldn’t let it remain in this dilapidated condition as long as he was alive. He would raise its walls and plaster them, and put a thatched roof over the house. The memory of his Chanda resided here. In one corner of the hut was the pot in which he used to fetch water for the plant. He picked it up and left to get water. He hadn’t eaten in five days. At night he had been hungry but not now.

He felt the surge of a surprising strength in his body. With water from the river, he started kneading earth. He ran to and from the river. He had never had so much strength.

In one day, he had raised a wall higher than what even four labourers could manage. And it was so straight, so smooth, that it could put even a bricklayer to shame. Infinite is the power of love!

It was evening. The birds had returned to their nests. Even the trees shut their eyes, but there was no rest for the prince. In the hazy light of the stars, he kept on kneading earth. *Oh love, will you work this poor thing to death?*

The sweet song of a bird was heard from the tree. The pot slipped from the prince's grasp. He sat under the tree, limbs caked in mud. There was so much elegance, so much exhilaration, and so much light in these notes! Human music was nothing before it. Where was this consciousness, this nectar, this life in it? There is oblivion in the pleasure of music but that oblivion is so momentous: what else but music can give life to the past and make it glow?

Suddenly a traveller stood before the prince and, seeing him, started asking the questions one generally asks a stranger—Who are you, where are you from, where are you going? He too had lived in the village earlier but after it was abandoned, he had resettled in the one close by. His lands were still here and he slept here to protect his crops from wild animals.

The prince asked, 'Did you know a Kuber Singh who lived here?'

The farmer answered eagerly, 'Yes, yes, Bhai, of course! Poor fellow, he died on this very spot. Were you acquainted?'

'Yes, I used to come here often. I too was in the king's service. Did he have a family?'

'Arré, Bhai, don't ask anything about that, it's a sad tale! His wife passed away long ago. Only his girl remained. Ah, what a gentle, comely girl! One's eyes would light up seeing her. Like a goddess descended from heaven! One day, the runaway Prince Rajnath started living with them, and got acquainted with Chanda. But after the prince was captured by his enemies and Kuber Singh got killed, Chanda lived alone in this house. The villagers really wanted her to get married. There was no dearth of grooms for her, brother! Who wouldn't consider it his good fortune to wed her? But she refused to marry anyone. This tree that you see here was a small plant then. There were small rows of flowers around it. Her days were spent tending, weeding and watering it. She always said, "My prince will come."'

Tears cascaded down the prince's eyes. The stranger paused for breath and continued, 'She diminished with each passing day. You wouldn't believe, brother, but she passed ten years in this manner. She grew so weak that she was unrecognizable. But still she believed her prince would return. Finally one day, her body was found under this tree. Who would love

anyone so much, brother? Who knows if the prince lives or if he even remembers his beloved, but this one fulfilled all the duties of love.'

The prince felt as if his heart would break. He clasped his chest and sat down. The traveller had a burning piece of cow-dung cake with him. He lit his chillum, took a few puffs and said, 'This hut fell after her death. The village had been abandoned long ago. Now, it was even emptier. Few men sat here: not even the offspring of birds come here visiting. Many months after her death, a bird was found singing on this tree. Other birds would sleep at night but this one . . . this one would continue singing. Its partner has never been seen. It is all alone. It'd remain in the hut all day and at night, it would sit on this tree. Its song is different; one's eyes would be moistened by it. It seems as if someone has wrenched its heart. I sometimes cry in bed listening to it. Everyone says that it's Chanda. She's still grieving at her separation from the prince. God knows why it is so immersed in its song today!'

The farmer smoked his pipe and fell asleep. The prince remained standing, lost. Then he said softly, 'Chanda, is it really you? Why don't you come to me?'

Immediately, the bird flew to his hand. The prince looked at it in the moonlight and suddenly his eyes were opened as if a film had fallen off them. Chanda's features were imprinted on the bird.

The next day, when the farmer woke up, he found the lifeless body of the prince.

8

The prince was no more but a thatched roof was placed on the walls he had erected. A few flowers were planted at the threshold of the hut. What more could the village farmers do?

A pair of birds has made their nest in the bed. They go out looking for grains together, they eat together and at night, they are spotted together on the branch of the tree. Their soulful music echoes far out in the silence of the night, entrancing wild beasts.

The birds are the prince and Chanda: no one doubts it.
Once, a bird catcher tried to trap them but the villagers drove him away.

Translated from the Hindi by Shalim M. Hussain



Soujan, the Devotee

1

Simple-minded farmers, once they become affluent, turn towards religion and want to gain social prominence. Unlike the well-to-do, they do not hanker after fulfilling their desires first. For several years, Soujan's crop had been yielding well; it had been raining riches for him. All the farmers in the village worked hard but his stars shone the brightest. Even if he tilled arid land, it would yield some return. For three consecutive years, he sowed sugar cane. The price of jaggery was quite high. He managed to earn about two or two and a half thousand rupees. That was enough to turn him towards the observation of religious and moral prescriptions. He began to welcome sadhus and saints into his house and observe their practices. He also began to burn incense at his doorstep. Whenever the *kanun go* passed through the district, he stayed at Soujan Mahto's residence. The local constable, the *thanedar* or an officer of the education division could usually be found lounging in his *chaupal*. Mahto would be beside himself with joy. How fortunate he was! Such distinguished people came to stay with him—the very officers in whose presence he was unable to utter a word now had parched throats from repeating, 'Mahto! Mahto!' One mahatma found the environment quite favourable and decided to sit in penance there. Ganja and charas were in plenty. A dholak was procured, cymbals were purchased and

a congregation of people gathered to worship and sing devotional songs. All this was possible only because of the pains Soujan had taken. There were several *ser*s of milk in the house but not a drop went into Soujan's mouth. Sometimes the officers drank it and sometimes the sadhus. How could milk and ghee interest a farmer? All he needed was lentils and roti. Soujan's humility was bottomless; he stood before everyone with his head bowed low. He feared people would imagine that having got his hands on wealth he had become puffed up with pride.

There were only three wells in the entire village. All the fields could not be irrigated with water; the crop was adversely affected. Soujan commissioned the digging of a fourth well. A grand feast was thrown for Brahmins and a yagna was performed for the inaugural ceremony. On the day water was drawn from the well for the first time, Soujan felt he had received countless bounties. With the goodwill and blessings of his father and his forefathers, he had accomplished a task which nobody in the entire village had been able to successfully carry out.

One day, some travellers on their way to Gaya stopped by the village. They had their meals at Soujan's house. Listening to them, Soujan too became keen on undertaking a journey to Gaya. Perceiving this as an opportune moment, he made preparations to travel with them.

His wife, Bulaqi, said to him, 'Let it be for now, we can go next year.'

Soujan said seriously, 'Who knows what will happen next year? It is not good to postpone matters pertaining to one's faith. How can one know when one will die?'

'We will be eating into our savings.'

'If Bhagwan wills it, we will acquire money once again. There can be no dearth of anything when it comes to His munificence.'

What could Bulaqi say in response to that? Why would she interfere in his religious convictions and defile her own life after death? In the morning, man and wife set out on their journey to Gaya. When they returned from the pilgrimage, they decided to organize a yagna and a throw a grand feast for Brahmins. The entire community was invited. Betel nut was distributed in eleven villages. All the preparations were conducted so lavishly that people

all over began to talk about it. Everybody said that if Bhagwan bequeaths wealth on anyone, He should also endow him with a heart to match. ‘There is no trace of arrogance in him. He goes around carrying the oil in his own hands. He has brought a glowing radiance upon the family name. If one has to have a son, he should be like Soujan. When his father died, they were in abject poverty; now Goddess Lakshmi has made a permanent residence in his house.’

When one man, who was jealous of Soujan, said, ‘He must have dug a pot of gold somewhere,’ people all around began to shower abuse on him. ‘Of course! He’s got his hands on the treasure that your ancestors left behind. Arré, Bhaiya! This is the recompense of piety and devotion. You also put in very hard work, but you will not be able to produce a sugar-cane crop like his. Bhagwan is aware of the fortitude with which men work. He provides only those who are willing to spend with riches.’

2

Soujan Mahto became Soujan Bhagat. The customs and principles observed by Bhagats are special. A Bhagat does not eat anything without taking a ritual bath. If the Ganga is a considerable distance away from his house and he cannot return from there after a bath before afternoon on a daily basis, it is obligatory for him to go to the river on days of festivals. He must perform puja and sing bhajans at his house every day. Both performing the puja and reading from the scriptures are obligatory. He has to ensure that he abstains from consuming all forbidden food and drink. Most significantly, he must quit lying. A Bhagat cannot tell a lie. If an ordinary person is liable to be punished by a single reckoning for telling a lie, then for a Bhagat the punishment is not less than a hundred thousand retributions. For an uninformed person many blunders are pardonable but for a knowledgeable one there is neither pardon nor expiation from sin and if at all there is, it is incredibly stiff. Now, Soujan had to live up to the stature of a Bhagat. Till now, his life had been one of a labourer. He need not have followed any ideology or ethics governing his way of life. But now, he could not do

without them. The path he had chosen was laid out with a great many hardships. Earlier, he had spent his life working for personal benefits. He had always weighed everything in a balance supporting that lifestyle. Now he weighed everything in the balance of propriety and impropriety. In other words, he had left behind a barbaric lifestyle and stepped into a world which demanded learned and decent behaviour. He had set up a business of sorts. Now he felt guilty making a profit on transactions—to an extent that while milking the cows, he always thought about the well-being of the calves. 'Hope the calf is not hungry; if he is, he will feel hurt.' He was the village mukhiya and had provided false evidence in several cases. In so many others he had accepted bribes in order to settle disputes. Now he hated even thinking about these dealings. He distanced himself from all manner of falsehood and deception. Earlier, he used to make his labourers toil as hard as humanly possible and pay them as measly an amount as he could, but now he was more concerned with their wages than with the work they could put in. He did not want poor labourers to work very hard because he felt like he was oppressing them. His deepest anxiety was that nobody should suffer even the slightest hardship. Both his grown-up sons would chastise him every now and then. So much so that even Bulaqi began to perceive that he was a Bhagat in totality, and that he was not really concerned with the well-being of the household any more. Erudite principles had converted Soujan Mahto into a Bhagat in toto.

Gradually, all of Soujan's rights and privileges were withdrawn. Nobody consulted Bhagatji about anything—even such significant matters as what would be sown in which field, what transactions had to be carried out and with whom, or what price had been fixed for the sale of which item. Nobody, neither the two sons nor Bulaqi, looked up to Soujan. They began to settle matters by themselves. Soujan's credibility and estimation were on the rise among the village folk but within his own household, it was on the decline. His sons treated him with a great deal of deference—if they saw him lift a charpoy, they would dart across to take it from him; they did not permit him to replenish the tobacco in the chillum—so much so that they did not let him wash his own dhoti. But he lost charge over everything. He

was no longer the patriarch of the household; he was a revered person belonging to the holy sanctuary of worship.

3

One day Bulaqi was pounding grain in the mortar with a pestle when a beggar came up to the doorway and began to beg for alms in a shrill voice. Bulaqi thought to herself, *I must give him some dal and rice*. Just then, her eldest son, Bhola, came up to her and said, 'Amma! A mahatma is screeching away at the doorway. Give him something lest he feel hurt.'

Bulaqi said mockingly in response, 'Has Bhagat applied mehendi on his feet? Why doesn't he go and give him something? How many people should I tend to? So many of them approach us all day long and beg for alms.'

'He is hell-bent on bringing ruin upon all of us. What else can I say? A while ago, Mehengoo had come to deliver the brinjals. According to the estimate, they ought to have weighed seven maunds.[43] However, when we actually weighed them, it turned out he had brought only six and three-quarter maunds. I said, "Bring ten sers more," and Soujan Bhagat said, "Now how can he travel such a long distance to bring them? You can note down that you have received his share, or he will feel hurt." But I did not write that his account had been settled; I noted that he had to bring ten sers more.'

'You have done well to write that. He talks nonsense. When he is snubbed a few times, he will stop interfering.'

'All day long he messes with something or the other. A hundred times I have told him not to interfere in household matters but he is not able to hold back from meddling in almost everything.'

'Had I known he would be reduced to this condition, I would not have permitted him to receive the oath from his guru.'

'As the old adage goes, he has become lost to worldly affairs as well as to religious convictions since becoming a Bhagat. The whole day is spent in performing puja and reading from the scriptures. He still needs to perform

the other duties expected of him—he's not so old that he can get away with not doing them.'

Bulaqi changed the topic of conversation and observed, 'You are being unfair, Bhola. He is too old to wield either the axe or the shovel. But he usually does something or the other. He feeds the oxen, milks the cows and does whatever else is possible for him to do at his age.'

The fakir was still standing at the door and screaming away. When Soujan observed that nobody from the house was coming out to give him anything, he got up, went inside and said in an authoritative tone, 'Someone has been standing at the door begging for alms for over an hour now—can't you people hear? You have all day to do your own work. You can take some time out to do something for Bhagwan as well.'

Bulaqi responded, 'You are sitting around to toil for Bhagwan, aren't you? Should the rest of the family do the same?'

'Is there any flour in the house? Let me take some out and give it to him. You can sit there like a queen.'

'A lot of money and hard work has gone into making the flour. Give him some grain instead. I do not wake up early in the morning to grind the flour for such sturdy louts like him.'

Soujan went into the storeroom and returned with a small basketful of millet which would not have weighed any less than a ser. Just to provoke Bulaqi and Bhola, Soujan had deliberately brought out a larger quantity than was considered appropriate for distribution as alms. However, he wanted to demonstrate that there was not enough millet in the basket. Therefore, he was holding it in a weak grasp, between his thumb and forefinger. Unable to carry so much weight in that manner, his hand began to tremble. Even a moment's carelessness was likely to cause the basket to fall from his hand. That is why he wanted to hurry up and go outside. All of a sudden, Bhola snatched the basket away from his hand and said angrily, 'There isn't enough for you to squander this way. We put in a great deal of hard work, only then can we get provisions for the house.'

An embarrassed Soujan responded, 'I do not sit around either.'

‘Alms should be given in due measure—they should not be frittered away. Here we eat only once a day so that we may live respectfully but you can think only of giving away extravagantly. But how can you be aware what is going on in the house?’

Soujan did not reply. Instead, he went out and said to the beggar, ‘Baba! Go away for now. Nobody at home is free at the moment.’ Then, he went and sat under a tree and started contemplating. How he was disrespected in his own house! He was not handicapped; his limbs were still quite functional. After all, he also worked hard. In spite of this, he was slighted so grossly. He had made the house; all the affluence that everybody enjoyed was because of the effort *he* had put in. But now, it seemed his status as the patriarch of the family was irrelevant. He was merely a mongrel at the doorstep. He would survive on whatever scraps were dished out to him by his kin. A curse on such a life! Soujan could not live in such a house.

It was evening. Bhola’s younger brother, Shankar, filled tobacco in the chillum and brought it out to Soujan but he let it lie against the wall. Gradually, the tobacco burnt itself out. In a short while, Bhola laid out the charpoy in the doorway. Soujan did not get up from his place under the tree. Some more time passed. Dinner was served. Bhola came out to summon him in but Soujan replied, ‘I am not hungry.’

When he refused to get up even after a lot of cajoling, Bulaqi came out and said, ‘Why don’t you come in and eat your food? Are you feeling all right?’

Soujan was most livid with Bulaqi. *She took the boy’s side. She sat and watched while Bhola snatched the grain from my hands. Couldn’t she say, ‘Let it be; let him take it if he wants’? Maybe the boys do not know how hard I have worked to make this household thrive, but she certainly knows. I’ve toiled untiringly through the days and nights. All through the dark nights, during the month of Bhadon, I sat guard over the jowar fields with nothing but a stick in my hand. Neither did I take a break in the hot afternoons during the months of Jeth and Baisakh. And now I have lost all rights and privileges over the affairs of my own household; so much so that I cannot even give alms to anyone. Agreed, that such large quantities of*

grain are not distributed as charity, but Bhola ought to have remained quiet. Why don't I set my own house aflame? I have some legal rights over this place too! I do not take my share for myself; I give it away to others instead. Why should anybody be concerned with that? Now she has come to support me. I haven't ever hurt her with anything as fragile as a stick made of flowers. Is there any other woman in the entire village who has not been kicked by her husband? Never have I even glared at her angrily. She has always had complete control of all the money and has always conducted all the transactions by herself. Now that she has stashed up some money, she behaves arrogantly and to me! Now, she is very fond of the boys! I am merely a housebound, worthless and imprudent man. Why should she worry about me? When she did not have any sons, it was I who carried her around, in my arms, from one vaidya to another. But today, she has her sons and she is only their mother! I am an outsider. Why should I be concerned with the household?

He said to her, 'Why should I eat and drink now? After all, I cannot plough the fields; I cannot wield the pickaxe. Why should you waste the grain by feeding it to me? Put it away; your son can have it for his second meal.'

'You get cross at every little thing. It is quite true that a man is not able to think rationally in his old age. All Bhola said was that you should not give alms in such large quantities. Or was it anything else?'

'Yes! That is all that the poor fellow was able to say. Had he struck me a couple of times with a staff you would probably have enjoyed it. Isn't that so? If that is what you want, go ahead and fulfil your desire now. Bhola must have eaten by now. Go and call him. But no! Why should you call Bhola? You can hit me instead. That is all that remains to be done. Let that happen as well.'

'Right, that *is* the duty of a woman. Thank your stars you have been married to someone as simple as me. You make me do as you please. Had I been as strong-headed as you are suggesting, we could never have lived together with such equanimity.'

‘Yes, of course! That is exactly as I am saying—you were and still are an epitome of perfection. Earlier, I was a demon but now I am Satan himself.’ He thought to himself, *Her sons earn the money. Obviously, she will now pander to them. Why should she speak up for me? What does she stand to gain from me?*

‘You are bent upon picking a fight, and I am not willing to get into it because outsiders will become privy to our quarrel and we will become a laughing stock. Come in and have your dinner without making a fuss or else I too will go to bed.’

‘Why should you go to sleep hungry? Your sons are earning. But yes! I am a stranger.’

‘They are your sons too.’

‘No! I would rather not be father to such sons. They could be somebody else’s sons. Had they been mine, would they have treated me in this awful manner?’

‘If you curse them like this, I may say something unwarranted. I have heard that men are very intelligent but you seem a cut above the rest. A man should act in accordance with the changing times. It is best for the two of us to live the rest of our lives as heads of the family in name only, and do exactly as the boys want us to do. If I can understand this, why can’t you? The man who earns runs the house as he pleases. This is the way of the world. I do nothing without seeking the approval of the boys. Why should you continue to do as you please? You have lived through your prime doing as you wished. Why should you involve yourself in worldly matters now? Come in and have your dinner.’

‘Am I then a stray dog at the doorstep?’

‘I have spoken my mind; now you can call yourself whatever names you want.’

Soujan did not get up. Having tired herself out trying to make him see her point, Bulaqi went inside.

Soujan now found himself face to face with a fresh dilemma. He had been the patriarch of the household for quite some time and, in fact, still considered himself worthy of that status. He did not have any idea about how much things had changed. His sons respected him and took care of his needs and this is what had put him in a quandary. They did not smoke the chillum in his presence; neither did they sit on the bed in his presence. Were these not indications enough to establish that he was still the patriarch of the household? However, today he had realized that these were merely indicative of the respect that they had for him and not proof of his status in the family. Could he surrender all ideas of his patriarchal position in favour of the respect they provided him? Certainly not! How could he begin to live like a servant in the house in which *he* had set the rules? He could not bear to see others control that house. He did not want to live his life like the priest in a temple.

Sometime in the middle of the night, Soujan got up and began to chop the food for the oxen in the chopper. The entire village was asleep but Soujan was cutting fodder. He had not worked so hard in a very long time. Since the time he had given up exerting physical labour, chopping food for the oxen had become a crucial matter requiring resolution. Both Shankar and Bhola would chop the hay but somehow it seemed that it never sufficed. Today he would prove to those boys how fodder was chopped. Soon, a large heap of the chopped fodder accumulated in front of him. The bits were small and clean, as though they had been taken out of a mould.

When Bulaqi woke up early next morning, she was quite astonished to see the heap of chopped fodder. 'Has Bhola chopped fodder all night? How often I have said to him, "Son, health is wealth" but he does not listen to me. It seems he hasn't slept all night,' she said.

Soujan Bhagat responded with sarcasm, 'Does he ever sleep? Every time I look at him, he is doing something or the other. Could anyone in this wide world be as hard-working as him?'

Just then Bhola came out rubbing his eyes. He too was surprised to see the stack of chopped fodder. He asked his mother, 'Did Shankar wake up very early in the morning, Amma?'

‘He is fast asleep. I thought you have chopped this.’

‘I cannot wake up so early in the morning. I can do any amount of work during the day but I cannot stay up at night.’

‘Has your dada chopped it then?’

‘Apparently—it certainly seems like that. He has not slept all night. I made a grave mistake last night. Arré! He is taking the plough and going out. Is he bent on sacrificing his life?’

‘He has always been stubborn. He will not listen to anyone now.’

‘Wake up, Shankar. I too will wash up quickly and go out with the plough.’

By the time Bhola arrived at the field, carrying the plough with the other farmers, Soujan had already ploughed half of it. Bhola began to work without uttering a word. Nobody could summon up the courage to say anything to Soujan.

In the afternoon, all the farmers released their oxen and stopped work. Only Soujan continued. Bhola was tired. Time and again, he felt like releasing the oxen but didn’t want to suggest it out of sheer dread. It astonished him to see how much work his father could put in. Finally, with a great deal of apprehension he observed, ‘Dada, it is afternoon now, we should release the oxen.’

‘Yes, release them. You can proceed with the oxen; I will join you in a while after scattering the seeds.’

‘I will scatter them in the evening.’

‘Do you really think you can do that? Don’t you see that the field looks more like a basin now? That is why the water accumulates in the centre. We should have reaped twenty maunds of produce from this field, but you people have made a mess of it.’

The oxen were released. Bhola began to return home with them but Soujan continued to scatter the seeds. Having done that, he returned home after half an hour, but he was not tired at all. Then, having eaten and bathed, he began to feed the oxen instead of taking rest. He caressed their backs, rubbed their legs and stroked their tails, which they held tautly. With their heads placed in Soujan’s lap the oxen derived immense relief, for it was

after a very long time that they had received such loving care. Their eyes expressed tremendous gratitude, as though they were expressing their willingness to toil day and night with him.

Like the rest of the farmers, Bhola was still resting his back when Soujan lifted the plough and began to walk towards the fields. Both the oxen were following him in merry excitement, as though they were keen to reach the fields as fast as they could.

A sleepy Bhola saw his father walk out of the house carrying the plough but could not bring himself to get up. His courage failed him. He had never worked as hard because he had inherited a ready-made domestic sphere which he had been managing somehow. He was not prepared to assume the role of the patriarch of the household at such a heavy cost. As a young man he had several occupations with which he could employ himself. He also needed time to indulge in gossip and to make merry. A wrestling contest had been organized in the neighbouring village. As a young man, how could he resist attending it? In another, a song and dance party had been organized as part of the celebrations to receive the groom's wedding procession. How could he refrain from enjoying that? Older people are not bothered with such distractions. They are neither concerned with song and dance nor are they distracted by fun and games; they are only concerned about performing their duty.

Bulaqi said, 'Bhola, your dada has left with the plough.'

'Let him go, Amma. I cannot work like him.'

5

Soujan's boldness became the talk of the entire village. 'He is no longer a Bhagat. He was feigning all this while. He is quite steeped in avarice. He is not a man, he is a phantom.' But one could still see sadhus and saints meditating at Bhagatji's doorstep and they were still welcomed. This time his land bestowed gold on him. There was a shortage of space in his storeroom for the grain. The field that barely produced five maunds of grain had produced ten maunds this time.

It was the month of Chait. The fields had yielded their crop. Heaps of grain were piled up in several places. This was the time when for a brief period the farmers realized the worth of the laborious toil—when their hearts filled up with pride for the success that they had reaped. Soujan Bhagat filled up the wicker baskets with grain and passed them on to his sons who dispatched them to their house. A considerable number of tramps and fakirs had gathered around Bhagatji. Among them was the sadhu who had approached their house about eight months ago and had to return from their doorstep disappointed.

Suddenly, Bhagat asked the fakir, 'Why, Baba, where have you done the rounds today?'

'I have not been anywhere as yet, Bhagat! You are the first man I have approached.'

'All right, these mounds of grain lie before you. You can pick as much as you want.'

Casting a hungry look at the mounds of grain the fakir ventured, 'I will take whatever you give me with your own hands.'

'No, you may take as much as you can carry.'

The fakir had a coverlet with him. He filled up about ten sers of grain and began to lift it. He did not have the courage to take any more because he was frightened.

Having judged the fakir's desire, Bhagat began a pep talk in order to boost his morale. 'Is that all? Even a child can lift that much grain.'

The fakir looked at Bhola meaningfully and said, 'This is more than enough for me.'

'No! You are afraid. Here, take some more.'

The fakir filled up about five more sers of grain and cast a petrified look at Bhola.

'Why are you looking at him, Babaji? Do as I tell you. Take as much as you can carry.'

The fakir was afraid that if he filled up his bundle with more grain and Bhola did not permit him to take it, he would be greatly embarrassed. The other fakirs would get a chance to laugh at him too. Everybody would say

that he was very greedy. He did not have the courage to take any more grain.

Then, Soujan filled more grain in his coverlet and tying it up in a bundle said, 'Take this away.'

'Baba! I will not be able to lift so much.'

'Arré, won't you be able to carry this much? At the most this must be one maund. Try and lift it. Bhola, will you help him lift it?'

The fakir tried to gauge the weight of the bundle. It was heavy. He could not move it. He said, 'Bhagatji, I will not be able to lift it.'

'All right, tell me the name of the village where you live.'

'It is far away, Bhagatji. You must have heard of Amola.'

'Never mind, you can lead the way. I will take it to your village.'

Bhagatji lifted the bundle with great effort, and began to follow the fakir.

The people who were watching Bhagat were quite astounded. They had no idea about the emotions that regaled Bhagat now. After eight months, he was finally reaping the fruits of his hard work. Today, he had been able to restore the respect he had lost. The sword that is powerless to cut a banana can slice through iron once it has been sharpened. Wealth is a very useful thing to have in a man's life. An old man who is strong is in fact young; a young man who lacks strength and self-respect is as good as a dead man. Soujan had strength, wealth and self-respect. He was fired with passion and that is what provided him with extraordinary strength. As he was about to leave, he looked at Bhola with eyes full of pride and proclaimed, 'None of the fakirs and tramps standing here should leave empty-handed.' Bhola stood there with his head bowed low. He did not have the courage to say anything. He had been defeated by his elderly father.

Translated from the Urdu by Fatima Rizvi



Temple

1

Salute to motherly love! Everything else in this world is false; indeed, all else is transitory, frail. For the past three days, Sukhiya had taken neither a morsel of food nor a drop of water. Lying on the straw, the mother's child was groaning. For the past three days he hadn't opened his eyes. Sometimes his mother would take him in her lap, sometimes she would make him sleep on the straw. Nobody could tell what had happened all of a sudden to such a lively child. In such a condition how could a mother feel hungry or thirsty? Once she had taken a sip of water but it would not go down her throat; the poor soul's trouble was boundless. She had already surrendered two of her children to the Ganga. Her husband was dead. Now this child was her sole reason to live. Oh! Did God want to snatch him away too? Tears streamed down her face as such thoughts came to her mind. She didn't leave the child alone even for a moment. She took him along when she went to cut grass, to the bazaar to sell the grass; she kept the child in her lap all the time. Sukhiya had got a small sickle and a tiny woven basket made for him. Jayawan would cut the grass with his mother and exclaim proudly, 'Mother, make me a big sickle, we will cut a lot of grass. You can sit at the door sill and rest, I will sell it in the market.' The mother would ask, 'Son, what will you bring for me?' Jayawan promised her bright red saris while he wanted a

whole lot of jaggery for himself. These innocent words kept coming back to her and piercing her heart like an arrow. Whosoever saw the child said it was the effect of witchcraft. But whose spell? How could this widow have an enemy? If one had some clue as to who it was, Sukhiya would fall at his feet and keep the child in his lap. Wouldn't his heart melt? But nobody was telling her the name! Whom should she ask? What should she do?

2

Three hours of night had passed. Her worried and restless heart was wandering. *Which goddess should I seek protection from? To which god should I make a vow?* Lying in this condition she dozed off. She saw her husband standing by the child's bed and stroking his hair. He said to her, 'Don't weep Sukhiya! Your child will recover. Go and worship *thakurji* tomorrow, he will be your support.' Sukhiya's eyes opened. Her husband had definitely been there; Sukhiya had no doubt about it. The fact that he cared for her made her heart hopeful. Her eyes brimmed with tears of faith and love. She took the child in her lap and gazing towards the sky said, 'God! May my child recover, I will worship you, have mercy on this orphaned widow.'

Jayawan's eyes opened at that very moment. He asked for water. His mother rushed to fetch him water in a small bowl and made him drink.

After drinking the water, Jayawan said, 'Mother, is it day or night?'

Sukhiya replied, 'It is night, son. How do you feel?'

'I'm well, mother. Now I've recovered.'

'God bless you, my child, I will pray to God that you get well soon. Do you feel like eating something?'

'Yes, mother, give me some jaggery.'

'Don't eat jaggery, son. It will harm you. Should I make some khichdi for you?'

'No, mother! Give me a little jaggery, I fall at your feet.'

His mother could not ignore his plea. She took out a little jaggery and placed it in Jayawan's hand. As she was closing the lid of the jar, someone

called from outside. She left the jar there and went to open the door. Jayawan took out two more lumps of jaggery and quickly ate them.

3

The whole day Jayawan was fine. He ate some khichdi, once or twice he also went to the door slowly, and in spite of being unable to play with his companions, his heart was amused seeing them play. Sukhiya thought her son had recovered. In one or two days when she had some money in hand she would go to worship thakurji. The winter day passed in sweeping, bathing, eating and drinking, but when in the evening Jayawan's health worsened, Sukhiya got worried. A suspicion arose in her heart that it was because of the delay in worship that her son had had a relapse. There was still some daytime left, so she made the child lie down and started gathering things for the puja. She got flowers from the zamindar's garden. The tulsi plant was at her doorstep. But she also needed some sweets to offer as *bhog* to thakurji. Else, what would she distribute among the villagers? She definitely needed at least an anna to offer thakurji. She scoured the entire village looking for a lender, but when she didn't get money from anywhere she grew sad. Bad days, nobody lends even four annas. At last she took off the silver bangles she was wearing and ran to the pawnbroker. She pawned them, bought sweets and ran to her house. When the things were arranged, she picked up the child in one hand, held the puja tray in the other and ran towards the temple.

The *aarti* bells were ringing in the temple. Five to ten devotees were standing and chanting hymns of praise to God. Meanwhile Sukhiya went and stood in front of the temple.

The priest asked, 'What's the matter? What are you doing here?'

Sukhiya moved closer to the platform and said, 'I had kept a vow for thakurji, Maharaj. So I have come to offer puja.'

In the daytime the priest worshipped his zamindar customers, in the morning and evening, thakurji's. He slept in the temple at night. His food was also cooked in the temple, as a consequence of which the statue of

thakurji had blackened. He was very kind-hearted, and such a devotee that no matter how cold it grew, no matter how harsh the wind blew, he didn't even drink water without bathing. In spite of this if there was a layer of dirt on his hands and feet it wasn't his fault. He said, 'So, you want to come inside? The puja is over. Will you come and defile it?'

A devotee remarked, 'She has come to purify thakurji.'

Sukhiya said helplessly, 'I have come to touch the feet of thakurji, Sir. I have brought all the things required for the puja.'

The priest said, 'How do you talk so ignorantly? Have you gone mad? How will *you* touch thakurji?'

Till now Sukhiya had never had the opportunity to come to thakurji's door. Surprised she said, 'Sir! He is lord of the world. Even the sinners get redemption after visiting him. Will he get contaminated if I touch him?'

'Aren't you a *chamarin*?'

'So hasn't God created Chamars? Is there some other God for Chamars? I have kept a vow for this child, Sir!'

The devotee who had spoken earlier and was done with the prayers remarked angrily, 'Give the witch a good thrashing. She has come to destroy our faith. Throw away her puja tray. The world is already on fire. If the tanners also start worshipping thakurji will the earth remain as it is or go into the abyss?'

Another devotee said, 'Now poor thakurji will have to eat from a tanner's hand. Now we are really approaching doomsday.'

It was cold. Sukhiya stood shivering as the contractors of religion were debating on the times. The child clung to his mother's chest for warmth but Sukhiya showed no sign of budging from there. It seemed as if both her feet had grown roots. Every now and then a deep desire to fall at thakurji's feet would arise in her heart. Is he only *their* thakurji? Doesn't he have any relationship with the poor like us? Who are these people to stop me? But she feared that these people would really throw away her puja tray, and then what would she do? So she repressed her emotions. Suddenly an idea struck her. She went and hid herself in the darkness in the shadow of a tree and waited for the devotees to depart.

4

After the aarti and prayers, the devotees read out the Bhagwat for a long time. On the other side the priest lit the fire and started cooking. He kept on saying ‘hmm, hmm’ while sitting in front of the fire, and from time to time he would make a suggestion. The reading went on till ten o’clock—Sukhiya was keeping an eye from beneath the tree.

At last the devotees started departing for their homes one by one. The priest was left alone. Sukhiya went and stood in front of the temple veranda. The priest was busy listening to melodious tunes while waiting eagerly for his food. The sound of light footsteps made the priest raise his head. He saw Sukhiya standing there. Irritated, he said, ‘Why are you still standing here?’ Placing the tray on the floor, Sukhiya pleaded most abjectly, ‘Maharajji, I am very unfortunate. This child is the sole reason for my life. Have pity on me, he hasn’t raised his head for three days. You will be highly blessed, Maharajji.’

Sukhiya started sobbing. The priest was kind-hearted. But how could he commit the grave sin of allowing a chamarin to touch thakurji. Who knew what punishment thakurji would give him for this! After all, he too had children. What if thakurji got angry and destroyed the entire village? He said, ‘Go home and chant God’s name, your child will recover. I am giving you basil leaves. Apply *charnamrita* on his eyes. God willing, everything will be all right.’

Sukhiya pleaded, ‘Won’t you let me fall at thakurji’s feet, Maharajji? I am bereaved. I have borrowed money and brought the items needed for the puja. I had a dream yesterday in which I was asked to go and worship thakurji so my child can recover. I have money, take it from me and allow me for a moment to fall at thakurji’s feet.’

This idea made the priest’s faith dwindle a bit, but being illiterate, he still had God’s fear in his heart. Gathering his wits he said, ‘O mad woman! Does thakurji see the devotion in the heart of the devotees or who is falling at his feet? Haven’t you heard the proverb—“If the mind is pure, then Ganga is close at hand.” If one does not have devotion in the heart, no

matter how many times one falls at his feet, it doesn't make any difference. I have an amulet, it is expensive but I will give it to you for only a rupee. Tie this around the child's neck, that's it. He will start playing from tomorrow.'

'So you will not let me worship thakurji?'

'This much worship is enough for you, which has never happened before. Suppose I perform the puja and some calamity falls on the village? Why don't you think about that? Take this prayer with you. God willing, the child will get relief from his pain tonight. Somebody has cast a spell on him. And little wonder, he is very lively and draws people's attention.'

'My life has been caught in a whirlpool since the day he fell ill.'

'He is a very talented boy, may God keep him alive. He will take away all your pain and suffering. He used to come here a lot to play. For the past two three days I have not been seeing him.'

'So how do I tie the amulet, Maharaj?'

'I am tying it in cloth and giving it to you, just tie it around his neck. At this hour where will you go looking for new cloth?'

Sukhiya had received two rupees for her silver bangles. One was already spent. She gave the second to the priest and taking the amulet returned home, consoling her heart.

5

The moment she reached home Sukhiya tied the amulet around the child's neck. But as the night grew, the child's fever increased. By three o'clock his hands and feet started getting cold. Worried, she started thinking, *Oh! I was so stupid and selfish for not having fallen at thakurji's feet and returning home. If I had entered the temple and fallen at God's feet, what could anyone have done? They would have pushed me out of the temple—only that would have happened. Maybe they would have beaten me but my mission would have been accomplished. If I could have washed the feet of thakurji with my tears and placed the boy at his feet, wouldn't he have taken mercy on me? He is a merciful God, fulfils the wishes of orphans, wouldn't*

he have mercy on me? Sukhiya's heart grew restless. She must not delay. She would definitely go and fall at thakurji's feet and cry. The helpless woman's scared heart could see no other way. If the temple gates were closed she would break the lock. *Has thakurji been sold to someone that he needs to be locked?*

It was three o'clock at night. Sukhiya wrapped the child in a blanket and took him in her arms, and holding the tray in one hand walked towards the temple. The moment she stepped out of the house, the wave of chilly winds made her chest shiver. Her feet were growing numb from the cold. On top of that it was dark all around. The distance was no less than two furlongs. The path winded through the trees. At some distance, on the left, there was a pond. There was a bamboo hut nearby which was owned by a washerman who had died, and now it was a den for witches. On the left, there were lush green fields. There was silence all around, the darkness was gasping. Occasionally, jackals would howl, making a terrifying sound. Oh! Even if someone had offered her lakhs of rupees she wouldn't have come to this place. But motherly affection had overtaken all the fear of danger. 'O God! You are my sole hope.' Chanting this she walked towards the temple.

When she reached the temple door, she tried to figure out the lock, but it was chained shut. The priest was sleeping in the room adjacent to the veranda. There was darkness everywhere. Sukhiya picked up a brick beneath the platform and started hitting the lock hard. Her hands were filled with a strange power. After two or three attempts both the lock and the brick broke and fell on the floor. She was about to open the door and enter when the priest woke up, opened the door, came out and started shouting, 'Thief! Thief!' and then ran towards the village. In the winter, people woke up before dawn. When they heard the commotion many men came out from here and there with lanterns and asked, 'Where's the thief? Which way did he go?'

The priest said, 'The temple door is open. I heard some commotion.'

All of a sudden Sukhiya came out of the veranda to the platform and said, 'There is no thief, it's me, I had come to worship thakurji. I haven't yet entered and you people have already raised a ruckus.'

The priest howled, ‘What a calamity! Sukhiya has entered the temple and rendered thakurji impure!’

As expected, many agitated men leapt at Sukhiya and started kicking and boxing her. Sukhiya was holding the child with one hand and protecting him with the other. Suddenly a strong Thakur pushed her hard and the child fell from her hands but he neither cried nor said anything. The child wasn’t breathing and Sukhiya had fallen on the ground. When she gathered herself and picked up the child, her eyes fell on his face. It appeared as if it was a reflection in the water. She let out a shriek. She touched the forehead of her child and saw that his entire body was cold. She drew a long breath and stood up. There were no tears in her eyes, her face was blazing with anger, sparks rained from her eyes, both her hands were clenched into fists. She clenched her teeth and said, ‘Sinners, why are you standing away after taking my child’s life? Why don’t you kill me too? On my touch thakurji will become untouchable. On coming into contact with a touchstone iron turns to gold; the touchstone doesn’t turn into iron. Didn’t thakurji become impure while making me? So, I will never touch thakurji now. Keep him locked safe, set up guards. Oh! You merciless people! You are so hard-hearted! In spite of having children you didn’t have mercy on this unfortunate mother; on top of it, you have become the contractors of religion. All of you are murderers! The perfect murderers! Don’t be afraid. I won’t go to the police station; my justice will be done by God. Now I will plea in His court.’

Nobody uttered a word, nobody stirred. All of them stood with their heads bowed low, like statues made of stone.

The entire village gathered at the scene. Sukhiya looked at the child once again, and a cry escaped her mouth, ‘Oh! My darling!’ Then she fainted and fell on the ground, and her soul left her body. The mother had sacrificed her life for the child.

Mother, you are blessed. The devotion you have, the loyalty you possess, is difficult to find even among the gods.

Translated from the Urdu by Shaheen Saba



The Borrowed Watch

1

I haven't been able to figure out till today why people go to their in-laws' with such pomp and show. What's the purpose of this, after all? Whether we are millionaires or paupers, what difference does it make now that we've already been married? Yes, it might help before marriage. Our prosperity can be quite helpful in confirming the deal. But when one has been married and the wife is privy to all the secrets of the house even as she must've most undoubtedly wept and narrated her story of misfortune to her parents, then all this fake splendour can only be detrimental to us instead of being profitable. Seeing us in dire straits, it's likely that our mothers-in-law may take pity on us and we may get a reasonable amount on the pretext of our farewell. But all this show will certainly give them the impression that our stars are favourably disposed towards us and that we've obtained a fortune fraudulently. On the other hand, the barber and the water-drawer will press for rewards, which is another reason for a headache. The wife may have doubts too. But in spite of knowing and understanding all of this, I went to my in-laws' last year for Holi, with elaborate preparations. I had never worn a silk jacket in my life and had only dreamt about flax boots. This dream would've remained a dream had it been a question of paying the money up front. But I managed to borrow both these things, thanks to a

friend's generosity. Another friend of mine lent me his suitcase. The mat was torn. I could have borrowed a new mat too but I didn't feel the need to carry one. Now only a wristwatch was lacking. Although many of my friends had watches of their own—there must be very few unfortunate ones save me who don't have one—I wanted a golden watch and only Daanu had it. But I was not on great terms with him. Daanu was of a surly disposition. Both lending and borrowing things for free were a sin in his eyes. He can follow this principle since God has ordained so. But how can I? My heart couldn't resist it even though I knew that he would flatly refuse. I've accomplished great deeds in my life through my ability of fawning over others, which also explains my monthly salary of thirty rupees. There were no less than a thousand graduate applicants. But all of them could only stare in disbelief while I haughtily walked away with the job. How difficult a task could borrowing a watch for two to four days be, when I could prevail in such a situation?

I started preparing for my visit in the evening. Next morning I went to Daanu's place and found his younger son playing in the inner courtyard in front of the sitting room. I took him in my lap and played with him, holding him tightly. When he saw me, Daanu knitted his brow at first but my affection for the child mollified him somewhat. He smiled and said, 'Let the wicked one play on his own—your shirt is being spoilt. As for me, well, I don't even touch him.'

Feigning an expression of disdain, I replied, 'Why do you worry when it's my shirt that's being made dirty? My goodness! Such a delicate child and that's how you treat him! God pointlessly blesses people like you with kids. Give him to me if he's a burden to you'.

And then I hoisted the child on my shoulders and went jumping about in the courtyard for around fifteen minutes. He laughed and laughed and wouldn't let me rest. Daanu finally brought him down from my shoulders, put him on the ground and then said, 'Didn't even care for a betel leaf and instead took a free ride. Go and tell your mother to prepare paan for us.'

The child became restive. To pacify him, I pretended to slap Daanu a couple of times. I then seized the wrist on which he was sporting his watch

and said to the child, ‘Go ahead. Take it, son. Take away his wristwatch because he beats you so often. (To Daanu) It’s unfair that you have a wristwatch while our darling one here doesn’t have one.’

I quietly unfastened the watch and put it on the child’s wrist. Then I took him in my lap and said to him, ‘Brother, lend me your watch.’

But he was a real chip off the old block. The child hid his watch with the other hand and said, ‘No! I won’t give it to you!’

But eventually I coaxed the watch out of him and fastened it on my wrist. The child left for the paan. Praising the singular merits of his watch, Daanu Babu said, ‘Till date at least I haven’t come across any watch that can tell time as accurately as this one.’

I seconded him, ‘After all, it’s a Swiss watch!’

Daanu retorted, ‘So what if it’s a Swiss watch? I have seen too many of them and each one has its own set of imperfections. Whenever you look at them, you find them at the mechanic’s. What is needed is the ability to recognize their true worth and this is no easy task. Many people think that an exorbitant price guarantees a good watch. To them, I can only say that they are fools. With a good price, even God can’t be bargained for. Knowledge is a must—both for Him as well as for a good watch. You must know Faust Sahib. I’m always on the lookout for such people. One day he came here. He is an alcoholic and was short of money. I bought this watch for twenty-five rupees. It’s been three years now and it still hasn’t malfunctioned by even a minute. Some say it’s worth one hundred rupees, some two hundred. There are also some who rate it at three hundred and fifty rupees while others at four hundred and seventy-five rupees. But I only tell them that they are fools, since such a watch cannot be worth less than a thousand rupees. Throw it on the floor and you won’t even find a scratch on it!’

I said, ‘In that case, lend it to me for a day, my friend. And don’t charge me for it. I’m going out of town. I’ll sing its praises to others too.’

Daanu quipped, ‘You know only too well that I don’t lend things for free. If I start telling you the reason for this, it’ll be like narrating the tales from *One Thousand and One Nights*. The long and short of it is that lending

things for free is like putting an end to friendship. It leaves no further room for consideration and is nothing but asking for trouble. I'll tell you about an incident or two since you seem quite interested. You do have the time, don't you? Indeed, the office is closed today, so listen. A friend of mine once borrowed my lanterns for free. When he returned them, the chimneys were all broken. I inquired about it and he said, "I'm returning them in the same condition that I took them. You never said that you'll be asking for new ones in their place. *Wah* Sahib! Wah! You've turned this into quite a business." Tell me, what could I do? Another gentleman borrowed my carpet. He brought a torn mat in its place. When I asked him, he said, "You at least have this mat, Sahib. Whom should I narrate my tales of woe to? Five of my carpets have been unaccounted for. Some friend of mine took them all." Tell me, what could I have possibly told him? Since then, I swore to myself that I won't be generous to anyone any more. The entire city calls me mean, skinflinty and God knows what! But I don't bat an eyelid! Nevertheless, since you're going out of town and consequently will be meeting a lot of people on your way, it's possible that you may find a valuable customer for this watch. So I won't be too harsh on you, though I admit that I want to sell it and hence expect support from you in this regard. Tell me if anyone will be interested in purchasing it.'

I was exulting in pride when I fastened the watch on my wrist and took Daanu's leave. Getting the watch did not make me as happy as the fact that I had hoodwinked a penny-pincher. How nicely I have tricked the innocent one! He thinks himself to be quite clever but little does he know that today he has met his equal.

2

The same day, I reached my in-laws'. It now became clear to me why people go to their in-laws' with such ceremony. A commotion broke out in the entire household. No one bothered about me. They were busy admiring my outfit. The Kahar ran to fetch water. One of my brothers-in-law brought a plate full of sweets while another one served the paan. The barber's wife

took a peek and left. There was such pride in my father-in-law's eyes it seemed like he thought that the entire world should bow before him for making such a good choice for his daughter. For someone who humbly earns only thirty rupees per month, I sat there pompously, like a head clerk in the office. The Kahar waved the fan and the barber's wife washed my feet. One of my brothers-in-law spread the sheet while the other one stood there with a dhoti in his hand, waiting for me to change. All this was a result of that show.

At night, my wife inquired, 'Have you spent all the money or is there anything still left?'

My romantic mood took a beating. No conversation regarding my health, well-being or even love! The only cry being—Alas! My money! Alas! My money! I felt like leaving the place that very instant but somehow restrained myself, saying, 'I think you know quite well about my earnings.'

'How should I know about it? You earn for yourself. What do you do for me? It would've been better if God had made you a woman. You would've combed and braided your hair all day long. You are a man for no reason. How can you worry about others when you are far too busy with your own adornments and desires?'

I flared up and said, 'Do you really want me to leave this place right now?'

Deviji too scowled and said, 'Why don't you do that already? It isn't as if I sent for you. Or have you brought some money for me?'

I asked anxiously, 'So is money everything in your eyes? Is love totally inconsequential?'

Deviji knitted her brow and said, 'You might love yourself, but you surely don't love me.'

'You never had this complaint before.'

'At least you now know that I don't care about money. But what I've observed is that as your circumstances are improving, you too have changed proportionately. It would've been better had there been no improvement at all. I can starve with you, spend my days wearing rags and tatters. But I

can't bear to see you enjoying yourself while I sit here in my parents' house, crying over my misfortune. I am not so tolerant in my love.'

I had been overwhelmed by my own importance when my brothers-in-law and the servants received me so grandly. But now that I was being treated indifferently here, I regretted my decision. If I had worn ordinary clothes and put on a tearful face, others might have been disrespectful to me but at least my wife would've been happy. However, it was too late now. I sympathized with my wife when I reflected on what she had said. Had I been a woman and she a man, would I have tolerated her jauntiness while I remained locked in my cage, longing for food and water? I should've told her the secret behind my modishness but my self-esteem couldn't allow this at all. Playing the part of a dandy was completely inappropriate but to reveal the secret behind it would've been a terrible sin. Finally I decided to resort to the same flattery that has helped me out on similarly difficult occasions. I said with pleasure and affection, 'Dear! I'm telling the truth. My circumstances are the same as they were before. But the desire to meet you grew so strong that I had to borrow clothes. I haven't bought any of it. I hesitated wearing tattered clothes because I didn't want you or your family members to feel bad about my condition. Our circumstances are what they are. It's more shameful to announce them publicly.'

Deviji remained silent for a while and then said, 'So you borrowed it?'

'Where was I to get the cash from?'

'And you've borrowed the watch too?'

'Yes. I took it from an acquaintance's shop.'

'How much is it worth?'

If someone else asked me the same question outside, I would not have quoted its price at anything less than five hundred rupees. But here I said that it was twenty-five rupees.

'In that case, you got it quite cheaply.'

'Why else would I have gone for it?'

'Give it to me when you leave.'

I felt paralysed. All my limbs became motionless. It was a catch-22 situation since I could neither refuse nor comply. I had been unable to

contain my joy when I had got the watch in the morning. But presently it looked like a spotted snake that had coiled itself up. I said, 'I'll purchase a better watch for you.'

'Oh no! Give me a break. You can buy it for yourself. I like this one very much. I'll always sport it on my wrist. It'll remind me of you whenever I look at it. Look, you haven't even given me a broken cowrie till today. If you refuse now, I won't ask for anything else.'

I shouldn't have feared any particular losses on account of my wife's demands. Rather I should've welcomed it since she usually doesn't have too many of them. But I don't know why I was so afraid. I began thinking of a solution which would neither be disagreeable to her nor would force me to forfeit the watch. I said, 'This watch is worth nothing, dear! I can sacrifice my life for you. Here, let me tie it on your wrist. But the fact is that sometimes I get late for office because of my incorrect estimates of time, which results in me being scolded unnecessarily. The watch is yours but let me keep it until I purchase another one. I'll soon buy an inexpensive watch for myself and will return this to you. I hope you won't have any objections to this arrangement.'

My wife fastened the watch on her wrist and said, 'God knows, you are quite a trickster. You get your job done through puffery. Don't expect me to rise to the bait so easily. Buy a new watch soon, once you leave from here. Till then, you can leave early for the office.'

I didn't have the courage to say anything more. I became anxious beyond measure the moment that watch left my wrist. I stayed for two days at my in-laws' but was sad and distressed. *What will I tell Daanu Babu?* Like some hidden anguish, this question kept wrenching my heart.

3

When I reached home and said to Daanu Babu with tearful eyes, 'I've lost the watch somewhere,' he expressed neither regret nor sympathy. Rather he replied cruelly, 'That's precisely why I didn't want to give you the watch in the first place. My doubts have come true after all. That watch had been

with me for three years but I didn't misplace it once. And you've lost it in three days. Where did you go after all?'

I had been afraid that Daanu Babu would scold me endlessly. Seeing his forgiving disposition, I was somewhat comforted. I said, 'I just went to my in-laws'.'

'So did you bring *bhabhi* home with you?'

'Sure, I would've brought her home with me! How could I when I'm unable to fend for myself?'

'What do you do with all the money that you earn?'

'All the money that I earn? Oh, please! I'm just a hired servant for thirty rupees a month.'

'So do you spend the entire amount?'

'Is this amount too much for me?'

'You have no right to spend everything on yourself when your income is only thirty rupees. Your wife cannot stay at her parents' house forever.'

'I'm helpless till I don't get a promotion. On what basis should I call her?'

'And what if you don't get a promotion for another three to four years?'

'Then it'll be God's will. There is no hope before that.'

'Splendid! You deserve a pat on your back. What don't you work extra hours? What is it that you do in the morning?'

'My entire time is spent in washing and bathing, eating and drinking. And then one also has to meet one's friends.'

'In that case, your situation has no remedy, brother. I can't sympathize even one bit with people like you. You know what? My watch was worth five hundred rupees and you'll have to pay the entire amount. Every month you can save fifteen rupees of your salary for yourself and give me the rest. When the entire amount is paid within two and a half years, then you can meet your friends as you like. Do you understand? I've already given you a waiver of fifty rupees and cannot be any more lenient than this.'

'How will I make do with fifteen rupees?'

'People manage with five rupees, they also make do with five hundred. So, don't give me that, I know what you are capable of.'

Daanu Babu's harsh words convinced me that it was pointless crying before him. He would not settle for anything less than the entire amount. The watch was worth two hundred rupees at best. But how does it matter? He had told me its price beforehand. How then can I have the audacity to be unsparingly critical on this matter? Cursing my stars, I returned home. So much for the perks of a married life! How happy I had been then—as if all the four goals of life had been accomplished. Now how I'm suffering! Serves me right for desiring such a watch! An empty wrist wouldn't have caused a loss of prestige. But when did I ever listen to anyone? How will I manage with fifteen rupees when I couldn't make ends meet with thirty?

Immersed in these thoughts, I fell asleep. I didn't even feel the need to eat!

4

This is how I used to make do with thirty rupees—twenty for the hotel, five for my meals and the remaining five for paan, cigarettes, clothes, shoes and everything else! How can I underspend when I don't have a fancy lifestyle or wasteful expenditures? But Daanu Babu's debt had to be paid all the same, whether I liked it or not. For a moment, I decided going back to my in-laws' for the watch. But I had told Daanu Babu that I had lost it. Now if I would return his watch, he would take me for a liar of the first order. But couldn't I say that I thought I had lost the watch but I found it again when I went back to my in-laws'? My wife had stolen it. Indeed, this was a good plan. But what excuses could I come up with, before Deviji? How sad would she be? She had looked so happy wearing that watch. If I snatched away the watch from her, it's quite possible that she may never see my face again. Yes, I could go to Daanu Babu and cry before him. In spite of the harsh words that he had uttered today, I was sure that his anger would subside within a couple of days or so. He would definitely feel pity for me once I start crying before him. Childhood friends cannot be easily forgotten. But I had never been so devoid of self-respect, nor could I ever be.

I moved to an inexpensive hotel the very next day. Here the rent was only twelve rupees. In the morning, I used to have milk and tea for breakfast. But now I survived on a few grams. I saved twelve rupees in this manner. I further reduced my expenses on paan and cigarettes by three rupees. And in a month I was neatly saving fifteen rupees. This was an unfriendly penance. It wasn't just a merciless repression of the senses, it was a complete *sanyas*. But when I gave the first fifteen rupees to Daanu Babu, I felt as though my head was held high with pride. I had never felt this joy before in my life.

Daanu Babu kindly said, 'You saved it or did you borrow from someone?'

'I saved it, Bhai. Who could I borrow it from?'

'Was it difficult?'

'Not in the least. Even if it was, this moment makes up for it.'

'But you are still free in the morning, aren't you? Why don't you consider earning even more than this?'

'I do, but I'm unable to find any extra work for myself.'

On my way back, I experienced a strange vigour and a newfound strength in my heart. I no longer bothered about the desires that I had difficulty curbing till now. That paan shop, the sight of which would make me restless, had no effect on me now as I walked before it with my head held high, as if it was something beneath me. Tea, cigarettes and *chaat*—none of them attracted me any more. I would have sprouted grams in the morning while roti and dal would be enough for the two meals of my day. Barring this, everything else was dispensable for me. But the most important thing was that I took a special liking for life itself. I was not interested in becoming disillusioned with life or being an easy prey to the jaws of death. I felt as if I could do something purposeful in my life.

One day, a friend of mine insisted on me having a paan but I refused. He then said, 'It's wonderful that you've stopped chewing paan. I could never even imagine you quitting this habit. Tell me the secret to it.'

'The secret is simply not to chew paan.'

'But I really can't help it.'

'Oh, you can.'

‘A no-smoking phase causes my belly to swell.’

‘So be it. It’ll return to normal on its own.’

‘All right then, from now on I too won’t smoke or chew paan.’

‘You can’t. How can you?’

I had expressed this doubt to challenge him further which only played out as I had desired. He said resolutely, ‘If you can quit, then even I can. I’m not any less competent than you are in any field.’

‘Good for you then. I’ll wait and see.’

‘You will.’

To this day, I haven’t seen him smoking or chewing paan again.

In the fifth month, when I went to Daanu Babu with the usual amount, he turned emotional, hugged me and said, ‘You are a man of your word, yaar. But tell me the truth, you don’t curse me, do you?’

I smiled and said, ‘I used to, but now I don’t.’

‘And pray why show this favour of late?’

‘Because you really taught me how to cut my coat according to my cloth. My wife deserves half of my income. But I used to usurp her share too. Now I’m beginning to be able to give her her share or to keep her with me. You taught me a wonderful lesson.’

‘If your income were to increase a bit, then would you again start living the way you used to?’

‘No, definitely not. I’ll bring my wife to my place.’

‘Fair enough! Be happy now, now that you’ve been promoted.’

I replied disbelievingly, ‘How can I be promoted right now when my seniors are already standing in the queue before me?’

‘Believe me. The head clerk of your office himself told me this.’

I still didn’t believe him. But I was getting butterflies in my stomach out of curiosity. Daanu Babu headed towards his home while I went to the head clerk’s house. The head clerk was milking his goat. Seeing me, he said, somewhat embarrassed, ‘What to do, Bhai, the milkman didn’t turn up today so I had to do this myself. Come, sit.’

I sat in the room. Babuji too came about half an hour later with a small hookah in his hand and started talking desultorily. At last I couldn’t resist

the temptation and said, ‘I’ve heard that I have been promoted.’

The head clerk said with a happy face, ‘Indeed, Bhai, you have been. Daanu Babu must’ve told you this, right?’

‘Yes, indeed. He told me just now. But how did this happen when my promotion wasn’t even in the pipeline?’

‘Don’t ask me about it. All you need are favours from officers. Who cares about numbers-*shumber*s?’

‘But what post have I got considering that there are no vacancies right now?’

‘Brother, didn’t I just tell you that officers can do everything? Sahib wants to pay you an extra fifteen rupees on account of some other pretext altogether. Daanu Babu probably must have had a word with him about this.’

‘Is someone being deprived of his share for this amount that is being given to me?’

‘No, that’s not true. I wouldn’t have allowed it.’

A month passed and I received a salary of forty-five rupees. But in the register, only thirty rupees were written before my name. The head clerk called me, gave me the amount in private and cautioned me not to spill the beans regarding this lest it threw the entire office into turmoil. He said that it was the sahib’s orders not to let the cat out of the bag.

I was satisfied that none of my colleagues had been deprived of his share for this extra amount. Feeling quite pleased with myself, I went straight to Daanu Babu’s house with the money in my hand. Seeing me delighted, he asked me, ‘So you finally got your promotion, didn’t you?’

‘Yes, yaar. I received an extra fifteen rupees but I haven’t been promoted. This amount has been given to me on some other pretext.’

‘You should only eat the mangoes and not count the stones. So now will you go and get your wife here?’

‘No, not yet.’

‘But you said that you will bring her to your place once there is a hike in your salary. What has happened now?’

‘I’m thinking of clearing all your debts first. I’ll give you thirty rupees every month from now on so that I can pay the entire amount within a year. Then I shall be free.’

Danu Babu’s eyes welled up. That’s when I came to know that under his stern exterior there was a tender-hearted person. He said, ‘No, don’t give me anything this time around. How will you pay for the railway fare? Go and get your wife home.’

I was in a fix. I replied, ‘Yaar, please don’t do this. What if I am unable to pay your instalment later?’

Daanu Babu seized my hands and said, ‘It doesn’t matter. The fact of the matter is that I’ve already been paid for my watch. I had only purchased it for twenty-five rupees. On top of that, I had used it for three years. I shouldn’t have taken anything from you and I’m ashamed of what I did.’

My eyes too welled up. I felt like revealing the truth about the watch but eventually restrained myself. I said falteringly, ‘No, Daanu Babu, let me clear my debts. After all, wouldn’t you have sold that watch for four hundred or five hundred rupees? Why should you suffer such a huge loss on my account?’

‘Bhai, let’s not talk about the watch any more. Tell me, when will you leave?’

‘Arré, but let me think of my accommodation first.’

‘I’ll take care of it. You can leave.’

‘But I won’t be able to afford a rent of more than five rupees. You can find rooms at reasonable rates in areas slightly removed from the city.’

‘Very well, then. I shall arrange everything. By which train will you return?’

‘How can I tell you this right now? It’s a matter of the bride’s farewell. The auspicious hour may or may not be near or they might force me to stay there for a day or two. Why should you get involved in this trouble? I can find an accommodation within two to four days and then be on my way.’

‘Oh no, leave today and come tomorrow.’

‘So where will I deboard?’

‘I’ll arrange an accommodation for you. You’ll meet my man at the station.’

I tried every trick that I could but that gentleman wouldn’t listen to any of it. That same day, I had to leave for my in-laws’.

5

I had to stay at my in-laws’ for three days. On the fourth morning I left with my wife. Deep down, I was worried. If Daanu did not send anyone, where would we go? It was the fourth day now. Why would he send his man to the station again and again? While boarding the train, I felt like sending a telegram to Daanu, informing him about our arrival. But I hesitated because it would have cost me twelve annas.

But when the train reached Banaras, I saw Daanu Babu himself. He was sporting a hat and standing there with two coolies. As soon as he saw me, he rushed towards me and said, ‘Were the chapatis at your in-laws’ too tasty? I’ve been coming here for three days. You’ll have to compensate for it.’

Deviji had stepped down from the train and was standing on the platform, all wrapped up in a shawl. I quickly wanted to jump inside a tonga and leave the place. The watch was fastened on her wrist. I was afraid because if she stuck her hand out and Daanu saw the watch on her wrist, then it would be quite embarrassing. But who can prevent what is destined to happen? I had already sung high praises of Daanu Babu’s goodness to my wife. Now that he came close to her and started helping with the boxes, Deviji greeted him. Daanu saw the watch on her wrist. What could he have said at that moment? But as soon as Deviji left in a tonga and we took another one, Daanu Babu smiled and asked, ‘Did Deviji hide the watch?’

I replied shamefacedly, ‘No, yaar. I myself had given it to her. Actually, I didn’t give it to her; rather she snatched it away from me.’

Daanu said reproachfully, ‘Then why on earth did you lie to me?’

‘What else could I have done then?’

‘If you had told me this clearly, I would not have been such a scoundrel and demanded the compensation amount for it. But anyway, none of God’s deeds is without advice or counsel. You needed such a penance for a few days.’

‘Where have you made arrangements for our accommodation?’

‘We are headed exactly that way.’

‘Is it close to your place? That would be real fun then.’

‘Yes, it’s adjacent to my house but it’s inexpensive.’

Both the tongas stopped at Daanu Babu’s house. Some servants came running and started unloading the luggage. Daanu Babu’s wife too came out in a moment and took Deviji inside. It appeared as though all of this had been planned in advance.

I said, ‘Then why don’t you say that we are your uninvited guests?’

‘You can find an accommodation of your liking now. But stay here for five to ten days.’

But I didn’t quite like this unwarranted hospitality. I found an accommodation for myself within three days of my arrival. While leaving, Daanu Babu put one hundred rupees before me and said, ‘This is your money. Take it with you.’

I asked in astonishment, ‘How can this be?’

Daanu answered, ‘In half a year, you gave me ninety rupees at the rate of fifteen per month, while the remaining ten is your interest.’

Daanu Babu’s kindness felt like a burden to me. I said, ‘So you want your watch back, don’t you?’

‘Why do you have to mention the watch again? Don’t talk about it.’

‘You want to outdo me.’

‘Yes, I do. I want to make a man out of you; otherwise you would have forever relied on the hotels for your meals while your wife cried your name in her parents’ house. How is that for a lesson? You won’t consider this a favour, will you?’

‘So why don’t you simply say that you have been my guru all this while?’

‘That’s right. You really needed a guru like me.’

I couldn't help but mention the watch again. I said, somewhat apprehensively, 'So brother, what about the watch—'

'What's wrong with you? Why do you have to mention the watch again?'

'You are forcing me to do it!'

'Consider it a gift for my sister-in-law.'

'And is this amount a gift for me?'

'Yes, indeed. This is your reward for passing the test.'

'That's two gifts then, isn't it?'

'What can I do when you are an Alexander in fortune?'

I was reluctant to take the amount but Daanu forced it into my pocket. I had no choice but to accept it. I deposited it in my savings bank account. I had rented my accommodation for ten rupees per month. My monthly expenses were now thirty rupees and so I could save five per month. I now realized that if Daanu Babu hadn't made me do this penance for six months, I really would have left my wife at her parents' house for God knows how many days. It was only due to the blessings of such a penance that I was living comfortably and could save something or the other above all of it. But I never told my wife about the story behind that watch. In the fifth month, it was my turn for promotion. I got the promotion letter and wondered whether I'd get an additional fifteen rupees this time as well or not. I got my salary on the first day of the month and it was still forty-five rupees. I stood there for a while hoping that the head clerk might give me another fifteen rupees. When the others left after collecting their salaries, the head clerk said, 'Are you still wrapped up in greed? You won't get anything more now.'

I replied, shamefaced, 'Oh no, I'm not standing here with this expectation. Is it not enough that Sahib has looked after us for so long? But at least tell me—on what pretext was I being given that extra amount?'

The head clerk said, 'What will you gain out of it?'

'Oh nothing, I just wanted to know.'

'Go and ask Daanu Babu.'

'What does Daanu Babu know about the circumstances of the office?'

'No, only he knows the story behind it.'

I took a tonga and went to Daanu Babu's house. Today I had hired a tonga after a total of ten months. I was dying of curiosity about the secret behind those extra fifteen rupees. I had decided that if that crafty one had laid this plot, then I'd settle his hash. He was taking a stroll in the garden. He became anxious when he saw me and said, 'Is everything all right? Where are you coming from?'

Feigning displeasure, I said, 'Yes everything is all right but you better watch out.'

'Why, brother, what is my offence?'

'Tell me the story behind the extra fifteen rupees that I received for five months.'

'Didn't you ask the head clerk about it? How should I know about the goings-on of your office?'

I had become quite friendly with Daanu these days. I said, 'Look, Daanu, it won't be good for you if try to pull a fast one on me. Why do you want to be beaten by me unnecessarily?'

'Beat me, Bhai, if that's what you want. You've done that on quite a few occasions so it won't hurt if you do it once more. Remember when you pushed me down from the upper porch? See, the mark is still there.'

'I'm dying of curiosity while you make light of my questions. Tell me the truth. What's the story behind those extra fifteen rupees?'

'There is no story-*shory*. I knew that thirty rupees would not be enough for you to get by, no matter how much you economized. If nothing else, there should at least be two square meals. This is the only story behind your extra fifteen rupees. You can punish me for this in any way you like.'

Translated from the Hindi by Shailendra Kumar Singh



Babaji's Feast

There was a sadhu at Ramdhan Ahir's door.

'Son, may God bless you; have some regard for the sadhus.'

Ramdhan went inside and told his wife: 'There's a sadhu at the door. Let's give him something.'

His wife was washing the dishes, preoccupied with how to manage dinner. There was not a single grain in the house. Though it was the month of Chait, darkness seemed to have overtaken everything at noon—the harvests had disappeared from the granary. The moneylender took half the share, the other half was grabbed by the landlord's agent; the earnings from selling the husk were used to pay off the ox merchant. Only a few sieves were left for her family; when threshed, it came to a mere forty kilograms of grains.

Somehow the month of Chait passed. What would happen next . . . what would the bullocks eat? What would the people in the house eat? Only God knows! But there is a sadhu at the door. *How can we disappoint him? How will he feel?*

The wife said, 'What shall I offer him? There is hardly anything left in the house.'

'Take a look at the pot. There may be some grain or flour lying at the bottom.'

‘I cleaned out the pot yesterday to cook the meal. There is absolutely nothing left.’

‘I can’t bring myself to tell him that there is nothing in the house. Go and borrow something from the neighbour.’

‘We haven’t been able to return what we borrowed earlier. How can I ask for more?’

‘You had set aside offerings for the gods; why don’t you get that?’

‘How will we worship the gods, then?’

‘The gods don’t come asking for it. If possible, give the offerings; otherwise don’t.’

‘You think the offerings are in maunds? At most it will be a handful. Won’t other sadhus come after this? One has to say “no” sometime!’

‘At least we can meet *this* crisis; we’ll see what happens in the future.’

Infuriated, the wife got up and lifted an earthen pot in which there was hardly half a kilogram of flour. That bit of wheat flour had been saved very carefully for the gods. Ramdhan stood thinking for a while; then, he put the flour in a bowl and poured it into the bag of the sadhu.

Taking the flour the good fellow said, ‘Child, this sadhu will stay here today. If you give me some lentils I will cook my meal.’

Ramdhan returned and told his wife about the sadhu’s demand. Incidentally, there were lentils in the house. Ramdhan gave him the lentils and some salt, supplied dried cow dung for the fire and got water from the well. The sadhu prepared his rotis, cooked the lentils, took a potato out of his bag and made mashed potato. When everything was ready he asked Ramdhan, ‘Child, a spoonful of ghee is required as an offering to God; if the food is not sacred how can it be offered?’

Ramdhan said, ‘Babaji, I wonder if we have ghee in the house.’

‘Son, God has blessed you with so much. Don’t say such things.’

‘My Lord, I don’t have a cow or a buffalo. Where shall I get ghee from?’

‘Son, God gives plenty. Just go and ask the mistress of the house.’

Ramdhan went and told his wife, ‘He’s asking for ghee; he came begging but he cannot eat his food without ghee!’

The wife said, ‘Then take some lentils to the shopkeeper and get some ghee for him; when you have done so much why are you grudging this?’

The ghee came. The good fellow took out a small altar for the god, tinkled the bell and helped himself to the offering. He ate his fill and, stroking his belly, lay down near the threshold. Ramdhan picked up the cup, the plate and the ladle for washing.

There was no proper dinner in Ramdhan’s house that night; they only had lentils and ate that.

As he lay on his bed Ramdhan thought, *Even these fellows are better off than me!*

Translated from the Hindi by Saroj Kumar Mahananda



The Actress

1

The curtain fell. Tara Devi had mesmerized the audience by playing the role of Shakuntala. As she delivered that fiery speech expressing pain, remorse and rejection in front of Dushyant, the audience went wild. They forgot all sense of restraint and ran towards the stage. Some even climbed up on the stage and fell at her feet. The whole stage was showered with flowers and gifts. Had Menka's helicopter not swooped to pick her up, the stampede would certainly have killed at least a dozen people. The manager quickly took the stage and thanked the audience for their appreciation. He promised that the play would be repeated the next day. It quietened the excited audience. However, there was a young man still standing on the stage. Tall, fair, handsome, with a powerful face and a well-built body—he looked like a prince.

After the others had left, he asked the manager, 'May I see Tara Devi for a while?'

The manager replied indifferently, 'It's against our rules.'

The young man asked again, 'Can you please take my letter to her?'

The manager replied with same indifference, 'No, Sir. Excuse us, this is against our rules.'

The young man didn't say a word. Disappointed, he was about to get off the stage when the manager asked, 'Wait a minute, do you have a card?'

The young man took a piece of paper out of his pocket, scribbled something on it and gave it to the manager. The manager had a quick look at it—Kunwar Nirmal Kant Chaudhuri, OBE. The stern demeanour of the manager softened at once. Kunwar Nirmal Kant—the richest landlord in town, a gem of literature, a great teacher of music, an eminent scholar, with an annual income of about rupees eight to ten lakh, whose generosity helped run many institutions in the country—was standing there like a humble supplicant. The manager felt ashamed of his indifferent attitude. He said politely, 'Forgive me, Sir, for my blunder. I will give your card to Tara Devi immediately.'

Kunwar Sahib gestured to him to stop and said, 'No, forget it. I will come at five o'clock tomorrow. I won't trouble her now. She must be resting.'

'I am sure she won't mind. I'll get back in a minute,' said the manager.

But after having revealed his identity Kunwar Sahib had no choice but to control his desire. He thanked the manager for his courtesy and promised to come the next day.

2

Tara was sitting at the table in a clean and well-furnished room lost in thought. Last night's scene danced in her mind's eye. Does such a day come often in life? How many men were dying for one look of hers! They were all climbing over each other. How many of them she had spurned! Yes, spurned! But in that crowd there was one person who had stood unfazed. There was so much love in his eyes, so much determination! It seemed as if his eyes would pierce her heart. Who knew whether she would be able to see him today or not! But if she did, she wouldn't let him go without speaking.

She gazed at the mirror. She looked like a brilliant lotus. Who could say that this flower had witnessed thirty-five springs? Her beauty, tenderness, agility and charm could put any young maiden to shame. Tara kindled the

spark of love in her heart once again. Twenty years ago she had had a bitter experience of love. Since then she had been leading the life of a widow. Many lovers had wanted to surrender their hearts to her but she had not encouraged anyone. She would smell hypocrisy in their love. But what a pity! Today, restraint gave way! Once again she felt that soft stirring in her heart, which she had experienced twenty years ago. The charming face of a man was preserved in her eyes, deeply engraved in her heart. She could not forget him. Had she seen him passing in a motorcar she wouldn't have bothered about him. But when she saw him with those gifts of love for her, she hadn't been able to control herself.

Suddenly, her maid came and said, 'All the gifts from last night have been kept safe; shall I bring them here?'

Tara said, 'No, there is no need to bring them . . . wait . . . what are they?'

'My lady, there is a whole bunch of them. How many shall I mention . . . gold coins, hairpins, buttons, lockets, rings . . . there's everything! There is also a beautiful necklace in a small box. I have never seen such a necklace before. I have kept all of them in the chest.'

'Okay, bring that chest to me.'

The maid brought the chest and put it on the table. Then, a boy brought a letter and handed it to Tara. Tara looked at the letter curiously—Kunwar Nirmal Kant OBE. She asked the boy, 'Who gave this letter to you? Was it a person with a silk turban?'

The boy hurried out saying, 'The manager sahib gave it to me for you.'

When she opened the chest, she noticed the box first. Inside the box she found a necklace of real pearls. There was a card in a corner of the box. Tara quickly picked it up and read—'Kunwar Nirmal Kant . . .' The card slipped from her hand. She sprang from the chair and rushed past many rooms and verandas to reach the manager. The manager got up and welcomed her. 'Congratulations on last night's success!'

Tara asked promptly, 'Is Kunwar Nirmal Kant waiting outside? The boy ran away after giving me the letter. I couldn't ask him anything more.'

'I received Kunwar Sahib's note last night just as you left.'

'Why didn't you send him to me then?'

The manager said a little contritely, ‘I thought you would be resting, I didn’t think it appropriate to trouble you. And yes, to tell you the truth, I was scared that if I introduced you to Kunwar Sahib, I might lose you! Had I been a woman myself I would have immediately run after him. I have never seen such an angelic personality before—the one with a silk turban. Even you had noticed him!’

‘Yes, I had seen him,’ said Tara, as if half asleep. ‘Will he come again?’

‘Yes, at five o’clock today. He is a great scholar, and the wealthiest person in the town.’

‘I won’t join you at the rehearsal today!’ said Tara.

3

Kunwar Sahib must be coming. Tara sat in front of the mirror while the maid did her make-up. These days, toiletry is considered an art. Earlier, one’s toilette was based on tradition. The poets, painters and aesthetes had almost set a standard for the toilette. Kajal for the eyes, henna for the hands and scarlet dye for the feet were the musts. Each limb had to have its own jewels. Today that tradition no longer exists. Every woman does her make-up according to her own taste and choice. Her aim is to make herself the most attractive of all. Tara was very good at this art. She had been in this theatre company for the last fifteen years and she had spent her whole life toying with men’s hearts. Who would know better than her which expression, smile, movement of the limbs and hairstyle should be used to win the hearts of lovers! When she went to the audience hall, laced with all the time-tested weapons of her charm, it seemed as if the beauty of the whole world lay at her feet. While looking at Kunwar Sahib’s card on the table, she was actually waiting to hear the sound of the motorcar. She wanted Kunwar Sahib to come right then and see her complete figure in the bloom of her beauty. With her clever toilette she had conquered time. Who could ever say that this restless beauty had already reached the age when the heart pines for rest or looks for a hermitage or when pride surrenders to humility?

Tara Devi didn't have to wait very long. Kunwar Sahib was probably more excited than her; within ten minutes the sound of his motorcar could be heard. Tara gathered herself. The next moment Kunwar Sahib entered the room. Tara forgot the courtesy of shaking hands. The anxiety and recklessness of love does not diminish even at a mature age; she stood there like a coy young maiden.

Kunwar Sahib's eyes fell on her neck—the pearl necklace gifted by him last night was brilliantly shining on her. He had never felt so happy. For a moment he felt as if all his desires had been fulfilled. He said, 'Forgive me for disturbing you so early in the morning today. It must be your time to rest!' Holding the slipping end of the sari, Tara said, 'What could be more pleasant than seeing you! Thank you for this gift. Hopefully, we'll meet every now and then.'

Nirmal Kant smiled and said, 'Not "now and then", every day! Whether *you* would like to meet me or not—I will certainly come every day to see you!'

Tara too smiled and replied coquettishly, 'Until another object of entertainment is found! Isn't it?'

'It's not a matter of entertainment for me; it's a matter of life and death. Yes, you may consider it as entertainment; that doesn't bother me. I would consider my life well spent if I were to spend it for your entertainment!'

Promises of love were exchanged and then they had breakfast together. Kunwar Sahib invited her to dinner and left.

4

A month passed. Kunwar Sahib would visit her several times in a day. Even a moment's separation was unbearable to him. Sometimes they would go boating on the lake; at other times they would sit chatting on a lush lawn; every day there would be different programmes for their entertainment. It was rumoured in the town that Tara Bai had ensnared Kunwar Sahib and was looting his wealth. But for Tara, nothing in the world could be

compared to the love of Kunwar Sahib. Seeing him by her side, she didn't desire anything else in the world.

But despite wandering for a month in the world of love, she couldn't find the thing her soul was longing for. She loved Kunwar Sahib; she loved him with all her heart. Every day she would hear of his confession of true and pure love, but not hearing a word about 'marriage' would make her restless. Her condition was like that of a thirsty person looking for water, who might like other things once the thirst is quenched, but water certainly had far greater value for her than any other thing in the world. She knew that Kunwar Sahib would stake even his life for her sake but why was he not saying a word about marriage? Was it possible to let him know her wish by writing a letter? Does he intend to simply use her for entertainment? She wouldn't be able to bear the insult! She could throw herself into the fire at the slightest hint from Kunwar but this insult was unbearable. Had it been another wealthy person, perhaps she could have enjoyed herself for a month or two and gone her own way. But, as they say, love should be treated with love; with Kunwar Sahib, she couldn't live a shameless life.

On the other hand, Kunwar Sahib's relatives would not take it lying down; they wanted to somehow free him from Tara Bai's influence. According to them, getting him married elsewhere was the best way to get rid of her. Although they didn't expect him to marry an actress, they certainly feared that he might give away his property to her or the children born to her in the future. There was pressure on him from all sides, so much so that his European friends too advised him to get married.

That day, in the evening, Kunwar Sahib came to her and said, 'Tara, I want to ask you something; please, don't refuse.'

Tara's heart leapt. 'Please, what is it? What can I do for you?'

Then, it was just a matter of formality. Tara agreed to it and fell at his feet in delight.

A moment later Tara said, ‘I was almost disappointed; you took a long time testing my love.’

Not sure of what he heard, Kunwar Sahib bit his tongue. He said, ‘It’s nothing like that, Tara; if I knew you would accept me I would have proposed to you on the very first day. But I didn’t consider myself worthy of you! You are the embodiment of virtue . . . and you know I am nothing! I had decided to worship you for the rest of my life. I hoped that you might be pleased enough to bless me some time in the future. If I have any quality worth mentioning, it is my love for you. But when you speak of literature or music or religion, I feel hopelessly small beside you. For me, you are not of this earth but divine. I am surprised that I have not gone mad with happiness yet.’

Kunwar Sahib kept pouring out his emotions for a long time. He had never been so loquacious.

Tara listened to him with rapt attention but, instead of happiness, she felt a kind of sadness—almost akin to shame—at the purity and simplicity of this man. She had never seen such humility and large-heartedness in any man!

Then, suddenly Kunwar Sahib asked, ‘When shall we get married, Tara? Please don’t delay any further.’

Conquered by his simplicity, Tara expressed a concern, ‘What will we do about the legalities of the matter?’ Kunwar Sahib promptly replied, ‘Rest assured, Tara, I have already spoken to my lawyers about this. There is a law that allows us to tie our love. It is called a civil marriage. So, shall we have the auspicious moment this day next week?’

Tara looked down; she could not say anything.

‘I will come in the morning. Be prepared.’

Tara listened but not a word came out of her.

Kunwar Sahib went away while Tara just sat there like a statue. She didn’t understand how the coquette in her, given to toying with men’s hearts, had gone speechless.

One more day to go for the wedding—congratulations were pouring in from all sides. Depending on their capacity, all the men and women of the theatre company had brought gifts for her; Kunwar Sahib had also presented her with a well-furnished toilette case. A few of his close friends had brought special gifts. But there was no trace of happiness on Tara's beautiful face. She was both cross and dejected at the same time. For the last four days she was being troubled by the question: How could she betray Kunwar Sahib? How could she deceive the person who was the very embodiment of love, who had broken off his other relations and sacrificed his family status for her sake, and whose love was as pure as drops of ice and whose heart was as large as the Himalayas? No, she couldn't be so mean! She had played with the hearts of many young men, she had aroused and shattered the hopes and passions of so many, but never had her heart rebuked her so badly. Was it because she hadn't found true love earlier?

Could she make Kunwar Sahib happy? Yes, of course; there was not an iota of doubt about that. If one is dedicated, nothing is impossible. But could she really defy the law of nature? Is it possible for the setting sun to glow like a rising one? Impossible! Where will she find that suppleness, that charm, that raptness, that sacrifice and that self-confidence which collectively define youth? She wavered, 'No, she won't be able to bring happiness to Kunwar Sahib however much she tries—old can never be compared to young.'

Alas! Why did she allow it to happen in the first place? Why did she deceive him through her artificial toilette? After everything that had happened, how could she tell him that she was a painted picture, that youth had left her long ago and she was just a remnant of it?

It was midnight. Tara was at the table, thinking these thoughts. There was a heap of gifts lying on the table but she couldn't even look at them. Only four days ago she would have died for them; she had always liked these things for how glamorous they looked but now she hated them. Love was the only truth—truth and falsehood cannot stay together.

Tara thought, *Why not run away from here to a place where no one would even know of me! And come back after a few days, when Kunwar Sahib is*

already married to someone else, and explain everything to him. He will be shocked to death, but there is no other way. His days will be filled with grief but howsoever grief-stricken he might get, I cannot deceive my beloved. For me, the very memory of our divine love and its pangs are enough. Apart from these, I have no right over anything else.

The maid came and said, 'Baiji, come, have your dinner; it's already twelve o'clock.'

Tara said, 'No, I have no appetite; you can go ahead.'

The maid said, 'Please don't forget me, I will also come along with you.'

Tara said, 'Have you packed some good dresses for yourself?'

The maid said, 'What shall I do with good dresses? I can manage with your discarded ones.'

The maid went away. Tara looked at the watch. Only six hours left for the morning, when Kunwar Sahib would come to take her to the temple where the marriage was to be solemnized. *O God! Why do you present me with something which I was deprived of for so long? This is all just your play, isn't it?*

Tara put on a white sari and set aside her jewels. After washing her face with soap and warm water, she stood before the mirror—where was that charm, that spark which used to tempt the onlookers? It was the same figure but without the life. Could she fake youth now?

It was difficult for her to stay there any longer; she felt as if the jewels and gifts spread out on the table had sunk their teeth into her; her artificial youth became unbearable, so much so that the comfort of the house felt like an oven.

She thought, *Where shall I go? If I leave by train I will not be able to escape. Kunwar Sahib's men are sure to find me in the morning. I will find a way that nobody will be able to think of.*

Tara's heart filled with pride; she was neither sad nor disappointed. She would meet Kunwar Sahib again but that would be a selfless meeting. If she was walking on the path of duty rolled out by love, why should there be sadness or disappointment!

Instantly a fear struck her—not finding her there, a grief-stricken Kunwar Sahib might do something unexpected. For a moment, the thought of it made her recoil. Then, she went to the table and wrote a letter:

> Dearest love, forgive me. I don't find myself worthy of being your servant. You have showered love on me, which I could not have expected. As long as I live I will live with it. To me, it seems there is more sweetness in the memory of love rather than in the enjoyment of it. I will come back to see you again, but it is possible only when you have already got married. That is the condition for my return. My dear, dear love, don't be angry with me! I am leaving the jewels and gifts presented by you for your bride. I am only taking the pearl necklace which was the first token of your love for me. I pray to you with folded hands, please do not look for me. I am yours and will always remain so.
> Yours,
> Tara

Tara placed the letter on the table, wore the necklace around her neck and went out. She could hear the music playing in the Theatre Hall. For a moment her legs froze—fifteen years of relations were being broken. She gasped when she saw the manager coming and quickly moved away towards the shade of the wall. As soon as the manager disappeared, she came out of the shade and took the road that led to the River Ganga.

There was absolute silence on the banks of the river. There were only a few sadhus lying near the ritual fire; and a few travellers were sleeping on blankets on the ground. The River Ganga was moving down like a huge snake. There was a small boat on the bank, on which sat the ferryman.

Tara called him, 'O Manjhi, will you take me to the other side?'

He replied, 'The boat will not go at this hour of the night.'

But the double wages made him pick up the staff. Untying the boat, he asked, 'Sarkar, where will you go on the other side of the bank?'

'I have to go to a village on the other side.'

'You won't find any transport now.'

'No problem, you just take me there.'

The ferryman untied the boat. Tara boarded it and the boat softly floated down the river as if one were swimming in a dream world.

At that instant, the eleventh moon rose on the other side of the world, to ferry its bright boat across the heavenly sea.

Translated from the Hindi by Saroj Kumar Mahananda



Trial by Fire

1

The company of sadhus and saints is known to make even bad people good, but in the case of Payaag it was the opposite. He got addicted to intoxicants in the form of bhang, ganja and charas. The consequence was—a hardworking, energetic young man became a disciple of idleness. Where was such pleasure to be found in the daily struggle for existence? Here under a banyan tree a sadhu's fire pit was burning; a mahatma with matted locks holding court, surrounded by his devotees, was slowly drawing on a pipe of ganja. Bhajans were being sung too. Could such heavenly happiness be found in hard manual labour? Payaag had been assigned the job of filling up the pipe with ganja. The devotees hoped for rewards for their good deeds in the next world, but Payaag drew immediate rewards—he had the first right on the ganja-pipe. Listening to religious discourse from the auspicious mouths of mahatmas, he became delirious with joy, reaching a state of trance. He entered a totally different universe full of fragrance, music and light. That was why, when his wife, Rukmini, came to take him home at ten or eleven at night, he felt it was unfair. The world appeared to him like a forest full of thorns. This feeling became more acute when, after reaching home, he found that the hearth was still unlit and that he had to chew dry gram to allay his hunger.

A Bhar by caste, he had inherited the job of the village chowkidar with a salary of two rupees and a few annas, and a free uniform and turban. He went to the police station once a week, swept the corridor near the officer's door, cleaned the stable and chopped wood. Payaag carried on this work even though he detested it because neglecting it would have cost him both physically and financially. He wiped away his tears thinking that there wasn't much work, and for four days a month two rupees and a few annas was not bad. And even if he couldn't impress the big people in the village with this meagre income, he could lord over the lower castes. He had a salary and pension, but ever since he had come into contact with mahatmas, his salary was spent as though it were his pocket money. For this reason his livelihood became increasingly a cause for concern. Before these sittings with saints, the couple had been labourers. Rukmini would collect firewood and sell it in the bazaar; Payaag sometimes sawed wood, sometimes ploughed, and sometimes irrigated the land.

He used to put all his energy into whatever work he did. He was a simple, cheerful, hard-working and good-humoured fellow. Such a person didn't have to starve. What is more, he was so helpful that he could never say 'no' to anyone. If someone asked him to do something, he would say 'Yes, Sir' and rush off to do it. And so he was held in high esteem by the people in the village, and it was because of this that even after he turned his back on his former way of life and became inactive, he faced no real difficulty for two to three years. If he couldn't manage two meals a day, it was nothing to be surprised about. Even Mahto, the village headman, who had three pairs of bullocks tethered at his door, could not afford it, so why talk of Payaag? He was certainly able to manage one simple meal of dal and roti a day. The problem, however, was getting more serious now. On top of this, what really hurt him was that Rukmini now was slack in her wifely devotion and attentiveness; her earlier readiness to serve was not there any more. In fact, she was getting increasingly petulant and outspoken. And so Payaag needed to find some means to liberate himself from the worry of earning a living, setting him free to devote himself to singing bhajans in praise of God and serving holy men.

One day when Rukmini came back from the bazaar after selling firewood, Payaag said, ‘Listen, give me some money, I want a smoke.’

Turning her face away, Rukmini replied, ‘If you’ve got such a taste for smoke, then why don’t you do some work? Aren’t there any holy men around? Go and fill their chillum!’

Payaag frowned and said, ‘Give me the money if you know what’s good for you. If you keep bothering me like this, one day I’ll leave you and go off somewhere. Then you’ll cry.’

Rukmini gave him a thumbs-down and said, ‘*Me* cry? Never! Even when you’re here, it’s not as if you’re keeping me in the lap of luxury. Even now I break my back working; I’ll do the same when you’re not around.’

‘So that’s your final decision?’

‘Yes, it is. I’ve told you I don’t have money.’

‘You have money to buy jewellery for yourself, but when I ask for a few paise, this is the answer you give me.’

Rukmini flared up. ‘If I buy jewellery for myself, why does it burn your heart? You’ve never even got a brass ring made for me! Can’t I do this much for myself?’

Payaag didn’t return home that day. At nine in the night Rukmini closed the door. She was sure he was hiding somewhere in the village. *He must be thinking that I’ll come and appease him any moment and take him back home—like I’ll ever do that!*

When Payaag didn’t come home the following day either, Rukmini began to worry. She searched the entire village. He wasn’t there at any of his regular haunts. That day she didn’t cook. When she lay down at night, sleep was a long time coming. She was apprehensive that he might really have renounced the world. She made up her mind to search every nook and cranny in the area in the morning—he must be with some sadhu or saint. And she would make a report at the police station too.

At dawn Rukmini got ready to go to the police station. She was just closing the door and stepping outside when she saw Payaag returning. But he was not alone. There was a woman walking behind him. Seeing the woman in her chintz sari, colourful shawl, the long veil over her face and

her shy gait, Rukmini's heart missed a beat. For a moment, she stood transfixed, and then she walked forward, held her co-wife with both hands and led her slowly into the house in the same way a sick person with no hope of recovery drinks a cup of poison.

When the crowd of neighbours had dispersed, Rukmini asked Payaag, 'Where did you pick her up from?'

Payaag laughed. 'She was running away from her home. I found her on the road. She'll do the chores at home, and sleep somewhere.'

'It looks like you've had enough of me.'

Payaag gave her a sideways glance, '*Dhat*, you crazy girl! I've brought her here to run errands for you.'

'When there's a new woman, who cares for the old?'

'Forget it—it's the meeting of minds that's important, not new or old. Come, give me some money if you have it, I haven't had a smoke for three days, my feet are wobbling. Listen, feed the poor girl well for a couple of days, and then she herself will start to work.'

Rukmini took a whole rupee and put it in his hand. He didn't have to ask twice.

2

Whatever other qualities Payaag may have had, one had to accept that he knew the basic principles of administration. He made it his motto to divide and rule.

For one month things went on smoothly without a hitch. Rukmini had forgotten all her cockiness. She got up at the crack of dawn and got busy with either collecting firewood or chopping fodder. Sometimes she made cow-dung fuel-cakes and then set off for the bazaar. She handed half of what she earned to Payaag. The other half was used to run the household. She didn't let her co-wife do any chore. She would tell her neighbours, 'So what if she is my husband's second wife, she's still a young bride. If she doesn't live a life of comfort even for a few months, what will there be for her to remember later? Meanwhile I'm there to do the work.'

The people of the village praised Rukmini's virtuous nature. The shrewd Payaag watched everything and was happy with the success of his plan.

One day the bride said, 'Didi, I've got bored sitting at home. Please give me some work to do.'

Rukmini replied in a tone drenched in affection, 'Do you want to blacken my face in the village? You just take care of the chores at home. I'll take care of the outside.'

The bride's name was Kaushalya, which had been shortened to Siliya. Siliya did not reply at that moment. But it grew unbearable for her to live in the house like a maidservant. She spent all day doing backbreaking chores, and nobody appreciated it. Rukmini brought a few paise from outside and ruled the household on its strength. Now she would begin working outside and break Rukmini's pride.

By now it had become apparent to her that Payaag was a friend of money. When Rukmini left for the bazaar that day with a bundle of fodder to sell, Siliya drew the sack-cloth screen of the house and stepped out to see what the village looked like. People of all castes lived there—Brahmins, Thakurs, Kayasthas and Baniyas. Siliya put on such an act of coyness and virtue that the women were totally bewitched. Some gave her rice, some dal, and others something else. Who doesn't welcome a new bride? In her first round of visits Siliya discovered that there was no woman in the village to grind grain. She could fill that gap. She came back home with a basketful of wheat on her head.

When he heard the sound of the grinding stone in the early hours of the morning, Payaag said to Rukmini, 'Siliya's started grinding so early today!'

Rukmini had brought flour from the market. There wasn't much difference between the price of grain and the price of flour. She was taken by surprise. What was Siliya grinding so early in the morning? She got up and tiptoed into her room, where she saw Siliya sitting in the dark, working the grinding stone. She grabbed her arm, lifted her basket and said, 'Who asked you to grind this? Whose grain are you grinding?'

Siliya was unperturbed and said calmly, 'Why don't you go and sleep comfortably? If I am grinding, what harm does it cause you? Are you so

delicate that you can't even bear to hear the sound of the wheel turning? Come, hand me the basket. How long can I go on sitting and eating, it's already been two months.'

'Did I say anything to you?'

'It doesn't matter whether you say anything or not. One must have her own sense of duty.'

'You have no idea about the people here yet. Everyone likes to have their wheat ground, but they do not want to shell out money for it. Whose wheat is it? I'll go in the morning and throw it on their head.'

Siliya snatched the basket from Rukmini and said, 'Why won't they give me money? I'm no one's slave.'

'You won't listen?'

'I'm not going to lead my life as your maidservant.'

When the sound of this altercation reached Payaag he arrived on the spot and told Rukmini, 'If she wants to work, why don't you let her? Will she remain a new bride all her life? It's already been two months.'

'What do you know about it? People will say all kinds of things about me.'

Siliya suddenly shot back, 'Do you think I'm a freeloader sitting idle at home? Who do you think spruces up the hearth, scrubs the pots, sweeps the floor, dusts, makes chapatis, fetches water, grinds and pounds? My hands have got calluses from hauling water from the well! I can't go on doing all these household chores!'

Payaag said, 'Then you start going to the bazaar. Leave the household chores. Rukmini will manage them.'

Rukmini objected, 'Don't you feel any shame when you say such things? What will people say if a new bride roams in the bazaar?'

Siliya replied insistently, 'What *will* people say? I'm not committing a crime.'

Siliya won her case. The power slipped out of Rukmini's hands. Siliya thrived in her new role. She was a young woman. After grinding the wheat, she got up and went off with the others to cut grass, and she cut such a big heap that it left everyone awestruck. Her bundle of grass was so heavy that

she was barely able to lift it. She even surpassed the men who were experienced grass-cutters! Her bundle sold for twelve annas. With it she bought flour, rice, lentils, oil, salt, vegetables and spices—everything—and still managed to save four annas. Rukmini had thought that Siliya would return from the bazaar with just a couple of annas and that she would get the opportunity to reprimand her and start going to the bazaar herself from the following day. Then her authority would be restored. But when she saw all the stuff Siliya brought from the market, her eyes popped. Payaag sat down to eat and waxed eloquent about the spicy vegetables. He had not tasted such delicious food for months. He was delighted. As he was coming out after his meal, he found Siliya standing in the veranda and said, 'How much did you earn today?'

'I got twelve annas.'

'Have you blown it all? If there's any left, give it to me.'

Siliya handed him the remaining four annas. Payaag clinked the coins in his hands and said, 'You've made me feel rich today. Rukmini would give me just a paisa or two.'

'What's the point of hoarding the money? It is for eating and drinking and not for burying underground.'

'From now on, you can go to the bazaar every day. Rukmini will look after the house.'

3

Rukmini and Siliya were at war. Siliya worked hard to please Payaag and maintain her control over him. The sound of her grinding stone could be heard long before dawn. The moment the sun was up, she went out to collect grass and after a few minutes' rest set off for the bazaar. Even when she returned from the bazaar, she didn't sit idle. Sometimes she spun hemp, sometimes she chopped wood. Rukmini tried to find fault with whatever she did and, whenever she got the time, made cow-dung fuel-cakes and sold them in the village. Payaag had a good time. The women gave him most of their money and treated him with utmost love in order to have him under

their influence. But Siliya had taken her position with such determination that nothing could make her budge. Things got to the point where one day both adversaries came to blows. Once, when Siliya returned home after collecting grass, she was drenched in sweat. It was the month of Phagun; the sun was hot. She thought she would take a bath before going to the bazaar. Putting down the bundle of grass next to the door she went to bathe in the pond. Rukmini took out some grass from the bundle and hid the sheaf in a neighbour's house. Then she loosened the bundle and adjusted the remaining grass. When Siliya returned, she saw some grass missing. When she asked Rukmini about it, she replied, 'I don't know anything.' Siliya began to curse the person, 'May worms eat the body of the person who touched my grass, may her father and brothers die, may her eyes burst!' Rukmini controlled herself for a while, but finally her blood began to boil. She shot up angrily and gave Siliya a few tight slaps. Siliya began to howl and beat her breast. All the neighbours gathered there. All of them envied Siliya's good sense and energy—she gathered the largest bundles of grass and firewood, she got up so early, she earned more than anyone else. These qualities ensured that she lost their sympathy. They all began to speak ill of her. 'Creating such a fuss over a handful of grass! People throw away this much grass while making a bundle! As though it's not grass but gold! You should have remembered that even if someone has taken it, it must be somebody from this village. No thief has come from outside. Who are you cursing so much if not your neighbours?'

Payaag had gone to the police station that day. When he returned, tired out, he said to Siliya, 'Come, give me some money. I feel like having a smoke. I'm totally exhausted.'

The moment Siliya saw him, she began to howl and beat her breast. Alarmed, Payaag asked, 'What happened? Why are you crying? Is someone dead? Did anyone come from your family?'

'I can't stay in this house any longer. I'm going back to my own home.'

'Arré, tell me, what happened? Did anyone call you names? Let me know who. I'll burn his house down, I'll report him to the police!'

Siliya narrated the entire story punctuated with sobs. That day the police had given Payaag a good beating. He was seething with rage. When he heard the story, he felt as though his body was on fire. Rukmini had gone to fetch water. She had barely managed to put her pitcher down when Payaag pounced on her and knocked the breath out of her. She responded to his blows with abuses and, with each abuse, he got more infuriated and struck her even more furiously. Rukmini's knees started bleeding and her bangles got smashed. Meanwhile Siliya taunted her, saying, 'Just look at yourself, what a foul tongue you have! I've never seen a woman like you! You're a witch, not a woman, not the least rein on your tongue!' But Rukmini didn't pay any attention to her. She consumed all her energy in abusing Payaag. He got tired of beating her, but couldn't stop Rukmini's tongue. She kept hurling the same curses—'May you die, may your corpse rot, may Goddess Bhavani devour you, may epilepsy strike you!' Payaag's anger would flare up intermittently and then he would lunge at her and hit her a few times. But Rukmini now seemed immune to the blows. She didn't even move from where she was. Her hair loose, she sat on the ground muttering the same curses. There was no anger in her voice now, only a frenzied flow of words. Her entire being was consumed with a desire for some violent act.

When it became dark, Rukmini stood up and left the spot; a stream of tears flowed from her eyes. Siliya was cooking dinner. She saw her go but said nothing to her. Payaag was sitting by the doorway smoking his chillum. He, too, said nothing.

4

When the crops began to ripen, Payaag had to keep watch over the village fields for close to two months. The farmers owed him grain for the ploughing he did in their fields during the two annual harvests. In the month of Maagh he would clear a small corner in the harvest field and put up a shack of straw. Every night after dinner he would go there with some embers, his pipe, tobacco and charas, and lie there to watch over the fields. He followed this routine until the end of the month of Chait. It was that

time of the year. The crops had ripened in the fields. The harvest was to begin in a couple of days. Payaag waited for Rukmini till ten o'clock. Then, thinking that she might be sleeping at a neighbour's house, he ate his dinner, picked up his stick and said to Siliya, 'Shut the door. If Rukmini comes, let her in, coax her into eating a little something. You caused such a ruckus today. I've no idea how I got so furious. I have never ever laid a hand on her before. If she's drowned herself in a fit of anger, there'll be mayhem tomorrow.'

Siliya replied, 'Who knows if she'll come back or not? How can I stay here all by myself? I'm scared.'

'But there's no one else to stay here. If a thief finds the house deserted, he might make off with the pots and pans. What are you scared of? And for all I know, Rukmini might be on her way.'

Siliya lowered the grass screen from inside. Payaag set off for the fields. He was transported to a trance-like state because of the charas and was singing a bhajan:

> Deceiver! How you flash your eyes
> Cut a pumpkin to make a drum, a lime to make cymbals
> Five gourds sing auspicious songs, a cucumber-lover dances
> Wearing silver you show off, you entice us wearing gold,
> With a garland of tulsi beads round your neck, you confuse all three worlds.
> O Deceiver!

He had barely reached the edge of the fields when he saw that someone had lit a fire in the fields. A flame flared up in a moment. He shouted out, 'Who's there? Arré, who is lighting that fire?'

The raging flames responded by leaping still further.

Now Payaag realized that it was his shack that was on fire. His heart began to sink. Setting his shack on fire was like setting a pile of cotton ablaze. The wind was blowing. An arm's length from the shack, on every side, the ripened grain spread like a sheet. Even at night one could see their golden colour glowing. One flame, even a tiny spark, could reduce the entire field of crop to ashes. The village would be ruined. Adjoining their fields were those of a neighbouring village. Those would also be burnt. Oh!

The flames were rising higher. There was no time for delay. Payaag flung his dung fuel-cakes and pipe away and ran towards the shack, with his iron-tipped stick on his shoulder. It was a long way to go along the dykes and so he was running across the fields. The flames grew stronger every moment and Payaag was running even faster. Even a racehorse would have found it difficult to catch up with him now. He was amazed by his own speed. It seemed as if his feet were barely touching the ground. His eyes were fixed on the shack, he had no other thoughts in his mind. This single-mindedness had put wings to his heels. He didn't gasp for breath nor did his feet tire. He covered three or four furlongs in two minutes and reached the shack.

There was no one near the shack. There was no time to find out who was responsible, let alone search for them. Payaag suspected Rukmini but this was not the time for anger. Like mischievous children, the flames laughed as they blazed, nudged and shoved each other, sometimes leaping to the right and sometimes to the left. It seemed that they would reach the fields any moment. They seemed to advance towards the dyked plots with all their energy, and when they didn't succeed, they advanced a second time with double the energy. How could he put out the fire? He couldn't do it by beating it with his stick, to try doing that would be foolish. What else could be done? If the crop got burnt, he'd never be able to show his face to the villagers out of shame. There would be total mayhem in the village. Everything would be destroyed.

He didn't reflect further. Rustic people can't think. Payaag straightened his stick, leapt into the fire and lifted the burning shack on the end of his stick. Then holding it above his head, he ran towards the village on the widest dyke marking the plot boundaries. It seemed as if a fiery weapon was flying through the sky. Shards from burning straws were falling on him, but he was totally oblivious to them. A handful of burning straws came loose and fell on his arm. His whole arm was scalded. But his step did not falter for a moment, his hand on the stick did not waver. If his hand shook, the crops would be ruined. He had no other concern. His only worry was that the central part of the thatch where he had wedged the tip of his stick might catch fire, because if the tip burned, the entire shack would collapse

on top of him and bury him in a fiery grave. Payaag knew this and was running like the wild wind. It was a four-furlong race. Death had assumed the shape of fire and was dancing over his head and over the crops in the field. He was running at such a speed that the flames were swept backwards and most of their energy was being consumed in fighting the wind. Otherwise the fire would have reached the centre of the field by now and it would have turned into a scene of devastation. One furlong was covered and Payaag was still unfazed. He covered the second furlong too. 'Look, Payaag,' he told himself. 'There are only two furlongs left. Don't let your feet slacken one bit. If the fire gets to the tip of your stick, your life is over. People will curse you even after you're dead, you'll burn in the fire of people's curses for eternity. Just a minute more! There are only two more fields to cross.' Catastrophe! The tip of his stick had jutted out. The thatch was slipping downwards. There was no hope left. Payaag was running for his life. He reached the last field. Now it was a matter of two more seconds. Victory was just twenty yards away, waiting to welcome him. Heaven stood there, hell here. The thatch slipped down and was touching Payaag's head. He could still throw it aside and save himself, but he didn't care for his own life. He continued running as the flames burned around his head. Now he stumbled. This cruel game of fire became unbearable for him.

Suddenly a woman came out from behind a tree and ran towards Payaag. It was Rukmini. She bowed her head before him, thrust herself beneath the thatch and held it up with her two hands. At that moment Payaag fell down, unconscious. His whole face was scalded.

Carrying his fire, Rukmini reached the end of the fields in a second. But in that short distance her arms were burned, her face was scorched and her clothes had caught fire. Her mind was not active enough even to think of escaping the burning thatch. She fell with the thatch on top of her. After this, for some time, the thatch kept shaking. Rukmini was flailing her legs and arms, and then was swallowed by the fire. Rukmini had chosen death by fire.

After some time Payaag regained consciousness. His whole body burned. He saw the red embers of the thatch gleaming beneath the tree. He ran over

and shifted the embers with one foot—beneath lay Rukmini's half-charred corpse. He sat down right there, covered his face with both hands and wept.

In the morning, the villagers picked Payaag up from the spot and carried him home. He received medical treatment for a week, but didn't survive. He had been half-burnt by the fire and whatever was left of him was consumed by the fire of grief.

Translated from the Hindi by M. Asaduddin



Moteramji Shastri

1

Who didn't know Pandit Moteramji Shastri? He observed the attitude of the government officials and acted accordingly. When the Swadeshi Movement was on, he had opposed it vigorously. During the Self-Rule Movement too he had obtained a certificate of loyalty from the government officials. But when, even after all these efforts, his fortune did not change and he found no escape from his daily drudgery as a teacher, he finally decided to take matters into his own hands and carve for himself a new destiny. He went home and said to his wife, 'Rote-teaching these old parrots is addling my brain. What have I gained by imparting the gift of knowledge for so long? How can I hope for anything better in the future?'

Concerned, his wife replied, 'We do need some means to fill our bellies.'

'You always worry about where your meals will come from. Hardly a day goes by when I am not invited to a ritual feast as a Brahmin, and even if people criticize me for it, I always bring a portion of the food for you. Even today I do have a number of acolytes. But if all I do my entire life is just feed my belly, what will I have achieved? We must enjoy some of the pleasures that this world has to offer. I have decided to become a vaidya.'

Taken aback by this sudden declaration, his wife asked him, 'You want to become a vaidya, but have you ever studied Ayurvedic medicine?'

‘I don’t need to study Ayurveda. In this world knowledge is not as important as intelligence. There are only a few simple tricks that one must know, and that’s it! Today onwards I am going to add Bhishagacharya—Doctor of Ayurveda—before my name. Who’s going to care if I am actually one or not? People have more important work to do than test my medical knowledge. I’ll have a huge signboard put up with the following words printed prominently: “Secret diseases of men and women are treated here with utmost confidentiality.” I’ll keep three or four paise-worth of myrobalan and other herbs pounded and sieved. That should be quite enough for this purpose. Yes, and I’ll have advertisements placed in the newspapers and distribute flyers. In them I will quote from letters of imaginary dignitaries from far-off places like Ceylon, Madras, Rangoon and Karachi. They will vouch for the efficacy of my medicine. No one is crazy enough to go roaming around to find out whether people bearing such names really exist in these places or not. Then you’ll see how my practice thrives!’

His wife asked, ‘But if you give medicine without any knowledge of it, how will it help people?’

‘I couldn’t care less if it doesn’t help. It’s a vaidya’s job to prescribe medicine; he hasn’t taken up the responsibility of defeating death. Besides, everyone who falls ill doesn’t die. I tell you, people who don’t take any medicine get better on their own once the disease runs its course. Vaidyas get undeserved praise. Out of five patients, even if one recovers, I will certainly get the credit for it. If the other four die, well, they aren’t going to come back to complain about it. I’ve thought hard about it and decided that there is no better job for me than this. You know very well that I write newspaper articles, and I can compose poetry. I’ll write some pieces in the papers on the importance of Ayurvedic medicine, with a couple of verses thrown in here and there. I’ll write in an entertaining way, and then you’ll see how many idiots get caught in my trap. Don’t think for a moment that I have just been rote-teaching old parrots all these days. I’ve been observing the tricks of all the successful vaidyas in this town, and finally I have

learned the secrets of their success. God willing, one day you will be decked in gold from head to toe.'

Suppressing her delight, his wife cackled, 'I'm past the age when women crave for jewellery. I've no desire for it now. But tell me one thing—you don't even know how to prepare medicine, how will you prepare extracts and essences from the herbs when you don't even recognize them?'

'Sweetheart, you really are a fool! A vaidya doesn't need any of these things. Even a pinch of ash from a vaidya can turn out to be an essence and elixir. All that is necessary is a bit of pomp and show. I'll need a fairly large room with a dhurrie on the floor, and a dozen or so glass tumblers and bottles in niches in the walls. Nothing else is required; my wits will do the rest. My articles written in a literary style will have great impact, just you wait and see. You know very well how skilfully I use poetic devices in my writings. There's no one in the world today who can get past me in the use of figures of speech. After all, I haven't spent the days of my life simply digging grass! A dozen or so people come to me merely to discuss poetry. They will be my agents. They will bring patients to me. Just wait and see, my practice will thrive not because of my knowledge of Ayurveda but thanks to my way with words.'

His wife was not convinced. 'I am scared that you will end up losing your students as well. You will be neither here nor there. Teaching children is written in your destiny. Kicked from all sides, you will be compelled to rote-teach the same parrots again.'

'Don't you have any faith in my ability?'

'Because you'll be deceiving people there too. I've got sick of your lies. Why do you want to pretend to be something you're not and can never be? You could not become a leader, and didn't, and kept lamenting over it. But you do not give up your deceitful ways. I'm really fed up. I want you to lead your life like a decent human being. Live a simple and honest life. But when do you ever listen to me?'

'Then what use will I ever make of my gift of the gab?'

'Why don't you become a flatterer to some aristocrat? You will recite a few beautiful verses in his praise and he'll be pleased with you and will

definitely give you something. Why do you have to pretend to be a vaidya?'

'I know of tricks that even the forefathers of vaidyas don't know. And all of them keep roaming around for just one or two rupees. I will charge five rupees, with conveyance extra. This will make people believe that I must be a great vaidya, otherwise I wouldn't charge such high fees.'

His wife now felt somewhat convinced. She said, 'Finally you've said something sensible. But you must understand that you won't be able to make much of an impression here, you'll have to move to a town which is far away.'

Moteram laughed. 'Don't I know that? We'll set up business in Lucknow. Within a year my profession will thrive so much that all the other vaidyas will disappear from the scene. I know many other tricks. I won't even start treating a patient until I have observed him two or three times. I'll say that until I am closely familiar with the nature of the patient, I will not be able to treat him. What do you say to that?'

His wife beamed and said, 'Now I'm impressed. Your medical career will certainly thrive, there's no doubt about it. But don't try your tricks on the poor, or you'll make a fool of yourself.'

2

A year passed.

Bhishagacharya Pandit Moteramji Shastri made a name in Lucknow. He of course knew his figures of speech well; in addition he could also sing and play a little. On top of that he was a specialist of intimate diseases—the literati of Lucknow made him the toast of the town. Panditji recited poetry to them, made them laugh and fed them potent herbs, and the aristocrats, who always hankered after medicines of potency, praised him to the skies. In just one year he'd established his reputation to such a degree that it appeared as though he was the sole doctor of secret diseases in Lucknow. In some cases, he kept the identity of his patients secret. He became especially popular among pleasure-loving widowed ranis and indiscreet aristocrats given to sensual pleasures, and he considered himself unmatched.

His wife, however, kept on exhorting him not to get mixed up with the ranis and their problems, warning him that he would regret it one day.

But Moteram was undeterred, despite the repeated warnings. Among Panditji's devotees was the rani of Birhal. The raja had left for his heavenly abode, and the Rani Sahiba was afflicted by some chronic disease. Panditji used to go to her home five times a day. The Rani Sahiba didn't want him to leave her side even for a moment. If Panditji was even a little late in arriving, she would become agitated. A motorcar stood constantly at his door. Now the Panditji had undergone a sartorial transformation. He wore a long coat of fine muslin, tied a Banarasi silk turban and showed off his leather shoes. He and his high-spirited friends rode around in the motorcar with great pomp and show. He had got a few of them appointed to some posts in the Rani Sahiba's court. How could the Rani Sahiba ever refuse a request from her messiah?

One day Panditji had one hand on the Rani Sahiba's fair-skinned wrist to feel her pulse, while his other hand felt the speed of her heartbeat, when suddenly a number of club-wielding men burst into the room and fell upon him. The Rani fled to another room and closed the door. Moteram was beaten mercilessly. Panditji was himself a strong, powerfully built man and always carried a stick with him, but what could he do when he was set upon by several men at once without warning? He fell at the feet of all his assailants by turns. He kept screaming *'Hai! Hai!'* but they were brutal and showed him no compassion.

One of them kicked him hard and said, 'Chop off the nose of this villain.'

Another said, 'Smear his face with soot and lime and let him go.'

A third said, 'So Vaidyaji Maharaj, what do you prefer? Would you like your nose chopped off or your face painted black?'

Panditji replied, 'Please, Sirs, I'm dying. Do anything, but please do not chop off my nose.'

'Will you come here again?' asked the first man.

'Not even by mistake. Hai, I'm dying.'

'Make yourself scarce from Lucknow today itself. Or else, you'll face the music!' said the second man.

‘Sarkar, I will leave this very day. I swear to you by my sacred thread. You’ll never see my face here again.’

‘All right, everyone, let’s all give him five kicks each and let him go,’ said the third.

‘Arré, Sarkar! I’ll die, please have mercy on me.’

‘Hypocrites like you are better dead. So let’s start,’ said the fourth.

They began to kick him five times each. Each kick made a thudding sound. It was as though someone was beating a kettledrum. After every kick, Moteram yelled out ‘hai’ like a reverberating echo!

Once the five-kick ritual was over, the men dragged Moteramji outside and sent him home in the motorcar. As he was leaving, they warned him that he would be administered some more of the treatment if he did not disappear by the morning.

3

Moteram entered his house limping, moaning and leaning on his stick, and threw himself on to a charpoy. Alarmed, his wife asked, ‘What happened to you? Why are you looking so distraught? Hai, hai, what’s happened to your face?’

‘Hai, Bhagwan! I’m dying.’

‘Where does it hurt? It is for this reason that I told you not to eat so much *rabri*. Shall I give you digestive salts?’

‘Hai, the wicked fellows have almost killed me. That wretched low-born bitch is the one responsible for me being in this condition. They have knocked the stuffing out of me.’

‘So, you’ve been thoroughly bashed up? Yes, that’s what it is. And you were rightly served. You are fit for kicking. I exhorted you not to keep going to the rani’s place, but when do you listen to me?’

‘Hai, hai! Whore, you too are abusing me at this moment? I am in a bad shape and you are bad-mouthing me. Go and tell someone to bring a pushcart, we have to run away from Lucknow tonight. They’ll kill me in the morning if they find me here.’

‘No, you still haven’t had enough of this place. Stay here a few days more and enjoy the air. How contented our life was when you used to teach those boys! But no, you had to think of becoming a vaidya. Good, you’ve learnt a lesson you’ll never forget as long as you live. Where was the rani when they were thrashing you? Couldn’t she protect you?’

‘Hai, hai! That witch ran away. All this happened because of her! I never imagined such a thing could happen, otherwise would I ever have agreed to treat her?’

‘You’re an unlucky fellow. How your practice had begun to thrive! But your shenanigans destroyed it all. In the end you have to go back to teaching. You *are* ill-fated.’

The next morning a pushcart was standing at Moteramji’s door and his possessions were being piled on to it. Not a single friend of his was in sight. Panditji lay writhing in pain, and his wife supervised the operation.

Translated from the Hindi by M. Asaduddin



The Spell

1

It was evening. Dr Chaddha was getting ready to play golf. The motorcar was waiting at the door when two palanquin-bearers bearing a litter were seen coming. Leaning on a stick, an old man followed the litter. The litter stopped before the clinic. The old man came slowly and peeped though the bamboo curtains. He was afraid of placing his feet on this tidy floor lest someone scold him. Seeing the doctor before him, he didn't dare say anything.

Doctor Sahib shouted from behind the curtains, 'Who is it? What do you want?'

The old man folded his hands and said, 'Huzoor, I am a very poor man. Since many days, my son—'

Doctor Sahib lit his cigar and said, 'Come tomorrow morning. I don't attend to patients at this hour.'

The old man bent his knees, prostrated himself on the ground and said, 'O lord, I beseech you, my son will die! Huzoor, since four days, he hasn't opened his eyes.'

Dr Chaddha looked at his wristwatch. Only ten minutes were left. Taking down the golf-stick from the peg, he said, 'Come tomorrow in the morning. Tomorrow in the morning; this is my sports hour.'

The old man took off his turban and put it on the doorstep. Crying, he said, ‘Huzoor, just a quick look would do. A mere look. I’ll lose my son, master. Of my seven sons, only he is left, Huzoor. Both me and my wife will die crying, master. O friend of the poor, may you prosper even more.’

Such stupid rustics often came here every day. Doctor Sahib was well acquainted with their behaviour. One may say whatever one wishes to, but they’ll carry on with their litany of complaints. They won’t listen to anybody. He raised the curtain slowly, stepped outside and walked towards the motorcar. The old man ran after him saying, ‘Master, you’ll be doing me a great favour. Huzoor, have mercy; I am very poor and unhappy. I have no one else in this world except him, Babuji!’

But Doctor Sahib didn’t even turn his face in his direction to look at him. He sat in the motorcar and said, ‘Come tomorrow morning.’

The car left. For several minutes, the old man stood there like a statue. There were people in the world who didn’t care about anyone’s life over their pleasures. Perhaps he was still finding it difficult to believe it. That the civilized world could be so harsh and merciless was something he hadn’t experienced until now. He belonged to the older generation, when people were always ready to extinguish a fire, to provide a shoulder to carry a corpse, to build a thatch and to resolve a dispute. The old man just stood there and kept on staring at the car till it went out of his sight. Perhaps he still hoped for the Doctor Sahib to come back. Then he told the palanquin-bearers to lift the litter. The litter went back in the same direction from where it had come. He had come to Dr Chaddha’s clinic having been turned away from all the other places. He had heard the doctor being spoken highly of. He didn’t go to any other doctor after being turned away from here. He was resigned to his fate!

That night, his smiling and playful seven-year-old son passed away, putting an end to his childhood exploits. He had been the centre of his old parents’ lives. They had lived only through his presence. The dark night of their lives started howling as soon as this lamp was extinguished. The tenderness of old age pierced through the broken heart in the dark and wept in a distressed tone.

2

Several years passed. Dr Chaddha acquired great wealth and fame. But along with this, he also cared about his health, something that was unusual. It was due to his disciplined life that even at fifty years of age, his zest and sprightliness put young men to shame. He had a fixed time for everything and he didn't deviate from his routine even a little. People often follow the healthy route when they fall sick. Dr Chaddha knew the secrets of treatment and restraint very well. The number of his children was also in keeping with this principle. He only had two children—a boy and a girl. He didn't have a third child and so even Mrs Chaddha looked quite young. The girl had been married off while the boy studied in a college. He was the lodestar of his parents. He was an embodiment of courtesy and humility, had a sense of humour, and was of a generous disposition. He was also the pride of his college, and the very grace of society. There was a glow on his face. It was his twentieth birthday today.

It was evening. Chairs were put out on the green grass. The rich and the elite of the town were sitting on one side and feasting, while the students sat on the other side. Electric lights lit up the entire grounds. All objects of entertainment had been gathered. A play was going to be staged. It was written by Kailash Nath himself, who was also the main actor. Wearing a silk kurta, he was busy welcoming his friends. His head and feet were bare. If some beckoned him from one side, several others called him from another direction. Everyone was teasing him, determined to have some fun at his cost. He didn't have a moment to spare. Suddenly, a woman came to his side and said, 'Kailash, where's your snake? Show it to me.'

Kailash shook hands with her and said, 'Mrinalini, not now. Sorry. I'll show you tomorrow.'

Mrinalini insisted, 'Oh no, you have to show me now. I'm not going to budge today. Whenever I ask you, you always postpone it for the next day.'

Mrinalini and Kailash were classmates and in love with each other. Kailash reared, fed and played with snakes as a hobby. He kept snakes of all kinds in his house. He tested their nature and characteristics. Only a few

days earlier, he had delivered a key speech in his school on the subject of snakes. He had also made the snakes dance in public. Even great scholars of biology were stunned to hear his speech. He had gathered all the information from a snake charmer. He was obsessed with collecting roots that acted as an antidote to snake venom. If he got a clue that any individual was in possession of such roots, he would try to get it by any means. This was his passion—on which he spent thousands of rupees. Mrinalini had visited him a couple of times but hadn't expressed a desire so far to see the snakes. One didn't know whether she was actually curious that day to see the snakes or whether she wanted to display her hold over Kailash. But it was not the right occasion for it. A lot of people would gather there. Seeing them, the snakes would be restless, and it was not right to bother them at night. But she didn't care about any of this.

Kailash said, 'No. I'll certainly show them tomorrow. At this moment, I can't show you properly. There will not be even an inch of space in the room.'

One gentleman teased him, 'Why don't you show her? Why are you making a fuss over such a trivial thing? Miss Govind, don't let him off. Let's see what he can do.'

Another gentleman egged her on further, 'Miss Govind is so simple and innocent. That's why you push her around. Any other beautiful woman would've lost her temper in such a situation.'

A third gentleman added, 'Of course. She would've stopped speaking to him. You are giving lame excuses. On top of it, you claim that you can lay down your life for Mrinalini.'

Mrinalini understood that the others were trying to have some fun at their cost. She said, 'You don't have to plead for me, I'm quite capable of pleading my own case. I don't want to see the snakes right now. Let's forget it.'

His friends burst into a peal of laughter. One gentleman said, 'Indeed, you want to see them, but no one is ready to show them to you.'

Mrinalini looked crestfallen. Seeing her face, Kailash realized that his refusal had really hurt her. The moment the feast was over and the singing

was about to begin, he took Mrinalini and his friends to the enclosure where the snakes were kept and began to play a fiddle. Then he began to open the doors one by one and the snakes came out. What a magnificent sight it was! It looked as though they understood each movement of their master. Kailash picked up one snake in his hand, placed another on his shoulder and coiled another around his arms. Mrinalini begged him not to put them on his shoulder. Her heart was in her mouth when she saw the snakes coiling around Kailash's neck. She was regretting having asked him to show her these snakes. But Kailash didn't listen to her. He was keen on showing his mastery over the snakes to his beloved. One of his friends commented, 'Their fangs must've been taken out.'

Kailash replied with a smile, 'That is what the jugglers do. None of the snakes here have got their fangs broken. I can show you if you want.'

He grabbed a black snake and said, 'I don't have another snake here that is bigger or more poisonous than this one. If it bites anyone, that person will die instantly. He won't even shake. No spell can work on it. Shall I show you his fangs?'

Mrinalini grabbed his hand and said, 'Oh no, Kailash. For God's sake, leave the snake. I beseech you.'

Another friend said, 'I don't believe that. However, if *you*'re saying it, I've no other option but to accept it.'

Kailash grabbed the snake by its neck and said, 'Oh no, see it with your own eyes and then accept it. If I've tamed them after breaking their fangs, then what is so great about that? Snakes are intelligent creatures. If they're convinced that an individual won't harm them, they'll never bite the person.'

When Mrinalini saw that Kailash looked like one possessed at that moment, she tried to put an end to it and said, 'That's enough. Let's get away from here. The singing has begun. I would like to sing something today.'

Holding Kailash by his shoulder, she tried to take him out of the room. But Kailash wanted to put the suspicions of his rivals to rest. He grabbed the snake's neck and pressed it so hard that his own face turned red and all

his veins became taut. It was unusual for the snake to be treated like this. It wondered what Kailash expected. The snake felt that perhaps they were going to kill it, so it got ready to defend itself.

Kailash pressed the snake's neck harder, opened its mouth and showed its poisonous fangs to his friends. 'The doubting Thomases may come here and see. Are you convinced, or do you still have doubts?'

His friends came closer, saw the fangs and expressed their surprise. All their doubts vanished in the face of the evidence. After removing the doubts of his friends, Kailash eased his grip on the snake and wanted to place it on the ground, but that black snake had gone crazy with fury. The moment Kailash's grip eased, the snake raised its head and bit Kailash on his finger and crawled away. Kailash's finger started dripping blood. He pressed his finger hard and ran towards his room. In the drawer of his table, there was a root. If it was ground and placed over the injury, it would suck away all the poison from the bite. His friends were all running helter-skelter. The other invitees came to know about the incident. The doctor panicked and ran inside. The finger was tied tightly and the root was being ground now. The doctor didn't believe in the efficacy of the root. He wanted to amputate the finger, but Kailash had firm belief in the root. Mrinalini was sitting at the piano. Hearing the news, she ran inside and began to wipe away the dripping blood with her handkerchief. In a minute, Kailash's eyelids drooped, his lips became pale. He couldn't stand any longer and had to sit on the floor. All the guests trooped inside. If someone suggested one thing, others recommended something else. Meanwhile the root had been ground and Mrinalini applied the paste on his finger. Another minute passed. Kailash's eyes closed altogether. He lay down and gestured to the others to fan him. His mother took his head in her lap and turned on the electric fan.

Doctor Sahib bent down and asked, 'How do you feel, Kailash?'

Kailash raised his hand slowly but couldn't say anything. Mrinalini said piteously, 'Will the root be effective?'

Doctor Sahib said in despair, 'What can I say? I listened to him. Now even amputation will not help.'

The situation remained unchanged for half an hour. Kailash's condition worsened with every passing instant. This continued till his eyes became stony and his hands and feet became cold. His face turned pale and his pulse couldn't be traced. Every symptom of death was visible. The house turned into a scene of lamentation. Mrinalini started beating her head while Kailash's mother fainted. Dr Chaddha was restrained by his friends, otherwise he would've struck himself in the neck with his lancet.

One gentleman said, 'If we can find someone who can break the spell, then it's still possible to save his life.'

One Muslim gentleman supported him, 'Yes, there are extraordinary people who have brought even corpses lying in their graves back to life.'

Dr Chaddha said, 'I must've been out of my mind when I was convinced of his opinions. This situation would not have come to pass had I amputated his finger in the first place. I repeatedly advised him against rearing snakes, but who listened to me ever! Go ahead. Call some exorcist if that's what you really want. He may take away everything that belongs to me. I'll place all my property at his feet. I'll renounce my house and will be content with a mere loincloth on my body; if only my Kailash, my dear Kailash, is revived. For God's sake, call someone.'

One gentleman present there knew an exorcist. He ran to fetch him but looking at Kailash's face, the exorcist lost all hope. He said, 'Nothing can be done now, Sir. Whatever had to happen has already happened.'

What a fool he was! He should've said that whatever *shouldn't* have happened had happened. A lot of things were yet to happen. The parents had to see their son in his wedding outfit. Mrinalini's desires had not been fulfilled. The dream that she was weaving of a life of joy with him was not fulfilled yet. In the sea of life, their boat sank with all the possibilities that remained unfulfilled. What shouldn't have happened had indeed happened.

The fields still looked lush and green, the moon continued to envelop nature with its mantle of gold. All the objects of entertainment were present there but instead of laughter, the atmosphere was one of tears and mourning.

3

Several miles away from the city an old man and a woman were sitting before the fire to while away the cold night. The old man was drinking coconut water and coughing intermittently. The old woman was staring at the fire. An earthenware lamp was burning on the alcove. There was no charpoy or bed in the shack, only some straw was lying on one side. There was an earthen oven in the shack. The old woman gathered cow-dung cakes and dry branches of trees throughout the day. The old man made ropes and sold them in the market. This is how they lived their lives. No one has seen them laughing or crying. All their waking hours were spent in simply earning their livelihood. Death was knocking at the door, where was the time for laughing or crying?

The old woman asked, 'There's no hemp left, what will you do tomorrow?'

'I'll go and borrow ten *ser*s of hemp from Jhagdu Shah.'

'You haven't yet paid him for his earlier account. Why should he give you more?'

'I don't care if he doesn't. There's enough grass left. I can go in the morning and cut a bundle worth two annas by the middle of the day.'

At that moment, a man called out, 'Hey Bhagat, have you gone to sleep? Open the door please.'

Bhagat got up and opened the door. The man came inside and said, 'Have you heard—a snake has bitten Dr Chaddha's son.'

Bhagat was surprised, 'Bitten Chaddha Babu's son? The same Chaddha Babu who lived in a bungalow in the cantonment?'

'Yes, the very same. The entire town is in a tizzy. So, if you can do something, your life will be made.'

The old man shook his head and said sternly, 'Not me. I won't go. I know him very well. I had taken my son to him when he was sick. The doctor was going out to play. I fell at his feet and requested him to treat my son, but he didn't even talk to me properly. God was watching everything. Now he'll realize what it means to lose a son. Does he have other sons?'

‘Oh no, he has just one son. People are saying that he is a lost case.’

‘God is almighty. That day tears were streaming down my face but he didn’t show any mercy. If I were at his door now, I still wouldn’t have expressed any sympathy.’

‘You aren’t going then? I told you whatever I had heard.’

‘You did the right thing. This has brought me great comfort. His son must’ve also grown cold by now. You may go now. Tonight, I’ll sleep peacefully. (To his wife) Fetch some tobacco. I’ll take another puff. Now the Lala will come to his senses! All his lordliness will vanish. What did we lose? Our son’s death didn’t deprive us of an estate. My son went the way his six siblings had gone. But you’ll now be without any heir. You gathered such a large fortune by exploiting others for his sake. What will you do now? I’ll certainly go once to see for myself. But that’ll be after a couple of days.’

The man left. Bhagat closed the door and then started smoking his tobacco.

The old woman said, ‘Who’ll go there in the cold at this hour of the night?’

‘Hey, I wouldn’t have gone even if it were noon or if his vehicle had come to the door to pick me up. I haven’t forgotten anything. Panna’s face still floats before my eyes. This cruel fellow didn’t even look at him once. Didn’t I know that he wouldn’t survive? Oh, I knew it quite well. Chaddha was no God that his mere look could make my son immortal. No, it was only a last-ditch attempt. It would’ve been a consolation. That’s why I had gone to him. Now I’ll go there someday and ask him, “Why, Sahib, tell me, how are you?” The world may call me evil for all I care. The dregs of humanity have all the flaws. The elite have none, they are deities.’

This was the first time in Bhagat’s life that he was refusing to budge an inch despite hearing such news. Never before, in the eighty years of his life, had he not gone running hearing news about snakes. He never worried about the dark nights of winter, the sunshine and the hot winds of summer, and the flooded rivers and rains of the monsoon. He would immediately step out of his house—without any self-interest. The thought of transaction

never occurred to him. This wasn't his occupation. Who can ever pay the price of saving a life? This was a virtuous act. His spells had saved the lives of hundreds of despairing people. But today he wouldn't step outside the house. He was going to sleep after hearing the news.

The old woman said, 'The tobacco is near the fire. Even that cost me two and a half paise. She just didn't want to give it to me.'

The old woman lay down. The old man turned off the lamp, stood there for a while, and then sat down. Finally, he too lay down, but the news weighed like a burden upon his heart. He felt as if he had lost something, as if all his clothes had become wet. It seemed as though there was mud on his feet, as though someone was sitting in his mind and trying to push him out of his house. In a while, his wife began snoring. Old people keep on talking till they sleep and then wake up at the slightest noise. Bhagat got up from his bed, picked up his stick and opened the door quietly.

His wife asked, 'Where are you going?'

'Nowhere. Just trying to see how deep the night is.'

'The night is long. Go to sleep.'

'Sleep isn't coming.'

'How can it come? Your mind is now at Chaddha's house.'

'What good has Chaddha done for me that I should go to his house? I won't go even if he comes and falls at my feet.'

'But you've got up with the intention of going there, haven't you?'

'Oh no. I'm not crazy enough to take flowers to somebody who has dragged me over the coals.'

The old woman went to sleep again. Bhagat closed the door, went back to his bed and sat on it. But his mind was restless. He was like a person listening to the advice of a counsellor amidst drumbeats. The eyes may be looking at the counsellor but the mind is distracted by the drum. The drumbeats reverberated in his mind even though he did not get up out of embarrassment. Bhagat remembered the cruelty of the doctor but his heart went out to the poor young man who was dying, for whom every second's delay was fatal.

He opened the door again, quietly so his wife wouldn't get to know, and stepped out. The night watchman, who was making his rounds, asked him, 'Are you okay, Bhagat? It's very cold tonight. Are you going somewhere?'

Bhagat replied, 'Not really. Where would I go? I wanted to see how deep the night is and what time it was.'

The watchman said, 'It could be about one. I was returning from the police station when I saw a big crowd in front of Chaddha Babu's bungalow. You must've got to know about his son—he has been bitten by a snake. He is on the brink of death, perhaps you can save him. People were saying that he's ready to give ten thousand rupees.'

Bhagat said, 'I'm not going there, even if he gives me ten lakh rupees. What should I do with ten thousand or ten lakhs? I may die tomorrow. Who's there to make use of the money?'

The watchman left. Bhagat advanced a couple of steps. Just as an inebriated person loses control over his body and limbs, Bhagat too had no control over his feet now. Revenge occupied his mind but his mind didn't control his actions. A man who has never used a sword cannot use it even if his intention is strong. His hands shake and refuse to go up for the strike.

Bhagat was now walking fast, tapping his stick on the ground. His conscious mind tried to restrain him but the unconscious mind egged him on. It was a case of a slave overpowering the master. After covering half of the way, Bhagat suddenly stopped. Revenge triumphed over action. *Why did I come out so far? Why should I risk my life in this severe cold? Why didn't I sleep comfortably? If sleep didn't come, I could've sung a couple of bhajans. I've run this far for no reason. Chaddha's son may live or die—why should I care? Did they treat me so well that I should die for them? Thousands of people die every day. Why should I be bothered if someone is dying?*

But his unconscious mind took his thinking in a different direction, which was similar to revenge. He was not going there to exorcise or cast a spell. He would watch what people were doing. He would watch Doctor Sahib crying and lamenting, how he beat his head against the wall or prostrated himself on the ground. He would see whether big people also cried like

small people or if they controlled their emotions. They were wise people, they must have great self-control. Imbued with this sense of revenge, he moved forward.

He saw two men coming towards him. They were talking to each other. 'Chaddha Babu's family has been ruined. He was their only son.'

Bhagat heard their words. He wanted to walk faster, but his feet refused to rise because of exhaustion. His head was spinning so much that he felt he would fall to the ground. He walked in this condition for about ten minutes and finally saw Doctor Sahib's bungalow. The electric lights were on, but there was total desolation. There was no sound of crying or lamentation either. Bhagat's heart was in his mouth. *I hope it's not too late.* He began to run. Never before had he run so fast at this age. It was as though death were chasing him.

4

It was two in the night. The guests had left. Only the stars in the sky were still crying. The rest were tired of it. Every now and then, people looked expectantly at the sky hoping that somehow morning would come and the corpse could be set afloat in the Ganga.

Suddenly Bhagat called out, arriving at the door. Doctor Sahib thought that some patient had come. On any other day, he would've scolded that man but today he went outside. He saw an old man with a bent back and a shrivelled face. Even his eyebrows had turned grey. He was shivering as he leant on his stick. The doctor said with great humility, 'What is it, brother? We've been beset by such a misfortune today that it's impossible to say anything. Come at some other time. I may not be able to attend to any patient for the month or so.'

Bhagat said, 'I've already heard about it, Babuji. Therefore I've come. Where is *bhaiya*? Show him to me. God is almighty. He can bring corpses back to life. Who knows, He may still have mercy on us.'

Chaddha replied in agony, 'Come, see him; but it's been three or four hours since the bite. Whatever had to happen has already happened. Many

exorcists have already seen him and left.'

What hope could the Doctor Sahib have now! But he felt pity for the old man and took him inside. Bhagat observed the body for a minute. Then he smiled and said, 'All is not lost yet, Babuji! God willing, bhaiya will get up within half an hour. Don't be so disheartened. Just tell the Kahars to fill water.'

The Kahars started filling water and gave Kailash a bath. The pipes had been closed. More water was needed. There weren't enough Kahars so the guests chipped in and filled pitchers from the outlying wells. Mrinalini also joined them. Bhagat stood there, reading the mantra and smiling. It seemed like he was on the verge of victory. With every round of the mantra, he made Kailash smell a root. No one knew how many pots of water were poured on Kailash's head and how many times Bhagat blew the mantra over him. Eventually, when the sun began to rise in its reddish glory, Kailash opened his blood-red eyes. He stretched, and asked for water to drink. Dr Chaddha ran and clasped Narayani to his chest. Narayani fell at Bhagat's feet. Mrinalini stood before Kailash, wiping her tears, and asked, 'How do you feel now?'

In an instant, the news got around. Dr Chaddha's friends came to congratulate him. Doctor Sahib began to praise Bhagat before everyone. Everyone wanted to see Bhagat but when they went inside, Bhagat was nowhere to be found. The servant said, 'Just a moment ago he was sitting here and smoking. We wanted to give him tobacco but he didn't take it. He took some out of his own pocket and smoked.'

Everyone started looking for Bhagat but he was racing back home so he could reach before his wife woke up!

When the guests left, Doctor Sahib said to Narayani, 'I don't know why the old man disappeared. He didn't even smoke a chillum.'

Narayani said, 'I was going to give him a big amount of money.'

Chaddha replied, 'I couldn't recognize him last night but I did when day broke. Once, he had come with a patient. I remember now that I was going to play golf and so refused to see the patient. I can't say how wretched I feel about that now. I'll find him, fall at his feet and beg his forgiveness. I know

he won’t take anything. He deserves the highest praise. His goodness has provided me with an ideal that will remain before me throughout my life.’

Translated from the Hindi by M. Asaduddin



The Disappointment of Moteramji Shastri

1

Just as a barber is given the epithet of a thakur, a cobbler honoured as a chowdhary, and the sweeper is called a *jamadar*, Ghasitay, the provision-store owner, was also called *sethji* by the people around. Although he himself was illiterate, and could not tell the difference between the letters on a paper and a buffalo in the field, like other illiterate fathers, he too was bent on having his son anointed with education. After months of hard work, he was successful in teaching numbers up to one hundred to his son, but teaching him the alphabet required a master. He had been putting this matter off for months because of his miserliness, but today he had decided to conduct the *paati-puja* ceremony to formally initiate his son into learning. He had already found the auspicious moment for this. Talking to the *sethani*, his wife, he said, ‘This initiation will cost no less than one rupee!’

This angered the sethani, who said, ‘Why will it cost one rupee? Are we giving ourselves up to be looted? One rupee for just teaching a few letters! Who is the master?’

The seth told her, ‘I have been thinking of Moteramji. There are many other masters around, but Moteramji is different from the rest.’

Trying to cut corners, the sethani said, ‘What will he do with the money? Just offer him a bellyful of laddus.’

The seth tried to explain, ‘You think he will have any less than four rupees’ worth of laddus? If you follow my way, we will be done in only one rupee.’

So it was decided. The sethani bathed the boy, dressed him, made him wear auspicious golden wristbands, silver anklets and earrings, and put a kohl mark, a tika, on his forehead. The sethji too put on his kurta and tied his turban, and thrust his feet into his old shrivelled shoes after softening them with water. Seeing the father put on the shoes, the boy said that he too wanted shoes. Sethji was already concerned about spending that one rupee —now this new demand! Furious, he slapped the boy a few times and then set off for the master’s abode, forcefully dragging him along.

2

Worshipping the gods is always fruitful. So why would Pandit Moteram’s heartfelt wish not be fulfilled? He had connections not only with the gods but with their goddesses too! People often called him to their homes for purposes like getting him to declare the auspicious moments for various ceremonies, predicting their yearly fortune, writing horoscopes or reciting hymns to Goddess Durga. We cannot tell if Panditji was a hedonist or not, his girth was not of one, but Sona Devi, his wife, was not too pleased with such occasions and would warn him to be mindful of his health. Panditji was so soft-spoken, so light-hearted, and knew so many ways to charm women that no other pandit could have his way with Panditji around. It was for such reasons that Panditji was appointed a teacher in a school with a salary of thirty rupees a month.

The experiences Panditji had as a teacher were quite novel for him. Now he felt embarrassed accepting trivial invitations. The moment he reached the school, he would get reports of various ceremonies being held, such as a child’s paati-puja, or someone’s death anniversary, or a wedding. Panditji would send his sons as his proxies and assure himself that it was as if he himself were enjoying the feast. He had acquired the respect and position of a teacher at great cost, which is why, sometimes, out of frustration, he

would declare to his wife, ‘I will quit this job. Is this a job or a harsh punishment? If I am forced to eat only dal and roti, I will be dead in a few years. I have already lost so much of my health.’ But Sona Devi would somehow placate him. Now poor Moteram had to satiate his heart only with conversations that had delicious food as their subject. The only consolation was that he did not have to slog or do any work at school. Students of senior classes taught the students of junior classes. Panditji’s only job was to teach one student of the seniormost class and that student hardly ever troubled him.

When Ghasitay reached the school with his son riding on his shoulders, he found Panditji lying on a mattress with bolsters, having his chubby body massaged by his students. One young man was stroking his soles. Two were fanning him and another was massaging his head with oil. Even as he lay on the mattress, he was giving a lecture on poetry and literature, ‘Just as taste has six rasas, poetry has nine. Just as sweetness is the best among the rasas of taste, similarly, shringar is the best among the poetic rasas. Just as sweetness is found in many substances, shringar is associated with several heroines; and just as the motichur laddu is supreme among sweetmeats, similarly, among the heroines, Mugdha, the charming one, is supreme. I am charmed by that charming one!’ Suddenly, Ghasitay entered the room and bowed to Panditji in the traditional manner of *saashtaang dandavat* by completely prostrating himself on the floor.

Moteram blessed him, ‘Bless you! Bless you! What makes you come here? Is that the little seth with you?’

Ghasitay answered, ‘Yes, Maharaj, your servant in fact. I want to have his paati-puja ceremony done.’

Moteram agreed, ‘Of course, of course! By all means. There is nothing better than knowledge.’

Ghasitay said, ‘That is why I have come to you, Maharaj! Just bless him with a few letters.’

Moteram found his opening, ‘This requires the favours of the masters. You will have to incur some expenditure.’

Ghasitay agreed readily and said, ‘I am willing to spend, Maharaj!’

Moteram continued, ‘Yes, yes, I know. Listen, Chintamaniji, just do this for us. This is Seth Ghasitaymal. His son is to be initiated. On this auspicious occasion, he desires to honour the masters.’

Chintamani chimed in, ‘Great fortune! You are blessed! You are blessed! Creation survives only because of pious souls like him; or this earth would have collapsed into the underworld long ago. So, Sethji, how many Brahmins will you host for the feast?’

Moteram intervened, ‘You need not ask sethji this. You should speak to me. The number twelve is highly auspicious.’

Chintamani agreed with his superior, ‘Understood, Sethji? Make preparations for hosting twelve Brahmins.’

Moteram told Chintamani, ‘Make an estimate of the required things. Sethji is affluent—he is the son of Goddess Lakshmi himself. About ten *ser*s of *imarti* should be sufficient.’

Chintamani objected, ‘Ten sers! But I alone would need—’

Moteram rebuffed him, saying, ‘Dear friend! One should not speak unless required. Anyway, how much *kalakand*?’

Chintamani objected again, ‘You don’t even let me speak!’

Denying the accusation, Moteram said, ‘Not at all, not at all! You can express your views on this subject with absolute freedom.’

Chintamani declared enthusiastically, ‘Let there be forty sers of kalakand.’

Moteram refused to allow this, saying, ‘No, no, we cannot burden our client like this. Let there be ten sers of kalakand.’

Chintamani was now beginning to feel frustrated. He questioned, ‘Then why do you even ask me? What kind of behaviour is this? Whenever we land a prey, you—’

Moteram cautioned him, ‘You should not be so fiery without cause. It takes great experience to be able to manage such difficult deeds. How much motichur laddu do you think we’ll need?’

Chintamani threw a tantrum, ‘I don’t know anything!’

Moteram tried to placate him, saying, ‘Don’t be upset, dear friend! I swear this time I will accept the quantity that you want.’

Without meaning it, Chintamani said, ‘A ser then.’

Moteram chided him, ‘What a great fool you are, dear friend! It does not behove a man of your kindness to insult a food item that is difficult even for the gods to obtain. Let there be twenty sers of it.’

Thus, they decided on a menu between themselves and explained its details to sethji. They also proposed an auspicious donation of one rupee each. Poor Ghasitay was befuddled when he heard this menu; he had had reservations about spending even one rupee! He pleaded, ‘This is more than what I can afford.’

Moteram ignored the plea, ‘Do not say that, O son of Lakshmi, do not say that. The Almighty has given you everything. Your son is a great soul. He will bring fame to your clan. So it is decided that all the great men will arrive by eight o’clock.’

Ghasitay tried to argue, ‘Maharaj, I’m very . . .’

Cutting him short, Moteram said, ‘Of course, of course. It ought to make you very happy. Where scholars and Brahmins set foot, that place becomes like heaven.’

Finally, Ghasitay gave up, ‘Maharaj, I feel incapable of saying anything. You know how my shop is. The sales too are low these days . . .’

Moteram assured him, ‘This sacred act will wash away all your pain and poverty. Serving the learned is itself like the tree of bounty. Make preparations for it to be early in the day. We will not be late.’

Poor Ghasitay could not say anything after this. Moteram, however, was sure that he had convinced Ghasitay, and went on to resume his lecture.

3

At the appointed hour, when people started off for the feast, they found it difficult to contain their pleasure. To bring the number of diners to an auspicious twelve, they took along four students from the school. It was decided that they would walk to Ghasitay’s house singing Vedic mantras. Shastriji had trained his students so well that anybody who visited the school was charmed by the music and became a follower of the school.

Shastriji had acquired quite a bit of fame through this stratagem. Even now, people in the street stood up in respect when they heard the students singing. An observer remarked, ‘This procession proves the power of Shastriji.’

Another said, ‘Great! Since Shastriji has joined, the school’s fortune has really turned around.’

Just as they turned the corner to Ghasitay’s house, Moteram said to Chintamani, ‘Just see if there is some illumination around.’

Chintamani looked around and informed him, ‘I can’t see any light.’

Moteram rebuffed him, saying, ‘Of course it is there. It is you who cannot see. There is a gas lantern lit. Can you hear any conversation?’

Chintamani, though, stuck to his observation, ‘Who knows! It’s all quiet.’

Moteram was still not convinced. ‘You fool! I can clearly hear people’s conversation, and lo, we have arrived! I really want to run and rush in. Just as a lover in the pain of separation becomes impatient when he finds the beloved near him, my heart too is becoming impatient. But what is this? It is actually quiet here. Maybe he is inside.’

Chintamani asked, ‘Should I knock on the door? But this place is locked!’

Moteram inquired from a shopkeeper next door, who informed him, ‘They were home till last evening at least. Can’t say about now. Just look, they must be at home.’

Pandit Moteram knocked on the door so vigorously that it shook the entire house, but there was no reply from inside.

Algoo offered, ‘Should I break the lock?’

Moteram declined the offer, saying, ‘No, no, don’t break the lock. Perhaps he has gone to the market to buy provisions.’

Both the pandits went ahead and sat outside the house. The students just strolled around. An hour passed by in this manner. Frustrated, Chintamani said, ‘I think this rascal has conned us.’

Moteram agreed, saying, ‘Right. Now I too suspect that.’

Chintamani was now seething with rage. ‘If only I could find that rascal, I would wring his neck. Scoundrel! Listen, you, Ghasitay, you Baniya, you

seller of provisions! Come out! Where have you hidden your face?'

Taking the cue, all the students started yelling and calling Ghasitay names like rascal, sinner and low-caste.

Algoo declared, 'This rogue has a blackened face!'

Chintamani cursed, 'God willing, he will be ruined!'

Bhawani cursed more, 'When he dies, he will be reborn as a mule!'

Algoo landed the final blow, 'The rogue will become a donkey and will only go around braying!'

Moteram sat in silence through all this. His head was lowered out of anger, shame and self-loathing. Finally, he rose slowly and said, 'We should go now.'

Algoo offered, 'Should I set this house on fire?'

Bhawani suggested that they should pelt stones.

Moteram dissuaded them, 'No, child. This is not a Brahmin's character. God will punish him for his lowly conduct. I have forgiven him.'

Even as he said this, his eyes welled up and tears streamed from them. Never in his life had he been shamed like this.

Chintamani tried to placate him, 'Brother, you have no need to be disheartened. You should have been placating us. Instead, you yourself are crying now. Whatever God has destined for us is bound to happen. But you will see, this will be avenged sooner rather than later.'

Wiping his tears, Moteram said, 'What will be avenged, friend? This wound will never heal. How unfortunate we are that we look towards others for our food! At this moment, what my heart wants is that even if I were to die, I would never turn towards that school. The life of a being who cannot acquire his favourite food through his own efforts is worthless. The way I have supplicated the authorities, the way I have sung the praises of rich men, if only I had devoted half that effort to anything else, I would have been a successful man. Today, this cunning Ghasitay has opened my eyes.'

Chintamani wondered, 'Let's see how Sona Bhabhi reacts to this.'

Moteram now told him of his own condition, 'My legs are already shaking. To tell you the truth, I am so embarrassed that I can't show my face anywhere. Sona is going to kill me today!'

Translated from the Hindi by Vikas Jain



Foolish Friend

1

A bird had laid her eggs above the cornice in Keshav's house. Keshav and his sister, Shyama, closely watched the bird coming and going. Rubbing their eyes in the morning, they eagerly approached the cornice. What delight the children found seeing the bird couple sitting there! They even forgot their milk and jalebis. Myriad questions arose in their hearts. How large would the eggs be? What colour? How many? What did they eat? How would babies come out of the eggs? How would the babies' wings sprout? How did the nest feel? But there was no one to answer these questions. Amma wasn't free from the household chores and Babuji could not spare any time from his reading and writing. Both children contented their hearts by questioning and answering each other.

Shyama asked, 'Brother! Would the nestlings fly immediately after coming out of the eggs?'

Keshav replied in a knowledgeable way, 'No, stupid! First the wings will come out. How can the poor babies fly without wings?'

'What will the poor mother feed them with?'

Keshav was unable to answer this difficult question.

Three or four days passed. The children's excitement grew day by day. They were desperate to see the eggs. They conjectured, 'The babies would

definitely have come out by now.' Now the question of the babies' food arose. How will the poor mother find so much food to fill the bellies of all her babies? The poor babies will die peeping and cheeping of hunger. Anticipating this calamity, they decided that they would put some food over the cornice. Thrilled, Shyama said, 'Then the birds need not go to and fro for food?'

'No, they wouldn't have to.'

'But, Bhaiya, won't the nestlings get hot in the sun?'

This problem had not occurred to Keshav.

'It will definitely be a problem. Won't they start feeling uncomfortably thirsty because they don't have a shade over them?'

In the end, they decided to put up a roof of cloth over the nest. And they both agreed to place a cup of water and a small amount of rice near it.

Both children worked enthusiastically. In order to avoid her mother's eye, Shyama got the rice out of the pot stealthily. Keshav spilled the oil from the stone cup on the floor and, after cleaning it thoroughly, filled it with water.

Now where could they get the cloth for the roof and how would the cloth stay without the support of sticks and how would the sticks stand?

For a long time Keshav was in a state of confusion. At last he solved this problem too. He said to Shyama, 'Go and bring the dust basket. Don't show it to Ammaji.'

'But it has a hole in the middle. Won't sunshine pass through it?'

Keshav said irritably, 'Just bring the basket. I'll find a way to cover up the hole.'

Shyama ran to get the basket. Keshav poked some paper into it to cover up the hole and then, hanging the basket on a branch, said, 'See! Just like that I will screen the nest—now how can the sunshine come in?' Shyama thought, *How smart my brother is!*

2

It was summer. Father had gone to office. Mother had fallen asleep after putting her children to bed. But today how could sleep come to the

children's eyes! To please their mother both of them held their breath and feigned sleep with closed eyes, just waiting for an opportunity. The moment they felt that Mother was sleeping soundly, both of them rose quietly and slowly opened the bolt of the door and ran outside. The preparations for the protection of the eggs had begun.

Keshav brought a stool from the room. But when the stool alone did not work, he brought the bathing seat and placed it below the stool and climbed on to it fearfully.

Shyama was holding the stool with both hands. Under his weight its uneven legs made it unstable. Only Keshav's heart knew the immense anxiousness he had to tolerate at that time. He grabbed the cornice with both hands and scolded Shyama in a low voice, 'Hold it firmly, otherwise I will pummel you when I get down.' But poor Shyama was absorbed by the cornice. Time and again Shyama lost her concentration and loosened her grip. Both birds flew away the moment Keshav set his hand on the cornice. Keshav saw a few pieces of straw spread on the cornice and three eggs lying on it. The nest was not like any of those nests that he had seen in trees.

Shyama asked from below, 'Are there babies, Bhaiya?'

'There are three eggs; the babies have not come out yet.'

'Show them to me. How big are they?'

'I'll show you. First bring some pieces of cloth so that I can spread them here. The poor eggs are lying on some straw.'

Shyama went running to get her old dhoti, and tore a piece out of it. Keshav took the cloth and, after folding it multiple times, made a cushion out of it and spread it on the straw. Then he placed the three eggs slowly on it.

Shyama asked again, 'Bhaiya, show me too.'

'I'll show you, but before that, give me that basket to shade the birds.'

Shyama handed the basket from below and said, 'Now come down, let me also see.'

Hanging the basket on one of the branches, Keshav said, 'Go! Get the food and the cup for water. I'll show you once I come down.'

Shyama brought the rice and cup as well.

Keshav placed both things under the basket and descended slowly.

Shyama pleaded, ‘Bhaiya, now help me climb the stool as well.’

‘You will fall down.’

‘I won’t fall down. You will be holding the stool from below.’

‘No dear, mother will make chutney out of me if you fall down. She will say that I made you climb up. What difference does it make if you see? The eggs are lying very comfortably. When the babies come out, we will take care of them together.’

The two birds would come to the cornice again and again but then fly away without sitting there. Keshav thought they were probably not sitting out of fear. He lifted the stool and put it in the room. The bathing seat was also put away.

Shyama’s eyes brimmed with tears. ‘You didn’t show me. I’ll tell mother.’

‘I am warning you, if you tell mother I will bash you up.’

‘Then why didn’t you show me?’

‘If you had fallen, your head would have been smashed into four pieces.’

‘So what? You just see—I’ll tell her.’

In the meantime, the door of the closet opened and mother, shielding her eyes from the sun, said, ‘When did you both come out? Haven’t I told you not to go out in the afternoon? Who opened the door’s shutter?’

The shutter had been opened by Keshav but Shyama didn’t tell her mother. She was afraid that her brother would be beaten. Keshav’s heart was trembling—what if Shyama opened her mouth because he had not shown her the eggs? He didn’t trust Shyama. Was Shyama quiet because of her love for her brother or because of her complicity in the crime? Perhaps both the things were true.

After a good scolding, mother took them inside and then slowly started fanning them. It was only two o’clock. A strong wind was howling outside. Both children fell asleep.

Suddenly, at four o'clock, Shyama's eyes opened and she saw that the shutter of the door was open. Running, she went to the cornice and started looking up. The basket was not in sight. And then she suddenly looked down and ran into the room and shouted, 'Bhaiya, the eggs are lying on the floor, the nestlings have flown!"

Worried, Keshav went outside running to find all three eggs lying smashed on the floor. A lime-like substance had come out of them. The cup of water was lying broken on one side.

The colour of Keshav's face changed. He searched the ground with fearful eyes. Shyama asked, 'Bhaiya, where have the babies flown?'

Keshav said apologetically, 'The eggs have broken.'

'And where have the babies gone?'

'In your head! Can't you see the white water that has come out of the eggs? This is what would have developed into babies in two or four days.'

Taking a stick in her hand, their mother asked, 'What are you both doing in the sun?'

Shyama replied, 'Mother, the bird's eggs are lying broken.'

The mother, seeing the broken eggs, said angrily, 'You two must have touched the eggs.'

Now Shyama didn't feel a bit of sympathy for her brother. He must have placed the eggs in such a way that they'd fallen down. He had to be punished for this and she said, 'Ammaji, he fiddled with the eggs.'

Mother asked Keshav, 'Did you?' Keshav just stood there like a wet cat.

'How did you reach up there?'

'Ammaji, he climbed up placing the stool over the bathing seat.'

'Were you not standing there holding the stool?'

'He told me to.'

'At your age how could you know that the eggs of birds get dirty if somebody touches them? After that the bird never incubates them.'

Shyama asked, scared, 'Amma, did the mother drop the eggs?'

'What else could she do? The blame is on Keshav's shoulders! Oh! Oh! Oh! The wicked boy took three lives.'

Keshav was on the verge of tears, ‘Ammaji, I only kept the eggs on the cushion.’ That made the mother smile.

For many days Keshav felt sorry for his mistake. Instead of protecting the eggs, he had destroyed them. He would cry whenever he remembered the incident. The two birds were never seen again.

Translated from the Urdu by Shaifta Ayoub



Two Friends

1

Lucknow
1-7-1925

Dear Friend,

Ever since I have come here, I have been missing you. How nice and pleasant it would be if you could come here for a few days. I would then introduce you to my Vinod. Can it not be possible? Will your parents not allow you even this bit of freedom? What surprises me is how you can accept these chains and do nothing about it! I could not live like that even for an hour. I thank God that my father is not among those who cannot give up the old ways. In fact, he is a follower of the new ideals which have improved the life of women immensely. I would have been destroyed otherwise.

Vinod has recently returned from England after completing his DPhil and wants to tour the world before settling down. He has already seen most parts of Europe but he will not rest until he has toured America, Australia and Asia. He is particularly interested in Central Asia and China. His aim is to investigate those aspects of these countries that have been overlooked by European travellers. I tell you truly, Chanda, that I have never seen such a

brave, fearless and idealistic man. I feel amazed when I listen to him talking. There is no discipline that he does not know comprehensively or which he cannot critique. And this criticism is not bookish but new and original. He is an unmatched votary of independence. Which woman would not think herself fortunate to be his wife? Friend, now how do I tell you the condition of my heart when I see him walking towards my bungalow in the morning? My heart longs to sacrifice itself for him. He resides in my soul. The way I had imagined my husband to be—there is not an iota of difference between him and that image. I worry all the time about him finding some fault with me. I study till midnight the subjects that he is interested in. I have never laboured so hard. I never had such a liking for dressing up, nor did I ever learn by heart epigrams with such enthusiasm. If, even after doing so much, I am unable to claim his heart, then, dear friend, my life shall be destroyed, my heart shall break, and the world shall have no attraction for me.

Along with the feeling of love, also arises the sentiment of jealousy. When my neighbour Kusum comes to the veranda as she sees him walking towards my bungalow, my heart wishes for her to go blind. Yesterday, it was almost a disaster. Just as Vinod saw her, he took off his hat and smiled. That slut also started flashing her teeth! May God send us any crisis He wishes, but save us from false pride. She looks like a witch but thinks herself to be a fairy. She writes poems and has even published them in many magazines. That has gone to her head. I tell you truly that for a while I lost my reverence for Vinod. There was such a surge of passion that I wanted to scratch her face out. The only solace was that there was no conversation between them, but when Vinod came in to sit, I could not say anything for half an hour, as if his words had lost their magic, as if his voice had lost its appeal. Since then, my heart has been restless. I could not sleep all night, the same scene kept flashing before my eyes. On many occasions, I have wanted to embarrass Kusum. Chanda, till this day, I was not aware that my heart was so weak. If I did not fear that Vinod would think of me as lowly and small, I would have clearly expressed my feelings to him. I want to belong completely to him and make him completely mine. I firmly

believe that even if the most handsome youth in the world presented himself to me, I would not so much as look at him. Why does Vinod's heart not have the same sentiment for me?

Chanda, dear friend, come over for a week. My heart is pining to meet you. I really need your advice and sympathy in this hour of crisis. This is the weakest moment of my life. It is the next few days that will decide my fate either way—success or decimation. Lo! It's already seven o'clock and I haven't combed my hair yet. This is the time for Vinod's visit. I will take your leave now. I wonder if that cursed Kusum will come to her veranda today as well. My heart is beating already. Yesterday, I took solace in telling myself that she might have smiled just like that. If I see the same scene today, I will not be able to placate myself so easily.

Yours,
Padma

2

Gorakhpur
5-7-1925

Dear Padma,

Great that you remembered me, even if it is after ages. I was thinking you might have passed on to the next world! This is the callousness for which Kusum in fact is punishing you. The college closed on 15th April and you have written the letter on 1st July: a full two and a half months later. That too because of Kusum. I bless the Kusum you are cursing. If she had not troubled you like a grievous ache, would you have even thought of me? Anyhow, the picture that you have drawn of Vinod is quite attractive and I pray to God that the day soon arrives when I will meet him as a brother-in-law. But see to it that you do not go for a civil marriage. The wedding must be according to the Hindu custom. You do have the right to keep away the hundreds of meaningless and frivolous dresses, but do call a real learned

pandit, not because he can make you pay money on every useless occasion, but to ensure that everything is conducted as prescribed in the scriptures.

All right, now it's your turn to ask me why I was silent for all these months. There have been five weddings in my family in the past two and a half months. There was a lot of hustle and bustle. There was hardly a day when there were less than a hundred guests here, and the number would shoot up to five hundred on the wedding day. All these five girls are younger than me and, if I had my way, I would not speak of my marriage for at least another three or four years, but who listens to me! However, when I think about it, I feel it is not out of order for parents to hurry when it comes to their daughters' marriages. Life has no guarantees. Who is to take care of the marriage if the parents pass away before their time? And how can one rely on the brothers? If parents leave behind a lot of wealth, then it is all right, but the way it usually happens is that the father leaves behind a loan, and the girls seem like a burden to the brothers. Like many other Hindu customs, this too is an economic issue. And this custom cannot be eradicated until our economic lot improves.

Now it is my turn at the sacrificial altar. In fifteen days, this home will turn alien to me. Even when I visit for a few months, I will be like a guest in this house. My 'Vinod' is from Benares. He is currently studying law. His father is a famous lawyer. I hear that they are lords of several villages, own several houses and are respectable people. I have not seen the groom yet. Father had asked me if he should request the groom to visit. But I declined saying that there is no need for it. Who wants to act the daughter-in-law in one's own house? It is anyway a matter of fate. Neither father nor I can look into anyone's heart. If I had seen him once or twice or met him . . . so what? Could we have judged each other? This is not possible in any way. At the most, we can inspect each other's appearance. Regarding this, I am sure, father is no less capable than me. Though my two older brothers-in-law may not be the epitomes of handsomeness, no beautiful woman can dislike them. My sisters are happily living out their lives with them. Then why should father do injustice only to me? I do accept that in our society, there are some people whose married lives are not happy, but then, which

society in the world does not have unhappy people? And it is not always the men's fault. A lot of the times, the women too are venomous. I consider marriage as a vow of service and sacrifice, and welcome it with the same sentiment. I don't want to take you away from your Vinod, but if you can come by 20th July, just for a few days, I will be happy. As the day for the vows approaches, I feel strange misgivings in my heart. But how can you, yourself sick with love, cure me? Do come, dear!

Yours,
Chanda

3

Mussoorie
5-8-1925

Dear Chanda,

I have hundreds of things to write. Don't know where to begin. First of all, I seek your pardon for not being able to attend the auspicious occasion of your wedding. I had decided to come. How could I not go to my dear Chanda's wedding! But just three days before that, Vinod so captivated me by surrendering himself to me that I lost sense of everything. Ah! The warm, surging and trembling words issuing from the deepest seat of love in his heart still echo in my ears. I was standing, and there Vinod was, kneeling before me—an icon of inspiration, tenderness and appeal. Such an occasion comes only once in a lifetime, but its sweet memory permeates every fibre of one's being, just like some heavenly music. You cannot experience that pleasure. I started crying. I can't express the emotions that welled up in my heart. A flood of tears flowed from my eyes. Perhaps this is the ultimate limit of pleasure. I had become somewhat hopeless. For a few days, I had observed Vinod talking casually to Kusum. Every day Kusum would show up decorated with new jewellery, and how do I tell you, one day Vinod recited to me one of Kusum's poems, and he went over each

and every word. Proud that I am, I thought for what benefit should I wrack my brains over him when he seems to be falling over himself for that witch! Next day, when he came in the morning, I sent word that I was unwell. When he insisted on meeting me, I had to come out to the room to see him. I had pledged in my heart that I will clearly tell him not to visit any more, that I was not suitable for him. I am not a poet, I am not wise, I am not erudite. A whole speech was waiting to be blurted out. But dear, I cannot describe that surging emotion I felt when I went into the room and saw Vinod's thirsty eyes, and his lips trembling with a violent yearning. He did not wait for me to sit. He kneeled on the floor in front of me and his wistful, delirious words made my heart waver.

A week passed by in preparations. There was no limit to father's and uncle's happiness.

And Kusum was the happiest! The same Kusum whose face I detested! Now I knew what a grave injustice I had done by suspecting her. Her heart is guileless. She has no jealousy. No thirst. Service is the fundamental substance of her life. I do not know how I would have spent these seven days without her. I was so lost that I had left everything to Kusum. Her knowledge is impeccable when it comes to selecting and designing ornaments, and dyeing and tailoring clothes. On the eighth day, when she dressed me as a bride, I was shocked at how I looked. I have never considered myself so beautiful. My eyes looked intoxicated with pride.

That very evening, Vinod and I became one, inseparable, like the confluence of two separately flowing rivers. Preparations for the honeymoon had already been made. In the morning, we left for Mussoorie. Kusum came to the station to see us off and cried a lot when we parted. I wanted to take her along but I don't know why she didn't agree.

There is no doubt that Mussoorie is quite idyllic. Wreaths of dark clouds rest on mountain peaks and cool winds play on the heartstrings, but I firmly believe that I would be equally happy with Vinod even in a desolate forest. Now that I have him, I do not desire anything else. You, dear, perhaps cannot even imagine such a pleasant life. In the morning, breakfast is duly served, after which the carriage is brought. By nine o'clock, we are out for

an excursion. Either we sit by a waterfall and listen to its sweet music, or we sit on a rock and look at the heavenly games that the clouds play. We return by eleven o'clock. By then, lunch is ready. After lunch, I play the piano. Vinod loves music. Though he himself sings very well, he starts dancing when I sing. In the afternoon, we rest for an hour and then go out to play or watch a game. At night, we go to the theatre after dinner and, after returning from there, we go to bed. Here, there are no reprimands from the mother-in-law or the gossip and taunts of the sisters-in-law. But even in this happiness, sometimes I have a suspicion. Is there a thorn hiding somewhere in this bloom? Is there darkness behind this light? I do not understand why I have this suspicion. Arré, it's already five o'clock! Vinod is ready to go out. Today we are going to watch a tennis match. I should get ready quickly. Will write the rest later.

Oh, I almost forgot one thing. Do write to me about your wedding. How is your husband? What does he look like? Are you at your in-laws' or still at your parents' house? If you have been to your in-laws' house, do write about your experiences there. Surely you must have been paraded a lot. The women in the house, clan, and the mohalla must have lifted your veil to see your face and examine you thoroughly. Write in detail. Let's see when we meet again.

Yours,
Padma

4

Gorakhpur
1-9-1925

Dear Padma,

Your letter gave much solace to my heart. When you did not come, I understood that Vinod Babu must have swept you off your feet, but didn't know that you had reached Mussoorie. Of course, why would you think of

poor Chanda amidst all that revelry! Now I understand the difference between the old and new ideals of marriage. You followed your discretion and so you are happy. I submitted to popular prejudices and am now cursing my fate.

Okay, now listen to me. Although I think nothing of the pomp of dowry and gift-giving, father, of course, is very large-hearted. He must have given a handsome dowry. But my trial by fire began the moment the wedding party arrived here. How anxious I was to see the groom! But how could I? Would that not shame the family? The wedding party arrived and the entire world surrounded the groom. I thought I could see him from the terrace. So I climbed up but from there too I could not see anything, though of course, mother did reprimand me for this crime. Anything about me that they don't like gets blamed on my education. Poor father, though, sympathizes with me a lot, but how many tongues can he hold back? The welcome ritual happened very quickly and then preparations for the rituals to solemnize the marriage began. From the groom's side came a big platter full of clothes and jewellery. How do I tell you what happened, dear! Everybody in the house—men and women—fell upon it as if they had never seen anything like it before. Someone pointed out that the gorget was missing and another cried for a necklace! Amma actually started crying, as if I had been sacrificed. Everybody openly criticized the groom's side. But I did not even look at the jewellery. But yes, whenever anybody said anything about the groom, I listened to it wholeheartedly. I gathered that he was slim, dusky, had large eyes, and possessed quite a jolly temperament. Such news only made my desire to see him stronger. As the moment for the wedding ritual drew nearer, my heart grew more and more restless. Although I had not even seen his face till now, I was feeling an unprecedented love for him. I would have gone crazy with love if someone told me that his enemies had been decimated. So far I have not come face-to-face with him, nor have I heard his voice, but even the most handsome man in this world has no attraction for me now. Now, he means the world to me.

The rituals were conducted after midnight. The holy fire was in front of me, with priests on either of it. An earthen lamp had been lit, and the clan

deity's icon was also there. Mantras from the Vedas were being chanted. At that moment, I felt as if God himself was present there. Fire, air, lamp, and the stars—all seemed to have been illuminated by the light of the godhead. For the first time, I experienced a spiritual uplift. When I bowed to the fire, I was not playing out an empty ritual; instead, I was actually seeing the fire god right before me, shining with a heavenly radiance. Finally, even the rituals were concluded, but there was still no sign of the groom.

My last hope was that I would be able to see him in the morning when he was called in for breakfast. Then he would not be wearing the *maur*, the groom's headgear. I planned to go in with my friends and look at him to my heart's content. But I did not know that Fate was hatching different plans for me altogether. What I saw in the morning was this: the tents pitched for the wedding party were being pulled down.

It was really a trivial matter. Only that the food sent for their breakfast was not enough. Perhaps the ghee too was spoilt. You know how my father is. Has never given in to anybody. Has always lived like a lion. He declared, 'Let them go if they want to. There is no need to placate them. Sure, it is the duty of the bride's folks to welcome the wedding party, but it does not mean that the groom's party gets to resort to hectoring and threatening, as if it is the camp of some officer. If they can get their son married elsewhere, I too can get my daughter married.'

The wedding party left and I had not even seen my husband! It became the talk of the town. Our enemies got an opportunity to mock us. Father had collected a lot of things. All of it was wasted. Everybody in the house is speaking ill of my in-laws, saying things like those people are rude, greedy, ruffians, etc. I do not mind it at all, though at the same time, I do not want to hear a word against my husband! One day Ammaji said, 'The boy too is a fool. It's not like he is a child any more. He studies law. Has grown his beard. He should have reasoned with his father. But he too acted like a coward.' I was very upset when I heard this. I didn't say anything but it became clear to Ammaji that I did not agree with her on this. I ask you, sister, what was his duty then, given the situation? Would it not have been insulting to his father and relatives if he had not sided with them? That

time, he did exactly what was appropriate. But I do believe that he will surely return once the matter cools down a bit. I am already waiting for him. Whenever the postman comes, my heart starts beating. Is there a letter from him? I repeatedly think of writing him a letter, but then I hesitate. Perhaps I will never be able to write to him. It's not pride, but only hesitation. But yes, if there is no letter from him in the next few days or if he does not come himself, then this hesitation will turn into pride. Can you not write a letter to him? Probably everything will be all right then. Will you not do even this for me? But for God's sake, do not write in that letter that I beseeched you to write it. Forgive me, I am being unfair to you by suspecting you of such a cheap mistake. But then, have I ever been wise?

Yours,
Chanda

5

Mussoorie
20-9-1925

Dear Chanda,

I posted a letter to Kashi within one day of receiving your letter. I have not received a reply yet. He has probably written to you instead. He is a man of old ways. I would not have been able to live with him even for a day. But you can. If my husband had behaved in such a manner—getting angry without a reason—I would not see his face all my life. Even if he ever came to me on his own, I would shoo him away like a dog. The first claim on a man is his wife's. He cannot insult his wife just to please his parents. Your in-laws have behaved in an abominable way. People of the old ways have quite an audacity to say such things. Now you see the result of that custom which you praised so much. That wall is rotten. Only patchwork will not do. It needs to be built anew from scratch.

Okay, now listen to some of my story. I now suspect that Vinod has cheated me. His financial condition is not what I had thought it to be. He had put up this act only to deceive me. The car was a borrowed one, the bungalow's rent has yet to be paid and the furniture was also on hire. It's true, though, he did not cheat me openly. He never bragged about his wealth, but taking on a lifestyle which makes others think that he is a rich man is also a kind of deception. This act was put up only so that some prey could be trapped. Now I see that Vinod keeps trying to hide his real lot from me. He does not let me see his letters. He gets startled when anyone comes to see him and asks the servant, in a troubled tone, Who has come to visit? You are aware that I am not a slut for money. All I want is a pure heart. One who has manhood, one who has talent, will surely become rich. If not today, then tomorrow. It is this game of deception that makes me wince. If Vinod tells me of his problems, I will sympathize with him. I will help him overcome those troubles. By hiding things from me, not only does he lose my sympathy and help, he is also sowing the seeds of mistrust, malice and disappointment in my heart. This anxiety is killing me. If he had told me of his condition clearly, why would I then come to Mussoorie at all? Lucknow is not so hot that people will go mad there. Why would we have then wasted thousands of rupees? The toughest problem is that of livelihood. Applications have been sent to many schools, and we are waiting for them to reply. Perhaps he will find a position somewhere by the end of this month. In the beginning, the pay will be around three or four hundred. I wonder how we will make do with that. Even father used to give me a hundred and fifty rupees for college expenses. It is a matter of greater worry as to what he will do if he does not find a job in another five or ten months. The trouble is that Vinod keeps all this hidden from me. If only we could sit together and discuss it, we could untie all the knots. But perhaps he does not think that I am capable enough for this. Perhaps he thinks that I am a silken doll only to be adorned with a variety of jewellery, perfumes and robes of silk. If there is a new play at the theatre, he comes running to inform me. If there is a function or a game somewhere, or if we have to go for an excursion, I am informed of these without delay and with great

happiness, as if I only want to indulge in pleasure and play all the time and there is no sombre side to my heart. This is an insult to me. A grave insult, which I cannot tolerate any more. I can only be satisfied when I have my full rights. Enough for now! Rest for later. Write in detail about the situation at your end. I worry about you as much as I do for myself. Let us see where our paths meet. You are sailing in your five-thousand-year-old tattered swadeshi boat. I am in my new, fast-paced motorboat. Opportunity, science and industry are on my side. But if a divine bolt hits me, I will sink with this boat itself. Every year thousands of people die by coming under the train. Still no one travels by the bullock cart any more. The spread of the railways only keeps widening. That's it!

Yours,
Padma

6

Gorakhpur
25-9-1925

Dear Padma,

I received your letter yesterday and I am replying today itself. You, on the other hand, take months to write back. In this matter, you should learn from me. You are needlessly accusing Vinod Babu. Did you not inquire about his financial condition beforehand? Did you just see a handsome, jolly, decent and soft-spoken man and jump with happiness? This is your fault. Prove by your behaviour and lifestyle that you have a serious side, and then let's see how Vinod Babu hides things from you. And dear, this is nothing but human nature. Everybody wants to be seen as being rich. Every effort is made to keep up the act till the very end, and one who is successful at it is the one considered to have had a successful life. In an era when wealth is supreme, when dignity, glory, fame and even knowledge can be bought with money, it is only natural to put up such a masquerade. But do remember

that claims to success are nothing without merit. Try and understand it as the relationship between the flower and its fruit. Claims can bear fruition only if there is merit in the first place.

This lecture aside, let me offer you my heartfelt thanks. The letter that you wrote to my husband had a great effect. Within five days, I got a kind letter from him. Dear, you cannot imagine the happiness I felt when I received the letter. It was as if the blind could suddenly see. I was prancing all over the house. There was utter mayhem in the house! You would have found the letter utterly disappointing but it was a new lease of life, a beacon of hope for me. The lord of my life expressed regret at the behaviour of the wedding party, but also said that he could not raise his voice against his elders. It is also true that the hosts did not exactly extend the hospitality that was due to a wedding party. Finally he wrote, 'Dear, I fail to express the yearning I have to see you. Your imagined visage flashes before my eyes every day. But it is my duty to respect the honour of the family. Until the parents give their consent, I cannot come. Even if my life ebbs away from me in your separation, I cannot ignore my father's word. Despite this, I have made one firm resolution. That even if the entire world goes topsy-turvy, even if they call me a *kapoot,* a dishonourable son, even if father gets angry, even if I have to leave this house, I will not marry again. But as far as I understand, the matter won't stretch to this extent. These people will soften in a few days and then I will come and carry the lady of my heart on my eyelids!'

That's it, dear! Now I am happy. I don't need anything else! My lord favours me so much. What more can he do? My lord! Your Chanda shall forever be yours! Your command is her duty! She will be at your feet as long as she lives! Don't forget her!

Sister, my eyes are welling up. Can't write any more. Reply soon.

Yours,
Chanda

Delhi
15-12-1925

Dear Sister,

I beg pardon at your feet. It is not that I was too lazy or too busy travelling around to write to you. Every day I would think of writing you a letter, but then something or the other would come up, some trouble would present itself, and my heart would become disturbed, and then all I would be able to do was stretch out on the bed with my face down. If you see me now, you might not even recognize me. It has been a month since we came from Mussoorie to Delhi. Vinod has found a job here for three hundred rupees a month. This entire month passed by in scouting the market for a job. Vinod has given me complete freedom. I can do whatever I want, he doesn't care. It's almost as if he is my guest. He has entrusted me with all the responsibilities of the household, without taking on any himself. I have never known such a careless man. He is never around, and does not even come for dinner. If I call him, he joins me, otherwise he just keeps sitting in his room. As for the servants, it is as if he has sworn that he will never speak to them. I am the one who hires, reprimands or dismisses them. As if it is none of his concern. What I want is for him to criticize my decisions, find fault with them. When I get something from the market, he should tell me if I have been cheated or if I have made a good bargain. What I want is that we should argue a lot while preparing the monthly budget. But all these wishes go unfulfilled. I don't understand to what extent a woman can successfully manage a household in this manner. Vinod's absolute surrender has not left any room for my own needs. I feel bad about buying things that I delight in on my own. I do know that he will not be angry if I buy anything for myself. In fact, I am sure he will be happy. But my heart wants *him* to get me things I enjoy. The pleasure that is there in receiving these things from him is just not there in getting them on my own. Father still gives me the monthly allowance of one hundred rupees and I spend it the way I want. But I don't know why I fear that Vinod might think I am

squandering his money. A man who doesn't get upset about anything cannot be happy about anything either. I fail to understand what makes him happy and what upsets him. My condition is like that of a man who just wanders around without knowing his way. You may remember the excitement with which we used to check the answer to a math problem that we had solved. What a heartfelt joy it was to know that our solution matched the one provided in the book. We then believed our effort to have been successful. The math books that only had problems but no solutions—we did not feel like attempting questions from such books. We used to think that our effort would go to waste. Now I solve questions every day, but I do not know if my solution is right or wrong. Just think what my heart goes through in such a situation.

About a week ago, I ran into Miss Rigg from Lucknow. She is a lady doctor and visits me quite often. It struck me that I should invite Miss Rigg home and I did. When Papa was a professor at the medical college, he had taught this Miss Rigg. She is still grateful for it. Not inviting her for a meal despite having seen her here would have been rude. Miss Rigg accepted the invitation. I cannot explain the difficulties I faced that day. I had never eaten at a table with the English. I know absolutely nothing about their dining ways. I had assumed that Vinod would tell me everything. He had lived in England among the English for years. I even told him of Miss Rigg's visit, but it was as if that great man never heard it. I also resolved not to ask him for anything. At the most, Miss Rigg would make fun of it. Fair enough! I was angry with myself for having invited her. In the nearby bungalows, there are several families like ours. I could have solicited their advice. But I hesitated, thinking that they would consider me an oaf. I even cried at my helplessness. Finally, when I was totally disheartened, I did what I thought fit. Next day, Miss Rigg came over. Both of us sat at the table. The meal began. I noticed that Vinod made several mistakes and Miss Rigg also turned up her nose. This made it amply clear that the norms of etiquette were being violated. I was dying of embarrassment. Somehow the ordeal got over. It was then that I resolved that I would never invite any Englishman over. He probably believes that I have embarrassed him. I

believe rather that I am the insulted party. To tell you the truth, Chanda, these household worries do not leave me with any occasion to banter or laugh with anybody. Also, it has been months since I read any new book. Vinod, whose name itself means amusement, does not look jolly any more. Now he does not even speak of going to the theatre or the cinema, but he does agree to go if I want to. I want him to propose the idea, I should only confirm it. Perhaps he is trying to get rid of his old ways. His face clearly bears the mark of his resolve for austerity. It seems that having found himself incapable of running a household, he has left it completely up to me. He used to manage the house when we were in Mussoorie. He spent around fifteen hundred rupees in about two or three months. Where he got that money from, I still do not know. He would hardly have had any money of his own. It is possible though that he might have borrowed it from a friend. How can one even speak of going to the theatre or the cinema when one's income is just three hundred rupees? The rent for the house itself is fifty! I am now sick of these worries. Now I want to tell Vinod that I can't do this any more. 'You work at the university for two or three hours, then play a lot of tennis, read a lot of novels, sleep a lot, while I waste away the entire day managing the house.' I went up to him with the intention of discussing this, but being close to him takes away all my restraint, all my guilt and all my disaffection. His enlightened visage, his amorous gaze and his soft words cast an almost trance-like spell on me. Even a momentary embrace from him dissolves all my pain. It would have been much better if he were not so handsome, so affable, so gentle. Then I would probably have picked a fight with him, or told him of my troubles. In the present predicament, it is as if he has turned me into a sheep. But I am looking out for an opportunity to break this spell. In a way, I have lost my self-respect. Why am I scared of others' displeasure in every matter? Why do I not feel that what I am doing is right? Why do I seek approval? I must overcome this psyche of mine, come what may. Now I will take your leave. Write to me of news from your end. My heart longs for it.

Yours,

Padma

8

Kashi
25-12-1925

Dear Padma,

Reading your letter made me grieve a bit, smile a little, and somewhat angered me. What is it that you want, you yourself don't know. You have found the ideal husband. Do not trouble your heart over useless suspicions. You wanted freedom, which you have got. Three hundred rupees is not bad for two people. Add to it the hundred that your father still gives you. What more do you need? I fear that your heart has become a little eccentric. I do not have even a word of sympathy for you.

I arrived in Kashi on the 15th. My husband came to fetch me. I cried a lot when I was leaving my parents' home. I used to think that girls cry on such occasions only because they want to show off, and it was not that staying away from my parents was anything new for me. For the past six years, I have experienced this separation after every summer, and Dussehra and Christmas holidays. These occasions never brought tears to my eyes. Instead, the prospect of meeting my friends used to make me happy. But this time around, it felt as if somebody was wrenching my heart out. I cried so much hugging Ammaji that I became unconscious. My wish to weep at the feet of my father remained unfulfilled. *Hai!* The pleasure of weeping! At that time, I would have even given up my life just for the honour of crying at my father's feet. My only regret was that I never did anything for them. There is no pain that they did not suffer in bringing me up! I was a sickly child, and would fall sick every now and then. Ammaji would spend entire nights with me in her lap. I still remember the days when I frolicked on my father's shoulders. They have never cast a chastising glance at me. They would get extremely worried if I got even a headache. This is how the

first ten years of my life were spent. Then we lived in Dehradun for six years. Now that I have become capable of doing something for them, I am going away. Only for a total of eight months was I able to serve them, and these eight months are all I have to call the wealth of my life. My only prayer to God is that I am reborn in the same arms and I enjoy the same invaluable joys of parental affection.

The train left the station in the evening. I was in the women's compartment and the rest were in another room. Suddenly, I had a great urge to see my husband. My heart was longing for comfort, sympathy and refuge. I felt as if I was a prisoner being sent across the seas to Kaala Paani.

About an hour later, the train stopped at a station. I looked out of the window towards the rear of the train. That very moment the door opened and someone stepped into the room. There was not even one woman in that room. I immediately hid my face and said to him, 'Who are you? This is the ladies' compartment. Go to the men's compartment.'

Still standing, the man said, 'I will sit here. There are too many people there.'

Angry, I said, 'No, you can't sit here.'

'I will definitely sit here.'

'You will have to leave. You must leave now or I will pull the chain.'

'Come on, I am a human, not an animal. There is so much room here. So what is your objection?'

The train sounded the departure alarm. I became more nervous and said, 'Will you leave or should I pull the chain?'

The man smiled and said, 'You seem to have a quick temper. Don't you feel any pity for a poor man?'

The train started moving. I was sweating out of anger and embarrassment. I immediately opened the door and said, 'Fine. You sit. *I* will leave.'

To tell you the truth, sister, I was not at all scared at that moment. I knew I would die instantly if I jumped, but death was preferable to sitting alone with a stranger. I had only put one foot outside when the man caught me by the arm and pulled me inside and said, 'You almost arranged for me to be

sent to Kaala Paani. There is no one else here. Then why are you so scared? Just sit and enjoy yourself. I will get off at the next station. At least till that time, do not deprive me of the favour of your quips. Your beauty makes it difficult for my heart to control itself. Why be responsible for a wretched man's death?'

I jerked my hand out of his. My whole body was shaking. My eyes welled up. If I'd had a dagger or a knife with me, I would have surely taken it out and been ready for a bloody battle. But what else could I do in that state except for pursing my lips! Finally, thinking it to be useless to be upset, I tried to be careful and asked, 'Who are you?'

He replied with the same stubbornness, 'A seeker of your love.'

'Now you are joking. Tell me the truth.'

'I am telling you the truth. I am your lover.'

'If you indeed are my lover, then at least agree to my request and get off at the next station. You will gain nothing by bringing disrepute upon my head. Show at least this much mercy.'

I said this with folded hands. I was about to cry. The man then proceeded to the door and said, 'If that is your order, then all right, I am going, but do remember this.'

He opened the door and put one foot outside. I thought he was actually going to jump out. I can't tell you, sister, what my heart went through during that moment, but quick as lightning, I jumped and caught hold of his hand and pulled him back inside.

In a voice full of guilt, he said, 'Why did you pull me back? I was going, as per your wish.'

'Wait for the next station.'

'Since you are kicking me out, it is better I leave as soon as possible.'

'When have I told you to jump from a moving train?'

'If you feel such pity for me, show yourself, at least once.'

'How would you feel if an unknown man spoke to your wife?'

He raised his eyebrows and said, 'I would drink his blood!'

Without any hesitation, I said, 'Then you surely know how my husband will treat you?'

‘You are quite capable of protecting your honour yourself. Darling, you do not need your husband’s protection. Now come, hug me. I am none but your fortunate husband and servant.’

My heart jumped out. Words like ‘Arré! You!’ escaped my mouth, and I moved back a few steps. I pulled my veil down further. I could not speak a word.

My lord said, ‘Why this bashfulness and the veil now?’

I said, ‘What a trickster you are! What fun did you have by making me cry all this time?’

‘The way I have understood you in these moments—I would not have been able to do that at home. Forgive me for this misdemeanour. Would you really have jumped off the train?’

‘Absolutely!’

‘It all turned out well, but we will remember this prank for a long time.’

My husband is a dusky, slim, pockmarked man of average looks. I have seen men much more handsome than him. But how overjoyed my heart was! I cannot describe what joyful gratification I was feeling!

I inquired, ‘By when will the train reach its destination?’

‘We will reach by evening.’

I noticed then that my husband looked a bit sad. For ten minutes, he silently kept looking out of the window. I had asked him this unnecessary question only to engage him in conversation. But even now when he did not respond, I did not coax him any more. Instead, I opened the betel leaves box and started preparing a paan. Suddenly, he said, ‘Chanda, can I tell you something?’

I said, ‘Yes, yes, by all means.’

He bowed his head and, in an embarrassed tone, said, ‘If I had known that you were so beautiful, I would not have married you. Seeing you now makes me realize that I have been unfair to you. In no way am I worthy of you.’

Handing him a well-made paan, I said, ‘Don’t talk like this. Whatever you are, you are my world. I consider it a great fortune to be your handmaid.’

The train pulled into the next station. My husband left. After that, whenever the train stopped, he would come and talk to me for some time. In the evening, we reached Benares. The house is in a bylane and much smaller than my own house. Over the past few days, I have sensed that my mother-in-law is of a dull temperament, but it is still early to say anything about anybody. It is possible that I am getting the wrong impression. I will write about this again. It does not matter to me how the house is, or how their financial condition is, or how the in-laws are. What I wish is that everybody here should be happy with me. That my husband loves me is enough for me. I do not care about anything else. My mother-in-law does not like the fact that your *bahnoyi*—my husband—spends so much time with me! She fears that I will become too bold. I can't fathom why she is apprehensive of me, but I do know that if she objects to this, it is only for our own good. Why would she do anything that is not good for us? No mother can do ill to her own child. She must have noticed some shortcoming in me, I'm sure I'll get to know that in a few days! Do write to me about yourself. I am not expecting your reply before a month, but that's up to you!

Yours,
Chanda

9

Delhi
1-1-1926

Dear Sister,

The curious story of your first union gladdens my heart. I am feeling jealous of you. I had thought that you would be jealous of me, but it is the other way round now. You only see lush greenery on all sides, and wherever I look, I don't see anything other than an arid desert full of dunes and bare

rocks. Anyhow! Now listen to my story and, as they say, hold your breath; it's my turn now!

Vinod's unalterable philosophical temperament has become unbearable now. He is a strange creature. He would not care a hoot even if the house were on fire. He has no sympathy for me. He doesn't care that I fret the entire day over household matters. I have never seen a man so devoid of any sympathy. He is only fit for doing penance in a forest. Now there are only two of us, but if we were to have children, rest assured that I am doomed. God forbid, if I ever have to face that calamity!

Chanda, now I am determined to somehow break this penance of his. But no stratagem of mine succeeds, no moves produce any result. One day I broke the bulb of the lamp in his room. The room was dark all day. When he returned from his stroll, he found the room dark. When he asked me about it, I just told him that the bulb broke. That was all! He simply had his dinner and came to my room to rest. Didn't even look at the letters and novels there. I wonder where all his enthusiasm has vanished. The entire day passed, but he didn't bother to change the bulb. Finally, I had to get one from the market.

Another day, out of frustration, I fired the cook. I thought when His Lordship would have to sleep hungry, he would see some sense. But this gentleman didn't even ask for anything. He didn't get his tea, but he didn't care. At ten o'clock sharp, he dressed himself, peeped into the kitchen once and, finding it deserted, just left for college. A man is expected to ask things like—where is the cook, why has he gone, what new arrangements have been made, who will cook now . . . Or at least he could have told me that if I can't cook then I should order food from the market. I felt very guilty after he left. I ordered food from the Royal Hotel and sent it to the college through the attendant. But I myself stayed hungry. I suffered the entire day because of hunger. My head started aching. When he returned from college and saw me lying down, he made a great fuss, as if I had been struck by some great illness. Immediately, a doctor was summoned. The doctor came and inspected my eyes, tongue, temperature, etc. and prescribed medicines to take and ointments to apply. The man sent to buy medicines returned

with a bill of twelve rupees. I was so angry about all these things that I just wanted to run away somewhere. On top of this, he sat near my bed in an easy chair and kept asking me if I was feeling well, if the pain had subsided, and so on. I was so hungry that my intestines were churning. I didn't even touch the medicines. Finally, out of frustration, I ordered food from the market. This time too the trick backfired. I was scared that in the morning too Mister Husband would call for the doctor. So, conceding defeat, I resumed the household chores the next morning itself. A new cook was hired immediately. This new good-for-nothing cook, who cannot make even regular chapatis, was my punishment for having fired the older cook for no fault of his. There was fresh trouble from that very day. Teaching this new cook takes two hours each in the morning and evening. He is so proud of his culinary skills that no matter how much I prattle away, he does only what he wants. On top of it, he keeps smirking, as if telling me, 'You don't know these things. Just keep quiet and observe.' I wanted to teach Vinod a lesson, but have learnt one myself. Apart from having wasted the money, I am now stuck in a new rut. I know very well that Vinod calling a doctor and sitting by my side was just a show. His face showed no sign that he was worried or that his heart was troubled.

Forgive me, Chanda. I do not know how you would live with such a man, but it is unbearable for me to live in this condition. After listening to what I am going to tell you now, you may turn up your nose, curse me, or call me a disgrace, but I don't care. Four days ago, I put up a new act of our famous womanly character. We had gone to the cinema. There, a Bengali gentleman was sitting next to me. At the cinema, Vinod behaved as if he was in meditation. Didn't speak a word! The film was so beautiful and the acting so realistic that I praised it repeatedly. The Bengali man was also quite enjoying it! We started making comments about the movie. His explanations of the film were so interesting that it charmed my heart. I was enjoying his conversation more than the film. I tell you the truth, sister, that he was no match for Vinod when it comes to looks and handsomeness, but just to make Vinod jealous, I kept smiling while talking to him. He must

have thought he had trapped a prey! During the interval, when he was leaving the theatre, I also rose from my seat but Vinod did not even stir.

I said, 'I am tired of sitting here. Will you come out?'

Vinod replied, 'Sure, let's go. We'll just walk a bit.' But I said indifferently, 'Don't come if you don't want to. I won't force you.'

Getting back into his seat, Vinod said, 'All right.'

When I came out, the Bengali man asked, 'Are you from around here?'

'My husband is a professor at the university.'

'Okay! So he was your husband. What a peculiar man!'

'I do not think I have seen you here before.'

'Yeah, my home is in Bengal. I am the private secretary to the Maharaja of Kanchanpur. His Highness is here to meet the viceroy.'

'So you will be here for a few days?'

'Yes, I'm hoping. I may stay for a year or might leave by the next train. You can't say anything about our Maharaja Sahib. But he is a real gentleman and very amiable. He will be delighted to meet you.'

We reached the restaurant while we were still talking. He ordered for tea and toast. I took only tea.

He asked me, 'So should I introduce you to Maharaja Sahib right away? You'll be surprised that even those with crowns can be so courteous and humble. You'll be charmed if you listen to him.'

I looked at myself in the mirror and replied, 'No. Maybe another day. We will keep meeting you. Didn't your wife accompany you here?'

The young man smiled and said, 'I am still unmarried and likely to remain this way.'

Out of curiosity, I asked, 'Really! So you too are one of those who run away from women. We have talked so much but I didn't even ask your name.'

The man said his name was Bhuvan Mohan Dasgupta. I too introduced myself.

'No, Ma'am, I am one of those unfortunate ones who do not try again after the first disappointment. The world has no dearth of beauty, but beauty and character are seldom found together. The maiden I loved is today the

wife of a famous lawyer. I was poor. The lesson I got from this is something I will not forget all my life. What hope can I have when the one I worshipped the entire year sacrificed me for wealth?'

I laughed and said, 'You gave up too soon.'

Bhuvan looked at the door in front of us and said, 'I have, to this day, not seen a gallant who has not been beaten by a beauty. They strike at the heart and the heart can bear only one strike. The woman who thought my love to be lowly and trampled upon it—I want to show her what a lowly thing wealth is in my eyes. This is the only goal of my life. My life will be successful only on the day I have a grand mansion right in front of Bimala's house and her husband will consider it fortunate to meet me.'

I said seriously, 'This is not a very great motive. Why do you think that Bimala repudiated you only for wealth? It is possible there might have been other reasons. Maybe her parents pressurized her, or maybe she found herself unsuitable for you for some reason, which might have made your life miserable. Why do you think that the loss of love that caused you so much pain would have pleased her? It is possible that you also might have lost your way if you had found a wealthy woman.'

Vehemently, Bhuvan said, 'That is impossible, absolutely impossible. I would have given up the dominion of the three worlds for her.'

I laughed and said, 'You can say it now, but you can't say for sure how you would respond when confronted with such a test. The proof of a soldier's bravery is his sword, not his tongue. Think of it as good fortune that you did not have to go through that test. Love that seeks refuge in revenge is no love at all. The beginning of love is empathy and the end of love is also empathy. It is possible that even now you may get to know something which will soften you towards Bimala.'

Bhuvan was now deep in thought. After a minute, he raised his head and said, 'Mrs Vinod, you have brought my attention to something that I was oblivious to all this time. I never thought of it in this light. I do not understand why I became so rigid. Today I have learnt that only women can live up to the lofty ideals of love. A man can never self-surrender in love.

He cannot separate love from self-interest and desire. Now my life will be full of happiness. I thank you for the lesson that you have taught me today.'

Even as he was saying this, suddenly, he was startled, and continued, 'Oh! What a fool I am. Now I understand everything. Nothing is hidden now. Oh! I have done a great injustice to Bimala. I had become completely blind. Forgive me, Bimala!'

Bhuvan kept lamenting in this manner for a long time. He repeatedly thanked me and regretted his folly. We lost track of the bell and the resumption of the film. Suddenly, Vinod came into the room. I was startled. I scanned his face but it was devoid of any emotion. He said, 'Padma, you are still here! It's been a long time since the film started! I was looking for you all around.'

Taken aback, I stood up and said, 'The film has started? We didn't even hear the bell.'

Bhuvan also rose. We resumed watching the film. If only Vinod had said a few stinging words to me or if his eyes had betrayed some anger, my troubled heart would have recovered and found some consolation, but his immovable faith made my heart all the more turbulent. What I want, sister, is for him to rule me. I want to see a manifestation of his unkindness, his vehemence, his power. I have already experienced his love, mirth and faith. This does not satiate my soul! What would you call a father who feeds and clothes his son well, but does not care for his education, lets him go astray, lets him do as he pleases, and never glares at him! Such a boy is bound to become rootless. My condition is exactly the same. This indifference is unbearable to me. This gentleman did not even ask who Bhuvan was. Bhuvan must have thought that this woman's husband does not care at all. Vinod himself wants to be free and wants to leave me free too. He does not want to interfere in anything that I do. Similarly, he expects me not to interfere in anything he does. I consider such freedom to be like poison for both. Whatever currency independence might have in the world, at home it is dependence that brings fertility. I want to possess Vinod with the same intensity with which I possess a great piece of jewellery. If Vinod gives it away to anybody without consulting me, I will fight vigorously. I want such

a claim over him. I want a similar claim from him over me. He should pay attention to everything I say or do—whom I meet, where I am, what I read, how I live my life—he should keep a clear watch on all of this. If he does not care for me, why should I care for him? This tussle is drawing us apart from each other. What more can I tell you? I do not know who these friends of his are to whom he writes letters every day. He too has never asked me anything. Anyway, I have digressed from what I was telling you. Vinod did not ask anything about Bhuvan. I once again started talking to Bhuvan about the film.

When we came out after the film ended and were trying to get a tonga to go home, Bhuvan said, 'I will drop you in my car.'

We did not object to it. Bhuvan asked for directions to our house and started the car. On the way, I said to Bhuvan, 'Come to my house tomorrow for lunch.' Bhuvan accepted the invitation.

Bhuvan left after dropping us home, but I kept thinking of him for a long time. The way I understood Bhuvan in those few hours, I have never understood Vinod that way. Also, the way I shared things with Bhuvan, I have never shared with Vinod. Bhuvan is one of those men who will even kill another man if he sees them ogle at me. Similarly, he will kill me if he sees me flirting with another man and, if the need arises, will even jump into the fire for me. Only such a man can win my heart. Not only I but every woman, I believe, favours only such men. A woman is a weak creature. She seeks the refuge of a strong one.

Sister, you must be bored by now, the letter has become too long, but I can't stop until I have told you the full story. Right from the morning, I started the preparations for Bhuvan's visit. The cook, as you know, is an idiot. So I did all the work myself. I had never experienced such joy while cooking.

Bhuvan Babu's car arrived at the fixed hour. Bhuvan got out of the car and straight away came to my room. We talked for a while and then went to the dining table where Vinod also joined us. I formally introduced the two men to each other. I felt as if Vinod was somewhat ignoring Bhuvan. Vinod, being a communist, hates kings and aristocrats. And it is understood that if

he hates the kings, he would also hate their followers. He thinks that the courts of these grandees are peopled by sycophants, idlers, and unprincipled and characterless men, whose only business in life is to fulfil every wish of their master and enrich themselves by exploiting the subjects. While we were eating, the conversation veered towards important subjects like love and marriage.

Vinod said, 'No, I don't like the institution of marriage as it is now. This tradition was invented when man was in the early stages of civilization. The world has progressed much since then but the institution of marriage has not changed a bit. It does not suit the modern age.'

Bhuvan replied, 'What faults, after all, do you see in this institution?'

Vinod pondered for a while and then answered, 'The biggest problem with it is that it gives a religious form to a social question.'

'And the second?'

'The second problem is that it is an impediment to people's independence. It smothers our soul by putting up a masquerade of wifely and husbandly loyalty. No other material or divine revolutions have blighted our intellectual development the way marriage has. It has presented us with false ideals and till today we tread the beaten path of the same old, rotten, shameful and brutal ways. The vows are nothing but a name for a meaningless bond. By attributing such a significant name to it, we have covered this bondage in a religious colour. Why does man want woman to think of him as her god, her entire world? Only because he is the breadwinner. Is the only duty of a woman to produce an heir to the man's property? For that property, on which, according to the Hindu code, she can claim no rights after the husband's death. The entire social setup, the entire social structure is founded on this basis of property protection. It has made property primary and man secondary. No one can measure the blind selfishness, the slavery, that hides behind the idea that only the offspring born of our own semen must enjoy the wealth earned by us. What surprise is it then if the children born of such a bonded society create rivers of blood at home, in the country, and in the whole world for their own self-interest? I consider marriage to be the root of all ills.'

Bhuvan was surprised. I too was astonished. Vinod had never spoken to me on this subject with such clarity. I had of course always known that he is a communist. We had even argued over this a few times, but that he was such a vociferous opponent of marriage, I did not know. The expressions on Bhuvan's face indicated that he had never been exposed to such philosophical ideas. After a pause, he said, 'Professor Sahib, you have put me in an intellectual conundrum. Do you, after all, want to replace it with another institution or do you find it completely unnecessary? Should we also come together the way animals and birds do?'

Vinod replied immediately, 'Quite a bit. The intellectual development of all animals and birds is not to the same extent. There are some that do not put any thought into choosing their mate. There are some that separate after procreating once, and there are some that live together lifelong. There are so many different categories. Being a human, I think that category to be the best where they live together lifelong, but out of their own will. They do not have any bondage, nor any punishment. Both worry about only their own food. They build their nest together and rear the offspring together. No third male or female can come between them. So much so that if one partner dies, the other stays alone forever. It is only humans who practise this violence—if a woman speaks nicely to another man, her husband feels intensely jealous, and is even ready to kill. Or if a man looks at another woman amorously, his wife knits her eyebrows, and gets ready to kill the husband. What is all this? With what face can such a human society claim to be civilized?'

Bhuvan nodded, and said, 'But even among humans there are several categories. Some can even find a new partner every month.'

Vinod laughed and said, 'But that will not be so easy. Either he would want a woman who can rear the children by herself or he will have to pay a huge lump sum.'

Bhuvan too laughed. 'How will you categorize yourself?'

Vinod was not prepared for this question. In fact, it was a crude question. Uncomfortable, he said, 'Whichever category circumstances put me into. I am a votary of complete independence for men and women. If my heart is

attracted to a young woman and she too likes me, then there is no reason why I should not look at her, except for the fear of censure from society and its codes.'

Bhuvan was yet to reply when Vinod got up. He was getting late for college. He dressed quickly and left. Bhuvan and I went to the drawing room and continued our conversation.

Bhuvan lit a cigar and said, 'Did you notice the point at which he broke off his song?'

I lowered my head in shame. What could I reply to this? Vinod's last statement had dealt a severe blow to my heart. I felt that Vinod had prepared this new elaborate objection to marriage only for my ears; that he wants to escape from me; that he is seeking another woman and is done with me. This thought made me miserable. Tears started streaming from my eyes. If I was alone, I would have perhaps not cried, but I could not restrain myself in Bhuvan's presence. Bhuvan consoled me, 'You are unnecessarily mourning so much. Even if Vinod does not respect you, there is at least one man in this world who would sacrifice his life only to honour a mere gesture of yours. Which man in this world would not think himself fortunate if he were to get a woman like you? Do not worry about this at all.'

I found this statement of Bhuvan's objectionable. My face turned crimson in anger, thinking that this wicked man was planning to ruin me by taking advantage of my weakness. I wanted to cry over my misfortune. We had not even completed a year of our marriage and already my condition was such that other people had the audacity to try to seduce and cast a spell on me. How my heart had rejoiced when I had first seen Vinod! With what devotion had I offered my heart at his feet! But how could I know that I would fall in his eyes so soon and rakes would try to charm me, thinking that I am an abandoned woman.

Wiping my tears, I said, 'Excuse me, please let me rest for some time.'

'Sure, sure, I'll sit and watch.'

'No, now you please go. I will not be able to rest like this.'

'Fair enough. You rest. I'll come in the evening to check.'

‘No, you do not need to hassle yourself.’

‘All right, then I’ll come tomorrow. Probably Maharaja Sahib will also come.’

‘No, you should wait for my invitation. Do not come without an invitation.’

And I rose and went to my bedroom. Bhuvan kept looking at me for a moment and then left quietly.

Sister, it has been two days since the incident but I have not come out of my room. Bhuvan has visited about two or three times but I plainly refused to see him. Now he will perhaps not have the courage to come again. God made me see sense at the right moment or I would have utterly ruined myself. Vinod usually sits close to me but I do not feel like speaking to him. A man who can support debauchery using philosophical principles, in whose eyes there is no sanctity for a bond as pious as marriage, who cannot be mine, who cannot make me his, how long can a strong-willed and proud woman like me carry on with him?

That’s it. Now, I will take your leave. Forgive me, sister. I have taken up a lot of your precious time, but do know at least this much that I do not want your pity, only your sympathy.

Yours,
Padma

10

Kashi
5-1-1926

Sister,

Reading your letter made me feel as if I was reading a novel. If you write a novel, I am sure it will be a great hit. You can even be the heroine of the novel. What amazes me is where you could have learned to talk this way. I don’t understand how you could talk to that Bengali man, sitting alone with

him. I could have never done that. You want to make Vinod jealous; you want to unsettle his mind. You are committing a gross injustice to that poor man! Why do you think that Vinod is ignoring you or that he is so involved in his own thoughts that he doesn't care for you? Have you considered the fact that some psychological angst might be worrying him? That he might be troubled by some issue because of which he is not interested in the routine business of life? It is possible that he might be searching for some philosophical tenet; that he might be writing a thesis or even a book. Who can tell? If a man is worried despite having a beautiful woman like you as his wife, then take it that there is a huge burden on his heart. He needs your sympathy. You can share his burden. But on the contrary, you choose to blame him. I don't understand why you don't talk to Vinod some day with an open heart. The sooner a suspicion is dispelled from one's heart, the better it is. Suspicion is like that wound which, if not treated, continues to fester and then it only gets worse. Why don't you come over here for a few days? Maybe you will say, why don't I come myself. But I am not independent. I cannot do anything before seeking the permission of my father- and mother-in-law. You, of course, have no shackles.

Sister, my life these days is a strange mixture of happiness and sadness. When I am alone, I cry. When Anand comes to me, I rejoice. My heart wishes that he can be in front of my eyes all the time, but it is only after midnight that one gets to see him. One day, when he came home in the afternoon, the mother-in-law scolded him worse than one would an errant child. I fear that my mother-in-law is envious of me. Sister, I try my best to please her. I do chores for her that I have never done in my life. I heat the water for her bath; I lay out the altar for her puja. When she is done with her bath, I select the sari for her; when she lies down, I press her feet; when she sleeps, I fan her. She is like my mother; it is her womb that has given birth to the gem which is the foundation of my life. What could be a greater fortune for me than to be able to serve her? All I wish is for her to speak to me smilingly but I wonder why she taunts me at every possible chance she gets. I do know that it is my fault, though of course I don't know what it is. If my only fault is that I am more beautiful than both my sisters-in-law,

more educated than them, and that Anand likes me so much, then, sister, it is beyond my control. Probably it is this attitude of hers towards me which makes Anand upset with her. Maybe my mother-in-law suspects that I am the one instigating Anand. Maybe she regrets making me her daughter-in-law! She may be apprehensive about me snatching her son away from her. A couple of times, she has even abused me and called me a witch. Both the sisters-in-law are jealous of me without cause. The elder sister-in-law is already a widow, so her jealousy is understandable. But the younger sister-in-law is still just a girl, so I don't understand why she is jealous. If I was in her place, I would try to learn something, to get lessons from her *bhabhi*, or even worship her, but this girl finds joy in nothing but insulting me. I know that within a few days both the sisters-in-law will regret it, though of course, as of now, they detest me. I try my best not to give them a chance to be upset with me.

But what do I do with my beauty? How could I know that one day I would be declared a convict on account of my beauty? I tell you the truth, sister, that after coming here, I have in a way almost quit decking up. I sit around being dirty and ugly. I don't even touch books for the fear that someone will turn up their nose if I were to read or write. I had brought a bundle of many nice books from my home. My heart longs very much to read them but I fear that someone will taunt me. Both the sisters-in-law keep a watch over me to see what I do, how I sit, how I speak, as if two spies have been set after me. I cannot say what pleasure these two women derive out of insulting me. Perhaps these days they do nothing else except this. I get so angry that I want to rebuke them, but I stop myself from doing it by impressing upon myself that this situation will not continue for long. It is natural to shrink from a person new to you, especially when that new person is different from us in matters of education, thought and conduct. If I were made to live with a French lady, then perhaps I too would look at every aspect of her with a critical and suspicious eye. These people of Kashi practise a lot of religious rituals. In fact, my mother-in-law goes for a holy dip in the Ganga every day. The elder sister-in-law also accompanies her. I have never done a puja. Do you remember how we made fun of those

women doing puja? If I thought of people who did puja as exalted, then perhaps I too would have started doing it by now. But I have never experienced such a thing. Women who worship also bad-mouth others and fight among themselves just like women who do not worship. Anyway, I have gradually come to respect this ritual. My grandfather-in-law had a small temple constructed. It is right in front of our house. I often go there with my mother-in-law and now I have no hesitation in saying that the blessed sight of those icons gives me a feeling of a divine light in the depths of my heart. The disrespect with which I used to criticize the lives of Ram and Krishna has now been erased to a great extent.

The penalty of being beautiful is not limited to this. It is only natural that my sisters-in-law are jealous. The real regret is that this punishment is meted out to me from quarters where there should be no possibility of it: my Anand Babu is also punishing me for this, though, of course, his code of punishment is rather singular. Every day he gets some gift or the other for me. For the time that he spends with me, he is apprehensive that I do not like his company. He thinks that my love for him is only a show, an artifice. In my company, he is so diffident, so withdrawn, that I almost die of shame. While speaking to me, he feels such hesitation . . . as if he is making some unwarranted audacious move. His condition is akin to a man who wears dirty clothes and therefore stays away from those who wear clean clothes. He perhaps thinks that a beautiful woman cannot fall in love with a man who is not handsome. Perhaps, in his heart, he regrets having married me. Perhaps he feels guilty about himself. If he sometimes sees me crying, he thinks that I am crying over my misfortune. If he sees me writing a letter, he thinks that here too I am lamenting his lack of beauty. What can I tell you, sister, this beauty has become the bane of my life. I am disgusted by the things that I have to say, the acts that I have to undertake to drive this suspicion out of his heart and assure him from my side. If only I'd known of this beforehand, I would have prayed to Lord Brahma to make me ugly. I am in a great dilemma! If I do not serve the mother-in-law, if I do not please the elder sister-in-law, then I will fall in their eyes. If I disappoint Anand Babu, then it is possible that he might become estranged. I am telling you

the feelings of my heart. Sister, what's the point in keeping secrets from you? I love Anand Babu the way any woman can love a man. Now even if Lord Indra were to replace him, I would not look at him. But how do I convince him? When I see that he repeatedly comes into the house on some pretext or the other and looks at the door to my room with diffident and eager eyes, I want to go and grab his hand and pull him into my room. But I fear that if someone sees it, there will be some breast-beating. The greater apprehension is—what if Anand takes this to be an act as well? At present, his income is quite minimal, but still he blows off two or four rupees every day for some gift. Even if he gives me something as cheap as a stone as a token of his love, I will worship it, but he offers them like a tax, as if he has been punished by God. What can I do? Now, I too will have to make a show of love. I hate displays of affection. You would remember, I had once said that love can either be within us or it can be displayed. It cannot be an inner and outer thing equally. Displays are meant only for prostitutes. The love of true women resides in their hearts only.

Sister, the letter has become quite long. You must have got bored reading it. I too am tired of writing. I will write the rest of the things tomorrow. This letter will reach you the day after tomorrow.

x x x

Forgive me, sister. I could not find the time to write the letter yesterday. Something happened at night which troubled my heart. With great difficulty I have managed to spare some time. I had so far not complained to Anand about anybody in the family. If the mother-in-law says something or the sister-in-law taunts me, there is no need to tell him. What, other than a quarrel at home, can possibly be achieved? Families are ruined and bitterness rules at home if these minor scuffles are not ignored. But just accidentally I happened to say something yesterday for which I am still blaming myself. I am praying to God that the issue does not escalate. It so happened that last night Anand Babu came to me very late. I was reading a book while waiting for him. Suddenly the mother-in-law came and asked,

‘The light is still on? If he doesn’t come back all night, will you keep wasting electricity?’

I instantly switched off the light. After some time, when Anand Babu came in, the room was still dark. And I don’t know how my brain had become so blunt at that moment. If I had switched on the light when I heard his footsteps, nothing would have happened but I kept lying in the dark. He asked, ‘Have you slept? Why is it dark here?’

Hai! If only I had told him that I had just switched off the light, everything would have been all right. But I said, ‘It was mother-in-law’s command that the light be switched off, so I switched it off. What if you didn’t return at all, should the light have been on all through the night then?’

‘Then turn it on now. I have come through a lit passage and I can’t see anything.’

‘I have sworn that now I will not even touch the switch. If I need light, I will light a candle. Who wants to be snubbed for nothing!’

Switching on the light, Anand said, ‘And I have sworn that the light will stay on throughout the night, whether anyone likes it or not. I do observe all that is happening. I am not blind. We’ll see if another daughter-in-law serves her like this. You are of a blighted fate to have been tied to people like this. If you served any other mother-in-law the way you do here, she would have treasured you and pampered you. But here the situation is such that even if you were to give up your life, no one would even speak decently about you.’

It was then that I clearly understood my mistake. With the intention of pacifying his anger, I said, ‘It was my mistake that I kept the light on till midnight. What was wrong in Ammaji telling me to switch it off? It is her duty to instruct and guide me. My duty is to serve her and accept her lessons as much as I can.’

Anand kept staring at the door for a moment. Then he said, ‘I think now it will not be possible for me to live here. Although you don’t complain, I do hear everything that is said. I understand everything. You are repenting for my sins. Tomorrow I will tell Ammaji very clearly, “If you continue this

behaviour of yours, then keep your house to yourself. I will think of some other way for myself.”’

With folded hands, I beseeched him, ‘No, no, never do such a drastic thing. This cursed tongue of mine! Why did I have to mention the light! I swear by the blessings of your feet that I have no complaint against my mother-in-law or my sister-in-law. Both are older than me and are like my mother. Even if they speak a harsh word, I should be patient! Please don’t say anything to them. If you do, it will cause me a lot of suffering.’

With a lump in his throat, Anand said, ‘Ammaji’s heart is not pacified despite getting a daughter-in-law like you. Does she desire a heavenly goddess for this house? Don’t fear, I will not fight unnecessarily. But yes, I will definitely tell her to keep a check on her temper. If only I was earning a few hundred rupees for this house, nobody would say a word. This is my punishment for not earning anything. To tell you the truth, I had no right to get married. What right did a retard like me, who cannot earn a penny, have to take down a woman with him! I wonder what my sister has in mind when she is having a go at you. She ruined her own in-laws and now wants to burn this house down. It is only that I respect my father too much, otherwise I could have disciplined them in just one day.’

Sister, I somehow calmed him down then, but I can’t say how long he can be held back. Just for my sake, he is ready to take on the entire world. You can judge the situation I am in. Whatever atrocity is inflicted on me, I must not cry. The moment I do that, this home will be ruined. Then Anand will not listen to anything, or see any reason. Perhaps he thinks that this will help sprout love in my heart for him. Only now have I come to know how angry he can be. If I had provoked him just a little bit, he would have waged a war with the mother-in-law that same night. So many young women forget their station only out of this false pride for their rights. Sister, God willing, I will never forget my place. I am not scared of how we will live if Anand decides to live separately. As long as I am with him, I can withstand anything, but this home will be devastated.

That’s it for today, dear Padma. Reply soon to this letter.

Yours,
Chanda

11

Delhi
5-2-26

Dear Chanda,

What can I write now? Disaster has struck me! Hai, he has left! There has been no news of my Vinod for three days now. That detached one has left; has left me; has left without a word! I have not wept till now. When people ask about him, I make excuses that he will be back in a few days; he has gone to Kashi for some work. But if I weep, I will be drowned in tears. My life will be swept away by my tears. The deceptive one did not say even a word to me. He just woke up like every day, had his breakfast, went to college, returned home on time, and came to me smilingly like every day. Then both of us had a snack; he started reading the newspaper, and I went out to play tennis. His interest in tennis had waned in the past few days, so I used to go alone. When I returned, I saw him strolling in the veranda and smoking a cigar, like every day. The moment he saw me, he fetched my overcoat and put it on me, like every day. Stepping off the veranda, we started walking in the open courtyard, but that day he did not talk much. He was engrossed in thought. As the evening dew increased, both of us went inside. Just then the Bengali woman who gives me veena classes, arrived. Vinod too sat with me through the class. I have already told you how he loves music. That is nothing new. After the woman left, we had dinner together and then I went to my room to lie down. He went to his room to read and write, like every day! I slept early, but when he came to the room, I woke up. No matter how deep my slumber is, I wake up on my own when I hear his footsteps. I saw that he was standing there in his green shawl. I stretched out my hand to him and said, ‘Come, why are you standing

there?' and then I fell asleep again. That was it, dear sister! That was the last glimpse I had of Vinod. I can't say if he came to the bed or not. Wonder what great slumber my eyes were heavy with. When I woke up in the morning, I could not find Vinod there. Usually, I wake up before him and he keeps sleeping. But that day he was not in the bed. The shawl too was not there. I reckoned he might have gone to his room. So I went for my bath. When I emerged from the bath about half an hour later, he was still nowhere to be seen. I looked into his room, but he was not there either. I was amazed at where he could have gone so early in the morning. Suddenly I noticed the peg on which he hangs clothes. They were not there. Has he gone to meet anybody? Or has he gone for a stroll before his bath? At least he could have told me. My heart, then, would not have been in such tumult. I was angry. 'He thinks I am his slave!' I said to myself.

When it was time for breakfast, the servant came and served tea on the table. Waiting for him, the tea went cold. I was getting agitated. I would keep going in and out. I had resolved that whenever the gentleman showed up, I would give him a piece of my mind! I had resolved to say, 'Keep this house of yours. May you be happy in your house. I will go to my own home. I can fill my belly there too.' In winter, it is nine o'clock before you know it. Still no news of Vinod. Frustrated, I went to his room with the intent of writing a letter and leaving it there for him. I wanted to write very clearly—'If this is how you want to live, carry on. I cannot live like this. The more leeway I give, the more you rile me.' Sister, in that anger, a flood of heated emotions was surging in my heart. If I had sat down to write, I would have written page after page. But, ah! While I was only threatening to run away, he had actually run away. Just as I sat at the table, I found a letter from him in his writing pad. I immediately took out that letter and hurriedly read through it. My hands started to tremble, and my feet became unsteady. I felt as if the room was shaking. I drew in a cold, long, heart-rending sigh, and fell on the couch. This was the letter—

> Darling! It was nine months ago that I had the good fortune of first seeing you. I had considered myself blessed. Today, I have the misfortune of going away from you, but I still consider myself blessed. I have not an iota of regret about leaving, because I know that you

will be happy. When you cannot be happy with me, then why should I stay perforce? It will be much better if you and I separate. I will continue to be as I am, and you too will continue to be as you are. Where, then, is the possibility of a happy life? I consider marriage to be a means of self-development. If there is any meaning to the man–woman relationship, it is this. Otherwise I do not think marriage to be of any necessity. The children of mankind will continue to live without marriage, and perhaps in a better manner. Lust can be satisfied even without marriage. Establishing a household also does not require marriage. Livelihood too is an extremely minor concern. A creature blessed with two hands by God will never go hungry. The one and only motive for marriage is that man and woman can be of help in each other's self-development. Only where there is love, there is marriage, and love is the chief means to self-development. Where there is no love, there is no marriage. There is no meaning in marriage without love.

When I had seen you for the first time, you appeared to me like a living image of love. You had beauty, you had education, you had love, you had enthusiasm, you had zeal. I was enchanted. Blinded at that moment, I could not discern that while you had so many qualities, you also had a restlessness, which eclipsed all your other qualities. That you are restless, very restless, did not occur to me at that time. You are exactly like how your other sisters usually are, neither greater, nor lesser. I had hopes to make you independent, because in my understanding, independence is the most important requirement to reach the pinnacle of one's life. Why do you think there is such a vociferous protest against men across the world? Because we have deprived women of their freedom and have made them our vassals. I have freed you. I do not claim any rights over you. You are your own mistress. I had no dilemma while I was under the impression that you lived with me out of your own volition. It is now that I have understood that you live with me not out of choice but because of bashfulness or fear or compulsion. This came to my notice only a few days ago. That is why I do not want to obstruct your path to happiness. I am not running away anywhere. I am only withdrawing myself from your path and going far enough so that you can be relieved from constantly being by my side. If your life can become more beautiful without me, then I don't want to force my companionship on you. If I had found that you are an obstruction in my path to happiness, I would have told you very clearly. I do not believe in the pretence of religion or morality. I only want peace for the soul. For me, and for you. This is the essence of life, and the value of life. On the desk, I have left a letter to the head of my department. Please send it to him. Do not worry at all about money. There is enough money in my account for your needs for months, and you can withdraw from it as long as you wish to. I think I have made my thoughts clear. I do not want to explain any more. If you wish to meet me, you can find my address from the bank. But only after a few days. There is nothing to worry about. I do not think that a woman is without strength or is handicapped. She can protect herself on her own, if she so desires. Now, or in a few months, or in a few years, if you remember me, and you think that you can be happy with me, then just write me a word and I will return at once, because I have no complaints against you. Whatever days of my life I have spent with you, those days are like a heavenly dream to me. As long as I live, I will keep the pleasant memories of these days treasured in my heart. Ah! Even after having controlled my heart for so long, a drop of tear has, after all, fallen from my eyes. Forgive me, for having called you 'restless'. Who is it who is at rest? I do know that you have cast me out of your heart, but even then I have returned to my room after having glimpsed you so many times! But I do not want to provoke pity in you

by saying all this. You only did that which, according to my morality, was your right, is your right and will remain your right. In a marriage, I want to assign the supreme position to the soul. Between a man and a woman, I want only that love which is possible between two free persons; not the kind of love which is founded on dependence.

That is it. I will not write any more. I have this desire to give you a warning, but I will not because you can discern what is good or bad for you. You have revoked from me the right to advise you. Even so, I cannot but say that there is no dearth of rakes in the world who can make a pretence of love. Beware of them. I only pray to God that you be happy, wherever you are. If you ever need me, do call me. I am taking away a picture of yours. Forgive me, but don't I have that much of a claim? Hai! The heart longs to see you one more time, but I won't come.

Yours rejectedly,
Vinod

Sister, you can understand what the condition of my heart would have been while reading this letter. Though I did not cry, my heart sank. I only wanted to take poison and lie down. It was just about ten o'clock. I immediately went to the college and handed over Vinod's letter to the head of the philosophy department. He is a Madrasi gentleman. He offered me a seat very respectfully and, having read the letter, said, 'Do you know where he has gone and when he will return? The letter only has an application for leave of one month.' I evaded the question by saying, 'He has gone to Kashi for some important work' and returned disappointed. Like a thousand accusing tongues, my soul was cursing me. Kneeling before his picture in the room, the words of remorse I spoke begging his forgiveness—if only they could reach his ears, he would know how mistaken he is about me! Since then, until now, I have not eaten any food nor have I slept for a moment. Vinod has taken my appetite and sleep with him and if there is no news of him for a few more days, perhaps my life too will follow him, away from my body. Today I had gone to the bank, but I could not summon enough courage to inquire if there was a letter from Vinod. What would they think? That she is his wife but asks *us* about him!

Sister, what will happen if Vinod does not return? I used to think that he is indifferent to me, that he does not care for me, hides his thoughts from me, or that I am a burden to him. Now I understand how mistaken I was. If

I had known how tender his heart was, why would I have flirted with Bhuvan that day? I would not even have looked at that cursed man. If I saw him now, I would perhaps shoot him! Sister, I just read Vinod's letter once again. He wanted to make me free. If he wanted to free me, why was he so upset over my talking to Bhuvan for some time? I was piqued by his unshakeable calm. Actually, the kind of turbulence that this minor issue created in his heart, perhaps it would not do so in mine. If he were to be interested in some woman, I probably would have sulked, taunted, cried or made him cry, but I would not have run away so soon. It has never been heard of—men running away from home. It is only women who run away to their parents' house or drown themselves or commit suicide. The men only sit around hassle-free and twirl their moustaches. Here the Ganga is flowing backwards—it's the man who ran away! Who can measure this turbulence? Who can gauge the depth of such love? At this moment, if only I could die grovelling at Vinod's feet, I would believe that I attained paradise. That is it. Apart from this, I have no other desire. This unfathomable love has satiated me. Though Vinod has run away from me, he is still here. He was never so close to my heart, to my beliefs. I can still see him sitting before me. Were you being a philosopher to me? Where is your philosophical gravitas now? Are you deluding yourself? Are you trampling upon your own soul? You have run away once, but I will see how you run away again. I did not know that you were such a clever trickster. Now I have understood, and your philosophical gravitas would also have probably grasped that love is as tender as it is true and heartfelt. It can bear being tossed around in the choppy seas of adversity but cannot withstand a single strike of indifference. Sister, it is strange but true that the emotion, the joy I am feeling deep in my heart at this moment, I do not remember having experienced it even in the embrace of Vinod's heart. Then, there was a distance between us. Now, there is none. I had wanted to test him on the popular scales of the business of love. It has become a fashion that when a man returns home, he must get a gift for the woman. The woman does not complain if the man is always busy getting her jewellery, clothes, lace, ribbons and so on. Then he is the ideal husband. Who can suspect his love?

But such a man is known to organize a second wedding in the third month after the death of such a beloved. Then the same pretence is put up with the new beloved, the same act starts all over again. This is the love I had seen, and this was the scale on which I was weighing Vinod. How insane I am! I had mistaken flippancy for love. How many women are aware that most such men, busy with jewellery, clothes and laughter, are debauchees? They put up this act only to hide their wantonness. They merely throw bones to the dogs to keep them silent. The poor innocent wife only gets toys in return for her complete surrender and stays engrossed in it. I was weighing Vinod on this very scale—I was weighing a diamond on the scale meant for vegetables. I know, I firmly believe and it is my unshakeable belief that Vinod will not cast an eye on another woman. For him, it is me, me alone, good or bad, whatever it is, it is me. Sister, my bosom swells with pride and joy. I doubt if any other queen of human hearts has had the fortune of having such a vast, such an immovable, such an invincible empire! And I was unsatisfied even with this! I did not know that one can see only bubbles on the surface; pearls are found only at the bottom of the sea. Hai! What agony is Vinod going through because of my stupidity! I wonder where the treasure of my life might be roaming aimlessly, in what condition he might be! I wonder what kind of alarms about me might be raising themselves in his heart. Darling! You too have not been any less unjust to me. If I have thought you to be unfeeling, then you have thought me to be worse. Are you still not satisfied? You have thought me so lowly that this cursed Bhuvan . . . I can sacrifice lakhs of such Bhuvans at your feet. I fail to see another creature in this world on whom I can fix my eyes. No, you cannot think of me as so fallen, as so disgraced. If such a thing ever came to pass, then perhaps neither you nor I would continue to live in this world.

Sister, I have thought of a plan to call, catch and drag back Vinod. I can't say why I did not think of this on the first day itself. Vinod cannot rest until he has read the daily newspaper and I also know which newspaper he reads. Tomorrow's paper will carry this news—'Padma is dying'—and the day after, Vinod will be here. He will not be able to hold himself back. Then there will be a lot of quarrels, a lot of fighting.

Now, something about you. Is your old woman really jealous of you because you are beautiful and educated? Great! And even Anand seems like a strange creature. I have heard that no matter how ugly the man is, his gaze stills itself only on damsels. Then why does Anand Babu cringe from you? Just look carefully, and see if there is a third one coming between Radha and Krishna. If your mother-in-law keeps troubling you, then I can only advise you to set up a separate home. But I know that you will not heed this advice of mine, no way. I congratulate you on your tolerance. Write soon, but most probably you will receive a second letter from me even before your letter arrives.

Yours
Padma

12

Kashi
10-2-1926

Dear Padma,

I write this letter today after having waited for many days for your letter. Even now I am hoping that Vinod Babu might have returned home, but in case he has not and you are crying your eyes out, I will not feel an iota of pain for you! The injustice you have done to him deserves this punishment. I have absolutely no sympathy for you. Despite being a housewife, you went on to play that wicked game which is fit only for prostitutes. I would have been happy if he had smothered you and forever silenced the false sacraments that Bhuvan gave you. Although you may get angry with me, I will still say that you are not worthy of Vinod. You would probably have been happy with a husband who would make you jealous by his frequent shows of love to other women. Perhaps you have read in those English books that women fall for gallant lover boys only, and this is what has gone to your head. Every day you need a new sensation, otherwise your life

seems to become monotonous and dry. You are not the loyal Indian woman, but the fun-loving woman of Europe. I only feel pity for you. Even now you think that beauty is the root of attraction. I agree that beauty is attractive, but this attraction is nothing but an illusion. It is not long-lasting, but merely a fallacy. There is only one root of love, and that is service. Do not think that the man who hovers around you like a bumblebee is the one who loves you. His thirst for beauty will not last for many days. Beauty is the sapling from which love springs but to nurture and nourish it is the duty of service alone. I do not believe that you would have fanned Vinod when he came back from work, all tired and perspiring. Perhaps it would also not have occurred to you to switch on the table fan. Tell me the truth, is my guess correct or not? Tell me, have you ever pressed his legs? Have you ever massaged his head? You will say, this is the job of servants, and ladies do not indulge in these luxuries. You have not experienced that joy. You want to claim Vinod for yourself but do not make any attempt for it. A flapper can entertain someone, but cannot be a lifelong companion. Even in her man's embrace, she is miles away from him. I admit that attraction to beauty is a human trait, but beauty cannot satiate the heart, it cannot quench the thirst of the soul. Even if the husband of a beauty-less but serving woman gets entrapped by the beauty of another woman, he escapes it sooner than later. But a heart addicted to service cannot fall only for a coquette or a flirt. It may seem I am sermonizing, though you are perhaps a few months older than me. Excuse me, sister, this is not a sermon. We all know it. It is just that we forget it sometimes. I have only reminded you of it. A sermon is not heartfelt, but my sermon comes from the pain in my heart, which has arisen because of your troubles.

All right, now listen to my story. Major events have occurred here in the past one month. I have already written that there is discord between Anand Babu and Ammaji. That fire was only smouldering within them then. There would be an altercation or two between the mother and the son every day. One day, my younger sister-in-law took a book from my room. She is a voracious reader. When I could not find the book in my room, I asked her about it. Such a minor thing, but the good woman flew off the handle and

said, ‘You accuse me of theft!’ Ammaji sided with her and harangued me a lot. A mere coincidence—Ammaji was still taunting me when Anand came into the house. The moment Ammaji saw him, she started shouting even louder, ‘The audacity of your wife! It’s only because you pamper her so much. Did her father give her that book? If my daughter took it, what crime did she commit? She could not wait at all. She had to come running and snatch it away from her hands!’

Sister, I concede that I should not have been so impatient for the book. The sister-in-law would have returned it on her own after reading it, and even if she didn’t, what calamity could befall me just because I did not read that one book? But it was my misfortune that I tried to snatch it from her. If Anand Babu had scolded me over this, I would not have been hurt at all, but on the contrary, he sided with me and scowled, ‘Why should anybody take anybody’s things without permission? This is basic courtesy.’

Ammaji only had to hear this for her to act like she had been possessed by the devil. Anand Babu also fired his salvos intermittently and I sat in my room and cried, wondering why I had even asked for the book. That night, neither Ammaji nor Anand Babu ate anything. And my heart told me that I should consume poison and die. At night, when Ammaji went to bed, I went to her as usual to press her feet. Though she rebuffed me the moment she saw me, I grabbed her feet. I was at the foot of the bed. When Ammaji pushed me away with her feet, I fell from the bed. There were many bowls lying on the floor. I fell on those bowls and my back and waist were badly hurt. I did not want to scream but I don’t know how a scream escaped my mouth. Anand Babu had retired to our room but when he heard the scream, he came running and, standing at the doorstep of Ammaji’s room, said, ‘Do you want to kill her, Amma? I am the culprit here, why must you kill her?’ And he came into the room and, grabbing my hand, dragged me away forcefully. I tried my best to wrench my hand away from his but Anand did not let go! Actually, I did not like the way he had jumped into our fight. If he had not interfered, I would have pacified Ammaji somehow, possibly by crying buckets. Her anger had begun to abate when I had fallen down. Anand’s interference turned it into a disaster. Ammaji left the room and,

screwing up her face, said, ‘Sure, sure! Look carefully! Nurse her well! See that nothing is broken!’

Anand paused in the courtyard and said, ‘Do you want me to stay silent even if you kill somebody?’

Ammaji retorted, ‘Right! I must be a witch! And killing is all I do. Wonder why I spared you!’

Anand shot back, ‘Why are you regretting it? Even now just a bit of poison will be enough.’

Ammaji wasn’t one to let go. ‘If you want to pamper this woman in this way, take her somewhere else. You cannot live in this house any longer.’

Anand spat back, ‘I was just thinking about it myself. You don’t need to tell me.’

Ammaji was beginning to get bitter, ‘I too will convince myself I never gave birth to a son.’

He repaid in kind, declaring, ‘I too will convince myself that my mother is dead.’

I grabbed Anand’s hand and tried to drag him away in vain. Finally, when Ammaji went to her room, he came to our room and sat down with his head in his hands.

I said, ‘What did you do!’

With his eyes fixed on the floor, Anand said, ‘Amma has finally issued the notice today.’

‘You are the one who picked the fight. She hadn’t said anything.’

‘*I* picked the fight?’

‘Of course. I asked you not to intervene on my behalf.’

‘If I hadn’t pulled you out, Amma would have beaten you half-dead. You don’t know how angry she can get.’

I tried to reason, ‘You misunderstood. She did not hit me; she was only trying to free her leg. I was sitting on the edge, she pushed me slightly which made me topple over. Ammaji was about to help me get up before you came in.’

‘Do not praise hell in front of the devil. I know Ammaji very well. Tomorrow itself I will look for another house. Now I am determined to do

this. I will find a job somewhere. These people think I owe my livelihood to their mercy. That is why they show such attitude.'

The more I tried to reason with him, the angrier he got. Finally, out of frustration, I said, 'Then you live in the other house by yourself. I will not go along. Let me live here.'

Anand looked at me incredulously and said, 'You like being kicked around here?'

'Yes, this is what I like.'

He was in no mood to listen. 'Then you are welcome to them. I don't want to be kicked around. Will it not be enough that I won't have to see your pathetic condition, and that I won't suffer?'

'Just think of what people will say if you live separately!'

'I don't care. People are blind.'

'People will only say that the wife has cast this spell!'

'I don't care about that either. I can't endanger my life for fear of what people will say.'

Crying, I said, 'Will you abandon me? Do you not love me at all?'

Sister, I wonder what these pleading words of love would have achieved, had it been some other occasion. It is such appeals that bring down estates or break up relationships. A woman has no greater weapon than this. I had put my arms around him and was crying with my head resting on his shoulders. But at that time, Anand had become so obdurate that even this plea did not have any effect on him. Such resentment for the mother! The one who had borne him! What is the point of such self-pride if we cannot put up with a mere taunt from our own mother? Are these the hopes for which a mother sacrificed all the pleasures of her life? For which she sacrificed her daily peace and nightly sleep? Can a mother not exercise even this much claim over her son?

Still obstinate, Anand said, 'If loving you means that I abandon you to be tortured in this house, then that is not my way of loving.'

In the morning, when he got up and was leaving, he said to me, 'I will go and fix a house for us. I will also get a tonga. You be ready.'

I stood in the doorway and said, 'Are you still not pacified?'

‘It is not about being angry. It is only a matter of unburdening others of oneself.’

‘This is not a good thing—what you are doing. Just think how your mother will suffer. Have you even asked your father?’

‘There is no need to ask him. Amma is the boss here. Father is nothing but a mere ball of clay.’

‘Is he not the master of the house?’

Now he spoke with a sense of finality, ‘Do you want to come along or not? Speak clearly.’

‘I will not go now.’

‘Fair enough! Enjoy the kicks!’

I did not respond to this. After a moment, Anand said, ‘If you have some money, give it to me.’

I had two hundred rupees with me but I refused to give it. I had assumed that the concern for money would stop him, but I was mistaken. He had decided to leave. Irritated, he said, ‘All right, I will manage without your money. May you be happy with this mansion, these pleasures, these servants, these luxuries of yours! Why will you stay hungry with me? How can you find this pleasure there? What is the worth of my love anyway?’

And he left. Sister, how can I tell you how I suffered then because of my helplessness. The only thought I had at that moment was, if only Yamraj could come and carry me away to his realm. I, the destroyer of families, was now the cause of animosity between mother and son! I went to Ammaji, fell at her feet and, crying all through, gave her the news of Anand Babu’s departure from home. But the mother’s heart did not soften even a bit. That day I understood that even a mother can be so hard-hearted. Why, then, would Anand Babu’s heart not be hard? After all, he is his mother’s son!

With great cruelty, his mother said, ‘Why didn’t you go with him? If he wanted you to go, you should have gone along. Who knows, I might poison you here!’

I said pleadingly, ‘Ammaji, I bow at your feet. Please have him called back, or he will go somewhere forever.’

With the same ruthlessness, Amma said, ‘I don’t care whether he goes or stays, who is he to me anyway? Now what matters is you. Who cares for me? Today he is angry because of such a trivial issue. My mother-in-law has beaten me hundreds of times. I too was not an adolescent girl. I was your age but I never had the courage to speak to your father-in-law in anybody else’s presence. My mother-in-law would have eaten me alive if I did that! I would cry all night after getting beaten. But nobody left the house this way, as your husband has done. Boys these days don’t know how to love. We too used to love but not like this, where we had no regard left for our parents, elders, or the younger ones.’

She then left for her daily puja. I came back to my room to weep over my misfortune. I feared the next step that Anand might take. My heart was cursing me for not giving him the money. He must be roaming around aimlessly. He had not yet washed up; hadn’t even had his breakfast. He will catch a cold if he does not have his breakfast on time, and when he catches a cold, he gets fever too. I asked the *mahri*, the cleaning lady, ‘Just go and see if master is in his room.’ She came back to tell me, ‘There is no one in the room. The clothes too are missing from the peg.’

I inquired, ‘Has he ever been this angry with Ammaji?’ the mahri said, ‘Not ever, Bahu. I have never seen such an innocent boy. He has never even raised his head in front of his mother. Wonder why he has left today.’

I was hoping that he would come back in the afternoon for lunch. But forget afternoon, the evening too passed and there was no news of him. I stayed awake all night, with my ear to the door, alert to the sound of anyone coming in. But the night too passed. Sister, three days went by just like this. If you had seen me then, you would not have recognized me. I was utterly distraught. I cried so much, my eyes turned red. I did not sleep even for a moment over these three days, let alone eat. I did not even drink any water. I didn’t feel thirsty at all. I felt as if my body had become lifeless. An air of mourning spread across the house. Ammaji did report for both the meals, but would leave after the token morsel. The laughter and banter of both the sisters-in-law had also fallen quiet. The younger sister-in-law, in fact, came to me to apologize for her mistake.

On the morning of the fourth day, the cook came to inform me, ‘I just met the master at the Dashasvamedh ghat. The moment I saw him, I ran to him and said, “Brother, why don’t you come home? Everybody is worried. Your wife has not even drunk water for three days now. She is in a miserable condition.” Hearing this, he thought for a moment and then said, “Why has she given up food and water? Just go and ask her if she is already bored of the comforts for which she refused to leave that house!”’

That very moment, Ammaji came out to the courtyard. The cook’s words had reached her ears. She asked, ‘What is it, Algoo? Did you see Anand?’

The cook replied, ‘Yes, Badi Bahu, I just saw him at the Dashasvamedh ghat. When I asked him why he wasn’t coming home, he said, “Who is there for me in that house?”’

Amma inquired further, ‘Didn’t you say that at least his wife is here, if not anybody else? Why should he make his wife suffer?’

The cook explained, ‘I tried my best to reason with him, Badi Bahu, but he didn’t budge at all.’

Amma wanted to know, ‘What is he up to?’

The cook told her, ‘That I did not ask, but he looked very crestfallen.’

Amma scolded him saying, ‘You are going senile with age. You could have at least asked him where he is living, where he gets to eat. You should have simply grabbed his hand and dragged him home. But traitors like you are only concerned with your own welfare, and whether you get your largesse or not, no matter if someone lives or dies. All you do is just put out your hands to beg and twirl your moustache. Why would you care whether anyone at home gets to eat or not! I do not care if he comes back or not. My duty was to raise him, which I did. Now he can live where he wants. But what to do with this wife of his who is even now weeping away her life? God has given you a pair of eyes. Couldn’t you see her condition? Wasn’t your tongue worthy enough to tell him that his wife has given up all food and water?’

The cook said meekly, ‘Bahuji, God is witness to how much I tried to pacify him. But it was as if he just wanted to get away from me. What, then, could I do?’

Amma scoffed, ‘Like you did, my foot! You thought you would reason and he would simply follow you back? Can you talk smooth only to me? What do I do with this wife of his? If my husband was so rude to me, I would not even look at him. But I wonder what spell he has cast on her. Such indifferent men only deserve sluts who can make them dance to their tunes.’

Half an hour later, the water bearer came to inform me, ‘The master is sitting in the outer room.’

My heart started beating fast. I wanted to go and pull him into the house, but Ammaji is very hard-hearted. She said, ‘Go and ask why he has come. Who belongs to him here?’

With folded hands, I said, ‘Ammaji, please call him inside. What if he leaves again!’

Amma retorted, ‘Who is he related to here for him to come in? I for one will not let him step in.’

While Ammaji was still ranting, the younger sister-in-law went out and brought him into the house. He really looked very distraught, as if he had been sick for months. The way my sister-in-law was pulling him, he looked like a bride leaving her parental home. Ammaji smiled and said, ‘Why have you brought him here? Whom does he know here?’

Anand just stood there with his head bowed, like a criminal. He could not open his mouth. Ammaji now asked, ‘Where were you for four days?’

‘Nowhere. Just around.’

‘You must have been at peace.’

‘Yes. There was no trouble.’

‘Right! It’s all there on your face.’

The sister-in-law brought in some refreshments. Eating the sweets, Anand looked as embarrassed as a newly-wed bride feels at her in-laws’ house! After that, Ammaji took him to her room. Mother and son talked for about half an hour. Although I had my ears tuned in, I could not hear the conversation clearly, but I could discern that sometimes Ammaji would cry and sometimes Anand would cry. When Ammaji came out for her puja I noticed that her eyes had turned red. Anand came straight to my room.

When I saw him approaching, I quickly covered my face and got into my bed, as if I was sleeping, unaware of the world around me. He saw me lying on the bed, approached the bed, called out to me softly and turned back. He didn't have the courage to wake me up. He was suffering inwardly, thinking himself to be the sole cause of the pain I was suffering. I had presumed that he would wake me up, then I would act proud and he would cajole me, but all these designs came to naught. Seeing him turn away, I could not hold myself back any longer. I quickly sat up and was getting off the bed when my legs shook and I felt as if I was falling. Anand hastily turned back again, caught me and said, 'Lie down, lie down. I will sit in the chair. What have you done to yourself?'

Gathering myself, I said, 'I am doing very well. How are you?'

'You should first have some food. Only then I will talk.'

I taunted him saying, 'Why should you be worried about whether I eat or not? You are busy with your tours!'

'Only my heart knows of the tours I have been on. But I'll talk later. Now you should wash up and eat something. You haven't had a sip of water for four days. Ram! Ram!'

I feigned ignorance of this and asked, 'Who told you that I have been fasting for four days? When you did not care for me, why would I give up food and water for you?'

'That is writ large on your face. It looks like a wilted flower.'

'Go look at your own face in the mirror first!'

Anand declared, 'As if I was any handsomer earlier! It matters little whether a dried-up tree is watered or not. I did not know that you would take up this vow of fasting. If I knew, I would not have left even if Amma had chased and beaten me!'

With contempt in my eyes, I said, 'Did you really think that I stayed back only for the sake of comforts?'

Anand quickly corrected himself and said, 'No, no, darling, I am not such an ass, but I never thought you would give up food and water completely. It was my great fortune that I met the cook, otherwise you would have given

up your life. This mistake will never be repeated. I swear! As for Ammaji, she was crying while singing your praises.'

I said happily, 'This means my austerities have been successful.'

'Have some milk. Then we can talk. There is so much to talk about!'

'I will. What's the hurry?'

He cajoled me, 'Until you eat something, I will think that you have not pardoned me.'

'I will eat only if you promise that you will never sulk and run away in this manner.'

'I swear it from the bottom of my heart.'

Sister, those three days were full of misery, but I do not regret them a bit. The way this three-day fast has cleansed our hearts, I swear it would not have been possible in any other way. Now I firmly believe that our lives will be peaceful. Write to me about yourself. Soon, very soon.

Yours,
Chanda

13

Delhi
20-2-1926

Dear Sister,

Reading your letter made me feel pity for you. No matter how obnoxious you think me to be, I can never—absolutely never—accept such horrible treatment at anybody's hands. I would have either given up my own life or never seen the face of such a mother-in-law again. You are welcome to your docility, your tolerance, and your devotion to your mother-in-law. I would have immediately left with Anand and even if I had to beg on the streets, I would never step into that house again. I not only pity you, I am also angry with you because you have no self-pride. It is women like you who have made these husbands and mothers-in-law think that they are the lords of the

world. ‘To hell with such homes where I am not respected.’ I will not accept even a loving husband at such a cost. You should have been born in the nineteenth century. In that era, your qualities would have earned you praise. In this era of independence and women’s agency, you are a relic of history. This is not the age of Sita or Damayanti. Men have ruled for ages. Now women must rule. But anyway, I will not damn you any more.

Now listen to my story. I had considered having the news of my condition printed in newspapers. But then it occurred to me that once it is out, friends would line up to see me. Somebody would come to ask after me, and somebody else would come to see me. Also, I am not a queen to have my health bulletin published every day. What would people think of me? Considering all this, I abandoned the thought of putting this out in the papers. I can’t tell you what my heart went through the entire day. At times, I considered poisoning myself, or running away. Several alarming thoughts about Vinod came to my mind. I also remembered several occasions on which I had displayed negligence towards Vinod. I had wanted him to provide me with everything, but had not wanted to provide him with anything. I wanted him to hover around me day and night like a bumblebee, or a kite. I used to get frustrated seeing him engrossed in books and papers. I used to spend most of my time adorning myself, rather than asking after him. It is only now that I understand that devotion is far more valuable than beauty. Beauty can charm the heart, but that which can please the soul is an entirely different thing.

A week passed. One day, in the morning, I was making preparations for going to my parents’ house—this house was becoming oppressive—when suddenly the postman came to deliver a letter. My heartbeat quickened. With shaking hands, I took the letter. The address was not in Vinod’s hand. It was clear that the handwriting was a woman’s, but I didn’t know whose it was. I immediately opened the letter and was startled to see the name at the bottom. It was from Kusum. I read the letter hurriedly, in one go. The letter contained this—

> Sister, after staying here for three days, Vinod Babu has left for Bombay. Perhaps he wants to go overseas. He will stay in Bombay for a few days. I tried my best to call him back to Delhi, but he would just not agree. You should send him a telegram on the address given below. I had coaxed this address out of him. He warned me to keep it a secret, but what's the point of hiding it from you? You should send the telegram immediately. Maybe he will not go then. Despite a lot of probing, Vinod refused to tell me what the matter was, but I could see that he was very unhappy. I am amazed that you could not make a man like him your own, but I had suspected this beforehand. The relation between beauty and vanity is like that between a lamp and its light. Vanity is the light that issues from the lamp of beauty . . .

I kept the letter aside and instantly telegraphed him to come back, saying I was very ill. I had expected Vinod to reply over the telegraph, but the entire day went by and yet there was no response from him. Whenever a bicycle passed by in front of the bungalow, I would immediately go and look out for him, thinking that perhaps it was the peon from the telegraph office. At night too, I kept waiting for the telegraph. I consoled my heart thinking that Vinod did not reply because he himself was on his way back.

Doubts began to rise in my mind again. Why did Vinod go to Kusum? Is it that he loves Kusum? Is this the love that has made him indifferent to me? Could it be that Kusum has cast a spell? What right did she have to welcome Vinod into her house? These thoughts disturbed my heart. I was getting angry with Kusum. Surely they must have been exchanging letters for many days. I again read Kusum's letter and this time every word of it had something for me to think over. I decided to write Kusum a letter and rant at her. I even wrote half of it but then I tore it up. Then I wrote a letter to Vinod. I will show you the letter if we have the occasion to meet. In the letter, I blurted out whatever came to my head. But this letter too met the same fate as the one I had written to Kusum. Only after having written the letter did I realize that it was the act of a mind which has turned insane. The only thought in my mind at that time was that he was with Kusum, and that the witch had cast her magic spell on him. The day somehow got over. The postman passed by many times but I did not even look towards him. I can't tell you, Chanda, how distraught my heart was. I wonder what I would have done to Kusum if I had laid my hands on her at that time.

At night, when I was in bed but could not sleep, it occurred to me—what if he has left for Europe? The very thought was disturbing. I was delirious . . . I felt as if I was drowning. If he had indeed left for Europe, then all hope was lost. I immediately got out of bed and looked at the clock. It was two o'clock. I woke up the servant and went to the telegraph office. I found the telegraph clerk sleeping in his chair. He was woken up with considerable difficulty. I sent a registered telegram. After the clerk had sent the telegram, I inquired, 'By when can I expect a reply?'

The clerk replied, 'Ask an astrologer. Who can say when he will reply? The telegraph cannot insist on him writing a reply. If nothing goes wrong, then a reply can be expected by eight or nine o'clock.'

In times of trouble, even a man's wisdom deserts him. Asking such a meaningless question only left me embarrassed. What a foolish woman the clerk must have thought me to be! Anyway, I sat there on a bench, and you would not believe it, I waited there till nine o'clock. How many hours do you think that was? Seven full hours! Hundreds of men came and went, but I kept waiting. My heartbeat quickened whenever the telegraph dummy would rattle, but I did not dare ask the clerk anything out of fear that he would be annoyed. But when the office clock struck nine, I very gingerly asked him, 'Is there no reply yet?'

The clerk said, 'I can see you are waiting. I would not have eaten your reply, had it come.' Unabashed, I again asked, 'So won't there be any reply?' The clerk turned his face away and said, 'You can continue waiting here for another few hours!'

Sister, these words pierced my heart like an arrow. My eyes welled up, but I still did not budge from there. Even now I had hope that perhaps there might be a reply. When two more hours passed, I was disheartened. Hai! Vinod has completely ruined me. When I left for home, tears were streaming from my eyes. I could not even see the way.

Suddenly, I heard the honking of a motorcar behind me. I stepped away from the road. At that moment, the thought of lying down under the motorcar and finishing off my life occurred to me. I wiped my eyes and looked towards the car. It was Bhuvan! And sitting next to Bhuvan was

Kusum! A sensation passed through my body. I felt as if my whole body was blazing with fire. I wanted to escape their notice, but then the car came to a halt and Kusum, stepping off the car, embraced me. Bhuvan kept sitting in the car, silent, as if he didn't even know me. Heartless, wicked man!

Kusum asked me, 'I was coming to see you, sister. Have you heard any news of him?'

To evade the question, I said, 'When did you come?'

I did not want to narrate the story of my suffering in front of Bhuvan.

Kusum said, 'Come, get in the car.'

But I declined, 'No, I will manage. If you find time, do visit me once.'

Kusum did not press me, and just got into the car and left. And I was left there standing and staring! Was this the same Kusum or someone else? How she had changed!

On the way home, I was thinking, *How does she know Bhuvan? Can it be that Vinod has sent her to keep an eye on me? Can it be that she has come to ask Bhuvan something about me?*

I had barely sat down after reaching home, when Kusum arrived. This time, she was not alone in the car. Vinod was with her. The sight of him rooted me to the spot! What I should have done was run to him, grab his hand and drag him from the car, but I could not move from my place. I sat there fixed as if I was a statue. My streak of self-pride became impatient to exhibit its vanity. Kusum helped Vinod out of the car and, holding his hand, brought him in. It was then that I noticed that Vinod had turned completely pale, and he had become so weak that he could not even stand without support. Worried, I asked, 'Why are you in this condition?'

Kusum intervened, 'That is for later. For now, spread out his bed quickly and call for some milk.'

I immediately laid out the bed and helped Vinod lie down. The milk was ready by then. At that moment, Kusum was like my mistress. I was dancing to her tunes. Dear Chanda, it was then that I understood that Vinod trusted Kusum more than he trusted me. I am not even worthy of his trust. My heart was getting restless and I wanted to ask Vinod hundreds of questions but Kusum did not move away from Vinod even for a moment. I am so foolish

that given the opportunity, I would have lined up questions for Vinod despite the miserable condition he was in.

When Vinod finally fell asleep, I, with tears in my eyes, asked Kusum, 'Sister, what is wrong? I sent a telegram, but there was no reply. At two o'clock in the night, I sent another urgent telegram registered as a reply. Till ten o'clock I kept waiting at the telegraph office. It was on my way back from there that I met you. Where did you find him?'

Kusum held my hand and led me to another room. 'First, tell me, what happened with Bhuvan? Look, you must be honest.'

I objected, 'Kusum, you are doing me an injustice by asking such a question. You should have understood there is absolutely nothing to it! Vinod was mistaken.'

'Without a reason?'

'Yes, as far as I can see, there was no reason.'

Kusum dismissed my assertion and said, 'I don't accept that. Why don't you admit that you put up this act only to taunt him, make him jealous and bring him closer to you?'

Amazed at Kusum's acumen, I retorted, 'That was just banter!'

Kusum now scolded me, 'Only to you. It struck him like lightning. You failed to understand him despite living with him for so many days! How could you find the time to understand him when you were busy beautifying yourself! Probably you think that this charming form of yours is all that there is. The currency of this form is short-lived. What lasts is something entirely different!'

Admitting my mistake, I said, 'At the very least, Vinod could have clarified it with me?'

Kusum laughed and said, 'That is exactly what he cannot do. It is impossible for him to ask you such things. He is one of those men who cannot live if they fall in a woman's esteem. He does not want to enforce any religious or moral obligations on anybody, be it man or woman. He is a votary of complete freedom for every being. He does not accept any restrictions save for one's own mind and will. We have talked a lot on this subject. Anyway, since he knew my address, he straight away came to me

from here. I understood that you could not get along with each other. I suspected that you were the one at fault.'

I asked, 'Why? Why did you suspect me?'

'Because I know you.'

'So do you still suspect me?'

'No, but not because you can restrain yourself, but because of tradition. Forgive me for being so blunt.'

'You think I don't love Vinod?'

She revealed me to myself, 'No. You do love Vinod, but you love yourself more. At least this was the case ten days ago; otherwise why would things come to such a pass? From here, Vinod came straight to me and, after living there for two or three days, left for Bombay. I asked him many questions but he didn't tell me anything. One day in Bombay, he consumed poison.'

My face lost all colour.

'As soon as he reached Bombay, he wrote me a letter, in which he gave me a detailed account of how the circumstances were here. And at the end, he had written, "I am tired of this life now. There is no other option for me but death."'

I sighed helplessly.

Kusum continued, 'I got worried when I received this letter, and immediately left for Bombay. When I reached, I found him almost dead. There was no hope that he would live. A relative of mine is a doctor there. When I called him and showed Vinod to him, he said, "He has consumed poison." Immediately the medicine was administered. For three days, the doctor cared for him day and night, and I too did not leave his side even for a moment. Late on the third day, he opened his eyes. I had received your first telegram, but who had the time to reply? We had to live in Bombay for three more days. Vinod had become so weak that it was impossible for him to undertake such a long journey. On the fourth day, when I proposed coming to Delhi, he declined, saying, "Now I will not go there." I continued reasoning with him, and finally he agreed on the condition that I first come and assess the situation here.'

I lamented, ‘Hai! God! How unfortunate I am!’

‘Not unfortunate, sister, just that you could not understand Vinod. He wanted me to come by myself, but I reckoned that given his condition, it would not be advisable to leave him alone. We departed from Bombay the day before yesterday. After reaching here, Vinod stayed in the waiting room, and I found Bhuvan by asking people of his whereabouts. I reprimanded Bhuvan so much that he started crying. He even told me that you had repudiated him. He has a roving eye, but he is good at heart. My remaining doubts were cleared after I met you on the road, so I brought Vinod to you. Now I hand over to you what is yours. I hope that this accident has awakened you enough not to allow things to reach such a point again. Learn to surrender yourself. Forget that you are a damsel. This is the fundamental mantra for a life full of joy. I don’t brag but if I want, I can snatch Vinod away from you today. But I am not your equal in beauty. I am inferior to even the soles of your feet. If you can serve, along with being beautiful, you will be invincible.’

I fell at Kusum’s feet and crying, I said, ‘Sister, I will remain indebted to you till my last breath for the charity you have bestowed upon me. If you had not helped me, I wonder what my destiny would have been.’

Sister, Kusum is leaving tomorrow. Now she seems like a goddess to me. I feel like washing her feet and drinking that holy water. Not only has she given my Vinod back to me, I have also gained the knowledge of what is true service and what is a woman’s duty. From today begins a new phase in my life, a phase in which not enjoyment and luxury, but tenderness and intimacy shall reign supreme.

Yours,
Padma

Translated from the Hindi by Vikas Jain



A Tearful Holi

1

No one knows when and where the practice of distorting people's names started. If anyone can bring to light the genesis of this universal malady, he would certainly earn a place in the history of the world. Panditji's real name was Sri Bilas, but his friends called him Silbil. Often it is found that names do influence people's habits and activities. Poor Silbil was truly a *silbil*. Sometimes he'd be found leaving for office with the drawstring of his pyjamas hanging out. In spite of wearing a big cap, his long plait would be peeking out from behind. The coat would be exquisite, the fabric à la mode, the stitching perfect, but always a tad long.

No one knows why he had such an aversion to festivals. Diwali would come and go, but the good fellow would not spend even a penny. To him, Holi was like going through a difficult test; he did not come out of his home for three days. He wore black clothes and sat at home. Friends snooped around to grab him. They couldn't possibly enter his house forcibly and make him a part of their revelry. He was trapped a few times but escaped untarnished by pleading and beseeching.

But the issue was complex now. After abiding by the scriptures and living a life of celibacy for twenty-five years, he had recently got married. Whatever was lacking in his long, celibate life was amply compensated by

three years of married life. He had no apprehensions about his wife. He was not one to allow his wife to dance on his head. In this respect he was old-fashioned. When sufficiently chastised, his wife would not show the effrontery to even touch the colours. The problem was that his in-laws were also coming to celebrate Holi at his home. As the old saying goes—*Behn andar toh bhai sikandar* or in the sister's house, the brothers are warriors like Alexander. He could not devise a plan to shield himself from the attack of these warriors. Friends could not enter the house, but who could stop warriors? His wife widened her eyes and said, 'Hey Mister, won't you fetch some colours for our home?'

Silbil frowned and said, 'I'm telling you once and for all—and I don't like to repeat myself—neither will there be any colours at home nor shall anyone touch it. I feel nauseated when I see red smudges on clothes. No Holi revelry in our home!'

His wife hung her head and said, 'Well, as you wish. We've nothing to do with Holi? When you won't touch colours, how can I?'

Silbil was delighted and said, 'Indeed, this is true loyalty.'

'But my brothers are coming, they may not agree with us.'

'I have conceived a plan for them, and it is your responsibility to make it successful. I will feign sickness and lie down with a duvet over me. You just have to tell them that I have fever. And we are done.'

His wife shot him a curious glance and said, 'God forbid! What are you saying? May your enemies have fever! If it dares to come here, I'll burn its face.'

'Is there any other way out, then?'

'You can hide in the small closet upstairs. I will tell them that you've taken *julaab* and if you come out, you might catch a cold.'

Panditji was thrilled. 'Yes, yes, what a wonderful idea!'

2

It is the day of Holi. There is lot of hustle and bustle outside. Earlier, no other colours except saffron and *gulal* were used. But now, blue, green,

black and all other colours are blended together and it is impossible for people to escape this amalgamation. Silbil's two brothers-in-law were the targets of all the women, men and children of the neighbourhood. They too had prepared a mixture of colours. Warriors were attacking. The floor, the walls and even the pictures of the outer courtyard were smudged with colours, and the condition of the home was similar. How could the damsels of the neighbourhood hold back? Even the water in the drains had become colourful.

Silbil's elder brother-in-law asked, 'O Champa, is he really ill? Didn't he come down for his meal?'

Champa bowed her head and said, 'Yes, brother. His stomach has been aching since yesterday and the doctor has asked him not to come out into the open air.' After some time, the younger brother-in-law said, 'Sister, won't he come down? Is it so serious? Shall I go up and see?'

Champa grabbed his hand. 'No, no, don't go upstairs. He won't play Holi. The doctor has forbidden it.'

The two brothers were disappointed.

All of a sudden, an idea came to her younger brother. 'What if we play Holi wearing brother-in-law's clothes? *They* aren't sick. The elder brother thought it a good idea. What could the poor sister do now? These warriors snatched the keys from her hand and took out all of Silbil's clothes and splashed colour on them. They did not even spare his handkerchief. When Champa hung them in the courtyard to dry, it seemed as if the dyer had dyed the clothes. Silbil observed all this from above, but did not utter a word. It was heart-breaking to see this. All the clothes were spoiled. 'There's nothing left to wear for the office. I don't know what enmity these wicked souls had with my clothes!'

A variety of delicious food was being prepared. A Brahmin woman from the neighbourhood was assisting Champa. When the two brothers-in-law and the others sat for food in the courtyard, the elder one asked Champa: 'Have you prepared any khichri for him? Since the poor soul can't eat puris today.'

Champa replied, 'Not yet, but I'll do it now.'

‘Are you out of your mind? Didn’t you think about what he’s going to eat? You were never so careless! Go and fetch some rice and mung dal.’

So, khichri was cooked. The guests started having food and Silbil wept over his misfortune. He believed that the root cause of all this was his marriage. ‘If Champa hadn’t been here, my brothers-in-law wouldn’t have come. The clothes wouldn’t have been spoiled. Why should I be made to eat khichri on Holi?’

It was no use crying over spilt milk. By the time everyone finished their food, the khichri was ready. The elder brother-in-law sent Champa upstairs to deliver the khichri. Silbil gawked at the plate and said, ‘Take it away.’

‘Will you fast today?’

‘Of course, if you want me to.’

‘What is my fault? I have been busy working since morning. My brother got it prepared and sent me up to give it to you.’

‘Yes, I can see that I’m not the proprietor of the house any more. Warriors have occupied it. And I don’t believe it. If you wanted, the plate could have reached me before other people had had their meal. What shall I say? I consider it against your duty towards your husband.’

‘You saw how they kept me busy.’

‘Good joke! People are having samosas and snacks. And I’m served khichri. O my fate!’

‘Have a few morsels. The moment I get the chance, I will bring you the other delicacies.’

‘All my clothes are tainted. How shall I go to office now? I didn’t like this jollity at all. I call it sheer roguishness. Can I ask why you gave them the keys to the chest?’

‘Didn’t you hear? They snatched the keys forcefully. What could I have done?’

‘Let bygones be bygones. Take this plate away. If you consider it your duty, bring the other plate. Or else, I’d be better off fasting today.’

Suddenly, footsteps were heard. Silbil saw the two brothers coming. He frowned, covered his face with the quilt and started groaning.

The elder brother inquired, ‘How do you feel now? Have some khichri.’ Silbil grimaced and said, ‘I don’t feel like having anything now.’

‘Oh no! It’s injurious to keep your stomach empty. Eat some khichri.’

In his heart of hearts, poor Silbil cursed the two devils and swallowed the khichri like a bitter pill. On the eve of this Holi, khichri was written in his fate. They did not budge an inch until all of the khichri was finished. It seemed as if prison officials were forcibly making a fasting inmate eat. The poor fellow had to gulp down this poison. There was no space left in his stomach for other delicacies.

3

At ten in the night, Champa took a plate of delectable food to her husband. He was boiling with rage. ‘Who cares about me while the brothers are there? I wonder where these devils came from. Made me fast for a whole day and still no sign of food.’ Finally, when he saw Champa with the food, he was somewhat mollified. But he couldn’t help saying, ‘It’s too early, why didn’t you come after a few more hours?’

Champa put the plate down and replied, ‘Nothing pleases you. There are two guests at home—shouldn’t I treat them well? Even you won’t like it if I don’t. After all, who comes to visit us daily?’

‘God forbid that they come daily. I am devastated after a single day.’

Suddenly, a delightful smile appeared on Panditji’s face at the sight of the fragrant, delicious plate of food. He showered appreciation on Champa as he picked up each new delicacy. ‘Champa! To tell you the truth, I have never tasted this thing before. What can a cursed confectioner make? I feel like giving you some reward.’

‘You are making fun of me. What can I do? I only tried my best.’

‘No, dear. I’m telling the truth; even my soul is contented now. Today, I have come to know that food is not related to the stomach as much as it is to the soul. Tell me, how can I reward you?’

‘Will you give whatever I ask for?’

‘I will. I swear by this *janeyu*, the sacred thread.’

‘If you don’t, I’ll feel embarrassed.’

‘I told you I will. Should I give it in writing?’

‘All right. My earnest wish is—let me play Holi with you.’

Panditji turned pale. He stared at her and said, ‘Play Holi with you? I don’t play Holi and I never have. If I had to play Holi, why should I hide myself inside the house?’

‘Don’t play with the others, but you have to play with me.’

‘It is against my principles. How can an act that is permissible inside the house be impermissible outside? Just think!’

Champa lowered her head and said, ‘There are indeed many things that are permissible inside the house, but considered not only impermissible but sinful outside the house.’

Panditji replied regretfully, ‘All right. You won, I lost. Now I just ask for this concession . . .’

‘Give me my reward first and ask for concessions later.’ And Champa picked up a jug containing liquid colours and poured it all over Panditji, drenching him completely. Before he could make any move to flee the scene, she smeared a handful of gulal on his face.

Panditji looked as though he would burst into tears and said, ‘Come on, do your worst. I didn’t know that you would betray me this way.’

When Champa glanced at her husband’s face, she found it suffused with deep sorrow. She said regretfully, ‘Did you really take it to heart? I thought you were just teasing me.’

Mr Bilas said in a quivering voice, ‘No, Champa. I didn’t take it to heart. Yes, you reminded me of my obligation, which I had forgotten because of my cowardice. The picture you see in front of you is of my intimate friend Manhar Nath, who is not in this world now. I can’t tell you how jolly, good-natured and courageous he was. He used to worry about the condition of the country greatly. He had decided the objective of his life when he was barely nineteen or twenty years old. He would grab every opportunity for voluntary service with such eagerness, as though it would bring him some wealth. He was of an independent spirit. There was not the slightest trace of greed in him. Other friends would go for outings and recreation but his way

was different from all the others. Ready to lay down his life for truth, he felt upset whenever he witnessed any injustice. If he read any news of injustice and oppression in the newspapers, his face would turn red with anger. I have not seen another man like him. He would have been a respectable figure in society if he hadn't died a premature death. He would risk his life to help a person in trouble. He had great regard for women, who were for him objects of worship and devotion! Five years ago, on the day of Holi, I was in a state of inebriation after having had bhang and soaked in colour from head to toe. I had gone to fetch him so we could listen to music together, but I saw that he was all set to leave for somewhere. I asked him, "Where are you going?"

'He grabbed my hand. "You've come at the right time; otherwise I would have had to go searching for somebody. An orphaned old lady has died; I cannot find anyone to carry her to the river. Some have gone to visit their friends, some are dead drunk, some are busy inviting their friends and some are organizing parties of dance and mirth. There is no one to carry this dead body! How can a Brahmin or a Kshatriya touch the body of this *chamarin*? Their faith would get polluted. No one is ready to do this; it is just me and I found a Kahar with great difficulty; a fourth person is needed. Now God has sent you. Come, let's go."

'Oh! If I'd known that that was going to be my dear Manhar's last request, this sorrow would not have gnawed at my heart so acutely today. Many friends had gathered at my house, and the music was blaring. At that moment, I was feeling a bit awkward about leaving home to carry a dead body to the river. I said, "Brother, I can't go at this moment; I have guests at home and I'd come to invite you to join us."

'Manhar looked at me scornfully and said, "All right! You go, I will find someone else. But I did not expect this from you! You've also turned out exactly like the others. It is not a new thing. If we had not forgotten our obligations, why should a situation like this arise? Curse on this Holi! Festivals do not mean sightseeing, eating delicious food and wearing fancy clothes. It is *brata* and penance. To express love and sympathy for people is the real message of festivals."

‘He left after saying that. I did not like this advice at that time. He had no right to lecture me about my own sense of duty. I returned home but those words kept echoing in my ears continuously. All the fun of Holi was spoilt. We did not meet each other for a month. The college was closed for exam preparations, so we did not meet there either. I did not know how and when he fell ill and when he left for home. Suddenly, one day I received his letter. Oh! It breaks my heart to read that letter even today.’

Mr Bilas could not speak for a moment because he was choked with emotion. Then he resumed, ‘Someday I will show you his letter in which he had asked me to go and visit him for the last time. “We might not have another opportunity to meet in this life again,” he had written. The letter fell from my hand. His house was in Meerut district. Half an hour was left for the next train to leave. I set off immediately, but it was not in my fate to see him alive. He passed away before I reached. Champa, after that day I did not play Holi again. Not only Holi, I’ve stayed away from all festivals. Perhaps God has not given me the strength to undertake any worthwhile work. I desperately want someone to get me into some kind of social service. I cannot lead but I am ready to follow. But there is no one to lead me. By splashing these colours on me today you have reminded me of that curse. May God make me like “Manhar”, the heart-stealer, not only in my thoughts but in my deeds as well.’

Mr Bilas took the gulal from the plate and splashed it on that picture and joined his palms together in reverence to the figure in the frame.

Translated from the Urdu by M. Asaduddin



The Grinding Woman's Well

On her deathbed, Gomti said to Chaudhuri Vinayak Singh, 'Chaudhuri, it has been the desire of my life.'

With gravity in his voice, he consoled her, 'Don't you worry, Kaki, God will fulfil your wish. I will call the labourers today itself and put them to work. God willing, you will drink water from your own well. How much do you have on you? You must have counted the money.'

Putting together the scattered shreds of memory with her eyes closed, Gomti spoke, 'Bhaiya, how should I know? Whatever money there is—it's all in the pot. Just ensure that the amount suffices. Who will you go to and beg from?'

Weighing the sealed pot in his hands, Chaudhuri said, 'You are right, Kaki, there is no one so generous to part with money these days. People are not ready to give even a handful of alms, who will make a donation for a well? You are blessed that you have handed over the savings of your lifetime for a noble cause.'

Gomti averred with a sense of pride, 'Bhaiya, you were so small. When your *kaka* died, I didn't have a penny in my hands. I would starve for days. Whatever he had, his ailment consumed. But he was a real devotee of God, so he was called away early. From that day onwards you have seen for yourself how I have survived. On a single night I have ground tons of grains at a stretch. Son! Those who saw me would wonder what gave me such

strength. There was just this wish—to construct a well in his memory in the village. The name should be cherished. That is what makes people yearn for a daughter or a son.'

Having expressed her will to Chaudhuri Vinayak Singh, the old woman, Gomti, left for her heavenly abode. The last words on her lips as she lay dying were, 'Do not delay the construction of the well.' The woman sure had money, but no one expected it to be a handsome amount of two thousand rupees. She would hide her money as if it was something to be ashamed of. Chaudhuri was the chief of the village and a man known for his honesty. So the old woman had entrusted him with this responsibility.

Chaudhuri did not spend much on her last rites. Once relieved of the rituals, he called his son Harnaath Singh and drew up an estimate for brick, lime, stone and concrete for the construction of the well. Harnaath was a dealer in grains. He listened for some time, then said, 'Is there any harm if we put aside the construction for a few months?'

Chaudhuri nodded and said, 'There is no harm as such, but why delay at all? She has already given the money. We will earn a good name for free. Even while dying she had urged me to get the well constructed as soon as possible.'

Harnaath said, 'I know but now that the market is brisk, let us store grains worth three thousand rupees. We will earn a 25 per cent profit on it by Aghan and Poos. I will pay you some interest.'

Chaudhuri was in a dilemma. He had his doubts, coupled with a sense of fear. If the sum of two thousand could turn into two and a half thousand, he could get some embellishment work done. But there was the fear of loss at the same time. He could not hide his feelings and so he said, 'What if we suffer a loss?'

A cross Harnaath said, 'Why would there be a loss? What makes you think so?'

Chaudhuri said, 'But what if there is a loss, then?'

Agitated, Harnaath said, 'Why don't you say that you don't want to give me the money? The pious man that you think you are!'

Like other elderly people, Chaudhuri was also in awe of his son. He said in a subdued tone, ‘When did I say I will not give you the money? But it is not ours, so we must think twice before touching it. Who knows about business? What if the prices fall further, or the grains get infected, or some claimant puts the house on fire? Just keep all these things in mind.’

Harnaath retorted, ‘If you start thinking this way, anything can happen. You may as well say that the house might get robbed, or that a strong standing wall might just collapse of its own accord. These things keep happening.’

Now Chaudhuri had no excuse to offer. Posing as a fighter, he had entered the arena and slapped his thighs to challenge his opponent but he collapsed when the sword flashed. Looking sideways, he said, ‘All right then, how much do you want?’

Seeing his opponent retreat, Harnaath, like an accomplished warrior, said, ‘Give me everything. I am not a child to be amused with a hundred or a fifty.’

Chaudhuri consented. Nobody had seen Gomti giving him the money. There was no possibility of people talking ill of him. Harnaath hoarded the grains. Sacks of grain piled up. Accustomed to sound sleep, Chaudhuri would now keep a watch on the stock. He kept such a tight vigil that even a mouse dared not enter. Chaudhuri would rush with an alacrity that would put even a cat to shame. Six months passed thus. The grains were sold and there was a profit of a full five hundred rupees.

Harnaath said, ‘Take fifty rupees out of this.’

Irritated, Chaudhuri said, ‘Are you giving me alms! If you had taken so much money from a moneylender, he would have charged a minimum interest of two hundred rupees.’

Harnaath avoided further argument and handed him one hundred and fifty rupees. Chaudhuri’s soul had never experienced such ecstasy. At night when he went to his room to sleep, he felt as if the old woman was standing there and smiling. His heartbeat increased. He was not sleepy, nor under intoxication. Gomti stood there before him with a smile playing on her lips. But her withered face had a strange aura of freshness on it.

Many years passed. Chaudhuri was restless and would constantly think of getting the money back from Harnaath. But Harnaath offered some excuse or the other. He would give him a small interest at the end of every year but for the principle, he would come up with a thousand excuses. One way or the other it was the same old story of having to pay the creditors or having already borrowed from the lenders. However, his business was growing. Finally, one day, Chaudhuri warned him, 'I don't care whether your business flourishes or declines. This month you will have to return the money.' Harnaath tried to come up with many excuses but Chaudhuri was adamant.

Irritated, Harnaath said, 'I say just wait for another two months. As soon as the stuff is sold out, I will pay back the entire amount.'

Chaudhuri responded firmly, 'Your goods will never sell nor will your two months ever come. I want the money back this very day.'

Fuming, Harnaath stood up, got the money and threw it at Chaudhuri.

Chaudhuri said sheepishly, 'So you had the money with you!'

'One doesn't do business with words.'

'Give me just five hundred rupees. You can pay the rest in two months' time. Not all of it is needed today.'

Harnaath said arrogantly, 'The money is yours. I don't care if you spend it or keep it. Are all the moneylenders in this world dead that I should tolerate your overbearing attitude?'

Chaudhuri put the money in a niche. The zeal to lay the foundation of the well had cooled down. Although Harnaath had returned the money, he was planning something else. Around midnight, when the house was wrapped in silence, he pushed the door of Chaudhuri's room and crept in. Chaudhuri was in a deep slumber. Harnaath tried to get the money kept in two bags and slip out. But as he reached for them, he suddenly saw Gomti in front of him. She was firmly holding both the bags in her hands. Frightened, Harnaath stepped back.

Then it struck him that it might be his imagination. He reached for the bags again, but now the figure got so eerie that Harnaath could not stand

there for a moment. He rushed back, but fell down unconscious in the corridor.

He had collected money from his resources to give to the dealers. When Chaudhuri expressed his anger, he had thrown back the same money at him thinking he would steal it back in the night. Also, he planned to raise an alarm so that he would not be suspected. But the scheme had backfired. The creditors started asking for their money. He could not keep them at bay on hollow promises for long. Things worsened and some of them threatened to sue him, and one of them even lodged a complaint for three hundred rupees. Poor Harnaath was in big trouble.

Harnaath would sit at the shop. Chaudhuri no longer had anything to do with it. But the reputation of the shop was because of Chaudhuri. People respected him as a man of fair dealings. None approached him directly for money, but he would avoid people. He had, however, made up his mind that come what may, he would not touch the money kept for the well.

At night, a Muslim peon of a businessman came to his door and shouted insults at him. Chaudhuri was boiling with anger and felt like going and pulling out his moustache. But he calmed himself. These insults were not meant for him. What the son owes should not necessarily fall on the head of the father. It was not his duty to pay the loans of his son.

When he sat down for his meal, his wife asked, 'What is this quarrel all about?'

Chaudhuri said in a feeble voice, 'I have not created this mess.'

'Who else, then? My son swears he has just a little money. You have taken back all the money from him.'

'He left me with no choice. I can't use the money for my own ends. It would be like offering *Fateha* from a sweet-shop for my grandfather.'

'So you like this humiliation?'

'How can I help this? Will the well ever be made? Already five years have passed.'

'He has not had dinner. Even in the morning he hardly touched his food.'

'Why did you not ask him to eat? His not eating will not get him money.'

'Why don't you go yourself and counsel him?'

‘He considers me his greatest enemy now.’

‘I am going to give him the money. When you get it back, get the well constructed.’

‘Don’t you ever do anything like that! I won’t prove myself a cheat even if my house is ruined.’

But his wife did not pay heed to the moral considerations of her husband. She quickly went inside and was about to seize the bags when she let out a cry and backed away. Her whole body throbbed like the strings of a guitar.

Worried, Chaudhuri asked, ‘What happened? Are you feeling giddy?’

Casting a frightful glance towards the niche, she said, ‘There . . . look, the witch is there!’

Chaudhuri turned his eyes to the same direction and said, ‘What witch are you talking about? I do not see anyone there.’

‘My heart is pounding. For a moment I felt that the old woman had caught my hand.’

‘You are imagining things. It has been five years since the old woman died. Is she still sitting here?’

‘I can’t doubt my eyes. It was her! No one else. My son also said he saw her in the night, holding the bags.’

‘But when did he come to my room in the night?’

‘He wanted to talk to you regarding the money. Seeing her, he fled.’

‘Well, try again. Let me see.’

The wife put both her hands on her ears and said, ‘*Na baba*, I will not step into the room ever again.’ Chaudhuri said, ‘All right. Let me check.’

Chaudhuri went inside and picked up the bags from the niche. He did not feel anything unusual—not even a shadow of the woman. His wife was peeping in from the door. Chaudhuri came out and said boldly, ‘I do not see anything. If she was indeed here where did she vanish now?’

His wife replied, ‘I don’t know why you fail to see her. Seems like she has a soft corner for you. This is why she moved away when you went.’

‘It was pure illusion and nothing else.’

‘Let me call my son. He will testify to this.’

‘Go again and see for yourself. I am standing right here.’

The wife mustered up some courage. She went towards the niche, reached for the bags with apprehension, let out a shriek and came running back to the courtyard to catch her breath. Chaudhuri too came to her wonderstruck and asked, 'What was it? Why did you come back running for no reason at all? I still did not see anything.'

The wife replied, 'Let me go. You might as well have taken my life. What has come over your eyes? See, the witch is still standing there.'

Meanwhile Harnaath too arrived. Finding his mother in the yard pale and nervous, he asked, 'What happened? How are you feeling, mother?'

She replied, 'The witch appeared again today. Son, I thought of giving you the money. When there is enough money, the well can be made. But as I tried to grab the bags, the witch held my hands. I was almost dead.'

Harnaath said, 'We should call for a good *ojha* who can beat her away.'

Chaudhuri asked, 'Did you see her in the night?'

Harnaath replied, 'Yes, I wanted to consult you about some issue. As I came in, I saw the witch standing by the niche. I lost my senses and ran away.'

Chaudhuri said, 'All right then, give it one more try.'

The wife protested, 'I will not let him go there again, even if you offered me a lakh.'

Harnaath said, 'Who is going? Not me, ever.'

Chaudhuri averred, 'But I can't see her. What does it mean?'

'Who knows? She may be scared of you. Let us send for an ojha.'

'Really, this is complicated. And what about the court case of Beju Pandey?'

These days, Harnaath scorned Chaudhuri to such a degree that he would not share any matter related to the shop with him. Looking far away towards the yard, as if talking to the air, he said, 'What will be, will be. What more can one draw from me than my life? What I have already consumed, I can't vomit.'

Chaudhuri said, 'What if he gets the order issued against us?'

Harnaath replied, 'Then what? There is stuff worth four or five hundred rupees. It will be put on auction.'

‘The business will be ruined.’

‘How long will I continue shedding tears in the name of business? Had I known that you were compelled by such a sense of urgency to get the well constructed, would I have started this work? Even earlier we somehow managed to earn our daily bread. At the most I will have to spend some months in jail. What else can I expect?’

The mother said, ‘I will throw fire at the face of anyone who dares take you to prison. Who will do that as long as your mother is alive?’

Harnaath said philosophically, ‘Parents are the companions of your life, not the companions of your actions.’

Chaudhuri loved his son very much. He had doubted his son because of the way he’d dilly-dallied. He had been scared that he’d never get the money back. But now he realized that his son was really facing tough times. If he was jailed or the shop was auctioned off, the name of the family would be tarnished. There was nothing wrong if Gomti’s money was used. The shop must somehow keep going. There would be sufficient money saved in the days to come.

Suddenly somebody called out from the outside, ‘Harnaath Singh!’

Harnaath’s face turned white.

Chaudhuri asked, ‘Who is there?’

‘He is the auction clerk.’

‘Has he come to put the shop on auction?’

‘I suppose so.’

‘How much is the penalty?’

‘Twelve hundred rupees.’

‘Can’t we bargain with the clerk?’

‘We could make a settlement, but the lender would have already greased his palms.’

‘Anyway, take twelve hundred rupees from Gomti’s money.’

‘Who can dare touch that money now? Who knows what may befall?’

‘No one is going to devour the money. Let me do it myself.’

Chaudhuri was somewhat scared that this time he might see the woman. But his fear was baseless. He took out twelve hundred rupees from one bag,

put it into another bag and gave it to Harnaath. By the evening not a single penny was left out of that two thousand.

Twelve years passed. Now there is neither a Chaudhuri nor a Harnaath in this world. As long as Chaudhuri lived, he was gripped by the worry to get the well made. Even when he breathed his last, he was talking about the well. But the shop was always suffering losses. The business collapsed with Chaudhuri's death. Not content with the profit of an anna and driven by the greed to double and triple the gain, Harnaath started gambling. Within a year the shop was closed down for good. Jewellery, clothing and utensils, everything went to dust.

Exactly one year after the death of Chaudhuri, Harnaath also bade goodbye to this world of profit and loss. There was no one to take care of the helpless mother. She fell ill and couldn't survive without medicines. For three or four months she bore all kinds of pain and was finally relieved forever. Now the daughter-in-law was the only member of the family, left with a child in her womb. The poor soul had no one to fall back on. She couldn't even work in this condition. Somehow, she managed to struggle for five or six months, sewing clothes for the neighbours to make ends meet. Going by the symptoms, she expected a baby boy. She felt happy that she would get an anchor to support her. The birth of a girl child took away her last hope.

The mother hardened her heart. She would not let the infant touch her breasts. The neighbours intervened and made her realize her duty as a mother. Only then was she ready to feed the child. But not a drop of milk would come out. The wretched soul of the mother shuddered and her whole being quaked, as the motherly instinct created an upheaval in her with love and affection for the poor child. She would have felt herself blessed if the last drop of her blood could turn into milk.

Her eyes flooded with tears looking at the pitiable and innocent face of her child. Love, prayers, good wishes and blessings would flow from her eyes and bathe the child like the cool moonlight washed flowers. But the child was not lucky enough to get her mother's love. The mother did her

best to keep the child alive with the milk squeezed from her blood and milk from the market. As a result, *she* was reduced to skin and bones.

One day people found her lying on the floor, with the little child sucking at her dry breasts. A body which had borne the onslaughts of pain and poverty was hardly left with a drop of blood to produce milk.

The child was brought up by kind neighbours. One day, while digging up grass, she came to the spot where Gomti's house had stood. The hut had been long gone. Here and there you could see only a few crumbling walls. On an impulse, the girl started digging the earth with her tool. She kept on digging from noon till late in the evening. She was so lost in her work that she had little care for hunger or thirst, nor did she have any kind of fear. It was getting dark but she sat there digging. After dark, not even peasants would dare cross this place. This little girl fearlessly kept digging up the ground. When it was all dark, she left.

The next day she got up in the wee hours of the morning. She dug up more grass in the morning than she had done the whole of the previous day. In the afternoon she went to the same spot with her bamboo basket and tool. But today she was not alone. She was accompanied by two boys. Till evening the three of them kept digging the well. The girl would go deeper and deeper and the boys would move the earth out.

On the third day two more boys joined the sport. The fun continued till the evening. Today the hole was as deep as the length of two hands. This strange sport had filled the village boys and girls with a new energy and unprecedented zeal.

The fourth day witnessed some more boys joining the group. Everything was discussed, including who would enter the hole and who would throw out the soil. The hole was now four hands deep. But so far, nobody knew of it except the children. One day a farmer happened to pass by that ruin, searching for his buffalo that had gone missing. Seeing a huge heap of earth, a big hole and an oil lamp with flickering light, he ran away frightened.

Many others came. As there were many of them, there was no room for fear. When they went closer, they found the girl sitting there.

One of them asked, ‘Arré, have you dug this up?’

The girl said, ‘Yes, it was me.’

‘What for?’

‘I will make a well.’

‘How will you be able to do that?’

‘As I have dug up this much, I will dig more. There are many boys who come here to play. They could be of help.’

‘It seems you have no love for your life, or for the others’ either. Do not try to dig up this place ever again.’

The next day the rest of the group did not turn up. The girl alone worked throughout the day. In the evening the lamp was lit again and she was seen sitting there with her tool in her hands. The villagers beat her and locked her up in a room. As soon as she found a chance to escape, she reached the place again.

The villagers are usually people of faith. They could discover in the girl a spiritual connection. Eventually they became attached to her divine urge. Work for the construction of the well began.

As they dug, the girl started moulding bricks with the wet earth. All the boys of the village came and offered their help. In the moonlit night when people slept, she moulded bricks. No one knew what filled her with such indefatigable energy. This seven-year-old girl would outdo people thrice her age in wit and understanding.

Finally, the day came when the construction of the well was finished; it was ready, with a concrete platform around it. That day the girl slept on the platform. Her happiness knew no bounds. She would chuckle and sing.

In the morning, her dead body was found on the platform of the well. From that day onwards people started believing her to be Gomti and the well came to be called ‘Pisanhaari’s well’.

Translated from the Urdu by Sarfaraz Nawaz



A Wedding That Turned into a Funeral

1

On the roof of a small house in a hilly town in Madhya Pradesh, a young man sat as if absorbed in the stillness of the evening. In front of him, the reddish-blue mountains appeared grave, secretive, harmonious and alluring in the moon's anaemic light, and a silvery stream of water below appeared as though all the harmony, all the gravity, all the secrets of the mountains had been absorbed into its radiant flow. The young man's attire indicated that he was not very well-off. But yes, his face was lustrous and determined. His eyes weren't rimmed by spectacles, moustache was not upturned, his hair hadn't been combed, his wrist lacked a watch; indeed there wasn't even a fountain pen in his coat pocket. He was either a lover of principle or an enemy of frippery.

The young man was looking towards the mountain, thoughtful, silent, when suddenly he heard the thunder's terrible sound. The river's sweet song was drowned in the roar of the noise. It seemed as if the horrific sound had shaken even the mountains, as though a war had broken out. It was a train, trundling towards him on the bridge over the river.

A young woman emerged from a room on to the terrace and said, 'The train is already here today. It had to play the enemy's role, and today!'

The young man held her hand and said, ‘Love! I don’t wish to go anywhere; I have decided. I’d agreed to it for your sake but I don’t feel like going any more. Three years!’

In a timid voice, the young woman said, ‘At least after three years of separation, there’ll be nothing in our way lifelong. You’ve taken this decision, now see it through, I’ll endure any and every sorrow at the prospect of eternal happiness.’

She went inside on the pretext of getting the food. She could not control her tears any longer. These two had now been married a year—it was their first anniversary. The boy, having finished his MA from Bombay University, was a teacher in a college in Nagpur. The marital and social revolutions of this era hadn’t disturbed him one bit. Such a profound attachment to traditional practices was perhaps rarely to be found even in the aged. His parents had married him off to this young girl once he’d become a professor. As is customary, in the hide-and-seek that followed, they’d together found the jewel of love. Whenever there were holidays, but only then, mind you, he’d come by the first train and leave by the last. Those few days would pass like a sweet dream.

The two would part crying like children. She’d stand in this very room and keep looking at him till the merciless mountains swallowed him up. Not even a full year had passed when separation started plotting its evil plan. Keshav received an invitation to complete his education abroad. His friends congratulated him. Who is so lucky as to receive such an opportunity to advance his fortune without asking for it? Keshav, however, was not very happy. He reached home in a dilemma. His parents and relatives strongly opposed the plan.

The obstacles placed in his way here were no fewer than the congratulations he had received in the city. But there was no limit to Subhadra’s aspirations. Perhaps she wanted to see Keshav at the pinnacle of success. She would adhere to the same ideal of serving her husband even then. She would massage his head, iron his dhoti, press his feet and fan him in the heat. A worshipper’s wishes are reserved only for the worshipped. She would get a temple of gold constructed for him, adorn his throne with

gems, bring him flowers from heaven, but remain a worshipper herself. The desire for a crown upon her head or yellow robes never occurred to her. Subhadra did not budge till Keshav promised her that he would go abroad; his parents called her names—a disgrace, a defamer—but agreed in the end. All the preparations were taken care of. The station was close by. The train would halt at this station for a long time. For the residents of the village who lived next to the station, the coming of the train wasn't an enemy attack, but the arrival of a friend. The train was here. Subhadra, having finished cooking, had come to help her husband wash his hands. At this point, her love for Keshav suddenly made Subhadra restless. Who knows what might happen in three years? She felt a strong desire to say—dearest, don't go. We'll eat less, we'll dress simply, but at least we won't spend our days crying. If Keshav ever took a few weeks or a month to visit, she'd start feeling anxious. She'd wish she could fly to his place and visit him. How then would these three heartless years pass? But she shoved these dispiriting thoughts aside firmly, rose quivering, and said, 'What I want is no different. When I think of the three years, it seems like an aeon. But when I think of the honour and esteem you shall be granted abroad, these three years seem like three days. You'll forget me as soon as you set foot on the ship. There'll be new sights to captivate you. You won't think of home once you're absorbed in scholarly exchanges in Europe. There's nothing for me to do but cry. Memories shall be my life's sole basis. But what do I do, the longing for life's pleasures won't leave me be. And then, a separation whose end shall bring us all of life's greatness is true penance. Nobody is granted a boon without doing penance.'

Keshav also realized it was foolhardy to give up such a good opportunity for the improvement of his prospects to satisfy a momentary impulse. He stood up and said, 'Don't cry, or I shan't feel at ease.'

Subhadra, taking his hand in hers, held him close and, looking at him with eyes full of tears, said, 'Write to me regularly.'

Teary-eyed but smiling, she added, 'Watch out, don't get ensnared by a girl abroad.' Keshav sat on the bed again and said, 'If you've such a suspicion, I shan't go at all.'

Subhadra embraced him, looked at him with trusting eyes, and said, ‘I was only joking. If you get some time off, do come home at least once.’

‘No, love, I may not have any time off in between. But the moment I hear that you’re dissolving in your tears, that you’ve stopped eating, I’ll leave for home at once to ensure that my flower does not wilt one bit.’

They embraced and bid farewell to each other. Friends and relatives were gathered outside. Keshav touched the feet of those who were older, hugged the young, and left for the station. His friends accompanied him to the station. The train carried the passenger off in an instant.

Keshav sat in the train gazing upon the mountains’ beauty, while Subhadra sat on the ground, sobbing softly.

2

Time passed. As it does when one is ill—the day heavy as a mountain, the night black as ink. She’d spend all night imploring the dusk to turn to day, and at dawn implore the day to turn to night. She went to stay with her parents thinking she’d feel better. For five or ten days, it helped, then she felt even worse, and ran back to her in-laws’. One who is sick keeps tossing and turning just to feel a little better.

For the first five or six months, a letter from Keshav would arrive every fortnight. These contained little of the sadness of separation but many descriptions of new sights. But Subhadra was satisfied. Writing a letter, she’d be conscious of nothing but the pain of separation. At times, anxious and impatient, she’d regret having let him go. What if I die one day and never get to see him again.

But in the sixth month, even the letters started coming late. For several months, there’d be one letter every month, then even that stopped. Subhadra would write four or five letters, and get one letter in response; even that one was written without enthusiasm—a long litany of complaints about how much work there was and how little time. Not one sentence which would put her heart at rest, which would soothe her wounds. Ha! Not one sight of the word ‘love’ from start to finish.

Subhadra became restive. She decided on a trip to Europe. She would endure all the torments which would come her way, whatever her lot. At least she'd be able to see Keshav with her own eyes. She'd keep this a secret from him, wouldn't add to his troubles, she wouldn't even speak to him! Only, every once in a while, she'd look at him to her heart's content. That'd be enough for her peace of mind. What did she know of Keshav no longer being hers? That he was now begging and pleading for the affections of another?

Subhadra allowed this idea to slowly germinate. She wasn't at all suspicious. Reading newspapers kept her apprised of the details of sea travel. One day, she told her in-laws about her plan. Both of them tried to persuade her not to go, tried their best to stop her, but Subhadra wouldn't budge. When people eventually realized she was not going to change her mind, they agreed. Her parents also tried to coax her into not going, but in vain. She had saved some money, and got some from her in-laws. Her parents helped out too. She didn't worry about travel expenses, nor had she decided what she would do once she reached England. All she knew was that those who were willing to work hard never lacked food.

Her in-laws accompanied her to the station. When the train's whistle went off, Subhadra folded her hands and said, 'Please don't write to him about my trip. Or else he'll worry, his heart won't be in his work.'

Her father-in-law gave her his word. The train set off.

3

In that part of London which, even in this time of economic abundance, lies destitute, Subhadra is sitting on a chair in a room above. It's been a month since she arrived. The many doubts she had before she set out are now beginning to disappear. The problem of finding a place on the ship at Bombay Dock resolved itself quite easily. She was not the only woman going to Europe. There were five or six other women aboard. Subhadra found neither getting a place aboard difficult nor the journey cumbersome. Once she got here, she lost touch with the other women. Some left for

college; some joined their husbands who had reached earlier. Subhadra rented a room in this neighbourhood. Earning a livelihood wasn't a big problem. Some of the women she had travelled with were married to high-ranking officials. They were acquainted with well-connected English families. Subhadra got a job teaching Hindustani classical music and Hindi to two Englishwomen. In her spare time she stitched clothes for some Indian women. Keshav lived nearby, which was why Subhadra had chosen this neighbourhood. She had spotted Keshav the day before. Oh! Seeing him get off a bus her heart had grown so impatient. She'd felt like running up to him, flinging her arms around his neck and asking, 'So, my dear Sir, you have come here and changed entirely? Remember all the promises you'd made on the eve of your departure?' She stopped herself with great difficulty. She felt as though she was in a trance—she was so close to him! She could see him every day if she wanted, listen to him; yes, even touch him. Where will he run from her now? She no longer cared about the letters. In a few days she could very likely ask the staff of his hotel all about him.

It was evening. The smoke blurred the electric lights like a teary-eyed vision. Men and women went for walks on the street. Subhadra started thinking—how these people love pleasure, as if they have no worries, as though they are all satisfied, maybe that's the reason they can work together so well. When they work, they put their heart and soul in it. There's a desire to play and an equal desire to work; and then there's us—who neither laugh nor cry—we merely sit quietly. Our lot works all day, there's hardly any time to eat, but there's no zest in the work. Actually, even a fourth of our time is not spent working. We just pretend to work. It seems our people have been bled dry of life.

All of a sudden, she saw Keshav. Yes, it was indeed Keshav. She got up from her chair and went into the balcony. She had a strong urge to fling herself round his neck. If she was at all guilty, it was because of him. If he had written to her regularly, would she have come?

But who was this girl with Keshav? Oh! Keshav was holding her hand. They were walking along, smiling, chatting. Who was this girl?

Subhadra looked intently. The woman had a wheatish complexion. She was an Indian girl. The way she was dressed was Indian. Subhadra could not see any more. She put on her shoes, closed the door behind her and, in a flash, stepped out. Keshav could no longer be seen, but she rapidly walked in the direction in which he had gone. Who was this girl? She wanted to eavesdrop on their conversation, she wanted to see the girl. She walked so fast, she was almost running. But where did both of them disappear to so fast? She should have reached them by now. Perhaps they had caught a bus.

She had now left the lane and emerged on to a wide road. There were large shops on both sides of the road, lit up with the wealth of the world. At every step, there was a hotel or a restaurant. Subhadra, looking around wide-eyed, chasing the mirage one step at a time, lost track of how far she'd come.

Then she thought, *How far will I go like this? Who knows where they went? Let me go back to my balcony and look. After all, if that is where they started from, that is where they are bound to end up at*. As soon as this thought occurred to her, she whirled around and went back running to where she had come from. It was noon by the time she got back. And all this time had passed as she walked. She had not rested a moment.

When she reached upstairs, her hostess said, 'Your food has been laid out for so long.'

Subhadra asked for the food to be brought to her room but who could eat now? She was standing on the balcony looking in the same direction in which Keshav had disappeared.

It was one o'clock, then two, but Keshav did not come back. She thought to herself, *He's come back by some other route. It's pointless standing here. I should go sleep*. Then she thought, *But what if he returns while I am asleep?*

Who knew when she fell asleep?

The following day, early in the morning, Subhadra was getting ready for work when a young woman in a silk sari came up to her and said with a smile, ‘I beg your pardon, I am bothering you so early in the morning. It seems you’re about to step out.’

Subhadra offered her a chair and said, ‘Yes, I was about to go out for some work. What can I do for you?’

As she said this, Subhadra scanned the young woman from head to toe with a gaze only women possess. By no norm of beauty could she be called beautiful. She had a wheatish complexion, a broad face, a nose which was slightly squashed. She was short, and had a somewhat large body. She was bespectacled. But despite all this, there was something which drew one’s gaze to her. Her speech was so sweet, so measured, so gentle, that it almost seemed like a goddess’s blessing. Every single part contributed to the radiance of the impression she made. Subhadra seemed pale in comparison, of little importance. The young woman sat on the chair and said, ‘If I am mistaken, I beg your pardon. I have heard that you sew clothes, which is confirmed by the sewing machine in the room.’

Subhadra: ‘I teach two English ladies, and in my spare time I sew. Have you brought your clothes along?’

The young woman: ‘No, I haven’t brought any clothes at the moment.’ Having said this, she bent her head shyly, smiled, and said, ‘The thing is, I am about to get married. I’d like my wedding attire to be Indian. The wedding, too, will be conducted according to Vedic rituals. You’re the only person here who can design clothes for such an occasion.’

Subhadra laughed and said, ‘It will be my pleasure to design clothes for you on such an occasion. When is the big day?’

The young woman hesitated and said, ‘My fiancé suggests we get married this very week, but I keep postponing it. I’d like to get married when we return to India, but I can’t tell you how insistent my fiancé is. I have managed to postpone it for the time being by telling him I’m still getting the wedding attire stitched.’

Subhadra: ‘Then I’ll give you your clothes very soon.’

The young woman laughed and said, ‘I’d actually like you to take months over it.’

Subhadra: ‘And why, pray, should I be a hindrance in such a happy event? I will finish sewing your clothes within the week, and collect my reward from your fiancé.’

The young woman burst out laughing. The room glowed with her radiance. She said, ‘Yes, for this he will reward you; indeed, reward you with utmost happiness and be indebted to you. I had resolved never to get married, but he’s managed to break my resolve. I have now realized how pleasurable the bonds of love are. You’ve arrived here only recently. Your husband must be with you?’

Subhadra lied. She said, ‘He is in Germany. He loves music. He has gone there to do research on music.’

‘Do you also understand music?’

‘Very little.’

‘Keshav loves music.’

Subhadra felt as if she’d been stung by a scorpion. She was stunned.

The young woman asked, ‘Why are you surprised? Do you know Keshav?’

Subhadra lied, ‘No, never heard the name. What does he do here?’ She thought, *Can’t Keshav be the name of another man?* That’s why she’d asked the question. Her entire life depended on the answer.

The young woman said, ‘He teaches in a school here. He has been sent by the Indian government. It hasn’t even been a year since he came. You’ll be happy to see him. He is the epitome of wit and intelligence. The most well-known professors here respect him. I’ve never heard anyone speak so beautifully. His life is a perfect model. I am surprised he fell in love with me. I am neither good-looking nor attractive. It’s my luck, really. So then, I’ll come back with the clothes this evening.’

Subhadra said, holding her fury back, ‘That’ll be nice.’

Once the young woman left, Subhadra burst into tears. It was as if she had no blood in her veins, as if life had left her body. For the first time, she realized how lonely, how weak she was. She could count on nobody. Her

life was worth nothing now. What else could she do but cry? Her senses went slack, as if she had fallen off a tall tree. This was the reward for her love and devotion. How much she had insisted that Keshav take this opportunity to go to England. Was it just so he could come here and utterly destroy her?

Her mind wandered to the past. Keshav's loving, innocent, smiling eyes appeared before her. How restless Keshav would get if she had the slightest headache. Once, when she had a viral fever, Keshav, fearful of what might happen, took fifteen days' leave from work, and sat by her side all night, fanning her. This selfsame Keshav had now lost interest in her in such a short span of time! Subhadra had left no stone unturned in loving him. She had considered him everything: the spirit animating her being; her life's wealth. No, it cannot be Keshav's fault, it's this woman's fault. She has cast a spell on him with her sweet words. Her erudition, intelligence and eloquence have won Keshav's heart. Oh! How often she'd said to Keshav, why don't you teach me a little too, but he always said, I like you just the way you are. I don't want to ruin your natural simplicity by educating you. Keshav had been very unfair to her. Yet it isn't his fault but this young, flirtatious woman's charms that are to blame.

Subhadra, possessed by jealousy and despair, didn't feel like leaving for work. She started pacing up and down the room as if someone had locked her in, clenching her fists, her teeth biting her lips. She was in a frenzied state. A sharp light radiated from her eyes. Whenever she'd think of this cruel blow Keshav had dealt her, she'd remember all the troubles she'd undergone for his sake, and her heart would be contorted with the desire for revenge. If there had been an actual rift with Keshav, something within their relationship, she wouldn't have been so sad. But this felt as if someone, smiling at her all the while had, in a flash, sat on her neck, choking her. If she wasn't good enough for him, why did he marry her? Why did he not leave her even after they had been married? Why did he, then, sow the seed of love? And now, when the seed had borne fruit, when its roots had percolated into her innermost self and embedded the seed in its every atom, when her blood, sweat and tears had been spent in sustaining and nurturing

this tree, now he wanted to uproot it and throw it away. Can the tree be uprooted without the heart being shattered to pieces?

Suddenly, she remembered something. Her face, lit by a violent satisfaction, assumed a harsher countenance. Keshav must have kept his first marriage a secret! Subhadra would expose him and ruin all his plans. She was angry with herself for not having taken the young woman's address. She would have written to her, exposed Keshav's shallowness, selfishness and cowardice—brought the falseness of his erudition, abilities and stature out into the open. Anyway, the young woman would, of course, return with her clothes in the evening. When she did, Subhadra could tell her the entire story.

5

Subhadra waited for the woman all day. She'd come out on to the balcony and look around, look at the road, but the woman was nowhere in sight. She was peeved with herself for not having disgorged the entire story earlier.

She knew Keshav's address. She remembered the house number and the lane number from which he used to write to her. As morning turned to evening and the girl still didn't come, she felt a wave of anger. She wanted to go and rebuke Keshav, bring him back to his senses. She'd say, 'You're so vicious, such a liar, this I did not know. Is this what you've come here to learn? Is this the fruit of your erudition? You deceive and cheat a woman whose only support is you, who's sacrificed everything she had for you. Are you no longer human, even for the sake of appearances? What then have you got planned for me? That I weep all my life, muttering your name!' But pride stopped her in her tracks. No, she wouldn't confront somebody who'd deceived her like this. She wasn't sure she'd be able to hold back her tears when she saw him, and she didn't want to cry in front of Keshav. If Keshav hated her, she too hated him.

It was evening; the woman still didn't come. The streetlights came on, but there was no sign of her.

Suddenly she heard somebody at the door. She jumped up and came out. The girl was standing there with a set of clothes. As soon as she saw Subhadra she said, ‘Sorry, I got late. Keshav has to leave for Germany on some urgent work. He’ll be there for over a month. He wants me to accompany him. My presence will really help him in writing his thesis. Berlin’s libraries will have to be searched and scanned. I’ve agreed. Keshav wishes that we get married before we leave for Germany. Tomorrow evening we’ll perform the marriage rites. Now, you can give me these clothes when I am back from Germany. We’ll wear ordinary clothes for our wedding. What else could I have done? There’s no other way out, Keshav has to go to Germany.’

Subhadra kept the clothes on the table and said, ‘You’ve been deceived.’

The young woman asked, afraid, ‘Deceived? How? I don’t understand. What do you mean?’

Subhadra tried to overcome her hesitation and said, ‘Keshav wants to fool you into marrying him.’

‘Keshav isn’t the sort of person to deceive somebody. Do you know Keshav?’

‘Has Keshav told you everything about himself?’

‘Everything. As far as I know he hasn’t kept a thing from me.’

‘Do you know he is married?’

The young woman’s expression dimmed, her neck lowered in embarrassment. Hesitating, she said, ‘Yes, he did . . . tell me that.’

Subhadra was utterly defeated. Eyes full of hatred, she said, ‘You know of this and you’re still willing to marry Keshav?’

The young woman looked back at her with some pride and said, ‘Have you seen Keshav?’

‘No, I have never seen him.’

‘Then how do you know him?’

‘A friend of mine told me this, he knows Keshav.’

‘You wouldn’t have asked me this question if you’d seen him, spoken to him once. Why once, I wouldn’t have refused if he’d been married a hundred times. I forget myself when I see him. If I weren’t to marry him,

I'd have to remain unmarried all my life. When he starts talking to me, I feel myself blooming like a flower. I feel as if I have been lit up, as if I'm progressing. The world can laugh at my expense as much as it likes, it can insult me as it likes, I cannot leave Keshav now. It is true that he's married, but he never felt there'd been a meeting of minds with that woman. He was not really married. She was an ordinary, half-educated girl. Think about it, a scholar like Keshav, a cerebral man, how could he have been happy with that chit of a girl? You'll have to come with me for my wedding tomorrow.'

Subhadra's face was flushed. Her blood boiled thinking of how Keshav had painted her black. What she really wanted to do was snub her this minute, but then she started to get other ideas. She asked with a grave but sad expression, 'Has Keshav said anything about that woman?'

The young woman eagerly said, 'Once he gets home, he'll tell her they can no longer be man and wife. He'll provide for her, what else can he do? A man and woman can't be divorced under Hindu law. But to set the woman entirely free, he is willing even to convert to Islam or to Christianity. He was going to write her a letter explaining this but I stopped him. I feel very bad for the unfortunate woman—I'm even willing for her to stay with us if she likes. I'll treat her like a sister. But Keshav doesn't agree.'

Subhadra said, her voice ironic, 'He's willing to provide for her, what else does a woman want?'

The woman, ignoring the irony, said, 'So I'll take the clothes when I'm back, okay?'

'They'll be ready.'

'You'll come tomorrow evening?'

'No, I'm afraid I won't be free.'

The girl said nothing. She left.

6

As much as Subhadra wanted to think about the problem calmly, her heart smouldered with rage! She didn't value even her life as much as she did

Keshav's and the same Keshav was giving her the foot. The trauma was so sudden and so harsh, all the tenderness in her thoughts vanished! Every atom in her body yearned for revenge. If the same story had unfolded the other way round, wouldn't Subhadra's throat have been slit? Wouldn't Keshav have bayed for her blood? Was a man forgiven everything and a woman forgiven nothing? No, Subhadra's rebellious spirit refused to acquiesce to this. She didn't care about high womanly ideals. Those women mustn't have any self-respect. They must be happy to live grovelling at a man's feet. Subhadra wasn't so devoid of respect. At least as long as she lived, she could not countenance her husband destroying her life and living happily ever after. The world would call her a murderess, a demoness, let it —she didn't care! Every now and then, she'd feel a strong impulse to go to him that very moment and, before he could enjoy the young woman's love, snuff his life out. She goaded herself, recalling Keshav's ruthlessness, scolding herself out of any doubts she had. Is she so weak? Did she not have even an iota of courage? If a rogue barged into the room and tried to have his way with her, would she not fight him? It was, after all, to protect herself that she'd bought a pistol. Keshav had had his way with the truth. His disquisition on love was trickery. He made love to her only to satisfy his lust. Wasn't it her duty then to put him to death?

She felt strengthened by this last reflection—a strength she needed to bring her terrible resolve to an end. This was the state in which a woman is thirsty for a man's blood.

She took down the pistol hanging on the hook and looked at it carefully, as if she'd never seen it before. Tomorrow evening when Keshav and his lover would be sitting opposite each other at the Aryan temple, she would end the spectacle of Keshav's love with this bullet. She'd shoot the second bullet into her own breast. Could she spend the whole of her miserable life weeping?

It was evening. The bride and bridegroom were sitting in the courtyard of the Aryan temple with their close friends. The wedding ceremony was in progress. Subhadra arrived at that very moment and, having entered the veranda, stood behind a pillar in such a way that Keshav was facing her. She recalled, in her mind's eye, what had transpired three years ago when, just like today, she had looked at Keshav sitting in the *mandap,* through the corner of her eye. How her heart had blossomed. There had been a tickling sensation in her heart, how infinite the love was, how many limitless desires there were, as if the morning of her life was only just dawning. Life was happy, sweet as music, the future as inviting as a morning dream. Was this the same Keshav? Subhadra felt as though this wasn't Keshav. No, this wasn't the same Keshav. This was another man who had the same name and the same appearance. Now her heart found nothing attractive in his smile, his eyes, his words. As she watched him, she stood there, not trembling, unmoving—as if she were looking at someone she didn't know. So far, there had been no other man in the world who was as handsome, as glorious, as gentle, as urbane as Keshav, but now Subhadra felt that there was no difference between him and the other young men sitting with him. The jealousy, which had been consuming her, the violent thoughts which had brought her here, seemed to have disappeared. Emptiness is even more violent than violence. Subhadra's violent thoughts were driven by a certain attachment—her Keshav, her beloved, the be-all and end-all of her existence could not belong to anyone else. But she no longer felt that attachment now. He did not belong to her; she did not care whom he belonged to.

The wedding ceremony came to an end, male friends congratulated them, female friends offered their warmest wishes, then people went and sat at the tables, the feast started. It was midnight, but Subhadra continued to stand there like a stone statue, as though dreaming a strange dream. Yes, as though a township had been destroyed, as though some music had stopped playing, as though a light had gone out.

When people started leaving the temple, she too came out but she couldn't make out the way. She seemed to have forgotten streets previously

known to her. The whole world had changed. She roamed the streets all night. She could not find her house. All the shops had closed, there was silence in the streets, yet she continued to look for her house. Alas! Would she also have to roam the road of life like this?

Suddenly a policeman called out, 'Madam, where are you going?'

Subhadra stopped in her tracks, and replied, 'Nowhere.'

'Where is your house?'

'My house?'

'Yes, where is your house? I've been watching you roaming here and there for a long time. Which street do you live on?'

Subhadra did not even remember the name of that street.

'You don't even remember the name of your street?'

'I've forgotten it, I can't remember.'

Suddenly her glance fell on a signboard. Oh! *This* was her street. She lifted her head and looked around. Her house was right in front of her. And she had been walking up and down for God knows how long on this very street, in front of her own house.

8

It was morning when the young woman arrived at Subhadra's house. Subhadra was stitching her clothes. She was engrossed in them. It is unlikely that a young woman would be as engrossed in dressing even herself up. Who knew what prize she wanted to win? She didn't realize that the young woman had come.

The young woman asked, 'You didn't come to the temple yesterday?'

Subhadra looked up, and felt as though a poet's gentle fantasy had been sculpted in stone. Her appearance was irreproachable. Love's greatness had lit up every inch of her being. Subhadra ran to her and embraced her, as if she were her younger sister, and said, 'Yes, I did.'

'I didn't see you.'

'Yes, I was standing a little away.'

'Did you see Keshav?'

‘Yes.’

‘Why do you answer quietly? What did you think—that I was lying?’

Subhadra smiled a considerate smile and said, ‘I didn’t see him through your eyes, I saw him through mine. He didn’t seem to me to be worthy of you. He’s duped you.’

The woman laughed loudly and said, ‘He! As I see it, I’ve duped him.’

‘Once you see yourself in the mirror decked up in this finery, you’ll realize what I am saying.’

‘Will I metamorphose into somebody else then?’

‘Remove the carpet, pictures, pots, vases from your room; the room’s essential beauty remains the same.’

The young woman shook her head and said, ‘You’re right. Where do I procure jewellery from! God knows how long it’ll take for them to get ready.

‘I’ll give you mine.’

‘You have jewellery?’

‘Lots. Wait, let me get it and help you put it on.’

The girl kept saying ‘no’, but she was thrilled. Subhadra put all her jewellery on her. She didn’t keep even a single earring for herself. This was a new experience for the young woman. She did feel shy stepping out dressed like this, but it had lit her up—one couldn’t deny that. When she looked at herself in the mirror, her face shone, as if a mistress had received news of her lover. She was gratified. She’d never realized she was so beautiful.

She wished Keshav could see her like this, but how could she articulate such a wish? A while later, she lowered her head shyly and said, ‘Keshav will laugh if he sees me like this.’

Subhadra, ‘He won’t laugh, he’ll bless you with a long life. He’ll keep on gazing at you. Today, you meet him dressed like this.’

She was taken aback, ‘Really? I have your permission?’

Subhadra said, ‘With great happiness.’

‘You won’t be mistrustful?’

‘Not in the least.’

‘And if I keep them on a few days?’

‘Keep them on a few months if you wish. In any case, they’re just lying around unused.’

‘You come with me too.’

‘No, I don’t have the time.’

‘Okay, take down the address of my house.’

‘All right, write it down, I might come sometime.’

The girl left in a trice. Subhadra stood at her window happily gazing upon her as though she were her own sister; there wasn’t a trace of jealousy or malice in her heart.

It had been hardly an hour when the young woman came back and said, ‘Subhadra, I’m sorry I’m disturbing you. Keshav’s right outside. Can I ask him to come in?’

For a moment, only a moment, Subhadra was afraid. She got up hurriedly and removed the things scattered on the table, and laid out the clothes neatly. She straightened her hair and, smiling sadly, said, ‘Why did you trouble him? Go, ask him in.’

Keshav’s face turned ashen. He stood there nonplussed, uncertain. Guilt and shame would colour his face, first this way, then that. This was going to happen sometime or the other, but despite this prospect of inevitability he had never in his wildest dreams anticipated that he’d have to meet Subhadra like this all of a sudden. He’d thought a lot about how he’d tell Subhadra about the situation. He’d thought up answers to her accusations, had even thought out what he would write in the letter to her. All of it remained undone and here was the encounter with Subhadra. Subhadra was not at all startled at seeing him; no sign of surprise, fear or sadness could be spotted on her face. She spoke to him as if he were a stranger. Keshav was dying to ask her many questions—when and how she came to be there, why did she come, how did she earn her keep . . . He’d thought Subhadra would scold him, would threaten to take poison—heartless, pitiless, and who knew what else she’d call him. He was prepared for all of these disasters, but for this casual meeting, this proud cold-shouldering, for this he wasn’t prepared. Could Subhadra, deeply devoted to the vows of love, now be so hard, so

heartless? Surely she had learnt everything already. And the hardest pill to swallow was how casually and benevolently she'd given away her jewellery, and who knew if she wished to even have it back? Defeated and shocked out of his wits, he sat down on the chair. He could not utter a word in reply.

The young woman, making her gratitude evident, said, 'Her husband's in Germany at the moment.'

Keshav stared at her but couldn't say a thing.

The young woman spoke up again, 'The poor woman earns her keep by teaching music and sewing some clothes. If that gentleman had turned up, I'd have congratulated him on his luck.'

Keshav couldn't find a reply even to this, but Subhadra smiled and said, 'He was upset with me. If you congratulated him, he'd be even more irritated.'

The young woman was taken aback. 'You came here because you loved him, left your home and its comforts behind, you're earning your own keep, in spite of all this he's upset with you? That's unbelievable!'

Subhadra, her countenance pleasant, said, 'Man's nature is a thing of wonder, even if Mr Keshav does not agree.'

The young woman looked at Keshav with a gaze full of reverence, but Keshav still sat in shock. He'd suffered a trauma. Seeing him silent, the young woman spoke up in his stead, 'Men and women, Keshav wants the both of them to have equal rights.'

Keshav was drowning; catching hold of this straw, he felt stronger. He said, 'Marriage is an agreement of a sort. Both parties have the right to break it off when they like.'

The young woman sighed, 'In civilized societies, people are fighting for this right.'

Subhadra was sceptical. 'Shouldn't there be a reason to call off an agreement?'

Keshav took the support of gestures and said, 'It is enough if one feels one would be happier free of this bond. If a woman realizes that with another man, she'd be—'

Subhadra cut him short and said, ‘Forgive me, Mr Keshav, I don’t have the brains to argue with you over this. The ideal agreement is one which lasts a lifetime. I am not speaking of India. A woman there is a man’s handmaid, I am speaking of England. I’ve spoken to so many women here. They’re not happy about the rising number of divorce cases. The highest ideal of marriage is its purity and stability. Men have always transgressed against this ideal, women have always maintained it. Now I can’t say where the injustice of men will lead women.’

This grave and moderate statement ended the debate. Subhadra called for tea. All three drank it. Keshav wanted to ask—how many more days will you be here? But he could not. He remained there for fifteen more minutes but stayed immersed in his thoughts. When leaving, he couldn’t hold himself back. He asked, ‘How many more days will you be here?’

Subhadra looked down at the ground and said, ‘I can’t say.’

‘If you need anything, do let me know.’

‘Thank you for your reassurance.’

Keshav was unsettled the whole day. Subhadra kept appearing before his eyes. Her words kept echoing in his ears. He no longer had any doubt that it was for him that Subhadra had come here. The entire situation was now clear to him. His hair stood on end contemplating Subhadra’s terrible sacrifice. What challenges she must have faced, what troubles she must have suffered, and all for his sake. She did not want to weigh him down. Isn’t that why she hadn’t apprised him of her arrival? Had he known that Subhadra had come here, he would never have been attracted to the young woman. The thief dare not enter a house in the presence of the guard. Seeing Subhadra had reawakened his realization of his responsibilities. He felt impatient to fall at her feet and beg her forgiveness; he’d hear the entire account from her mouth. This reticent neglect he found unbearable. He got through the day somehow, but as soon as it was ten in the night, he set off to meet Subhadra. The young woman asked, ‘Where are you off to?’

Keshav, tying his shoelaces, said, ‘Just need to meet a professor, I’d promised him I’d meet him now.’

‘Come back soon.’

‘I will, very soon.’

When Keshav left home, multiple trains of thought pursued one another in his mind. What if Subhadra refuses to meet him, what then? No, that couldn’t be. She isn’t that cruel. Yes, it was possible she’d say nothing about herself. To calm her down, he thought of a plea for mercy. He could say he had been so sick, there was no chance he’d have survived; Urmila had nursed him and cared for him so attentively that he fell in love with her. Keshav had no doubt about the effect this story would have on Subhadra. She would forgive him despite any misgivings. But what would come of it, what would come of it?

Would he be able to love both of them equally? Now that she’d seen Subhadra, Urmila might have an objection to staying with him! This hasn’t been hidden from her. Of course, it needs to be seen whether Subhadra agrees to it or not. Going by the way she had snubbed him, he was doubtful. But he’d bring her around, plead with her, fall at her feet and eventually persuade her. It was as if finding renewed proof of Subhadra’s love and affection had awoken him from a deep sleep. He was now realizing that the place in his heart reserved for Subhadra was empty. Urmila couldn’t lay claim to that. He now realized that his love for Urmila was the mere thirst that comes from encountering something delicious. It wasn’t real hunger and now he felt a hunger for simple, regular food again. He doubted the pleasure-loving Urmila would ever be able to sacrifice so much.

As he approached Subhadra’s house, his heart was full of misgivings. But he hardened his resolve, climbed the stairs and was at the entrance to her room in a trice, but the door was shut. There was no light inside either. She must have gone somewhere, she’ll be back soon. He decided to walk around on the balcony until then.

The landlady scanned him from head to toe and said, ‘But she left this place today.’

Keshav asked, startled, ‘She left? Where did she leave for?’

‘That she didn’t tell me.’

‘When did she leave?’

‘She left in the afternoon.’

‘Did she take all her furniture with her?

‘Whom would she have left them for? Yes, she has left a small packet for a friend. It has Mrs Keshav written on it. She told me, if she comes, give it to her, or send it by post.’

Keshav felt his heart sink like the setting sun. He took a deep breath and said, ‘Could you show me that packet? I am Keshav.’

The landlady smiled and said, ‘Wouldn’t Mrs Keshav mind?’

‘Shall I go call her then?

‘Yes, that’d be better.’

‘I’d have to go very far.’

When Keshav walked towards the stairway somewhat hesitantly, the landlady said, ‘I understand; why don’t you just take it, why should I make you run around for nothing? But please send me a receipt tomorrow. I may just need it!’

She brought out a small packet and gave it to Keshav. Keshav took the packet and ran, ran as if it was a thief running off. His heart was restless to know what the packet contained. He couldn’t bear to wait till he got home. There was a park nearby. He went there and, under an electric lamp, he opened the packet. His hands were trembling and his heart beat fast, as though he’d received the news of a dear friend’s illness.

The packet opened, and from Keshav’s eyes fell a stream of tears. It contained a yellow sari, a small box of sindoor and a photograph of Keshav, and accompanying these, there was an envelope. Keshav opened it and read. It said—

> Sister, I take your leave. These are the remains of my marriage. Immerse them in the Thames. It’d be best if both of you performed this rite.
>
> Yours,
> Subhadra

Keshav, the heartbreaking letter in his hand, lay on the grass right there and wept bitterly.

Translated from the Hindi by Anirudh Karnick



The Policeman

Last evening, I was out on an errand when a gentleman hailed the tonga I was in and clambered on. The tongawala did not want to give him a ride but he could not very well refuse. Who wants to cross a policeman? Being a *daroga*, this gentleman was the sub-inspector at some police station. He was in Sadar for a prosecution case.

I am not in the habit of conversing with policemen. Frankly, I hate the sight of them. All too often, I have witnessed the sufferings they inflict upon ordinary citizens. I slid to the far corner of the seat and turned my face away when darogaji piped up. 'Janaab, it is a common complaint that policemen take bribes. Nobody observes that policemen are forced to accept bribes. If policemen were to stop taking bribes, I swear, all these rich men with their grand turbans would be sitting in jail. And if we started to *chalaan* every small incident, the world would bad-mouth the police even more. You will not believe it, Janaab, bags full of money are placed around our necks. We might refuse a thousand times but there is such pressure on us that we are rendered helpless and forced to accept.'

I retorted with a touch of sarcasm, 'What you do for them after taking money you could just as well do for free.'

Darogaji laughed as he replied, '*Bandaparwar!* That would be a sin drained of all pleasure. A policeman is not such a fanatic angel and I do

believe that no human being is so pure. I observe people from other walks of life too, and I do not find any angels among them.'

I was just about to retort again when a man in a long jacket and a Turkish cap crossed the road in front of our tonga. At once, darogaji bowed to offer his salaam, and it seemed as if he would inquire about his health when the gentleman responded to the salaam with a string of abuse. When the tonga moved a few steps ahead, he picked up a stone and began to give chase. The tongawala urged the horses to trot faster. That gentleman also gathered speed and then he threw the stone. My head was spared by a whisker. He picked up a second stone and this one landed at our feet. The third stone was hurled with such force that darogaji's knee took a rather bad hit. But by this time, the tonga had managed to pull so far ahead that we were now safe from the assault of the stones. The verbal assault continued though. We saw the man, another stone in hand, hurling gross abuse at us until he disappeared from view.

When my heart steadied itself, I asked darogaji, 'Who is this man, Sahib? Is he a lunatic?'

Darogaji said, rubbing his knee, 'He's not a lunatic, Sahib. He's an old enemy. I had assumed that the tyrant had let go of the past, or I would not have bothered to offer my salaam.'

I asked, 'You must have had him sentenced in some case?'

'Oh, it's a long story, Janaab! Believe me, if he could, the man would eat me up alive.'

'You're just fanning the flames of curiosity. Now I cannot rest until I have the whole story.'

Darogaji turned his face around and said, 'Very well then, listen. Many years ago, I was posted in Sadar. Those were carefree days. Young blood. I found a lover. We grew close. To this day, when I think of that beauty, my eyes fill with tears. I have not found such modesty, such loyalty, in a woman of the market. The two years I spent with her brought me such joy that it makes me weep to think of it. But let me not draw out the story too much, or I will not be able to finish it. In brief, after two years, I received my transfer orders. If I began to describe the trauma of this phase, I could

fill up a whole file. I wanted to resign from the job. When the beauty heard the news, she almost collapsed. I had only three days to prepare for the journey. We spent all three days making plans. This was when I realized how very mistaken we are in our assumption that women have no intelligence. My own plans were Quixotic: let's run away to Calcutta and set up a shop there, or some such scheme. But she said, you go there and start working. Once you've found a house, send for me. I'll come running.

'Finally, the moment of parting was upon us. I felt the life drain out of my body. It was time for the train but I could not leave her side. But again, I digress. What happened was this, I promised to call her over after two or three days, and took my leave. But alas! Those two or three days never passed. The first five or ten days were spent meeting the officers and taking care of my territory. Then I had a letter from home saying "Your wedding has been arranged; take leave from work and come." Rapt in the joys of wedded life, I did not spare a thought for that goddess of loyalty. When I returned, a month after the wedding, my wife came with me. Whatever memories remained were dimmed further. She did write to me after a month, but I did not answer. I was afraid that she might turn up in a huff and I would have no face to show my wife.

'A year later, I had to be in Sadar for some work. It was then that I thought of the woman. I thought, let me go and see how she is faring. At once, I thought up responses to all possible queries about why I did not answer her letter or visit her all this while. Then I took myself to her door. The door was neat and the house was also in much better shape than before. My heart was gladdened to see that her circumstances were not as strained as I had imagined. And why should they be? Are there not more men like me in the world?

'I knocked on the door. It was locked from inside. A voice called out, "Who is it?"

'I said, "*Wah!* Have you forgotten me already? It is me, Bashir—"

'There was no response. Without a doubt the voice was hers, but why did she not open the door? She must be angry with me. I knocked again and began to narrate my troubles. After fifteen minutes, the door opened. The

beauty gestured that I should step in, and she quickly shut the door again. I said, “I have come to beg your forgiveness. I found myself facing grave difficulties as soon as I left. It’s such a rough territory that I scarcely have time to breathe.”

‘The beauty said, without looking at me, “What is there to forgive? We were not married. If you fell in love with someone else, why would you think of me? I have no complaints. You acted as all men do. At least you showed up after all this time. Have you been well?”

‘“I’m alive, somehow.”

‘“I suppose the grief of our separation has caused this paunch to grow? God help me if I lie, but you’re twice your size.”

‘I squirmed as I said, “This is all the result of phlegm. How could I have gained weight otherwise? The water there is quite phlegmatic. But you have not missed me at all.”

‘She gave me a sharp look this time and said, “You did not even answer my letter and now you accuse me? I had always thought you faithless, and that is exactly how you turned out. You brought home a wife and did not even write to me?”

‘Surprised, I asked her, “How do you know I was married?”

‘She said drily, “Why do you want to know? It’s not a lie, is it? I have seen many disloyal men, but you beat them all. When I heard your voice, my first instinct was to yell at you. I opened the door only because I felt I ought not to insult someone who has come home to visit.”

‘I took off my coat and hung it up on a peg. I took off my shoes too and lay down on the string cot. I said, “Laili, look here, don’t be unkind. I confess my sins and have come here to seek forgiveness. Let me have a paan made by your delicate hands. Tell me honestly, would you have missed me so much? You must have found another suitor.”

‘Laili opened her paan-*daan* and had just begun to prepare a paan when someone knocked on the door. Shaken, I asked, “Who the devil is that?”

‘That beauty placed a finger on her lips and said, “That is my husband. After you disappointed me, I married him.”

‘I raised my brows. “Why did you not tell me at once? I would have gone away immediately and this would not have come to pass. What are you punishing me for?”

‘“How was I to know that he would return so soon? He usually returns later in the evening. And you had come from so far, I had to show you some hospitality.”

‘“So much for your hospitality. Now where do I go?”

‘“I can’t think. Ya Allah! What a mess!”

‘That gentleman knocked again. It seemed as if he would break the door down. The beauty’s face was changing colour each moment. She stood there trembling. All she could say was, “Ya Allah! Have mercy!”

‘The voice outside rang out, “Arré! Have you already fallen asleep? It is not yet eight. Have you lost your tongue? By God, if you delay any further, I’ll have the door torn down.”

‘I begged, “For God’s sake, show me a place to hide. Isn’t there a back door?”

‘“No!”

‘“What about the toilet?”

‘“That’s where he’ll go first.”

‘“Okay, what about that storeroom?”

‘“Yes, but what if he opens the storeroom and looks inside?”

‘“Is he a very big man?”

‘“He can hold two men like you in his armpit.”

‘“Then open the storeroom. As soon as he enters, I’ll open the door and run away.”

‘The beauty opened the storeroom. I slipped inside. The door was shut again.

‘After locking me in the storeroom, the beauty opened the front door and said, “Are you trying to break the door down? I was just coming.”

‘I peeped from between the cracks of the storeroom door. The man was a real giant. He stepped in and said, “You were asleep so early in the evening?”

‘“Yes, I’d nodded off.”

‘“I thought you were talking to someone.”

‘“Luqmaan himself has no cure for suspicion.”

‘“I heard it quite clearly. There was someone. You’ve got him hidden somewhere.”

‘“It is these things that burn my heart. The house is yours, why don’t you take a look?”

‘“That I will. But I’m asking you straight up; tell me, who was it?”

‘The beauty threw the bunch of keys before him and said, “If someone was here, he must still be here. Go, look around. It’s not a needle that I can hide somewhere.”

‘But that devil was not deceived. Perhaps he had been conned once before. He picked up the bunch of keys and the first place he headed to was the door of my storeroom. He began to try the lock! But the key to the lock was not in the bunch. He said, “Where’s the key to the storeroom?”

‘The beauty faked surprise. “Arré, is there someone hiding in there? It’s just full of wood.”

‘“Why don’t you just give me the key?”

‘“Sometimes you behave like a madman. What if a snake or a scorpion jumps out in the dark? No, I will not give you the key.”

‘“Like hell a snake will jump out! Let it. It may be for the best. It is better to die than to live so shamelessly.”

‘The beauty began to look around here and there, and said, “I don’t know where I’ve left the key. I can’t remember.”

‘“I’ve never seen a lock on this storeroom before.”

‘“I do put a lock on it every day. But I wouldn’t say that I’ve never forgotten to.”

‘“So you won’t give me the key?”

‘“I said I can’t find it right now.”

‘“I’m warning you, I’ll eat you up alive.”

‘Until now, I had been standing there, controlling myself. I was cursing myself for having come here. Who knew how this devil would treat me? What if he killed me in rage? I didn’t even have a knife. *O God! You are my only refuge.* I was holding my breath, waiting for a chance to slip out and

run at the slightest opportunity. But when that wretch began to shake the door hard, my spirit all but evaporated. I looked about for a place to hide. There was a bit of light filtering in from the cracks in the door. I raised my eyes overhead and spotted a sort of shelf. It was straw to a drowning man. I leapt up to clamber atop it but when I saw a man already sitting there, I couldn't help but cry out. This gentleman, wearing a fine coat and a watch and a beautiful turban, was crouched upon the shelf. Now I knew why it had taken my beauty so long to open the door for me. I was just looking at this man when the door was slammed by a pestle. It was an ordinary pair of doors and a few blows sufficed. Both sides fell and that wretch entered the room with a lantern. You can imagine my plight at this moment. As soon as he spotted me, he set down the lantern and grabbed my neck. He said, "Oh, so here you are! Come, let me show you some hospitality. Guests like you are so rare."

'As soon as he said this, he grabbed my hand and pushed me so hard that I fell out into the courtyard, landing on my face. There were sparks flying from the devil's eyes. I felt as if his lips were moving with the intention of drinking up my blood. I had not been able to get off the floor when that butcher came up with a big, sharp knife and was at my throat. But Janaab, I'm not a policeman for nothing. I thought up a plan that saved my life, otherwise you would not have been sitting in this tonga with me today. I folded my hands and said, "Huzoor, I am absolutely blameless. I was just accompanying Mir Sahib."

'He roared, "Mir Sahib who?" I hardened my heart and said, "The one who is crouched up on the shelf. I am only huzoor's slave; I accompany him whenever I'm ordered to. How am I at fault?"

'"Oh! So there is a Mir Sahib also seated upon the shelf?"

'He grabbed my hand and dragged me back into the storeroom to look at the shelf. The gentleman was huddled there like a wet cat. His face had turned white, as if the life had drained out from his body.

'He seized this gentleman's hand—one jerk and he came crashing down. His finery left no doubt that he was indeed my master. His face moved me to both pity and mirth.

‘“Who the hell are you?”

‘“Er, I . . . my house, this man is a liar, he’s not my servant.”

‘“What did you come here for?”

‘“I was tricked into coming here,” he said, looking at me, “by this knave.”

‘“Why don’t you just admit that you came here for some fun? Pig! You think you can get away with blaming someone else? Well, you’ll always remember who you came up against.”

‘And the man cut off this gentleman’s nose with his sharp knife. I ran off the moment I got a chance but his cries kept ringing in my ears. What transpired between them afterwards, what troubles beset the beauty, I don’t know. I have come to Sadar scores of times since then but I never went there again. This stone-throwing gentleman is the same man whose nose was cut off. I happened to see him today and, unfortunately, offered him a salaam. You did not take note of his nose.’

Now that I thought about it, it did seem as if the man’s nose had been sort of flat. I said, ‘Yes, the nose did look flat. But you got the poor man in a real fix.’

‘What else could I do? I guess we could have jumped him together. But a thief has only half a heart. At the time, we were thinking only of ourselves and didn’t consider fighting back. If I had been overcome in that brawl, I would have lost my honour as well as my job. But henceforth, I must be wary of this gentleman.’

At this point, we reached the chowk and went our separate ways.

Translated from the Hindi by Annie Zaidi



Moteramji, the Editor

1

When Pandit Chintamani returned from his pilgrimage of several months, he went to meet his close friend Pandit Moteram Shastri. He had witnessed and heard countless new things and acquired a wealth of experience during his long pilgrimage. He was impatient to describe all this, adding spicy details of his own, to his friend. He reached Moteram's house and, as he was going to step in, an attendant stopped him, 'Where are you going? Stand outside. What's your business?'

Surprised, Chintamani asked, 'Isn't this Moteram's house?'

'We don't know anything. The manager has asked us not to allow anyone to go in.'

'Who's the manager? Isn't this Moteram's house?'

'We don't know anything. We are carrying out the manager's orders.'

'But do tell me—who's this manager?'

'The manager is the manager. What else can I say?'

Puzzled, Chintamani looked up and down the house to see if he had been mistaken, and then he saw a big signboard in front of the door. On it was written—Sona Office. In his eagerness to meet his friend he had missed the board earlier.

'Is this some office?' he asked.

The attendant parried, ‘Don’t you have eyes to see?’

‘Why are you being so arrogant? Do you think I’m a beggar? If it is Moteram’s house, go inside and tell him that Pandit Chintamani has come to see him. Show your authority to others.’

‘Give me your card.’

‘What do you mean?’

‘The manager doesn’t allow anyone in without seeing their card.’

‘Go and tell him my name.’

‘How can I just go and tell your name? He’ll be annoyed.’

When Chintamani saw that all his coaxing was in vain, he stood before the door and called out, ‘Moteram! O Moteram!’ The attendant grabbed Chintamani by the hand and pushed him back. ‘No one is allowed to shout here.’

Chintamani flared up. He was going to let the attendant have it, when Pandit Moteram came out and greeted him, ‘Is that you, Chintamani? Why didn’t you send in your card? You must have seen the signboard declaring that I’m now the editor of the magazine *Sona.* Come on in. I don’t meet anyone without seeing their card, but you’re an old friend. I can bypass procedures for you.’

As Chintamani went in he saw that everything had undergone a transformation. The room that had been empty earlier was now furnished with a table and chairs. The kitchen was stuffed with heaps of magazine bundles. There were clerks sitting on the veranda and writing in huge register notebooks.

As the two fellows sat down, Moteram said, ‘When you went on the pilgrimage, I brought out a magazine.’

‘I see. So, you’ve given it the name—“Sona”—and you are editing it.’

‘Since I have brought out this magazine, there has been a stir in the Hindi world. It is less than three months old but the subscription has gone beyond twenty-five thousand. New orders are coming in every day. The post office has had to employ additional staff to deal with the orders.’

‘You’re lying! Twenty-five thousand! Don’t you have any fear of God? If you had said twenty-five hundred, one could still believe you. You don’t

even know how to lie convincingly.'

Moteram laughed, 'Others also say the same thing. Whoever hears it is astonished but I'm telling you the truth. You can check the registers. If you don't find the number of subscribers to be twenty-five thousand, you can give me the punishment given to a thief. And it's just the beginning. Mark my words, I'll take the subscription to one hundred thousand by the end of the year. There's no dearth of subscribers, there is only a dearth of workers. Give me some hard-working fellows who know their job well, and then I'll show you how you can draw subscribers. It's all a matter of how you advertise your product. Shall I show you the register?'

'Anything can be done with the registers—the names could be fake, you could've skipped numbers in between. Granted that you are an efficient person; I couldn't have done even one-fourth of what you've achieved. But the figure of twenty-five thousand is unbelievable. Where did you find that kind of money?'

'Don't talk about money, it is all God's benevolence. This is one trade where you can build a huge business without investing even a penny of your own. What you must have is style. You needn't invest your own money. You can borrow paper from the paper merchant, you can get the printer to publish—what else do you need? If you get money in return you can pay the trader and the publisher. If you don't, just sit and relax. Who can cause you any harm?'

'How will you pay the trader and the publisher?'

'That is another skill which is God's special gift. You can't acquire it by reading books, nor can you have it by watching others. You can call it an inheritance from your earlier birth. You know Seth Suddilal, the paper merchant. He has fed both of us several times. He is a really pious soul. I got the paper from him. I just had to ask him. He sent papers worth five hundred rupees on a cart. I don't have a press of my own yet. I get it printed in a press owned by somebody else. I have around two dozen agents. They wander about the city and the villages to publicize it. I'm very strict with my employees. If I see them making excuses or not working hard, I lose my temper. It is as if my whole body catches fire. I feel like giving them the

severest of punishments. Many have left me. This suits me fine, as I don't have to pay them any more. I have thrashed many of them. They tremble at my sight. I need some more agents. If you want I can employ some of your friends. It'll bring good profit.'

'I have very few friends who will tolerate your immorality. If you dare raise your hand against them, they'll fight you. But tell me one thing, how do you manage to edit the magazine?'

'How do I edit? I have intelligence, that's how.'

'You were never known for your intelligence!'

'How can you measure the sharpness of my intelligence? A man who can open an office without spending a penny from his pocket, a man who can become the editor of such a big magazine, whose fame is now widespread in the country—only donkeys like you can doubt the intelligence of such a personality.'

'This is duplicity, not intelligence.'

'You may call it duplicity, cunning or something else, but in my dictionary this is called intelligence. When a writer of a high calibre sends me an article, I make some corrections before sending it for publication. I use my red pen in a couple of places for sure. This scares the scholarly people. I've employed a couple of translators who can translate commentaries from Bengali, Gujarati and other languages. I give them the responsibility of my editorial. Since it doesn't carry the name of the writer, people think that I've written it. Who has the time to comb through my articles? I've discovered the secrets of worldly success after a long time, but I won't tell you about it.'

Chinta protested, 'Why, friend, why keep this secret from me? Considering that I've always regarded you as my guru and my elder brother, this seems very mean on your part.'

Moteram replied, 'All right. Promise me that you'll get one hundred subscribers for me.'

'Have I ever disobeyed your orders?'

'Okay, now listen to me. The secret is that you must know how to show off. You should do it in such style that people get really impressed by you.

Don’t bother if people don’t trust you or make fun of you. After you leave the scene, they’ll be compelled to think that if even 1 per cent of what you said was true, that’s not a small achievement. Exaggeration—that’s the name of the game. Don’t tell anyone that the number of subscribers is less than one hundred thousand. Declare it at the top of your voice that we’ve arranged to get articles from Western scholars. Claim that the articles and the illustrations published by you are unique, and then see how the subscribers rush to you. You dither a little and the business will be spoiled. For a moment you forget about yourself and imagine that whatever I’m saying is true to the letter. You haven’t seen my magazine. It carries remarkable articles on social reform.’

‘Social reform! Since when have you become a social reformer? You’re so orthodox that you don’t even eat puris bought from the market.’

‘Don’t ask me how I eat and how I live. When I enter this room, I turn into a pukka social reformer. When I reach home I turn into an enemy of social reform. How can you succeed if you can’t maintain this duality? You may be surprised to see that I’ve supported widow remarriage and have taken up the responsibility of preaching against untouchability and performing *shuddhi*. I think the Hindu society is going to the dogs because of such measures of social reform, but what can I do? I have to maintain my family some way or the other.’

‘Yaar, you’re very cunning. I’m impressed by your cleverness.’

‘Just wait and see. Now I’ll put out an advertisement claiming that all the twelve issues of the magazine in a year will be special issues, and they will be edited by well-known personalities of the world. They will be edited by Dr Tagore, Dr Iqbal, the venerable Shankaracharya, Mussolini, Lloyd George, and so on. You can imagine what an uproar it will create!’

‘What if these personalities do not agree to lend their names to your magazine?’

‘It goes without saying that they won’t agree, but the subscribers will be duped anyway. And once they become subscribers, they won’t ask us to return their money. In the following year, I’ll play some other such trick.’

2

As the two friends were conversing, Sona Devi came out, her anklets tinkling. Her face had such a glow that Chintamani was totally floored. The moment Sona saw Chintamani, she said, ‘Lala, you’ve come here after a long time. Have you forgotten us?’

Chinta replied, ‘What could I do, Bhabhiji? I had gone for a pilgrimage. One must also think about the hereafter.’

‘You haven’t become old enough yet to think about the hereafter. You aren’t even fifty. Your friend has got a new hobby to obsess over. How I tried to persuade him not to get entangled in these responsibilities and to remain content with whatever God has bestowed on us! But he never listens to anyone. He doesn’t even have five hundred subscribers, but goes around claiming at the top of his voice that he has got twenty-five thousand of them.’

Moteram thundered, ‘Who asked you to appear here like a witch? Go inside.’

Chinta asked Sona, ‘You mean to say that you don’t even have five hundred subscribers? He was telling me that he has got twenty-five thousand!’

Sona replied, ‘That is him bragging. Lying is his old habit.’

Moteram threatened Sona, ‘Are you going away from here or not?’

Sona challenged him, ‘No. Let me see what you can do. You can’t order me about, let me tell you. You can cheat the whole world. You’re a cheat. You’re showing me your temper! Control your temper. I’m very angry with you today. Don’t you feel any shame in supporting widow remarriage through your magazine? You have a widowed sister, why don’t you get her married off? And where are your twenty-five thousand subscribers, show me. You’ve got fake registers that you show to everybody. Lala, let me tell you about a new trait that he has developed—he has started drinking liquor.’

Chinta was shocked. ‘Oh God! Is it true?’

Moteram growled, ‘I will choke you to death.’

Sona continued, ‘God knows he drinks liquor. He can drink bottles of them. He goes to the English shops stealthily like a thief, puts the bottle in his pocket and slinks away. Like a real thief. He claims that if a man drinks liquor, his intelligence is sharpened; that it helps digestion, that he enjoys it. To hell with your enjoyment.’

Chinta asked Moteram, ‘What is this, my friend? You used to take bhang. Wasn’t that intoxicating enough?’

Shrugging off his wife’s accusation, Moteram said, ‘Let her babble. She has lost her wits, stupid woman.’

Sona said angrily, ‘Now you keep quiet. Or else I will expose all your misdeeds. Lala, God knows why such misfortune has befallen my family. He goes around eyeing other women. He got beaten up in a case involving a rani but he refuses to mend his ways. He styles himself as the editor of a magazine, a social reformer. He shows direction to others and gives others advice. But what about himself? He owes the paper merchant five hundred rupees, and the owner of the press comes calling every day for his money, but he lives in a world of his own. Anxiety is driving me to death.’

Chinta tried to reassure her, ‘That may not be true, Bhabhiji. I have never seen him doing such things.’

Sona looked at Moteram from the corner of her eye and said, ‘As many as three women are sitting in his house. Has he got enough of them? I’m telling you, don’t mess with me, I will return it hundredfold. You’ve seen the duplicity of your friend. The real register is hidden in the other room. I can show you the real figures. Come with me . . .’

Chintamani knew this already. He immediately got up, but Moteram didn’t sit idle. He leapt up to grab Chintamani’s hand. Poor Chintamani was in a fix. On one side, Sona was pulling his hand with all her might; on the other, Moteram was using all his force to pull his other hand. Chintamani felt as if both his hands were going to be pulled apart. He began to howl.

Sona said, ‘Okay, Lala, you hold him tight. I’m bringing the register. Don’t let him off.’

She hurried into the other room, leaving the two friends engaged in the wrestling match.

Moteram said, ‘I’ll break all your bones.’

Chinta retorted, ‘I’ll bury you in your grave.’

‘I’ll trample all over you.’

‘I’ll make pickle out of you.’

‘I’ll tear your stomach.’

‘I’ll break your nose.’

The two friends were now lying on the floor, engaged in the verbal duel. Sona brought out the register containing the names of the subscribers. Chintamani saw the last figure. It was five hundred and eighty. He said, ‘What do you say, my friend? You were making such tall claims. What now?’

Moteram cried out, ‘This wife of mine is the very image of my accumulated sins in the past life. Now my honour is in your hands. Please do not tell anyone.’

Chinta reassured him, ‘No, friend, I’m not such a fool. But you must do one thing. You must add my name in the magazine. Both of us will be editors. You can place your name on top and my name below. Do you accept my condition?’

Moteram said solemnly, ‘Yes, I agree.’

Translated from the Hindi by M. Asaduddin



Selfhood

1

When Munni came to Dildarnagar, she was not more than five years old. She was completely alone; no one knew if her parents had died or just gone away somewhere. All Munni knew was that sometimes one goddess-like woman would feed her and at other times some godlike man would place her on his shoulders and stroll about in the fields. She used to speak of these events as if she were narrating a dream. Whether it was all truly a dream or reality, she did not know. Whenever someone asked her where her parents were, the poor girl, to avoid replying to such questions, would raise her hand and say, ‘Up.’ Other times she would point towards the sky and say, ‘There.’ No one knew what she meant by ‘up’ or ‘there’—perhaps not even Munni herself. One day people had simply found her playing under a tree. Nobody knew more than this about her.

The girl was very pretty. Whoever saw her adored her. She had no worries about where her next meal would come from. She would eat whenever someone called her and fed her, and then she would return to her play. From her appearance, she seemed like somebody who hailed from a well-to-do household. Even in the poorest of houses she could find two bites to eat and a coarse sack to cover herself with as she slept. She was everyone’s and no one was hers.

Time went by in this fashion. Munni reached an age when she was able to do some work. Someone would tell her, ‘Go and get these clothes washed at the pond,’ and Munni would immediately take the clothes and set off. But if on the way someone else called her and said, ‘Could you draw two pots of water from the well, child?’ she would leave the clothes right there and walk off towards the well. At the well, someone else would say, ‘Just go to the field and fetch some spinach,’ and Munni would leave the earthen pots she was carrying and go to the fields. Meanwhile the woman waiting for the water would grow tired of sitting and waiting. She would go and see her pots lying at the well and curse Munni, swearing that she would stop giving food to the hussy from the very next day. The woman sitting in wait for her clothes would also start getting impatient and angrily walk towards the pond, only to find her clothes lying midway. Then she too would curse her and swear never to feed her again. And so Munni would have to go without food on certain days and then she would remember her childhood, when she did not have to do any work and people would keep beckoning to her to give her things to eat. Whose work was she to refuse? Whoever she said no to was bound to get upset. *Whom can I call my own*, she thought, *even though I belong to everyone*. The poor girl did not know that one who belongs to everyone, belongs to none. How good were the days when she did not have to worry about where her next meal would come from, or about pleasing or displeasing anybody! Though stricken with misfortune, her childhood had still offered her some comfort.

More time went by and Munni grew into a young woman. If up until then, she had belonged to the women, she now started belonging to the men. She was the beloved of the whole village but she had no one to love her. They all said, ‘I yearn for you,’ or ‘You are my heart’s deepest desire,’ or ‘I count the stars in your absence’—but she was clueless about who it was that really loved her. Nobody asked her to share his grief with him. They all wanted her to come and rule over their hearts. They wanted to sacrifice themselves for just one glance from her, for the faintest of her smiles, but there was no one who wanted to hold her hand or to protect her honour. She belonged to everyone, her love was anyone’s for the taking, but

no one wanted to step up and own her, so that it could be understood by everyone that she was his and no one else's.

That young and innocent girl—God knew where she had come from—was now the queen of the village. When, with her ample bosom thrust forward and her head held high with the pride of her beauty, she walked her elegant gait, the hearts of the lustful youths would stop beating and they would cast their lovelorn glances beneath her feet. Who was not willing to offer his life at the slightest gesture from her? The orphaned girl who had once received dolls to play with, now had hearts to toy with. Some she crushed, some she let live and some she rejected; she soothed some, some she got offended by, and others she cajoled. She derived the satisfaction of the hunt and the kill from this play. The tables had turned. Earlier she had belonged to everyone while no one was hers; now everyone was hers and she belonged to no one. She could not find what it was she was in search of anywhere. No one had the courage to come up to her and say, 'From this day on you are mine.' There were many who offered her their hearts, but not a single one who offered his companionship. The truth was, she despised these romantic fools. She didn't think even one of them worthy of her love, and she did not want to give such faint-hearted creatures more importance than she would to playthings. To let them die or to allow them to live was nothing but entertainment for her.

2

Whenever a young man appeared before her with a garland and a trayful of sweets, she felt like clawing at his face. These gifts seemed like the deadliest of poisons to her. In their stead, she wanted stale bread soaked in true love. Huge mounds of jewels and gold coins appeared like the stings of scorpions to her. Instead of them she wanted conversations wrung from the depths of the heart, redolent with love and as sonorous as truth. She was offered palaces to live in, silk to wear, and the choicest foods to eat, but she had no desire for these. She desired straw huts, rough, coarse cloth and

plain dry bread. Life-preserving restrictions were dearer to her than life-threatening freedoms; more appealing than the open sky was the shut cage.

One day a stranger came to the village. He was a very weak and abject man. Having eaten some *sattu,* he was lying under a tree. Munni happened to walk by and, on seeing him, she asked, 'Where would you be going?'

'To hell,' the traveller replied dryly.

Munni smiled and said, 'Why? Isn't there room enough on this earth?'

'There is. But not for me.'

'Is there some grief you nurse in your heart?'

At this, the traveller laughed scornfully and said, 'What else is there in store for the unfortunate? To weep, suffer and die in misery—that is the very essence of their lives. I have wept and I have suffered; all that remains is to cross the final stage and, if God wills it, it shall happen soon.'

These were the words of a wounded heart. It was certain that a heart beat within his breast. Where else could such pain arise from? Munni had been in search of a heart for a long time. She asked him, 'Why don't you look for love elsewhere?'

The traveller dejectedly replied, 'That's not what fate has in store for me, or else why was everything that I had so lovingly built destroyed? I have neither wealth nor a handsome countenance, so why would the goddess of love shower her blessings on me? I once believed that one received love in exchange for one's heart, but I know now that like everything else, it too can be bought with silver and gold.'

It now dawned upon Munni that her eyes had initially deceived her. The traveller's complexion was not really as dark as she had thought; it was merely wheatish. His facial features also started to appear attractive to her and she replied, 'No. What you had thought earlier was right.'

And she walked away. Her emotions were slipping out of her control. The traveller got lost in thought. He was contemplating the parting words of that beautiful damsel. Was it possible that his misfortune would not catch up with him here?

The traveller spent the night in the village. He did not leave the next day either, and on the third day he built a straw hut. Munni asked him, 'Who did

you build this hut for?'

'For the one I expect love from,' he answered.

'And what happens if you leave?'

'The hut will still be here.'

'But only ghosts live in empty houses.'

'Even the ghost of a loved one is loved.'

Munni shifted into the hut the next day. The villagers were shocked. They thought Munni wouldn't be able to survive in that hut. They were certain that she would let him down too. Munni, however, had never been happier. She had found a man within whose breast a heart did beat.

3

The traveller, however, soon started to worry that in this village too perhaps, he would have to see the day when he would be betrayed. The same things had happened earlier as well, he reminisced—similar promises had been made, vows had been exchanged. But how long did it take for those brittle ties to break? Would the same ties not be severed again? His momentary spell of contentment was short-lived and despair soon overshadowed his heart. This balm too had been unable to heal his wounded heart. He sat deep in worry and was anxious throughout the third day, and on the fourth he disappeared. All that was left of him was the straw hut he had built.

Munni sat all day waiting for him to come back. She was sure that he would return. But months went by without a sign of him—not even a letter. Munni, however, did not lose hope. She was certain he would come.

Years passed. New buds sprouted on the trees, flowers bloomed, fruits ripened, the skies darkened, lightning crashed, even winter came and went, but the traveller did not. But Munni still believed that he would and she wasn't the least bit anxious or frightened. She laboured throughout the day and lay in the hut in the evenings. The hut was now a secure fortress where even the very gaze of her lustful suitors would dare not fall.

One day, while she was walking with a bundle of sticks on her head, one such suitor teased her, ‘Munni, why do you do such injustice to your soft and tender body? I could, for one merciful glance from you, shower you with as much gold as the wood you carry on your head.’

‘Keep your gold to yourself. I have faith in my own labour,’ Munni replied in utter disgust.

‘Why this conceit? He is not coming back.’

Munni gestured towards her hut. ‘When did he ever leave, that you talk of his coming back? Where could he ever go after having become mine? He is right here in my heart.’

Similarly on another day another suitor came to her and said, ‘My palace awaits you. Why do you lie in neglect in this ramshackle hut?’ To him, Munni replied with pride, ‘I would give a million palaces for this hut. It is here that I found what I had been looking for and could not find anywhere else. This is not a hut; it is the heart of my beloved.’

Munni spent seventy years in that hut. Until the day she died she did not lose hope of the traveller’s return and her gaze was still fixed on the door. Some of those who had sought to buy her favour had died and some were still alive. However, the day that she had started belonging to one person, a radiance had become visible on her face, the very light of which was enough to blind all their lustful eyes. Once selfhood is awakened, all weakness shudders to go anywhere near it.

Translated from the Hindi by Sunil Kumar



The Day's First Sale

1

I was elated the day a paan shop opened on the opposite side of the road in front of my house. There hadn't been one for at least a furlong earlier and I had to make many trips to the corner of the road. At times I had to wait in front of the shop for several minutes. It was at the crossroads and there was always a crowd there. I hated waiting. I can't recall when it was that I got addicted to chewing paan, but it seems now that for as long as someone keeps folding the betel leaf and serving me the little triangular cones, I shall perhaps never refuse. If not a large, then at least a small, part of my income is served as an offering to paan. Many a time have I considered buying and carrying a paan-case on me, but one knows that maintaining it is not child's play and for me it would be no less than buying an elephant. And even if I were to take the risk of procuring one, it would not be like owning a golden goose that would keep on supplying me with the neatly folded cone-shaped leaf endlessly as and when I desired. To purchase the betel leaves from the market, to keep turning them over and over four times a day, to soak them in water, to sift the rotting leaves out—is all this an easy task? I have always observed the womenfolk of well-to-do households constantly occupied with the maintenance of the paan cases. If I had it in me to put in so much effort, then perhaps I would have been a man by now. And even if

I am willing to go through all this pain with the leaves, pray, who is to chop the betel nut? Just the sight of the scissors used for cutting them makes me shudder with fear. And if an unavoidable situation does arise, then I make use of a grinding stone instead—but to handle those scissors is simply out of the question. The very sight of someone making use of them to chop the betel nut surprises me just as much as it would to see someone dancing along the edge of a sword. And even if this hurdle were somehow crossed, then how is one to overcome the third and final stage—the apportioning of the catechu and lime, which is no mean task. When even those who are skilful at this art make mistakes on a daily basis, then who the hell am I to think that I could pull it off? If the shopkeeper were to apply too much lime, one can scold her and ask for more catechu, and one is thus saved. The real trouble comes when one visits a friend's house. The minute the paan is placed in the mouth, one has to swallow it like a fly—one has no choice but to knowingly gulp the poison down. You cannot complain, good manners hold you back. Sometimes, as soon as the paan is placed in the mouth, one feels its sting on the tongue as if a glowing ember has been placed on it. It burns as if someone were pouring boiling mercury all the way from the throat down to the chest: but in spite of all this, one has no choice but to swallow. How one can err so grievously in the apportioning is beyond me. I myself might be a complete amateur but I never apply more lime than would cause just a few blisters on the tongue. I think that such blunders are the expressions of anger of the womenfolk of the household. By what other means are they to protest against your excesses? The silent boycott is not acceptable to you, and they have no other weapon at their disposal. The bows of their eyebrows, the spears of their eyelashes, and the arrows of their smiles are all of no use at such times—when, with your sleeves rolled up, your eyes red with rage, you raise hell, simply because you weren't served breakfast a little earlier. They then have no other means of taking revenge other than adding some extra salt to your food or applying too much lime on your paan.

Well, anyway, after three or four days, when I went to the shop one morning, the shopkeeper did not display too much eagerness in wanting to

serve me. She kept on smoothening out the betel leaf for a whole minute and then disappeared inside somewhere, returning with some ground spices. I was pleased, thinking that she was very ritualistically preparing the paan today. But she still had her gaze wistfully fixed on the road, almost as if there was no customer at all at her shop and even if there was, it was only one who visited her scores of times a day. I became agitated and said, 'Do you have any idea how long I've been standing here?'

The shopkeeper replied in an apologetic tone, 'Yes, Babuji, you've been waiting for quite a while, but please wait for another minute or so. I hope you don't mind my saying it, but it's not good luck for the business to make the day's first sale to you. I made the first sale to you yesterday and I only did six annas' worth of business. You were the first customer day before yesterday as well and my shop only earned eight annas. But two days ago I made the day's first sale to Panditji and by noon I had already earned two and a half rupees. Sometimes, Babuji, some people just don't have any luck in their hands.'

It was almost as if I had been shot. I don't lay any claim to being the luckiest of people, there would indeed be very few who are unluckier than me. If I'm not the king of misfortune, I'm at least a highly placed noble in that realm. But it is completely unacceptable that I be labelled a jinx. If someone considers it unlucky to make the day's first sale to me, or if people consider it bad luck to set eyes on my face the first thing in the morning, then this is a huge disgrace to me.

I took the paan, and resolved that I would at any cost wipe this stain of being jinxed off my person. I had just returned to my room when a friend dropped by. He was on his way to buy some groceries. To him, I praised my paan-seller to the skies. This gentleman, being a worshipper of beauty and quite jocular, looked at me cunningly and said, 'I don't have any money on me now and neither am I in need of paan.'

'Take the money from me,' I said.

'All right, that sounds fine; don't ask me to repay it later though.'

'That's quite sly, isn't it?'

'So what? Were you expecting to improve your reputation free of cost?'

Left with no choice, I gave the fellow money for a bundle of about two hundred paan leaves. And in this way I praised my paan-seller to whoever came to visit me. My friends shared many a laugh at my expense; I became the butt of their jokes. They would call me a ‘sly fox’, her ‘devotee’, and God knows what other epithets were heaped on me, but I laughed along and took it all in my stride. I was willing to go to any extreme to wipe the stain of being a jinx off me.

When I went to the shop the next day, she served me my paan immediately and said, ‘Babuji, making the day’s first sale to you brought a lot of good luck to the shop yesterday, about three and a half rupees. From now on, please come and make the first purchase every day.’

2

For about three or four days I continuously recommended her to my friends; I sang her praises, even taking money out of my own pocket to achieve my goal. But even in this short period my coffers had started to run dry. I could not keep up this farce for long, so I decided that after a few days, I would stop visiting her shop altogether. Why, after all, would I need to be anxious about her business once I stopped making the first purchase from her shop? So the next day, after washing my hands and face, I popped some cardamom in my mouth and sat down to work. But I had barely been sitting for half an hour when I heard someone’s footsteps. I looked up and saw the shopkeeper before me, smiling and offering me the triangular betel leaves. I was extremely agitated at her sudden appearance but could not be so rude as to tell her off. ‘Why did you go through this trouble? I was just about to come,’ I said.

Placing the betel leaves in my hand, she said, ‘You were late, so I thought that I would come and make the first sale to you myself. There are many customers waiting at the shop, but I did not let anyone else make the first purchase.’

What could I do? I ate the betel leaves and made the first purchase. The anxiety that I wanted to be rid of now stuck to me like a noose around my

neck. I had thought that if my friends visited her and bought paan from her shop for a few days, then, being impressed with her, they would soon no longer need me to recommend the shop to them. But it seems that perhaps to the cost of the paan she also added the price of her beauty, and that was why whoever visited her once did not visit her shop again. There were a few lustful young men who still came; they came to enjoy the pleasure of her paan and her beauty at one go and then left. In order to maintain my good reputation, I had to spend a rupee and a half that day; I was almost broke.

I locked the doors from the inside the next day, but was forced to open them when she started screaming and shouting and banging on them. I went down rubbing my eyes, so that she would know I had overslept. I had to make the first purchase again and once more the curse was hanging around my neck. By the evening I was two rupees lighter. Finally, all that was left to do, in order to be free from this blighted calamity, was to leave the house.

3

I settled on a house in an inconspicuous locality two miles away and shifted with all my belongings overnight. Even a prisoner set free from jail would perhaps not have been as happy as I was at leaving that house. I slept a deep, restful sleep that night, and in the morning experienced the freedom of a bird whose wings are suddenly unfolded. I smoked a cigarette in complete repose, washed my hands and face, and then set about arranging my belongings. I was anxious about finding a hotel to eat in, but so content was I at having overcome that blighted calamity, that all other anxieties melted into nothingness before it. I went downstairs after washing up. Even the air that day was drugging me with freedom. Everything seemed to be smiling. Having bought and eaten a paan, I was ascending the stairs to my room when I saw her, the shopkeeper, eagerly bouncing towards me. Do not ask what I went through at that moment. All I felt like doing was splitting both my head and hers open. She was as happy to see me as a washerwoman would be on finding her long-lost donkey. And my anxiety

can be understood by guessing the mental state of the donkey. She shouted from afar, ‘I must say, Babuji, you ran away so stealthily that not even a soul got a hint of your departure. There were so many good, vacant houses in that area. How was I to know that you were unhappy with that house, or else I would have let you know that there was a very comfortable house vacant right behind mine. I won’t let you live here—I’m ready to do whatever it takes—even if I have to carry you out of here myself. How much rent do you pay for this house?’

I pulled a long face and said, ‘Ten rupees.’

I had thought that once I told her how low the rent was, she would have nothing more to argue about. The rent was actually twenty rupees. For ten one would not even be able to find a place to die in. But this ruse had no effect on her. ‘Ten rupees for this small shack!’ she said. ‘You pay eight and, if the house isn’t better than this, then leave whenever you wish. Come, I’ll go get the keys to the house and I’ll show it to you right now.’

I knitted my brows and said, ‘But I’ve just moved in. How can I leave? I’ve already paid an advance on the rent.’

The shopkeeper gave the most disarming of smiles and said, ‘It’s only ten rupees and ten rupees is no large amount to you. And think about it, if you don’t come, I’ll be ruined. Nobody else’s first purchase would bring as much good luck to the shop as yours did. If you don’t come, then I will shift my shop here.’

My heart sank. This was a nice mess I was in. What if the witch actually shifted her shop here? I felt like lashing out at her but I was much too civil for that. I told her, ‘Nothing about me is certain—how long I will stay, or when I will have to move out. I could get a posting anytime and then I will have to leave immediately. You would then be in a fix.’

In a voice choked with grief, she said, ‘When you leave, I will also leave. But you are not going today.’

‘But nothing about me is certain.’

‘Then I’ll come here every day and make the day’s first sale to you.’

‘You’ll come this far every day?’

‘Yes. I’ll come. It’s only two miles. Here, let me make the day’s first sale to you—I’ve brought the betel leaves. Make the first purchase with your auspicious hands.’

I took the little triangular betel leaves, paid her, went up in a state of stupor and lay down on my cot.

My brain has now stopped working out a solution to get out of this mess. I have been in a state of anxiety ever since and can see no way out. I want to remain honourable and do not want to be rude, and I want to be rescued from this horrible situation. If there is any gentleman out there who can give me some advice as to how I can extricate myself from this pitiful mess, I would be indebted to him for the rest of my life.

Translated from the Hindi by Sunil Kumar



Desire

There was a huge commotion in the neighbourhood yesterday. A paanwala was beating up his wife. The poor woman wept bitterly but the heartless man did not take pity on her. Finally, the woman too lost her temper. She stood up and proclaimed, ‘That’s it, it would not do any good to hit me any more. From today, I sever all relations with you. I would rather beg than return to your home.’ Having said this, she picked up one of her old saris and walked out of the house. The man stared after her, transfixed. The woman walked a few paces and then, retracing her steps, opened the cashbox and took out some money. Perhaps, till then, she may have felt some compassion for him, but that callous fellow immediately held her hand and forcibly snatched away the money. Such heartlessness! The levels of atrocity that man can inflict upon weak women! And then there might have been a day when he was ready to sacrifice his life at her altar, he might have loved her to distraction, but today he had become so cruel that under the present circumstances it seemed that he had never known her at all. Leaving the money aside, the wife left without paying any heed to anybody. Nobody knows where she went! I stood there watching for hours through the window of my room thinking that she might return or that paanwala might try to persuade her, but neither happened. Today I learnt about the real predicament of women. The shop belonged to both of them. The man loitered around, while the woman contributed significantly by putting in

serious hard work. I would see her sitting up late at her shop till ten or eleven in the night. Early morning when I woke up from sleep, then too I found her at the shop. When they fought like cats and dogs, which was rather often, the woman usually had the upper hand but the male ego quite naturally reigned supreme. A woman is nothing in front of a man. Whenever the man wants, he can throw her out of the house!

I was so disturbed that I lost all sleep. It was past midnight and I remained seated. The sky was suffused with the gentle moonlight. It seemed that the moon swelled with pride as it sat on a star-studded throne. Gradually small clouds floated towards the moon and then disintegrated completely as though beautiful women clad in white wept over the disgrace and oppression to which they had been subjected. I was so disconcerted by this thought that I shut the window and sat on the couch. My lover was deep in sleep. At that point his radiant countenance looked quite like the moon to me. It was that courageous countenance which always gratified my eyes. It was the same broad chest upon which I laid my head and experienced a soft and sweet tremor deep down in my mind. These were the arms that filled me with ecstasy when they held me close in an embrace. But it has been several days since I last saw the bright outline of a smile on his face; neither have I been desirous to see it. It's been long since I last rested my head on his chest and or had those arms embrace me. Why? Which one of us has suffered change: my husband or I?

It was not so long ago, about five years in all—a total of just about five years, when my husband had welcomed me with loving eyes and eager lips. I had bowed my head in modesty. In my heart I felt a strong desire to take a peek at his face but I was so shy that I could not raise my head. At last I mustered the courage to steal a glance at him but my scan had to stop midway. However the happiness I felt in that half glance—will I ever be able to forget that? That sight is still engraved in my heart indelibly. Every time I recall that sight, my heart feels enraptured. That happy memory can still create the same tingling, the same thrill of delight. Now I see that person day in and day out. At dawn, in the morning, at noon, in the evening

and at night, all day I see him, but my heart does not flutter any more. He stands in front of me and chats but I keep looking at the crochet pattern. Every time he went out of the house, I would stand near the entrance to see him off. And when he looked back to throw a smile at me, I felt that I reigned over the kingdom of heaven. Towards the evening I would climb up to the terrace and await his arrival. Just when I saw him coming from afar, I would rush down in excitement to greet him at the door. But now I do not know when he leaves or when he returns. When the entrance gate is shut, I know that he has left, and when I hear the crackling sound of the opening gate, I can guess that he has returned. It is hard to comprehend whether *I* have transformed or if it is my husband who has become something else.

In those days, he seldom came home. Every time I heard him speak, a shiver of excitement ran down my spine. I noticed even the most inconspicuous things about him with enchanted and fond eyes. When he took the little one in his lap and cuddled him, when he patted Tommy's head to make him lie down, when he ran outside jeering at the old devotee, when he watered the plants with buckets full of water, my eyes followed him everywhere. Now he is always at home, he laughs and talks in my presence, I don't even have any inkling about it. I wonder why.

During those early days he once brought a bouquet of flowers and gave it to me with a smile. I was overwhelmed to receive that gift of love. There were only a few flowers and leaves but my eyes were never satiated looking at them. For some time I held it in my hands, later I kept it in a flower vase on my table. Even if I was busy with some work, I came back again and again to take a look at the bouquet. How many times I held it close to my eyes, how many times I kissed it. Even if somebody had offered me a hundred thousand rupees for it, I wouldn't have given it to them. Each of the petals had the value of a gem for me. When the bouquet wilted away, I kept it inside my box. Since that day he has gifted me a thousand things—jewellery studded with precious stones, expensive apparel—each one better than the other, and as for bouquets, he brings them regularly. But there is no

thrill in receiving these gifts any longer. I wear these things, see myself in the mirror and swell with pride. I show them off to my peers to enhance my prestige and evoke their envy. That's it.

Recently he gave me a neckpiece in the shape of a half-moon; whoever sees it gets enamoured by it. I am also charmed by its design and embellishments. I opened my casket and brought out my bouquet. Oh! No sooner had I held it in my hands than a stream of excitement rushed through my veins. The threads in my heart began to quiver. Those dried petals, which had now turned yellow, seemed to speak to me. The inchoate tremor of its dry, withered petals seemed to me like quick-flowing words soaked in affection, but that lustrous, gem-studded, gold necklace was merely a pile of stones which had neither life nor consciousness nor meaning. I kissed the bouquet once again, held it close to my heart, looked at it lovingly with moist eyes and then kept it inside the casket once more. A casket full of jewels is trivial in front of that one single memory. What was the mystery behind it?

I was reminded of one of his old letters. He had sent it to me while he was in college. When I read it, I felt such pleasure in my heart, such strong emotions, that tears ran down my eyes; how could I ever forget that? I had kept that letter in my vanity box. At that moment I felt a strong desire to read that letter. I took it out of the box. No sooner had I touched it than my hands began to tremble and I felt my heart beat loudly. I cannot even say how long I stood there holding the letter in my hand. I felt as though I had again become the same person that I was when I had received the letter for the first time. Was that letter a poetic outpouring of love? Was it a literary critique of love? Was it a piteous lament of the pain of separation? It did not even contain a single word of love. He had written—

> Kamini, you've not written a single letter in the last eight days. Why haven't you written? If you do not write, I won't come home during the Holi holidays, do understand that! After all, what do you do all day? Have you opened my closet of novels? Why did you open the closet? If you don't write, then your lover will cry and feel sad. Do you care about that? I go to bed at nine and then wake up at eight in the morning. The only thing that bothers me is that I should not fail. If I fail then you are to be blamed.

How simple it was, the outpouring of an innocent heart, how sincere, meaningful, and yet how frightening! As though the entire responsibility of his well-being depended upon me. Will he be able to give a similar threat now? Never! Such a threat can only be given by a person who experiences the pain of separation. My husband knows well that a similar threat will not have the same effect on me any more; I'll laugh and sleep without any pangs of anxiety, because I know that he'll surely come, as he has nowhere else to go. Where can he go? Since then he has written me so many letters. Even if he goes out for a couple of days, he makes it a point to write me at least one letter, and when he goes out for five or ten days I receive letters regularly. The letters are billets-doux, suffused with amorous expressions and epithets. I read them and put them away with a sigh. Alas! All has suffered change. Those amorous words now seem lifeless, bland and contrived. Where has the charm gone? Where is the passion, where is the anger? Where has the frustration disappeared? I try to search for some emotion in them—some unknown, imperceptible, indistinguishable thing—but I cannot find it. They are full of a sweet fragrance, the quality of the paper surpasses that of artistic handmade paper, but this embellishment looks similar to the adornment of a heroine who is past her youth. Sometimes I don't even open the letters. I know what has been written.

During one of those days I was observing a fast for the festival of Teej. I had bowed my head in front of the deity and prayed, 'Devi, I ask only one boon of you. The two of us should never be separated, I have no other desire, and I don't want anything else from this universe.' It's been four years since then and we have never been separated for a single day. I had asked for only one boon. The deity gave me a whole treasure of blessings. But if I get a vision of the devi today, I would ask her to take back all her blessings. I don't want any of them. I would rather experience the same desire of love once more. By giving me everything, you have deprived me of that unequalled pleasure that is found in desire. I would entreat you, O Deity, to let me have the experience of roaming around searching for my lover in a lonely riverbed or a dense forest. I shall ask the ripples of the

river, ‘Have you seen my lover?’ I shall ask the trees, ‘Where has my lover disappeared?’

Shall I never experience that bliss? A cool gentle breeze began to blow. I had been looking out of the window. I felt as though my lover was in the wafts of the breeze. I looked at the sky. The rays of the moon were playing hide and seek with my eyes like the sparkling silvery stars. They would come close to me when I closed my eyes but vanished as soon as I opened them. At that moment I felt as though my lover, seated upon those stars, was descending from the sky. Just then someone sang:

> The sacrifices of the lover are extraordinary,
> Extraordinary is the universe of sorrow!
> Where have you vanished?
> Leaving behind an invaluable world of love!

‘Leaving behind an invaluable world of love.’ I can’t say from where this couplet landed and pierced my heart like an arrow. I had goosebumps. A continuous stream of tears rolled down my eyes. I felt as if someone was snatching my lover away from me. I shrieked loudly and my husband instantly woke up from his sleep. He came to me and said, ‘Are you okay? What! You are crying? What’s the matter? Did you have a bad dream?’

Between my tears I asked, ‘What should I do—laugh or cry?’

My lord held my hand and said, ‘Why, do you have a reason or are you crying for nothing?’

‘Don’t you know the reason?’

‘How do I know what’s going on in your heart?’

‘Did you even try to know?’

‘I didn’t even have the notion that there could be a reason behind your tears.’

‘You are so well read, still you say something like this?’

Looking confused, my husband said, ‘You speak in riddles to me.’

‘Why, you never cry?’

‘Why should I cry?’

‘Don’t you have any desire now?’

‘My biggest wish has been fulfilled. I don’t desire anything now.’

Having said this, my husband smiled and moved forward to hug me. I felt hurt by his lack of feelings. I pushed him aside with my hands and said, ‘I don’t consider this pretension to be love. One who is incapable of feeling is incapable of love. To weep and to love, both these emotions arise from the same source.’

At that moment, the same song could be heard again:

> The sacrifices of the lover are extraordinary,
> Extraordinary is the universe of sorrow!
> Where have you vanished?
> Leaving behind an invaluable world of love!

That smile of my husband vanished somewhere. I saw him shivering. It felt as if he was in ecstasy. At once his right hand moved towards his chest. He took a deep breath and tears ran down his cheeks. Still weeping, I placed my head on his chest and experienced that ultimate pleasure for which my heart had been longing. Today I could again feel his heart beat; today there was a renewed vigour in his touch.

Until now, the words of that couplet had been echoing in my heart:

> Where have you vanished?
> Leaving behind an invaluable world of love!

Translated from the Hindi by Ranjeeta Dutta



The Rebel

1

I have suffered in silence for the last ten years. I hide a blazing fire in this tender little heart. There must be peace somewhere in this world, fun and games and happiness, but for me, there is just this inferno and nothing else. All my desires have been burnt to cinders in it. Who can I share my tale of suffering with? Of what use would that be, in any case? It is better for someone who only has tears, endless tears, in store for him, to die.

I first met Tara when I was ten. My father was one of Agra's well-known doctors. A paternal uncle lived in Lucknow. He had made a lot of money in the legal profession. I lived with my uncle in those days. My uncle did not have any children, so I was his legal heir. Both *chacha* and *chachi,* my uncle and aunt, loved me as their own son. My mother had passed away when I was a child. It was from my aunt that I received as alms the little maternal love that was my due. Those alms were like the benediction of my childhood, deprived of maternal love as I was.

There was a gentleman from our community who was my uncle's neighbour. He held a good post in the railways division, earning two hundred to two hundred and fifty rupees a month. Vimalchandra was his name. Tara was his daughter. She must have been about five years old then. I can picture that childhood day when Tara, dressed in a frock, a rose tucked

into her hair, came and stood before me. I can't explain why, but the sight of her did something to me. She seemed to me like a divine creature who had descended from the skies, embellished with the perfume and light of evening.

Tara often came to see me since that day. There was no room for her to play in her own house. There was a large field in front of my uncle's house. That is where she would play. I gradually got used to her company. When I returned from school, Tara would come running and take my bag of books from me. When I got into the car to go to school, she would come and sit beside me. One day, when Tara was around, my aunt told my uncle, 'I'll make Tara my daughter-in-law. What, Krishna, will you marry Tara?' I ran out, embarrassed. Tara remained there as if my aunt had called her to give her sweets. From that day on, my uncle and aunt would discuss this often—sometimes in all seriousness, sometimes in jest. I'd flee the scene in shame then, but Tara would be delighted. The two families were so close that such an arrangement would not have been out of the ordinary. Tara's parents were absolutely certain that she would be married to me. I was welcomed heartily whenever I went to their home. Tara's mother would leave her with me and disappear on some pretext or the other. Nobody had any doubt that it was Tara who would become the queen of my heart.

That innocent girl made a toy clay hut one day. There was a neem tree in front of my house. She built her hut in the shade of that tree. There were many small rooms and several utensils of clay as well as a small charpoy. I went and saw that Tara was quite engrossed in making the hut. As soon as she saw me, she rushed to me and said, 'Krishna, come and see our house; I have just built it.' I saw the hut and smiled and asked, 'Who will live here, Tara?'

Tara made a face as if to say that it was a stupid question. She said, 'Why, where will you and I stay? When we get married, we will come and live in this house. There, see, that is your study; you will sit there and do your reading. The other room is mine; I will sit here and play with my dolls.'

I laughed and asked, ‘What? Will I spend my whole life reading and will you always play with dolls?’ Tara looked at me in a way that suggested she did not understand what I meant. For that madcap, life was only about laughter and play. She did not know that a gust of wind would one day blow this hut away and who knew where it would leave us then.

After this, I came to my father’s house and carried on with my studies for several years. I cannot say for certain if the climate of Lucknow did not agree with me or if that was just the excuse my father made to keep me close to him. I studied in Agra till my intermediate but I used to go back often to visit my uncle. I went to Lucknow for every occasion; and my summer holidays were entirely spent there. As soon as one holiday got over, I’d start counting the days to the next. A letter from Tara would arrive if I was late by even a day. The enthusiasm and intoxication of youth had now taken over that innocent childhood love. How can I forget those wonderful days! Those sweet memories are all I have now. The two of us would secretly meet at night and build castles in the air. Which is not to say we had vulgar thoughts—by no means! Not a word or a single indication passed between us that we would be unable to repeat in public, that was outside the bounds of propriety. Ours was merely the hesitation that is natural in these circumstances. Even a newly married man and woman can be embarrassed about talking to each other in company. Yes, I do not think of those who argue for the English concept of equality. They even embrace and kiss in the presence of their elders. Tara and I met as friends—we would bet on card games, discuss literature, sometimes plan to serve the country, and sometimes to make a family. What can I say, Tara’s heart was so pure! It’s only then that I understood how a woman could control a man, how she could make the ugly pure. We derived such boundless joy from talking to each other, sitting face-to-face. Then again, you need romantic talk only to convince someone of your total admiration, great devotion and complete surrender. Our relationship was sealed. Only the rituals remained. She considered me her husband, and I thought of her as my wife. Who can possibly touch the items on the plate before it is offered to the gods? Sometimes we quarrelled and wouldn’t speak to each other for days, but no

matter who was at fault, it was always she who would have to make up. I would flare up over small things. She was ever smiling and very tolerant, but she was also highly sentimental. She wouldn't eat even after getting me to eat; she wouldn't smile even after making me smile.

I got a position in the army as soon as I passed my intermediate. My father was highly respected by the officers of my division. I was made a sergeant and, by a stroke of good fortune, was posted in Lucknow. My deepest prayers had been answered.

But destiny was hatching a very different plot. I was lost in the fantasy that Tara would soon be mine. But something else altogether was brewing. One of the city's wealthy men broached the subject of marriage to my uncle, promising eight thousand rupees. Chachaji's mouth watered. *This is an unheard of sum*, he thought, *why let it go?* Vimal Babu's daughter would no doubt get married to someone or the other. Chachaji promised to think over the matter and let him know; then he summoned Vimal Babu and said, 'Chaudhuri Sahib was here today to talk about Krishna's marriage. You do know him, right? He is offering eight thousand rupees. I told him I would think over it. What do you say? Should I agree to the match?'

'What are you saying?' Vimal Babu said, alarmed. 'Hasn't Krishna's marriage been fixed with Tara?'

Feigning innocence, chacha said, 'That's something I'm hearing for the first time. Who has decided on this marriage? You and I have never talked about anything like it.'

Vimal Babu retorted rather heatedly, 'I've been hearing about this for the last ten or twelve years. Should I have had it officially approved? I've always believed that it's been decided. Why just me, the whole neighbourhood thinks it a done thing.'

Afraid now that people might slander him, my uncle said a little more gently, 'Bhai Sahib, the truth is that whenever I talked about this relationship, I did it in jest, but I don't want to disappoint you. You're an old friend. I am ready to discuss anything with you. I'm getting eight thousand. You could give me seven thousand—even six thousand will do.'

Vimal Babu said distractedly, ‘Are you joking . . . or are you really asking for dowry . . . I can’t believe it.’

2

My uncle clutched his head and said, ‘This is no joking matter. I can talk to Chaudhuri right now.’

Vimal Babu said, ‘Babuji, you’ve mentioned something I never thought would come up between you and me. God has done much for you. A few thousands will hardly make a difference. But this sum is beyond me. I can only beg for your mercy. For ten or twelve years now, we’ve imagined Krishna as our son-in-law. What you’ve said has also often encouraged us to think that. You know of the love between Krishna and Tara. For God’s sake, don’t destroy so many people for a few thousand rupees.’

My uncle said brazenly, ‘Vimal Babu, I am sorry I cannot negotiate any further on this matter.’

Vimal Babu retorted sharply, ‘You are strangulating me!’

‘You should be grateful to me for the allowances I’m making for you.’

‘Of course, you strangle me and I ought to be grateful to you! I am not so generous. I’d have stayed away from you if I had known you were so greedy. I used to think you a gentleman. I see now that you too are a slave to money. I cannot call a person who has no sense of principles and whose promises are hollow, honest. You’re free to get Krishna Babu married off wherever you like, but see if you don’t regret it. Tara will be married for sure, and God willing, she will get married into a good family. There is no dearth of good people in this world, but you will come by nothing but disgrace and dishonour.’

‘If you hadn’t been in my house, I would have had an answer to this insult,’ my uncle said, raising his voice.

Vimal Babu took his walking stick and said as he left the room, ‘What answer would you have given? You aren’t good enough for that.’

That evening after tea I was just about to leave for Vimal Babu’s house when my aunt said, ‘Where are you going? There was a scuffle between

Vimal Babu and your uncle today.'

I froze and asked in shock, 'A scuffle? Over what?'

My aunt recounted all the details, painting Vimal Babu as black as she possibly could. 'What can I tell you, *beta*, I've never seen a man with such cheek. He cursed a thousand times, he was itching to get into a fight.'

I stood silently for a minute and then said, 'Okay, I won't go there. I am going back to the barracks.' My aunt cried and screamed, but I did not stop even a second. It felt as if someone in my heart was howling. It could not have taken me longer than ten minutes to reach the barracks from home. My soul revolted not against my uncle, not even against Vimal Babu, but only against myself. Why didn't I have the courage to go and tell my uncle —even a lakh of rupees couldn't compel me to get married? Why was I such a coward, so meek, so spineless?

Thus boiling with rage, I wrote a letter to my father telling him all that had happened and then saying, 'I have decided I will not get married anywhere else, even if it means disobeying you.' I don't even remember everything I wrote in that highly charged state. I only remember filling up ten or twelve pages in ten minutes flat. If I could, I'd have wired the whole letter.

I spent the next three days in a state of such anticipation as can only be imagined. How base Tara must consider me, I would fret. So many times I wanted to go across and fall at her feet, saying, 'Devi, forgive me, don't think about my uncle's cruelty. I was always yours and I remain yours. I don't care about my uncle getting mad at me or my father throwing me out of the house, but if I lose you, I lose my life.'

The reply to my letter arrived on the third day. The little hope I had left crumbled. It was exactly the reply I had feared. It said—'I have nothing but respect for Bhai Sahib*;* I cannot say a single word to oppose his decision and you too would do well not to say anything to annoy him.'

I tore that letter up and trampled upon it and immediately started walking in the direction of Vimal Babu's house. Alas! If only someone had stopped me then, if only someone had threatened me, I would not have breathed till I got there and my life would have turned out different. But who was there

to try and stop me! I lost my courage midway. I turned back. I don't know what made me turn back. I didn't give a damn about my uncle's displeasure. I no longer had any respect for him. I was prepared to give up all claims to his property. Nor was I afraid of annoying my father. I was hesitant because —how could I show my face there? I was, after all, the nephew of that very uncle. What would there be left to do but go and drown myself if Vimal Babu refused to meet me or if he showed me the door the moment I got there? My biggest fear was about what I would do if Tara found fault with me. Alas! Heartless Tara! Cruel Tara! Insensitive Tare! If only you had written me a couple of lines then to bolster my confidence, my life would have been full of joy and happiness today. Your silence damned me— forever! Ah, forever.

3

The next three days I walked on hot coals. I had decided that I would not see anyone. The whole world felt like my enemy. I was angry with Tara as well. As for my uncle, I despised his very face. But on the evening of the third day, his summons came—'Come and meet me.' I felt like writing to him—'There is nothing between us now; consider me dead.' But then I remembered his love and kindness towards me. This was also a good chance to tell him what I thought of him to his face. My heart full of passion and spoiling for a fight, I presented myself at my uncle's service.

He eyed me from head to toe and then asked, 'Aren't you keeping well these days? Raisahib Sitaram had come here today. He wanted to discuss a few things with you. Come down here tomorrow morning if you can manage some time; or, if you are not in a hurry to get back, I can send for him right now.'

I understood, of course, who this Raisahib was, but I asked with an air of naivety, 'Who is this Raisahib? I don't think I know him.'

'Oh, it is the same gentleman who has been pestering us about your marriage,' my uncle said casually. 'He is rich, upper class. I've agreed to

his proposal. The girl is good too. Far better than Tara. In any case, if you have any questions for him, you're free to ask him.'

Deliberately silencing the storm of emotions brewing inside me, I said, 'You agreed to the proposal unnecessarily. I don't want to get married.'

My uncle glared at me and asked, 'Why?'

I replied with the same fearlessness, 'Because I want to be free to make up my mind on the subject.'

He said a little more gently, 'I have given my word. Don't you care about that?'

'I cannot ruin my life for a promise bought for a few rupees,' I retorted passionately.

'Is this your final decision?' my uncle asked grimly.

'Yes, Sir, final.'

'You'll regret it.'

'Please don't worry yourself over it. I won't come to trouble you.'

'Good.'

He got up and went inside. I left the room and walked towards the barracks. The world spun, the skies seemed to be dancing and my body seemed to be floating. I felt like I was walking on air.

When I reached the barracks, I lay down and cried my heart out. I had parents, uncle and aunt, wealth, and yet I was an orphan. What a cruel blow!

The next morning, our regiment received orders to proceed to Dehradun. I seemed to get a fresh lease of life. Lucknow had become intolerable to me now. I despised its every lane and alley. I felt like going and seeing Tara once, but then the same fear haunted me—what if she refused to meet me? I was no longer sure if Vimal Babu felt the same affection for me as he had in the past. Earlier, I had been the heir of a wealthy family; now, I was an orphaned young man who had nothing but his labour to fall back on.

Had I been able to spend some peaceful time in Dehradun, perhaps my injured heart would have healed itself and I could have persuaded Vimal Babu. But I had not been there even a week when a letter from Tara reached me. My hands began to tremble as soon as I saw the address. The trembling

engulfed my whole body. I could not have felt so terrified coming face-to-face with even a tiger. I just could not muster up the courage to open it. That same handwriting, that same row of pearls, the sight of which I would drink with my eyes, which I would kiss and hold close to my breast, those very black letters today seemed more terrifying than serpents. I tried imagining what she had written, but even the wildest of my conjectures could not arrive at the contents of the letter. Finally, steadying my heart, I went ahead and opened the letter. Darkness clouded my eyes the moment I read it. I felt as if someone had fed me molten glass. Tara's wedding had been fixed. There were only twenty-four hours to go before the wedding. She begged my forgiveness for her mistakes and asked me not to forget her. My tears gushed out as I read the last line. 'This is my final offering of love to you,' she had written. 'After today, we are just friends. Thinking of it in any other way would be unfair to my husband, and you would probably be the one to dislike it the most. This is all I have to say. It is a very good thing that you have left. You'd have suffered if you'd stayed, and so would I. But, my love! Do not forget your unfortunate Tara. This is my last request to you.'

I lay down, clutching the letter. My chest felt ready to burst. *God, what do I do now?* The groom's party would be at the door by the time I reached Lucknow. But I just could not suppress the overpowering need to see Tara one last time. That was now the last temptation of my life.

I went and said to the commanding officer, 'I have to go to Lucknow on some urgent work. I want to request a three-day leave.'

The sahib said, 'You can't get leave now.'

'I must go; it's urgent.'

'You cannot go.'

'There is no way I can stay.'

'There is no way you can leave.'

I did not plead my case further. I left. I decided to take the night train to Lucknow. The prospect of being court-martialled did not alarm me in the least.

It was evening when I reached Lucknow. I stood at some distance from the platform for a while, waiting for it to get darker. Then I left to witness the most terrible chapter in the drama of my fortunes. The groom's party had arrived. The gaslights were lit. Members of the groom's party were milling around. The terrace of our house was right next to the terrace of Tara's house. The road led past the men's quarters of the house. Chacha Sahib appeared to be out. The servants were witnessing the pomp and show of the groom's party. I furtively climbed up the stairs and stepped on to the terrace. Everything was quiet there. My heart was overwhelmed with emotion. Alas! This was the place where we had shared our love. This was where I would sit with Tara and make plans. This place was, for me, a paradise of hope and a site of pilgrimage. Each particle of this ground was sanctified with sweet memories. But, alas! Like my heart, it too was barren, forsaken and dark today. Embracing the ground, I wept uncontrollably. If only Tara had come then, I would have rested my head at her feet and gone off to sleep forever! I had the feeling then that Tara's pure heart was weeping at my plight. She must have been here today as well. She might have embraced this ground like me and wept. The scent of her perfumed hair floated up from the floor. I took my handkerchief out from my pocket and began to collect dust from the floor. I cleaned the whole terrace in a trice and, holding the cinders of my life's desires, cried bitter tears. This was the reward for my love, the fruit of my meditation, the benediction of my life. Such was my fate!

The rituals of marriage were being carried out downstairs. Exactly at midnight, the bride stood in the *mandap*; it was time for them to culminate their wedding by walking around the fire. I moved to the edge of the terrace and began to watch that terrible spectacle. It felt as if someone were cutting up my heart into pieces. I don't know why it didn't burst, why my eyes did not pop out of their sockets. That mandap was my funeral pyre, where everything precious to me was being set on fire.

When the ritual was over, I climbed down from the terrace. What was left now? Even the embers of the pyre had been doused with a flood of water. With my heart in my mouth, writhing in agony, I came to the gate near the

staircase, but the gate was shut from the outside. What now? I turned back in my tracks. There was no way I could leave now except through Tara's courtyard. Nobody would recognize me in that throng; I could slip by unnoticed, I thought. But Tara's mother saw me the moment I stepped into the courtyard. She asked, startled, 'Krishna Babu? When did you arrive? Come into my room. We didn't send you an invitation because we were scared of your uncle. Tara will leave in the morning. Come and meet her. She's been waiting for you all day.'

She then clutched my arm and pulled me along to her room. Then she asked, 'You have been home, haven't you?'

'Where is my home here?' I asked.

'Why, your uncle is here, isn't he?'

'Yes, that is my uncle's house; I don't have a home anywhere. I did have the hopes of setting up one, but you folks have dashed that hope.'

'How are we to blame? The girl had to be married off somewhere. Your uncle had left us stranded midstream. It was God who came to our rescue. Have you come directly from the station? You probably haven't eaten.'

'Yes, you can get me some poison; that is the best medicine for me.'

The startled old woman looked me in the face. What did the poor thing know about how much I loved Tara?

I said with the same irritation in my voice, 'Since all of you have already decided to slaughter me, why the delay? I hadn't imagined that you would cheat me like this. Anyway, whatever has happened is for the best. I suppose it is too much to expect that you would tolerate me after I fell from grace in the eyes of my father and my uncle.'

The old woman looked at me with hurt in her eyes and said, 'Do you really think we are that selfish, my son?'

With a heart burnt to cinders, I replied, 'I didn't until today, however, circumstances leave me no choice but to think that. Even my worst enemy could not have dealt a blow as terrible as this. My blood will be on your hands.'

'It was *your* uncle who refused us.'

‘But did any of you ask me anything, did you say anything, did you even give me a chance to say anything? You turned your face away as if deep down this is what you really wanted. But why should I hold it against you now? It’s enough for me that Tara stays happy.’

‘But, son, you didn’t write anything either; if you had written even a small note, we’d have been reassured. How were we to know that you loved Tara so much? We have made a mistake, but the bigger mistake is the one you’ve made. Now I understand why Tara would always be looking out for the postman. She spent the whole day yesterday waiting for the postman. She lost all hope when she didn’t hear from you. Should I call her? Do you want to meet her?’

I got up from the charpoy and said, ‘No, no, don’t call her. I can’t face her now. I don’t know what I might do if I see her.’

And I left. Tara’s mother called out to me many times, but I never turned back.

This is the story of my helplessness. Ten years have passed since then. Only I know what I have had to face these last ten years. I have often gone without food. I was thrown out of the army just three days after the incident. I have nothing to do but wander around aimlessly. Nobody gives me work, and when they do, I can’t hang on to the job. Life has become a burden. Nothing interests me. And I flee from the very face of man.

Tara is happy. Three or four years ago, I went to her house. Her husband had very earnestly requested me to go visit them. He had coaxed and cajoled and made me promise to come. I had no option but to go. That bud had blossomed into a flower. Tara came near me. Her husband, too, was sitting there. I could not meet her eyes. She wrapped her arms round my feet. Not a single word escaped my lips. If Tara had been unhappy, in distress and a broken person, I would have sacrificed myself for her, but the satisfied, happy, blooming Tara did not deserve my sympathy. I could not stop myself from thinking—*What cruelty! What infidelity!*

That evening, I was sitting despondently and regretting my visit when Tara’s husband came and sat beside me and said with a smile, ‘Babuji, I was sorry to hear that my marriage to Tara caused you such great shock. A

woman like Tara could make even the gods selfish, but I can tell you honestly, if I had known you were so much in love with Tara, I would certainly not have become a thorn in your path. My regret is that I got to know of it only much later. Tara has told me your love story.'

I smiled and said, 'So, I suppose you despise the very sight of me.'

He said vehemently, 'Quite the contrary; I am indebted to you. You have set such a pure and shining example of love before her. She still remembers you with the same love. Rarely does a day pass without her talking of you. She considers your love the most precious thing in her life. You probably think she is unhappy remembering the past. Not at all; they are her sweetest memories. She says, "I have found my Krishna in you."'

For me, just this is enough.

Translated from the Hindi by M. Asaduddin



Experience

1

My dearest husband had been given a year's imprisonment. His only offence was that three days ago, he had shown the kindness of offering sherbet-paan to some freedom fighters in the sweltering summer afternoon. I was standing in the court and outside, the political conscience of the entire city howled like a captive beast. My sweetheart was brought to the court in handcuffs. Silence fell. A tumult rose within me. I felt desperate, as if life were slipping out of my hands. Waves of fury rose and enflamed my entire body. Oh, I had never felt such pride! The court, the British officer seated there, the policemen wearing red brocade turbans, all of it appeared so disgusting. I strongly felt that I should fall at the feet of my beloved and end my life there and then. How calm and composed he looked! An epitome of pride and self-respect! His face showed no sign of regret, distress or melancholy; instead, his lips bore a ready, charming and radiant smile. To be given one year of rigorous imprisonment for a small offence like that! What amazing justice! I would willingly commit thousands of such crimes. My beloved glanced at me as the police was taking him out; he smiled softly and then suddenly his face stiffened. After returning from the court, I sent someone to buy sweets for five rupees and distributed them among the volunteers. Later in the evening, I not only went to attend a Congress

meeting for the first time in my life but also addressed the gathering from the dais and took a pledge to be a satyagrahi. I don't know where I found such courage from. Having lost everything, what was there to worry about or fear now? Even destiny's harshest blow could not do me any harm now.

2

I sent two telegrams the next day, one to my father and the other to my father-in-law. My father-in-law was a pensioner and my father held a decent position in the forest department. The entire day went by without a reply. Even on the second day, there was no response. Finally, letters from both the gentlemen reached on the third day. Both were furious. My father-in-law had written—'I had hoped that both of you would look after me in my old age but you have belied my hopes. What do you want now? That I should go begging? I receive a pension from the government and I can't afford to lose it by offering you shelter.' My father didn't use such harsh words but he also conveyed the same message. He was expecting a higher grade that year and if he were to call me to stay with him, he might have lost it. Nevertheless, he was willing to give me emotional support. I tore both letters in anger and never contacted them again. How ruthless and selfish! How could a father be so cold and indifferent towards his own daughter just because he doesn't want to suffer from any material loss? How could a father-in-law become so unconcerned about his daughter-in-law? Well, I was still very young and had yet to experience the ways of the world.

So far, I hadn't had to worry about myself but now this new problem had cropped up. How would I live in this deserted house, alone and bereft? But where could I go? Had I been a man, I could have easily sought refuge in the ashram run by the Congress or I could have found some odd job but the consciousness of being a woman fettered me. I wasn't really concerned about my life, I was more worried about my honour. I wanted to protect myself from evil and lustful eyes.

I heard someone talking and looked below. I saw that two men were standing there. I wanted to ask, ‘Who are you? Why are you standing here?’ But then I realized that I had no right to ask such questions. This was a thoroughfare. Still I grew suspicious. I could not brush aside the fear that smouldered in my heart like an ember.

My body was burning with the growing heat, yet I locked the doors from inside. I had a big kitchen knife in my house, which I always kept under my pillow for safety. That fear seemed to stare me in the face. I heard somebody calling me. My hair stood on end. I pressed my ear against the door. Someone was knocking at my door. My heart started beating fast. I was afraid that they might be the same two louts whom I saw the other day. Why were they pestering me? What did they want from me? I was exasperated. I opened the door and went out into the balcony and shouted, ‘Who’s that?’ Someone answered and my fear vanished. It was Babu Gyanchand. Among all my husband’s friends, there was no one gentler or kinder than him. I rushed down to open the door. A woman was with him. It was his wife. She was older than me. This was her first visit to my home. I touched her feet. In families like ours, women weren’t supposed to be friendly with men.

They came inside. Gyan Babu was a teacher in a school. A learned, generous and simple man. But that day I realized that his wife was his guide. She was plump but she was a very talented lady. Laden with ornaments from head to toe, she had the aura of a queen. She was not really pretty but her face had a distinct charm. If I had met her elsewhere, I might have ignored her. She appeared very arrogant but behind the rough exterior was a kind heart.

‘Have you informed your family?’ she asked hesitantly.

‘Yes,’ I replied.

‘Is someone coming to fetch you?’

‘No, neither my father nor my father-in-law seems interested in keeping me.’

‘What will you do then?’

‘What else? For now, I’ll continue staying here.’

‘Why don’t you come with me? I won’t let you live alone in this house. Two men from the Intelligence are also spying on you.’

I already knew that those two fellows must be from the Intelligence.

Gyan Babu looked at his wife and said, ‘Shall I go and fetch a tonga for you?’

Madam looked like she was going to snub him, ‘Why are you still standing here?’

Master Sahib walked quietly towards the door.

‘Wait!’ she shouted. ‘How many tongas will you get?’

‘Tell me, how many?’ Master Sahib grew flustered.

‘You are asking me how many? You know only three people can fit in one tonga. Will I carry the trunks, mattresses and utensils on my head?’

‘Never mind, I’ll hire two,’ Master Sahib said nervously.

‘After all, how many things can you pile on one tonga?

‘Shall I get three, then?’

‘Of course, why don’t you go at once? You have wasted an hour over a trifle.’

Gyan Babu left before I could utter a word.

‘Dear sister, it will be a problem if I come to stay with you . . .’ I said hesitantly.

She replied sharply, ‘Yes, of course! You’ll be eating two square meals a day, will be occupying a small corner in the room, and will be spending about an anna on hair oil and stuff. That’s really a big problem, isn’t it?’

I was embarrassed.

‘Don’t worry, you can keep me as a guest when your husband is released. I shall be duly compensated. Are you convinced now? All right then, pack your luggage. We’ll send for the cot tomorrow,’ she placed her hands on my shoulder and said warmly.

3

I had never before met such a sensitive, generous and soft-spoken woman. Even if I had been her younger sister, she couldn’t have been more caring

and loving. She seemed to have total control over anger and anxiety. She always had a winsome smile on her face. Though she was childless, she never looked unhappy. She had kept a servant for running errands but she would do all the household work herself. It was difficult to believe how she could be so flabby when she ate very little and worked really hard. It was as if rest was not written in her fate. She would not rest even in the hottest afternoon in the month of Jeth and would never let me help her in any way. On the contrary, she was always offering me something or the other to eat. Her persuading me to eat so frequently was my only cause of concern here.

Barely eight days had passed when I noticed that those same spies were sitting on the street. I was alarmed. These louts had followed me here too. I immediately told *behenji*, 'It seems those two rogues are still chasing me.'

'Bloody dogs!' she said contemptuously. 'Let them sniff around.'

'I'm afraid they might create a scene,' I said anxiously.

'What else can they do except bark at you?' she replied indifferently.

'They might also bite,' I responded.

She chuckled, 'One doesn't run away for fear of such things.'

But I was apprehensive. I would often look out from the balcony and find them roaming about.

They were after my life. What harm could I do to the administration? What was I capable of?

Are they intent on kicking me out of here too? What will they gain from such a petty action except that I would then be rendered homeless? How despicable!

Another week passed but the spies didn't let me live peacefully. They scared the life out of me. I considered it improper to live here under the circumstances but I wasn't able to say anything to Deviji.

One evening when Gyan Babu returned home, he seemed shaken. I was peeling *parwal* in the veranda. Gyan Babu went straight into his room and asked her to come up. 'First, change your clothes, relax, have something to eat; we'll talk later,' she said without getting up.

But Gyan Babu was so impatient that he couldn't contain himself. 'Can't you leave your work for a minute? Don't you see I'm extremely upset?' he

insisted.

‘Why don’t you speak up? What’s the problem?’ she said without stirring.

‘Come here,’ he insisted.

‘Is there a stranger around?’ she protested.

I got up to leave but she held my hand. I tried to leave but couldn’t free myself from her grip. Gyan Babu didn’t want to speak in my presence but he could no longer restrain himself. He blurted out, ‘I had an altercation with the principal.’

‘Oh really! You must have beaten him up then,’ she said with mock seriousness.

‘How can you think of jesting at such a time, I might even lose my job!’

‘If you had such apprehensions, why did you quarrel with him?’

‘I didn’t start it. He scolded me.’

‘For no fault of yours?’

‘How do I tell you?’

‘Again you’re trying to conceal something. I’ve told you that she’s like my own sister and I don’t want to hide anything from her.’

‘What if it concerns her?’

Deviji spoke as though solving a riddle, ‘Oh, I see! It must be something related to the Intelligence. The police must have complained to your principal.’

But Gyan Babu couldn’t concede that she had solved the riddle so easily. He continued, ‘The police haven’t complained to the principal but to the district magistrate. He ordered the principal to seek an explanation from me.’

Deviji hazarded a guess, ‘Oh, I see, the principal must have asked you to throw the woman out of your house.’

‘Yes! You could say that.’

‘So, what did you say?’

‘What could I have said then? I had no answer.’

Deviji berated him, ‘What’s there to think about when the question has only one answer.’

‘Still, I had to give it some thought,’ said Gyan Babu indecisively.

Deviji knit her brows. Today, for the first time, I saw her fly into a temper.

‘Tell that principal you can’t abandon her, come what may. If he doesn’t agree, submit your resignation. Go at once, you can change and rest afterwards,’ she snapped.

I sobbed, ‘Dear sister, for my sake—’

‘Shut up or I will pull your ears.’ She scolded me gently, ‘Why are you butting in? We will live together and die together. What can I tell you about this fool? He is almost middle-aged and he has still not learnt how to assert himself.’

She said, turning to her husband, ‘Why are you still standing here? If you are scared, shall I go and talk to him?’

‘Don’t worry, I’II tell him tomorrow. Who knows where he is now,’ Gyan Babu said sheepishly.

That night I couldn’t sleep a wink. She was showing such respect for a poor woman who had been forsaken by her own family. Such honour for a homeless beggar! She was indeed a goddess.

The next morning, when Gyan Babu was about to leave, she reminded him, ‘Come back only after you have settled the matter. Don’t leave any possibility for second thoughts.’

‘Dear sister, you’re being unfair to me. I could never bear you having to go through all this,’ I said after Gyan Babu had left.

‘Have you said all you wished to say, or is there anything left?’ she said in a half-serious tone.

‘I have something more to say.’

‘All right, tell me why your husband was sent to jail. Just because he had shown some respect to the volunteers? Who are the volunteers? They are our brave soldiers who are fighting for the country. They too have families, children, parents, businesses, but they have sacrificed everything for the country. My sins will be washed away by the very presence of a woman whose husband has been thrown behind bars for honouring such courageous

men. I'm not doing you any favour. In fact, you are doing me a great favour.'

I felt myself drowning in the ocean of her kindness. What could I have said? When Gyan Babu returned in the evening, his face reflected the joy of victory.

'Victory or defeat?' Deviji asked.

'Victory!' he replied proudly. 'He grew flustered when I tendered my resignation. He ran to the district magistrate. God knows what they discussed in the motorcar. He immediately returned and asked me, "Do you attend political meetings?" "Certainly not!" I said. "Are you a member of the Congress, by any chance?" he asked me. "Forget being a member, I'm not even a member's friend," I replied. "Do you contribute to the Congress fund?" he asked. "Not even a penny," I said. "Well! We don't have any complaints against you. Here's your resignation back."'

Deviji embraced me warmly.

Translated from the Hindi by Asmat Jahan



The Balance Sheet

1

Kokila was washing away the last few traces of her licentious existence with her tears. Every time she remembered that tainted life, she would sink into gloom and despair and cry out, ‘Alas, why was I ever born?’ She tried to wipe away those blemishes through acts of charity and fasting, and squandered the springtime of her life in this futile effort. But was this awakening the boon of a sage or the result of a religious ceremony? No, this was the blessed first sight of the infant whose birth had filled up her nest after fifteen years. The sight of the infant’s face brought a feeble and melancholy smile upon her bluish lips, but only for a moment. After an instant, the smile dissolved into a long sigh. That helpless and tender cry had altered the course of her life. That radiance of motherly affection became a life message and a silent spiritual instruction for her.

Kokila named the newborn Shraddha. Shraddha’s birth had affirmed her faith in God. She considered Shraddha not just her daughter, but the incarnation of a goddess. Whenever her female friends came to congratulate her, Kokila would protect the girl from their gaze. It was unacceptable to her that their sinful glance should fall upon Shraddha. Now Shraddha was her only wealth, the pivot of her existence, and the light of her life. When she held her in her arms and looked at her affectionately, she thought, *Will*

this radiant child too become a victim of the fierce blows of lust? My efforts will have been in vain! Oh! Is there no remedy that can wipe away the instincts of birth? She prayed to God to keep Shraddha away from the thorns of life. She resolved to uphold the highest ideals in front of Shraddha through her speech and action, thoughts and behaviour. Shraddha was so humble, talented and clever that sometimes, overwhelmed with affection, Kokila would rub Shraddha's palms on her forehead and shed tears filled with penitence and joy.

2

Sixteen years passed by. The innocent and gullible Shraddha of the past was now a self-possessed, calm and modest young girl of great charm. She was a seeker of knowledge but was indifferent to worldly affairs. The girls she studied with did not talk to her. She had become somewhat conceited, growing in the isolation of her mother's love. Having only lived in an environment filled with maternal affection, abandoned by her female friends, pursuing her studies rigorously all day and night, and in solitary confinement with her books for company . . . how was it surprising that Shraddha had become egotistic? She did not have the right to speak to anybody. At school, girls of decent families considered her company shameful. As she walked on the road, people would point fingers at her and say, 'She's Kokila prostitute's daughter.' Hearing this, her head would bow down, her cheeks would turn red for a moment, but the next moment they would be as white as lime.

Shraddha was in love with seclusion. She considered marriage to be the wrath of God. If Kokila ever raised the matter, her forehead would scrunch up, darkness would spread over her gleaming, reddish face, tears would start trickling and flowing down her eyes, rendering her mother silent. There was a contrast between their life principles. While Kokila was a devotee of the deity of society, Shraddha despised all three: society, God and humans. Her books were the only things dear to her in the whole world. Shraddha only engaged with those scholars for whom there was no

difference between the high and the low, no scope for caste or creed, and everyone had equal rights. The general idea about Shraddha's nature can be gleaned from a verse of the great poet Rahim's couplet:

Prem sahit maribo bhalo, jo vish deye bulaaye

It's well to die when beckoned with love, even when given poison thereafter.

If someone summoned her with love and doled out poison alongside, she would have bent her knees in acceptance and raised it to her forehead. But in her view even ambrosia held no value if offered with scorn.

One day Kokila, her eyes filled with tears, said to Shraddha, 'Why, *munni*, speak truly, you must be ashamed of the fact that you are my daughter. Had you been born in a noble family, would such thoughts have troubled your heart? You must be cursing me from within.'

Shraddha gawked at her mother. She had never felt such reverence towards her. In a trembling voice, she said, 'Ammaji, why do you ask me such a question? Have I ever insulted you?'

Overwhelmed, Kokila replied, 'No, *beti*, I pray to that most generous God to bestow a courteous daughter like you upon everyone. But at times I think you must rue being my daughter.'

Shraddha replied firmly, 'Amma, this feeling of yours is baseless. I'm telling you the truth: I have the utmost reverence for you. Being known as your daughter is not a matter of shame for me; instead it is an honour. Man is a slave to circumstance. The atmosphere in which you grew up had to have a bearing on you, but once trapped in the mire of sin, resurfacing is definitely a matter of glory. It's quite easy to row a boat alongside the current, but only a true sailor is able to row against it.'

Kokila smiled, 'Then why do you get exasperated at the very mention of marriage?'

Shraddha lowered her eyes. 'Can't life be spent without marrying? I want to live unwed. After passing out of school, I'll join college, and after two or

three years, both of us can live independently. I can be a doctor or practise law, since all routes are accessible to women now.'

Kokila asked fearfully, 'Why! Do you harbour no other desire? Don't you yearn to love someone?'

Shraddha took a deep breath. 'Ammaji, is anyone devoid of love in the world? Love is an exalted part of human life. The divinity of the divine is expressed only in love. When I meet a person who doesn't consider choosing me to be an insult, I'll worship him with my heart and soul, but why should I beg for love? If someone did marry me in a momentary urge for reform, I'll not be happy. It is better that I give up the very thought of marrying.'

3

One of these days, the women's organization held a meeting. Passionate students of the college participated in large numbers. The hall was jam-packed. Shraddha too came and stood in the last line of women in the audience. She found all this farcical. She had joined such a gathering for the first time today.

The meeting began. After the speech of the chairperson, proposals began to be tabled, and speeches delivered in support. But all the women either forgot their speeches or felt so intimidated by the assembly that they were unable to recall the art of delivering speeches. After uttering a few broken sentences, they returned to their seats. The tenor of the assembly started deteriorating. Many ladies came up to the platform with great enthusiasm, but couldn't go beyond two or three words. The young men present there got a golden chance to poke fun at the women. Jokes began to be cracked, and mock clapping started. Shraddha fumed at their wickedness and every part of her being flared up. She went over to the platform and spoke with such elegance that the entire assembly was stunned. The noise died down; people started gawking at her. Shraddha spoke eloquently like a heavenly muse, each word suffused with novelty, liveliness and firmness. The

fragrance of her budding youth also spread all around, rendering the assembly speechless.

The meeting ended, and people engaged in extensive commentary.

One of the men present there asked, 'Who was that woman, brother?'

Another replied 'Daughter of that whore Kokila.'

A third one added, 'That's why such a voice and clarity. That's why the magic. It's magic, Janaab, magic of the body. And why not? Her mother also wreaked havoc. Ever since she left her profession, the city has become lifeless. Now it seems she's going to take her mother's place.'

At this, a coarse-clothed, dark youth snapped, 'How well you've expressed your discernment, Janaab, *wah*!'

The third man asked, 'Why do you feel bad? Is there a nexus?'

The dark youth said a little sharply, 'Aren't you ashamed of uttering such words?'

The second man asked, 'What's there to be ashamed of, Janaab? If a prostitute's daughter becomes one herself, what is so surprising about it?'

The youth replied in a disgusted voice, 'Perhaps it is right in the understanding of intelligent people like you. The delightful woman whose mouth can deliver such words is a goddess, and not one selling beauty.'

At that instant, Shraddha was leaving the assembly, and she happened to catch these last few words. She was both surprised and delighted. She gazed at the dark youth with eyes full of gratitude and moved on swiftly, but throughout the way back, those words kept resonating in her ears.

Till now, the only one to appreciate and encourage Shraddha had been her mother, Kokila. Everywhere else, she faced the same contempt and censure. Now the picture of an unknown, dark-skinned but fair-hearted, coarsely dressed young man's face danced in front of her eyes. She pondered, *Who was he? Will he ever appear again?*

While going to college, Shraddha sought the youth with befuddled eyes. At home, standing behind the blinds every day, she combed the people travelling to and fro but never spotted him.

After a few days, the announcement for a second meeting of the women's association was out. Four days remained. Shraddha spent all four preparing

for her speech. She wracked her brains for hours searching for each word. She read every sentence over and again; read the speeches of great leaders and tried emulating them. After completing the speech, Shraddha went to her room and started reading it aloud, addressing the tables and chairs. All the characteristics of the art of speechmaking were there in her performance. The conclusion was so beautiful that she herself was bowled over by it. It had such melody and attraction, and it sounded quite revolutionary.

The day of the meeting arrived. Fearful and nervous, Shraddha entered the assembly hall. The hall was full and the crowd was bigger than last time. As soon as they saw Shraddha, people clapped and welcomed her. An uproar began and everyone called out in one voice, 'Please begin your speech.'

Getting on to the stage, Shraddha cast a fleeting glance at the crowd. The dark youth was standing in the last row as there was no room. Shraddha's heart was tickled. She began her speech in a quivering voice. In her eyes, the entire hall was full of dummies. If anyone was alive, it was that dark youth standing at the very end. Her face was turned towards him. She demanded appreciation for her speech only from him. Only a jeweller can be expected to identify a diamond.

For half an hour, it seemed as if there was a shower of flowers from Shraddha's mouth. People had seldom heard such a speech.

4

At the end of the assembly, when Shraddha left for her home, she saw the dark youth walking briskly behind her. Shraddha knew that people had liked her speech a lot. But she had not got the opportunity to hear the youth's opinion. She slowed down. The next moment, the youth caught up with her. Both walked silently.

Finally, he said hesitatingly, 'You were wonderful today!'

Shraddha suppressed her delight. She only said, 'Thank you! You are just being kind.'

‘I’m not worthy enough. And it wasn’t just me, you impressed the entire assembly.’

‘Do you live nearby?’

‘Yes, I’m pursuing my MA here. I don’t know how long this spectre of high and low caste will continue to rule our minds. Unfortunately, I’m also one of those people who are considered inferior. I belong to the Chamar caste. My father worked as an attendant to the inspector of the school. I was admitted to the school through his recommendation. Since then I’ve been wrestling and sparring with fate. Earlier, the schoolmasters wouldn’t even touch me. Though that’s not the case any more, boys still shrink away from me.’

‘I judge nobility not by birth but by the virtue of merit.’

‘That has been proven by your speech. And that’s how I mustered the courage to talk to you. Otherwise, your station is well above mine!’

Shraddha lowered her eyes. ‘Perhaps you are unaware of my condition.’

‘I know it very well. I’ll be immensely grateful if you let me meet your mother.’

‘She’ll be very happy to meet you! You are . . . ?’

‘I’m known as Bhagatram.’

The short introduction gradually stabilized and strengthened, and the bond was reinforced. In Shraddha’s eyes, Bhagatram was a deity, and Bhagatram thought of Shraddha as a goddess in human form.

5

A year passed. Bhagatram went to see his goddess every day. Both talked for hours. Whenever Shraddha delivered a lecture, Bhagatram dropped everything to go and listen to her. Their aspirations were one, life ideals identical, interests similar, and thoughts the same. When they were together, Bhagatram poignantly analysed love and its mysteries. There had never been such a combination of sentiment and ornamentation in his speech. He had achieved expertise in denoting emotions. But exactly at those junctures when Shraddha felt new stirrings in her heart, her cheeks reddening with

rapture, Bhagatram would change the subject and disappear from the scene under some pretence. After he left, Shraddha would shed tears of longing and wonder, *Doesn't he love me?*

One day Kokila called Bhagatram aside. 'Beta! It'd be good if *munni* is married to you. Life is unpredictable. What if I die? This desire would remain unfulfilled in my heart.'

Bhagatram shook his head. 'Amma, let me clear this exam first. Marriage is apt only when the issue of livelihood is settled.'

'All this is yours! Will I tie it all up and take it along when I die?'

'It's your generosity, Ammaji, but don't think me so shameless. I'm committed to you: I can't turn away from this gate even if you reject me. Who's as fortunate as me in the whole world? Yet, an offering of betel and flowers needs to be arranged for before entering the temple of the goddess.'

Another year passed by. Bhagatram got his MA degree and joined his own school as an economics teacher. That day, Kokila gave away a lot of money to charity. When Bhagatram came and bowed his head at her feet, she pulled him into an embrace. She believed that Bhagatram would definitely raise the question of marriage today. Shraddha had become a statue of waiting. It was as if every part of her being was resonating like a hundred strings. Her heart was intoxicated, and her feet would not touch the ground. Seeing Bhagatram, she said to her mother, 'Amma, please buy us a small car.'

Kokila smiled. 'Why small? You could get a big one. But first decide upon a nice house.'

Shraddha took Bhagatram to her room. Both had already planned the decoration of the new house. Curtains, flooring, paintings—arrangements were made for all this.

Shraddha suggested, 'We'll take the money from Ammaji.'

Bhagatram replied, 'I feel embarrassed about taking money from her.'

Shraddha smiled. 'But she has to give us my dowry money!'

They talked for an hour. But the word that Shraddha's heart had been longing to hear did not come out of Bhagatram's mouth and he said goodbye.

After he left, Kokila asked fearfully: ‘What did you two discuss today?’

Shraddha understood. ‘If I’m such a burden, why not throw me into a well?’

But as she said this, the wall of her patience gave way. The pain that she had kept tightly suppressed flowed out. She broke into heart-rending tears.

Kokila was peeved. ‘When there is nothing to be discussed, why does he come every day? He neither hails from an exalted lineage, nor is he a fat cat.’

Shraddha wiped her tears. ‘Ammaji, don’t say anything about him in front of me. I’m aware of what is in his heart. He may not say it in so many words, but his heart has spoken. And I may not have heard anything, but my heart has heard it all.’

Kokila did not say anything to Shraddha, but the next day she said to Bhagatram, ‘Now what are you thinking, beta?’

Bhagatram scratched his head. ‘Ammaji, I’m ready, but my parents are not agreeing. If I get some respite, I’ll go home and convince them. It’s not good to offend one’s parents.’

Kokila could not muster a reply.

6

Bhagatram’s parents lived far from the town. He was their only son. All their aspirations were hooked on his marriage. They had fixed his marriage many times, but Bhagatram refused each time, saying that he would not marry till he found work. Now that he had found employment, both his parents arrived with bag and baggage at Bhagatram’s house on a chilly morning in the month of Maagh. Bhagatram ran to them, touched their feet and asked about their well-being. ‘Why did you take the trouble of coming all the way here in this cold? You could’ve called me over.’

Chowdhary looked at his wife. ‘Did you hear that, *bachcha ki amma*? When we call him, he says he has exams, there’s this and there’s that. Now that we’ve come, he says why didn’t you call me? Your marriage has been

fixed. Now you'll have to take leave for a month and accompany us. That's why both of us have come together.'

Chowdhrain commented, 'We thought it won't work till we come. So you should put in an application today itself. The girl is very beautiful, educated, and hails from a good clan.'

Bhagatram flushed. 'My wedding has been fixed here itself. If you give your consent, I'll go ahead.'

Chowdhary asked, 'Who of our caste resides in this town, eh, bachcha ki amma?'

Chowdhrain replied, 'There's no one here from our community.'

Bhagatram said, 'It's just a mother and daughter. There's money. The girl is so good that you'll be glad. The marriage will happen free of cost.'

Chowdhary asked, 'Has the girl's father died? What was his name? Where's his home town? What's his clan? Until all these matters are known, how can the wedding happen! Eh, bachcha ki amma?'

Chowdhrain agreed, 'Yes, without finding out all this, how can it happen?'

Bhagatram did not reply.

Chowdhary continued, 'Which locality do they live in? The entire town has been screened by us, we have stayed here for twenty-odd years, eh, bachcha ki amma?'

Chowdhrain added, 'We've lived here for more than twenty years.'

Bhagatram said, 'Their house is at the *nakhaas*.'

Chowdhary asked, 'Towards which direction from the nakhaas?'

Bhagatram replied, 'In the lane in front of the nakhaas, the first house is theirs. It's visible from the street.'

Chowdhary asked again, 'The first house is Kokila prostitute's. Isn't it painted in pink?'

Bhagatram replied sheepishly, 'Yes, that's the house.'

'So, isn't Kokila prostitute living there?' Chowdhary inquired.

Bhagatram replied, 'Yes. Both mother and daughter live there.'

Chowdhary exclaimed, 'So you wish to marry the daughter of Kokila prostitute? Are you bent on bringing us disgrace? No one in the community

will ever accept this.'

Chowdhrain retorted angrily, 'I'll douse the face of the whore in flames! Did you get tempted by her beauty?'

Bhagatram answered, 'I consider it my good fortune that she's ready to wed her daughter to me. If she wants, she can marry her off to one of the wealthiest houses.'

Chowdhary reacted, 'The wealthy will not marry her. They'll only keep her. If God grants you the capacity, you can keep four instead of one. What stops men! But in the matter of matrimony, only a marriage within the community is considered valid.'

Chowdhrain wailed, 'A man becomes crazy if he studies too much.'

Chowdhary responded, 'We're mere rustics, but we can't understand how *you* can harbour such intentions? The daughter of a whore will remain the daughter of a whore, even if she's a nymph from paradise. We'll not let your marriage be formalized there. If you still marry, both of us will kill ourselves. Understand this well—eh, bachcha ki amma?'

Chowdhrain howled, '"I'll marry!", as if it is a laughing matter! I'll thrash the whore with a broom! She can keep her daughter to herself.'

Bhagatram replied, somewhat chastised, 'I will not marry her against your wishes, but I will also not marry any other woman.'

Chowdhrain approved, 'Yes, your remaining a bachelor is acceptable to us. But we will not marry you into a concubine's house.'

Now Bhagatram was agitated. 'Why do you call her a concubine over and over again? It might have been her profession once upon a time, but today, it is unlikely that anyone else lives with the beliefs and decorum that she abides by. I haven't seen anyone with such pure conduct.'

Bhagatram's efforts were in vain. Chowdhrain held on to her stand with such obstinacy that she did not waver an inch.

At night when Bhagatram reached his temple of love, his face was long. Hopelessness dripped from every part of his being. Shraddha had had been looking out for him, worried that he had not turned up yet. She thought, *He wouldn't know the condition of my heart. Once he gets leave from his friends, perhaps he'll accidentally venture here.*

Kokila said, ‘I’ve already told you that he is no longer the same. But still you won’t listen. After all, there has to be a limit to this indecision.’

Shraddha was upset. ‘Ammaji, I’ve told you a thousand times that though I remain formally unmarried in the eyes of society, at heart I am his wedded wife. If such a man is not worthy of trust, I don’t know who can be trusted.’

At that instant, Bhagatram entered the room like a statue of disappointment. Both the women looked at him. Kokila’s eyes harboured reproach, while Shraddha’s eyes reflected agony. While Kokila’s eyes complained—*What are these manners?* Shraddha’s eyes were pained—*Such cruelty!*

Bhagatram said in a low, anguished tone. ‘You had to wait for me for too long today, but I was helpless. Amma and Dada have arrived from home, I was talking to them.’

Kokila inquired, ‘Is everything fine at home?’

Bhagatram hung his head. ‘Yes, everything is fine. The matter of my marriage was discussed. They’re old-fashioned. They are refusing to agree to this match.’

Kokila’s face flushed with anger. ‘Right, why would they agree? We’re worse off than them, but since you were a slave to their wishes, you should’ve asked for their permission before visiting us. What have you gained by insulting us? If I’d known that you were a slave to your parents’ wishes, things wouldn’t have reached such a state.’

Shraddha saw tears streaming from Bhagatram’s eyes. She said gently, ‘Ammaji, it is not a sin to be a slave to one’s parents’ wishes. Wouldn’t you feel hurt if I neglected you? Those people must also be in a similar condition.’

Shraddha walked towards her room and gestured Bhagatram to follow. While in the room, the two kept staring at the ground for a long time. Neither had the courage to break the silence. In the end, Bhagatram mustered some courage befitting a man and said, ‘Shraddha, a tumultuous war is going on in my mind right now. I can’t explain my condition in words. I feel like poisoning myself. I can’t live without you. I can only writhe painfully. I tried my best to convince them, even cried and pleaded

with them, but both of them stuck to their guns. They kept repeating that if this marriage were to take place, they would kill themselves. They can accept my death, but they cannot accept you becoming the queen of my heart.'

Shraddha said consolingly, 'My dear, it is understandable that they are disgusted by me. Many such people will be found even in the educated class. They are not at fault. I'll go meet them in the morning. Seeing me might melt their heart. I'll serve them in every possible way: will wash their dhotis, press their feet. I'll do all that their desirable daughter-in-law would do. What is there to be ashamed of? I'll caress the soles of their feet, sing them devotional songs—and I also know a lot of folk songs. I'll pluck the grey hair from your mother's head. I don't want compassion, I'm the devotee of love. I'll do everything for you—everything.'

Bhagatram felt as if the light of his eyes had been turned up, or as if a different luminous soul had entered his body. His heart was overflowing with devotion for Shraddha. He experienced the same delight as one does when one witnesses small, red-cheeked, silken-clothed, curly-haired, smiling children coming out of their house to play.

7

Two weeks had passed since Chowdhary and Chowdhrain had come to the town. Every day they resolved to return, but ended up staying back. Shraddha would not let them go. In the morning, when they woke up, Shraddha was found warming the water for their bath, and Chowdhary found his hookah filled up. As soon as they finished their bath, Shraddha began to wash their dhotis and hung them up for drying. Both were astonished to see her service and continuous hard work. Chowdhary had not seen such a beautiful, soft-spoken, cheerful and delightful woman, even at the house of inspector sahib. She appeared to be a goddess to Chowdhary, and Chowdhrain found her to be the goddess of prosperity herself. Both expressed their amazement at Shraddha's service, dedication and love, but despite all this, the fear of disgrace and the question of their community

hindered their consent. On the fifteenth day, once Shraddha returned home at ten in the night, Chowdhary said to Chowdhrain, ‘The girl is Lakshmi incarnate.’

Chowdhrain said, ‘When she begins washing my dhoti, I’m torn asunder with shame. People of our station must be serving her as her maids.’

‘So what do you suggest? Such a talented girl won’t be found in our community.’

‘Let’s wed them in the name of God. We can just organize a wedding feast. The feast can be managed in five and twenty, we need not spend too much! At first we had doubts about how the whore’s daughter would turn out to be. Now all our doubts have been wiped out.’

‘When she talks, it seems as if flowers fall from her mouth.’

‘I want to sing praises of her mother, from whose womb such a Lakshmi has taken birth.’

‘Let’s go tomorrow and meet Kokila to settle everything.’

‘I feel ashamed to go to her house. She’d be sitting there like a queen, and I’d look like her maidservant.’

‘So get some talc and dab it on your face—you will grow fair. Even the inspector sahib’s wife used to apply talc every day. Her complexion was dusky, but when she applied the talc, her face glowed.’

‘Poke fun at me and I will curse you back, all right? Does dark skin take up any colour? How would the powder stick? *You* would look like her watchman.’

‘So let’s go tomorrow before dawn. Once Shraddha comes, she won’t let us go. We’ll ask the boy to consult the pandit for auspicious dates.’ Then he laughed. ‘I am sure they are in a great hurry!’

Remembering their own days, Chowdhrain also started smiling.

8

Having secured the consent of Chowdhary and Chowdhrain, Kokila started preparations for the wedding. Clothes were ordered to be made. Shops of utensils began to be screened, and orders were sent out to the jewellers for

ornaments. But inexplicably, there was no sign of happiness on Bhagatram's face. He went to Shraddha's place as usual but he seemed depressed and somewhat lost. For hours, he would stare blankly at the sky or the earth in a state of stupor. Shraddha showed him her expensive clothes and elaborately set jewellery. Every part of her being was brimming with hope and desire. Under its intoxication, she was unable to spot the tears lurking in Bhagatram's eyes.

On the other side, Chowdhary was also making preparations. He went to the town often and bought various things for the wedding. Bhagatram's liberal-minded friends envied his luck. A woman as beautiful as a heavenly nymph, with unlimited wealth like Korah's treasure—whoever acquired both together? But Bhagatram, who was the reason for his friends' envy, Kokila's happiness, Chowdhary–Chowdhrain's delight and the object of Shraddha's desire, would cry in secret and was upset with his life. Darkness had spread beneath the lamp. No one was aware of this lurking storm which was causing an uproar in his heart.

As the day of the wedding drew closer, Bhagatram's fake enthusiasm also cooled down. When four days remained, he came down with a light fever. He could not go to Shraddha's house any more. Chowdhary and Chowdhrain and other members of the community had come over, but all of them were so engrossed in the preparations that they did not spare him any attention.

The next day too, he was unable to venture out of the house. Shraddha thought that perhaps he was busy with the wedding rituals. The third day, when Chowdhrain went to call Bhagatram, she found him looking at one corner of the room with fearful, gaping eyes, his hands stretched forward. He was moving backwards as if protecting himself from someone's attack. Anxious, Chowdhrain asked, 'Boy, how is your health? Why are you moving back? There is no one here.'

There was a manic senselessness on Bhagatram's face. Fear loomed large in his eyes. He spoke in a petrified voice, 'No, Ammaji, look, Shraddha is approaching me! See, she has two black cobras in both her hands. She wants me to be bitten by those cobras! O Amma! She has come closer.

Shraddha? Shraddha! Why've you become an enemy of my life? Is this the reward of my infinite love? I was always prepared to sacrifice myself at your feet. What worth is this life? Throw away these cobras. I'll sacrifice this life for you, lying at your feet . . . Eh, eh, you'll not listen?'

And he fell. Chowdhrain sprang and called Chowdhary. Both of them picked up Bhagatram and laid him on the charpoy. Chowdhary's attention was drawn towards the possibility of an evil spirit. He immediately fetched cloves and ash, and arranged for the removal of the spirit! He himself was an expert at spells and chants. Bhagatram's entire body was cold, but his head was heating up like a frying pan.

At night Bhagatram woke up suddenly many times, and each time Chowdhary chanted the mantras, and thought that he had managed to shoo away the evil spirit.

Chowdhrain grew anxious. 'Why don't you call a doctor? Maybe medicines would help. The wedding is tomorrow, and he's in such a critical state today.'

Chowdhary replied with absolute certainty, 'What will the doctor do? This has been brought on by the spirit of that Peepul Baba. Using medicines will only escalate the row with him. Let the night pass. At dawn, an offering of a goat and a bottle of liquor will be made to him. That's all, nothing else needs to be done. A doctor can treat an illness, not winds and spirits. He doesn't have any disease, it is just that the gods are displeased because he's marrying outside the community.'

In the morning, Chowdhary ordered for a goat. Singing and playing instruments, a group of women moved towards the shrine of the goddess. When they returned, they saw that Bhagatram's condition was worse. His pulse was fading gradually. His face bore the stamp of the horror of death. Tears streamed from his eyes, rolling down his cheeks, as if conveying the final message of unfulfilled longing to the cruel world. It was such a painful spectacle of life—summed up in two teardrops!

Now Chowdhary panicked and immediately informed Kokila. A man was sent to fetch the doctor.

There was still some time left for the doctor, who was one of Bhagatram's friends, to arrive. Meanwhile, Kokila and Shraddha arrived. Shraddha stood in front of Bhagatram. Tears flowed from her eyes.

In a while Bhagatram opened his eyes and looked at Shraddha—'You've come, Shraddha, I was waiting for you. Accept this final love. Today, the balance sheet that had begun three years ago will be cleared. In these three years, only my heart knows what internal strife I've faced. You're a goddess of fidelity but I was plagued by a delusion over and again—whether you'd be able to destroy the effect of your blood. Will you be able to leave the convention of your lineage? Will you be able to break the natural principles of birth? Don't grieve for these deluded thoughts. I wasn't worthy of you in any way, and I could never become as magnanimous as you. Yes, by succumbing to this delusion, I depart from this world without fulfilling my desires. The memory of your profound, honest and flawless love will always remain with me. But alas, sadly . . .'

Bhagatram's eyes closed once again as he spoke. A deep red streak passed over Shraddha's face. Her tears dried up. Her drooping neck straightened. Furrows appeared on her brow; her eyes reflected her self-esteem. She stood there for a moment, and in the next instant was back in her car. Kokila came running after her and said, 'Beti, this is not the time to be angry. What'll the people think? His condition is worsening by the minute! Your presence will console the old ones.'

Shraddha did not reply. She instructed the driver, 'Let's go home.' Kokila too finished what she had to say and sat in the car.

An unbearable chill descended. Dark clouds floated in the sky. A cold wind blew. These were the final days of the month of Maagh. Trees, plants and shrubs were all shrunken from the winter. It was eight in the morning and even now people had their faces tucked inside their quilts. But Shraddha's body was drenched in sweat. It appeared as if the entire heat of the sun had penetrated the veins of her body. Her lips went dry not because of thirst, but due to the flames of the blazing fire inside. Every part of her being was scorched by the enormous heat of the fire. Burning, hot breath issued repeatedly from her mouth, like the flames emanating from a *chulha*.

By the time she reached home, her flower-like face had turned pale, lips turned yellow, as if a black cobra had bitten her. Kokila gazed at her with teary eyes but what could she say and how could she make Shraddha understand? Once home, Shraddha went towards her room upstairs, but she did not have the strength to climb up. Grabbing the railing tightly, she somehow reached her room. Alas, just half an hour ago, every item of this room had been stamped with happiness, jubilation and desires, but now everything appeared to the contrary. Looking at the wedding finery displayed in big trunks, a wrenching pang shot through Shraddha's heart, and she fell down, the way a playful deer falls on being shot by an arrow.

Suddenly her eyes fell upon the photograph which had been the basis of her life for the past three years. How many times had she kissed that photograph, embraced it and held it close to her heart. All these things were coming to her mind one by one, but now it was pointless to remember them.

Her heart ached in a far more deadly and frightening way. Alas! She had caused so much suffering to the dying man. Her strong retort to Bhagatram's pitiful disbelief was so affecting and heart-rending. Alas! How had she become so ruthless! Her beloved was dying in front of her eyes! But not one word had issued from her mouth for his sake or for consoling him! She thought, this must be the effect of blood—if not that, what else? Today, for the first time, Shraddha repented being Kokila's daughter. It was only today that she realized how self-absorbed and heartless she was. The sacrifice, the spirit of service, and those higher ideals on which she prided herself, crumbled in front of Shraddha; she found herself debased in her own eyes. Who but a prostitute's daughter could have offered such a hopeless answer to that heavenly love!

Shraddha came out of the room immediately, descended the stairs with great speed and ran towards Bhagatram's house. She wanted to embrace him one last time, to see him one final time. She decided she would hold on to the difficult bond of eternal love and, till the last breath, live on as only his!

No transport was available on the way. Shraddha was getting exhausted. She was drenched in sweat from head to toe. She got hit and fell down a

number of times, but she got up again and started running! Blood oozed out of her knees, her sari got torn in many places, but at that time, she wasn't even aware of her body. Every pore of her body seemed to have a thousand throats and prayed to God for the light of that morning lamp to sustain a little longer. Her soul was desperate to hear the word 'Shraddha' from Bhagatram's mouth. Having heard just that word, no desire of hers would remain unfulfilled; all her hopes would be successful and her ambitions complete.

As soon as she saw Shraddha, Chowdhrain caught hold of her hand and said weeping, 'Beti, where had you gone? He has called out your name twice.'

Shraddha felt as though her heart was being torn asunder. Her eyes turned stony. She felt as if she had fallen into the whirlpool of a bottomless and vast sea. Entering the room, she placed her head on Bhagatram's cold feet and tried to warm them up by washing them with the warm tears from her eyes. This was the tomb of all her desires and aspirations.

Bhagatram opened his eyes. 'Is that you, Shraddha? I knew that you'd come, that's why life has lingered till now. Place your head on my heart for a while. Yes, I now believe that you've forgiven me. My heart is sinking. I want to ask you something, but by what right? I couldn't ask you while I was hale and hearty, so what can I say now?'

Our final moments contain some secreted unfulfilled desires. Death first destroys our envy, discrimination and hostility. We become restless for the same old affection and friendship, and we want to embrace those very faces that have aroused our disgust in the past. Whatever we could have done, and whatever we couldn't do—its expectation remains. In a mournful voice, Bhagatram professed his love for Shraddha again. He could have been happy after acquiring this heavenly treasure, he could have put it to use, but alas, today he was departing from the world carrying memories of unfulfilled desires! Alas, the unfortunate yearning!

Shraddha was weeping with her head bent towards Bhagatram's chest. Bhagatram lifted his head and kissed her withering, unsoiled cheeks awash with tears: this was the ultimate laughter of the dying desire.

Bhagatram said, his voice choked with tears, ‘This is our marriage, Shraddha—this is my last gift.’ And his eyes closed forever! The yearning also died and fell over.

Shraddha’s eyes turned red from the incessant weeping. She felt that Bhagatram was standing there, smiling and ready to hold her in a lovers’ embrace. She forgot everything; her state, time and location. An injured soldier forgets his pain at the news of his victory. For a moment, death too becomes trivial. The same happened to Shraddha. She too became ready to give up her life on the cruel altar of love, where Laila and Majnoo, Shireen and Farhad—and thousands before had sacrificed themselves.

Replying to the kiss, she said, ‘My beloved, I’m yours, and shall always remain yours.’

Translated from the Hindi by Kalyanee Rajan



Resignation

1

An office clerk is a mute creature. If you show your temper to daily-wage workers, they will talk back and challenge you. If you are rude to a porter, he will dump your baggage somewhere and walk away. You reprimand a beggar, he will give you an ugly look and turn away from you. Even a donkey, when in trouble, starts kicking the people nearby. But show your temper to an office clerk, reprimand or chastise him, and he will not show the slightest annoyance. Even an ascetic may not have the kind of control the office clerk has over his baser passions. He is the very embodiment of contentment and patience, truly obedient; in short, he has all the good human qualities. They say that even desolate ruins can come back to life. During Diwali, the light falls on them too; during the rains they are covered in green. The ruins have a share in nature's renewal. But the fate of the poor clerk never smiles. No silver lining ever redeems his dark destiny. His pale face is never lit up with a smile. For him, the month of Saavan is rainless and the month of Bhadon is without any vegetation. Lala Fatehchand was such a mute creature.

It is said that a person's name has some impact on his destiny. This wasn't true in the case of Fatehchand. If he was named Haarchand[1] that would have been more appropriate. He was a loser in all areas of life—in

the office, at home, among friends. He had to face disappointment in every sphere of life. He didn't have a son, though he had three daughters; he didn't have a brother but two sisters-in-law, he didn't have a penny in his hand but his heart was full of kindness and munificence. He didn't have a true friend; he had developed friendships with some, but they betrayed him. On top of it, he wasn't healthy—at the age of thirty-two his hair had turned all salt and pepper. His eyesight was weak, his digestion feeble, his face pale, cheeks shrunken and back bent. He had no energy in his body and no courage in his mind. He went to his office at nine in the morning and returned at six in the evening. He didn't have the energy left to go out anywhere after that. He had no idea about what was happening in the world. His entire world and the hereafter were limited to the four walls of his office. He thanked God for the job and simply passed the days of his life. He didn't have any attachment to his religion or any other faith. He had no interest in games or any other means of entertainment. An age had passed since he had last played cards.

2

It was winter. There were a few clouds floating in the sky. When Fatehchand returned home at five, the lamps were already lit. He was not in the habit of talking to anyone when he returned from office. He just threw himself on the cot and stayed there for fifteen to twenty minutes absolutely still, without moving his limbs. Only then would he find the energy to talk to anyone. Today he was in a similar state when someone called him. His younger daughter went out to see who it was. It was the office attendant. Sharda, his wife, was ready with the tumbler for him to wash his face and hands. She said, 'Ask him what it is about. He has just returned from the office, why is he being called again?'

The attendant said, 'The sahib asked me to call him immediately. There's some urgent work.'

Fatehchand broke his silence. He craned his neck and asked, 'What is it?'

Sharda replied, 'Nothing. The attendant from the office is here.'

Fatehchand said in a subdued tone, ‘The office attendant! Has sahib called for me?’

‘Yes, he says that the sahib is calling you. What kind of a boss do you have? He keeps calling you at all hours. You went to the office early in the morning and have just returned, and he’s calling you again.’

Fatehchand said solemnly, ‘I’ll have to find out why he has called. I’ve completed all the work. Let me go and see.’

‘Take some snacks before going. If you start talking with the attendant, you will forget about your food.’

She brought him some snacks. Fatehchand had got up, but seeing the snacks, sat down again on the cot. Looking at the teacup longingly, he said, ‘Have you given some to the girls?’

Sharda frowned and said, ‘Yes. Don’t bother about them. You take some.’

In the meantime their youngest daughter had appeared in the room. Sharda glared at her and said, ‘Why have you come down here now? Go and play outside.’

Fatehchand said, ‘Let her be, why are you scolding her? Come here, Chunni, take some snacks.’

Chunni looked at the angry eyes of her mother and slunk away.

Fatehchand said, ‘Why did you shoo her away? You could have given her a morsel and she would’ve been happy.’

‘It’s such a small amount as it is. If you’d given her some, the other two would have appeared. There’s just not enough for everybody.’

Meanwhile the attendant was getting impatient. ‘Babuji, I’m getting late.’

Sharda suggested, ‘Why don’t you tell him that you can’t go now?’

‘How can I say that? It’s a question of our livelihood.’

‘Then will you give your life for the job? Take a look at your face—it looks like you’ve been sick for six months.’

Fatehchand quickly took two or three bites of the food, drank a glass of water and rushed out. Sharda was still making paan for her husband.

The attendant said, ‘Babuji, you’ve delayed me. Now let’s speed up, or we’ll both be reprimanded.’

Fatehchand took two rapid steps and said, ‘Well, I can walk only as normal people do, never mind if we’re reprimanded. I can’t run. Is he in his bungalow?’

‘Of course. Will he come to the office now? Isn’t he the king?’

The attendant was accustomed to walking fast. The poor clerk Fatehchand walked slowly. He lost his breath after walking for a while but he was a man, after all! How could he appeal to the attendant to walk slowly? He gathered all his energy and walked with him, but his thighs began to ache. Then his legs gave way before half the distance was covered. His whole body was bathed in sweat. His head began to spin. Butterflies began to fly before his eyes.

The attendant goaded him. ‘Hurry up, Babuji.’

Fatehchand said feebly, ‘You go ahead, I’m coming.’

He sat on the parapet flanking the road and held his head in his hands, panting heavily. When the attendant saw him in this condition, he moved forward. Fatehchand was scared that if this devil went to the sahib and reported against him, all hell would break loose. He somehow stood up and began to walk. But he was panting heavily because of weakness. At that moment even a child could have thrown him to the ground. With great difficulty, he finally reached the sahib’s bungalow. The sahib was pacing up and down. His gaze was fixed on the gate, and he was getting more and more annoyed. When he saw the attendant, his eyes almost bulged out in anger as he said, ‘Where have you been all this while?’

The attendant stood on the steps of the veranda and said, ‘My lord, he’s taking a long time to come. I have rushed back.’

The sahib stamped his foot and said, ‘What did the babu say?’

‘He’s coming, my lord. It’s been about an hour since he left his house.’

Meanwhile Fatehchand entered the compound, came up to the sahib and saluted him, lowering his head.

The sahib said sternly, ‘Where have you been all this while?’ When Fatehchand saw the sahib in such an angry state, his blood froze. He said, ‘My lord, just a while ago I had left office to go home. As soon as the attendant came to my house, I rushed here.’

‘You’re lying. You’re a liar. I’ve been standing here for an hour.’

‘My lord, I don’t tell lies. I may have taken some time reaching here. But I started from home as soon as I got your message.’

The sahib rolled his stick in his hand. ‘Shut up, you swine. I’ve been standing here for an hour. Grab both your ears and twist them.’

Swallowing the insult, Fatehchand said, ‘Huzoor, I have been working here for ten years. Never—’

‘Shut up. I order you to twist your ears.’

‘What is my fault?’

Sahib ordered the attendant, ‘Chaprasi, pull his ears.’

The attendant said softly, ‘Huzoor, he’s my superior. How can I pull his ears?’

Sahib thundered, ‘I order you to pull his ears, or I’ll beat you with a baton.’

‘Huzoor, I’ve come here to work, not to be beaten. I’m a man of honour. Keep your job to yourself. I’m ready to carry out any of your orders, but I can’t destroy someone’s honour. My job is only going to last for a few years. Why should I spoil my life for it?’

The sahib couldn’t control his anger any more. He picked up his baton and rushed towards the attendant. The attendant saw that standing there wasn’t safe and took to his heels. Fatehchand was still standing there silently. Failing to catch the attendant, the sahib came up to Fatehchand and pulled both his ears. He said, ‘You swine, you dare to disobey me? Go and bring the file from the office.’ Fatehchand stroked his ears and said, ‘Which file?’

‘Are you deaf? Don’t you hear what I’m saying? I’m asking for the file.’

Fatehchand said courageously, ‘Which file are you asking for?’

‘The file that I want—bring me that file this moment.’

Poor Fatehchand had no courage left to ask the sahib anything more. This sahib bahadur was short-tempered, had the arrogance of the ruling race and on top of it he was drunk. He could have pounced on him with his baton. Fatehchand walked towards his office silently.

The sahib hollered, ‘Run, and run quickly.’

Fatehchand replied, ‘Huzoor, I can’t run.’

Sahib: ‘Oh, you lazy bum, I’ll teach you how to run. Run! (Pushing him) Can’t you run even now?’

The sahib went back to bring the baton. In spite of being an office clerk Fatehchand was a human being. If he had been strong, he would have drunk the blood of that scoundrel. If he had a weapon, he would have used it against him. But his destiny dictated that he should be beaten. He ran for his life and came out of the compound on the road.

3

Fatehchand didn’t go to the office. There was no point in going there, because the sahib didn’t say which specific file he wanted. He was probably too drunk to remember it. Fatehchand walked slowly to his home, but the humiliation he had faced seemed like shackles on his legs. Granted that he was no match for the sahib in physical strength and he had no weapon in his hand, but couldn’t he have replied to his insulting words? He had shoes on his feet. Couldn’t he have used them? Then why had he put up with such humiliation?

But what was the remedy? If the sahib had shot him out of anger, no one could have done anything. He would probably have been sentenced to simple imprisonment for one or two months. It was possible that he could have been fined a couple of hundred rupees. But Fatehchand’s own family would have been ruined. Who was there in the world to look after his wife and children? Where could they have gone to seek help? If he had enough money to look after his close ones, he would not have put up with such humiliation today. Either he would have died or taught a lesson to this scoundrel. He had no fear for his own life. He did not crave any comfort that would make him compromise his honour. The only thought that restrained him was the ruin of his family.

Fatehchand had never regretted his own physical weakness as he did today. If he had looked after his health, if he had done some physical exercise or practised some manoeuvres of stick fighting, then this scoundrel

would not have had the audacity to pull his ears. He would have gouged out his eyes. At least he should have taken a knife with him. He could have used it when the sahib tried to humiliate him. What would have happened, after all? He didn't care if he had to go to jail or undergo some other punishment.

As he stepped forward, he felt more self-reproach at his own weakness and cowardice. What would have happened if he had leapt at the sahib and given him a couple of tight slaps? Probably the sahib's servants would have pounced on him and beaten him unconscious. Maybe his own children would have suffered. But the sahib would have realized that it was not easy to humiliate an innocent, ordinary person. *If I die today, what will happen? Who will look after my children? They would suffer the same fate as what would have happened if I had taken a stand*.

This last thought filled his mind with such emotion that he turned back, intending to take his revenge. But after a couple of steps he realized that the humiliation he'd suffered had already taken place. And who knew whether the sahib was still in his bungalow or had gone to the club. At that moment he also thought about Sharda's helplessness and the plight of his children if they became orphans. He turned back again and walked towards his home.

4

As he stepped into the house, Sharda asked him, 'Why did he call you? You've taken a long time.' Fatehchand threw himself on the cot and replied, 'He was dead drunk, what else? The scoundrel called me names and humiliated me. He was going on and on about why I got late reaching his bungalow. The tyrant asked the attendant to pull my ears.'

Sharda was furious. 'Why didn't you hit the swine with your shoes?'

'The attendant is a gentleman. He said clearly that he couldn't do it. He also said that he didn't do his job for humiliating honourable people. And he left the place.'

'This is what is called courage. Why didn't you beat up the sahib?'

‘Yes indeed, I did beat him up. He chased me with a stick and I hit him with my shoes. He hit me a couple of times and I also did the same.’

Sharda was happy. ‘Really? He must have been very shaken, like a wet cat.’

‘He was looking totally washed out.’

‘Serves him right. You should’ve beaten him even more. If I were in your place, I wouldn’t have left him alive.’

‘Well, I’ve beaten him all right, but it’s a serious matter. Wait and see the consequences we have to face. I’ll lose my job; maybe there’ll be other punishment too.’

‘Why should you be punished? Is there no justice in the world? Why did he abuse you? Why did he hit you with the stick?’

‘Who will listen to my complaint against him? The court will also side with him.’

‘Let it be. But you’ll see that from now onwards no sahib will ever dare abuse his clerks. The moment he uttered the abuse you should’ve hit him with your shoes.’

‘If I had done that, I wouldn’t have been able to return alive. He would’ve definitely shot me dead.’

‘I don’t care.’

Fatehchand smiled and asked, ‘What would you have done then?’

‘We would have done whatever God had ordained. For a man the most valuable thing in life is his honour. He cannot lose his honour even for the sake of his children. If you had returned after killing that devil, I would have celebrated it with great pride. If you had returned beaten by him, I would’ve probably hated seeing your face. Maybe I wouldn’t have said anything to your face but I would have lost all regard for you in my mind. I’ll put up with whatever comes my way . . . Ay listen to me, where are you going?’

Fatehchand got out of his house like a man possessed. Sharda was calling after him. He was walking in the direction of the sahib’s bungalow. He didn’t look scared but went with his head held high. His face indicated his strong determination. His legs no longer felt weak, his eyes did not indicate

helplessness. He had been transformed. In the place of the office clerk with the feeble body and the pale mien he now looked a young man full of courage and valour. First he went to a friend's house to collect a stick and then he reached the sahib's bungalow.

It was going to be nine. The sahib was at the dinner table. But Fatehchand didn't wait for him to get up from the table. As his servant came out of the room, Fatehchand lifted the bamboo curtain and went in. The room was bathed in light. A soft carpet was on the floor. The sahib looked at him angrily and said, 'Why have you come again? Get out. How did you come inside?'

Fatehchand stood there with his stick and said, 'I've brought the file that you asked for. I'll show it to you when you finish your meal. I'll sit here till then. Eat well because it might be your last dinner. Eat to your heart's content.'

The sahib was stunned. He looked at Fatehchand in fear and anger. There was no mistaking Fatehchand's intention. The sahib realized that the fellow had come here ready to kill him or die himself. Fatehchand could not match him in strength. But he was sure that Fatehchand would use the iron stick. If he called him names, Fatehchand could pounce on him with his stick. In a hand-to-hand fight he was sure to win, but it was not a good prospect to be beaten with a stick. You can beat a dog with a stick as long as it doesn't growl. But once its patience runs out and it leaps at the attacker, no one can stop it. The sahib bahadur was in the same state now. As long as Fatehchand was ready to bear with his abuse, blows and kicks silently, the sahib was like a lion. Now Fatehchand had changed his attitude and was armed with a stick, waiting for an opportunity to strike. If the sahib uttered one harsh word, he would use his stick. All he could do was dismiss him from service. If he struck him now, he was in danger of being beaten. And then there would be a criminal case to fight. Granted that he had the power to eventually send Fatehchand to prison, but there was no way he could save himself from worry and infamy. Like an intelligent and far-sighted man, he said, 'I see, you are perhaps angry with me about something. Did I say anything objectionable? Why are you offended?'

Fatehchand straightened up and said, ‘Just half an hour ago, you had pulled my ears and uttered hundreds of abuses. Have you forgotten it so soon?’

‘I pulled your ears, ha ha ha! You mean *I* pulled your ears, ha ha ha! Is it a joke? Am I crazy, or do you take me for a madman?’

‘Then am I lying? The attendant is a witness to the incident. Your servants too have seen it.’

‘When did it happen?’

‘Just a while ago. Just half an hour earlier. You’d sent for me, and without any reason you pulled my ears and pushed me around.’

‘Oh Babuji, I was drunk. The bearer had given me a lot to drink. I’ve no idea what happened. I swear by God, I’ve no idea at all.’

‘If you had shot me when you were drunk, wouldn’t I have died? If you were drunk and if everything can be done with impunity in such a condition, then I’m drunk now. Now listen to me—either you pull your own ears swearing that you will never treat a gentleman in the same way, or I’ll come forward and pull your ears. Do you understand? Don’t move from your place. If you make the slightest movement, I’ll hit you with the stick. Then it won’t be my fault if your brain bursts open. Just do as I say, grab your ears.’

The sahib put on a fake smile and said, ‘Well, Babuji, you’re an interesting person. If I have said anything wrong, I apologize.’

Fatehchand raised his stick and growled, ‘Oh no, hold your ears.’

It was difficult for the sahib to bear such humiliation. He leapt from his place and tried to grab Fatehchand’s stick, but Fatehchand was alert. Before the sahib could rise, Fatehchand struck him with all his might. The bare head of the sahib took the full impact of the stick. His head was spinning. He held his head for a minute and then said, ‘I’ll dismiss you from your service.’

‘I don’t care. Today I won’t leave this place without making you pull your ears. You grab your ears and promise that you will never be disrespectful to a gentleman. If you don’t agree, be prepared for my second strike.’

Saying this, Fatehchand raised his stick again. The sahib, who was still smarting from the first blow, feared that a second blow might break open his head. He placed his hands on his ears and said, ‘Are you happy now?’

‘Will you utter insults against anybody?’

‘Never.’

‘If you do it ever again, then remember that I’m not too far.’

‘Now I won’t curse anyone.’

‘Good. This is the end of my service today. Tomorrow I’ll send my resignation letter saying the reason that I don’t want to do the job under you is because you’ve abused me.’

‘Why are you resigning? I haven’t dismissed you.’

‘I will never work under a man like you again.’

And Fatehchand went out of the room and walked towards his house with a great sense of satisfaction. Today he felt truly triumphant. He had never felt such happiness before. This was the first victory of his life.

Translated from the Hindi by M. Asaduddin



Atonement

1

Coming a little late to the office is a matter of pride for the officers. The higher the officer, the later he comes and the sooner he leaves. The peon attends for all the twenty-four hours. He can't even go on leave. He has to provide his replacement. Anyhow, when Bareilly Zila Board's head clerk, Babu Madarilal, came to the office at eleven, it was as if the office woke up from slumber. The peon ran and took the cycle, the attendant lifted the blinds of the room, and the sweeper placed the day's share of the mail on the table. Madarilal had just opened the first official envelope when his face paled. He stood in a state of bewilderment for many minutes, as if all his cognitive faculties had gone numb. There had been many attacks upon him in the past, but never had he been so completely stupefied. The thing was the government had given the position of the secretary of the Board, which had been lying vacant for the past one month, to Subodhchandra, and Subodhchandra was someone whose very name disgusted Madarilal. Subodhchandra had been his classmate, whom he had tried to thwart many times but had never quite succeeded. The same Subodh was now returning as his superior. There had been no news of Subodh for many years. All anyone knew was that he had been drafted in the army. Madarilal thought that he might have died there by now, but today it was as if he had risen

from the dead and was returning as the secretary. Madarilal would have to work under him. It was far better to have died rather than face such an affront. Subodh would definitely remember all the incidents from school and college. Madarilal had employed all sorts of tactics to get him ousted from the college—falsely accused him, disgraced him. Would Subodh have forgotten it all? No, never. He would make up for the old losses as soon as he got here. Madari Babu was unable to think of a way to save his life.

Madari's and Subodh's stars themselves were in opposition. Both had been admitted to the same school on the same day and from the very first day, a spark of envy and hostility had been ignited, which had not been extinguished even after twenty years. Subodh's only crime was that he had been a notch above Madarilal in all respects—physique, complexion, deportment and conduct, education and intelligence. He had aced all of this. Madarilal had never forgiven him for this crime. Subodh was the thorn that had been continuously pricking his heart for the past twenty years. Once Subodh acquired his degree and returned home, and Madari failed the test, joining work at this place, his heart was somewhat placated. But when he came to know that Subodh was going to Basra, Madarilal's face had lit up. The old knot in his heart loosened. But alas, hard luck! The old sore had split open today with envy and was smarting a hundredfold. Today his fate was in Subodh's hands. God is so unjust! Destiny is so cruel!

Once his heart had calmed down, Madari read out the government order to the clerks of the office, 'Now all of you should tread cautiously. Subodhchandra is not one to forgive mistakes.'

A clerk asked, 'Is he very stern?'

Madarilal smiled. 'That you'll come to know within a couple of days. Why should I make negative remarks against anyone? Nonetheless, I have forewarned you that you should tread cautiously. The man is capable, but he is very quick-tempered and arrogant. He starts fuming at the drop of a hat. He might digest a thousand bucks himself without a trace, but a subordinate cannot dare to swallow even a penny. Only God can save one from such a man! I'm planning to take leave and go home. One would have to mark their attendance at his house at all times. Today onwards, you all are not

government servants but servants of the secretary. Someone would have to tutor his son, while someone would manage the deals and purchases from the market, and yet another would have to read him the newspaper. And the peons may not even be visible in the office!'

Thus, having provoked the entire office against Subodhchandra, Madarilal assuaged his heart.

2

After a week, when Subodhchandra got down from his train he found all the employees of the office waiting to welcome him at the station. As soon as he saw Madarilal, Subodh sprang forward, embraced him and said, 'Wonderful to meet you, Bhai! How come you're here? Oh! We're meeting after ages!'

Madarilal replied, 'I'm the head clerk at the Zila Board office here. Are you keeping well?'

Subodh replied, 'Oh, don't talk about me! I have wandered around Basra, France, Egypt and many other places. You are in this office, that's excellent. I had just not figured out how things would shape up. I am an ignorant simpleton, but my good fortune travels with me wherever I go. All the officials at Basra were pleased. The term at France was spent in great harmony. I earned about twenty-five thousand rupees in two years but blew up all of it. After returning, I kept wandering aimlessly at the cooperation office for a few days. Now that I've been posted here, I've found you. (Looking at the clerks) Who are these people?'

Spears seemed to pierce Madari's heart. The scoundrel had earned twenty-five thousand rupees from Basra! *Here we have died scratching our pens out and have not even accumulated five hundred rupees.* He said, 'These people are employees of the board. They have come to salute you.'

Subodh shook hands with each of them and said, 'All of you unnecessarily took the trouble of coming here. I am very grateful. I hope that you gentlemen will not find anything to complain about. Consider me your brother and not your officer. All of you should work together so that

the reputation of the board is heightened, and I should be at peace too. Your head clerk sahib is my old friend and playmate.'

A clever, sweet-tongued clerk said, 'We all are attendants of huzoor. We won't displease you as far as possible, but we too are all human, so even if something is amiss, we hope huzoor will forgive it.'

Subodh replied humbly, 'This is my principle and has been so throughout my life. Wherever I've gone, I've had a friendly rapport with my subordinates. Both you and I are servants of a third higher-up, so I don't believe in airs and officialdom. But yes, we should discharge our duties with honourable intentions.'

When the employees left after bidding goodbye to Subodh, they starting talking amongst themselves—

'He seems to be a nice fellow.'

'From the head clerk's account, it seemed as if he would devour us alive.'

'Everyone talks like that in the beginning.'

'These are merely pretences, like the elephant's teeth.'

3

A month has passed since Subodh's arrival. The board's clerk, attendants and peons are all happy with his behaviour. He is so jovial and humble that whoever meets him once becomes his friend forever. A harsh word never appears in his speech. He doesn't let even a 'no' sound unpleasant. But in the eyes of the malevolent, talent becomes even more dangerous. All these positive qualities of Subodh rankled like eyesores as far as Madarilal was concerned. He kept hatching secret conspiracies against Subodh. First he tried inciting the employees, but failed. Then he tried to rouse the members of the board and failed miserably. He picked up the task of inflaming the contractors; it ended in embarrassment. He wanted to set fire to the haystack and watch the show from afar. He would meet Subodh with a smiling demeanour, speak in a sweet tongue, as if he was his true friend, but would actually always prey upon him. Subodh possessed many talents, but he could not read humans. He still considered Madarilal a friend.

One day Madarilal entered the room of the secretary and found the chair empty. Secretary Sahib had gone out for some work. Notes of five thousand lay tied up in bundles on his table. Some wooden items had been ordered for the madrasas run by the board. This was their payment. The contractor had been summoned to collect the amount. Secretary Sahib had sent the cheque to the treasury today itself and had the amount brought in. Madarilal peeped into the corridor, Subodh was nowhere to be seen. His intentions turned bad. Greed mingled with envy. He picked up the bundles of money with trembling hands, shoved them into both pockets of his pants, came out of the room and called the peon—'Is Babuji in?' The peon was buoyed up at the thought of some collection from the contractor. He came over from the betel shop right across and said, 'No, Sir, he is talking to someone at the court. He has just left.'

Madarilal came inside the office and said to a clerk, 'Take this case file and show it to Secretary Sahib.'

The clerk took the case file and left. He returned after a while. 'Secretary Sahib was not in the room. I have left the file on the table.'

Madarilal made a face. 'Where does he go leaving his room unattended? He'll be cheated someday.'

The clerk said, 'Apart from the office staff, who else goes into his room?'

Madarilal said sharply, 'So are all the office staff godlike? No one can predict when someone's intentions might go awry. I have seen the intentions of a good many change colours for petty amounts. At the moment, all of us are like side posts to the door, but hardly anyone would miss the mark if they got a chance. This is the nature of man. You should go and shut both the doors to his room.'

The clerk deferred the matter. 'But the peon is sitting at the door.'

Madarilal was irritated. 'You should do what I am asking you. You say, but the peon is sitting. Is the peon a sage or a hermit? If the peon himself swindles something, what would you be able to do to him? The bail is also for a mere three hundred rupees. Here each paper is worth lakhs.'

Then Madarilal himself got up and closed the doors of the office from both sides. As his mind calmed down, he removed the bundles of money

from his pockets and hid them under some papers in an almirah. Then he returned and busied himself in his work.

Subodhchandra returned after about an hour. At that moment, the doors to his room were shut. Entering the office smiling, he asked, 'Who has closed my room, brother, have I been disowned?'

Madarilal stood up and said a little reproachfully, 'Sahib, pardon my impertinence. Whenever you go out, even if for a minute, please shut the door. Money and official papers and letters lie spread across your table, who knows when someone's intentions might overturn. I just heard that you had gone somewhere, so I shut the doors.'

Subodhchandra opened the door, went inside the room and started smoking a cigar. He was totally unaware of the money that was supposed to be lying on the table.

Suddenly the contractor came in and saluted him. Subodh got up from the chair and said, 'You've taken too long, I'd been waiting for you. I'd got the amount brought over at ten o'clock itself. Have you brought the stamp for the receipt?'

The contractor replied, 'Huzoor, I have brought the written receipt.'

'Then you may take your money. I am not too happy with your work. The wood that you've used is not good and your work is also not meticulous. If you do such a shoddy job again, your name will be taken off the register of contractors.'

Then, when Subodh glanced at the table, he saw that the bundles of money were not there. He thought that perhaps they were under some file. He sifted through all the papers near the chair but there was no trace of the money. *Oh where did the money go? I had just kept it here. Where could it have gone?* He started shuffling through the files once again. His heart started palpitating. Even after screening the papers on the entire table, the bundles were nowhere to be found. Then he sat on the chair and started analysing the events of the past half an hour: *The peon had given the bundles of money to me directly, I remember this perfectly. Is this a matter to forget so easily, and so soon? I had taken the money and kept it here on this table, didn't even count it. Then Lawyer Sahib had arrived, and he is an*

old acquaintance. As I talked to him, I walked up to that tree. He ordered paan, and hence the delay. When I had left, the bundles were lying here. I remember this very well. Then where did this money disappear? I did not keep it in any box, drawer or almirah. Then where did it go? Perhaps someone in the office kept it aside as a precaution. Yes, that must be the case. I'm just unnecessarily becoming anxious. Chhi!

Immediately he returned to the office and asked Madarilal, 'Did you keep aside the money lying on my table?'

Madarilal was startled. 'Was there money on your table? I had no inkling. Just now Pandit Sohanlal had gone to your room with a file and he didn't find you. When I heard that you had gone out to talk to someone—that was when I asked for the doors to be shut. Is some money missing?'

Subodh's eyes widened. 'O Sahib, it was an amount of five thousand! The cheque was encashed just a while ago.'

Madarilal beat his head. 'Five thousand! Oh God! Have you searched the table properly?'

'Oh, I've been searching for the past fifteen minutes.'

'Did you ask the peon who all had entered the room?'

'Come, why don't you all search too? My senses have deserted me.'

The entire office staff started looking through Secretary Sahib's room. Table, almirahs and boxes—everything was searched. Pages of registers were shuffled through but there was no trace of the money. Now there was no doubt that someone had stolen it. Subodh took a deep breath and sat down on a chair. All colour drained from his face. His face shrank. If someone saw him right now, they'd have thought that he'd been ill for the past several months.

Expressing sympathy, Madarilal said, 'This is really strange. Such an incident has never happened till now. I have been working here for ten years, not even a penny's worth has ever gone missing. I wanted to caution you from the very beginning to be careful in money matters, but since this had to happen, the thought slipped my mind. Someone must have come from outside and disappeared with the money. The only crime of the peon is that he let anyone inside the room in the first place. He may swear a

thousand times that no one came in from outside, but I cannot believe this. From here only Pandit Sohanlal had gone with a file, but he simply peered into the room from the door and returned.'

Sohanlal clarified, 'I didn't even step inside, Sahib! I swear upon my young son, if I ever stepped in.'

Madarilal frowned. 'Why are you swearing unnecessarily? Is someone saying anything to you? (Into Subodh's ears) If there's any money in the bank, it should be withdrawn and given to the contractor, otherwise there would be great infamy. The loss has been incurred, why add insult to it?'

Subodh replied in a pathetic voice, 'There's hardly two to four hundred rupees in the bank, Bhaijaan. If I had the money, I wouldn't have been so worried. I would have thought that just as the twenty-five thousand had been spent earlier, now thirty thousand had been spent. There isn't a penny even for a shroud.'

That night Subodhchandra committed suicide. He could not arrange such a large amount. Except for the cloak of death, he did not have any screen to hide his pain and helplessness.

4

The next morning the peon went to Madarilal's house and called out to him. Madari hadn't been able to sleep a wink the whole night. Alarmed, he came out. The peon saw him and exclaimed, 'Huzoor! There's been an outrage! *Sikattary* Sahib slashed his throat with a knife last night.'

Madarilal's eyes rolled upwards, his mouth gaped wide and his whole body shook with fear, as if he had come across a live wire.

'Slashed with a knife?'

'Yes, Sir, it was found this morning. The police have gathered. You have been called.'

'The corpse is still there?'

'Yes, Sir, the medical is going to take place now.'

'Have a lot of people gathered?'

‘All the big officers have arrived. Huzoor, one is unable to even glance at the *carpse*. What a good-natured, diamond-like man he was. Everyone is weeping. There are two little kids and one grown-up girl of marriageable age. People are trying hard to restrain Bahuji, but she keeps running to the *carpse*. There’s hardly anyone not dabbing his eyes with a handkerchief. He had arrived quite recently but what a good rapport he shared with everybody. Money he was never bothered about. The heart was so vast!’

Madarilal’s head began spinning. Had he not supported himself holding the frame of the door, he would have fallen down. He asked, ‘Was Bahuji weeping a lot?’

‘Don’t ask anything, Huzoor. It is as if the leaves of the tree are shedding too soon. Her eyes are swelling like a wild fig.’

‘How many boys, did you say?’

‘Huzoor, two boys and a girl.’

‘Oh yes, I have seen the sons, the girl must be mature?’

‘Yes, Sir, she is of marriageable age. Incessant weeping has caused the poor thing’s eyes to swell up.’

‘There must be some discussion about the money as well?’

‘Yes, Sir, everyone is saying that this is an insider’s doing. Darogaji had wanted to arrest Sohanlal, but ’haps he’ll do that after consulting you. *Sikattary* Sahib has written that he doesn’t suspect anybody.’

‘Has Secretary Sahib left a letter?’

‘Yes, perhaps *whaail* slashing himself with the knife, he would’ve thought that in the *marning* everyone at the office would be arrested. So he left a letter addressed to *Calaktar* Sahib.’

‘Has he written anything about me in the letter? How would you know about this?’

‘Huzoor, now how would I know, but everyone was saying that he has written a lot praising you.’

Madarilal’s breath quickened even more. Two big droplets of tears fell from his eyes. Wiping his eyes, he said, ‘We had studied together, Nandu! Together for eight to ten years. Together we sat, ate and played; we used to

live together like two real brothers. What is written in the letter in praise of me? But what would you know?'

'You are coming along, Sir, see for yourself.'

'Has the shroud been arranged?'

'No, Huzoor, like I said, the medical of the *carpse* will be done now. But you come along soon. Otherwise, someone else will be sent to call you.'

'All the people of our office must have arrived?'

'Yes, Sir, the people from this locality are all there.'

'Didn't the police question them about me?'

'No, Sir, no one at all.'

When Madarilal reached Subodhchandra's house, he felt everyone eyeing him with suspicion. The police inspector immediately called him and said, 'You should also get your statement recorded, I have written the statements of all others.'

Madarilal got his statement recorded so carefully that even the police officers were astonished. They might have had some doubts about Madarilal, but this statement uprooted the very bud of suspicion.

Subodh's two sons came weeping to Madarilal and said, 'Please come, Amma is calling you.' Both were familiar with Madarilal. Madarilal used to come over every day, but had never been inside their house. Subodh's wife used to observe purdah in front of him. Hearing the summons, his heart beat faster—what if she suspects me? What if Subodh had expressed doubts regarding me? Fearfully and hesitantly he went inside, and his heart shuddered at the sound of the widow's pitiful wails. As soon as she saw him, another stream of the helpless woman's tears flowed out, and the girl ran over to him, wrapping herself around his feet. Both the boys too surrounded him. Madarilal felt an unfathomable pain; their eyes were filled with such gut-wrenching grief that he couldn't bear to look at them. His soul began reproaching him. The poor ones who had placed upon him such a degree of confidence, trust, attachment and affection—he had worked the knife on their very throats! Their wholesome family was reduced to nothing because of him. *What will happen to these helpless ones now? The girl needs to be married off, who would undertake it? Who would shoulder the*

burden of nurturing and bringing up the children? Madarilal felt such intense guilt that he was unable to utter a single word of consolation. He felt as if his face had been blackened and his height somewhat shrunken. At the time of stealing the money, he had not guessed it would lead to this. He had only wished to checkmate Subodh; he had not wanted to destroy him.

Sobbing, the distraught widow said, 'Bhaiyaji, he has left us mid-stream. If I had known that this was the course he had decided upon, I would have laid at his feet whatever little I had. He kept telling me that something or the other would work out. He wanted to contact a moneylender through you. I can't tell you how much he trusted you.'

Madarilal felt as though someone were running a knife through his heart. He could feel something getting stuck inside his throat.

Rameshwari, the widow, continued, 'Before he slept at night, he was laughing a lot. He had his milk like always, expressed affection for the children, played the harmonium for a while, and then, rinsing his mouth, finally lay down. There was nothing to arouse even a bit of suspicion. Finding me worried, he said, "You worry for no reason. I have a long-standing friendship with Babu Madarilal. After all, when will it be put to use? We played together as children. He is familiar with everyone in this town. The money will be arranged quite easily." So I can't understand when this thought entered his mind. I, of the grave misfortune, slept so soundly that I couldn't hear anything. How was I to know that he would take his own life?'

Madarilal felt the whole world swimming before his eyes. He tried hard to control himself, but could not stop the flow of tears.

Rameshwari wiped her eyes. 'Bhaiyaji, what was to happen has already occurred. But you must identify that villain who has completely destroyed us. This is the job of someone from the office. He was like a god. He kept telling me that he didn't suspect anyone, but this is definitely the handiwork of someone from the office. My only plea is—do not let that sinner escape. The police might let him off after taking some bribe. But in your presence, they won't dare to do that. Now who is there to look after us except you?

Who can we share our grief with? This defacement of the corpse was also destined.'

For once, Madarilal's heart raged with the desire to reveal everything: to say clearly, '*I* am that villain, that wretched and base person.' He felt like falling at the feet of the widow and asking her to turn the same knife on the neck of this murderer. But speech failed him, and sitting in the same position, his head felt so giddy that he fell on to the ground.

5

The inspection of the corpse ended by the third quarter of the day. The bier proceeded towards the lake. The entire office, the senior officers, and thousands of men walked along. The crematory rites should have been performed by the boys, but they were still minors. So the widow was getting ready to go along when Madarilal went in and said, 'Bahuji, let me perform this final ritual. If you join this ceremony, who will look after the children? Subodh was my brother. I could not treat him as one when he was alive but now, after his death, let me discharge some portion of my duty for the sake of our friendship. After all, I also had some right to him.'

Rameshwari wept. 'God has given you a very generous heart, Bhaiyaji, otherwise who bothers about whom after someone's death? Other people of the office, who used to wait upon him until midnight, did not even come under the pretence of concern, so that we would be somewhat consoled.'

Madarilal performed the crematory rites. He kept overseeing the rituals for thirteen days. *Pind daan* was held on the thirteenth day. The Brahmins were fed, food was given to the beggars and a feast was thrown for the friends. Madarilal did all of this at his own expense. Rameshwari insisted many times, 'Whatever you have done is more than enough. Now I don't wish to burden you further. To what extent will you fulfil the obligation of friendship?' But Madarilal did not pay any heed. The whole town resonated with his glory: this is how friends should be.

On the sixteenth day, the widow said to Madarilal, 'Bhaiyaji, we shall not be able to repay the debt of your favours and obligations till our last

moments. If you had not supported us closely, who knows what our condition would've been. There was no help from anywhere. Now allow us to go back home. Expenses will be lower in the village and I can also take up farming or something. Somehow these days of hardship will come to a pass. Please continue to be compassionate towards us.'

Madarilal queried, 'What assets do you have at home?'

Rameshwari replied, 'What of the assets, there's just a *kachcha* house, and the tenancy of ten to twelve bighas of land. We had started constructing a pukka house, but the money ran short. It is lying incomplete. Ten to twelve thousand have been spent, yet the roof is nowhere close to be laid.'

'Is there some money in the bank, or is farming the sole support?'

'Not even a penny, Bhaiyaji! Money never stayed in his hands for long. The farm is the only succour.'

'Would the yield of the farms be good enough to pay the taxes and for your subsistence?'

'What else can we do, Bhaiyaji? One has to somehow carry on with life. If not for the children, I would have poisoned myself.'

'And the daughter too has to be married off.'

'Her marriage is no longer a matter of concern. There will be many in the farming community who would marry her without any expectations.'

Madarilal thought for a moment. 'If I were to suggest something, would you agree to it?'

'Bhaiyaji, if I don't agree to your suggestions, who will I listen to, and after all who else is there?'

'So instead of returning to your home, please come to my house. Your children will live like my own. You will not face any difficulties. God willing, the girl will also be married into a good family.'

The widow's eyes welled up. 'But, Bhaiyaji, please think—'

Madarilal cut her short. 'I will not consider anything and will hear no objections. Don't the families of two brothers reside together? I considered Subodh my brother and will always continue to think so.'

No more objections were heard. Madarilal took everyone along to his own house and has been looking after them for ten years now. Both the

children are studying in a college and the girl has been married into a reputed family. Madarilal and his wife serve Rameshwari with great dedication and fulfil all her wishes. Madarilal is atoning for his sins through his relentless service.

Translated from the Hindi by Kalyanee Rajan



Nitpicker

1

When Babu Kundanlal came back from the court, he saw his wife buying vegetables. The seller was asking for two paise, she was giving her just a paisa and a half. The argument went on for several minutes. The seller eventually agreed to a paisa and a half. The question of the weights and the weighing scale came up. The two sides were not equal. There was a *pasanga* in one. The measure didn't go all the way down. They got a weight from the neighbour's house. When the vegetables were weighed, the question of who was at a loss came up. His wife asked for more vegetables to be put in, and the seller said, 'Should I sell at a loss, Miss?' Anyway, in half an hour, the deal was done, and the vegetable seller left threatening never to come back. Kundanlal was standing there watching the show. The seller having departed and his wife having brought him a glass of water, he said, 'Today, you spent an entire half hour buying a few vegetables. One could've made a deal worth a thousand bucks in the same time. Haggling over a few vegetables—doesn't your head ache?'

Rameshwari said, a little embarrassed, 'Does money grow on trees?'

'That's fine, but time's worth something too. After all that time and exertion, you must've saved a paisa. The seller too must have said to herself, "What a country bumpkin." And she's never going to come back.'

‘Well, I can’t allow people to rip me off.’

‘You could’ve read twenty pages in that time. Yesterday, you argued for hours with the maid. The day before, you wrangled for hours with the milkman. Is life to be wasted doing these things?’

Kundanlal would frequently sermonize. This was his second marriage. It had been just two or three months since Rameshwari had come home. Her elder sister-in-law would do the chores upstairs. Rameshwari didn’t get along with her. She felt—*she’ll ruin everything I have*. At last, she left. Since then, Rameshwari had been the lady of the house; she wanted to keep her husband happy. She followed his every direction; once she’d been told something, it was etched in stone. But every day, something would happen and Kundanlal would get an opportunity to deliver a sermon.

2

One day, the cat drank up the milk. Rameshwari heated the milk, kept it next to her husband’s bed and was preparing the paan, when the cat claimed her God-given right to the milk.

Rameshwari couldn’t bear it. She picked up a stick and hit the cat so hard, it rolled over a few times.

Kundanlal was reading the newspaper lying down. He said, ‘What if she’d died?’

Rameshwari said boldly, ‘Then why did she drink my milk?’

‘You didn’t get the milk back by hitting her.’

‘When somebody causes a loss, one is bound to feel angry.’

‘One shouldn’t. Should a man behave just like an animal? What is the difference between a man and an animal then?’

For several minutes, Kundanlal gave her a sermon on compassion, prudence and harmony, so much so that Rameshwari started crying from contrition.

Similarly, one day, when Rameshwari shooed a beggar away, Babu Sahib began sermonizing again. ‘If you can’t bring yourself to get up,’ he said,

‘then let me give him money. You shouldn’t shoo away a poor man like that.’

Rameshwari frowned, ‘They queue up all day long. For how long can one put up with it? It seems the whole country’s full of beggars.’

Kundanlal smiled scornfully. ‘You live in the same country!’

‘Where do so many beggars come from? All these people—why don’t they work?’

‘Nobody’s base enough to ask for alms if he has a job. Yes, if he’s crippled, it’s a different matter. What else can a cripple do but ask for alms?’

‘Why doesn’t the government open an orphanage for them?’

‘Come independence, maybe they will; you can’t hope for it right now; even independence depends on “dharma”.’

‘Lakhs of sadhus and sanyasis, pandits and priests live off others, isn’t that enough “dharma”? If this “dharma” was to have given us our independence, we would have got it long ago.’

‘It is this “dharma” because of which the Hindu race still lives, or they’d have reached the nether world a long time back. There’s not a trace left of Rome, Greece, Iran, Syria. It’s only the Hindus who continue, even now, to resist time’s cruel blows.’

‘You may think that the Hindu race is still alive. I thought it dead the day it became a slave. Life is but a name for freedom, slavery is death.’

Kundanlal looked at the young woman with astonishment. Where did she get such ideas from? She looked innocent enough. Must have heard it somewhere, he thought. He hardened, and said, ‘What crock. Not only are you not ashamed, you’re talking back.’

Reproved, Rameshwari kept quiet. She stood there for a moment and then slowly walked out.

3

One day, Kundanlal threw a party for all his friends. Rameshwari entered the kitchen in the morning, and did not have a moment to herself till

evening. She hated these chores. If he wanted to dine with his friends, why didn't he make arrangements for the food to be cooked? Why make it all her responsibility! He could at least have asked her—Shall I throw a party? What was happening now is exactly what would have happened then. She would have cheerfully acquiesced to the proposal, and then she would have understood, it's me who's throwing the party. Now she realized that she was being forced to do all the work. Anyway, dinner was prepared, people ate and left, but Munshiji sat there, sulking.

Rameshwari said, 'Why don't you eat, is it not your dinner time yet?'

Babu Sahib's eyes widened in anger. 'What should I eat—is this food? It's cattle feed!'

It was as if somebody had hauled her over coals. All day she had sweated it out in front of the stove and in return—this! She said, 'I did what I could. I cannot do what's beyond me.'

'The puris are all half-cooked!'

'Fine.'

'The kachori had so much salt, nobody even touched it.'

'Fine.'

'The halva hadn't been fried properly—it grated in the mouth.'

'Maybe it was.'

'The shorba was so thin, it was like drinking tea.'

'Fine.'

'A woman's foremost duty is that she be skilled in the kitchen.'

Then he delivered a string of homilies, which went on for so long that Rameshwari got bored and left!

4

Five or six months passed. One day, a distant relative of Kundanlal's came to meet him. As soon as Rameshwari got to know, she asked the maid to serve him sweets as refreshment and invited him to eat there. The gentleman was delighted. He came with his luggage and stayed put.

A week passed; there was no sign of his departure. If there had been something lacking in the hospitality, he may have been discomfited but Rameshwari devoted body and soul to taking care of him. Why would he leave then?

One day, Kundanlal said, 'I don't know why you're indulging this fellow!'

Rameshwari asked, shocked, 'Which fellow?'

'Why don't you send him on his way?'

'What harm is he doing me?'

'He's staying put and increasing our expenses. If you extend such hospitality to him, he won't budge from here.'

'I can't do it. If somebody's visiting for a couple of days, I can't bite his head off for it. Let him stay however long he wants.'

'It's a sin to be hospitable to such freeloaders. If you hadn't been so hospitable, he'd have been long gone. When he gets three meals a day and hundreds of paans, he'd be crazy to go back home.'

'It's not nice to be stingy about food.'

'We should see if a person is worthy or unworthy. To feed such lazy people is to give them poison; poison destroys only the body, but this kind of tending destroys the soul. If this gentleman stays here even a month longer, he'll become ruined for life. He'll never be able to do anything useful and it'll be your fault.'

Thus did he tie the thread of the argument. A row of proofs followed. Rameshwari left irritably. Kundanlal could never be contented with her. *Will his sermons ever stop?* The question kept coming back to her.

5

One day, they got some fresh buffalo ghee from their village. For months on end, they'd been eating ghee from the market, and were fed up of it. Rameshwari boiled it, put some cloves in it, took it out of the pan and put it in a pot. Its sweet aroma filled the whole house. When the maid came to wash the dishes, she thought she'd keep the pot on the hanging rope basket

or the alcove. But when she picked up the pot, it slipped from her hands by accident and fell. All the ghee was spilt. Rameshwari ran in, hearing the crash. The maid was standing there crying—the pot had shattered into tiny pieces. Rameshwari said wrathfully, ‘How did the pot break? I’ll deduct it from your wages. Oh God, all the ghee’s been spilt! Are you blind? Or do your hands have no strength? I brought it from so far off, heated it for so long, but not a drop even grazed my throat. What are you standing there for dumbstruck? Go do your work.’

The maid wiped her eyes and said, ‘O Madam, now the mistake’s made, deduct my wages, take my life if you will. I thought I’d keep it on the alcove so I could wash the dishes. How would I know this was written in my fate? Who knows whose face I saw this morning!’

‘I don’t care, I’m going to deduct all the money from your wages. And I’ll fine you a rupee too!’

‘I’ll die, Madam, I don’t have even a paisa extra.’

‘Snuff it, croak it, I don’t care.’

The maid thought for a minute, and then said, ‘Okay, deduct it, Madam. You can’t bear it; I will. Not only that, I’ll die of hunger. It’s not as if my life’s at all happy, so why fear dying? I’ll pretend I’ve done no work for a month. People sometimes cause large losses, this was just ghee.’

In a flash, Rameshwari felt pity for the maid. She said, ‘If you die of hunger, who will do my work?’

‘If you want to get work done, feed me; if you don’t, let me die of hunger. From now on, I’ll come and sleep at your doorstep.’

‘Go daub the kitchen with dung, throw away the pieces of the broken pot. And go to the market and get ghee.’

The maid happily cleaned the kitchen with dung, and was picking up the pieces of the pot, when Kundanlal arrived. Looking around and seeing the pot broken, he asked, ‘How did the pot break?’

Rameshwari said, ‘The maid was putting it aside, it slipped from her hands.’

Kundanlal screamed, ‘And all the ghee was spilt?’

‘What did you expect?’

‘And you said nothing to the maid?’

‘What could I say? She didn’t do it on purpose.’

‘And who’ll pay for the loss?’

‘We will, who else? If it had slipped from my hand, would I have cut my hand off?’

Kundanlal bit his lip and said, ‘I can’t understand your reasoning. The one who caused the loss should pay for it. That’s God’s law. An eye for an eye, a life for a life, that’s what a kindly man like Jesus Christ said. If there is no provision for punishment in the world, who’ll be able to live here? The whole world will be reddened by blood, murderers will slit peoples’ throats in broad daylight. It is punishment that maintains the decorum of society. The day there is no punishment, there is no planet. Manu and other law-givers were not idiots to give the law of retribution so much importance. If nothing else, punishment is necessary to maintain society. The maid will have to pay up. We’ll have to cut her wages. Today she’s broken a pot of ghee, tomorrow she’ll break something else.’

Scared, Rameshwari said, ‘But I’ve forgiven her.’

Dilating his eyes in anger, Kundanlal said, ‘But I can’t forgive her.’ The maid stood listening to the argument at the door. When she saw Kundanlal’s rage swelling, and realized that Rameshwari was having to listen to rebuke after rebuke because of her, she stepped forward and said, ‘Master, the mistake’s been made. Deduct all the money from my wages. I don’t have the money, or I’d have given the whole amount to you right now.’

Rameshwari reprimanded her, ‘Scoot. Why are you here? Acting like a rich woman!’

Kundanlal looked at his wife coldly and said, ‘Why are you arguing her case? It’s not complicated—even a child understands that whoever makes a mistake pays for it. Why should I suffer a loss of five rupees? For no reason? Why didn’t she carry the pot carefully, why the hurry, why didn’t she call out to you for help? It’s sheer carelessness.’

Having said this, Kundanlal went out.

Rameshwari was wounded by this insult. If he had to rebuke her, he could have called her and done it in the privacy of a room. But he had

talked to her sharply in front of the maid. She couldn't understand him at all. What kind of a man was this? Says one thing today, contradicts it tomorrow, as if he was daft. An embodiment of compassion and generosity that morning, and choking over five rupees today. How lovely it would be if the maid didn't turn up tomorrow. *If I had ever heard one gentle word from his mouth! I'll have to alter my temperament! This is a result of my being straightforward. Give him an inch, he takes a mile. The only cure for this is that if he gives me one, I give him two right back. How long can I tolerate this? There's a limit to everything! He rebukes me all the time. Who can keep a person with an unstable temperament happy? The day I hit the cat, he was overflowing with the milk of human kindness. Where did that kindness disappear to today? The way to set him right is to pretend he's a dog barking. No, why should I? I won't do anything of my own volition; I'll do only what he says; not a jot more, not a jot less. When he likes nothing I do, has a mad dog bitten me that I should interfere? This is it!*

She wrestled with this problem all night. In the morning, Kundanlal went to the river for a bath. It was nine by the time he got back. When he reached home, he saw that the dishes hadn't been washed. He was rattled. He asked, 'Didn't the maid come?'

Rameshwari answered, 'No.'

'Then?'

'Whatever you decree.'

'This is a real problem.'

'Yes, it is.'

'Why didn't you call the neighbour's maid?'

'On whose instructions could I have called her? Now that you've instructed me, I'll call her.'

'If you call her now, when will she prepare the food? It's nine o'clock, you should have had the sense to call the neighbour's maid when ours didn't turn up.'

'Had you asked why I called another maid, what would I have said? I've stopped using my mind. I will only do what you ask me to do. I don't want to be shouted at for nothing.'

‘Okay, so what’s going to be prepared now?’

‘Whatever the lord instructs.’

‘You’re mocking me.’

‘Do I have the audacity to mock you? I’m the lord’s *laundi*. He instructs, I follow. I’m a slave to his wishes.’

‘Okay, I’m leaving, do what you want.’

‘Go, I want nothing, and I shall do nothing.’

‘At least tell me what you want to eat.’

‘I will eat what you give me.’

‘Give me money, I’ll go get puris.’

Rameshwari gave him the money. Kundanlal got some puris. Lunch was taken care of. He went to work. Came back late. As soon as he came back, he asked, ‘Did the maid come?’

‘No.’

‘I’d told you to call the neighbour’s maid.’

‘I did. She was asking for five rupees.’

‘That’s a difference of just a rupee, why didn’t you hire her?’

‘I hadn’t been instructed to do that. I would’ve been asked to explain myself—*Why did you give her an extra rupee*? If you’d given me a sermon on moderation, what would I have done?’

‘You’re an absolute idiot.’

‘Absolutely.’

‘So no food will be cooked for dinner either?’

‘Can’t be helped.’

Kundanlal held his head in his hands and sat down on the charpoy. This was a new problem. He didn’t like puris. Enraged, he flung insults at Rameshwari but she turned a deaf ear to them. When nothing worked, he left to look for a maid. Whichever house he went to, they told him the maid had gone out for work. At long last, he found a Kahar. He called him. He took two annas, washed the vessels and left.

Rameshwari asked, ‘What’s to be cooked?’

Kundanlal replied, ‘Roti and vegetables, or is there a problem with that too?’

‘No vegetables at home.’

‘You were at home the whole day, you couldn’t even buy vegetables? Where will we find them so late at night?’

‘I’d received no instructions about buying vegetables. What if I’d paid too much?’

Kundanlal ground his teeth helplessly. ‘What is it that you want?’

Rameshwari answered calmly, ‘Nothing, I just don’t want to be insulted.’

‘Who’s insulting you?’

‘You.’

‘Do I have no right to speak about the matters of the house?’

‘You have every right. If you don’t, who does? I’m here merely to carry out your orders.’

Dinner was roti and dal. Both lay down. Rameshwari promptly fell asleep. Kundanlal tossed and turned. If Rameshwari did not cooperate, not a day would pass smoothly. Today’s dinner had been difficult enough. *She’s a fool. I explain things to her, she thinks I’m scolding her. I can’t keep mum. But if this is the result, then I might as well not speak; at least I’ll be spared having to come back from office and going to the market.*

He woke Rameshwari up and said, ‘How deeply you sleep!’

Rameshwari replied, ‘Those who work hard sleep well.’

‘Don’t tease me. Don’t take the money back from the maid.’

‘Yes, maybe she’s waiting outside with the money this very moment.’

‘If she gets to know we’re not going to ask her, she may come back.’

‘All right, I’ll send for her.’

‘I beg your forgiveness, I won’t interfere any more.’

‘And if I destroy the entire home?’

‘Do what you will, but don’t be angry. If you ask me for my advice, I’ll give it, otherwise I won’t even open my mouth.’

‘I want respect.’

‘Forgive me this time.’

‘Do you mean it?’

‘I do.’

Translated from the Hindi by Anirudh Karnick



The Holi of Love

1

At seventeen, Gangi, who had been widowed for three years, knew that the gates of worldly pleasures had been closed for her. Then why should she cry and whine? Not everybody returns from the fair with boxes of sweets, flowers and garlands. Many are entertained by just going there and watching other men and women standing at the brightly lit shops. And so Gangi lived her life—she laughed and talked; nobody saw her with a long face, or lamenting her fate. Waking at night, giving the cows and buffaloes fodder and making cow-dung cakes for fuel was her daily routine. Then she woke up her brother to milk the cow. Then she drew water from the well, and began her kitchen chores. The women of the village cracked jokes with her, barring a particular kind; the women narrated their entire stories after returning from their in-laws' home, barring a special context. Everybody respected her widowhood. She was forgiven for those very minor faults for which her sister-in law was scolded, her mother abused or her brother beaten up. Who can batter one whom God has beaten! She never felt drawn towards forbidden things. For her, such things simply didn't exist. There were no turbulent waves in the swelling ocean of youth, no fearful roars; rather a reign of peace prevailed.

2

It was Holi. Everybody wore pink saris; Gangi's sari was not dyed. Her mother asked, 'Daughter, should I dye your sari too?' Gangi said, 'No, mother, put it aside.' The sister-in-law sang *phaag*. She was happily making *pakwaan*s.

People from other villages came to play Holi in the late afternoon. Gangi's people would return this visit. This was the tradition of the villages. Maiku Mahto had already kept the bhang ready; cannabis, sweets laced with hemp—everything had been bought. Gangi had also ground hemp leaves and prepared sweet as well as savoury items from it. Her brother served the drinks while she poured water for the guests to rinse their hands. The young drank with bowed heads and left, the elder folks asked Gangi, 'Are you well, daughter?' Or asked her light-heartedly, 'What's the matter, Gangi? Doesn't your sister-in-law feed you that you have turned so lean!' Gangi would laugh it off. Was the body in her control? She didn't know why it had been so stout earlier.

After drinking bhang, people started singing phaag. Gangi stood listening at her doorstep. A young man was singing. What a lovely voice! How sweet! Gangi was enjoying herself. Her mother called out several times, 'Can you hear me?' She didn't respond. She went out once and rushed back. Her mind was on the song. What drew and bound her to it? The young man also glanced repeatedly in Gangi's direction and sang with gusto. His companions were astonished. Where had this talent emerged from? Even after they left, Gangi remained at the doorstep. The young man also glanced at her and walked away.

Gangi asked her father, 'Who was that singing?'

Maiku said, 'He is Garibsingh, the son of Budhusingh from Kothar. Budhu used to visit us on various occasions and festivals. Now that he's passed away, his son has taken his place.'

'Has he come here for the first time?'

'Yes, I haven't seen him before. His demeanour is just like his father's and his speech just as sweet. Not a touch of pride. His granaries are

overflowing yet he greets even a tanner. Such is his nature.'

The cows were returning. Gangi went inside to fetch the rope for harnessing them. Garibsingh's voice resonated in her ears.

3

Many months passed by. One day Gangi was preparing cow-dung cakes. Suddenly she saw the same young man walking by their house, his head bowed. She left the cow dung and stood up. There was no man in the house. Everybody had gone out. She wanted to say, 'Thakur! Do sit down and have a glass of water at least before you leave!' But she was speechless. Her heart was beating hard. A strange worry overtook her—what to do, how to stop him? Garibsingh glanced towards her once and lowered his eyes. What was in that glance that gave her goosebumps? She ran inside the house and said to her mother, 'Mother, that young man is going by, Garibsingh.' Her mother said, 'Perhaps he has come on some work.' By the time Gangi came out again, the young man had gone. She began patting the cow dung into cakes again, but the cakes kept breaking. Her hands seemed to stop working on their own, but she would resume making the dung cakes again, as if a distant voice was reaching her ears. The same scene was before her eyes. What magic did it hold? What enchantment? He had said something to her without words. Gangi had also heard something. She did not know what, but that scene sank deep into her eyes.

Lying in bed at night, the scene played before her eyes. She even dreamt of it.

A few months passed. One evening, Maiku was twisting the stalk of hemp and Gangi was stirring the fodder for the oxen when she shouted, 'Father, father, Thakur!'

Maiku lifted his head and saw Garibsingh approaching. They greeted each other with a 'Ram, Ram!'

Maiku asked, 'Where are you going, Garibsingh? At least have some water.'

Garib came and sat on a stool. He looked pale and dull. He appeared unwell. Maiku said, ‘Have you been sick?’

‘No, father.’

‘You look pale, are you worried about loans and interest?’

‘What is there to worry about when you are alive, father?’

‘You’ve paid the debt?’

‘Yes, father, I have cleared everything.’

‘Go, daughter, get some water for the Thakur to drink. If you see your brother, tell him to bring the chillum.’

‘No need for chillum! I don’t smoke.’

‘The tobacco has been prepared at home this time. Try it. You’ve never smoked?’

‘Don’t make me so discourteous, father. I never touched the chillum in front of *kaka.* You are in his place.’

And his eyes brimmed with tears. Maiku’s heart was also faltering with emotion. Gangi was standing like a statue with the basket in her hands. Her entire consciousness, her emotions, were drawn to Garibsingh’s words! She didn’t have the capacity to think of or do something else. Oh! How courteous, how disciplined, how cultured he was!

‘Didn’t you hear, daughter, go and get some water to drink!’ Gangi was startled. She ran into the house. She washed a bowl and poured out some thickened sugar-cane juice. Then she washed a glass and a lota and made some sherbet.

Her mother asked, ‘Who is there, Gangi?’

‘Thakur Garibsingh. Is there no milk, mother? I would have mixed it with the juice.’

‘Check the handi.’

Gangi took out all the cream and mixed it in the juice and came out with the small metal pot and glass. Thakur looked at her. Gangi looked down. How had this bashfulness come over her?

Thakurji drank the juice and departed saying, ‘Ram, Ram.’

‘He has turned so lean!’

‘Is he sick?’

‘He is worried, and why wouldn’t he be? He is alone in such a big household, what will he do?’

That night Gangi couldn’t sleep. *What was he anxious about? Father didn’t say anything either. Why does he think so much? His face had turned yellow.*

Early next morning Gangi said to her mother, ‘Garibsingh has grown so lean, mother!’

‘He is no longer carefree, daughter. When his father was alive, he would eat and play. Now he bears the burden of running the household.’

Gangi was not satisfied with this answer. She went out and asked Maiku, ‘Father, didn’t you help him understand? You should have asked Garibsingh the reason for worrying so much?’

Maiku glared at her. ‘Go and do your work.’

Gangi felt as if she had been struck by lightning. She had never expected such an answer from her father. *Hai! Even my father does not care for Garibsingh. Nobody is his friend. Who can make him understand? The next time he visits I will tell him myself.*

Each day Gangi thought, *Perhaps today Thakur will come.* But he did not. Once again it was Holi. Once again phaag was being sung in the village. The women wore pink saris. Colour was stirred again. Maiku bought cannabis and hemp. Gangi prepared sweet and salty bhang once more. *Taat* was spread out at the door. Acquaintances started arriving. But nobody came from Kothar. Evening arrived, but there was still no news of anyone from Kothar. Gangi grew anxious. She went in and out several times. She would ask her brother, ‘Haven’t the people from Kothar come? Her brother replied, ‘No.’ She asked her father, ‘There is no more bhang left, what will the people from Kothar drink?’

‘Now, would they come at night? The village is nearby. We would have been able to see if they were coming.’

Night descended, but Gangi was still hopeful. She climbed up the temple terrace and looked towards Kothar. Nobody!

Suddenly she saw flames blazing near the village border. The flames gradually grew intense. What is this! Holi is being burnt there today. But

Holi had already been burnt yesterday. Who knows, maybe the pandits there wanted the Holi to burn today. That's why they didn't turn up today. Perhaps they will come tomorrow.

She came home and told Maiku, 'Father, Holi is being burnt in Kothar today.'

'Mad girl! Holi was burnt everywhere yesterday.'

'I saw it from the temple. It is Holi burning. If you don't believe me, come, I will show you.'

'All right, let me have a look.'

Maiku went along with Gangi to the temple terrace and looked in the direction of Kothar. He kept watching for a minute. Then he descended without saying a word.

'Isn't that the Holi that you were denying was being burnt?'

'It is not Holi, mad girl—it's a burning pyre. Someone has died. That is why the people from Kothar didn't come.'

Gangi's heart skipped a beat. And then someone called out, 'Maiku Mahto, Garibsingh of Kothar has passed away.'

Maiku went down, but Gangi stood stock still. She knew not who she was or where she was. It seemed as if Garibsingh were leaping out of the distant fire and looking at her—the same gaze, the same face, could she forget him?

After that day she never went to watch Holi again. Every year Holi came. Every year she prepared bhang, every year phaag was sung, and every year colours were blown, but for Gangi, Holi had gone forever.

Translated from the Urdu by Shaheen Saba with Mini Krishnan



In Memoriam

1

I was conscripted into the army as soon as I left the government orphanage. I was robust and strong. My limbs were longer than normal and far more sinewy. I was six feet nine inches tall. I was renowned in my regiment as Div, or the giant. My luck turned from the moment I joined the army and I managed to do several things which brought me fame as well as an increase in my earnings. Every soldier of the regiment knew me. I was also blessed with the favour of Major Sardar Himmat Singh, whose life I had once saved. I cannot say why but I would be overwhelmed by a feeling of devotion and reverence every time I saw him. I virtually worshipped him and the Sardar Sahib's behaviour towards me was always affectionate and friendly.

I do not know who my parents were, nor do I have any memories of them. Sometimes when I ponder on this I see some dim images—a family living amidst large mountains, and a woman's face, perhaps that of my mother. In fact, I have grown up surrounded by mountains. There is a village eighty kilometres east of Peshawar, Kulaha, that has a government orphanage. I was brought up there. My body has been sculpted by the Himalayan winds, and I am like those huge primevals, the kind that live on the borders of the mountains, of the Afridi, Ghilzai, Mahsudi tribes. If there

is a difference between them and me, it is of civilized behaviour. I can read and write a little, carry on a conversation, I am familiar with the rules of social conduct, I can respect the high and the low. But I look exactly like any man from the frontiers.

Every once in a while my mind would be overwhelmed by a strong desire to roam freely in the mountains. But the question of livelihood would crush that desire. That parched country hardly had any food. Its people could kill one another for a piece of bread; they could strip and dismember a corpse to get a bit of cloth. And for a rifle they could ambush an army camp. But above all, every one of those wild tribesmen knew me and was thirsting for my blood. Had they encountered me, they would have left no trace of me in this world. Heaven knows how many of the Afridis and Ghilzais I had killed, how many I had captured and thrown into prison, and the countless villages that I had razed to the ground. Therefore, I too watched my step and, as far as possible, never stayed in any one place for more than a week.

2

One day I was headed towards Major Sardar Himmat Singh's house. It was two in the afternoon. Those days felt like holidays since we had only recently torched several of their villages and there was no chance of retaliation on their part. We spent our time relaxed; without any worries, our days passed in chatter and laughter. But having lounged around for a long time, I was feeling restless. I began walking towards the Sardar Sahib's house to cheer myself up but had an accident on the way. An old Afridi, who, even at his age, was capable of single-handedly wringing the neck of an Indian soldier, was arguing with a jawan. He drew a sharp knife from his waistband and plunged it into the soldier's chest before my eyes. The soldier had a rifle and that was the sole reason for this fight. Before you could blink, the jawan lay dead and the old man picked up the rifle and broke into a run. I sprinted after him, but he was so fast that in a few moments he had vanished. I followed recklessly. Finally, as we neared the border, I was only twenty feet away from him. He turned around and saw

that I was the only one in pursuit. He aimed the gun at me. Instantly, I lay flat on the ground and the bullet hit the stone in front of me. He thought that I had fallen prey to his bullet. He inched closer towards me, slowly and cautiously. I lay silent, holding my breath. When he stood almost over me I lunged at him like a lion, caught hold of his neck and threw him down on the ground, whipped out my knife and stabbed him. The Afridi's life drained out of him. Just then several members of my regiment reached there. All around people began to praise me. I had been in a daze thus far, but now slowly I became conscious of things around me. I do not know why but I panicked looking at that old body. Till then I had killed countless Afridis but had never experienced such unease. I slumped down on the ground and stared at the old man. The soldiers from my regiment came close and, assuming that I was injured, began asking all kinds of questions. I rose slowly and headed silently towards the town. The soldiers followed, dragging the old man's body behind them. The town's residents began a litany of praise for me. I entered Major Sardar Himmat Singh's house without a word. Sardar Sahib was sitting in his favourite room, writing. He saw me and asked, 'What? Did you kill that Afridi?'

I answered as I sat down, 'Yes, I did, but for some reason, Sardar Sahib, I feel like a coward.'

Surprised, Sardar Sahib countered, 'Asad Khan, a coward! The two cannot coexist.'

I stood up and said, 'Sardar Sahib, I do not feel well here, let us sit outside in the veranda. I don't know why but I am feeling very uncomfortable.'

Sardar Sahib walked up to me and, rubbing his hand affectionately on my back, said, 'Asad, you have become tired from all the running, that is all. But let's go and sit in the veranda. The evening breeze will refresh you.'

Sardar Sahib and I headed to the veranda and sat on the chairs there. The old man's body still lay at the town square and was surrounded by crowds on all sides. When they noticed me sitting, the people began to point in my direction. Sardar Sahib observed all this and commented, 'Asad Khan, see,

how highly the people regard you! Even the children here applaud your bravery. Would you still say that you are a coward?'

I smiled as I said, 'Since the moment I killed that old man, my conscience has been reproaching me.'

Sardar Sahib laughed in response. 'That is because you have killed someone weaker than you.'

I said, consoling myself, 'Perhaps that is the case.'

Just then a young Afridi woman walked slowly up to Sardar Sahib's gate. As soon as Sardar Sahib saw her, his face turned ashen. His frightened gaze turned from her to me. I looked at his face, taken aback. The woman had a well-toned body, one that even many men do not possess. She was wearing coarse clothes, khaki-coloured pyjamas and a blue kurta. She had a scarf tied on her head like other Baluchi women. Her skin was a burnished gold and a youthful glow oozed from her pores. At that moment her eyes possessed such fearful hatred that it would immediately produce dread in those who beheld them. She turned her eyes from the Sardar Sahib to me and stared so hard that I was alarmed. She looked again at Sardar Sahib, spat sharply on the ground and began walking away, only turning back to glare at me.

Sardar Sahib seemed to revive as soon as the woman walked away. Even I felt lighter.

I asked him, 'Do you know her?'

He took a long, deep breath and answered, 'Yes, indeed I do. There was a time when she doted on me and had even protected my life without a thought to her own, but now she abhors the very sight of me. She's the one who murdered my wife. I lose my bearings every time I see her. And all I can recall is that same scene over and over again.'

I asked in a terror-laced voice, 'Sardar Sahib, she stared at me as well with that frightening look. I don't know why but my hair stood on end.'

Sardar Sahib shook his head and said gravely, 'Asad Khan, beware! She may be related to that old Afridi. It is possible that he was her brother or father. She stared at you and that must mean something. She is a dangerous woman.'

I shuddered as I heard Sardar Sahib say this. I swiftly changed the topic. ‘Sardar Sahib, why don’t you turn her over to the police? She will be hanged to death.’

Sardar Sahib responded, ‘Asad Khan, she saved my life once and perhaps still cares for me. Her story is long. I shall tell you another time.’

I was curious. I urged him to tell me the story. He attempted to dodge me but when I pushed him further he said resignedly, ‘Asad, I consider you my brother, that is why I will not hide anything from you. Now, listen . . .’

3

‘Asad Khan, five years ago I was not as old as I seem now. I was not more than forty then. Not a hair on my head had turned grey and I was strong enough to single-handedly fight two soldiers together. I have fought the Germans and God alone knows how many I have sent to hell. After the First World War, I was made a major in the native platoon of the British army and sent here to the frontiers. In the initial days of my posting here, I faced several hurdles but nothing deterred me and I overcame them all. The first thing I did after coming here was learn Pashto. I learnt other tongues as well; in fact, I could speak them all with their local phrases. Then I formed several small teams and scoured the interiors of this land. In these endeavours I nearly lost my life several times. But I managed to survive all such difficulties and settled down happily. In those days I performed several such amazing deeds for which I gained recognition and fame within the government. I even rescued Colonel Hamilton’s wife all on my own once. I have saved the lives of countless men and women of this land. My story begins three years after I first arrived here.

‘One night I was lying down in my camp. A fight was on with the Afridis. Soldiers lay around, drained after a hard day of work. The camp was enveloped in silence. Soon I fell asleep. When my eyes flew open, I saw an Afridi—perhaps twice my age—astride me, about to plunge his dagger into my chest. He had me completely in his grip. I had no means of escape. But I

dealt with the situation with extreme calm, and said to him in Pashto, “Do not kill me, I am a government officer with the army, take me as your captive, the government will pay you for my release.”

‘By God’s grace he took my words seriously. He pulled out a rope from his waistband, tied up my hands and feet, slung me over his shoulder and made his way out of the camp. The atmosphere outside was delirious with all the fighting and killing. He yelled out a strange call and said something, then broke into a run towards the forest with me on his shoulder. I can vouch for the fact that he did not feel my weight one bit as he sprinted across the forest. He was followed by several men, all from the same tribe, carrying the treasures they had looted so far.

‘We reached a lake at dawn. It was surrounded by huge mountains. Its water was serene and wild shrubs and bushes grew all around. We halted close to the lake. The old man, who was actually the leader of the group, dumped me on a boulder close by. This hurt my back and I experienced extreme pain, as if I had broken a bone. But by God’s grace no bone was broken. The leader then asked me, “How much money can you get us?”

‘I masked my pain as I replied, “Five hundred rupees.”

‘The leader made a face and replied, “No, we won’t accept such a measly amount. If we are given even a rupee less than two thousand, your life will not be spared.”

‘I pondered over this. “The government will never spend such a large sum for a dark-skinned man like me.”

‘He pulled out a dagger and said, “Then why did you say that the government would reward us? Come, prepare to die right now.”

‘He advanced towards me with the dagger.

‘Startled I said, “Okay, Sardar, I will get you the two thousand.”

‘The man stopped and guffawed. His resounding laughter shook even the lifeless mountains with dread. I thought to myself, *What a terrifying man*.

‘One by one, the other members of the group began to place their booty in front of their leader. The loot contained several guns, bullets, some food and clothes. I was also searched. I had a six-bore revolver on me. The old man jumped with delight as soon as he held the revolver and turned it this

way and that, admiring it from all angles. They began to divide the loot among themselves right there. Each of them received an equal share, but the rifle was not a part of this division. That was the special share of their leader.

'After a short rest, the journey began again. This time they freed my legs and asked me to walk with them. I was blindfolded so that I would not know the way. My hands were still tied and one end of the rope was held by an Afridi.

'My feet began to hurt from all the walking but their destination was nowhere in sight. The summer sun shone blindingly overhead, my feet burned, my throat was parched, but they continued to walk. They talked among themselves as they walked but now I could not make sense of anything they said. A word or two was familiar but long sentences remained incomprehensible. They were thrilled with their victory and one of them began to sing in his tongue. It was a beautiful song.'

Asad Khan asked, 'What was the song, Sardar Sahib?'

Sardar Sahib replied, 'I remember its essence. It was about an Afridi who is leaving home. His wife asks him—Where are you off to? The youth replies—I am going to get some food and clothes for you. The wife asks—Will you not get anything for the children? The man replies—I will get guns for the children so that when they grow up, they can fight and in turn get food and clothes for their loved ones. The wife then asks—Tell me, when will you return? The man says—I will return only when I win something, or else I will die fighting. The wife then says—That's the spirit, go now, you are brave, you will surely succeed.

'I was entranced by the song. It ended and we stopped. They forced my eyes open. There was a wide open ground in front with tiny caves all around it. Those caves were their quarters.

'They searched me again, this time stripping me naked except for my pyjamas. There was a huge boulder in front of us. Together they pushed it aside and pulled me towards that place. My soul shuddered. These people will bury me alive. I looked at the old leader with deep sorrow and

implored, “Sardar, the government will give you a lot of money, do not kill me.”

‘He laughed, “Who is killing you? You are being imprisoned. You will stay a prisoner in this house, and will be released when we receive the money.”

‘At these words, I began to breathe again. The sardar took out my pencil and pocket book and, putting it down in front of me, ordered, “Write in this. If we get even a rupee less, you will lose your life.”

‘I wrote a letter addressed to the commissioner. Then they hung me upside down and pulled the rope away from me.’

4

Sardar Sahib drew a deep breath and continued, ‘Asad Khan, my soul shuddered as I was lowered into that hole. It wasn’t pitch dark inside but covered in a faint glow. It was neither big nor small. Its floor was gravelly, as if water had flowed through it for years before carving it like this. Its walls were of thick rock and light and wind filtered in from its numerous pores. I now began to think about the situation I was in. I felt very confused. Destiny had writ that I should suffer the pains of this dark prison.

‘Gradually evening set in. Those people had not inquired after me so far. Hunger was driving me crazy. I cursed my fate and myself by turns. When man becomes helpless he curses his fate.

‘At last someone tossed four large rotis through a gap. Just as a dog leaps at food thrown at it, I ran towards the gap and looked up. But nothing more was thrown my way nor was I told anything. I began to eat. After a while, a metal tumbler filled with water was placed in the same gap. I thanked God as I drank the water. When I felt sated, I asked, “May I have some more water?”

‘A mocking laugh resounded on the other side of the cave and a voice jingled, “Now you will get water only tomorrow. Give back the tumbler or else you will not get any again.”

‘What could I do, I left the tumbler at the spot.

‘Several days passed like this. I received the same four rotis and a tumbler of water twice daily. Gradually, I became used to this dull routine. The isolation did not hurt as much. At times I would sing in my language and at times in Pashto. This would make me feel better and calm my hapless heart.

‘One night I was singing a Pashto song. Majnu asks the fire-spitting herons—Do you not possess the heat that chars caravans to dust? Then why does that heat not burn me as well? Is it because I am already consumed by a fire? Please cover me with sand when Laila comes looking or else her heart will melt like glass upon seeing me.

‘My song came to an end. And just then someone spoke through the gap, “Prisoner, sing again.”

‘I was startled. Happy and surprised, I asked, “Who are you?”

‘An answer floated in through the gap, “I am Turya, the leader’s daughter.”

‘I asked, “Do you like the song?”

‘Turya responded, “Yes, sing it, prisoner, I want to hear it again.”

‘I began joyfully. The song ended and Turya said, “Sing this song to me every day. I will give you more rotis and water in return.”

‘Turya left. After that every night I sang that song, and Turya stood by the gap listening.

‘I had discovered a way to entertain myself.

‘A month passed in this manner, but no one had sent any money for my release. As the days went by, I felt more disheartened about my future. Exactly a month after I was captured, the Sardar came and said, “Prisoner, if the money does not arrive by tomorrow, you will be killed. I can no longer feed you.”

‘I lost all hope. That day I could neither eat nor drink anything. Night came, the rotis were thrown at me again, but I had no stomach for them.

‘Turya arrived at her usual time and said, “Prisoner, sing me the song.”

‘I was feeling very low that day. So I stayed silent.

‘Turya said again, “Prisoner, have you fallen asleep?”

‘I answered, irritated, “No, why should I sleep tonight? When I sleep tomorrow, there will be no waking up ever again.”

‘Turya asked, “Why, will the government not send the money?”

‘I answered, “Well, they will certainly send it but I am to be killed tomorrow. If the money arrives after my death, what use will it be to me?”

‘Turya consoled me softly, “Anyway, you sing your song, I will not let you die tomorrow.”

‘I began to sing. As she was leaving, Turya asked, “Prisoner, would you like to live in a jailhouse?”

‘I replied happily, “Of course, I would like to get out of this hell anyhow.”

‘Turya responded, “Okay, tomorrow I will tell Abba.”

‘The very next day I was pulled out of the blind well. My feet were chained to two huge beams and these were pegged deep into the ground with wooden nails.

‘The sardar came up to me and said, “Prisoner, we give you fifteen more days, after that we will cut off your head. Write another letter for your people today. If the money does not reach us by Eid, you will be slaughtered.”

‘I wrote a second letter and handed it over.

‘Turya arrived as soon as the sardar left. She was the woman you saw a while ago. She was the sardar’s daughter. She is the one who listened to my songs and she was the one who requested them not to take my life.

‘She came and stared at me. I stared back as well.

‘She asked, “Prisoner, who all live in your home?”

‘I answered timidly, “Two small children, no one else.”

‘I knew that the Afridis were extremely fond of children.

‘Turya asked, “Don’t they have a mother?”

‘I wanted to invoke her pity, so I said, “No, their mother is dead. They are alone. God knows whether they are alive or dead, because they have no one to take care of them except me.”

‘My eyes filled with tears as I said this. Even Turya’s eyes did not remain dry. She controlled her emotions as she said, “So you have nobody? Your

children are alone? They must be crying a lot."

'Feeling pleased inside, I replied, "Yes, surely they must be crying. Who knows, they might even be dead."

'She cut me short, "No, they are not dead. Tell me, where do you live? I will go get news of them."

'I gave her my address. She said, "I have been to this place many times. I shop there frequently; when I go there next I'll find out about your children."

'I asked her suspiciously, "When will you go?"

'She thought it over. "I'll go there next Friday. Now you sing the song."

'This time I sang with abundance and joy. I also saw how much this affected Turya. Her body shivered, her eyes filled with tears, her cheeks lost their colour and she sat down, trembling. Noticing her condition, I poured double the emotion into my singing and, when it ended, said, "Turya, if I am killed, do convey that news to my children."

'My words had the desired effect on her. She managed a croak. "Prisoner, you will not die. I will release you for the sake of your children."

'Disheartened, I replied, "Turya, I will not be able to flee even if you free me. I will lose my life trying to find a way out of this forest. And you may also land in trouble. I will not put you in danger in order to save my own life."

'She said, "Don't worry about me. No one will suspect me. I am the leader's daughter and they will all believe whatever I say. But will you send the money once you get back?"

'I replied thrilled, "Yes, Turya, I will send the money."

'She said as she left, "Then I too will give you your freedom."

'After this exchange, Turya always spoke to me about my children. Asad Khan, children are truly very dear to these Afridis. God may have made them barbaric, bloodthirsty animals but He has not left them devoid of a humane side. At last Friday dawned but the sardar had still not come back. Nor had anyone from his group. That evening Turya came and said, "Prisoner, now I cannot go because my father has not returned yet. If he

does not return tomorrow, I will free you at night. Return to your children but do not forget to send the money. I put my trust in you."

'I sang heartily that night. Turya listened to me till midnight, then went off to sleep. I prayed through the night for the sardar not to return. Bound to the logs, my feet had become useless. My body ached. Perhaps I had been better off in the blind well, at least I could move my hands and feet.

'The gang did not return the next day either. Turya seemed extremely worried. She came that evening and unbound my feet, "Prisoner, now leave. I will take you a little distance."

'I lay still awhile, having no control over my limbs. Gradually, my feet felt better and I began to walk with Turya, thanking God for his kindness.

'I wanted to make Turya happy, so sang all through the way. She listened and continued to weep. Around midnight, I reached the lake. Turya said, "Keep walking straight, you will reach Peshawar. Be very careful or you may become the victim of someone's bullet. Here, take these, your clothes, but do not forget to send the money. I am your guarantee. If the money does not arrive, I will lose my life, and so will you. If the money comes, no Afridi will ever raise his hand on you no matter how many of them you kill. Go, let the lord protect you and reunite you with your children."

'She did not wait. She walked back, humming. It was well past midnight. A terrifying silence surrounded everything; only the wind blew loudly. The moon shone in all its glory. It was not safe to stop by the lakeside. I inched southwards. I kept looking around in all directions. By God's grace I reached the outskirts of Peshawar at dawn.

'Soldiers guarded the frontiers. As soon as they spotted me, a commotion took over the camp. They had all thought me to be dead. They were delighted to see a dead man walking back.

'Colonel Hamilton heard the news and came immediately to meet me. He said, "Major Sahib, I thought you were dead. I received your two letters, but even in my wildest dreams I did not think that you had written them. I thought they were fake. Thank God you have returned safely."

'I thanked the colonel but thought to myself, "The letters seemed fake because they were written by a dark-skinned man. Had a white man written

them, why two, even four thousand rupees would have been dispatched instantly. Countless villages would have been burnt down and untold acts would have been carried out."

'I returned home without a word. I felt relieved when I met my children at last. That very day I sent two thousand rupees to Turya with a trusted servant.'

5

The sardar drew another deep breath and began, 'Asad Khan, my story does not end here. Its tragic end has yet to unfold. After my return, I put my troubles behind me one by one, but I could not forget Turya. It was through her grace that I was reunited with my wife and children, in fact, I owed my life to her. How could I then forget her?

'Months and years passed by. I never saw Turya or even her father again. She had promised to visit but never did. After my return from captivity, I had sent my wife to her mother's home. I felt that should Turya visit, I would appear a liar. But when three years went by and Turya did not come, I became free of my worry and asked my wife to return. Our days were happy again, when suddenly misery struck once more.

'One evening, as I sat on this veranda chatting with my wife, someone knocked. The servant opened the door and a Kabuli woman confidently sprinted up the stairs. She came to the upper floor and asked in pure Pashto, "Where is the Sardar Sahib?"

'Walking into the room, I asked, "Who are you and what do you want?"

'She fished out a few corals, "I have come to sell these. Would you buy them?"

'She placed the large stones on the table as she said this.

'My wife had followed me inside. She picked up the corals and began studying them. The Kabuli woman asked, "Sardar Sahib, who is this woman?"

'I answered, "My wife, who else?"

‘The woman shot back, “Your wife had died, so have you married again?”

‘Angrily, I said, “Be quiet, you fool, you must be the dead one yourself.”

‘My wife did not know Pashto, she was still lost in the corals.

‘But my words had a strange effect on the Kabuli woman. Her eyes glittered. In a shrill voice she pronounced, “Yes, if I was not a fool, I would not have freed you. Unfaithful dog, you lied to me. Here, if your wife was not dead, now she is.”

‘And even as she said this, she leapt up like a lioness and plunged a sharp dagger into my wife’s chest. I lunged to stop her but she jumped into the courtyard. “Now, recognize me, I am Turya. I had come here today to live with you. I wanted to marry you and become yours forever. I forsook my father, my home—everything—for your sake, but you are a liar, a scoundrel. From today you will weep for your wife, and I for you.” And she dashed down the stairs.

‘I rushed to my wife. The dagger had pierced her heart. One swift attack had ended her life. The doctor came but my wife was dead by then.’

Sardar Sahib’s eyes brimmed over. He wiped them and said, ‘Asad Khan, I could not even imagine in my dreams that Turya would be so diabolical. Had I understood this quickly enough, I could have averted this tragedy. But the room was dimly lit and I had already given up on her ever coming again.

‘Turya never came again. Now if ever she sees me, she walks by hissing like a snake. Whenever I see her, my soul shivers and I become completely helpless. Several times I have thought of handing her over to the authorities but I lose all control over my limbs in her presence, my courage seems to dissipate.

‘Not just that, Turya still nurses some affection for me. She always leaves precious gifts for my children. If she doesn’t meet them, she tosses the gifts inside and goes away. These are all wrapped in a piece of paper that says—For the Sardar Sahib’s children.

‘I have still not understood this woman. The more I try, the more complex everything seems. I do not know if she is human or a demon.’

Just then the Sardar Sahib's son came in to tell him, 'Look, that woman left this gold amulet just now.'

Sardar looked at me and said, 'Do you see that, Asad Khan, what I just told you. Now today she has left this amulet. I have lost count of the many charms and gifts she has left for Arjun and Nihal so far. I repeat again, Turya is a very strange woman.'

6

I took my leave of Sardar Sahib and began walking home. The old man's body had been removed from the town square. But my hair stood on end as I crossed the place. For a minute my feet halted at the spot of their own accord. I suddenly looked back. A woman was trailing me like a shadow. She stopped as soon as I did and began to make some purchases at a shop.

I questioned myself, *Is that Turya?*

My heart replied, *Yes, perhaps it is.*

Why is Turya following me? I reached home as I mulled over this, then ate my food and went to bed. But sleep evaded me. The incidents of the day were too overwhelming. The more I tried to sleep, the more it eluded my grasp.

The camp clock struck twelve, then one, two. But I lay awake. I turned this way and that. At some point during this tussle, sleep descended, but I do not know when.

Though I slept, my senses remained alert. I felt a woman, very much like Turya but far more terrifying, smash the wall and enter the room. She holds a sharp dagger that glints in the light of the lantern. She tiptoes towards me, her eyes darting this way and that. I want to rise up, but my limbs are paralysed. They seem lifeless. The woman comes close to me. She stares at me and then raises the dagger. I try to scream but choke. The words die in my throat. She pins down my hands under her knees and sits astride me. I struggled hard and my eyes flew open. There really was a Kabuli woman astride my chest. She held a dagger and was indeed trying to kill me.

I blurted out, 'Who are you? Turya?'

Indeed, it was Turya. She held me down and spat out, ‘Yes, I am Turya. Today you took my father’s life, in return you will have to lose yours.’

Turya raised her dagger. This was a moment of life or death for me. My thirst for life filled me with courage and I knew I was not prepared to die. My desires and pleasures remained to be fulfilled. I fought hard to free my right arm and managed it in a swift move. I gathered all my strength and grabbed the hand with which she held the dagger. I do not know why but Turya did not protest at all. She slid off my chest as she stared at my arm. Her eyes were stony but she did not take them off my arm.

I laughed, ‘Turya, the tables have turned. Now it is your turn to die. I killed your father and now I will kill you.’

She continued to stare at my arm and said nothing.

I shook her. ‘Why don’t you say something? Your life is in my hands.’

Her trance broke. In a firm voice, she said, ‘You are my brother. Today, you have killed your own father.’

I laughed.

Then I countered, ‘That the Afridis are also deceitful, I have just found out.’

She replied calmly, ‘You are Nazir, my long-lost elder brother. The tattoo on your arm convinces me that you are indeed my lost brother.’

I have had a snake tattooed on my arm since I was a child. It is this identity mark that is entered in the army registers.

I laughed again. ‘Turya, you cannot deceive me. I will not let go of you at all.’

She threw down the dagger and said, ‘You really are my brother. If you don’t believe me, then look at this, my right arm has the same tattoo.’

I looked at her right arm—yes, it was exactly the same snake.

I thought aloud. ‘Turya, this must be a coincidence, I cannot believe you.’

She responded, ‘Let go of my hand, I will not attack you. We Afridis don’t lie.’

I let go of her hand. She slumped down and looked at me again. A little later she asked, ‘Tell me, do you know of your parents?’

I shook my head. ‘No, I was brought up in the government orphanage.’

She stood up and said, ‘Then you most certainly are my elder brother Nazir. You got lost a year before I was born. Our parents had come to ambush the army and you were with them. Our mother was a great fighter. You were tied to her back as she fought. Just then a bullet hit her leg and she fell down unconscious. Somebody untied you and took you away. Our father carried our mother away on his shoulder but he could never find you. They looked everywhere, but there was no trace of you. Mother spoke of you very often. She had the same tattoo on her arm.’

She held out her arm again for me to see. I held the two snakes together. They were exactly the same, not a dot was different. I sat down on the cot, feeling despondent.

Turya sat by, lovingly wiping my forehead. She said, ‘Nazir, mother always believed that you were alive, that one day you would reunite with us.’

I had begun to believe her now. My heart insisted that what she was saying was true. I took a deep breath. ‘Turya, the man I killed today, was he truly our father?’

Her face clouded over. She said in a pained voice, ‘Yes, Nazir, that unfortunate soul was our father. Who knew that he would be butchered by his beloved son?’

She consoled me again, ‘Nazir, you did it unknowingly. I had become an orphan after our father was killed, but now that I have found you, I will overcome my sorrow. Nazir, don’t mourn this misfortune. How were you to know who your father was, or your mother? See, even I had come to kill you; I may even have killed you. But by God’s grace I saw our family tattoo. This is what God wanted for us.’

From Turya I found out that our father was called Haider Khan, and that he was the leader of an Afridi gang. When I discussed Sardar Himmat Singh with Turya, I found out that she had fallen in love with him. She had fought with our father and come to marry the Sardar Sahib. But anger and jealousy consumed her when she saw his wife, and she murdered the

woman. She had wanted to surprise him disguised as a Kabuli woman, before events took such an unfortunate turn.

I described Sardar Sahib's state of mind to her. She thought about it awhile and then said, 'No, that man is a liar and a fraud. I will not marry him. But for your sake I will forget the past. Bring his children here tomorrow, I will shower them with my love.'

The next morning my servant was startled to see Turya there. I told him, 'This is my sister.'

The servant refused to believe me. I told him my story in detail and sent him off to inquire about my father's dead body. He returned to say, 'The body is still lying at the police station.'

I explained everything in a letter addressed to the head constable and requested that the dead body be handed over to me. He granted my request immediately.

I sent another letter to the major, asking him to come over.

The major arrived and asked, 'What is it, Asad? Why the rush?'

I laughed, 'Major Sahib, my name is no longer Asad, my real name is Nazir.'

He looked at me, startled. 'Have you gone mad overnight?'

I laughed again. 'No, now listen to this. Turya is my own sister, and the man I killed yesterday was my father.'

Sardar Sahib looked as if the skies had fallen on him. His eyes widened in disbelief. 'Why, Asad, you will make me go mad.'

I held his hand. 'Come, Turya will tell you the whole story. She is waiting for you at my house.'

Sardar Sahib shuffled behind me. Turya stood up as she saw him; she smiled and said, 'Prisoner, sing that song again.' Sardar Sahib and I could not control our laughter when we heard this.

I made Sardar Sahib sit down and narrated everything to him in detail. He said, 'Nazir, now I will always call you that. I ask you for Turya's hand. I wish to marry her.'

I laughed in response. 'But you are a Hindu and we are Muslims.'

He laughed too. 'Soldiers have no religion.'

Turya piped up, ‘Sardar Sahib, I will not marry you. But yes, if you send your sons to me, I agree to become their mother.’

Sardar Sahib left with a light heart.

That evening, I, along with Sardar Sahib, Turya and all my camp-mates buried my father.

The sun was setting. As darkness spread gradually, Turya and I read the memorial prayer at our father’s grave.

Translated from the Hindi by Chandana Dutta



A Trip to the Hills

1

At daybreak Muhammad Gulbaaz Khan read the namaz, got dressed and told the maid to hail him a rickshaw. Shireen Begum asked, ‘Where are you off to so early?’

Gulbaaz replied, ‘Just to pay my respects to the *chhote* sahib.’

Shireen advised, ‘Why don’t you walk? It’s not far.’

‘You wouldn’t understand.’

‘What’s the harm in walking there, is all I’m saying. The rickshaw-wala will charge at least a rupee.’

‘A magistrate never pays the fare. I’ll fine him if he dares to ask.’

‘You’re not even a magistrate’s assistant.’

‘How would anyone know? Do magistrates have horns or tails? A magistrate’s friend is just as good as a magistrate. Am I a fool to put all my work aside to wait on the magistrate? Why do you think subordinates in the police pay me their respects? The gift the police inspector sent yesterday—why did he send it? Am I his son-in-law? No, they’re all scared of me.’

The maid got him a rickshaw. Khan Sahib tied his headscarf and left. Shireen said, ‘Hey, at least eat your paan!’

‘Why don’t you put some mehendi on my hands too? My good woman, you don’t chew paan when you meet the magistrate.’

‘When will you be back? You’ll eat here, right?’

‘Don’t worry about my lunch, I may go to Kunwar Sahib’s house. If somebody comes asking for me, tell them I’ve gone to meet the magistrate.’

Khan Sahib then got into his rickshaw.

The rickshaw-wala asked, ‘Where to, Sir?’

‘The magistrate’s bungalow. I need to go there on official work.’

‘How long will Sir take there?’

‘I can’t say now. If the sahib insists I sit with him, I can’t just get up and leave, can I? It’s official work, who knows how long it’ll take? He’s a good man, poor guy. Doesn’t dare refuse what I ask of him. A man shouldn’t be proud. Pride is the devil’s work. I’ve issued notices to many police officers. If I see one troubling the poor, he’s had it.’

‘The police are thieves. They make you work all the time, midnight or morning. We’re robbed to death. Then there are soldiers at every corner, asking for money. Don’t pay up, they’ll fine you.’

‘I know all about it. I may be sitting in my hut but I can see the whole world. Listen, don’t take the rickshaw into the bungalow compound. Stop at the gate outside.’

‘All right, Sir. There you go, a soldier standing at the kerb. He’ll ask for money. If I don’t pay up, he’ll shout at me. But I swear by the Koran, I’ll tell him off today. Sir is sitting here, what can he do?’

‘No, no, I don’t fight with riff-raff over petty matters. Give him the money. I’ll take his case later. If I don’t get him suspended . . . but to abuse and argue face-to-face—no. I don’t fight with commoners.’

The rickshaw-wala also thought this sensible. At the kerb, he gave the soldier money. The rickshaw reached the magistrate’s bungalow. Khan Sahib got down and, like a sharp-eyed hunter, tiptoed in and stood on the veranda. There was a servant sitting there. Gul, as soon as he saw him, saluted.

The servant said, ‘Sir, you embarrass me. I should salute you but instead you raise your hand before I can.’

‘Who cares about these customs? In God’s eyes, everyone’s equal.’

‘What a thought! May Allah keep you safe, Sir. That’s the truth, but man gets too big for his boots. Even minor officials halt, waiting for me to salute them. Shall I tell the sahib you’ve come?’

‘If he’s resting, let it be, I’m in no hurry.’

‘No, Sir, he finished breakfast long ago, he must be reading the paper.’

‘It’s your job, do as you see fit. It’s your task to determine if the occasion is suitable. What’s happened with your daughter, is she all right?’

‘Yes, Sir, she’s very well. Ever since you called her in-laws over and scolded them, nobody’s bothered her. My daughter blesses your life and your estate.’

The servant informed his master of Khan Sahib’s visit and in a trice, Khan Sahib was taking off his shoes, standing in front of him. After saluting him, he sat on the floor. The magistrate’s name was Carton.

Carton exclaimed, ‘Oh! Oh! What are you doing? Please, please sit on the chair.’

‘I’m fine, Sir. I can’t sit with you, after all. You’re the king, I’m just a commoner.’

‘No, no, you’re my friend.’

‘Sir may proclaim me a rising sun, but I know where I stand. I’m not one of those guys who, having hobnobbed a little with his superiors, can’t keep his feet on the ground, and considers himself their equal.’

‘Khan Sahib, you’re a very good man. Five days from now, I leave for Nainital. I’ll meet you once I’m back. You must’ve been there many times. All the rich people go there.’

Khan Sahib hadn’t even been to Bareilly, let alone Nainital, but how could he now say he’d never been there? Wouldn’t he fall in the magistrate’s esteem? This man isn’t rich, he’d think, he’s just a peasant. So he said, ‘Yes, Sir, I’ve been many times.’

‘You’ve been many times? Well, I’m going for the first time. I’ve heard it’s a lovely place.’

‘It’s a big city, Sir, but not that big.’

‘Where do you put up? Hotels there will be expensive.’

‘Don’t ask, Sir, sometimes here, sometimes there. You might say, I have friends everywhere.’

‘Could you write a letter asking someone to arrange accommodation for me? I want to travel frugally. Better yet, why don’t you come along with me?’

Khan Sahib was in real trouble. There was no way out. He had to say, ‘As you wish, Sir, I shall go with you. But I must go now, I’m getting late.’

‘Oh! No problem, I can wait a week for you. Okay, goodbye. Tell your friend to arrange our accommodation today. Seven days from now, you and I shall go together. I’ll meet you at the railway station.’

Khan Sahib saluted him and went out. To the rickshaw-wala, he said, ‘Take me to Kunwar Shamshersingh’s bungalow.’

2

Kunwar Shamshersingh was born into a wealthy family. He hadn’t yet been touched by the lifestyle of the British. He slept till ten in the morning, then chatted with some friends and cronies, ate at two, then slept again, went to the chowk in the evening to get some fresh air and once back, watched a houri’s *mujra*. He didn’t have a clue about what was happening in the world. If he did, it was through his friends. Khan Sahib was one such friend.

By the time Khan Sahib reached the bungalow, it was ten. Kunwar Sahib had woken up and his friends had also assembled. Seeing Khan Sahib, Kunwar Sahib asked, ‘Where’ve you been, Khan Sahib?’

‘I’ve just been to see the magistrate. He’d been asking me to visit for many days, but I just didn’t have the time. Today, his attendant dragged me over there. What could I do, I had to go. I couldn’t have sent him away, after all.’

‘Man, I don’t know what spell you cast on the officers. Whoever comes here takes to you immediately. Why don’t you teach me your tricks?’

‘I myself don’t know why the magistrate is so fond of me. You won’t believe it, as soon as he heard my voice, he came and stood at the door, and

pulled me into his favourite chair.'

'Into his favourite chair?'

'Yessir, I was taken aback, but I had to sit in it. Then he asked for a cigar to be brought, cloves, dry fruits, tea, one after the other. A feast. The hospitality astonished me.'

'It turns out they know how to cultivate a friendship.'

'Come on! Is a man your friend because he's fed you well? Now he's insisting I go to Nainital with him. It's too much!'

'Really?'

'I swear by the Koran. I was taken by surprise. I didn't know what to say. But when I realized he wouldn't budge, I had to give him my word. We're leaving this day next week.'

'Do you think he'd mind if I came along?'

'That'd be great, what could be better?'

'People say all sorts of things about Nainital, I'm a bit scared to go there. You must've been already?'

'Many times. But it's been a while.'

'One must get out of breath climbing the slopes, isn't it?'

Radhakant Vyas said, 'My dear Sir, if you have to climb, you'll manage somehow, but the water in the hills is bad, once it strikes, it doesn't stop till it kills you. Nobody who goes to Badrinath returns alive and all of those who do, have diarrhoea.'

Kunwar said, 'Yes, I've heard the water in the hills is terribly unclean.'

Lala Sukhdayaal sighed. 'Hadn't Gosaiji also cursed the water. . .'

Laagat ati paharh par paani
Barh dukh hawat na jai bakhani
Water in the hills gives one trouble
Words cannot describe the pain it causes.

Gulbaaz Khan said, 'Then why do all these Englishmen go there, Sir? They are careful with their time. Not a thing they do is without benefit. If a trip to the hills was not beneficial, why would they go there, think about it.'

Vyas replied, ‘This is the kind of thinking that’s driving our rich to ruins. Before their very eyes, they see the destruction of their wealth, the destruction of their dharma, the destruction of their strength, yet we don’t open our eyes.’

Lala added, ‘My father once went to the hills with an Englishman. When he got back, he made me swear never to go to the hills. He must’ve seen something, or why would he have made me swear it?’

Wajid said, ‘Sir, if Khan Sahib is going, let him go, I wouldn’t advise you to go. Think about it, you will have to climb fathoms, and the road is so dangerous, may God shelter you! A narrow trail and on both sides chasms fathoms deep. A man looks down and, shivering out of fright, he falls, and if the rocks catch fire, well, he’s breathed his last. He’ll be burnt into a kebab.’

Khan: ‘And the lakhs of people who live on the hills?’

Wajid: ‘That’s different, brother.’

Khan: ‘Different how? Aren’t they men too?’

Wajid: ‘Lakhs of people plough their fields, wield spades, cut wood, but would you? Do you have it in you? Can you climb those heights?’

Khan: ‘Why not? We’ll use carts.’

Kunwar: ‘A cart! I can’t. If the horse rears, we’re done for.’

Lala: ‘If you fall, even your bones won’t be found.’

Vyas: ‘Your very soul will be ground to bits.’

Wajid: ‘My dear Sir, when a man looks down from a great height, he starts shivering, forget climbing up the hill.’

Kunwar: ‘Isn’t there a protective brick wall on the sides of the road?’

Wajid: ‘How can there be a brick wall on a steep road?’

Kunwar: ‘It’s not man-made.’

Lala: ‘I’ve heard goitre is widespread there.’

Kunwar: ‘Oh boy! That’s a bad disease. If that’s the case, I won’t even consider going there.’

Khan: ‘Ask Lala Sahib why the white sahibs who go there don’t catch goitre.’

Lala: ‘They drink brandy. Can we live like that?’

Wajid: ‘I don’t believe Khan Sahib’s ever been to Nainital. He’s bragging. Yes, Sir, how long were you there for?’

Khan: ‘I lived there for about four years.’

Wajid: ‘Which locality did you reside in?’

Khan: (Suddenly nervous) ‘What? Me?’

Wajid: ‘Yes, where did you stay for all of the four years?’

Khan: ‘I’ll tell you when it comes to me.’

Wajid: ‘Get lost. You’ve never even set eyes on Nainital . . . boasting you’ve stayed there four years!’

Khan: ‘Okay, if you like. I’ve never been to Nainital. Are you happy now?’

Kunwar: ‘Why don’t you tell us where you stayed in Nainital?’

Wajid: ‘He’d tell us if he’d ever been there.’

Khan: ‘I said I’ve never been there. End of conversation. Now tell me, Kunwar Sahib, do you want to come or not? Everything they’re saying is true. There’s goitre in the air, the water there is bad, the food causes indigestion, every day five to ten people fall into the gorges. What’s your decision now? The pleasures you can enjoy there, you can’t even dream of here. The magistrate—whom you cannot meet even if you stand at his door for hours here—will be your companion every hour of the day there. Nowhere else can you enjoy boating across the jheel with young women. Think: you’ll be friends with hundreds of Englishmen. In three months there, you can earn a reputation that you wouldn’t be able to in your whole life here. That’s it. What else can I say?’

Kunwar: ‘Will I be able to become friends with eminent Englishmen there?’

Khan: ‘My dear Sir, you’ll have to attend so many dinners, you won’t have time to breathe.’

Kunwar: ‘I’d like to see it at least once.’

Khan: ‘Well then, get ready.’

When the assembly saw that the Kunwar Sahib was ready to go to Nainital, they started agreeing with him.

Vyas: ‘You sometimes see yogis in the hills.’

Lala: ‘Yes, I’ve heard you see yogis over two hundred years old. If they deign to look at you, then your life is made!’

Wajid: ‘But, Sir, if you go, go in such style that the people there say, it’s a rich man from Lucknow.’

Lala: ‘Take Laxmi the elephant along. Nobody will have ever seen an elephant’s face there. When you, Sir, ride on it, and when the colourful howdah shines, people will be stunned.’

Vyas: ‘If you have a drum, even better.’

Kunwar: ‘No, I don’t think a drum is advisable. When in Rome, you must do as the Romans do.’

Lala: ‘Yes, even I wouldn’t suggest taking a drum. But you should at least tie a bell round the elephant’s neck.’

Khan: ‘Well then, wire a friend, asking him to book us a bungalow. The magistrate can also stay with us.’

Kunwar: ‘Why would he stay with us? He’s a magistrate, after all.’

Khan: ‘Getting him to stay with us is my responsibility. I’ll push, I’ll pull, I’ll manage it somehow.’

Kunwar: ‘If I get a chance to stay with him, it would be a charmed journey indeed.’

3

A week passed. Travel preparations were made. At daybreak, Carton Sahib’s letter arrived—Will you come to my place or shall we meet at the station? Kunwar Sahib ordered that a letter be sent—You can come here. It’s on the way to the station. I’ll be ready. Having got the letter written, when Kunwar Sahib went into the inner room, he saw his sister-in-law, Rameshwari Devi, sitting there. She saw him and said, ‘Is it true you’re going to Nainital?’

‘Yes, leaving tonight.’

‘Oh! Tonight! It can’t be. It’s the child’s *mundan* tomorrow. What will people do if you are absent?’

‘Then why didn’t you tell me earlier? If I’d known, I’d have planned the trip on some other day.’

‘What’s the big deal? If not tomorrow, you can leave in two to four days.’

Kunwar Sahib’s wife, Susheela Devi, said, ‘Yes, why don’t you leave after two to four days, it isn’t as if there’s an auspicious time.’

Kunwar said, ‘Ah! I’ve promised the chhote sahib, he’ll come to pick me up tonight. What will he think?’

Rameshwari said nonchalantly, ‘Such promises are made to be broken. You haven’t sold yourself to him, have you?’

‘I can’t tell you how helpless I am! I’ll have to suffer real shame.’

‘As if the chhote sahib is everything, and I nothing.’

‘But what do I tell him, what excuse do I make?’

‘Tell him it’s your nephew’s *mundan*, you can’t travel this week. That’s it.’

‘How easily you’ve solved the problem. Is it that easy? I won’t be able to show my face anywhere.’

Susheela said, ‘Why isn’t it easy? Are you his slave?’

Kunwar retorted, ‘You hardly get out of the house. What do you know about how the British think?’

Rameshwari said, ‘Oh God! Does he not have a son, a child, is he a monad? Everybody has festivals—Hindus, Muslims . . . everybody!

‘I can’t get out of this.’

‘I won’t let you go. Period. If you go, I’ll be very sad. All of you add lustre to the occasion, who else do we have?’

‘I can’t even write to him now. He must have left for work. I’ve packed my luggage too. Even paid the servants and told them to get ready to leave. How can I stay now?’

‘Whatever it is, you can’t go.’

Susheela was incensed. ‘Why the big fuss about going after four or five days? Is the king himself waiting there to greet you?’

Kunwar Sahib was in a quandary. If he didn’t go, he wouldn’t keep his word to the magistrate. What a boor, he’d think to himself. If he went, he’d

get into a fight with his wife; the woman was clearly angry. He stepped out in this state. Wajid said to him, ‘You seem troubled.’

Vyas: ‘His face has lost its colour.’

Kunwar: ‘Don’t ask, man, big trouble.’

Wajid: ‘What’s the matter, tell us.’

Kunwar: ‘It’s a strange country.’

Vyas: ‘My dear Sir, in times long past, sages meditated here.’

Lala: ‘There’s no such country in the world, if you ask me.’

Kunwar: ‘Yes, fools like you cannot be found anywhere else in the world, totally untouched by intellect.’

Wajid: ‘Sir, we run after the intellect with a stick.’

Vyas: ‘My dear Sir, what do I say? It’s a pathetic situation.’

Kunwar: ‘I was ready to go to Nainital. Then sister-in-law pipes up, “It’s my child’s *mundan*, I won’t let you go, if you do, I’ll be heartbroken.” What do I do? Where else can you see such foolishness on display? The barber will cut his hair, there isn’t a dearth of people who’ll come and sing and dance. Who cares if I can’t attend? But who will get this into their heads?’

Vyas: ‘My lord, the obstinacy of women is famous all over the world.’

Kunwar: ‘Now think about what excuse I can make to the chhote sahib.’

Wajid: ‘It’s a thorny matter, Sir.’

Lala: ‘It isn’t wise to anger the magistrate.’

Wajid: ‘Even if the magistrate’s a lump of clay, he is still a magistrate.’

Kunwar: ‘I’m in real trouble now.’

Lala: ‘Now, don’t sit outside, Sir. That’s my suggestion. Whatever happens, we’ll manage.’

Wajid: ‘We’ll shed blood if need be, instead of sweat. I’m not joking, you’re our brother, after all!’

Kunwar: ‘Yes, I think that is wise. Say I’m sick.’

They were still chatting when a footman came panting and said, ‘Sir, there’s somebody at the door. He’s calling you, Sir.’

Kunwar: ‘Didn’t you ask him who he was?’

Footman: ‘Britisher, Sir, red-faced, sitting on a horse.’

Kunwar: Not the chhote sahib, I hope. I'm going inside. It's in your hands now.'

Kunwar Sahib went in and shut the door. Wajid Ali peeped out of the window and saw the magistrate standing there. He was petrified. Who will go and talk to him? Nobody dared, they all kept pushing one another.

Lala: 'Go ahead, Wajid Ali. See what he wants to say.'

Wajid: 'Why don't you go?'

Lala: 'He's just a man like you, he won't eat you up.'

Wajid: 'Then why don't you go?!'

Carton Sahib waited for two or three minutes. When nobody emerged, he said irritably, 'Hey! Tell Kunwar Sahib that Carton Sahib's waiting.'

Mr Wajid emerged terrified, went up to him and, with one hand in the other said, 'Good Sir, Kunwar Sahib ate very late today, he's feeling unwell. He's resting right now, he can't come out.'

Carton: 'Oh! What're you saying? He was going to come to Nainital with me. He'd written me a letter.'

Wajid: 'Yes, Sir, he was going, but he fell sick.'

Carton: 'That's sad.'

Wajid: 'A coincidence, Sir.'

Carton: 'That's unfortunate. Tell Kunwar Sahib I want to meet him.'

Wajid: 'He cannot come out, Sir.'

Carton: 'No problem, I'll go in.'

Stuck to the door, Kunwar Sahib was listening to Carton and Wajid's conversation with bated breath. Seeing Carton Sahib get off his horse and come towards the door, he scrambled to Susheela and said, 'The bastard's coming home to see me. I'll lie down on the charpoy. Have a quilt taken out and cover me. Bring five or ten vials and keep them on this round table here.'

He'd just finished speaking when Wajid Ali knocked on the door and called out to the maid, 'Open the door, Sir wants to see Bahadur Kunwar Sahib.' Susheela asked for a quilt but it was summer, and the winter clothes were packed inside boxes. Opening a box hastily, she took out two or three thick quilts and wrapped Kunwar Sahib in them. Then she took many vials

and many bottles out of the cupboard, kept them on the table and said to the maid, ‘Open the gate, I’ll go up.’

As soon as Carton Sahib reached the room, Kunwar Sahib stuck his head out of the quilt and, moaning, said, ‘What suffering, Sir! My whole body’s on fire.’

Carton: ‘You were fine till the afternoon. Khan Sahib told me you were ready. Where does it hurt?’

Kunwar: ‘Sir, I’ve got a terrible stomach ache. I feel as though I won’t survive it.’

Carton: ‘I’ll go call the civil surgeon. He’ll cure you in a trice. Don’t fear, he’s a friend of mine.’

Carton left, Kunwar Sahib came and sat outside. He’d bitten off more than he could chew. Now he worried about how to stave off the civil surgeon.

Kunwar: ‘Man, here is a new problem.’

Wajid: ‘Now, Sir, even I can’t think of a solution.’

Kunwar: ‘Somebody go call Khan Sahib. Tell him to come immediately. He’ll take his time and we’ll find the civil surgeon sitting on our head.’

Lala: ‘The civil surgeon’s fee must also be high?’

Kunwar: ‘My dear man, my life’s in trouble, and you’re concerned about the fee. If I can get rid of him by paying him a couple of hundred bucks, I’d consider myself lucky.’

Wajid Ali got the phaeton ready and reached Khan Sahib’s house. He saw that he was packing his stuff. He told him the whole story and said, ‘Now come quick. He’s asked for you.’

Khan: ‘This is a knotty situation. We’ll have to put our shoulder to the wheel. I swear to God, all of you deserve to be shot. I got a little late and you ruined the whole game.’

Wajid: ‘Khan Sahib, don’t get annoyed with us. Kunwar Sahib is dazed. It’s a matter of two to four hundred bucks. Come, you tell the civil surgeon it’s nothing.’

Khan: ‘Let’s go. Maybe I’ll be able to think of something.’

Both of them walked towards the civil surgeon's bungalow. There, they learnt the civil surgeon had already left for Kunwar Sahib's house. They turned the phaeton around immediately and reached Kunwar Sahib's bungalow. They saw the surgeon sitting in front of Kunwar Sahib's charpoy with an enema.

Khan: 'I'm coming from your bungalow, Sir. How are you, Kunwar Sahib?'

Doctor: 'He's got a stomach ache. I'll give him an injection and he'll be fine.'

Kunwar: 'Sir, the pain's gone now. I feel this pain only sometimes and then it goes on its own.'

Doctor: 'Ah! You're scared. There's nothing to be scared of. You'll be fine in a minute.'

Kunwar: 'Sir, I'm perfectly fine. No complaints now.'

Doctor: 'Nothing to be scared of, let all these guys leave the room, I'll cure you in a trice.'

Khan Sahib said in the doctor's ear: 'Sir, take your night fee and the fare for the cart and leave, don't take these rich buggers seriously, they're ill all twelve months. For a week, come every day, see how he is.'

The doctor understood. He promised to return on the morrow and left. They'd escaped. People started praising Khan Sahib's wiliness.

Kunwar: 'Khan Sahib, you always come to the rescue. I'll be grateful to you my whole life.'

Khan: 'Sir, I had to shell out two hundred rupees. He was saying it's the chhote sahib's order and that he wouldn't leave without giving you the injection. You know the British. If they give somebody their word, they keep it.'

Kunwar: 'You also told him, I hope, to intimate the chhote sahib of my illness and to tell him—he's in no position to travel.'

Khan: 'Yes, Sahib, what else did I pay him for then? Is he my relative? But the magistrate will be greatly upset. Because you had promised that bungalow, the poor fellow hadn't even booked a hotel. It's a mess.'

Kunwar: 'What could I have done, man, think about it.'

Khan: ‘Your plan backfired. When Carton Sahib came here, you should’ve met him. Told him clearly, I have to be here, it’s an emergency. Anyway, I’ll be with him, we’ll figure something out.’

Kunwar: ‘Are you still thinking of going? I swear I won’t let you go, who knows how things will pan out here, or won’t. Miyan Wajid, please inform the people at his house that he won’t be travelling today.’

Khan: ‘You want to take me down with you. If the chhote sahib is angry with you, big deal, but if he’s angry with me, he can cause a lot of damage.’

Kunwar: ‘Till I’m alive, my friend, nobody will dare cast an evil eye on you. Tell the chhote sahib, “Kunwar Sahib is not well, I can’t come with you.” That’ll put me in the clear. And seeing how true a friend you are, he’ll respect you even more.’

Khan: ‘Whether he respects me or not, when you’re repeatedly entreating me, I’m not so ill-mannered as to leave you and go. I can’t do it. I had gone home for only a little while and look at the price we had to pay. If I go to Nainital, somebody might kidnap you.’

Kunwar: ‘We’ll enjoy ourselves watching these programmes for four days. There’s no such fun in Nainital. Vyasji, we can’t keep sitting around like this. See if you have a few bottles lying around, let’s have some fun.’

Translated from the Hindi by Anirudh Karnick



Mother

1

The prisoner is returning home today. Karuna had cleaned and painted the house the previous day. All the money saved during the three years of hardship was spent to welcome her husband. She had made a new pair of dhotis and kurtas for her husband and managed to get a coat and a new cap for her child. She kept hugging her child, and felt comforted. If this child had not illuminated her dark world, God knows when her hardships would have ended her life. She had given birth to her son only three months after her husband had been jailed. Karuna had survived these three years only because of her son's presence. She would think—*How happy he will feel when I show him his son's face. He may get shocked first but then he will take him in his lap and say, 'Karuna, you have pleased me with this gift.' Hearing the boy's lisping talk, he will forget all the suffering of his prison days. His one pure, innocent and delightful glance will take away all the grief from his heart.* Her joy knew no bounds while imagining this.

She thought—*Many people might accompany Aditya. When they will reach the door, the sky will reverberate with the echoes of celebratory slogans. That would be a heavenly sight.* Karuna had spread a torn rug for those men to sit on. She had prepared paan as well. She would keep looking at the door with hopeful eyes. The firm, strong and radiant image of her

husband continuously flickered before her eyes. She was constantly reminded of his words, his patience and his confidence, which was firm even when the police attacked him. She cherished his smiling face, the pride that radiated from his face even when he was arrested. Was it possible for Karuna's heart to forget it? The mere thought of him would light up her depressed face. It was this image that had reassured her during the three years of hardship. Many nights passed without food. Often there was nothing at home to light the fire for. But the tears of scarcity never moistened her eyes. Today all those hardships were going to end. She could endure every hardship cheerfully if her husband's love and closeness was ensured. After getting this everlasting happiness, she would have no other desires.

The sun was setting. It was as if a golden carpet decorated with white flowers had been spread across the dark sky. At the same time Karuna saw somebody walking with a stick—like a shadow of a tattered man—coughing at every step. His head was hung low, so Karuna could not see his face, but from his gait he seemed to be an old man. The moment he came closer, Karuna recognized him. He was her beloved husband. But he looked different. His youth, agility, robustness and strength were no more. A mere skeleton remained. He was alone, with no friend or well-wishers around. Karuna came out the moment she recognized him but buried the desire to embrace him in her heart. All her planning had failed and all her excitement was washed away in tears.

As Aditya entered the house, he smiled at Karuna. However, that smile was full of agony. Karuna stiffened as if her heart had stopped beating. She was staring at her husband in shock, as if she could not believe her eyes. She was so stunned that she was unable to greet him or express her grief. Even the child was looking at him with frightened eyes and clinging to his mother.

At last she exclaimed anxiously, 'What has happened to you? It is difficult to recognize you.'

Aditya smiled and soothed her, 'Nothing! It's just that I have become a little weaker. I will regain my health once I start eating the food cooked by

your hands.'

'Ah! You have been reduced to a mere carcass. Don't they provide adequate food there? You would say political prisoners are treated well. And where are your comrades? The ones who would surround you all the time, those who were even ready to die for you!'

Aditya frowned. He said, 'It was a very bitter experience, Karuna. I never knew people would turn away from me the moment I was arrested. Nobody cares. This is the reward given to people who sacrifice their lives for the nation. I never knew this. Although I was aware that people forget their leaders soon, the experience of your own comrades and friends abandoning you was new to me. But I harbour no grudge against anyone. Service is a reward in itself. It was my mistake to expect name and fame from it.'

'Don't they even provide food?' Karuna asked with concern.

Aditya replied, 'Don't ask, Karuna. It's a sad tale. I am grateful that I returned alive. I was destined to meet you. Otherwise, the hardships I faced there should have ended my life. Let me lie down now. I can no longer stand. I've travelled the whole day to reach here.'

'Come and eat something first and lie down comfortably later. (Lifting the boy in her lap) Son, he is your *babuji*, your own babuji. Go to him. He will embrace you.' Karuna encouraged the boy.

Aditya looked at the boy with tearful eyes. It seemed as though the boy was an embodiment of reproach for Aditya. Never before had he felt so sad because of his pitiable condition. If he recovered fully by God's blessings, he would never be a part of any national struggle. He had no right to beget this child only for him to be left to hardships. Now he would earn money and live a simple life devoted wholly to the upbringing of his child. That moment he felt like the boy's eyes were blaming and questioning him, 'What filial responsibilities have you fulfilled?' He became impatient to embrace the child but failed because his body lacked strength.

Lifting the child, Karuna stood up and brought some food in a thali. Aditya stared at the thali eagerly as if he had not been offered food for many days. He knew that he should control himself as he had not eaten for a long time, but he became impatient and pounced on the thali. In no time

he finished everything. Karuna felt uneasy. She did not ask him if he wanted more, and carried away the thali. Inwardly she thought, *He would never eat so much.*

Karuna was feeding the child when, all of a sudden, she heard her name being called. 'Karuna!'

Karuna rushed to Aditya and asked, 'Were you calling me?'

Aditya looked pale. He was breathless. He had crawled to a rug to lie down. Karuna asked nervously, 'Should I call a doctor?'

Aditya said, 'It's futile, Karuna. Now I can't hide this from you. I'm suffering from consumption. I have escaped death many times. Death could not take me before I saw you. Oh dear, please don't weep.'

Karuna suppressed her sobs and said, 'I will fetch the doctor immediately.'

Aditya refused again, 'No, Karuna, just sit by my side. There is no hope now. Doctors are helpless. I wonder how I managed to reach here. Who knows what divine power was leading me? Oh! I have been unjust to you. I will regret this forever. I could not give you any comfort. I couldn't do anything for you. Ah! I could only leave you widowed and that too with the burden of nurturing a child.'

Karuna hardened her heart. 'Are you in pain? Should I prepare a fire? Why are you silent?'

Aditya turned over and said, 'Dear, there is no need to do anything. I am not feeling any pain. I feel like my heart is sinking, as if I am drowning in deep waters. My life is ending. I can feel the dimming of my life's lamp. I can't say when my voice will fail me. I want to say whatever I need to right now. I don't want to go with any craving. If I ask you one question, will you answer me?'

It seemed as if all the debility, sorrow and weakness in Karuna's mind had vanished and been replaced with a strength that mocks death and laughs at tragedy. The way a sharp sword hides within a beautiful, jewel-encrusted scabbard, a tremendous power resides within smooth flowing water, courage, strength and patience lie within a delicate woman. Just like anger

brings the sword out of the scabbard, scientists harness the power of water, love brings out the strength and patience of a woman.

Caressing her husband, Karuna replied, 'Why don't you ask, dear?'

Feeling her soft touch, Aditya asked, 'What do you think of the life I have led? Is it praiseworthy? Look, you have never kept me in dark. Be honest now. Do you think I should be proud of my life or regret it?'

Karuna replied with exuberance, 'Dear, why do you ask such a question? Have I ever ignored you? Your life is like that of a saint's—selfless, detached and ideal. How many times have I tried to shift your focus from your political life to worldly things? Even then I knew I was lowering your status. I *would* have been happier if you had attached more importance to wealth. But my soul would never have felt the pride and happiness that it is feeling now. If I have to give my best blessing to someone, it would be that he live his life as you have lived.'

Karuna's face glowed while saying this, as if she had acquired an aura of divinity. Aditya looked at Karuna proudly and said, 'Enough, Karuna. I am contented now. Karuna, I am not worried about this child now. I am leaving him in the most capable hands in the world. I believe that your high ideals and piety will remain with you always. Now I am ready to die.'

2

After Seven Years

Little Prakash had now grown into a handsome, strong boy of ten. He was sharp, courageous, fearless and high-minded. Karuna's agonized heart would delight when she looked at him. No matter how unfortunate and pitiable Karuna was in the eyes of the whole world, her eyes never betrayed tears of misfortune. She sold all her jewels, which had been dearer to her than her life when her husband had been alive, and bought cattle with that money. She was a farmer's daughter and looking after cattle was not new to her. She made it her means of livelihood. Where is pure milk easily available? All her milk was sold out in no time. Karuna had to work day

and night but she was happy. Her face never looked depressed or sad. Instead, she glowed with courage and conviction and exuded confidence. Her eyes had a divine quality about them—solemn, unfathomable and gleaming. Prakash's presence took away all the woes of widowhood.

She loved Prakash dearly. He constituted her entire world. She was ready to sacrifice all her desires and even her peace for him. But she could not turn a blind eye to his misdemeanours. She monitored his conduct strictly. She was not only Prakash's mother, but his father as well. Her love for Prakash was full of both a mother's tenderness and a father's guidance. The last words of her husband were still echoing in her ears. The image of her husband, full of pride and contentment, still flickered before her eyes. She always felt his presence. She would feel that Aditya's soul was constantly protecting her. It was her utmost desire that Prakash should follow in the footsteps of his father.

It was evening. A woman came begging at the door. Karuna was giving water to the cows. Prakash was playing outside. He was just a child. He suddenly thought of a naughty plan. He went inside and came out with a bowl of chaff. She lifted the hem of her sari and Prakash emptied the bowl of chaff in that. Clapping loudly he ran away.

The beggar retorted with burning eyes, 'Oh naughty brat! Are you making fun of me? Is this what your parents have taught you? If so, you will bring great fame to your family.'

Karuna overheard her and asked, 'What happened, *maata*? Who are you talking to?'

The beggar pointed towards Prakash and said, 'Your son emptied a bowl of straw in the hem of my sari. It got mixed with the little amount of flour I had and turned that useless too. Who torments the poor like this? The days of prosperity are not always permanent. One should not be too proud.'

Karuna called sternly, 'Prakash.'

Prakash didn't flinch. He came proudly to her and said, 'Why has she come begging at our house? Why doesn't she work?'

Trying to make him understand, Karuna said, 'Instead of feeling shame you are behaving rudely.'

‘Why should I feel ashamed? Why does she come to beg every day? Do we get things for free?’ Prakash was unrepentant.

‘If you didn’t want to give her anything, you could have said that. But what was the need for this mischief?’ asked Karuna.

‘How would she quit her begging habit then?’ Prakash argued.

‘Now I will beat you,’ Karuna said angrily.

‘Why should I be beaten? That will be high-handedness on your part. In other countries, people are jailed if they beg. Beggars are never encouraged.’

‘How can handicapped people work?’

‘Let them drown themselves. They have no right to live.’

Karuna was speechless. She gave the old woman some flour and pulses. But Prakash’s warped argument hurt her. *Where had he learnt such cruelty and arrogance?* This thought bothered her the entire night.

Prakash woke up all of a sudden at midnight. The lantern was lit and Karuna was weeping. He stood up and asked her, ‘Amma, haven’t you slept yet?’

Karuna turned her face and said, ‘I couldn’t sleep. How did you wake up? Are you feeling thirsty?’

‘No, Amma, God knows how I woke up. I committed a grave mistake today, Amma.’

Karuna looked at him affectionately.

‘I misbehaved with the old woman today. Please forgive me. I will never repeat this.’

He started weeping. Karuna hugged him happily and kissed his cheeks. She asked him, ‘Son, are you saying all this to please me or do you really regret it?’

Prakash replied sobbing, ‘No, Amma, I am really ashamed. Now when the old woman comes again, I will give her a lot of money.’

Karuna was thrilled. She felt as if Aditya was standing there and blessing his child, and telling her, ‘Karuna, don’t be sad. Prakash will bring fame to his father. All your wishes will be fulfilled.’

3

But Prakash's deeds did not match what he had promised. As days passed, this aspect of his character became more prominent. Brilliant as he was, he won scholarships from the university. Karuna also tried her best to help him. But despite the scholarships, he failed to manage his expenses. He could have delivered scholarly lectures on the value of a frugal life, though his own life matched exactly with blind followers of fashion. He loved to show off. There was a conflict between his heart and intellect. His heart wanted to be altruistic but his intellect would direct him to selfishness. His reason would overpower his heart. Social service is akin to working on a barren field, the maximum one can yield is name and fame, which can be so momentary that one may in an instant lose everything that has been acquired in a lifetime. So his conscience was more inclined to a luxurious lifestyle. Gradually he even became resentful of ideas like sacrifice and social welfare. He lacked compassion and emotion. He was ruled by intellect, where there was no pain and mercy, just logic and reason.

There was a flood in Sindh. Thousands of men were ruined. The college sent a group of volunteers there to help the victims. Prakash was indecisive. 'Should I go or not?' If he spent these days preparing for his exams instead, he was likely to pass with a first division. When the group was leaving, Prakash said he couldn't go along because he was ill. Karuna wrote to him, 'I regret that you didn't go to Sindh. There were doctors in the group—you could have gone even if you were unwell.' Prakash did not reply to her letter.

Orissa was affected by famine. People were dying there like flies. The Congress organized a mission to serve the affected people. At that time the college authorities decided to send the history students to Lanka for a study tour. Karuna wrote to Prakash, 'You should go to Orissa.' But Prakash was eager to go to Lanka. He was indecisive for many days. Finally, Ceylon triumphed over Orissa. This time Karuna did not write to him. She just wept silently.

After returning from Ceylon, Prakash went home for his vacation. Karuna remained aloof. Prakash felt ashamed and resolved that the next time such an opportunity arose, he would certainly make his mother happy. With this resolution, he returned to college. But the moment he got there, he started worrying about his exams again. Even when the exams ended, Prakash did not go home. A teacher from his college was going on a tour to Kashmir and Prakash accompanied him. The results were declared and Prakash stood first. Feeling a little homesick, he wrote a letter to Karuna instantly and informed her that he was coming. In order to please his mother, Prakash wrote a few lines favouring social service. 'Now I am ready to work on your advice. I have decided to work in the field of education, as it is because of this field that I have acquired my present distinction. Even our leaders respect college teachers. They have not stopped respecting these degrees. They do not have as high a regard for skill, competence and devotion as they do for these degrees. Now they will respect me and entrust me with responsible tasks which would not have been given to me earlier even if I had asked.' Karuna was hopeful again.

4

As soon college reopened, Prakash received a registered letter in his name. It stated that Prakash had been granted a government scholarship to study in England. Holding the letter, Prakash went to his mother in excitement. 'Amma I have been granted a scholarship to study in England.'

Karuna asked indifferently, 'So what is your plan?'

'My plan? Who would waste such an opportunity?'

'But you were going to volunteer for social service.'

'So you think that one can serve the nation only as a volunteer? I can serve my nation even after returning from England. Amma, to be honest, a thousand volunteers cannot match the service that a single magistrate can render to his nation. I will appear in the civil service examinations and I believe I will succeed.'

Karuna asked in surprise, 'So you want to be a magistrate?'

‘An altruistic magistrate can serve a nation more than a thousand Congress chairpersons. Newspapers may not eulogize him, his speeches may not be loudly applauded, people may not follow his processions and college students may not salute him but only a magistrate can render genuine service.’

Karuna objected, ‘But the magistrates are the ones who give orders to punish and shoot volunteers.’

‘If social service drives a magistrate’s heart, he handles things peacefully instead of using bullets.’

‘I disagree. The government hardly grants such liberty to its servants. It formulates a policy which every government servant has to follow. The first policy of a government is to become more organized and decisive day by day and for that it is necessary to suppress independent thought. If a magistrate violates these rules, he can no longer stay in office. It was an Indian magistrate who sentenced your father to a three-year imprisonment for his minor involvement in the freedom struggle. He died because of this system. Son, I suggest you don’t go for these government jobs. I will be happier if you live meagrely while serving your country instead of becoming an officer and living luxuriously. Keep it in mind, the moment you sit on an officer’s seat, your mind will become like that of an officer. You will desire to become more famous and prominent among the officers. Take an ordinary example from rustic life. A girl believes that she belongs to her parental home till she gets married. But the moment she is married, the same home becomes a stranger’s home to her. All the members—mother, father, sister and brother—remain the same, but the home does not remain the same. This is the way of the world.’

Prakash protested, ‘So you want me to live a miserable life?’

Karuna looked at him sternly. ‘If suffering gives peace to the soul, then I believe it is good to suffer.’

Prakash asked with determination, ‘So, is this what you wish for me?’

Karuna replied in the same tone, ‘Yes, that’s all I wish for.’

Prakash did not reply. He stood up and went out. Instantly, he wrote a letter of refusal to the registrar. But from that moment he looked depressed.

He would stay in his room indifferent and apathetic. He would come and go out of the house with a long face. Months passed. His face lost its glow. His eyes became expressionless. He forgot how to smile. It was as if with that letter of denial, he had been denied the vitality, vigour and happiness of life. Karuna understood his emotions and tried her best to make him forget his sorrows but failed to please him.

Finally, she told Prakash, 'Son, if you are determined to go abroad, then go. I won't stop you. I now regret having stopped you. If I knew it would hurt you so much, I would never have done it. I did it only because your babuji would have been happy seeing you do social work. He expressed this wish in his final moments.'

Prakash replied curtly, 'How can I go now? I have already posted the letter of refusal. Who is waiting there for me now? They might have selected some other student. What are the options left for me now? You want me to wander about in the villages. So be it.'

Karuna's pride was shattered. She had wanted to stop him from going abroad but she'd failed. She said, 'They might not have selected anyone yet. Write to them that you are ready to go.'

Prakash said sullenly, 'Nothing can be done now. People will laugh at me. I have decided to live my life according to your principles.'

Karuna exhorted him, 'Had you decided this from your heart, you wouldn't have been like this. You are showing me passive resistance. How does it matter if you are fulfilling my wishes by suppressing your own innermost feelings? I would have been happy if the desire to serve had come to you naturally. Write a letter to registrar right now.'

'I can't write now.'

'So will you continue to live in this grief?'

'I am helpless.'

Karuna did not say anything further. After sometime Prakash saw her going somewhere, but he said nothing. It was normal for Karuna to go out. But when she did not return by evening, Prakash became worried. *Where had Amma gone?*

Prakash sat at the door the entire night. Many doubts disturbed his mind. Now he remembered how sad Karuna had looked while leaving. Her eyes were quite red. Why hadn't he seen all these things then? Why had he been blinded by his own self-interest?

Now Prakash remembered that Amma had been wearing clean clothes. She had an umbrella in one hand. Had she gone too far? Should he make inquiries? Prakash began to weep in anxiety.

It was a terribly dark night of Shravan. The clouds had covered the sky like a nightmare. Prakash gazed time and again towards these clouds as if Karuna was hiding behind them. He decided that he would start searching for his mother with the break of the dawn, and if . . .

Someone knocked at the door. Prakash ran and opened it to find Karuna standing there. She looked depressed and lifeless, as if her husband had just died again, as if she had lost everything, as if she was standing on a riverbank watching helplessly as the boat of her life sank in the river.

Prakash asked impatiently, 'Amma, where have you been? It has been so long.'

Karuna replied staring at the ground, 'My work took me long.'

She threw a sealed envelope at Prakash. Prakash took it curiously. It bore the stamp of the college. He opened it immediately and read. His face glowed. He asked, 'Where did you get this from, Amma?'

'I brought it from your registrar.'

'Did you go there?'

'What else could I have done?'

'But there was no train yesterday.'

'I hired a car.'

Prakash remained silent for a moment. Then he asked in an annoyed tone, 'Why are you sending me if you don't want to?'

Karuna replied indifferently, 'Because *you* want to go. I can't look at your depressed face. I sacrificed twenty years of my life for your well-being. I can't kill your ambitions now. I heartily wish you a successful journey.'

Karuna felt choked and could not speak any more.

5

From that day Prakash started making arrangements for his journey. Whatever money Karuna had was spent. She had to borrow some money as well. New suits were stitched. Suitcases were bought. Prakash was lost in his own world, continuously demanding something or the other.

Karuna became so weak in the same week that her hair turned white and wrinkles appeared on her face, but Prakash failed to notice all this. He could only imagine the scenes in England. Ambition blindfolds a person.

The day of departure arrived. The sun shone after many days. Karuna brought out the old clothes of her husband. His blanket, khadi kurtas, pyjamas and quilt were still preserved in a trunk. Every year they were exposed to sunlight, brushed and kept back. Karuna brought them out again this year, not to be kept back but to be distributed among the poor. Today she was unhappy with her husband. The mug, watch and thread, which Aditya had kept with him and Karuna had worshipped for twenty years were thrown into the courtyard. The bag that Aditya had slung across his shoulders was thrown in the dustbin. The picture at which Karuna had bowed her head was hurled recklessly to the ground. She did not want to keep any souvenir of her husband in her house. Her conscience was torn with sorrow and distress. Who else could she unleash her anger on? Who was her own now? With whom would she share her life? To whom could she lay bare her inner struggles? Would Prakash's father have been overjoyed at his success if he had been alive? Who would convince Prakash that his father would have equally regretted his decision?

Prakash's friends had thrown a farewell party today. He returned by evening in a car and put his luggage in the same car. Then he came inside and told his mother, 'Amma, I am leaving. I will write to you once I reach Bombay. Swear on me that you won't weep and you will answer my letters on time.'

Karuna felt like the relative of a deceased person who mourns and weeps bitterly when the corpse is taken out of the house. Her heart was wailing, which made every pore of her pitiable soul shiver. She felt like drowning.

She could not utter a single word of blessing or complaint. Prakash touched her feet, bathed them with his tears and went out. Karuna just stood like a statue.

Suddenly the milkman arrived and said, 'Bahuji, *bhaiya* went away. He was weeping bitterly.'

Then Karuna came back to her senses and found that there was nobody around her. A deathlike silence reigned in the house. She felt like her heart had stopped beating.

Suddenly Karuna's eyes turned upwards. She saw Aditya holding the dead body of Prakash in his arms. Karuna collapsed to the ground.

6

Although Karuna was alive, she was indifferent to this world. Her little world, which she had imagined in her heart, had vanished like a dream. Prakash, whose presence had made her hopeful and complete, despite her loneliness, was not around any more. Neither was there any shelter—not that it was required now. The cows she fed remained tied to the stakes, staring at the door in dejection. Nobody was there to caress the calves. For whom should she milk the cows? For whom should she prepare the curd and butter? Who was there to eat any of it? Karuna's world shrank further to just herself.

But then her life took a new turn after a week. Her small world expanded to become all-embracing. The anchor which had tied the boat to one spot of the bank was uprooted. Now the boat was free to sail in the boundless sea, even if it was destroyed in the stormy waves.

Karuna would sit at the door, gather all the children of her mohalla and give them milk. She churned butter till noon and the children would come and eat that. She prepared different dishes to feed the dogs. It was now her daily routine. Birds, dogs, cats and ants all were her own. Her door of love was open to all. The little space, which had been insufficient even for Prakash, accommodated the whole world now.

One day Karuna received Prakash's letter. She threw it away. After sometime, she tore it up and went to feed the birds. But when the nocturnal goddess forced her to take rest, Karuna's passion intensified. She craved to read Prakash's letter. She thought, *What relationship do I have with Prakash? What have I got to do with him?* The question echoed repeatedly in her mind—*Who is Prakash to me? Who is Prakash to me?* Her heart answered, *Prakash is everything to you. He is the token of your immortal love, which you had lost long ago. He is your soul, the light of your life.* Karuna collected all the scattered pieces of his letter, as if she was gathering her life. Each piece seemed to her a footprint of her lost love. When she collected all the pieces of the letter, she sat in front of the candle to join them like a recluse connecting the broken wires of love. Ah, this motherly affection! The unfortunate woman spent the whole night rearranging the pieces. As the letter was written on both sides, it was even more difficult to put the pieces together. A word or a sentence would be missing and she would have to start the search again. The whole night passed but the letter was still incomplete.

It was day again. The boys from the mohalla gathered to get milk and butter. Dogs and cats arrived too. Birds came hopping into the courtyard but Karuna was too busy with the letter to notice them.

It was afternoon. Karuna did not raise her head. She was neither thirsty nor hungry. Evening approached, but the letter was still incomplete. The meaning of the letter was slowly becoming clear—Prakash's ship was going from one place to another. Something was happening to her heart. What was it? Karuna failed to understand. Karuna wanted to read each word her son had written and lodge them in her heart.

Three days passed. It was evening. Her eyes, which had not closed for three days, fluttered a little. Karuna dreamt that there was a big room with tables and chairs arranged in it. A man was sitting at the centre on a high dais. Karuna looked keenly and found that it was Prakash.

Instantly a prisoner was brought to him—his hands and feet chained, and back bowed. It was Aditya.

Karuna's eyes opened wide and tears started flowing. She collected all the pieces of the letter again and burnt them to ashes. There was nothing left except a pinch of ash which was constantly hurting her heart. All the memories of her childhood, her agonized youth and her parched widowhood were reduced to this pinch of ash.

In the morning people found that her soul had flown from the cage of the body. Holding Aditya's picture close to her empty heart, her broken self finally found peace in the memories and the love of her husband. All this happened while Prakash was steadily sailing off to Europe.

Translated from the Hindi by Shaifta Ayoub



Mourning

When I do not have anything else to do—like watching children play, playing cards, fiddling with the harmonium or looking at the passers-by on the street—I flip through the day's newspaper. I am drawn to news with women at their centre, those which report on adulterous relationships, abduction, divorce or rape. I especially enjoy stories on rape.

Coincidentally I stumbled upon such a story yesterday. With uncanny excitement I asked the servant to prepare my chillum and was about to immerse myself in the pleasure, when all of a sudden I heard a shrill call from the door—'Babuji . . . ?'

The untimely, uninvited intervention surprised and irritated me. But it could be a letter or invitation. So I hesitantly decided to check who the visitor was and asked him, 'Why are you here? What do you want?'

He had no invitation or a list of invitees with him. This irked me further; hurling angry abuse in English I asked him why he was at my door, and waited for his response. The man stuttered reluctantly—'I have come from Babu Bhageerath Prasad's house. They are in mourning.'

Worriedly I asked, 'Who passed away?'

The man replied, 'I do not know that, Huzoor. I was only asked to pass on the sad news.'

He left immediately after the announcement but I had a whirlwind of questions in my head—Who could have died at that house? The woman

was not sick, nor was any child. Then who could it be? Oh yes! The woman was pregnant. The poor thing must have died of complications during childbirth. The family would be shattered. There were other small children. Who would raise them now? Above all, it would be such a pain to go to the river barefoot in this biting cold and take a dip in the freezing water, that too in the dead of the night. That would be like walking straight into the jaws of death.

I stood there dumbfounded by this thought. Then I went into the house, changed into a dhoti and took off barefoot to the house in mourning. When I reached Bhageerath's residence, the inside of the house was filled with the faint glow from a dying lamp. Many men in dhotis were seated on benches at the door.

I asked the dhoti-clad men, 'Do you know who has passed away in the house?'

One of them replied, 'No. We do not know. The barber only passed on the news of mourning. Maybe it is the woman. We should ask Bhageerath Lal. This wait is useless. We do not even know if they have ordered the shroud or arranged for the wood. The whole night is doomed.'

I garnered some courage and shouted from the door, 'Can we come in? Have you moved the body from the charpoy to the ground?'

In a minute Bhageerath appeared in a flannel kurta, carrying a plate of paan and cardamom. His mouth was full of paan. The mourners were stunned into silence. This was quite an unlikely observance of sorrow; no sign of a corpse, no shroud, no wailing. I was flustered. How do we ask him whose death we had come to mourn? It would be insensitive. But we had to know. So I mumbled with hesitation, 'Who . . . who exactly is dead? Why is there a delay in the funeral?'

Bhageerath slowly eased into a chair. 'Please be seated, enjoy a paan, I will answer all your questions.'

'Then please hurry, it is already night. Who is it?'

Bhageerath's expression changed. He started glumly, 'My happiness . . . the most beloved friend of mine, the foundation of my life, which I cherished more than my son, which is closer to me than my wife . . . it is

that happiness which I have lost with the birth of this child. It is hard to provide for two children, how am I going to fend for a third one? I have no means to hire a maid. My wife cannot leave all her other chores and look after this baby. So I will have to take care of it. My peace and happiness and those few minutes I had to myself are gone forever. This birth is not a moment of joy but an event of grief. I invited you all to share my grief. Forgive me for the inconvenience. You have come prepared for the holy dip in the Ganga. If you intend to carry the corpse on your shoulders for the funeral rites, please take my deck of cards and my game of *chausar*, too. May those be cremated in the pyre as well. Then I will take an oath with water from the Ganga in my hand that I will never be a fool again.'

We had a good laugh, enjoyed a sumptuous feast and returned to our homes.

But Bhageerath Prasad's words kept ringing in my ears.

Translated from Hindi by Rashmi C.P.



The Legal Eagle

Mr Qanooni Kumar, MLA, is sitting in his office amidst a pile of newspapers, magazines and reports. He has grown obese worrying about the problems that have beset his country. He crusades relentlessly to save it. There is a park in front of his house. Several boys are playing in it; some purdah-clad women can be seen as well. A few beggars squat along the fencing; a vendor is selling tea under a tree.

Qanooni Kumar: (Conferring with himself) 'The condition of this country is worsening. The government does absolutely nothing. Its only occupation is to feast and frolic. (Gazing at the park) Aah! These tender boys smoking cigarettes! Grief! What heart-wrenching grief! No one utters a word; no one even tries to stop such behaviour. Not a soul is aware of how poisonous tobacco really is, how much harm it can cause these children. (Looking at the Tobacco Report) *Uff!* My hair stands on end just thinking of it. Of all the young offenders, 75 per cent are cigarette addicts. This is a terrifying scenario. What can we do! No matter how many speeches we make, nobody pays attention. We must stop this with the law or else there will be untold damage. (Making a note) I must present a Tobacco Boycott Bill. I must do this as soon as the council reopens.'

(A moment later he turns to look at the park again and, seeing the purdah-clad women sitting around, lets out a deep sigh.)

‘Incredible, how incredible, the injustice of this all. What animal-like behaviour! These delicate-limbed beauties seem so disgusting, so uncouth wrapped up in their veils. This is the condition of the country! (Reading another report) The number of women dying is mounting. Tuberculosis is on the rise, delivery-related illnesses are storming up the scale, and we continue to lie back, relaxed, our eyes shut. Very soon this divine land of the rishis, this brave fertile mother of ours, will disappear under the ground, leaving no trace behind. And what does the government care? And the people—they have become so stone-hearted. They watch these horrors with their own eyes and yet are not surprised. This is what they call the paralysis of death. We need the law here as well. We should impose a law so that no woman is ever forced to remain behind the purdah. This is the time for the government to step forward. Nothing will ever improve without the help of the law and who needs it more than in this case? The future of the nation depends on mothers. I should table an Abolish-the-Purdah Bill. I know there will be a lot of opposition, but the government should face this with courage; the dread of an impotent opposition should not hinder the work of progress. (Making a note on paper) I must present this Bill as soon as the Assembly reopens. We have delayed this long enough; there simply is no cause to postpone this further. Or else, the patient will die.’

(Begins to write a proposal—Cause and Purpose)

Suddenly, a sadhu calls out, ‘My lord, may you prosper. May Goddess Lakshmi rain abundance on you!’

Qanooni: ‘Get out of the way, swine. Why don’t you do some work?’

Mendicant: ‘If you could give me something, it would be very kind of you. I can barely see anything—I am so starved.’

Qanooni: ‘Shut up, you fool. Get out of the way, get away right now.’

(Putting the proposal aside, he again mumbles to himself)

‘This land of the rishis is fast turning into one of beggars. Wherever you turn, you see queues and clusters of them. This is the blessing of the government’s negligence. No one can beg in England. The police will instantly put them in prison. No developed country has so many beggars. Such things can only happen, even in the twentieth century, in a slavish

country like ours. Uff! What a waste of manpower. (Whipping out yet another report) Oh! Fifty lakhs! Fifty lakh people live by begging and what guarantee do we have that it is not actually double this figure? Who would like to claim begging as their profession? I am sure there are no less than one crore beggars in this country. And these are only those who beg from door to door. In addition to this there are the Tikadharis, Kopundharis and Jatadharis, who probably number about two crores. When a country has so many parasites and freeloaders, people who grow fat on the income of others, why should it not be so poverty-stricken? It is a mystery how this country is still alive. (Making a note) Another Bill is urgently required; it must be tabled soon. It should be titled Ban-the-Beggars Bill. Piles of shoes will fly around, the guardians of our dharma will kick up a fuss and hurl abuse, even the government will try to evade the issue, but the way to advancement is bound to be thorn-ridden. These three Bills must have my name on them. And then we'll wait and watch the chaos they unleash.'

(A voice floats in—Hot tea! Hot tea! But there are few takers. Qanooni Kumar's attention is drawn to the tea seller.)

Qanooni: '(Speaking to himself) There's not a single customer at the tea seller's stall. What a stupid nation. Such a nourishing drink and not a single buyer. They drink tea instead of water in civilized countries. (Checking the report) England imports five crore pounds of tea. The English are not idiots. Today they are ruling the world; who can even guess how much tea has contributed to this position? And this poor tea seller is parked here and no one even ventures close to him. The Chinese won their independence by drinking tea but we will not drink it. What intelligence! The government is to be blamed entirely. There is so much noise over insect-filled milk but nobody asks for tea, which is germ-free, energizing and healthy. The whole country has lost its mind. (Makes a note) I should question the government on this. I will fire a volley of questions as soon as the Assembly restarts.'

Question: Will the government tell us what the consumption of tea was in the last five years and what measures it has taken to publicize its use among the masses?

(A young lady enters. Clipped hair, a side parting, a Parsi silk sari, sporting a wristwatch, glasses, high-heeled shoes, holding a purse, a brooch pinned to her sari and a pearl necklace to boot.)

Qanooni: (Stretching out his hand) 'Hello! Mrs Bose. What a surprise! Where were you off to? Your poem in the *Alok* was beautiful. I thoroughly enjoyed myself. How does your little heart contain so many emotions? I am amazed. You are the queen of wordplay. How do you manage to convey such hard-hitting ideas?'

Mrs Bose: 'When your heart burns, clouds of smoke float out on their own. As long as men continue to oppress women, such feelings will arise in abundance.'

Qanooni: 'Has something happened recently?'

Mrs Bose: 'It happens every day. Dr Bose does not allow me to meet anyone or to go visiting. This year the heat has curdled my blood, but I could not go to the mountains. I can no longer bear this torture, this slavery.'

Qanooni: 'But Dr Bose hasn't gone to the mountains either.'

Mrs Bose: 'Let him not go; he only cares about his wealth. But why does he have to force me to fall in line? He doesn't want to go to clubs, his time is money, but why does he stop me? He can wear khadi for all I care, but why should he stop me from wearing what I like? He can be a slave to his mother and brothers, but why does he force me to weep with them in their misery? I can't take this any more. Even one bitter word can cause a relationship to break in America. A man gets back home a little late and his wife can divorce him. That is a country which respects independence; people are independent-minded there. Ours is a nation of slaves; here every single thought bears that mark of slavery. I can no longer live with Dr Bose. I've just had enough. And the responsibility for this lies with our leaders and administrators. If you think that you will become free by enslaving women, it is a strange expectation. For as long as divorce does not become legal, your notion of Swaraj will remain a dream. You know Dr Bose, how much he respects the notion of dharma, rather how much he fears it. And I abhor that very word. This very concept has enslaved women to men. If I

had my way, I would simply consign all our dharmic treatises to the waters.'

(In walks Mrs Iyer. Extremely fair and tall, wearing a short dress, a round cap, glasses, her face is powdered, her eyes and cheeks are made up, silken stockings and high heels.)

Qanooni: '(Extending his hand) Hello! Mrs Iyer. What a pleasure! Tell me, which way are you headed? Your piece in the *Alok* was striking, it left me amazed.'

Mrs Iyer: (Smiling at Mrs Bose) 'Did you simply remain stunned or could you do something about it? We women wear our heart on our sleeves but you men, your hearts never melt.'

Mrs Bose: 'True, absolutely true.'

Mrs Iyer: 'But this male domination will end very soon. Women cannot stay enslaved any more. I do not wish to look upon Mr Iyer's face any more.'

(Mrs Bose turns her face away)

Qanooni: (Smiling) 'But Mr Iyer is a handsome man.'

Lady Iyer: 'He is welcome to his beauty. I do not crave beautiful dependence, I crave ugly independence. He forced me to accompany him to the mountains this year. I cannot bear that chill. I begged him not to force me but he just wouldn't listen. I do not wish to follow someone like a dog.'

(Mrs Bose walks to the window)

Qanooni: 'Now I am absolutely certain that I must table the Divorce Bill in the Assembly.'

Mrs Iyer: 'Well, at least you realize that, though the end of the world is at hand.'

Qanooni: 'Don't worry, Mrs Iyer. I will present the Bill soon after the holidays, and this will be done with a lot of ceremony. No doubt the tyranny of men is on the rise. The tradition that you two women are fighting against is no doubt harmful to our Hindu community. If we have to become civilized, then we must follow in the footsteps of the civilized nations. The custodians of dharma will certainly raise a hue and cry, but we should not

be affected. It will be up to you two women to take care of them. Fix them in a way that they cannot show their faces to anyone.'

Lady Iyer: 'Well, thanks in advance. (Shakes his hand and leaves)'

Mrs Bose: '(Moving away from the window) Her home will shine with bright lights today. She will now head straight for Mr Bose. I'll leave as well.'

(She goes out)

Qanooni Kumar picks up a legal tome and begins to check the pages for the law on divorce just as Mr Acharya walks in. Clean-shaven, wearing a monocle, a half-sleeved shirt, shorts, woollen socks and long boots. A terrier dog follows.

Qanooni: 'Hello, Mr Acharya! What a surprise. Where were you headed? How is your hotel doing?'

Acharya: 'I am dying a dog's death. Such delicious food, a clean home, bright lights, comfort and yet a famine of customers. I just can't figure out how much more discount I should offer. At these rates no one can afford to have even a basic meal at home these days. To top it all, there are all the problems of the world—the complaints of the servant, the milkman, the washerman, the janitor. Here, at the hotel, you are completely free from all these troubles. And even then, half the rooms are vacant.'

Qanooni: 'This is indeed bad news.'

Acharya: 'Why do you think there is so much happiness and peace in the West, so much enlightenment and wealth, such independence and courage? It is all because of these hotels. Hotels are the main feature of Western pride, their civilization. If you want to see India scale the heights of success, then you must promote hotel culture. There is no other alternative. As long as you are not free from day-to-day problems, you can never achieve anything. Let the kings and the rich live in their own houses, they can spend untold wealth without a thought. But the promotion of hotels is the only answer for the middle class. I am willing to take on all the troubles of my guests, and still the masses will not see this. These idiots will not wake up to this fact until you impose a law on them.'

Qanooni: (Very gravely) ‘Yes, I am thinking. We must take the help of the law. Just one law, if we can make it, that people who earn less than five hundred rupees every month should stay in hotels.’

Acharya: ‘If you can make this happen, then our next generation will think of you as their saviour. At one go, you will lead the country ahead by five hundred years.’

Qanooni: ‘No problem. I will present this Bill as well as soon as the Assembly reopens. There will be a lot of noise over this. God knows what the people will label me, a traitor or worse, but I am prepared for it. I feel so sad when I see people standing at the doors of milkmen with their begging bowl. The lives of women are becoming absolutely hellish. They have no respite from early in the morning till late at night. Wash the utensils, cook meals, clean the home. How can they remain healthy, their lives be happy, relaxed and filled with pleasure, how can they even pursue knowledge? You have said it, one giant step and we’ll move ahead by five hundred years.’

Acharya: ‘So, will you table the Bill this time?’

Qanooni: ‘Absolutely.’

(Acharya shakes his hand and leaves)

Qanooni Kumar stands by the window, deep in thought about the Promote-the-Hotels Bill. Suddenly, a woman walks by in the park. She holds a child in her arms, two children trail behind her, and it is clear from the shape of her womb that she is pregnant. It is obvious from her lean frame, her sallow face and her slow walk that she is unwell, and it pains her badly to be carrying the weight that she does.

Qanooni Kumar: ‘(To himself) God destroy this society, this country, and this life where women are seen only as child-bearing machines. What happiness does this poor creature have in her life? There are countless such young sisters who, when in actual truth should be living happily at thirty-two or thirty-five years of age, are in reality undertaking their last journey, ill and disease-ridden. Ha! India! When will this misfortune let go of you? This world is full of such stone-hearted people who do not pity these unfortunate souls at all. How else can we set such a blind, hard-hearted and double-faced society straight, one which only makes women an object of its

lust, other than with the help of the law? There is no other option. The punishment awarded for killing a man is what should be given to these perpetrators as well. It will indeed be a joyous day for India when such barbaric practices—the death of women and children, and the death of a society which bases itself on such progeny—will come to an end. Why shouldn't such rouges be punished? Such blind people! Unemployment, and so much of it, that there is not enough for even a meal. Children cannot even get the taste of milk in their dreams and all that these blind fools care about is producing scores of children. This country does not require any other Bill as badly as it does the No-More-Children Bill. I must present this Bill as soon as the Assembly reopens. This can only produce total destruction, that I know, but what alternative do I have? Anyone with more than two children should face a minimum of five years of jail with at least five months of rigorous punishment. Anyone earning less than a hundred rupees should not be allowed to have children at all. (Feeling as pleased as Punch at the thought of the aftermath of the presentation of the Bill) How happy life will become after all this. Oh, yes, there should also be a clause which states that there should be a minimum gap of seven years between two children. Only then can this country have peace and happiness, only then will our women and children be in the pink of health, and only then will our men become strong in limb and heart.'

(Enter Mrs Qanooni Kumar)

Qanooni Kumar immediately arranges all his files and begins to flip through a novel.

Mrs Qanooni Kumar: 'What are you up to? The same old story?'

Qanooni: 'I was reading a novel.'

Mrs: 'You are forever drafting laws for the world, why not one for me as well? No other law will help the country as much as this one. Your name will become immortal and you will be worshipped in every home.'

Qanooni: 'If you think that I am working for the country to only promote my own name and gain success, I must confess that you have not understood me one bit.'

Mrs: ‘Working to become famous is not bad at all; if you wish to become known, why not, I will not make fun of you. In fact, I am trying to tell you about one such means through which you will earn so much popularity that it will begin to bore you. You will drown under the weight of flowers that people will shower on you. You will be forced down under the weight of the garlands around your neck.’

Qanooni: (Trying to hide his excitement) ‘I am sure it is something funny. Can you see, Minni, that for a man who strives hard there can be no worse fate than the members of his family making fun of him? When you behave like this, it always saddens me.’

Mrs: ‘Well, you are about to draft the Divorce Bill, so what are you afraid of?’

Qanooni: ‘You are being sarcastic again. I would like you to pay serious attention to these issues.’

Mrs: ‘I do pay very serious attention to these issues. Believe me. I feel bad that you are unable to understand my feelings. I know that what I wish to discuss with you at this moment is not only necessary for the progress of this nation, but absolutely crucial to it. And, about this I have no doubt.’

Qanooni: ‘I don’t dare ask you.’ (He chuckles to cover up his embarrassment)

Mrs: ‘That is why I have come to tell you. You are well aware of how shameful our marital life has been. We fight day and night. Sometimes men deceive women, and at other times women put them down. But something or the other is always at play. While sometimes one sulks, at other times the other threatens to leave home. Do you know why? Have you ever thought about it? It is all because of the frivolous nature and meanness of men. These are the two shortcomings that make human life hellish. Wherever you turn there is unhappiness, rebellion, obstacles. These are the reasons why lakhs of murders are committed every year, uncountable women are widowed, and so many men take to drinking. Is this true or not?’

Qanooni: ‘There are many problems that cannot be controlled by law.’

Mrs: ‘(Guffawing) Really, are you acknowledging the limitations of the legal system? I never thought you’d do that. I, in fact, think that the law is

stronger and much more omnipresent than even God.'

Qanooni: 'You have again started making fun of the whole thing.'

Mrs: 'Oh, I am sorry. I won't laugh any more. In fact, I have thought up a law to put an end to all these problems. We'll name it—Happiness-of-Couples Bill. It will be mainly in two parts, and you can fine-tune those further. One will state that the man will hand over half his salary every month to his wife without making a noise about it. If he does not do this, then he must face five years of rigorous imprisonment and five months of confinement. The other part will say that men aged fifteen to fifty years must not be allowed to step out of their homes and if they disobey, then they must face ten years of rigorous imprisonment and ten months of confinement. Do you agree to this?'

Qanooni: (Earnestly) 'Impossible! You wish to invert the course of nature? No man will agree to be confined at home.'

Mrs: 'He will agree and so will his father. The police will make them, with the force of their sticks. And if he still does not accept, then he will face punishment. Is it a joke that you will confine your wives within the walls of your homes and run after the wives of other men? You feel that this is an unnatural law. Don't worry. Let the women come to power. And if they do not force this into becoming the first Act, then you can come and tell me. A woman should crave for every single penny and you men should have fun. You have to hand over half your salaries and will not be allowed to even ask for any accounts.'

Qanooni: 'Do you think that the human race is a clay toy?'

Mrs: 'Certainly not. I only believe that the law is capable of everything. It can even change human nature.'

Qanooni: 'No, the law cannot do this.'

Mrs: 'Of course it can.'

Qanooni: 'No, it can't.'

Mrs: 'Yes, it can. If it can force boys into schools, if it can fix the age for marriages, if it can force children to be inoculated, then it can certainly force men to stay indoors and it can get them to give up half their earnings to women. Of course, you will say that men will feel pained by all this.

Anything that is got by force will surely hurt the one who is being compelled. You are never the one to face that pain, so you are never bothered. I am not saying that we don't need improvements. Even I want the spread of education, that we stop child marriages, that diseases should not spread. But I don't think that we should implement these forcibly by drafting laws. Spread education and awareness among people, so that they progress without living in fear of the law. You can hardly give up your love of power, you barely ever step out of the home, you cannot think of giving up the luxuries of the city for even a day, and here you are raring to become the saviour of the nation. This is not the way to change. But yes, the chains of dependence will certainly become stronger and harder.'

(Mrs Kumar leaves, and Qanooni Kumar begins a distracted walk around the room)

Translated from the Hindi by Chandana Dutta



Holy War

1

It's an old story. A band of Hindus fled from the north-western side of the mountain regions to protect their religion. The Hindus and the Muslims of that province had coexisted since antiquity. There had been no religious enmity between them. The Pathans had a tendency to fight every now and then. Their swords never rested. They would mobilize against rivals over trifles as there was no law and order among them. Every tribe had its own set of arrangements. Even for domestic squabbles, there was no alternative other than the sword. Blood for blood and an eye for an eye—there was no exception to this principle. This was the only dharma and creed they knew. But even amidst this terrible bloodshed, the Hindus lived peacefully. This situation, however, had changed for some time. A mullah came, God knows from where, and ignited religious sentiments among the uneducated Pathans who didn't care much for religion. His voice was so enticing that it attracted the old and the young, men and women alike. He roared like a lion and declared, 'God has brought you into this world so that you can illuminate it with the light of Islam, so that you can wipe out the very trace of doubt. To enlighten a non-believer's heart with the splendour of Islam is more valuable than a lifetime's worth of fasts, prayers and charities. The fairies of heaven will ward off all evil for you and angels will place the dust of your

feet on their foreheads. God himself will kiss your forehead.' Crowds of people went crazy at this and raised frantic religious slogans. This fanaticism drove a wedge between Islamic and non-Islamic people. Every Pathan got impatient to enjoy the bliss of paradise. The Hindus, with whom they had lived peacefully for centuries, became the target of their attacks. If somewhere a Hindu temple was being razed to the ground, elsewhere abuse was being hurled at Hindu deities. And at other places, Hindus were forced to accept Islam. The Hindus were fewer in number and unorganized. As they lived scattered in different places, they were not at all ready to face this situation. They were terribly frightened. While many among them left their properties and ran for their lives, some waited for the storm to subside.

This caravan consisted of those who were fleeing. It was noon. Fire was raining down from the sky. Flames were emanating from the mountains. There were no trees anywhere. These fugitives were travelling on a circuitous route, away from the main thoroughfare. At every step, they were scared of being caught. They were exhausted because of hunger, thirst and the heat, and stopped in the shade of an upturned rock. They were afraid of the Jihadi groups following them. Two young men with loaded guns on their shoulders kept guard. The elderly among the fugitives spread their blankets on the ground and stretched their limbs. The women put down the children they were carrying in their laps, wiped the sweat off their foreheads and tucked in their dishevelled hair. Their faces looked washed out. All were filled with fear, even the children had forgotten to cry.

Of the two young men, one was tall and of a good physique. His eyes exuded pride. It seemed as though he didn't care for anybody in the world, and even the gods from the sky seemed to be praising each of his movements. As opposed to him, the other youth was feckless, lean and thin. His face gave away his mean state. It was as though he had lost all hope in the world and was resigned to spend the rest of his life crying and lamenting. The former was Dharamdas and the latter Khazanchand.

Dharamdas rested his rifle on the ground, sat on a rock and said, 'What plans do you have for your future? You must have left property worth more than a lakh of rupees.'

Khazanchand replied indifferently, ‘Not that much. It could be between fifty and sixty thousand in cash.’

‘What will you do now?’

‘I’ll do as the situation demands. I have a couple of relatives in Rawalpindi, they might help me. What have you decided?’

‘I’ve no worry. My two hands are my main asset. I depended on *them*. They will support me wherever I go.’

‘If today passes off without any mishap, then we are safe.’

‘I’m lying in wait for some prize. Even if a dozen of them appear before me, I’ll make short work of them.’

Meanwhile, from behind the rocks appeared a young woman who was holding a lota and a rope in her hands and going to the well. She was stunningly beautiful.

Both the young men walked towards her, but Khazanchand stopped after taking a couple of steps. Dharamdas took the lota and the rope from the woman, looked at Khazanchand with pride and then walked towards the well. Khazanchand picked up his gun, forgot his discomfiture and began to stare at the sky. Dharamdas always stole a march on him. He was accustomed to it. Now he had no trace of doubt that Dharamdas was Shyama’s admirer. All of Khazanchand’s properties paled into insignificance before the handsome physique of Dharamdas. Several times Shyama had been quite rude to Khazanchand, but Khazanchand, even in a state of despair, loved her beyond redemption. All three had lived in the same hamlet. Shyama’s parents were no more. Her aunt had brought her up. Shyama was still with her. The aunt wanted to make Khazanchand the son-in-law who would make Shyama happy and be a support to her in her last days. But Shyama was attracted to Dharamdas. She didn’t realize that the man she was spurning was her only support. Khazanchand was a manager, cashier and employee—all rolled into one for the old woman. He provided his services despite the realization that Shyama would never be his. If he had not cared to manage their affairs, he would’ve preferred to renounce the world and become a mendicant.

2

Dharamdas was returning from the well when he saw several horse riders coming towards them from the west. As they came closer, he saw that they were five in number. The barrels of their guns glinted in the sun. Dharamdas tried to run to escape being caught by them, but he couldn't run fast with the gun on his shoulder and the water tumbler in his hand. The distance between them was less than two hundred yards. The path was strewn with heaps of stones. He was scared lest he stumble or slip. The horsemen were getting closer and closer. He couldn't have competed with their Arabian horses. Hardly had he covered fifty steps when the horsemen caught up and surrounded him. Dharamdas was a courageous fellow, but when he saw death standing before him, his eyes darkened and his gun slipped from his hand. All five were Pathans from his village. One of them said, 'Sever the head of the unbeliever. A cheat and hypocrite.'

The second rider said, 'No, stop for a minute. If he accepts Islam even now, we can forgive him. Dharamdas, what punishment should we give for your betrayal? We had given you the entire night to take a decision. We can consign you to hell right away, but we are giving you another chance. This is your last opportunity. If you don't accept Islam now, your life will be snuffed out.'

Dharamdas said hesitantly, 'If my mind doesn't accept something, how can I—'

The first rider said impetuously, 'Religion has nothing to do with rational thinking.'

Third rider: 'A kafir, that's what he is! An unbeliever!'

First rider: 'Sever his head, send him to hell.'

Second rider: 'Stop for a minute. It's easy to kill him, but it's difficult to get someone's confidence. Where are your other companions?'

Dharamdas: 'All are with me.'

Second rider: 'I swear by the holy words, if all of you are ready to believe in God and his Prophet, no one will dare even look at you with evil intentions.'

Dharamdas: ‘Won’t you give us some time to think over this?’

All the other four riders yelled out, ‘No, we won’t allow you to go from here. This is your last chance.’

The first rider aimed his gun at Dharamdas’s chest and said, ‘Now tell us, do you accept our proposal?’

Dharamdas was shivering from head to toe. ‘If I accept Islam do you promise that my companions will be saved?’

Second rider: ‘Yes, if you guarantee that they’ll also accept Islam.’

First rider: ‘We don’t agree with this condition. We’ll deal with your companions. Tell us about yourself. What do you want? Yes or no?’

Dharamdas said as though he was swallowing poison, ‘I accept Islam as my faith.’

All five exclaimed, ‘God be praised.’

Then they hugged Dharamdas one after the other.

3

Shyama was witnessing this scene with bated breath. She regretted allowing Dharamdas to fetch water for her. *If I knew this was going to happen, I wouldn’t have allowed him to go even if I were dying of thirst.* Khazanchand was standing at some distance from Shyama. Shyama looked at him, her eyes full of anger, and said, ‘I don’t think they’ll spare his life.’

Khazanchand: ‘His gun has also slipped from his hand.’

Shyama wondered what they were talking about. *Oh God, the scoundrel is aiming his gun at him.*

Khazanchand: ‘Let them come closer, then I’ll fire my gun. My gun doesn’t have this range.’

Shyama: ‘Just see—they are embracing Dharamdas. What’s happening?’

Khazanchand: ‘I can’t understand what’s going on.’

Shyama: ‘I hope he hasn’t accepted Islam.’

Khazanchand: ‘Oh no, I didn’t expect this from him.’

Shyama: ‘I have understood everything. Shoot them.’

Khazanchand: ‘Dharamdas is with them. He may be hit.’

Shyama: ‘Don’t bother about that. I want the first bullet to hit Dharamdas. Coward, shameless fellow. He has renounced his religion to save his life. Such shameless fellows should die rather than live. What are you thinking? Are you scared? Come on, give the gun to me. I’ll shoot that coward with my own hands.’

Khazanchand: ‘I can’t believe that Dharamdas—’

Shyama: ‘You’ll never believe it. Give the gun to me. Don’t just stand there staring. Will you fire the gun only when they jump on us? Do you also want to save yourself by becoming a Muslim? Good, go ahead. I can protect myself, but don’t show your face to him.’

Khazanchand fired the gun, which threw off the turban of a rider. The jihadis cried out, ‘Allahu Akbar!’ He shot again, which hit one of the horses in its chest and it fell. The jihadis yelled out the slogan ‘Allahu Akbar’ once again and moved forward. Khazanchand fired a third shot. One of the Pathans fell down, but before the fourth one was shot the Pathans pounced on Khazanchand and snatched the gun away from him.

One of the riders aimed the gun at Khazanchand and said, ‘Shall I smash his skull? Blood for blood.’

The second rider, who seemed to be the group leader, said, ‘Now, he is a courageous fellow. Khazanchand, you are accused of three crimes: betrayal, murder and infidelity. It is a virtuous act to kill you, but we’ll give you one more chance. If you’re ready to believe in Allah and his Prophet even now, we’ll embrace you. There’s no other remedy for the crimes you’ve committed. Do you accept our proposal?’

All the four Pathans unsheathed their swords and kept them hanging over Khazanchand’s head. If Khazanchand said no, all four swords would strike him instantly.

Khazanchand’s face was luminous with a special glow. Both his eyes sparkled in heavenly light. He said firmly, ‘You are asking this question to a Hindu? Do you think that he’ll barter his faith for his life? The Hindus don’t require a Prophet or saint to reach God.’

The four Pathans yelled out, ‘A kafir, that’s what he is.’

Khazanchand: ‘If you think I’m a kafir, so be it. I consider myself a better believer than you. I follow a religion that is based on rationality. A man’s intelligence is God’s light in him and my intelligence is my faith.’

The four Pathans yelled out, ‘Kafir! Kafir!’

All the swords struck him at the same moment. The body fell to the ground. Dharamdas was standing there with his head bowed low. He was happy about the fact that now Khazanchand’s property would come to him and he could spend the rest of his life with Shyama happily. But destiny had something else in store for him. So far Shyama had been witnessing this scene, grief-stricken. The moment Khazanchand’s body fell to the ground, she ran to it and took his head in her lap, trying to stop the flow of blood with her *pallu*. Her clothes got drenched in blood. She had worn beautiful saris with multi-coloured motifs but the beauty of this blood-spattered sari was unique. Ordinary saris enhanced the external beauty of a woman but this blood-red sari was a reflection of Shyama’s soul.

It seemed as though Khazanchand’s closing eyes were lit up with a heavenly light. His gaze was full of contentment and happiness. Someone who had not cared for him while he had been alive was giving him all her love at the moment of his death.

4

Dharamdas held Shyama’s hand and pleaded: ‘Shyama, come to your senses. Your clothes have got drenched in blood. What will you get by crying now? These are our friends now. They won’t give us any trouble. We’ll return to our hearth and home and enjoy life once again.’

Shyama looked at him reproachfully and said, ‘If your hearth and home are so dear to you, then go by all means. Don’t worry about me. I won’t go. And yes, if you still have some feelings left for me, please get these fellows to kill me here with their swords.’

Dharamdas said piteously, ‘What are you saying, Shyama? Have you forgotten what we had decided? I am deeply grieved by Khazanchand’s death. But who can fight against destiny?’

‘If this is destiny, then my destiny is to spend the rest of my life mourning the death of the man I had always looked down upon.’ While she was saying this, all her pent-up emotions welled up, and she clasped Khazanchand’s lifeless hands around her neck and began to sob.

Seeing this spectacle of love and total surrender, the heart of the four Pathans filled with pity. The chief said to Dharamdas, ‘Tell this chaste woman to come with us. Our tribe won’t give her any trouble. We will treat her with utmost respect.’

Dharamdas’s heart was now burning with jealousy. This woman whom he considered his own was now not ready to even look at him. ‘Shyama, you might shed rivers of tears on this dead body, but it won’t come to life. Get ready to leave this place. I’m going to persuade the others. The khans have promised to protect us. We will get back our land and property. We will also inherit Khazanchand’s property. Don’t waste time. There’s nothing to be gained by crying.’

Shyama glared at Dharamdas and said, ‘And what’s the price we have to pay for safe return? The same price that you’ve paid?’

Dharamdas didn’t understand her jibe, and said, ‘I haven’t paid any price. What did I have to pay them with?’

Shyama, ‘You had the treasure bestowed on you by the rishis for thousands of years, a treasure guarded by Raghu and Manu, Rama and Krishna, Buddha and Shankar, Shivaji and Govind Singh. You’ve bartered away that valuable treasure for your mean life today. Go back and touch the feet of these fellows, congratulations! The swords that put the valorous Khazanchand to death have also decided the fate of my love. When he was alive, I didn’t show him any respect. I was indifferent to him. Now that he’s no more, I’d like to atone for my earlier neglect and indifference. He was a hero ready to die for his religion, not a coward to sell it out. If you have any shame left in you, please help me perform his last rites. Of course, if your new masters have any objection to it, then don’t. I can manage everything.’

The Pathans were greatly touched by her feelings. Their fanaticism had subsided. They gathered a heap of wood. Dharamdas sat with his head bowed in shame while the four Pathans got busy chopping the wood. The

pyre was ready, and the cruel hands that had taken away Khazanchand's life placed his body on the funeral pyre. The flames rose. The fire god sang praises of the hero with his flames.

5

The Pathans made over all the immovable property of Khazanchand to Shyama. Shyama got a small house built right there and started spending her days worshipping Khazanchand. Her old aunt stayed with her, others returned to their homes with the Pathans. The condition that the Hindus convert to Islam was waived. Khazanchand's sacrifice helped mitigate the heightened emotions of jihad. But the Pathans compelled Dharamdas to convert to Islam. A day was fixed for his initiation. Mullahs crowded the mosque. Someone went to Dharamdas's house to call him but he wasn't there. People looked for him all around, but couldn't find him.

A year passed. It was evening. Shyama was sitting in front of her shack, lost in the sweet thoughts of the future. Her past was filled with sorrow, the present was a despairing dream. All her desires were concentrated on her future. This future had no relationship with her current life. A red glow had spread across the sky. The mountains in view were covered in a peaceful, golden hue. The leaves in the trees were making a rustling sound, as though some forlorn souls were sobbing away.

Just then a raggedly beggar appeared in front of the house. The dog barked, and a stunned Shyama let out a cry, 'Dharamdas!'

Dharamdas squatted there and said, 'Yes, Shyama. It is indeed the wretched Dharamdas. I've been wandering here and there for a year now. An award has been announced for my arrest. The entire region is looking for me. I've got tired of this life, but death also refuses to come.'

Dharamdas paused for a moment, then resumed, 'Shyama, do you still have reservations about me? Haven't you forgiven me yet?'

Shyama said indifferently, 'I don't understand what you mean.'

'I'm still a Hindu. I haven't adopted Islam.'

'I know.'

‘Don’t you feel any pity for me, knowing this fact?’

Shyama looked at him fiercely and said in a raised voice, ‘Don’t you feel any shame talking this way? I’m wedded to the hero who has brought pride to the Hindu nation. Do you think he’s dead and gone? You are delusional. He’s immortal. Even at this moment I can see him seated in heaven. You’ve brought ignominy to the Hindu community. Get lost from my sight.’

Dharamdas made no reply. He stood up quietly, heaved a deep sigh and walked away.

The following morning when Shyama was going to draw water, she saw a corpse lying abandoned by the wayside. A few vultures were hovering over it. Her heart missed a beat. She recognized him as she went closer. It was Dharamdas.

Translated from the Hindi by M. Asaduddin



Family Break-up

1

When Bhola Mehto married a second time, after the death of his first wife, bad days began for his son, Raghu. Raghu was only ten years old then. With no worries to bother him, he entertained himself playing *gilli-danda* with the other boys in the village. With the arrival of his new mother, he had to do all the menial tasks at home. Panna was a beautiful woman and there is an inextricable link between beauty and vanity. She avoided all burdensome tasks. Raghu gathered the cow dung, fed the ox and even cleaned the utensils. Bhola was so changed now that he saw nothing but shortcomings in his son. He now blindly followed all that his wife told him and ignored Raghu's complaints. As a result, Raghu stopped complaining. Was there no place for him to shed his tears? Not just his father but the entire village seemed to be his enemy now. Bhola was irritated by Raghu's obstinacy that refused to see how Panna loved and cared for him. Panna's goodness was responsible for this. Any other woman would not have tolerated all this. Panna, being so gracious, somehow managed to live with Raghu. Everyone heeds the complaints of the powerful but no one listens to the pleas of the weak. Each day took Raghu further and further away from his father. Eight years went by this way. And one day a message from Death came for Bhola.

Panna had four children—three sons and a daughter. Too many liabilities and no earning member. Why should Raghu bother about them now? This was an accepted thing. He would bring his bride and live separately. The wife would come and add fuel to the fire. Panna saw only darkness all around her. But no matter what, she would not live in this house with him as his dependent. Where she had ruled like a queen, she would not live like a maid. How could she look up to someone whom she had hitherto considered a slave! She had beauty and was still quite young. Her youth was in full bloom. Why couldn't she live separately? At the worst people would probably make fun of her. Who cares! Don't such things happen in her community? She wasn't a Brahmin or a Thakur to bother about such things. Only among the higher castes can you do what you like inside the house, but behind the purdah. Unmindful of the whole world, she could set up another home. Why, then, should she depend on Raghu?

A month had passed since Bhola's death. It was twilight. Panna was caught up in anxiety when she suddenly realized that her sons were not at home. It was time for the oxen to return. She feared that one of her sons may have been trampled by the oxen. Who was there now to keep an eye over her children? She went out and saw Raghu cutting pieces of sugar cane, surrounded by her three sons, while her daughter was trying to climb on to his back by encircling his neck with her arms. Panna could not believe her eyes. This was something new. *Perhaps he is trying to show to the world how dearly he loves his brothers whereas in truth he holds a dagger in his heart. Given a chance he would even kill them. He is a snake, a black snake.* She asked sternly, 'What are you all doing here? Come home. It is evening and time for the cattle to return.'

Raghu answered respectfully, 'I am here, Kaki. Why do you fear?'

The eldest son, Kedar, said, 'Kaki, Raghu Dada has made two toy carts for us. See, Khunnu and I will sit in one of them and Laxman and Jhunia in the other. Dada will pull both the carts.'

He then brought the two carts from the corner, each with four wheels and a platform that could be used as a seat and arms to be used for brakes.

Panna asked in surprise, 'Who made these carts?'

Kedar answered with irritation, ‘Raghu Dada, I just told you! He brought the chisel and adze from Bhagat’s house and quickly made the carts. They run very well, Kaki. Sit, Khunnu, and I will pull.’

Khunnu sat on the plank of the cart and Kedar began to pull. The cart made a whirring noise as if it too became a part of the children’s game.

Laxman sat on the other cart and shouted, ‘Dada, pull.’

Raghu made Jhunia too sit on the cart and ran, pulling it forward. The three boys started clapping in appreciation. Panna observed all this in surprise and wondered whether this was the same Raghu or someone else.

After some time both the carts returned. The boys came back home and described their experiences of the travel, making it seem like they had been in an aeroplane!

Khunnu said, ‘Kaki, in truth the trees were running.’

‘And the calves, how they all ran!’ said Laxman.

Kedar said, ‘Kaki, Raghu Dada can pull both the carts at the same time.’

Jhunia was the youngest. She communicated her excitement through her eyes. She jumped up and down and clapped her hands.

Khunnu said, ‘We’ll even have a cow now. Raghu Dada has asked Girdhari to bring us one. Girdhari said he will bring it tomorrow.’

Kedar added, ‘The cow will give us three *ser*s of milk. We can drink a lot of milk.’

In the meantime, Raghu too entered the house. Panna asked him indifferently, ‘Did you ask Girdhari for a cow?’

Raghu answered earnestly, ‘Yes, I have. He will bring it tomorrow.’

‘From where will the money come? Have you thought about that?’

‘Yes, I have. See this chain? I am getting twenty-five rupees for it; five rupees I will pay for the heifer and the cow will be ours.’

Panna was stunned. Now even her disbelieving heart could not ignore Raghu’s affection and graciousness. She said, ‘Why sell the chain? What’s the hurry to get the cow? When you have sufficient money you can buy it. Without the chain your neck will look bare. We didn’t have a cow for so many years. Didn’t the children survive?’

Raghu answered philosophically, ‘These are the days for the children to eat and drink, Kaki. If they don’t get to eat at this age, then when will they eat? I really don’t like wearing a chain. People will say—see, his father has died and he is still wearing a chain round his neck.’

Bhola Mehto had died dreaming of the cow. He never had the money. So the cow never came. He had been helpless. And Raghu had solved this problem with such ease today. Today, for the first time in her life, Panna felt herself trusting Raghu. She said, ‘If you must sell jewellery, then why your chain? Take my necklace.’

‘No, Kaki, It looks so good on your neck. What does it matter whether a man wears a chain or not?’

‘Oh ho! I am getting old! What do I need to wear a necklace for? You are young. Your bare neck will not look good.’

Raghu said with a smile, ‘You are not old. Is there anyone in the village who can compare with you?’

Raghu’s simple praise embarrassed Panna. A flush of happiness spread over her dry and withered face.

2

Five years went by. It was hard to find a more honest and industrious man than Raghu in the village. He would do nothing against Panna’s wishes. He was twenty-three years old now. Panna would tell him constantly, ‘Bring your wife from her parents’ home. How long will she remain there? Everyone blames me. As if I prevent her from coming to live with you.’ But Raghu always ignored Panna’s request. ‘What is the great hurry?’ he would say. He had learnt about his wife’s nature and temperament from the others and was not keen to bring her here and disrupt his peace of mind.

One day Panna asked him sharply, ‘So, you won’t bring her here?’

‘I told you there is no great hurry.’

‘You may not need her but I do. I am sending someone to fetch her today.’

‘You will repent it, Kaki. She is not good-natured.’

‘How does it matter? If I don’t speak to her at all, who will she fight with? She will at least do the cooking. I cannot manage the kitchen and the work outside. I am sending for her today.’

‘If you want to call her, call her. But don’t say later that I cannot control her, that I am her slave.’

‘I won’t. Now, go and bring two saris and some sweets.’

Three days later Mulia came from her parents’ home. Drumbeats welcomed her. Melodious notes of the shehnai echoed in the air. People poured in for the ritual of seeing the bride. She seemed like an oasis in the desert. Her wheatish complexion, long and pointed eyelashes, the little blush on her cheeks and attractive eyes mesmerized Raghu.

In the early morning hours, when she walked with the water pitcher on her head, the gentle rays of the rising sun seemed to blend in with her wheatish complexion, making the atmosphere fragrant and full of passion.

3

Mulia came from her parental home bitter and angry. *My husband slogs the whole day and Panna sits like a queen, her sons behaving like lords*. Mulia wouldn’t tolerate this. She would never be anyone’s slave. *When you are not sure of your own children, how can you trust your brothers? Now, they surround Raghu with attention and concern. Once they grow wings they’ll fly away*. One day she told Raghu, ‘If you wish to live like a slave, do so by all means. But I won’t.’

Raghu retorted, ‘So what do you want me to do? The boys are not old enough to take care of the household work.’

Mulia said, ‘The boys are their father’s sons and not yours. I have heard everything. I know that Panna used to make you grovel for everything. I shall not live here at her mercy. I have no account of the money you earn nor what she does with it. You think the money is being used at home. But remember, nobody will give you a cowrie when you need it.’

‘Just think, if I start giving you what I earn, what will the people say?’

‘Let the people say what they want. They don’t own me. You just wait and see, you will get nothing out of being so good to them. You are free to die for your brothers but why should I make sacrifices?’

Raghu didn’t react. His apprehensions were coming true sooner than he had expected. If he persisted, he could ward off the evil for another six months or so. Things didn’t look promising even for that length of time. As the saying goes, how long can the mother goat pray to save her baby from the sacrificial knife?

One day Panna left the mahua leaves out to dry. The rains came. The grain was getting wet in the granary. She told Mulia, ‘Bahu, keep an eye. I shall go and bathe in the pond.’

Mulia replied indifferently, ‘I am feeling sleepy, you sit and keep an eye. What will happen if you don’t bathe for one day?’

Panna kept her sari back. She did not go for her bath. Mulia’s blow went in vain.

Several days later, Panna returned late in the evening from the paddy field. She hadn’t eaten anything the whole day. She had expected her bahu to have cooked the food. But she saw that the hearth was cold and the children were restless with hunger. She gently asked Mulia, ‘Have you not lit the fire?’

Kedar said, ‘She didn’t do it in the afternoon either. Bhabhi didn’t cook anything.’

‘Then what did you all eat?’

‘Nothing. Khunnu and Laxman ate leftover rotis. I had *sattu*.’

‘And Bahu?’

‘She has been sleeping the whole day. She has eaten nothing.’

Panna immediately lit the *chulha*. She kneaded the atta and wept. What a fate, the whole day I faced the burning heat in the field and now I come home to face the flames of the chulha.

Kedar was nearing fourteen. He had begun to understand everything from observing the manner and attitude of his *bhabhi*. He said, ‘Kaki, bhabhi doesn’t want to live with you any more.’

Panna was astonished. ‘Why, did she say anything?’

‘She said nothing. But I know what she’s thinking. Why don’t you leave her? Let her live the way she wants. God will take care of us.’

‘Shut up, don’t you say such things in my presence. Raghu is not just your brother, he is like your father. If you say anything like that to Mulia, I will drink poison.’

4

The festival of Dussehra arrived. A fair was held at a small village two miles away. All the village boys went to see the fair. Panna also got ready to go with her sons but where was the money? The keys were with Mulia.

Raghu came and told Mulia, ‘The boys are going to the fair, give them two annas each.’

Raising her eyebrows, Mulia retorted, ‘There is no money in the house.’

‘But we just sold the oilseeds. Has all the money been spent?’

‘Yes.’

‘Where did you spend it? Tell me. You don’t want the boys to go to the *mela* today?’

‘Ask your kaki to take out the money. What will she gain by hoarding it?’

The key was on the peg. Raghu took the key to open the trunk but Mulia held his hand and said, ‘Give me the key or you will regret it. We have to pay for food, we have to pay for clothes, we have to pay for their books and notebooks, and now they want to visit the fair too. We don’t earn this money so that others can eat and enjoy themselves at our expense.’

Panna told Raghu, ‘Bhaiya, what do you need the money for? The boys won’t be going to the fair.’

‘Why won’t they go to the fair?’ Raghu snapped. ‘The whole village is going. Only our boys will stay back?’

Raghu took out the money and gave it to the boys. But when he tried to return the key to Mulia, she threw it away, covered her face and lay down. The boys didn’t go to the fair.

Two days passed after this episode. Mulia ate no food. Panna too remained hungry. Raghu tried to appease both, but neither relented. Finally,

Raghu asked Mulia, ‘Why don’t you say what you really want?’

Mulia looked at the ground and said, ‘I don’t want anything. Just send me home.’

‘All right. Get up. Prepare the food and eat. I will take you home.’

Mulia raised her eyes. Raghu was frightened. The charm, the attractiveness, the beauty had vanished. Her teeth were bared, her eyes bulged, and her nostrils flared.

Her eyes bloodshot, she said, ‘Oh! Has your kaki taught you this mantra? Don’t you take me for granted. I will make both of you squirm for this! What did you think?’

‘All right, make us squirm. But first have something to eat and drink, then you can do what you want.’

‘Now I shall eat only when we have a separate home. I have tolerated enough. I’ll take no more of this.’

Raghu was stunned. For a minute he was speechless. He had never dreamt that the family would be separated. He had seen a few families in the village splitting up. He knew very well how separate kitchens led to the separation of hearts. Even your own become strangers. The relationship between them was like the ties one has with other village folk. Raghu had resolved that he would never allow such a problem to enter his home. But he was powerless before the inevitable. *My face will be blackened. People will say that after the death of the father the family couldn’t remain together even for ten years. Who shall I separate myself from? The ones who played in my lap, the ones I nurtured like my own children, for whom I suffered, shall I be separated from them all? Shall I drive away my loved ones from my home? He choked. He had a lump in his throat.*

‘Do you want to separate me from my brothers? Just think, I won’t be able to show my face to anyone.’

‘I cannot live with them.’

‘Then you move out. Why drag me?’

‘Do you think I’m enamoured of your house? Is there no other place for me in the world?’

‘Do as you please. Stay where you feel like staying. I shall not be able to part with my family. The day we have two separate kitchens in the house, my heart will break into two. I shall not be able to bear it. I can take care of your problems. You have control of all household things, also of foodgrains. What else is there? If you don’t want to do any work, don’t. Had God provided me with sufficient means, you wouldn’t have had to lift even your little finger. Your tender hands and feet have not been made for hard work. What can I do? I am so helpless. Still, do as you please. If you wish to do no work, don’t do it. Don’t ask me to divide this family, I fall at your feet.’

Mulia pushed back the *pallu* of the sari, moved closer to him and said, ‘I am not afraid of hard work, nor do I wish to eat without working but I don’t like being bullied. I hate to be bossed around. Your kaki may be doing the household work but she does it for herself, for her children. She is doing me no favour. Then why does she dictate to me what I should do? Her own children are dear to her. I am dependent on you alone. I cannot bear to see how everyone here has a jolly good time, little children enjoying milk, whereas the one person on whom the whole house depends has to yearn even for buttermilk, with nobody to care for him. Just look at yourself. How pale you look. In four years these colts will become horses whereas in ten years you will take to the cot. Sit down. Why are you standing? Are you waiting to hit someone and run away? I cannot bind you by force. If I knew I would have to contend with such cruel people, I would have thought twice before coming here. I would not have developed any attachment towards you, but now I do care for you. Even if I go home, my heart will remain here. And look at you, you don’t even care for me.’

Mulia’s sweet words did not have any effect on Raghu. He said drily, ‘Mulia, I will not be able to do it. My heart cannot bear the thought of separation.’

Mulia said mockingly, ‘Then wear bangles and stay inside. I will put on a moustache. I thought you were a strong man but now I realize you are just a lump of clay.’

Panna listened to this conversation from the veranda. She could not take it any more. She came inside and told Raghu, ‘When she is hell-bent on

separating us, why are you so insistent on living together? You live with her. God will look after us. When Mehto died and there was not even a leaf's shade to protect us, God was kind enough to take care of us. Why then should we have any fear now? By God's grace now all the three boys have grown up. There is nothing to worry about now.'

Raghu looked at Panna with tearful eyes and said, 'Kaki, have you gone crazy? Don't you know that two hearths will lead to the division of the heart too?'

'When she is averse to the idea, what can you do? If this is God's will, what can one do? We stayed together as long as it was destined; if He wills it this way, let it be. I can never forget what you have done for my children. Had you not been there to protect them, where would they be today? Who knows in what state they would be! Who knows—they may have been begging somewhere. I shall sing your praises till the end of my life. If my skin could be used in making shoes for you, I would be only too happy to give it. If you ever call me any time, I shall come running like a dog. Never think that being separated from you I can ever nurture any ill will towards you. I shall consume poison and die the day I ever think of causing you any harm. May God grant you prosperity and bless you with children. Till my last breath, this blessing shall issue forth from every pore of my body. And, if the boys are the true sons of their father, they will remain grateful to you lifelong.'

Panna left the place weeping. Raghu stood there like a statue. He gazed at the sky as tears flowed from his eyes.

5

Panna's words made Mulia feel triumphant. She got up quickly, swept the house, got the hearth ready and left to fetch water from the well. Her obstinacy had paid off.

In a village, women generally have two groups—one of the daughters-in-law and the other of the mothers-in-law. The former go to their own group for advice and sympathy, and the latter to theirs. Each has its own

panchayat. At the well, Mulia came across a few ladies. One said, ‘Today your old lady made a lot of hue and cry.’

Mulia answered in triumph, ‘For so many years she has been enjoying the privilege of being the lady of the house. Who wouldn’t resent giving up such rights? Sister, I do not wish her ill, but it isn’t possible to run the household on one man’s income. For me too, these are the days for enjoying life’s pleasures. Shall we now spoil our life for them and, later, when we beget children, waste our lives in their upbringing? Shall we spend our whole life shedding tears?’

One of the women said, ‘The old woman just wants you to remain her slave all your life.’

Another said, ‘On whom can one depend? When your own children don’t bother about you, what can you expect from others? When they become independent, they shall no longer care. They will be guided by their wives. It’s better to hold the reins right from the start. There won’t be any problem then.’

Mulia returned home with the water, prepared the food and told Raghu, ‘Go, take a bath, the food is ready.’

Raghu pretended not to hear. Putting his hand on his head he kept staring at the door.

‘Did you hear what I said? The food is ready, go and have your bath.’

‘Yes, I have heard. I am not deaf. If the food is ready, go and have it yourself. I am not hungry.’

Mulia did not ask him again. She went and extinguished the chulha. She put the rotis in a hanging pot, covered her face and lay down.

After a while, Panna came and said, ‘The food is ready, have your bath, and eat. She too must be hungry.’

Raghu was irritated. ‘Kaki, will you let me stay in peace at home or do you want me to go out and stain my face black? I have to eat. If I don’t eat today I shall eat tomorrow. But at the moment I don’t feel like eating anything. Hasn’t Kedar returned from school?’

‘He hasn’t returned yet. He must be on the way.’

Panna understood that until she made food and fed her children and ate, Raghu wouldn't eat. Not only this, she would have to quarrel with him, rebuke him, and convince him that it was she who had wanted the separation. Otherwise he would waste himself away in this anxiety. With such thoughts on her mind she lit her own chulha and began making the food. In the meantime, Kedar and Khunnu returned from school.

Panna said, 'Come, sons, and eat, the food is ready.'

Kedar asked, 'Shall I call Raghu Bhaiya?'

'You come and have your food. His wife has prepared his food separately.'

Khunnu asked, 'Shall I not go and ask bhaiya?'

'He will have his food when he wants to eat. You sit and eat, why concern yourself with such things? Those who feel like eating will eat. Those who don't won't. When he and his wife are bent on living separately, who can convince them otherwise?'

'Mother, does it mean we will live in a separate house?' asked Kedar.

'If they wish, we can live together. Otherwise they may erect a wall in the courtyard.'

Khunnu looked out and found Raghu sitting on the cot in his thatched hut, drinking coconut water. He said, 'Bhaiya is still sitting with his coconut.'

'He will eat when he feels like it.'

Kedar asked, 'Didn't bhaiya scold bhabhi?'

Mulia had been listening to this conversation. She came out and said, 'No, bhaiya didn't. Why don't you come and scold me?'

Kedar paled and was shocked into silence. The three boys ate their food and went out. The air was very hot outside. In the mango groves the village boys and girls were picking mangoes that had fallen in the wind. Kedar told them, 'Let us also go and pick mangoes today. Lots of mangoes have fallen.'

Khunnu replied, 'But with dadaji sitting over there . . . ?'

'I won't go,' said Laxman, 'dada will be angry.'

Kedar remarked, 'Now we've separated.'

‘If someone beats us, won’t he intervene?’ Laxman wanted to know.

‘Don’t be silly. Why won’t he?’

Raghu saw the three boys standing at the door but he said nothing. Earlier he would scold them whenever they ventured out. But today he sat lifeless like a statue. This emboldened the boys. They advanced a little but Raghu still didn’t say anything. What could he say? He was thinking, *Kaki has fed the boys and didn’t even care to ask me. Has she become blind? What if I call the boys and they don’t respond? Will I be able to thrash them? All of them will go wandering around in this heat. I hope they don’t fall ill.* His heart was perturbed but he could say nothing. His silence made them fearless and they went on their way.

Suddenly, Mulia came and said, ‘Will you get up now? The one whose case you have been advocating has conveniently fed her boys, has herself eaten, and is now enjoying her sleep. Not one of your brothers asked you to eat.’

Raghu felt great anguish and pain at that moment. Mulia’s harsh words poured salt on his wounds. He said balefully, ‘What you desired has finally happened. Now go and celebrate.’

‘No, she’s waiting with the plate laid out for you.’

‘Don’t provoke me. For your sake, I’m getting a bad name. When you don’t wish to stay with them, why should they flatter you? Go and ask kaki if I should I go and fetch the boys who have gone to pick mangoes.’

Mulia stuck out her thumb and said, ‘*This* will go to her. You are free to ask her a hundred times if you are so concerned.’

Meanwhile Panna too had come out.

Raghu told her, ‘The boys have gone to gather mangoes in this hot weather.’

‘Now who is there to look after them? They may go to the grove, climb trees, drown in the pond. How much can I do on my own?’

‘Shall I go and fetch them?’

‘When your heart is not willing, why should I ask you to go? If you wanted to stop them, you would have done it already. You must have seen them go—’

Panna had not completed her statement when Raghu kept the coconut aside and left for the grove.

6

When Raghu returned from the grove with the boys, he saw Mulia still standing in the hut. He said, ‘Why don’t you go and have your food? I’m not hungry now.’

Mulia said arrogantly, ‘Yes, why should you be hungry? What your brothers ate must have reached your stomach.’

Raghu clenched his teeth and said, ‘Don’t make me angry, Mulia, it won’t be good. The food is not going to disappear anywhere. I won’t die if I miss a meal. Do you think what has happened in this house today is a small matter? You have not merely lit the chulha, you have actually set my heart on fire. I was always proud of the fact that no matter what happens, there will be no break-up in our family. You have destroyed my pride. It’s destiny.’

Mulia said fretfully, ‘Is the responsibility to show such attachment only yours or are others too expected to show it? I have not seen anyone so concerned.’

Raghu drew a deep breath and said, ‘Don’t rub salt on my wounds. It’s because of you that I’m being blamed. If I don’t feel any attachment for this family, who will? I have kept the family together with great effort. Those whom I nurtured in my lap will now become my partners in the land. The kids I used to scold . . . today I cannot even frown at them. If I talk about their welfare, people will accuse me of robbing them. Go, leave me alone. I won’t be able to eat anything now.’

‘Please come in or I’m going to swear an oath to force you to . . .’

‘See, even now the damage can be repaired. Put your obstinacy aside.’

‘If you don’t get up to eat, you may as well drink my blood.’

Raghu touched his ears and said, ‘What have you done? I was about to get up. Come, let me eat. Who will go to have a wash and bathe? But I tell

you, I may eat six chapatis instead of four, you may drown me in ghee, but this stain will not be removed from my heart.'

'All stains will disappear soon. It seems so only for a few days. Don't you see how happy they all are? She also wanted the separation. Now that I've come and she doesn't have full control on your earnings, why should she want to live with us?'

Raghu answered in an anguished tone, 'That is what is painful. I didn't expect this from kaki at all.'

Raghu sat down to eat but the food tasted like poison. It seemed like the chapatis were made of husk. The dal seemed to be like water. Even water would not go down the throat. He did not even glance at the milk. He ate a few morsels and got up, as if he was partaking of a funeral meal of someone intimate. It was the same with dinner. He hardly ate anything. He was merely fulfilling the oath. All night his heart lay troubled. An unknown anxiety gnawed at his heart, as if Bhola Mehto were sitting at the door and weeping. He woke up several times in amazement. It appeared as if Bhola were looking at him with contemptuous eyes.

He would eat twice a day but as if he were eating at the house of his enemy. The sorrow-ridden image of Bhola haunted him constantly. He couldn't get any sleep at night. He would move about the village in a manner characteristic of one who has killed a cow.

7

Five years went by. Raghu was now the father of two sons. A wall had come up in the courtyard. The farmland had been demarcated into two parts. Even the cattle had been shared. Kedar was now sixteen. He gave up his studies and started working in the fields. Khunnu took the cows for grazing. Only Laxman continued going to school. Panna and Mulia couldn't stand each other. Mulia's two children would often be with Panna. She would massage them with gram flour and put collyrium in their eyes. She would hold them in her lap. But Mulia never uttered a single syllable in gratitude. Panna was least interested in such sentiments. Whatever she did,

she did with selflessness. Two of her sons started earning. The girl could cook meals. She herself looked after the other household chores. In contrast Raghu was all alone, too weak, without strength and a little too old for his age. He was not more than thirty but his hair had turned grey and dishevelled. His back was bent. Coughing had weakened him considerably. His sight generated pity. And farming is a task that requires the price of sweat. He was not capable of giving the attention that farming demanded. How then would one expect a good harvest? He had also incurred debts. Such worries were taking their toll. What he needed was rest. After having worked constantly so hard for so many years, he deserved to be free from worries. But Mulia's selfishness and shortsightedness had reduced a thriving farm to ruin. Had everyone lived together, he would have been receiving his pension now. He would have comfortably sat at the door and sipped coconut water. His brothers would have worked and he would have given advice. He would act like Mehto. He would resolve disputes somewhere, while working in the service of saints elsewhere. But that opportunity eluded him.

Finally, a light fever began to bother him constantly. This was the reward of heartache, worries, hard work and deprivation. Initially, he didn't bother. He thought he would recover on his own. But as his weakness increased, he became conscious of the need for medicines. He would take whatever anyone suggested. He was not in a position to consult doctors and vaidyas. And even if he were capable, he could have done nothing but waste money on medicines. The remedy for a fever like that lay in total rest and nutritious food.

Whenever Panna got the opportunity she would come and console him. But her sons never spoke to Raghu. Rather than arrange for treatment for him, they made fun of him. Bhaiya had thought that by separating from us, he would gain prosperity. Bhabhi thought she would be loaded with gold ornaments. Now, we'll see who cares for them. Just wait and see, they will die sobbing. Too much greed is not good. One should strive according to the limits of his capacity and shouldn't sacrifice his life for the sake of money.

‘How is poor Raghu to be blamed?’ Panna asked her sons.

Kedar replied, ‘Come on, Ma. I understand it too well. If I were in bhaiya’s shoes, I would talk with a stick in my hand. Dare she show her obstinacy in this fashion? It was all bhaiya’s doing and it’s all working out as expected.’

At last, one day Raghu’s flickering lamp of life was extinguished. Death brought an end to all his worries. As he lay dying, he had called Kedar but Kedar was busy watering the sugar cane. Apprehensive that he might be sent to fetch medicines, he made some excuse.

8

Mulia’s life was plunged in darkness. The ground on which she had built her wall of ambition slipped away. The stake on the basis of which she had been jumping high had been dislocated from its moorings. The village folk began to talk about how God had meted out the punishment she deserved. She did not dare show her face to the villagers. In shame the poor lass would weep with her children. Everyone seemed to be telling her, ‘In her haughtiness she thought her feet did not touch the ground. So now she’s got the punishment she deserves.’ How will she survive in this house? Who will she depend on? Who will cultivate her land? Poor Raghu was sick and weak, but as long as he was alive he did his job. At times, because of weakness, he would sit and hold his head, rest for a while and then get back to work. The entire harvest was going to waste, and there was no one to look after it. The sheafs of grain lay in the field, the sugar cane was fast drying up. How much could she do by herself? And then watering the fields is not a single man’s job. How would she manage three labourers? There were hardly any labourers in the village. There was a great demand for farm hands. What could one do?

In this way thirteen days passed. She became free after all the funeral rites. Early next morning, Mulia took her two children in her lap and went to thresh grain. After reaching the granary, she put one of them to sleep on the soft grassy bed under a tree and made the other sit on the ground. She

began threshing the grain. She drove the oxen and wept. Had God brought her into the world for this? Things had taken such a sad turn so quickly. Last year during these days when the grain was being threshed, she had brought for Raghu sherbet and pea-pottage in a pot. Today, she was alone! Yet she was not dependent on anyone. Still she did not feel any regret for the family break-up.

Suddenly, she heard the cry of her younger son and when she stared at him, she found her elder son pacifying him endearingly in his lisping voice, 'Little brother, be quiet.' He caressed his face slowly and when the child still wasn't pacified, he lay beside him and embraced him. But as this attempt too failed, he also began to cry.

At that moment Panna came running. She lifted up the younger son in her arms and said, 'Why didn't you leave the children with me, Bahu? *Hai, hai!* Look, the poor child is rolling in the dirt. When I am dead, do what you wish, but now I am alive. You may be living separately but this doesn't mean that the children have become strangers to us.'

'You had no free time either, Amma,' said Mulia. 'What could I do?'

'Why did you come here anyway? In our family there are three sons. They would have taken care of the threshing. Yesterday Kedar was willing to do the threshing but I said, "Water the sugar cane first, then do the threshing." Threshing can wait for ten days. But the sugar cane will dry up without the watering. Since yesterday watering is on and by the day after it will be completed. Then it will be the right time for threshing. You may not believe it, but from the day bhaiya died, Kedar has been worried. Several times a day, he comes and asks, "Are you sure that bhabhi isn't crying much?" If he sees any of the children crying, he comes running and asks, "What happened, mother? Why is the child crying?' Yesterday he wept and said, "Mother, if I had known bhaiya would leave us so soon, I would have taken care of him." While earlier one had to goad him into waking up, now see, he gets up to work in the early hours of the morning. Yesterday Khunnu said, "We will water bhaiya's sugar cane after we have watered ours." Kedar scolded him so much that he didn't utter another word. Kedar said, "What do you mean by our and their sugar cane? If bhaiya had not looked

after us, we would have either been dead or gone begging by now. Today you have become an expert on sugar cane. It is only because of his goodness that today you are living so decently." The day before yesterday, when I went to call him for lunch, he was sitting in the hut and crying. When I asked him, "What makes you cry?" he said, "Bhaiya died because of his grief over the family break-up, otherwise he was hardly of an age to die. I did not understand this at that moment, otherwise I wouldn't have been so unkind to him."'

Having said this much, Panna looked at Mulia meaningfully and said, 'He will not allow you to live separately; he says that if bhaiya has sacrificed his life for us, then we will also do the same for his children.'

Tears streamed down Mulia's eyes. Panna's words were filled with true agony, true compassion and genuine concern. Mulia's heart had never been drawn to her in this way. The one from whom she had expected sarcasm and retaliation had turned out to be a friend in need.

For the first time, she felt ashamed of her selfishness. And for the first time, her soul admonished her for the separation.

9

Nine years have passed since that incident. Panna is old today. Kedar is the master of the house and Mulia the mistress. Khunnu and Laxman have got married. But Kedar is still a bachelor. He says, 'I will not get married.' Many proposals came, but he never gave his consent. Panna tried several means to tempt and trap him, but could not succeed. He says, 'What happiness can women bring? With the arrival of the bride, the mind of the man changes. The wife then becomes everything. Parents, brothers and friends become strangers. If the mind of a man like bhaiya could change, how do others stand a chance? God has given me two sons, what else does one require? Without getting married, I have two sons. Can anything be better than this? Anyone you consider your own is yours, anyone you think a stranger is a stranger.'

One day Panna asked, ‘How will your line continue if you don’t have any progeny?’

‘My progeny is already here. I consider both the boys as my own sons.’

‘If it is a matter of merely how you think, can’t you think of Mulia as your wife?’

Kedar said in embarrassment, ‘You are mocking me, Amma.’

‘What do you mean mocking! She is your bhabhi, after all.’

‘Why should she be interested in an ill-bred fellow like me?’

‘If you are ready, I can ask her.’

‘No, Amma. She may kick up a storm.’

‘If you want, I can sound her out.’

‘I don’t know. Do as you wish.’

Panna understood what he desired. Kedar had fallen for Mulia. But fear and hesitation prevented him from saying anything.

The same day Panna spoke to Mulia, ‘What should I do, Bahu? Desires lie buried in the heart. If only Kedar settles down, I will be free from worry.’

‘But he is determined that he is not going to marry.’

‘He says that if I find a woman who can live in harmony with the rest of us, he will accept her.’

‘Where can one find such a woman? You’ll need to search high and low.’

‘I have already found her.’

‘Really! To which village does she belong?’

‘I shall not disclose that now. I only know this, if she is married to Kedar and his home is made, Kedar will be happy. I don’t know whether the girl will be ready or not.’

‘Why wouldn’t she agree, mother? Where would one find such a handsome and gracious husband who earns his own living? He may have been a saint in his previous birth, otherwise who avoids getting married out of fear of conflict and discord? Where does she live? I will go and convince her.’

‘You can get her consent; it all depends on you.’

‘I shall go today, fall at her feet and get her to agree.’

‘Shall I tell you? It’s you and no one else.’

‘You are making fun of me, Ammaji.’

‘Why should I make fun of you? He is your *devar*, after all.’

‘Why should he be interested in an old woman like me?’

‘His gaze rests on you only. He likes no one else except you. He says nothing out of fear but I know what he truly feels in his heart.’

Mulia’s face, which had become pale and withered by the grief of widowhood, now suddenly turned red like a lotus. Whatever she had lost in ten years returned to her with interest in a moment. The same beauty, the same attraction, the same tenderness and grace!

Translated from the Hindi by Sunita Rani and Nibir K. Ghosh



The Live-in Son-in-Law

1

In the extreme heat of a summer afternoon Haridhan watered the sugar-cane fields, came home and sat outside the house. Smoke was billowing from the roof and there was a jingling sound in the air. Both his brothers-in-law returned from the field and entered the house, as did their sons. But Haridhan waited outside. The ill treatment he had been receiving for the past month, especially the chiding the day before, seemed to have put fetters on his feet. Yesterday his mother-in-law had told him, 'I am fed up with you. Am I responsible for your upkeep for the rest of your life?' But it was his wife's insensitiveness that broke his heart. She was a mute witness to the whole scene and not once did the words 'Amma, why do you keep insulting him?' escape her lips. *Perhaps my humiliation pleases her,* thought Haridhan. How could he possibly enter this house? Only to be humiliated and disgraced again! *This is my fate after living in this house for a whole decade,* thought Haridhan. *Do I labour any less than the others? I chop fodder, draw water and feed the bulls when both my brothers-in-law remain cocooned in sweet slumber. They smoke the chillum but I, I shut my eyes and keep working. At dusk everybody goes for musical soirées, while I milk the buffaloes and cows late into the night. As a reward for my work, no one even calls me for dinner. Instead, what do I get— abuse!*

His wife, Gumani, emerged from the house with a pail and said, ‘Listen, draw some water from the well. There is not a single drop in the house!’

Haridhan took the pail and brought water from the well. He was very hungry and assumed that his wife would call him for dinner; instead, she just entered the house with the pail and didn’t come out. Fatigued and hungry, Haridhan fell asleep.

Suddenly, Gumani woke him up.

Without getting up, Haridhan said, ‘What is it? Won’t you even let me rest or do you want more water?’

Gumani replied bitterly, ‘Why do you growl? I have come to call you for supper.’

Haridhan saw his brothers-in-law and the two sons of his elder brother-in-law coming out after their meal. His body seemed to catch fire. *Have I become so base that I cannot share a meal with them? Now they are the masters. I am expected to lick leftovers off their plates. I am a dog who is tossed a piece of bread after the owners have eaten.* This was the same house which had treated him with so much respect only ten years ago. His brothers-in-law used to act like his slaves. His mother-in-law used to fawn on him. His wife worshipped him. Then he had had money and property—money and property which he had handed over to these people while submitting himself to poverty. Now he couldn’t even afford bread. A volcano seemed to erupt in his soul and all he wanted was to bathe his in-laws in boiling lava. But he restrained himself and said, ‘I am not hungry. I will not eat today.’

Gumani replied, ‘So don’t eat, what do I care? If you eat, food will enter your belly, not mine.’

Haridhan’s anger melted into tears. *She is my wife, for whom I have reduced my riches to dust. They want to make a fool of me and throw me out of the house. Where should I go? What should I do?*

His mother-in-law came in and said, ‘Why don’t you have your meal? Who are you angry with? No one has the patience to bear with your tantrums any more. Don’t give us any money if you don’t want to. We have married our daughter to you but we are not responsible for your life.’

Haridhan, deeply grieved, said, ‘Yes, Amma, I was mistaken. What do I have now that will make you feel responsible for me? When I had wealth, I had something to bargain with. Now that I am poor, why would you care about me?’

The old woman marched into the house in a huff.

2

To children a father is peripheral, a luxury, like gram to a horse or sweets to the rich. A mother is the staple diet. If one is deprived of delicacies for one’s whole life, no problem. But keep a man away from bread and water for a day and see what happens! The father meets his child in the mornings and evenings, plays with him, loves him, takes him in his arms and sometimes holds his finger and takes him for a walk—that’s where his function ends. Even if the father goes to a foreign land, it makes no difference to the child. A mother, on the other hand, is the whole universe to a child. He cannot bear to be separated from her even for a minute. It doesn’t matter who the father is: all a child wants is a man to play with. The mother is a child’s very own. If the mother is no more, the fountain of a child’s life dries up. He becomes like Lord Shiva’s mount, Nandi, to whom a floral offering can be made but is not mandatory.

Haridhan’s mother had died ten years ago. He had then been a young man of sixteen and already married. After his mother’s death he felt helpless and neglected, as if nobody had any authority on him any more. His sisters were married and he had no brother. Poor Haridhan was scared to remain in the house alone. He wept for his mother but was scared of her shadow. He never set eyes on the room where his mother had breathed her last. There was only his aunt who really cared for him and repeatedly inquired after him—‘Son, do you need something to eat?’ His father’s affection for him also grew: he bought a new cow for Haridhan and sometimes gave him money to spend as he liked. But these gestures were balms which couldn’t heal him. It was his soul that suffered. All this love and affection only reminded him of his mother. Besides, how could this

new-found affection compare to even his mother's rebukes? Getting something out of her after pleas, fights and tantrums had its own pleasure, unlike these acts of charity. Earlier he was healthier; he begged for food, fought for food. Now he was sick; his needs were fulfilled with better things but the hunger was gone.

He continued to be in the same state for a whole year. Then, a change occurred. A new woman whom people called his mother entered their house and, within no time, descended like a black cloud on his little world—his zest for life dried up and darkness veiled the light. Haridhan never talked to his stepmother, never went to her. One day, he left home and went to his in-laws' house.

His father called him many times, but Haridhan never visited him as long as the old man lived. When he learnt about his father's death, he felt a wicked pleasure. Not a single tear flowed from in his eyes.

In the new world Haridhan rediscovered the pleasure of maternal love. His mother-in-law was the vision of a saint; she filled his empty life with joy and fascination. Greenery crept back into the desert. Haridhan's heart found a sense of fulfilment in the maternal affection of his mother-in-law, the teasing of his sisters-in-law, the good humour of his brothers-in-law and the love of his wife. His mother-in-law said, 'Son, treat this house as your own; you are the apple of my eyes.' She would complain to him about her sons and daughters-in-law. Over time, Haridhan began to think that his mother-in-law loved him more than her sons. After the death of his father, he went to his house, sold his share of the property and returned with a bagful of money. Now he was accorded more respect than before. He placed all his wealth at the feet of his mother-in-law and considered his life complete. Earlier he used to be homesick, but now he forgot it completely, as though that house was filled with bad memories and was better forgotten. He would get up early and work more than the others. The villagers were astonished at his hard work and sincerity. They praised his father-in-law on his good fortune. But as days passed by, the esteem and respect for him diminished. From divinity, he degenerated into just another member of the house and then into a slave. Even food was sparingly available to him.

Humiliation was heaped on him. If all the people at home were also starving, he would have followed suit without complaint. But when he observed that everybody was hale and hearty and only he was considered unwanted, he felt depressed and gloomy. He was hardly twenty-five years old. How could he spend the rest of his life in this house? Moreover, his wife too had turned away from him, which was the most heart-rending aspect of the tragedy.

3

Haridhan was hungry and worried. Inside the house his mother-in-law and the two brothers-in-law were engaged in conversation. Gumani seemed to agree with whatever was being said.

The elder brother-in-law said, 'He claims equal status with us. Does Haridhan not know that no one has taken responsibility for his life? Ten years have passed. Has he not spent, say, two or three thousand rupees?'

The younger brother-in-law said, 'If he was a labourer, we could have rebuked and chided him but what do we do about him now? God knows how we can get rid of him! In his heart he must be thinking, didn't I give them two thousand rupees? Little does he know that those two thousand rupees were spent long ago. He needs one and a half kilograms of food for every meal!'

His mother-in-law remarked in a serious tone, 'He is a glutton.'

Gumani, who was picking lice from her mother's head, said in disdain, 'An idler only knows how to eat.'

His older brother-in-law said, 'It is not the matter of food. One must eat according to his appetite but also give something in return. Can a person remain a guest all his life?'

The younger brother-in-law quipped, 'One day I will tell him point blank: Leave us alone and look after yourself. We don't owe you anything.'

This kind of talk in the house had made Gumani hate her husband. If he had had a stable income, he would have been respected, and she would have been treated as a queen. Why did he not go out, find work and make some

money? Gumani's thoughts and feelings were still childish. As she did not have her own house, the well-being of her mother's house was her primary concern. She thought on the same lines and spoke the same words as her family members. The truth of the matter was this: what could two thousand rupees buy? Spread over ten years, it was worth even less: around two hundred per year. Does a couple not require two hundred a year for food? And then there are clothes, milk, ghee—a whole lot of expenditure. Ten years have passed and he has not been able to buy even a brass ring. The idea of moving out of the house scares him to death. He thinks that the respect he once enjoyed will be waiting for him forever. Things were different then and things are different now: he must respect that. Even a daughter-in-law who goes to her in-laws for the first time is given respect and received well. The moment she walks past her husband's threshold, music plays, all the village women throng to see her face and make offerings of money. For months on end she is given good food and clothing and kept away from work. But once six months pass, nobody cares for her. She becomes a slave of the house. *Had I lived with his parents, the same would have happened to me. Then why make a fuss? If you are under the impression that you work for your living, it is your mistake.* There's a difference between a wife and a labourer. The labourer can be rebuked, beaten up, hired and fired at will. He is made to do extremely hard work: it's not as if he can work when he wants to and sleep at his own will.

4

Haridhan was on the bed fretting and fuming when his brothers-in-law came to him. The elder one said, 'Why don't you get up, brother? It is afternoon. How long do you plan on sleeping? There is a lot of work in the fields.'

Haridhan sat up and said sharply, 'Do you take me for a fool?'

Both the brothers-in-law were struck dumb. The man who never loosened his tongue and always served like a slave had suddenly become self-respecting and assertive. They had no answer.

Haridhan understood that they were losing ground. He could not resist another push. He continued in the same vein. ‘I have eyes, you know. I am neither blind nor deaf. I do the hard yards and I am still treated like a dog. You cannot keep making a fool of me.’

The older brother-in-law said angrily, ‘Nobody has tied you down here.’

Now Haridhan was perplexed and had no answer. The elder one continued in the same tone, ‘If you think you can be a guest here all your life and also command respect, that is your problem, not ours.’

Haridhan’s eyes widened in anger. ‘Don’t I work as hard as you do?’

‘Who says so?’

‘Then it is the custom of your household that he who works most dies from starvation!’

‘You yourself refuse to eat. Do you want us to force-feed you?’

Haridhan chewed his lips in anger. ‘I refuse to eat? Aren’t you ashamed of saying that?’

‘Did sister not come to call you at dinner time?’ the younger brother-in-law said. ‘Mother also called you to come and have supper. You said that you were not hungry. What could she do?’

His mother-in-law suddenly emerged from the house and said, ‘I was tired of calling you for supper, yet you did not move.’

Haridhan’s voice was filled with poison, blood and fire. ‘Am I to eat your children’s leftovers? Am I a dog that you throw stale crumbs at me?’

The old lady said arrogantly, ‘So are you comparing yourself with my sons?’

Haridhan was completely devastated. The old lady’s insult was the final straw. His brows loosened, the fire in his eyes dimmed, and his twitching nostrils became calm. Like a wounded person he collapsed. ‘So are you comparing yourself with my sons?’ These words pierced his heart like a spear—it was as if the spear kept sinking into his heart and his heart kept growing.

All the members of the family had their meal except Haridhan. His mother-in-law, sister-in-law, father-in-law, and both the brothers-in-law coaxed and cajoled him to have supper but Haridhan did not move and slept near the door on a mat. He later took the mat on the platform near the well and slept there.

It was late at night. In the vast expanse of the sky the countless stars played like little children. Some jumped, some laughed, some shut their eyes and said peekaboo! Once in a while a brave star leapt and covered a vast expanse in a moment and disappeared. Haridhan remembered his childhood, when even he used to play like the stars. The memories glittered like constellations. He remembered the playground where he used to play kabaddi. The affectionate face of his mother appeared before him, kindness and pain flashing in her eyes. He could see his teary-eyed mother extending her hands to embrace and shower him with love and affection. He cried like a baby and these words spluttered out of his mouth—'Mother, you have forsaken me! Look at the wretched condition of your son. Nobody loves me at all. In the place where you are, is there no room for me?'

Suddenly Gumani shouted, 'Are you asleep? Why don't you eat?'

Haridhan was jolted awake from his dream world. He saw the platform of the well, the same torn mat and Gumani standing in front of him. 'How long should we wait for you to wake up?'

Haridhan sat up and his voice was now the drawing of a sword from its sheath. 'Well, you have finally remembered me! But didn't I tell you that I am not hungry?'

'Just how many days do you plan to fast?' Gumani challenged him.

'I will not drink water in this house. Will you come with me or not?'

Haridhan's firm determination frightened Gumani out of her wits. She asked, 'Where are you going?'

Haridhan spoke as if intoxicated, 'It is none of your business. Will you come with me or not? Don't complain later that I did not ask you.'

Gumani objected, 'Why don't you tell me where you are going?'

'Will you come with me or not?'

'Not as long as you don't tell me where you are going.'

‘I see you do not want to come with me. That’s all right, I just wanted to hear your answer, otherwise I would have gone halfway by now.’

He got up and left for his own home. Gumani continued to shout, ‘Listen! Listen!’ He never turned back to even glance at her.

6

Haridhan travelled the distance of thirty miles in five hours. When he reached the mango orchards of his village, the memory of his mother welled up inside him. At the sight of the temple’s golden dome, he was so happy that he could have reached the top in one leap. He ran fast, as though his mother were calling for him with open arms. He reached the mango orchards and stood under the trees he had once climbed and played at elephant-riding on. He remembered the heavenly taste of raw mangoes and sat down and wept, as though he was telling his tale of woe to his mother. The vast image of his mother pervaded the whole atmosphere, the air, the sunlight; every inch of the earth was blessed with the imprints of his mother’s feet and the air filled with vestiges of her spoken words. The invisible elixir of the place filled his grief-stricken heart with childlike joy. He climbed a tree, plucked the mangoes and began eating. The curt words of his mother-in-law, the harshness and humiliation inflicted by his wife, were all forgotten. His feet had swollen up and the soles were burning with pain but he forgot all of it in his new-found joy.

Suddenly the gardener shouted, ‘Who is there? Get down at once or I’ll throw stones so hard that your body will become cold right there on the branch.’

He shouted and cursed but the curses only made Haridhan happier. He hid in the branches, plucked the mangoes and threw them down and laughed boisterously. He hadn’t laughed this way for a long time.

The gardener seemed to recognize the laughter but it struck him as odd. How could Haridhan be here? He was freeloading at his in-laws’. How fun-loving and mischievous he used to be! God knows how he is. He used to

jump from the branches straight into the pond. There was no one like him in the village.

The gardener was angry now. ‘Come down quietly or I will climb up and tear that smile from your face.’

He was about to scold him again when a mango seed fell on his head. He rubbed the sore spot and said, ‘Who the devil is it? You won’t listen, right . . . Wait, let me get you.’

In a fit of anger he put down his club and, like a monkey, scrambled up the tree only to find Haridhan grinning at him. He was stunned. ‘Aye, Haridhan, when did you get here? How long have you been sitting here?’

The childhood friends embraced.

‘When did you come? Let us go home, good fellow. Didn’t you even get mangoes there?’

Haridhan smiled, ‘Mangru, the taste of the mangoes of our village can be found nowhere else. How is the village?’

‘Everything is in fine fettle, brother. You completely severed your ties with us. No one abandons his village like this! Your family has been in disarray since your father’s passing. He has left behind two small children. What can they do?’

Haridhan said, ‘I have nothing to do with this family, brother. I have taken my share. Would you give me some job? I will take your cow out to graze—in return, give me food.’

Mangru said in disbelief, ‘What are you saying, brother? I am ready to sacrifice my life for you. Won’t you go back to your in-laws’? Don’t worry, you have your own house. There are two small children in it, take care of them. You were unnecessarily scared of your stepmother. She is a simple and innocent lady. Look upon her as your own mother. She will be very happy to find you here. Will you bring your wife too?’

‘I will not see her face any more. She is dead to me.’

‘Then find a new wife. I will find you such a bride that you will dote on her. But what if the first one turns up?’

‘She won’t.’

7

Haridhan went to his house. When his two brothers saw him, they ran happily to inform their mother. As he stepped into the house, he experienced such peace of mind it felt as if he were in the lap of his mother. After all the battering he had taken over the past few days, his heart was now at peace. The sense of arrogance, obstinacy and boastfulness was replaced by frustration, defeat and longing. The ailment was less serious now; even a simple remedy was enough to cure it. The castles caved in, making way for entry. The house that he had left in disgust was now ready to give him refuge. Haridhan was now completely happy to live in this house.

In the evening his stepmother told him, 'Son, we are fortunate that you have come back. Take care of these children, you are still bound by paternal relations. Just give me enough food to survive. I will eat quietly and sleep in a corner. Your mother was like a sister to me. That relation too makes you my son.'

Haridhan's craving for his mother found reciprocation in his stepmother. In every nook and corner of the house, Haridhan found the manifestation of his mother's memory, which was also reflected on his stepmother's face.

The next day Haridhan placed the plough on his shoulder and left for the fields. There was happiness on his face and pride in his eyes. Now he was not the one who begged for shelter, but rather, a provider of shelter. He was not a beggar in someone's house but a custodian of his own.

One day Haridhan learnt that Gumani had remarried. He said to his stepmother, 'Aunt, Gumani has remarried.'

'How can she remarry—is this a joke? Is no one bothered in the clan? If the panchayat does not settle the issue, we shall go to court.'

Haridhan replied, 'No, aunt, it is good for us. I will offer sweets to the gods. I was scared that she would latch on to me. God has heard my prayers. When I left her, I promised I would never see her face again.'

Translated from the Hindi by M. Asaduddin



The Woman Who Sold Grass

1

Mulia came in with bundles of freshly cut grass, her wheatish complexion flushed and her large intoxicating eyes filled with apprehension. Seeing her, Mahaveer asked, ‘What happened, Mulia, how are you feeling today?’

Mulia didn’t answer, her eyes were teary.

Mahaveer came closer and asked, ‘What happened, why don’t you tell me? Has someone said something? Has mother scolded you? Why are you sad?’

Mulia said, sobbing, ‘Nothing. What could have happened? I’m fine.’

Mahaveer looked at Mulia from head to toe, ‘Are you going to cry in secret? Won’t you tell me?’

Dodging the question, Mulia said, ‘There’s got to be something to tell, what should I say?’

Mulia was a rose in that desert. She had a wheatish complexion, doe-like eyes, an elongated chin, slightly rosy cheeks, long pointed eyelashes and unusually sparkling eyes that clearly reflected a pain, a mute anguish. Who knows how this angel had descended into that home of Chamars! Was her soft, flower-like body made to carry a basket of grass on the head for selling? There were people in the village willing to dance to her tunes, who yearned for a glance from her, who would feel uplifted by even a single

word from her but she had been there longer than a year and no one had seen her glance at or talk to these youths. When she stepped out with her grass, it felt as if the light of dawn, dressed in gold, was going past, evenly scattering its rays. Seeing her, some serenaded her, others put their hands to their hearts but Mulia went by silently with her eyes lowered. People would exclaim with amazement, 'Such pride! And what is special about Mahaveer anyway? He is not in the prime of his life; God knows how she lives with him!'

But that day something had happened which other women of this community might keep secret, but for Mulia it was like a stake through her heart. That morning the fragrance of mango blossoms danced in the breeze, the sky seemed to shower gold on the earth. When, with the basket on her head, Mulia stepped out to cut grass, the rays of the morning sun transformed her dusky colour into gold. Suddenly, Chain Singh appeared before her. Mulia wanted to slink away but Chain Singh grabbed her hand and said, 'Mulia, don't you feel any pity for me at all?'

Mulia's flower-like face ignited like a volcano. She wasn't in the least bit afraid and didn't hesitate for a moment; she put down her basket and said, 'Leave me or I'll shout.' Chain Singh experienced something new that day. What use was beauty and grace in lower-caste women if not to be playthings for the upper castes? He had achieved many such feats but Mulia's countenance, her anger and pride, shocked him out of his wits. Embarrassed, he let go of her hand. Mulia strode ahead. In the heat of the battle you don't feel the pain; it's only later that it hurts. Having walked some distance, Mulia realized how angry and afraid she was, how helpless, and her eyes filled with tears. She tried to hold them back but soon she was sobbing. If she hadn't been so poor, who would have dared to insult her! She kept crying as she cut the grass. She knew Mahaveer's temper. If she told him, he'd be out for the Thakur's blood, and who knows what would happen then! She got goosebumps at the very thought of it. That's why she didn't answer Mahaveer's questions.

The next day Mulia did not go to cut grass. Her mother-in-law asked, ‘Why don’t you go? All the others have gone.’

Mulia lowered her head and said, ‘I won’t go alone.’

‘Do you think you’ll be carried off by a tiger?’ her mother-in-law said in a rage.

Mulia bent her head even further and said in a low voice, ‘Everybody teases me.’

The mother-in-law chided her, ‘You don’t want to go with the others and you don’t want to go alone. Why don’t you say clearly that you don’t want to go at all? You can’t carry on like a queen in my house. No one cares much for your beauty, they want their work done. You are very beautiful but can I live on your beauty? Take the basket and go get grass.’

Mahaveer was rubbing down the horse under the shadow of the neem tree by the door. He saw Mulia leaving with a tearful face but he couldn’t say anything. If he had his way, he would keep her close to his heart and before his eyes, but the horse needed to be fed. If he bought grass, it would cost him no less than twelve annas a day. He sometimes managed to earn a rupee or two but there was no guarantee. And where could he earn that kind of money? He hardly earned one and a half or two rupees; he was able to sometimes and sometimes he was not. Ever since these ruinous lorries had been introduced, the *ekkawala*s’ animals had gone out of work. Nobody even wants to travel for free. He’d bought the ekka and the horse with a loan of a hundred and fifty rupees from the moneylender, but who cares for ekkas when there are lorries? He couldn’t pay back the moneylender—not even the interest, forget the principal!

He said half-heartedly, ‘If you don’t feel like going, let it be, we’ll see.’

This show of sympathy pleased Mulia. ‘What will the horse eat?’ she asked.

She avoided yesterday’s path today and walked between the mounds on the fields. She kept looking around cautiously. Sugar-cane fields lay on both sides. Even the smallest sound numbed her—what if someone was hiding in the sugar cane? But nothing happened. She passed the sugar-cane fields and the mango orchards; irrigated lands came into view. A pulley was running

in a well in the distance. The mounds of earth in the fields were thick with green grass. Greed came over Mulia. In half an hour she could gather more grass here than what a dry field would yield over the entire afternoon! *Nobody keeps watch over here. If somebody shouts, I'll leave.* She squatted and started skinning the grass, and in an hour's time more than half her basket was full. She was so engrossed in her work that she didn't notice Chain Singh coming. When she suddenly raised her head at the sound of footsteps, she saw him before her.

Mulia's heart froze. She wanted to run, to turn over the basket and go home with the empty basket but Chain Singh said from some yards away, 'Don't be afraid, don't be afraid, for God's sake! I won't trouble you. Take as much grass as you want, it's my field.'

Mulia's hands were numb, the small hoe remained glued to her hand and she couldn't even see the grass. She wanted the ground to open and swallow her. The world seemed to float in front of her eyes.

Chain Singh asked reassuringly, 'Why don't you cut? Have I ever made an objection? Come out here every day, I'll help you cut too.'

Mulia was as still as a painted figure.

Chain Singh took a step forward and said, 'Why are you so scared of me! You think I've come to trouble you again? God knows that yesterday too I didn't take your hand to harass you. Seeing you, my hand just moved on its own. I lost my mind. You went away; I sat there crying for hours. I felt like chopping off my hand. I felt like consuming poison. I've been searching for you since and finally you came this way. Looking for you everywhere, I ended up here. You can punish me as much as you want. Even if you decide to chop my head off, my neck won't tremble. I was a rogue, a loafer, but after seeing you, I've been cleansed of all wickedness. I wish I were your dog and could follow you everywhere, or your horse whom you feed grass with your hands. If only this follower of yours could be of some use to you. My youth is cursed if I say this insincerely! Mahaveer is lucky to have got an angel like you.'

Mulia had been listening quietly and now, lowering her head, asked innocently, 'So what do you want me to do?'

Chain Singh came closer and said, ‘I want only your kindness.’

Mulia looked up and glanced at him. Her sense of shame had vanished. She said sharply, ‘Can I ask you something? Don’t mind. Are you married?’

Chain Singh replied in a suppressed voice, ‘Yes I am married, but what is marriage, it’s only a game.’

A scornful smile played on Mulia’s lips. She said, ‘Still, if my man spoke to your woman like this, how would you feel? Wouldn’t you be ready to chop his head off? Speak! What do you think—that Mahaveer is a Chamar so there’s no blood in his veins, he has no sense of shame, no idea about his dignity. You are fond of my looks. Don’t women many times more beautiful wander near the ghats? I can’t even be compared to the soles of their feet. Why don’t you appeal to one of them? Are they lacking in pity? But you won’t go there because it wounds your heart to do that. You dare to ask me because I’m a *chamarin*, from the lower caste, and women from the lower caste, with a little threatening and tempting, can be easily caught in your fist. It’s a cheap bargain. You’re a Thakur, why would you let such a chance pass?’

Embarrassed, Chain Singh said, ‘Mulia, that’s not true. I’m telling you the truth. It’s not a matter of high or low birth. Everybody is equal. I’m willing to place my head at your feet.’

Mulia said, ‘That’s because you know I can’t do a thing. Go place your head at the feet of a Kshatriya woman and then you’ll see the outcome of placing your head at the feet of a woman. Your head won’t be left standing on your neck.’

Chain Singh was sinking into the ground in shame. His face had the withered look of someone who has just spent months on the sickbed. No words came out of his mouth. Mulia was outspoken without being proud.

She spoke again, ‘I go to the market every day, I know what goes on in the big houses. Is there one well-to-do home which doesn’t employ a syce, a coachman, a water-carrier, a priest and a cook? All these people are diversions for the rich. Whatever those rich women do, they’re right in doing! Don’t their husbands go around losing their hearts to chamarins and *kaharin*s? The give and take is even. But the poor have no such means. I am

everything to my husband. He would never even glance at another woman. It's a matter of chance that I'm a little pretty but even if I were black and ugly, he would treat me the same. I'm quite sure about it. I may be a chamarin but I will not stoop so low as to repay his faith with deception. Yes, if he starts following his fancies, if he makes me suffer, then I'll do the same to him. You're crazy about my looks, aren't you? If I suddenly grow pockmarked, if I turn blind in one eye, you won't even spare me a glance. Tell me, am I lying?'

Chain Singh could not deny it.

Mulia continued in the same proud tone, 'If I turn blind in not just one but both eyes, he will still treat me the same way. He will nurse me and feed me. You want me to cheat such a person? Go! And never tease me again, or it won't be good for you.'

3

Youth is passion, strength, kindness, courage, self-confidence, honour and everything that makes life sacred, bright and complete. Youth is intoxicated with pride, cruelty, selfishness, impertinence, material love, wickedness and all that leads life towards beastliness, deterioration and ruin. Chain Singh was drunk on youth. Mulia's cool nature brought him back to his senses just as a splash of water poured over boiling syrup rids it of its impurities and a clear, pure liquid comes forth. Chain Singh's youthful obsession had been sent packing, only youth remained. The words of a beautiful woman can as easily make one lose one's faith as they can bring deliverance.

Chain Singh was a changed man from that day on. He had been short-tempered, used to swearing at, scolding and beating up his workmen over small things. The powerless trembled before him. The labourers would get busy with their work whenever they saw him approaching but no sooner had he turned his back than they'd start smoking their chillums. In their hearts, everybody hated him and bad-mouthed him. But from that day on, Chain Singh became so kind-hearted, so serious and patient that the people were awestruck.

Many days passed. One evening Chain Singh went on an inspection of his farm. Water was being drawn there for irrigation. He saw that the canal had cracked in one place and water was running waste. It wasn't reaching the beds but the old woman who had made them was sitting idly by. She didn't seem concerned about finding out why the water wasn't reaching the beds. If he'd seen this happen earlier, Chain Singh would have lost it. He would have cut the woman's wages for the day, and snarled at the workers operating the pulley, but that day he stayed calm. He took some clay and bound the fissure on the canal; then he went into the field and said to the old woman, 'You're sitting here while all the water is running waste.'

Agitated, the old woman said, 'It must have opened just now, my master! I'll go right now and fix it.'

She was trembling as she said this. Calming her, Chain Singh said, 'Don't run away, don't run away, I've closed the canal. Haven't seen the old man for many days. Does he go to work or not?'

Delighted, the old woman said, 'He's sitting idle nowadays, Bhaiya, there's nowhere for him to work.'

Chain Singh said gently, 'So put him to work with me. There's a little hemp, tell him to cut it.'

Having said this, he went towards the well. Four pulleys were at work there but two of the four labourers had gone off to eat *ber*. The other two were stunned to see Chain Singh. *If the Thakur asks about the others, what will we say? All of us will be scolded*. Poor creatures, they were squirming inside. Chain Singh asked, 'Where have those two gone?'

No sound came from either of their mouths. Suddenly, the other two could be seen making their way; each had bers tucked into a corner of his dhoti. They were chatting gaily as they walked but as soon as they saw Chain Singh, they shrivelled up with fear. Each foot felt as heavy as a quintal. They could neither move forward nor go back. Both knew that they'd be scolded and that their wages might be withheld as well; this slowed them down. Chain Singh called out to them, 'Come on, come on, what are the bers like, let me sample them, they're from my tree, aren't they?'

The two men were even more terrified. *The Thakur won't leave us alive today. See how sweetly he speaks. That's exactly how brutally he'll beat us.* The poor things were withering away. Chain Singh said again, 'Get here at once, I'll take all the ripe ones. One of you run home and get some salt. (To the other two workers) You two also join us; the bers from that tree are sweet. Eat some bers; work will always go on.'

Now the two truants were a little encouraged. They put all the bers before Chain Singh and started picking out the ripe ones for him. One of them ran to fetch some salt. For half an hour the pulleys stayed still. When all the bers were eaten and Chain Singh made to leave, the two offenders joined their hands. 'Bhaiyaji, please spare us today, we were very hungry or we wouldn't have gone.'

Chain Singh said softly, 'So, what's wrong with that? I had ber too. And we wasted an hour or so, that's all. If you want, you can do an hour's work in half an hour. If you don't want to do it, then even an hour's work can't be finished over a whole day.'

Chain Singh left, and the four of them fell into a discussion.

First: 'If the master stays like this, one would feel like working. It's difficult to work when someone's always breathing down your neck.'

Second: 'I thought he would eat us alive today.'

Third: 'I've been noticing him for some days, he's grown softer.'

Fourth: 'Let's see if we get a full day's wages in the evening, then we'll talk.'

First: 'You're so dim-witted. You can't even judge a person's countenance.'

Second: 'We should work whole-heartedly now.'

Third: 'Of course! When he has shown faith in us, it's our duty to do our best.'

Fourth: 'As for me, folks, I still can't trust the Thakur.'

Chain Singh had to go to court on work one day. It was a journey of about five miles. He usually went on horseback but the sun was quite harsh that day, so he decided to take an ekka instead. Mahaveer was sent word that he should take him along. Mahaveer called out to him at about nine o'clock. Chain Singh was ready; he quickly mounted the ekka. But the horse was so emaciated, the seat so dirty and tattered, everything so shabby, that Chain Singh was embarrassed to sit on it. He asked, 'Why is all this stuff in such a bad condition, Mahaveer? Your horse was never so feeble. Are there very few passengers these days?' Mahaveer said, 'No, master, there are passengers, but who asks for an ekka when there are lorries? I'd go home with two or three rupees earlier, I now hardly even get twenty annas. What should I feed the horse and what should I eat myself? I'm in big trouble. I'm thinking of selling off the ekka and the horse and working for those like you, but it's hard to find takers. A sum of at least twelve annas goes on the horse, not counting the grass. When we go hungry most of the time, who is going to care for the horse?'

Chain Singh looked at his torn kurta and said, 'Why don't you farm some two or three bighas of land?'

Mahaveer bowed his head and said, 'Farming takes a lot of hard work. I'm thinking that if I get a client, I'll remove the ekka's spare parts and use it for ferrying grass to the market. Both my mother and wife go out to gather grass these days. That's the only way ten or twelve annas come my way.'

Chain Singh asked, 'So the old woman goes to the market?'

Mahaveer said shamefaced, 'No, Bhaiya, how could she walk so far? My wife goes. She cuts grass till the afternoon and then heads to the market. By the time she returns, it's late at night. It's hard, but what to do, how does one fight one's fate?'

Chain Singh reached the court and Mahaveer, taking his ekka this way and that in search of passengers, went into the city. Chain Singh asked him to return by five.

At about four, Chain Singh emerged from his work. There was a paan shop nearby and a little further on a large banyan tree in whose shade stood

dozens of tongas, ekkas and phaetons. The horses had been untied. These were the carriages of lawyers, attorneys and officers. Chain Singh drank some water, had a paan and thought that if he got a lorry he would head to town for a bit, when his eye fell on a grass-cutter woman. With a basketful of grass on her head, she was bargaining with the syces. Chain Singh's heart leapt with joy—it was Mulia! She was dressed up nicely in a pink sari and was bargaining with the coachmen. Many coachmen had gathered; some bantered with her, some stared, some laughed at her.

A coal-dark coachman said to her, 'Mula, the grass is, at the very most, worth six annas.'

Mulia stared at him with her passion-arousing eyes and said, 'If you want it in six annas, the grass-cutters are sitting over there. Go on, you'll get it for two to four paisa less. But my grass you won't get for less than twelve annas.'

A middle-aged coachman said from atop his phaeton, 'It's your day, why twelve annas, ask for a rupee. The takers will take it boastfully. The lawyers are about to come out, there isn't much time left.'

A tongawala in a pink turban said, 'The old man's mouth is watering, why would Mulia spare us a glance now?'

Chain Singh was so furious he wanted to hit these scoundrels with his shoes. How everyone is staring at her, as if they will drink her up with their eyes. And Mulia is so happy here. She isn't shying away or hesitating or submitting. How, passing around smiles, looking about with her attractive eyes, sliding her sari further and further off her head, turning her face at everyone, she speaks. The same Mulia who had roared like a lioness at him!

It was now four o'clock. A carnival of agents, lawyers and attorneys appeared. The agents ran towards the lorries. The lawyers and attorneys headed to their carriages. The coachmen quickly readied their horses. Many of the dignitaries ogled lustily at Mulia as they boarded their vehicles.

Suddenly Mulia took her basket and ran after a phaeton. A young lawyer sahib turned out in the English fashion sat in it. He got Mulia to keep the grass on the footstep and, taking out something from his pocket, handed it

to her. Mulia smiled, the two said something to each other, which Chain Singh could not hear.

In the next instant, Mulia, happy-faced, was heading home. Chain Singh, hypnotized, remained standing near the paan shop. When the shopkeeper wound up, put on his clothes, shut the door of his cabin and came down, Chain Singh came to life. He asked, 'Have you closed your shop?'

The shopkeeper said sympathetically, 'Please get some treatment for this, Thakur Sahib, this illness is not a good thing!'

Chain Singh was astonished and asked, 'What illness?'

The shopkeeper said, 'What illness! You've been standing here for the last half an hour as if you were dead. The court has emptied, all the shops have closed, even the sweepers have gone—have you noticed anything? This is a serious illness, get it treated quickly.'

Chain Singh took his stick and went to the gate and saw Mahaveer's ekka coming towards him.

5

When some distance had been covered, Chain Singh asked, 'How much did you earn today, Mahaveer?'

Mahaveer laughed and said, 'Master, today I was left waiting all day. Nobody wanted a ride even for free. On top of that I smoked bidis for four paise.'

After a while Chain Singh said, 'I have some advice for you. You take a rupee from me every day, and whenever I call for you come over with your ekka. Then your wife won't have to go with grass to the market. Do you agree?'

Mahaveer looked at him with bright eyes and said, 'Master, I eat your salt, I am your subject. Whenever you want, just call for me. To take money from you—'

Chain Singh interrupted, 'No, I don't want free service from you. Come and get a rupee from me every day. Don't send your wife with grass to the market. Your honour is my honour. And whenever you need more money,

don’t hesitate to come and get it. Yes, and see to it that you don’t discuss this matter with Mulia. What’s the use!’

One evening, many days later, Mulia happened to meet Chain Singh. Having finished his transactions with his debtors, he was heading home when, at the very spot where he had seized Mulia’s hand, her voice came to him. Chain Singh stopped short and looked back to see Mulia running towards him. He said, ‘What is it, Mula? Why do you run when I am waiting for you?’

Mulia was panting and said, ‘I’ve wanted to meet you for many days. When I saw you coming, I ran. I don’t go to sell grass these days.’

Chain Singh said, ‘That’s good.’

‘Have you ever seen me selling grass?’

‘Yes, I saw you one day. Has Mahaveer told you everything? I asked him not to.’

‘He never hides anything from me.’

They stood quietly for a second. Neither knew what to say. Suddenly, Mulia said with a smile, ‘This is where you held my hand.’

Chain Singh said in embarrassment, ‘Forget about that, Mula. God knows what devil had possessed me.’

Mulia said in a faltering voice, ‘Why should I forget about it? You’re still fulfilling the obligation you took on by seizing my arm. Poverty makes people do what it will. You have saved me.’

They both fell silent again. After a little while Mulia said, ‘You must have thought that I was oblivious to all that laughter and talk?’

Chain Singh said forcefully, ‘No, Mulia, I didn’t think that for even a moment.’

Mulia said with a smile, ‘This is what I expected from you. And still expect.’

The air was coming down to rest on the furrowed fields, the sun was slipping away silently into the lap of the night, and in that dim light Chain Singh stood watching Mulia’s figure slowly fade into the darkness.

Translated from the Hindi by Ranjeeta Dutta and Anjum Hasan



A Narrow Escape

1

It happened a long time ago. I was the loyal servant of a big state. I was lean and thin, peace-loving, free from the factional fights of the state, focused on my work. The palace bustled with all kinds of activities—something new happened every day. Conspiracies were hatched by rival groups. I was not aligned to any group. It was perhaps because of this that Raja Sahib was well-disposed towards me. He was dignified, had an independent disposition and was somewhat narcissistic. He was not ready to play second fiddle to the British Resident. Other princely states were hostile to some newspapers and banned their entry, but newspapers and newsmen came to our state without any restrictions. Once or twice the Resident took exception to it and made his displeasure known, but Raja Sahib did not pay any attention to it. He didn't like anyone interfering in the internal affairs of the state. The Resident, too, was not pleased with him.

However, that does not mean that Raja Sahib was far-sighted or enlightened, or that he had a well-organized administration or that he believed in the virtues of thrift. On the contrary, he was a man given to luxury and licentiousness. There were dozens of queens in the palace, and new ones kept arriving. He was not ready to economize or exercise restraint on this count. He was a lover of beauty, and this had become his second

nature. He was ready to sacrifice everything, including his faith, for this passion. He wanted to remain independent. Because the European rulers wanted to place restrictions on his independence, he showed extraordinary courage in defying them and thus earned the respect and loyalty of his subjects.

For some time a Punjabi woman, Ranu, had been the object of his attraction. Many rumours floated about her. Some said that she was a common prostitute, some said that she was an actress, and some said that she was a girl from a decent family. She was not unparalleled in beauty but Raja Sahib had lost his heart to her. He had never showed great interest in the affairs of administration, but now he was totally lost in love. He was building a separate palace for her. Paintings and artefacts were ordered from Europe. To teach her music and dance, maestros were invited from Italy, France and Germany. He sent her new gifts every day. She was the talk of the town. People wondered what exactly it was that the woman possessed which made Raja Sahib so crazy about her.

One evening I had just gone to bed after dinner when Raja Sahib sent for me. The royal summons at this unusual hour surprised me. I was not among Raja Sahib's confidants. So, I felt somewhat scared and began to have misgivings. Such occurrences were not unusual in princely states. It was quite possible that an enemy had reported something against me. I got ready and promptly presented myself before Raja Sahib. Just one look at him and all my misgivings vanished. Instead of anger, his face was enveloped in longing and sadness. There was pleading in his eyes. As he saw me, he indicated a chair for me to sit, and said, 'Sardar Sahib, have you ever been in love? Have you ever lost yourself in the love for someone?'

Hearing his tone of familiarity I realized that it was not necessary to observe royal etiquette now. Raja Sahib wanted to consult me on personal matters. I said, 'There has never been an opportunity.'

Raja Sahib held out a perfume dispenser towards me and said, 'Truly, you're a lucky fellow. Good that you were never caught in this net. It is a golden trap. It's a sweet but fatal poison. It's a fascinating but painful

situation. It's that sweet music that sends human beings into the throes of hell forever.'

He filled his wine glass, took a sip and said, 'Do you know what I have gone through for her? Just a signal from her and I would've chopped my own head and presented it at her feet. I could've gifted this entire princely state to her. I made her bed with my own hands. I filled her hookah again and again. I dusted her room. When she dismounted from the bed, I placed the slippers stool before her. How much pleasure I derived doing all these services for her! I can't tell you how happy I was! When I went in front of her, I became a slave to her wishes. The pride of wealth and status vanished from my mind. That humble state was the wealth of the entire world for me. But that tyrant always avoided me. She probably never considered me worthy of her. My longing that she should give me a lovelorn glance or smile at me with her rosy lips languished within me. I had thought that she was probably an object of worship, that indifference is her second nature. Probably she didn't feel the pain of love, she was probably unfamiliar with love's deserts. Yes, I did think that she was too young, too immature to have those feelings. I lived in the hope that at some point my sacrifices would bear fruit, that at some point her dormant feelings would wake up.'

Suddenly Raja Sahib fell silent. Then he looked at himself in the life-size mirror in front of him and said, 'I'm not so bad-looking that a woman should show such indifference towards me.'

Raja Sahib was extraordinarily good-looking. A tall frame, broad chest, ruddy complexion—he was the very epitome of male beauty.

I said encouragingly, 'In this respect, nature has been extraordinarily generous to you, Huzoor.'

A wan smile played on Raja Sahib's lips. But it soon changed to longing. He said, 'Sardar Sahib, much have I travelled in this bazaar of beauty. I'm aware of black magic and other methods to subdue a woman. But the methods that have stood me in good stead for all these years have proved futile in this case. Eventually, I decided that this creature had no sensitivities at all. But alas, yesterday the secret of her indifference was

revealed to me. How I wish that the secret had remained a secret for some more time! That I stayed in my state of oblivion for some more time!'

Instead of longing, Raja Sahib's face now showed bitterness and hatred. 'See, these are the letters that came to me yesterday from an unknown source. I think it pointless at this moment to waste time investigating who sent them to me and where he got them. It must be the result of her indiscretion. I just want to verify whether the letters are genuine or fake. I do not have a speck of doubt that the letters are genuine. I have seen her writing and I'm familiar with the manner of her speech. I know the phrases she uses frequently in her conversations. The letters contain them. No difference at all. The same style, the same manner, the same words. While I was thirsting for a smile from her, she was busy writing love letters to others that contain a litany of her complaints and protestations. I've read the letters. I've hardened my heart and read them.'

Raja Sahib's eyes were now spitting fire.

'Yes, I've read them as though I were drinking my own blood and tearing my own flesh. My eyes dripped blood when I read them.

'Oh, this betrayal! Frailty of women! She stays in my palace and relishes all the privileges. Yet she chooses to trample upon all my devotion and sacrifice and exchanges secret letters with others! She doesn't spare me a glance while she lavishes others with her favours. She doesn't spare a morsel for me while she organizes a feast for others!

'*Uff*, you just can't imagine my state of mind when I read the letters! The first thing that occurred to me was that I should go to that heartless creature with a naked sword and pierce it through my heart right before her eyes. She should see me writhing in pain and dying. Probably she would value my love after my death. My warm blood would, perhaps, melt her stony heart. The cruel woman would realize what real love is. But I heard a voice from a corner of my heart that told me that it was sheer stupidity. *If you die, this sorceress would lay claim to all your assets. Oblivious of all the gifts that you've showered on her she would laugh her head off at your stupidity, and would join her lover on the next day. And then both would splurge your wealth and torment your restless soul.*

‘Believe me, Sardar Sahib, I had really heard that voice from a corner of my mind. Right at that moment I took out the sword from my waist and put it aside. I gave up the idea (of killing myself). Then in an instant the fire of revenge ignited in my heart. I was overwhelmed by a consuming rage, each pore of my body seemed to emit fire. I stood up with the determination to put an end to her tyranny. I was ready to lay down my life for a glance from her eyes, now I was going to put them out. Her poisonous lips would turn pale. I was going to tear open the heart that concealed so much deceit and cruelty and trample it under my feet. I was baying for blood. All her graces and attributes seemed a pretence. If I had got to know at that moment that someone had killed her, I’d have kissed the feet of that killer. If I had heard that she was in the throes of death, I’d have stood there and observed the spectacle of her death. Having made the firm resolve to kill her, I returned the double-edged sword to the sheath on my waist and entered her room. Earlier when I stood at her door my heart oscillated between hope and despair, but at that moment I experienced an evil delight in my heart.

‘Sardar Sahib, I don’t wish to recount the tumult of feelings and emotions that had overwhelmed me at the moment. Even if the words have the power to describe them I don’t want my heart to go through it again. I stepped into the room. She was lost in the thoughts of her lover. My heart went out to her. My rage and fury vanished into thin air. Instead, I felt empathy for her. What was her fault? If her fault was the same as mine, what right had I to avenge myself? If she was totally devoted and committed to her lover as I was, and loved him to distraction, what’s her fault? If I was helpless before my heart, couldn’t she be in a similar state? If a woman made me a captive and wanted to buy over my love with gold and pearls, could I make my heart love her? Probably not. I’d try to escape the moment I got an opportunity. I was being unjust to her, and unreasonable. If I possessed the attributes that her lover had, why shouldn’t she be attracted to me? I just didn’t possess the qualities that she expected in her lover. If I didn’t like bitter stuff, then I’d naturally turn towards a shop selling sweets. It’s probable that there would be a slow change in my taste and I’d begin to

love bitter stuff. But no one can force me into eating something I do not like to eat.

'These thoughts softened my heart. The face that a while ago had evoked revulsion in my mind now appeared a hundred times more attractive. Till then I had not seen her lost in dreams. In that state her beauty seemed purer and ethereal, just as a flower looks fresh and pure after the rain. When she was self-conscious, she did not have that irresistible appeal. My glance kissed her eyes, lips and cheeks by turns. In that dream state her beauty seemed just perfect.'

Raja Sahib smiled wanly, touched the wine to his lips and said, 'Sardar Sahib, my urge for revenge disappeared. You can't hate the one you've loved, even if she's disloyal to you. If a lover kills his beloved, you can be sure that it was not love but lust at play. I came back, but my mind was restless. From then on I tried all possible ways to control my anger, but in vain. As long as that devil is alive, he'll be a thorn in my side, a snake ready to bite me. I can't eat or sleep. That black snake was preventing me from reaching out to my love. He's a wall standing between her and me. He's a pain in the neck. This snake must be killed. This wall must be brought down. This fly must be thrown out. My soul won't find any peace until have seen him torn into pieces with my own eyes. I don't care how much I need to spend on this. Whatever it takes, I'll breathe freely only after sending him to hell.'

Raja Sahib finished his peroration, looked at me beseechingly and said, 'Tell me what you can do for me in this situation.'

I exclaimed in surprise, 'Me!'

Raja Sahib encouraged me, 'Do you know why I've made you my confidant, leaving all the others out? Why did I appeal to you? There is no dearth of people here who can chop off the head of the traitor if I give them the slightest hint. They'll reduce him to a bloody clod in full public view. Oh yes, I can have his bones turned into powder in a minute. I can have him pinned down with nails driven through his fingers. But I discarded all these options and chose you for the job. Do you know why? Because I trust you much more than those who are closest to me. I know this secret will lie

buried in your chest and mine. I'm confident no amount of greed can tempt you away from your path, no amount of brute violence or oppression can open your lips. You won't betray me or be disloyal to me. You won't take undue advantage of this. Do you know about the rewards you'll get? Don't have any misgivings about that. I may have many faults but ungratefulness is not one of them. You'll be rewarded lavishly—position, estate, wealth, honour—you'll get whatever you desire. Your greed and desires can have their fanciful flights. The old legends of patronage will come alive! You'll write the farmans yourself, I'll close my eyes and sign them. Tell me when you'd like to go. His name and address are written on this piece of paper. Imprint them in your mind and tear the paper. I've entrusted you with an onerous responsibility. My life is in your hands—you can save it or destroy it. I'm sure you'll carry out this responsibility with utmost competence. Your accomplices should be entirely reliable. You have to carry out the job with utmost caution and circumspection. An indiscreet word, lack of caution for a minute or even a second's delay may prove fatal for both you and me. The enemy is on the prowl, I'll be accused of a crime I haven't committed and it'll be used to dethrone me. You can well imagine what punishment will be meted out for actual crimes. I'll be exiled to a far-flung godforsaken wilderness. The state will be handed over to strangers and my life will be ruined. So, when do you want to go? This is a cheque book from the Imperial Bank. I've signed the cheques. You can draw as much money as and when you need.'

My mind was spinning. I realized how powerful the temptation of wealth was and why people worship Mammon. It was as though I was intoxicated. I had read in a book that every human being gets an opportunity to turn his life around, to make his destiny. If he grabs this opportunity with both hands, he becomes successful, but if he lets the opportunity slip by because of hesitation, he remains a failure. The former attains wealth, honour and fame, while the latter spends his days in poverty and want. And he gets just a minute, rather an instant, to make his decision. How precious that moment is! Precisely such a moment had arrived in my life and I decided to grab it with both hands. Destiny was standing before me with its best offerings, it

was ready to welcome me with the blessings for which a person laid down his life. I knew that the job was risky, but the rewards were enormous! Only those who plunge into the river get rare pearls. Those who lack initiative do not achieve anything. I had to stain my hand with the blood of an innocent. So what? Murder was the only way to climb the social ladder. This was the way of the world. Here, you had to reach your destination by making a staircase with corpses. You could reach the shore of victory only after swimming through rivers of blood. Look at the incidents taking place around you. Look at history! The story of glorious lives is written in letters of blood. The valiant had always waded through rivers of blood. They didn't show any qualms in shedding blood. It's a mark of cowardice and feebleness of mind to be afraid of blood. Heroes always keep their eyes fixed on their ends, not on the means. It was not the moment for procrastination. Men of action are not deterred by considerations of good or evil.

I stood up and said, 'This servant of yours is ready to do the job.'

Raja Sahib looked at me appreciatively and said, 'I expected this from you. My heart says that you'll accomplish the mission.'

'I'm sure about that.'

'I, too, was sure. Give me updates for every moment. Keeping the secret is the prime condition.'

'God willing, huzoor will have no occasion for complaint.'

'Don't take the name of God. You shouldn't invoke God on such occasions. Seek God's help when you don't have the strength of will. If you have strength in your arms, will power and foresight, why should you seek refuge in God? Go now and return victorious. I'll wait eagerly for you.'

2

I didn't allow my conscience to raise its head. My mind began to argue in favour of severing the head of the unfortunate fellow. What right had he to establish a liaison with Sarfaraz, when he knew that Raja Sahib had already inducted her in his harem? It was nearly as serious a crime as kidnapping a

married woman. Sarfaraz was married in every sense of the word, even more than that. Establishing a liaison with such a beautiful woman and laying a trap for her was a crime not deserving of forgiveness. If such a serious crime is met with fatal punishment, it needn't be regretted. If there was any trace of hesitation in my mind, then this argument drove it away. The secret of courage lies in the belief that we're fighting for justice. Now the murder didn't look wrong in my eyes. It appeared to be a legitimate one, and to turn one's back on it was sheer cowardice.

The train was supposed to set off in two hours. It was an overnight journey. But I had no appetite for food. I started packing for the journey. I bought a fake beard from the market thinking that I might need it. I placed two revolvers in my trunk. Then I started wondering whom to take with me. How should I begin the mission? It was not advisable to take anyone from here. Should I send a telegram to my brother to meet me in Bombay? Oh yes, this seems like the right move. He's a worldly-wise person. But no, why should I implicate my brother? Who knows what's in store for me? Is there a dearth of such fellows in Bombay? I'll drop a reward of a hundred thousand rupees. The job will be done in an instant. One can find any number of fellows there, each sharper than the other. Somehow the fellow should be brought to a prostitute's quarters and done away with. Or, when he goes for a walk by the seaside . . .

There was still time for the journey, so I thought of doing the *sandhya*. As I entered the worship room, the first thing that drew my attention, as usual, was the life-size portrait of my mother. I was startled. It was as though someone had placed his hand on the shoulder of a burglar just as he was breaking into someone's house. My heart came to my mouth. I was used to seeing this portrait a hundred times a day, but I had never experienced the same feeling as I was now. It seemed as though she was looking at me with reproachful eyes. There was reproach, censure and disappointment in those eyes. I couldn't look her in the eye and lowered my gaze. I simply did not have the courage to meet those eyes. They were not still and lifeless, but living, moving eyes—deeply penetrating and probing. I was afraid that I'd fall down. I plopped down on the floor right there. My

head drooped—unconsciously, involuntarily. My desires and thoughts underwent a great change. That image of truth, that embodiment of light illuminated my conscience. I could not fathom the tumult of thoughts that came to my mind. I know only this much that it was under some supernatural power that I came out of my house, got the car ready and reached Raja Sahib's palace at ten o'clock at night. He had left instructions that I was to have unrestricted access to him at all hours. I stood before him with folded hands and said, 'Huzoor, I have a request.'

Raja Sahib, having solved the dilemma that had been exercising his mind, was enjoying some moments of relief. The burden was off his shoulder and he was in the mood for relaxation. Seeing me he suspected some new complication in the plan and became restless. But he regained his composure in a moment and said, 'Well, has anything cropped up?'

I said without a trace of hesitation or fear, 'I'd like you to excuse me from the job.'

Raja Sahib's face turned ashen. He glared at me and said, 'What do you mean?'

'I can't do the job.'

'Why?'

'I'm not equipped to do it.'

Raja Sahib looked at me derisively and said, 'Probably your conscience has woken up . . . hasn't it? The disease that inflicts the cowardly and the impotent. It's all right, you can go.'

'Huzoor, I can't bring myself to do it.'

Raja Sahib looked at me with bloodshot eyes and thundered, 'Shut up, you b—'

Then he softened a little and said, 'Wealth and prosperity are not in your destiny. I had given you the opportunity of a lifetime, but you didn't appreciate it. Your luck is working against you. You will always be a slave and get pushed around. People like you should take on the garb of a monk and renounce the world. Then you can spend your time discussing dharma and adharma. The world is for *men*.'

I stayed silent. I was regretting that I hadn't excused myself in the first instance.

After a moment Raja Sahib said, 'The offer is still open, if you change your mind . . .'

As before, I said fearlessly, 'I've reflected on this a great deal. I can't . . .'

Raja Sahib suppressed his anger and said, 'All right. Get out from within the borders of my state tonight. Tomorrow you may not get the opportunity.' He went on to call me names like 'ungrateful', 'stupid', 'mean' and so on.

I saluted him and came out. I gathered a few clothes, picked up the box where I kept cash and went on my way. Oh yes, that picture was imprinted in my mind.

By the time the sun rose in the morning, I had left the borders of Raja Sahib's state and entered British territory.

Translated from the Urdu by M. Asaduddin



Two Graves

1

Gone are the days of youth, its intoxication and excitement. The lamp that illuminated its splendour has been extinguished. That symbol of pure love is asleep in the lap of a grave. Yet, the mark of intimacy lingers in the heart; unforgettable memories still persist before the eyes. Such fidelity, affection and commitment in a woman are quite uncommon. But what's even more striking is to find an equal degree of conjugality, sacrifice and devotion among the rich. Every evening Kunwar Ranveer Singh would visit Juhra's grave, decorate it with flowers and cry before it. Fifteen years had passed. But, not a single day went by without a visit. Love's worship had been the nucleus of his life. In it, he received what he had seen. The memories of what he had experienced would cheer him up. Sulochana, who embodied all of Kunwar Sahib's aspirations and was Juhra's gift, would also be with him in his prayers.

Kunwar Sahib had married twice. But neither of his wives could beget a child. He didn't marry for a third time. He had met Juhra one day in a *mehfil*. The concord between the disappointed husband and the insatiate maiden was like a meeting of friends who hadn't seen each other in a long time. The spring of life had arrived, filled with fragrance, music and progress. But alas! Even that ended within a short span of five years. That

pleasant dream melted into sleepless nights suffused with despair. The deity who epitomized service and devotion left for her heavenly abode, leaving three-year-old Sulochana in his care.

Kunwar Sahib had followed his beloved's orders with such dedication that everyone was astonished. Many of them even considered him mad. Sulochana's sleep would constitute his sleep; her waking up was sunrise for him. He would teach her himself and would travel with her. All of this was done with such single-mindedness that it appeared as if a widow were nursing her orphan child.

From the day she got enrolled in the university, he would drop her every day in his motorcar and then pick her up in the evening. He wanted to wash the blemish off her forehead, which Providence had brought to pass with its unsparing hands. His wealth had failed to accomplish this; who knows, knowledge might succeed in doing so.

One evening Kunwar Sahib was decorating Juhra's tomb with flowers. Sulochana stood at some distance, throwing a ball to her dog every now and then. Suddenly, she saw Dr Ramendra, a professor from her college. Feeling hesitant, she turned away, pretending not to have seen him. She was apprehensive about Ramendra broaching the subject of her mother's grave.

It had been a year since she'd been enrolled in the university. She'd already witnessed different forms of love in a short span. Some were characterized by amusement, jollity or even condemnation, while others were only defined by passion or extravagance. But the tenderness that constitutes the essence of love was nowhere to be found. Only Ramendra was a true gentleman whose looks would precipitate a sensation in her heart. But there was much helplessness, many impediments, and a lot of anguish that was concealed behind her eyes.

Ramendra looked at Kunwar Sahib and asked Sulochana, 'What is your father doing here near this grave?'

Sulochana replied, 'It's one of his old habits.'

Ramendra asked again, 'Is it a saint's grave?'

Sulochana tried evading the question. Ramendra knew that Sulochana was the daughter of Kunwar Sahib's mistress. But he didn't know that this

was *her* grave and that Kunwar Sahib was such a votary of past love. Moreover, he hadn't asked this question in a lowered voice. Kunwar Sahib was putting on his shoes at that moment and the question had reached his ears. He quickly wore his shoes, went to Ramendra and said, 'She wasn't a saint in the eyes of this world, but to me she is one. This tomb is the sanctuary of my love.'

Sulochana felt like fleeing. But Kunwar Sahib would experience spiritual pleasure by singing Juhra's praises. Seeing Ramendra's astonishment, Kunwar Sahib added, 'The deity who made my life heavenly is sleeping in this tomb. Sulochana is an embodiment of her spiritual grace.'

Ramendra looked at the grave and said, 'Oh! I see!'

Experiencing the delight of love, Kunwar Sahib went on, 'Professor Sahib, hers was a different life altogether. I had never seen such austerity anywhere. Come along with me if you're free. I shall tell you about the memories of our youth—'

Sulochana interrupted, 'Father, those things are just not appropriate subjects of conversation.'

Kunwar Sahib quipped, 'Ramendra Babu is no stranger to me.'

This supernatural form of love seemed like a psychological pearl to Ramendra. He accompanied Kunwar Sahib to his house and listened to him for hours together as he spoke of his memories of love, which were steeped in desire.

Today he asked for the very boon that he was otherwise quite indecisive about and for which he hadn't been able to muster up the courage since last year.

2

But Ramendra had a completely different experience after marriage. The comings and goings of women almost stopped, while more and more male friends started frequenting the house. Their influx would be felt throughout the day. Sulochana would remain occupied in entertaining them. Ramendra didn't pay any heed to this for the first couple of months. But when many

months passed and the women still didn't change their exclusionist attitude, he discussed the matter with Sulochana one day.

'These people only come alone nowadays,' he said.

Sulochana replied, her voice low, 'Yes indeed, I can see that.'

Ramendra asked her, 'But their wives aren't unfavourably disposed towards you, are they?'

Sulochana answered, 'Yes, probably.'

Ramendra added, 'But these people have such independent ideas! Their women are educated too; then what is this all about?'

Sulochana replied, her voice still subdued, 'Oh! It's simply beyond my comprehension.'

Ramendra remained in a state of uncertainty for a while. Then he spoke again, 'Maybe we should go and settle down somewhere else. No one would know us there.'

This time Sulochana said scathingly, 'Why should we go to some other place? We have done no wrong; we've asked nothing from anybody. Whoever wants to come here can, and whoever doesn't, well, it's their wish. Why should *we* hide our faces?'

Slowly, another secret dawned upon Ramendra. It was much more degrading and reprehensible than the behaviour of these prejudiced women. Ramendra learnt now that the men who visited and argued for hours over social and political questions actually had no real interest in the exchange of ideas. Rather, they only came to worship Sulochana's beauty. Their eyes would seek her out; their ears were attentive only to her words. Their only motive was to derive pleasure from her tender beauty. Here, they didn't have the hesitation that plagued them when they saw the daughters and daughters-in-law of respected families. Perhaps they thought that there was no one to stop them here. Sulochana would have a tough time when someone occasionally arrived in the absence of Ramendra. Through their amorous gestures, through their contemptible insinuations, their mysterious conversations and their deep breaths, they wanted to prove that they were like mendicants, begging for her mercy. They felt that if Ramendra had the absolute privilege of being her husband, then they too deserved an iota of

her charity. On such occasions, Sulochana could do nothing but silently fret about it.

Until now, both Ramendra and Sulochana would go to the club. A group of liberal gentlemen would throng the place. Till the time Ramendra didn't suspect someone, he would request her and take her to the club. Sulochana's very arrival would act as a stimulant for the club members. Whichever table she sat at would be thickly surrounded by people. At times, she would sing too, which made the others delirious.

There weren't too many women in the club—only five or six came, and even they maintained their distance from Sulochana. Besides, through their attitude, gestures and acrimonious remarks, they would let her know that 'you may please men's hearts but you can never come near us for we are brides belonging to respectable families.'

But when this bitter truth dawned upon Ramendra, he stopped going to the club. The frequency with which he visited his friends also decreased. He even started neglecting those who came to his house. He wanted no one to invade his privacy. Finally, he stopped going outside. It appeared as if the traps of hypocrisy and deceit had been woven all around him. He could neither trust nor expect civility from anyone. He would wonder, *Why should I ever meet such cunning and insidious men who are utterly malicious beneath the guise of friendship?*

By nature, Ramendra was quite affable and outgoing. This solitude that was bereft of any travel, diversion or any kind of hustle and bustle was nothing short of an imprisonment for him. Though he would assure Sulochana with his words and deeds, her incisive and restless eyes could discern that the situation was becoming unbearable for him with every passing day. She thought, *I am the one responsible for his plight. I am nothing but a constant thorn in his flesh.*

One day she asked her husband, 'Why don't you go to the club nowadays? It has been weeks since you last stepped out of the house.'

Ramendra replied reluctantly, 'I don't wish to go anywhere. Our house is the best place to be.'

Sulochana said, ‘All the same, you must be getting bored here. Why should you suffer because of me? You see, I don’t go there because I detest those women. There isn’t a single one among them who could really boast of a virtuous character. But all of them pretend to be like Sita. I’m repulsed by their faces. But why shouldn’t you go there? At least it’ll serve as a diversion.’

Ramendra replied firmly, ‘It can never amuse a heart that has been turned into stone. When there is turmoil inside, how can one find solace outside?’

Sulochana was shocked. It was the first time she had heard such words from Ramendra’s mouth. Until now, she had only considered herself as an outcast. Whatever disrespect came her way, it was solely hers. As for Ramendra, well, even now all the doors were open for him. He could go wherever he wished and meet whosoever he wanted. What impediments were there in his life? But no! Had he married someone from an honourable family, he wouldn’t have faced such a plight. Women from distinguished families would’ve visited the house. The degree of friendship would’ve intensified. Life would’ve been blissful; it would’ve been like a patch of silk. But now, it was merely a piece of sackcloth. *I’m like a dirty fish that has spoilt the entire pond.* Sadness descended over her face.

On the other hand, Ramendra realized that what he had said could be interpreted in two ways. He immediately tried to backtrack, ‘Do you really consider us as two separate individuals? Our lives are one. I can’t go to places where you’re not respected. Moreover, even I’m disgusted by these painted jackals of society. I’m quite aware of their dirty secrets. Rank, title or opulence—none of these can purify the soul. If a person from a lower standing committed the same deeds as these people do, he wouldn’t have had the courage to face anyone. But these people conceal all their vices behind the veil of magnanimity. It’s better to keep a distance from them.’

Sulochana was placated.

Sulochana gave birth to a girl child in the second year of their marriage. She was named Shobha and had a moon-like face. These days Kunwar Sahib was somewhat unwell. He had gone to Mussoorie. When he heard the news, he immediately sent a telegram to Ramendra, telling him to come to his place along with the mother and the child.

But Ramendra was reluctant to pay a visit on such an occasion. What better opportunity could there be to test the generosity of his friends for one last time? After much reflection, he decided to organize a splendid banquet. Music was also included in the programme, and many eminent singers were invited. English, Hindustani, Musalmani—foods of all kinds had been arranged.

Kunwar Sahib came from Mussoorie with much difficulty. The banquet was on the day he arrived. At the stipulated time, the people who had been invited started trickling in, one by one. Khan Sahib, Mirza Sahib and Mir Sahib came. But, Panditji, Babuji, Lala Sahib, Chaudhuri Sahib, Kakkar, Mehra, Chopra, Kaul, Hukku, Srivastava and Khare were nowhere to be seen.

These were people who had all their meals at hotels. They ate eggs and drank alcohol. They neither used their discretion nor thought twice before giving in to indulgences. Then why didn't they come today? It wasn't because of the fear of being polluted; it was because they considered their presence to be a licence for the marriage's approval. And they were certainly not interested in any such licences.

Night had fallen. Kunwar Sahib stood at the door till ten. When there was no sign of anybody else, he told Ramendra, 'It's pointless to wait for the others now. Feed the Muslims and distribute the rest among the destitute.'

Ramendra was sitting on a chair, completely nonplussed. He replied dully, 'Yes, I had the same thought.'

Kunwar Sahib added, 'I had already anticipated this. We aren't the ones who've been dishonoured; rather, it is they who've been exposed.'

Ramendra said, 'Nevertheless, the test has been most successful. What do you say, should I go and teach everyone a lesson?'

Kunwar Sahib asked, surprised, 'What? By going to their houses?'

Ramendra answered, ‘That’s right. I shall ask them about the basis on which they continue to play the tune of social reform.’

Kunwar Sahib said, ‘Oh! It’ll only be an exercise in futility. You go and rest peacefully. Our hearts are the best judges when it comes to discriminating between good and evil. If it bears witness to the fact that this isn’t a bad deed, then even if the world turns its face away from us, we shouldn’t worry about what anyone else says or does.’

Ramendra replied, ‘But I won’t spare them so easily. I won’t be the man that I know myself to be if I don’t strip them of their masks.’

And he picked up the leaf plates and the earthen pots and started distributing them among the paupers.

4

Ramendra was just returning from his walk when a group of courtesans arrived to congratulate Sulochana. Juhra had a niece—Gulnar. Earlier, she would frequently come to meet Sulochana, but in the last couple of years she hadn’t paid even a single visit. Congratulating Sulochana was her idea. A crowd of a considerable proportion had gathered at the door. Ramendra heard the commotion as Gulnar stepped forward, saluted him and said, ‘Babuji, may your daughter be always blessed. We have brought a present for her.’

Ramendra felt as if he was having a paralytic attack. His head hung and his face appeared to be smeared with the blackness of dishonour. He neither spoke nor did he ask anyone to sit down. He merely stood there like a statue. The very thought of forming an acquaintance with a courtesan was so disgraceful and heinous that even courtesy had been rendered silent. He couldn’t even uphold the civility of asking them to come in and make them comfortable. For the first time in his life, he experienced the twilight of his degeneration. The insidiousness of his friends and the indifference of women he didn’t see as humiliation. Rather, he considered it as injustice on their part. But this congratulatory present was too heavy even for his boundless generosity.

Sulochana had been brought up in a distinguished family. Though it is true that she would visit Juhra's grave daily, the memory of her mother was a sacred one, uncontaminated by the depravity of the world. But a relationship based on reciprocity was one thing, while kinship with Gulnar was quite another. Those who bow before pictures, offer flowers to them, even they condemn idol worship. One is tangible while the other is suggestive; one is overt, the other remains hidden from the eyes.

Sulochana stood behind the cover of the curtains and saw Ramendra in a state of distress and perplexity. The society that he had deemed worthy of worship, at whose altar he had offered his prayers, had disappointed him completely. His heart was insistent on revolting against it. In his mind, he would argue with himself, *Should I summon Gulnar and embrace her? Why should I play to the gallery of those who do not even bother about me? These wretched ones have come from distant places only because they consider me as their very own. Their hearts are completely filled with love; they're willing to partake in my sorrows.*

Finally Ramendra raised his head and told Gulnar with a dry smile, 'All of you, please come inside.' He was just showing them the way to the drawing room when suddenly the charwoman emerged and handed a note to Gulnar. Gulnar read it and then gave it to Ramendra. Ramendra stared at the note. 'Sister Gulnar, your coming here was not proper. We're already being dishonoured here. Please do not make it worse for us and take back your congratulatory present. If you ever wish to meet us, please come in the night and by yourself. My heart yearns to embrace you and weep bitterly. But I'm helpless in this situation.'

Ramendra tore up the piece of paper and said obstinately, 'Let them write what they will. I'm not scared of anyone. Please come inside.'

Gulnar took a step backwards and replied, 'No, Babuji, allow us to take your leave now.'

Ramendra said, 'At least sit for a while.'

Gulnar said, 'No, not even for a second.'

Ramendra went and sat in his room after Gulnar left. He had never been so comprehensively defeated in his entire life. The pride and true resentment that stems from the knowledge of injustice had disappeared. It had been supplanted by shame and guilt. Why on earth did she even think of bringing a congratulatory present? She had never visited before. But today only God knows why she had landed up here. Kunwar Sahib may be magnanimous; he may have forged a relationship of brotherhood with Juhra's kinsfolk. But I'm not so accommodating. Who knows, even Sulochana must be visiting her surreptitiously. The note mentioned coming alone in the night if she wished for a meeting. Why not, for she shares the same blood, the same outlook, the same opinions and ideals. Though she had been brought up in Kunwar Sahib's house, the effect of bloodlines cannot be easily erased. I wonder what the two sisters must talk about when they see each other. Certainly, it must not be a discussion on history or ethics but rather a conversation on immodesty. Gulnar must narrate personal accounts and debate the merits and imperfections of the buyers and shopkeepers of that market. It's completely impossible that she would forget her true self while meeting Sulochana and abstain from broaching vulgar, preposterous and undignified topics. In a moment, his thoughts turned topsy-turvy. But a man cannot exist in solitary confinement for this too is a hunger of another kind. If pure food is unavailable, then man settles for even leftovers in order to counter starvation. Sulochana felt a sense of belonging with these people. Had she not been ostracized, why would she ever have felt the need of meeting disreputable women like Gulnar? She can't be blamed for it; she is merely a victim of her circumstances—circumstances that always remind us of our past.

Ramendra was steeped in these thoughts when Kunwar Sahib arrived and said tartly, 'I heard that you returned Gulnar's present.'

Ramendra's ability to resist got further animated at this. He replied, 'I didn't return it, Sulochana did. But, in my opinion, she did the right thing.'

Kunwar Sahib said, 'Then why don't you explicitly admit that she was merely following your cues? To think that you let go of such a wonderful opportunity for drawing these decadent people in your favour! You negated

whatever effect the sight of Sulochana must have had. It would've been very likely that the pride emanating from a conjugal relationship with a reputed person would've ushered a new era in her life. But you never cared about such possibilities.'

Ramendra remained silent. Kunwar Sahib resumed with an impassioned voice, 'Why do you people forget that every vice is engendered by compulsion? A thief doesn't pilfer because he derives pleasure out of it; rather he does it because he is compelled by necessity. Yes, there can be a difference between a genuine need and an inauthentic one. It may be important for a man to get some jewellery made for his wife when the latter goes to her parents' house. But, it may be absolutely unnecessary for someone else. One may lose one's integrity out of the sheer distress that is produced by hunger. But there may also be someone who'll prefer death to imploring anyone for anything. But you learned men shouldn't forget the natural principle that the longing for life is pervasive in all human beings. One can do anything for one's survival. The more difficult the question of survival is, the greater the proliferation of vices. On the other hand, there will be fewer villainies if livelihood can be easily secured. Our first principle should be to ensure the possibility of subsistence for everyone. Ramendra Babu, you acted with these people in precisely the same manner in which the others acted towards you and because of which you're still unhappy.'

Ramendra listened inattentively to this long lecture as if it were the ravings of a madman. On many previous occasions, he had himself supported arguments of a similar kind. But arguments alone cannot mollify the sorrows of a distressed mind. The coming of these decadent women to this house on the pretext of kinship was so insulting to Ramendra that he couldn't forget it even after being defeated by arguments. *I don't maintain relationships with such people lest their poison spread in my entire house*.

Suddenly, Sulochana too barged into the room. The pangs of childbirth had not subsided completely, but provocation had turned her face red. Seeing her, Ramendra got only more actuated. He wanted to communicate to her that he could only go thus far and no further. He said, 'I shall never

approve of courtesans visiting my house in any guise. Coming in the night or putting on a veneer does not offset the inimical effects of the vice itself. I do not fear the retribution of society but rather the debasement of morality.'

In her opinion, Sulochana had already indulged in a lot of sacrifices in order to preserve the dignity of the family. Her spirit had not forgiven him as yet. She replied vehemently, 'Do you really want me to forfeit my life in this incarcerated household? There should at least be someone I can speak and laugh with!'

Ramendra said heatedly, 'If you were so interested in laughing and talking, then you simply shouldn't have married me. The bonds of conjugality are synonymous with bonds of sacrifice. Till the time this provision reigns supreme and woman is considered as the protector of the family's honour, no man shall ever accept his wife keeping in touch with people of improper conduct.'

Kunwar Sahib could now perceive that this disputation was only going to make him more obstinate and that the main subject would lose focus. So he said gently, 'But, my son, why do you always think that only these educated women from reputed families can be influenced by others? Why can't it be otherwise?'

Ramendra said, 'I don't trust education on such matters. Education upholds so many things which are otherwise redundant according to custom, tradition and ethics. We do not get our legs amputated simply because we stumble every now and then. But I'm completely adamant about the matter at hand. I want to say this unequivocally that a life with me entails a repudiation of all past relationships. That is not all—you'll have to train your mind in such a way that you automatically start hating them yourself. We'll have to cultivate our virtues in such a manner that even society feels ashamed of its injustice, instead of corrupting our conduct so much that this disdain finds its justification in the eyes of others.'

Sulochana said scornfully, 'As a woman, I'm not so helpless as to look at the world through your eyes. I have the right to decide what is advantageous and what is inimical to my interests.'

Kunwar Sahib interrupted, suddenly frightened, ‘Sillo, you forget that only polite words should be used in a conversation. We aren’t fighting each other but are merely expressing our subjective views on a particular question.’

Sulochana replied boldly, ‘I beg to differ, for these are mere manacles that are being forged for me. I don’t want to be fettered by them. I consider my spirit to be as independent as any man’s.’

Feeling a bit ashamed at his severity, Ramendra said, ‘I never intended to take away the autonomy of your soul and I’m not so inconsiderate either. Perhaps even you won’t disagree with these assertions. But if I happen to find you traversing the wrong path, do I not have the right to make you understand things?’

Sulochana replied, ‘Indeed you can, but only in the same capacity in which I can make you understand things. You can’t force me to do anything.’

Ramendra added, ‘I can’t agree to this.’

Sulochana said, ‘If I go to meet my relatives, you feel that your honour is compromised. Following a similarly slippery vein of thought, do you accept that your association with philanderers smears my reputation?’

Ramendra answered, ‘Yes, I do.’

Sulochana asked again, ‘More slippery still, if any of your libertine friends comes to your house, will you simply turn them away?’

Ramendra replied, ‘You can’t compel me to do that.’

Sulochana quipped, ‘But you can force me to do anything, can’t you?’

‘Doubtlessly.’

‘And why is that so?’

‘Because I’m a man and I form the nucleus of the family. Besides, it’s only because of you that I . . .’ Ramendra stopped. But Sulochana could very well make out what he meant. Her face flushed red, as if a spear had pierced her chest. There was such an upheaval in her mind that she felt like leaving the house that very instant, severing herself from all the relationships that she ever had with this world, never to show her face again. *If conjugality is all about being subordinate to someone’s wishes and*

to endure mortification, then I can only acknowledge such conjugality from a distance.

She wanted to walk out of the house, when Kunwar Sahib caught hold of her and said, 'Daughter, what is this that you're doing? Please go inside. Why should you cry? I'm still alive, so why should you worry? Ramendra Babu didn't mean to say any of those things. Moreover, one shouldn't mind what one's near and dear ones say. Perhaps, on some other occasion, even you can give him a piece of your mind.'

Kunwar Sahib took her inside the room. In truth, Sulochana had never wanted to meet Gulnar. She herself avoided her company. That note to Gulnar had been the outcome of a momentary impulse. Deep in her heart, even she had realized that maintaining kinship ties with these people would be most improper. But Ramendra had opposed her and that fact had been intolerable for her. *Why should he forbid me from doing anything? Do I not even understand this much? Is he really so doubtful of me? I know why—because I'm not from a noble family.*

I shall meet Gulnar right away, shall go to her purely out of stubbornness. I'll see what he can possibly do to me.

No one had ever glared at Sulochana with piercing eyes—she had been brought up amidst much pampering. Kunwar Sahib had been a slave to her wishes. All these days, Ramendra too had looked up to her for support and shelter. But today, she had suddenly been subjected to such disdain and reproach that her self-will became restless, and she wanted to crush every bond of tenderness and intimacy beneath her feet. She could tolerate everything but this browbeating, this injustice and this disrespect were completely unbearable for her.

She looked out of the window, summoned the coachman and said, 'Get your carriage immediately for I have to go to the square.'

Kunwar Sahib said affectionately, 'Beti Sillo, what are you doing? Have some mercy on this old man. At this moment, don't go anywhere for you'll regret it for the rest of your life. Ramendra Babu too is very irascible. He's older than you and more thoughtful; comply with whatever he says. I'll tell you the truth. When your mother was around, there were numerous

occasions on which I would be compelled to say to her, “Get out of the house.” But that goddess of love never stepped out of the threshold. Act with fortitude. I’m quite certain that Ramendra Babu will come here in a while, feeling ashamed, and seek your forgiveness.’

Suddenly Ramendra came and said, ‘Why did you call for the carriage? Where do you think you’re going?’

Sulochana shuddered at the sight of his face, which had turned red with anger. It appeared as if both his eyes were exuding fire. His nostrils twitched and his calves quivered. She couldn’t muster the courage to tell him that she was going to Gulnar’s house. The fear of him breathing down her neck at the mere mention of Gulnar’s name intimidated her. The impulse for self-preservation became predominant. She answered, ‘I’ll just go and visit my mother’s grave.’

Ramendra said sternly, ‘There is no need for you to go there.’

Sulochana asked timidly, ‘Why, am I not even allowed to visit my mother’s grave?’

Ramendra replied, ‘No, you are not.’

Sulochana said, ‘In that case, take care of your house on your own. I’m out of here.’

Ramendra said, ‘Suit yourself, for it doesn’t matter to you anyway. Besides, I’m sure you’ll find your perfect second home.’

The indestructible ties had been severed now. Normally Sulochana would’ve just gone to Kunwar Sahib’s bungalow and been upset for a couple of days or so. Ramendra would then have conciliated her and the matter would’ve been resolved. But this wound had severed the very roots of accord and negotiation. Sulochana had reached the door, but now she merely stood there, completely appalled. It seemed as if some ascetic’s curse had taken away her life. She could neither think nor say anything. How can one do anything when one is struck by lightning? Ramendra’s acrimonious words were more lethal than lightning itself.

Sulochana was completely oblivious of the duration for which she sat there. When she could somewhat gather her wits, she realized that silence had pervaded the house. She looked at the clock—it was one in the night.

On the easy chair before her, Kunwar Sahib had gone to sleep with the child in his lap. Sulochana got up and peeped into the veranda. Ramendra was lying there. She felt like stabbing herself and dying miserably in front of him. She remembered those fatal words. How on earth could he ever utter them? Why did he allow such words to issue forth from his lips, when he is so magnanimous and thoughtful?

Her chastity that had been nurtured in the lap of Indian ideals was now thrown to the dust; she cried obsessively at her wretchedness. Had she been from a reputed family and had this smear not been attached to her name, would he have uttered such words? *But I'm infamous, oppressed and dispensable, so anything can be said about me.* Alas! How indifferent this heart can be! Could she ever have inflicted such a severe blow to Ramendra under any circumstances?

A bulb glowed in the veranda. There wasn't even a whit of compunction or disappointment on Ramendra's face. The severity of his resentment explained the distortion on his face. Perhaps it would've been some consolation for Sulochana's aggrieved heart had there been tears in his eyes. But the swords were still drawn there. In her eyes, the entire world had been reduced to silence.

Sulochana went back to her room. Kunwar Sahib was still fast asleep. His radiant face had turned pallid within the last few hours. The stream of tears had dried up on his cheeks. Sulochana sat near him, at his feet, and shed tears that epitomized true devotion. *Alas! To think that he had to suffer so many adversities and weather so much humiliation because of me, an unfortunate woman. He dedicated his entire life to me and look how heart-rending its culmination is.*

Sulochana looked at her daughter. But even her rosy face was not enough to stir the feelings of motherhood in her heart. She turned her face away from her. Her daughter was the embodiment of the misery that she had had to endure for so many days. *Why should I jeopardize my life for her sake? If her heartless father loves her, then let him take care of her. And let him cry in the same manner as my father is crying today. O God! If you ever wish to give me another birth, at least make sure that I'm born into a noble family.*

Another grave has been erected near Juhra's tomb. Grass had grown on the older one, while the whitewash had come off at several places. But the other grave is quite neat and well decorated. Flowerpots have been placed all around it and the path leading to that grave has been embellished by rose vines.

Evening had fallen. It seemed as if the slender, disconsolate yellow rays of the dying sun were shedding tears on that grave. A man appeared on the scene with a three-year-old girl and started cleaning that tomb with his handkerchief. He picked up the leaves that were lying on the path and began to spray perfume on the grave. The child was running after butterflies, hoping to catch them.

This is Sulochana's grave. Instead of her body being cremated, her final wish was to sleep forever near her mother. Kunwar Sahib couldn't survive for more than six months after Sulochana's death. Yes, Ramendra was rightly repenting for his iniquity.

Shobha is three years old now and believes firmly that someday her mother will rise from this very grave.

Translated from the Hindi by Shailendra Kumar Singh



Prison

1

Mridula was pleased when she returned to the women's prison after the hearing at the magistrate's court. The prospect of acquittal glowed on her cheeks. Seeing her, a band of political prisoners gathered around and asked, 'How long is your sentence?'

Mridula replied triumphantly, 'I told them that I didn't picket. But all of you are adamant, so decide whatever you consider fit. I neither stopped nor grabbed anyone. What's more, I didn't even push or implore anybody. Though I stood at the shop, no customer came in front of me. Many volunteers were arrested there. People had gathered; I too stood there. Just then, the subinspector came and arrested me.'

Kshama Devi knew a bit of law. She said, 'The magistrate will decide on the basis of the police report. I have seen many such cases.'

Mridula replied, 'I inconvenienced the police so much that they'll remember it for the rest of their lives. I wanted no part in the investigation. But I couldn't restrain myself when their witnesses uttered blatant falsehoods. I catechized them; after all, I haven't spent all these days in jail in vain. I, too, am a bit familiar with the law. The police must have thought that I wouldn't say anything and that they could furnish whatever evidence that they wished. When I cross-questioned them, everybody was

dumbstruck. I proved all the three witnesses to be liars. I don't know how the questions occurred to me then. The magistrate upbraided the subinspector on a couple of occasions or so. When he gave preposterous replies to my questions, the magistrate would say, "Answer only what is being asked. Why do you talk pointlessly?" And the inspector would feel ashamed. I silenced everyone present there. So far, the sahib hasn't given his decision, but I am confident that I shall be acquitted. I am not afraid of prison but I don't want to be taken in by idealism either. Our secretary and many of our sisters were also present there. All of them said, "You will surely be acquitted."'

Looking grudgingly at her, the women prisoners left. Some were serving a year's sentence while there were others who had been convicted for a period of six months. They hadn't even opened their mouths in the court. In their code of ethics, doing this would've been nothing short of unrighteousness. By her catechism, Mridula had lowered herself in their eyes. A jail sentence might have condoned her behaviour, but an acquittal would completely preclude repentance.

From a distance, a woman said, 'We also could've been acquitted likewise, but we have to show that we don't expect justice from the bureaucracy.'

Another woman added, 'This is no different from an apology. What did she go to the shop for if it wasn't for picketing? The volunteers were arrested because of her. Why was she there in the first place? But now she denies being there at all. This is a blatant plea for mercy.'

A third woman said scornfully, 'It takes a courageous heart to live in prison. Then, she had received commendation with alacrity and now she is regretting it. Such women shouldn't be involved in nationalist activities. There can't be any merit in bringing dishonour to the movement.'

Only Kshama Devi stood near Mridula, immersed in thought. A vehemently offensive speech had earned her a year's sentence. It had only been a month since she had been transferred here from another district jail. She still had to serve her sentence of the remaining eight months. She could not get along with any of the other prisoners. She detested their petty

quarrels, their acts of ingratiating themselves with the lady wardens for items of adornment and their restlessness for meeting their family members. The same acrimony and gossip had formed a part of the prison as well. In her opinion, no one had the self-esteem that was essential in a political prisoner. Kshama remained sequestered from their company. Her devotion for the community was unparalleled. She was deeply steeped in its colours. But the others considered her snobbish and reciprocated her indifference with an equal measure of detachment.

Eight days had passed since Mridula was taken into custody. Within a short span, she had developed a sense of affection for Kshama. She was bereft of the vices of pettiness or jealousy and was not in the habit of denouncing others. She neither had the inclination towards adornment nor was she interested in indecent pleasantries. In her heart, there was only compassion, a spirit of service and dedication for the country. Kshama had happily thought of spending her remaining months in the prison in Mridula's company. But even here misfortune had not deserted her. Mridula was going to leave the next day. Once again, she'd be alone. Who else was there with whom she could share her sorrows and distress? Discuss the issues that beset the nation? Here, all of them were self-obsessed.

Mridula asked her, 'Sister, you still have eight months of your sentence to serve.'

Kshama replied pensively, 'It too shall pass, sister, somehow or the other! But your memory will constantly haunt me. Over the past week, I don't know what kind of a spell you have cast upon me. Since your arrival, this prison no longer seems suffocating. Keep visiting occasionally, if possible.'

Mridula observed that Kshama Devi's eyes were tearful. Comforting her, she replied, 'Certainly I will, sister. I too, won't be able to restrain myself. And I'll also bring Bhan with me. I shall tell him, "Your *mausi* has come. Let's go and pay her a visit as she is calling you." He'll definitely come running. Sister, I confess to you today that if I ever remembered anyone here, it was Bhan. The poor child must be crying without me. When he sees me, he'll become sullen. He will ask me, "Where did you go? Why did you leave me behind? Go away! I won't speak to you. Get out of my house."

Sister, he's quite mischievous. He doesn't sit quietly even for an instant. As soon as he wakes up in the morning, he starts singing, "May oul countly's flag fly high. The temple of Swalaj lesides in my haat." It's quite a sight when he puts a flag on his shoulders and says, "Dlinking toddy and wine is long."[1]

'He tells his father, "You are a slave." His father works in an English firm and mulls over the idea of resigning from his job albeit without any consequence. But one has to have a job for livelihood. How can he resign from his job? Left to himself, he would've done that by now. I'm telling you the truth, he abhors servility. But it is I who reasons with him. Poor fellow! I wonder how he must be striking a balance between his office and his duty towards our son. Bhan never stays at my mother-in-law's place. That poor old lady! How can she match his ability to run from one place to another? She merely wants him to sit timidly in her lap and Bhan is averse to such an idea. I'm afraid she'll reproach me quite a bit. She never came to see me, not even once. Yesterday, in the court, I was told by my father-in-law that she is quite displeased with me. For three days, she's neither eaten nor drunk anything. She would only say, "This contemptible girl has made a travesty of the family's reputation. It is a smear on the ancestral lineage. That dishonourable, worthless woman! I wonder what gibberish she went on blathering about." However, I don't get distressed by her tirades. She is absolutely old-fashioned. So, it would only be unfair to expect her to conduct herself according to our demands. I'll have to go and conciliate her; she'll only be pleased after such supplication. There will definitely be a prayer ceremony tomorrow. Of that, I have no doubt. The Brahmins will be fed. The entire kindred community will assemble there. I can't but will have to expiate for the offence of going to jail. Sister, before leaving, do come and stay at our house for a couple of days or so. I shall arrange for a parole.'

Kshama was a lonesome widow and therefore oblivious to the pleasures of such affairs. She had lost everything, including both her husband and her son, in the Jallianwala Bagh massacre. There was no one now whom she could call her own. Her heart hadn't yet grown capacious enough to consider the whole of mankind as her family. For the past ten years, her

heart had been looking for tranquillity in the form of community service. She had wholeheartedly devoted her life to obliterate the very reasons that had ruined the happiness of her family and rendered her childless. She had already made the biggest of sacrifices. For the final offering, what else was there other than her heart? Community service may be a civilizational virtue or a means of acquiring illustriousness for others, but for Kshama, it was austerity itself. She was steeped in its practice with the entire strength and devotion that is characteristic of a woman. But even a bird flying in the sky remembers its nest. Alas, where was Kshama's refuge? These were the moments when Kshama would become restless with self-pity. She had considered herself blessed when she found Mridula here. But even this was a transitory shelter.

Kshama said in a distressed voice, 'You'll certainly forget me, Mridula. For you, it must have been like a brief encounter that one has on a railway journey and for me your promises are assurances of that same encounter. If we happen to meet each other, either you won't recognize me or, saying namaste with a slight smile, you'll go your own way. That's the way of the world. Since there's no end to one's misfortunes, why on earth should anyone bother about other people's problems? I was nothing for you but you are exceedingly good for me. But do remember this unfortunate woman sometimes while sitting among your loved ones. Even a handful of flour is more than sufficient for a mendicant.'

The magistrate pronounced his verdict the next day. Mridula was acquitted. In the evening, she hugged and wept with all her sisters, and went away, leaving them in an equally disconsolate state. It appeared as if she was leaving her parents in order to go to her in-laws.

2

Three months passed. Yet Mridula didn't pay a single visit. The other prisoners had regular visitors; some would receive food items and other gifts from their homes. But who was there to ask for Kshama? From early morning onwards, on the last Sunday of every month, she would wait

anxiously for Mridula. When the visiting hours were over, she would weep for a while and console herself by saying, ‘That’s how the way of the world is.’

One day, Kshama had barely risen from her evening prayers when she saw Mridula coming towards her. She neither had the same complexion nor the unchanging radiance that she had before. Kshama went running towards her, gave her a hug and said, ‘Mridula, what is it that you’ve done to yourself? Your entire appearance has changed. Why, have you been unwell lately?’

A stream of tears gushed out of Mridula’s eyes. She said, ‘No, sister, I’m not ill at all. I have been buffeted by misfortunes. I’m sure you have cursed me a lot. However, I’ve come here to expiate for my unkindness, for now I’m free from all anxieties.’

Kshama shuddered. A wave seemed to rise from the unfathomable depths of her heart. In it, she could see her past life sinking like some storm-tossed ship. In a hushed voice she said, ‘If everything is as all right as you say, then why did you come here so quickly? Not even three months have passed since you left.’

Mridula smiled, but there was lamentation concealed beneath that laughter. Then she replied, ‘Sister, everything is all right now, all right forever. There are no worries for me at all. At last, I can spend the rest of my life here. It’s only now that I can truly appreciate the merit of your benevolence and affection.’

She took a deep, cold breath and continued with tears in her eyes, ‘You must not be cognizant of what is happening outside. Day before yesterday, there was a police firing in the city. Land revenue is being exacted through the sheer use of bayonets. But how can farmers pay their taxes when they do not possess any money? The prices of foodgrains are declining every day. You can purchase a maund of wheat for only a rupee and twelve annas. I’m not old enough to speak from experience but even my mother-in-law admits that the prices of foodgrains had never fallen so low in her entire lifetime. The harvest from the farms is not adequate to compensate for the cost of the seeds, not to mention the factors of labour and irrigation. In such

a case, how can the destitute peasant pay his taxes? On top of that, the government has ordered that the revenue be collected without clemency. The farmers are even willing to auction off their property and deposits, accept the seizure of their huts, and to relinquish their claims over their lands. But here, the officials are only bothered about making an ostentatious display of their diligence. The government wouldn't stop them even if they unsparingly trample over the helplessness of their subjects. Rather, I've learnt that they buttress such oppression. Tax is the only thing that the government cares about. People may live or perish; it is none of their business. Quite often, the landlords refuse to collect revenue. Consequently, policemen are being sent to help them out. The entire locality of Bhairoganj is being pillaged. The peasants have been compelled to leave their houses in despair. Some constables entered a farmer's hut and started beating him up. Poor man! He endured it helplessly; his wife couldn't bear it any more. Beset by misfortune, she shouted at them. At that very instant, a constable stripped her naked. What should I say, sister, just narrating this incident pains me. What could be more unfortunate than the fact that our own brothers are capable of such inhumanity? The peasant couldn't bear it. Despite working so hard, these indigent people barely got a square meal. They neither possess physical strength nor courage. However, his too was a human heart, after all. The poor fellow had been lying there helplessly but when he heard his wife's shouts, he got up and pushed the constable so hard that the latter fell on the ground. Then both of them started wrestling with each other. A farmer behaving brazenly with a constable—how could they ever tolerate such a thing? All the constables thrashed the poor man to death.'

Kshama said, 'The other villagers must have passively watched the spectacle.'

Mridula replied, 'Sister, the poor folk were helpless in every way. Had some people gathered there, the police would have considered them their adversaries. There would've been a lathi charge and if someone, in a state of resentment, happened to hurl a stone or two at them, they would've started firing. Quite a few people would've died because of this. That is

why people do not assemble there. But when this farmer died, the villagers got provoked. They ran out with lathis and surrounded the constables from all sides. Perhaps a couple of them also used those lathis against the policeman. The constables started firing on the villagers. Some of them received minor injuries. In return, twelve villagers were shot dead and many were severely injured. This is why those petty people have been given so much of authority, so that they can misuse it. After massacring half of the village's population, they went away, playing the drums of victory. Who would've listened to the grievances of the villagers? They are destitute, faultless and incapacitated, so kill as many as you feel like. They are too disillusioned with the courts and its officials to expect justice from them. After all, was it not the government itself that had sent these constables to subdue the farmers? Why on earth should they ever listen to their complaints? But man's heart is never relieved without voicing its grievances. The villagers decided to seek help from their brothers staying in the town. It's true that the public is unable to do anything; yet, it has its capacity for empathy. It at least sheds tears when it hears the tales of suffering. Even the tears of empathy are no less valuable for the wretched ones. Had people from the neighbouring villages gathered there and cried with them, these poor folk would've found some solace. But, the police had blockaded that village and guards had been deployed on all sides. It was like rubbing salt on one's wounds. You beat a person and do not even allow him to cry. Finally, they picked up their corpses and went towards the town in order to share their accounts of misfortune. Meanwhile, news of the upheaval had already reached the town. When they saw these corpses, the crowd got infuriated and matters worsened when the police superintendent didn't allow them to take out a procession with these bodies. It was a huge gathering. My father too, was a part of this group. I tried stopping him, "It's a hostile mob today; please, don't go." He replied, "Don't worry, I won't fight anyone." About fifty thousand people constituted the procession when the bier was lifted, against government orders. On the other side, approximately five hundred policemen stood, blocking their way. There were mounted policemen, constables and sergeants; it was the entire troop.

Those cowards felt no sense of shame in brandishing their swords in front of the unarmed crowd. When repeated warnings of the police failed to disperse the mob, firing was ordered. It continued for about an hour. Imagine, one full hour! Who knows how many died, not to mention wounded. My house is on that street. I stood trembling with both my hands on my heart.

'With the first volley itself, the crowd was in total disarray. Thousands of people were fleeing the scene in utter perplexity. Sister, that sight is still so vivid before my eyes. How dreadful, how gruesome and how reprehensible it was! You could clearly perceive the fear in their eyes. But behind these fleeing individuals, there was a group of heroic and steadfast people who firmly stood there like a mountain, bearing bullets on their chests. They simply showed no signs of retreat. The firing could be heard quite clearly. After every gunshot, victory slogans issued forth from their mouths, piercing the atmosphere. How full of intensity that sound was! How captivating! How delirious! In my heart, my only wish was to go out and face the bullets in order to die happily. At that instant, death appeared to be mere child's play. My mother-in-law, who was inside along with Bhan, was repeatedly calling me inside. When I didn't go in, she went to the balcony, bringing the boy with her. Right then, about a dozen men came to our front door, carrying my husband's dead body on a stretcher. My mother-in-law's gaze fell upon him. She could figure out what must have happened. As for me, I nearly collapsed. Amma glanced at her son, embraced him, kissed him and blessed him. Then, in a frantic state, she wandered out into the main road where the gunshots and the victory shouts could be heard alternately. I kept staring in a state of bewilderment at my husband's corpse, and then at my mother-in-law. I stood there motionlessly, without a word. I neither wept nor became afraid. I was absolutely stupefied, as if consciousness itself had disappeared.'

Kshama asked, 'So do you mean that even your mother-in-law went to the site of the firing?'

Mridula replied, 'Strangely enough, she did, sister! She would otherwise put her hands to her ears the moment she heard gunshots. The very sight of

blood would make her swoon. But that day she pushed through the ranks of the dauntless satyagrahis right to the front. In an instant, she too was shot down. With her death, these warriors lost their patience. The bonds of their commitment to non-violence had been broken. An overwhelming sense of acrimony possessed them. Though they were unarmed and powerless, each of them experienced a presence of infinite strength within themselves. Finally, they attacked the policeman. Seeing this tidal wave approach, the sepoys got alarmed. They scampered for their lives, shooting recklessly in the process. Bhan was standing on the balcony when out of nowhere a bullet came and hit him in the chest. It seemed as if he was reciprocating his mother's milk with his own blood. The sense of stupor that I was filled with wearing clothes that were drenched with his blood could not possibly have been the same sporting a silk sari coloured with red powder on his wedding. Boyhood, youth and death—it was all over in a flash. I placed him near my husband's body. Meanwhile, a few volunteers brought my mother-in-law's body too. Lying there on the ground, it appeared as if she was smiling. She had stopped me but had herself jumped into the fire, as if it was the path to paradise! She had lived for her son all this while. How could she leave him alone in death?

'By the riverside, when all the three corpses were laid on the funeral pyre, the sight of them brought me back from my state of stupor and consciousness set in. For an instant, I felt an impulse to be with them on the pyre. The entire household would then have reached God's celestial court together. Then I wondered, "What have I done to deserve such a lofty reward?" Sister! Amidst the flames of the pyre, it appeared as if my mother-in-law was indeed smiling, with Bhan in her lap. It also seemed as if my husband was standing beside her, telling me, "You go and do your duty without a care in this world." There was such radiance on his face! It is true that God dwells only in the fire and blood of martyrs.

'I lifted my head. There were innumerable pyres that had been set ablaze on the banks of the river. From a distance, those burning pyres looked as if God himself had lit a fireplace in order to carve out the future of India.

‘We returned after the pyres had been reduced to ashes. However, I didn’t have the courage to go inside that house of mine. For me, my home was no longer my dwelling place. It either belongs to where I am now or the funeral pyre. I didn’t even open the door. Rather I went straight to the Mahila Ashram. The Congress Committee had been obliterated as a result of yesterday’s firing. The organization had been declared seditious. The police had raided their office and locked up the entire premises. The Mahila Ashram too had been attacked and padlocked. So, we made a makeshift office under the shade of a tree and continued working with complete freedom. No walls could have incarcerated us there. We were as free as the wind.

‘We decided to take out a procession in the evening. It was imperative to do it in the light of the memory, cheerfulness and celebration of yesterday’s bloodshed. People always wonder, “What is the purpose of such processions?” The purpose is that it proves that we are alive, adamant and still haven’t left the battlefield. We had to furnish evidence of our tenacious self-esteem. We had to demonstrate that we won’t be intimidated by the bullets and the persecution and will not be deterred from pursuing our objectives. We shall put an end to that system that has self-interest and violence as its foundation. On the other side, the police too considered it necessary to give proof of their domination and victory. Perhaps they felt that people might have got the wrong impression that yesterday’s atrocity had engendered the moral spirit of bureaucracy. The constables considered it their duty to dispel such doubts. They wanted to indicate that, “We’ve come to rule you and we’ll do so by all means. Your happiness or resentment is inconsequential to us.” The procession was forbidden. People were alerted with the following warning, “Do not participate in any procession otherwise there will be serious repercussions.” But everyone present there gave such a rejoinder that the officers were left astonished.

‘Around fifty thousand people assembled in the evening. I had been entrusted with the task of leadership. I experienced an unusual sense of power and eagerness in my heart. By virtue of the devotion of my loved ones, I, a vulnerable woman who had no knowledge of the world, who had

never stepped out of the household, had been elevated to a distinguished position that is unavailable to even the biggest emperors and officers. At this moment, I was reigning supreme over the hearts of the public. The police officers were subservient because they received remuneration for what they did. The question of survival compels them to do what they do.

'People obey an emperor's orders only because they expect favours from him or are afraid they might displease him. But did this massive crowd expect any possible profits from me? Were they afraid of losing favour with me? Absolutely not. Yet, they were willing to abide by the most stringent of my orders. This was because people venerated my sacrifices. It was also because I became a living symbol of the yearning for freedom that was present in their hearts and for the restlessness with which they wanted to break the shackles of subservience.

'At the decided hour, the procession started advancing. Right then, the policemen produced a warrant for my arrest. On seeing the warrant, I remembered you. There was a time when you needed me. But now, I am the one who needs your friendship in my life. Then, you had longed for my sympathy; now, I yearn for your compassion. However, there is not even an iota of infirmity within me. I'm free from all anxieties. I shall welcome the severest of punishments that the magistrate decides for me. Now I won't oppose any false accusations or aspersions that the police may cast on me. This is because I have realized that I can do more by staying inside the prison than by remaining outside it. Outside the jail, there is a strong probability of committing mistakes, of being led astray. Besides, there is also the temptation of compromise and the anxiety about rivalry. The prison acts as a boundary of respect and devotion, the lines of which can't be trespassed by the wicked. In an open field, a blazing bonfire loses its heat to the wind. But when that fire remains locked within an engine, it becomes a seamless repository of propulsion.'

By then, the other women in the prison had also arrived. Mridula embraced each of them. Thereafter the shouts of *Bharat Maata ki Jai* penetrated through the doors of the prison and reached the sky.

Translated from the Hindi by Shailendra Kumar Singh



The Servant of the Nation

The *Rashtra Sevak*, the servant of the nation, said, ‘The only way to liberate the country is through the spirit of brotherhood—by embracing people of the lower castes, by treating the outcastes as equals. We are all brothers—equals in this world. Nobody is inferior or superior.’

He was applauded by the world. What a great vision! What a sensitive being!

His beautiful daughter, Indira, heard the statement and was drowned in an ocean of anxiety.

The Rashtra Sevak embraced a young man from a low caste.

The world exulted, ‘He is an angel, a messiah! He is the one who can steer the nation.’

Indira saw all this and her face lit up.

The Rashtra Sevak took the young low-caste man to a temple to pay obeisance to God. He said, ‘Our God is in poverty, in degradation, under intimidation.’

The world commended, ‘A man of pure conscience! How learned!’

Indira saw these reactions and smiled.

She went to the Rashtra Sevak and said, ‘Most worthy father, I want to marry Mohan.’

The Rashtra Sevak looked at her affectionately and asked, ‘Who is Mohan?’

Indira responded excitedly, ‘He is the same young man you had embraced, whom you had taken to the temple. He, who is honest, brave and noble.’

The Rashtra Sevak looked at her in fury and turned away.

Translated from the Urdu by Sabiha A. Zaidi



The Goddess

The night had advanced. I was standing on the veranda and Aminuddaula Park before me was steeped in sleep. There was only a woman sitting on a bench.

Outside the park, standing on the edge of the road, a beggar was blessing the passers-by: ‘In the name of God and the Prophet . . . in the name of Ram and Bhagwan . . . take pity on this blind beggar!’

The rush of motorcars and passengers on the road wasn’t there any longer . One or two solitary walkers could be seen. The beggar’s appeal . . . now seemed like a cry in the wilderness.

Suddenly the woman stood up, looked around her and placed something in the beggar’s hand. Then she muttered something under her breath and moved to one side. A piece of paper could now be seen in the beggar’s palm, which he rolled again and again. Did the woman give him that chit?

What was the mystery? Driven by curiosity, I left the veranda and went to the beggar.

Hearing my footsteps, the beggar held the piece of paper before me and asked, ‘Baba, just see, what is this?’

I saw that it was a ten-rupee note! ‘It’s a ten-rupee note. Where did you find it?’

Tucking the note away in his bag, the beggar said, ‘A good woman has given it to me.’

I didn't say anything but rushed to catch up with the woman who had disappeared into the darkness.

After passing through many winding lanes, she stood before a run-down house, opened the lock and went inside.

I did not think it proper to bother her in the dead of the night. So I returned home.

I thought about her the entire night. Early in the morning I reached her lane. I learnt that she was a poor, helpless widow.

I went up to her door and said loudly, 'Devi, I've come to visit you.'

The woman came out. She looked the very image of poverty and helplessness.

I told her hesitantly, 'At night, you gave the beggar—'

She cut me short saying, 'You see, I found the note lying there on the road. I had no use for it . . .'

I lowered my head in reverence to the goddess.

Translated from the Urdu by M. Asaduddin



Shame

1

Iran and Greece were engaged in a fierce battle. Day by day, the Iranian troops were moving ahead, and Greece was faced with a serious threat. The entire business of the country had come to a halt. The hands of farmers that held the plough were compelled to take up the sword, those who held the beam of a balance were now balancing spears. The whole country was prepared for self-defence. Even then, day by day, the enemy was marching forward. Iran, a country which Greece had subdued many a time, was charging towards it as if in a fit of rage.

Men were risking their lives on the battlefield and women withered day by day hearing the discouraging views. How shall honour be protected? They were scared neither for their lives nor for their property, but for their dignity. Inebriated, the victorious would arrogantly ogle at Greek women, touch their delicate parts and take them away as prisoners. The very thought of impending adversity gave them goosebumps. Eventually, when the situation became extremely grave, Greek men and women gathered together and went to the temple of Delphi and questioned: ‘Devi, why do the gods have this indifferent attitude towards us? What wrong have we done? Have we not followed the tenets, not offered sacrifice or fasted? Why then have the gods taken away their protection?’

The priestess said: ‘Even the boundless compassion of all the gods cannot save the country from the clutches of a traitor. Surely, there is a traitor in this country; unless and until he is slain, this country cannot emerge from this danger.’

‘Devi, who is this traitor?’

‘The house from which comes the sound of singing at night, the house from which whiffs of aroma emanate during the day, the man whose eyes reflect a drunken hue—he is the country’s traitor.’

The people raised many more questions to find out more about the traitor but the Devi did not respond.

2

The Greeks began to search for the traitor in those houses from which sounds of singing could be heard at night. But as soon as the sun set, the whole town was drowned in mourning. If there was any sound, it was that of wailing; no laughter, no singing was heard anywhere. Which house had whiffs of aroma coming out from it during the day? Wherever people went, they smelt only ditches. There were heaps of garbage in every lane. Who had the time to clean the house, to burn incense! There was a shortage of washermen for most of them had gone to fight; the clothes were not being washed, so who would swab otto?

Whose eyes had a drunken-red hue? Eyes seemed red not as a result of drinking but from weeping. The wine shops were deserted. In this struggle of life and death, who could think of merriment!

The people searched the entire town but could not find even one pair of eyes that had a drunken-red hue. Many days passed. Every minute brought with it terrible news from the war front and people almost died with fear.

It was around midnight. The town was engulfed in darkness as if it were a cemetery. Not a soul was around. Theatres, where once there wouldn’t be room to even step in, were now forsaken. The markets where young men strutted fully armed were now inhabited by hooting owls. There were no drums, no singing in the temples any more—darkness spread over the

palaces. An old Greek whose only son was at the battlefield came out of his house; lost in thought, he walked in the direction of the Devi's temple. There was no light anywhere on his path, he stumbled at every step but kept moving forward. He was determined to get from the goddess a boon for victory (of his country) or lay his life at her feet.

3

Suddenly he was startled. He had arrived at the Devi's temple and from behind it, he could hear a melodious sound coming from some house. He was surprised. Who, in this desolate place, at this hour, was making merry? His feet took wings and he landed himself behind the temple.

From the house where the priestess of the temple lived came the sound of singing. Shocked, the old man stood in front of the window and thought of the adage 'Near the church further from heaven'. Such gross transgression behind the Devi's temple itself ?

The old man peered through the door. In a well-decorated room, candles sparkled in the chandelier, a clean rug was laid out on the floor and a man sat singing at a table. A wine bottle and a few glasses were placed on it. Two servants stood in front of the table, bearing trays laden with food. A tempting aroma arose from the food.

The old Greek shouted, 'This is the traitor! He is the traitor!'

The walls of the temple echoed, '. . . is the traitor!'

A voice came from the garden '. . . is the traitor.' The priestess of the temple popped her head out of the house and said, 'Yes, he is the traitor!'

This traitor was Pasoneous, the son of the temple priestess. Whatever plans were thought out for the security of the country, whatever decisions were taken to overcome the enemy, all the information was passed on by him to the Iranians. The enemy would get to know each and every movement of the Greek army and would be prepared to foil their efforts. This was why, despite the best efforts of the Greeks, they could not triumph. It was with wealth thus dissolutely acquired that Pasoneous indulged himself. To fulfil his own desires, he sold his country to the enemy at a time

when it was under utter threat. Except for his own gratification he was not bothered about anything; whether anyone died or lived, whether the country was saved or forfeited! For his own devious gains, he was prepared to let his country be put in fetters of enslavement.

The temple priestess was unaware of her son's misconduct. She would seldom come out from her small, dark room where she sat chanting and meditating. Engrossed with the divine, she was oblivious of this mundane world. Her deep meditation had numbed her consciousness of the world around her. At this moment too, she, locked up in her room, had been praying for the well-being of her country when she suddenly heard, 'This is the traitor, this is the traitor!' She immediately opened the door and peeped outside. A beam of light was coming out of Pasoneous' room and notes of music danced on the flickering rays. The earth seemed to slip from beneath her feet; her heart stopped. *God! Is my son the traitor?*

As if compelled by some inner conscience, she screamed, 'Yes, the traitor is here!'

4

A multitude of Greek men and women thronged outside Pasoneous' room and shouted, 'He is the traitor!'

The lights of his room were switched off and the music also stopped, but the crowd outside kept swelling by the minute and thousands of voices repeatedly shouted, 'He is the traitor!'

People lit their torches, took up their staffs and forced themselves into his house. Some said, 'Off with his head!' Someone else said, 'Sacrifice him at the Devi's feet.' Some insisted on throwing him down from the rooftop. Pasoneous understood that the moment of trouble had arrived. He ran down the staircase and, finding no place to hide, entered the temple.

What to do next? Whosoever entered the goddess's temple received the boon of protection (and did not need to fear)—so it was traditionally established. It was considered a grave sin to kill anyone in the temple. But

who was in a mood to spare the traitor so easily! So different suggestions came up.

'Hold his hand and pull the swine out.'

'Devi will forgive us for killing such a traitor.'

'Devi, why don't you devour him (alive)?'

'Stone him, pelt him with stones. He will come running out.'

'Why don't you come out, you coward! Why are you hiding in there, having shamed yourself ?'

This hue and cry went on all night but Pasoneous did not come out. Ultimately it was decided that the temple roof would be broken down so that Pasoneous would suffer the scorching sun during the day and freeze stiff from the severe cold at night. What then? Instantly, in the heat of the moment, the people tore down the roof and the spire of the temple.

A damned Pasoneous stood out in the sun the whole day. He was extremely thirsty, but where could he find some water? He was hungry, but where was the food? The entire floor was heating up like a griddle over fire; there was no shade, no respite. He had never suffered like this in his entire life. He was writhing like a fish out of water and shouting for help, but there was nobody to listen to him. He repeatedly swore that he would never commit such an offence again, but nobody came anywhere near him. Time and again he wanted to bang his head against the wall and die, but a hope that people might take pity on him deterred him from doing so. Like a madman he started shouting, 'Kill me, kill me! Take my life this very minute—don't kill me by burning me up like this. O you murderers, do you have no sympathy?'

The day passed, and night, a frightful night, arrived. The sky was starlit, as if mocking Pasoneous' misfortune. As the night deepened, the Devi acquired horrifying forms. Sometimes she would open her mouth and pounce on him, sometimes she would glare at him with flaming eyes. On the other hand, as the cold intensified with every passing minute, his limbs started to stiffen, his heart shivered with fear. He slumped to the floor and sat with his head on his knees, and began to weep over his luck. Sometimes he would pull his shirt to cover his feet, sometimes to cover his hands, so

much so that in the process he tore his garment. Past midnight, it started snowing. During the day, he had thought that the heat was most unbearable, but compared to the cold then, he forgot all the miseries of heat.

Eventually, he came up with an idea to warm his body. He started running around the temple. But the lazy fellow that he was, he soon fell down panting.

5

The next morning, when the people opened the door, they found Pasoneous lying on the floor. It seemed his body had turned stiff. After much shouting and screaming at him, he opened his eyes but could not move. He was in an extremely pitiable state, but nobody had any sympathy for him. In Greece, betrayal of one's country was the gravest sin and there was no pardon, no sympathy for a traitor.

First: 'Is he not dead yet?'

Second: 'Traitors don't die!'

Third: 'Leave him, he will die!'

Fourth: 'Is he pretending?'

Fifth: 'He has been punished for his doing. We should leave him now.'

Suddenly Pasoneous sat up and said in a chaste voice, 'Who says I should be set free? No, don't let me go or else you'll repent it. I'm selfish, used to indulgence; don't trust me even by mistake. Oh, what you people had to suffer because of me! When I think of it, I feel like burning my sense organs to ashes. Even if I am born a hundred times and repent for it, then too there will be no deliverance for me. Don't trust me even in error. Even I don't trust myself. People who love indulgence don't adhere to the truth. I can serve you even now. I know many, many secrets which you can use to destroy the Iranian troops. But I don't trust myself and I warn you not to trust me either. Last night I worshipped the goddess with a true heart and she granted me a talismanic formula with which we can subdue the enemy. Even now we can deliver an instant blow to the advancing Iranian army. But I don't trust myself. I will forget all this when I go out from here. It's

quite possible that I might secretly start helping the Iranians again. So don't trust me.'

One Greek: 'See, see what he is saying!'

Second: 'He seems to be an honest man.'

Third: 'He is confessing his crime.'

Fourth: 'He should be forgiven and we should ask him about all this.'

Fifth: 'See, he is not asking to be let off; rather, he is constantly reminding us not to trust him.'

Sixth: 'The afflictions of the night have brought him to his senses.'

Pasoneous: 'Are you people talking of letting me go? I say again that I'm not worth trusting. I'm a traitor. I know a lot of secrets of the Iranians. Once I reach their army, I can pretend to be a friend and destroy them but I don't trust myself.'

One Greek: 'Deceivers don't talk so honestly.'

Second: 'Earlier he was selfishly blind but now his eyes have opened.'

Third: 'There is no harm in finding out about matters of our interest even from a traitor. If he fulfils his promise, then we should leave him.'

Fourth: 'It's because of the Devi's initiation that his fortune has changed.'

Fifth: 'Even sinners have a spark of divinity in them which is awakened by adversity. To think that someone who has committed a sin once can never again be able to do a virtuous deed is a general attitude of contradiction in human nature.'

Sixth: 'We will take him out from here in a procession, singing and dancing. It is so easy to fool the masses. This is the weakest point of any republic. Generally people are good and do not have the ability to differentiate the good from the bad. They are easily deceived by the cunning and wily jackal.'

Until only a day before, a sword was positioned at Pasoneous' neck, but now preparations were being made to take him out of the temple in a procession—all because he was cunning enough to know how to turn the situation in his favour.

A woman: 'Call the musicians. Pasoneous is noble.'

Second woman: ‘Yes, yes, but first let us go and beg his forgiveness. We have been very hard on him, more than was necessary.’

Pasoneous: ‘Had you people asked me, I would have told you yesterday itself, then you would have known if it would be right to kill me or keep me alive.’

Many men and women: ‘Our sincere Pasoneous! Alas! We made a grave mistake.’

Suddenly an old lady came running from somewhere and, standing on the highest landing of the temple staircase, said, ‘What’s wrong with you people? Are the sons of Greece so ignorant today that they can’t discern true from false? You believe Pasoneous? That same Pasoneous because of whom thousands of women and children have been bereaved, who has not left in thousands of families anyone to light their homes, he who has disrespected our gods, our men. You are so overwhelmed by a little deceptive talk from him. Remember, if this time Pasoneous is let out, then you are not safe. Iran will rule over Greece, and Greek women will be victims of their men’s roving eyes. It is the Devi’s order that Pasoneous should not be set free again. If you hold your country dear, if to you, your man’s name is precious, if you value your mothers’ and sisters’ dignity, then seal the door of the temple so that the traitor will not get an opportunity to step out free or to mislead you people again. Look here, I place the first stone with my own hands.’

The people looked on in utter disbelief—this was the priestess of the temple and Pasoneous’ mother.

Instantly, stone after stone began to pile up and the temple entrance was sealed. Pasoneous stood inside, disgusted and helpless.

Brave mother, all praise for you! It is because of mothers like these that a country is made proud, who in the interest of their country care tuppenny for their own motherly love. Their sons are for the country, not the country for the son.

Translated from the Hindi by Sabiha A. Zaidi



The Procession

1

Vandemataram. The *purna swaraj* procession was going past. *Vandemataram*. Just a few youths, elders and children. Walking past the Mall. Waving flags and singing. *Vandemataram*. A wall of spectators stood on both sides. As if they had nothing to do with this goal. As if this was one big spectacle and all they had to do was watch. *Vandemataram*.

Standing on the pavement in front of his shop, Shambhunath turned to his neighbour Deendayal and said, ‘Every last one of them is walking into the jaws of death. The posse of sepoys will give them such a thrashing, they will all run for their lives.’

Deendayal said, ‘Mahatmaji also has grown senile. If independence could be won just by taking out a procession, it would have been won long ago. And just see who all are taking part in it—lads, louts and good-for-nothings. None of the big men of the city is present.’

Maiku was standing with a garland of slippers and sandals around his neck. Hearing these two seths talk, he laughed.

Shambhu asked, ‘Why did you laugh, Maiku? The atmosphere seems quite charged today.’

‘I laughed because you said there were no big men in the procession. Now why would they join the procession? Which comfort do they lack

under this rule? They live in bungalows and palaces, roam around in motor cars, feast and dine with the sahibs. What do they have to suffer! It is we who are starving and dying, we who don't know where our next meal will come from. Right now, one of them would be playing tennis, another would be drinking tea, another listening to the gramophone and yet another would be taking a walk in the park. And *they* will come to get beaten up by police batons? You've said it well!'

'What would you understand of all these things, Maiku! That cause for which four men of some standing come forward, even the government sits up and takes note of it. What impression can a crowd of hooligans and ruffians possibly make on those in power?'

Maiku looked at Shambhu with an expression that seemed to say, it's not just you who has the sole prerogative of understanding these matters. He said, 'It is *we* who make or break these big men, or is it someone else? So many people whom no one knew of, whom no one even glanced at before, have now been raised to the status of big, important individuals. Who now roam around in motor cars and consider *us* lowly. Such is the beauty of human destiny! That anyone who becomes even slightly successful turns his face away from us. For us, our big man is the one who walks around barefoot in a loincloth. Who is willing to sacrifice his life in order that our lot may improve. We don't care for any other *bada aadmi*. If you ask me, it is all these *bade* aadmi who have ruined our country. Sarkar grants them a nice piece of land, and they immediately puff up with pride and self-importance.'

Deendayal remarked, 'That new *daroga* is one tyrant. As soon as he reaches the crossroads, he will start raining lashes on them with his hunter. Then you see how they run for their lives. It will be fun.'

Drunk on freedom, when the procession reached the crossroads, they saw that a contingent of mounted police and *sipahi*s barred their way.

Daroga Birbal Singh rode up on his horse and, facing the procession, said, 'You people are not allowed to go any further.'

Ibrahim Ali, an elderly leader, stepped forward and said, 'I assure you, there will be no riots or trouble of any kind. We have not set out to ransack

shops or burn motorcars. Our goal is much higher than that.'

'I have orders not to let the *juloos* pass beyond this point.'

'Shouldn't you perhaps ask your superiors once?'

'I do not consider that necessary.'

'Fine. Then we will wait here. Once you leave, we will get up and go on.'

'You cannot stand here either. There are orders. You will have to turn back.'

Ibrahim said gravely, 'Turn back we will not. Neither you nor anyone else has any right to stop us. You want to stop us with the might of your mounted men and your guns, stop us, but you cannot turn us back. When will that day come! When will our own brothers refuse to follow orders that aim only to shackle our people in chains of slavery!'

Birbal was a graduate. His father was the superintendent of police. His veins ran thick with pride. He was highly respected by the officers. A handsome man, fair, with blue eyes and brown hair. Perhaps the moment he wore his coat and donned his hat, he forgot that he, too, was a native of this same country. Perhaps he began to think of himself as one of the white ruling class. But the sheer contempt in Ibrahim's words shamed him for a few moments. The matter, however, was a delicate one. If he let the juloos pass, he would be answerable. If he let them wait there, God knows for how long they would keep standing there. He was still debating this conundrum when he saw the DSP riding up on his horse. Now there was no time to think. He had to seize the moment and act! He pulled out the baton from his belt, turned his horse and charged straight into the crowd. As soon as they saw him, the other mounted soldiers followed suit. Ibrahim was standing right in front of the daroga's horse. He received such a brutal blow on the head that he was momentarily blinded. He couldn't remain standing. He held a hand to his head and sat down heavily. At that very moment darogaji's horse reared up on its hind legs, and Ibrahim came under its hooves. The procession had been standing peacefully until now. Seeing Ibrahim fall, many leapt to his aid, but none could move ahead. The batons kept raining down mercilessly on the crowd. People would face the blows with raised hands and keep standing their ground, unperturbed. It was

becoming increasingly difficult to remain unresponsive in the face of such brutal violence. *When it is hurt and humiliation that we must suffer,* they thought, *then why not try and surmount this wall, too? Lakhs of eyes in the city are riveted on us,* they thought. *If we turn back from here with this flag, with what face will we raise slogans of freedom again?* But not one of them thought of running away to save their lives. This was no mob of mercenary hirelings. This well-organized band of freedom-lovers, these true volunteers of the cause of independence knew and understood their responsibility only too well. There were many who were bleeding from the head, many whose hands were wounded. If they wanted, they could have torn apart that posse of mounted soldiers in one go. But their feet were shackled—by principle, by belief, by ideology.

For ten or twelve minutes, the batons kept raining down on them without mercy. And the people stood perfectly calm.

2

News of this violence spread like wildfire to the bazaar. Ibrahim Ali was crushed under the horse; many men were wounded, many had their arms broken. But neither did they turn back nor did the police let them proceed.

Maiku agitatedly said, ‘Bhai, now it is simply impossible to stay here any longer. I too am going there.’

Deendayal said, ‘Let us also go, Bhai, we will see whatever happens.’

Shambhu stood silent for a minute. Then he too abruptly began to down his shutters, and said, ‘We all have to die one day. Whatever will happen will happen. After all, those people are giving their lives for every one of us.’

One by one, most of the shops shut down. All those who were standing by and watching the fun until ten minutes ago now began to run in from all sides. And soon, a huge crowd of thousands of people began to move towards the site of the incident. This was a mass of people roused and surging with violence. They cared neither for principle nor ideology. They were ready not only to be killed but also to kill. There were many who

carried staffs in their hand, many whose pockets were loaded with stones. No one spoke to anyone nor asked anyone anything. All of them had just sworn to one firm resolve in their hearts, and they went marching forth like a mass of darkening clouds.

Seeing this huge crowd approaching from afar, the band of mounted policemen grew nervous. Birbal Singh's face was a picture of fear. The DSP started his motor car. It was one thing to rain blows on those sworn to peace and non-violence, and quite another to face an enraged mob. The mounted horsemen and sipahis slunk towards the back.

A horse leapt over Ibrahim, who was lying motionless on the ground. Hearing the commotion, he opened his eyes. He gestured to a youth standing nearby and asked, 'Kailash, are there some people coming from the city?'

Kailash looked towards that massive cloud advancing closer, and said, 'Yes, there are thousands of men.'

Ibrahim said, 'Then all is not well. Return the flag. We must turn back immediately, or there will be a storm. We must not fight our own brothers. Turn back at once.'

And saying so, Ibrahim Ali tried to get up, but couldn't.

The people were just waiting for the sign. As soon as they got the command, like an organized army they moved back as one man. A stretcher was quickly fashioned out of the bamboo flagstaffs, turban cloths and kerchiefs. They laid Ibrahim down on it and turned back.

But had they been defeated? If some people would be content believing they had been defeated, let them. But in reality, they knew they had won an epochal victory. *We knew that our battle was with our own brethren. And that owing to circumstances, what was good for them was different from what was good for us. We didn't have to make enemies of them.* They also did not want that looting and riots should gain precedence in the city and that their high battle of faith and ideology, their *dharmayudh*, should end in plundered shops and broken heads. The brightest, most eloquent, sign of their victory was that they had gained the sympathy of the public. Those very people who had always laughed at them had now come forward,

seeing their determination and courage to help them. *It is* this *change in mindset which is our true victory. We don't need to fight anyone. Our goal is only to gain the sympathy of the people, to change their hearts and minds. And the day we reach this goal will be the day the sun of Swaraj will rise.*

3

Three days had passed. Birbal Singh was sitting in his room drinking tea. His wife, Mitthan Bai, was standing before him, cradling their infant son in her lap.

Birbal Singh said, 'What could I have done then? The DSP was standing behind me. If I had let them pass, I myself would have been in trouble.'

Mitthan Bai shook her head and said, 'At the very least, you could have stopped your men from raining their batons on them. Is it your job to beat up men? At the most you could have restrained them. If tomorrow you are entrusted with the task of caning criminal offenders, you would probably be delighted, wouldn't you!'

Birbal Singh got irritated and said, 'You just don't understand!'

'I understand perfectly well. The DSP was standing right behind you. You must have thought such an opportunity for displaying your mettle would never again present itself. Do you imagine there wasn't a single noble man in that crowd? There would have been so many present there who could have kept someone like you as their servant. Most of them would have been better educated than you. But you were showering blows upon them and crushing them underneath your horses, showing off your virility!'

Birbal Singh laughed a brazen laugh and said, 'Do you know the DSP has made a note of my name? Really!'

Darogaji thought he would please Mitthan Bai by giving her this piece of news. Civility, nobility, high morals and so on are all external, superficial things, after all, expressed not from the heart but from the tongue. But self-interest resides deep in the heart. This is a matter for serious thought.

But there was nothing on Mitthan Bai's face to suggest joy. Perhaps things of the surface had indeed percolated deep! She said, 'He must surely have done so, and you may well get an early promotion, too. But a promotion that is tainted by the blood of innocents—of what worth is it? This is not a reward for your bravado; it is the price of your treachery to the nation. Your true reward will come only when you track down a murderer or save a man from drowning.'

Just then, a sipahi appeared on the veranda and said, 'Huzoor, an envelope has arrived for you.'

Birbal Singh came out, took the envelope from him and began to read the official letter. Having read it, he kept it on the table.

Mitthan taunted, 'So has your promotion love letter arrived already?'

Birbal Singh retorted, 'You do mock me! There is going to be another procession today. I have been ordered to stay with it.'

'Oh, then it's your lucky day indeed! Get ready. You will get the same prey to hunt down again today. Go forth and shine, show your courage! The DSP will certainly come too. This time you will be made inspector for sure!'

Birbal Singh frowned hard and said, 'You do talk such nonsense sometimes. Supposing I just go and stand there quietly, what will the consequence be? I will be considered useless and someone else will be sent to replace me. If they suspect me to be a sympathizer of the swarajists, I will be done for. Even if I am not suspended outright, I will most certainly have to answer for it. A man has to work by the rules of the world he lives in. I may not be that wise, but I do know that these people are trying to work for the uplift of the country and the community. I also know that the government wants to crush this very idea underfoot. I am not such a fool that I will be proud to live a life of slavery, but I am bound by my circumstances.'

The sound of a band playing music was heard. Birbal Singh went outside and inquired, and was informed that the Swaraj procession was on its way. He quickly donned his uniform, tied his turban, and stepped out with the pistol in his pocket. His horse was readied and brought out in a jiffy. The

constables were already sitting prepared. Everyone hurried towards the procession.

4

Marching on the double, they caught up with the juloos in about fifteen minutes. As soon as the crowd saw them, countless voices rose together in one single roar of *Vandemataram* like thunder from the clouds. And then—silence. There was such a contrast between this procession and that one. That was a glorious celebration of Swaraj. This was a funeral procession in mourning of a martyr. After three days of high fever and acute agony, today the life of one who never aspired to any post, never bowed his head before any authority, had come to an end. As he lay dying, Ibrahim Ali had willed it that—'My corpse be bathed in the Ganga before being buried, and the flag of Swaraj be flown over my gravestone.' As the news of his death spread, a pall of gloom fell over the city like a black curtain. Whoever heard would be momentarily stunned as if hit by a bullet, and then instantly run for a last glimpse of his beloved leader. All the bazaars had shut down. There was no sign of the horse-drawn ekkas and tongas. It was almost as if the town had been plundered and razed. By and by, the entire city gathered together. At the time the funeral procession lifted the body and started off, the crowd was more than a lakh strong. There wasn't an eye that was not red with tears.

Birbal Singh ordered his constables and mounted sepoys to walk along with the procession at a distance of five yards from it. He went to the back. At the rear of the procession, for some fifty yards, marched women. He glanced at them. Right in the first row, he saw Mitthan Bai. Birbal couldn't believe his eyes. He looked again carefully—yes, it was her. Mitthan looked at him just once and averted her eyes. But there was such scorn, such shame and agony, such hatred in her gaze that it shot through him like a current from head to foot. Never before had he felt so weak, so small and so humiliated in his own eyes.

Just then a young woman looked at him and said, ‘Kotwal Sahib, hope you won’t start thrashing us with your baton. We are frightened just looking at you!’

Another said, ‘It was some brother of yours who fatally wounded the old leader at the crossroads of the Mall, wasn’t it?’

Mitthan said, ‘No brother of his, it was he himself.’

At that, many voices spoke up together, ‘Oh, so *this* is that gentleman? Greetings to you, O Mahashay! It is only thanks to your mercy that we, too, have gathered here today to receive the blessings of your baton!’

Birbal hurled spears at Mitthan Bai with his eyes, but kept silent.

Then a third woman said, ‘We will have a celebration where we will garland you victorious and sing high praise of you.’

A fourth said, ‘You look just like an Englishman, and no wonder, you are so fair!’

An old woman said, ‘If such a child had been born of my womb, I would have throttled him at birth!’

A young woman responded with scathing contempt, ‘What are you saying, Mataji! Even dogs are faithful to the salt they eat. This is still a man!’

The old woman angrily retorted, ‘Slaves of the belly! Oh woe the belly, the greedy belly!’

At this several women surrounded the old woman and held her, and the poor woman embarrassedly said, ‘Arré, who am I to say anything! But what kind of a man is he who goes blind with greed!’

Birbal Singh couldn’t take it any more. He led his horse to the far end of the procession. If a man shames us, we feel angry; if women shame us, we feel ashamed, guilty. At that moment Birbal Singh didn’t have the courage to face those women again. He was furious with his officers. *Why is it that only I am sent for these kinds of jobs again and again? There are others too, why aren’t they ever asked? Am I the most worthless and dispensable of the lot? Am I so numb, so devoid of any emotion? Mitthi must think I am such a lowly coward. Perhaps right now if someone killed me, she wouldn’t even say a word. Perhaps she would even be glad and relieved in her heart*

that it's good riddance. Now if someone goes and tells the Sahib that Birbal Singh's wife was in the procession, I will have no face left to show! Mitthi knows this. She understands this. And despite that, she went. Didn't once ask me. Of course, she has nothing to worry about, that's why she gets all these ideas in her head. Everyone here is so carefree, all these school and college boys, these wage labourers—what do they care about? It is we who have children, and family pride and honour to think of, it is we who suffer, we who have to pay the price. Those women, all of them, were staring at me as if they would eat me alive.

The procession was passing through the main roads of the city. On both sides, on roofs, balconies, windows and trees stood walls of spectators. *Today, all their faces seem agile and aglow with new hope, a new fervour and pride,* Birbal thought. The faces of all the trees seemed lively, those of the young men eager, and the young women proud. This was the pure joy of walking on the path to freedom and self-rule. The goal of their journey was no longer unknown. They no longer had to wander aimlessly like those who had strayed from their path. No longer had to bow their heads and weep like the oppressed. Shining far out on the horizon, the golden summit of Swaraj was now clearly visible. And it seemed as if the people cared nothing for the deep gorges and forests that lay in between. They were eager only to reach that golden goal. That was all they saw.

By the time it was eleven, the funeral procession had reached the riverbank. The body was lifted down with care, and taken to be bathed in the Ganga. The baton wound was clearly visible on the calm, pale forehead. The blood had congealed and blackened. The dried blood had made the long strands of hair on the head stick together like an artist's brush. Many thousands had gathered for a last glimpse of this martyr, and they stood encircling him.

Birbal Singh was at the back, astride his horse. He too could see the wound on the head. But he couldn't bring himself to look at the body and turned his face away. His conscience cried foul. That man, for whose last glimpse, to touch the dust of whose feet to their heads as blessing, lakhs were anxiously waiting, *this* is how I insulted that man! At that moment,

Birbal Singh's soul acknowledged that there wasn't even a shred of duty in that brutal cowardly assault. Only blind self-interest, the lust for an exploit and the greed to please his officers. He felt thousands and thousands of enraged eyes upon him, but he did not have the courage to meet them.

Just then a constable came up to praise him, 'Huzoor's hand fell heavy indeed—the skull is still gaping open! Huzoor opened up their eyes, taught them all a good lesson!

Birbal replied, 'I consider this not an instance of my virility, but of my wretchedness.'

The constable again resorted to flattery, 'He was a most obdurate fellow, Huzoor! *Bada sarkash aadmi thha*.'

Birbal sternly said, 'Quiet! Do you even know whom they call sarkash? Those who commit dacoity, who plunder, rob and murder, *they* are called sarkash. Not those who go about staking their lives for their country. It is our misfortune that instead of supporting them, we are opposing them. This is not something to be proud of or pleased about. It is a matter of great shame and despair.'

The ritual bath over, the procession moved on once again.

5

It was past two when the body was laid to rest in the ground and people began to return home. For some distance, Mitthan Bai walked along with the rest of the women. But at Queens Park, she stopped. She didn't feel like going home. As if that wasted, wounded, bloodless corpse was sitting inside her and mocking her. She was filled with such profound aversion and apathy for her husband that she didn't even feel like taunting him any more. She did not believe that anything other than fear could have an effect on such a selfish man.

She sat on the grass in the park for a long time, thinking, but couldn't come to any conclusion as to what she should do. She could go to her parents' place, but in a month or two, she would have to come back to this same house again. *No, I will not seek anyone's refuge. Can't I earn enough*

to even support myself? She imagined all manner of difficulties and challenges in her path. But God knows from where she found this kind of strength today—even the thought of these difficulties seemed to her to be her weakness.

All at once the thought of Ibrahim Ali's widow came to her mind. She had heard that they had no children. *The poor woman must be sitting by herself and weeping. There would be no one by her side even to console or comfort her*. Mitthan Bai started walking towards her house. She had already asked the other women where she lived. As she walked, she kept thinking, *How can I possibly face her? What will I say to her? In what words shall I explain to her . . . ?* Immersed in such thoughts, she reached Ibrahim Ali's house. The house was in a lane, neat and tidy, but the entrance, rundown with neglect, left much to be desired. Her heart pounded painfully as she stepped inside. In the veranda in front, on a bare cot, sat the old woman whose husband had sacrificed himself on the pyre of freedom. Standing before her in simple clothes was a young man talking to her, with tears streaming down his face. Mitthan was startled to see the youth—it was Birbal Singh.

She asked in angry surprise, 'How did you come by here?'

Birbal Singh said, 'The same way you did. I have come to get my sin pardoned.'

The glow of pride, joy and love that anointed Mitthan's fair face at that moment was beyond words. It was as if the troubles of all her past lives had been wiped out, and she had been freed from the bonds of care and delusion forever.

Translated from the Hindi by Moyna Mazumdar



Subhagi

1

Regardless of whatever went on in other households, Tulsi Mahto loved his daughter, Subhagi, not a bit less than his son, Ramu. Even after stepping into adulthood, Ramu had remained a blockhead. Subhagi, just a girl of eleven, was so efficient in household chores and so skilled in farming that deep down, Lakshmi, her mother, feared the gods might cast an eye upon her. For even God loves good children. To make sure that people did not excessively praise the girl, she would scold Subhagi for no reason at all. Her fear was not that excessive praise would spoil the child; rather the fear was of the evil eye! Today that same Subhagi had become a widow at the age of eleven.

There was lamentation in the house. Lakshmi fell unconscious out of grief, while Tulsi beat his own head. Seeing them cry, Subhagi too wept. ‘Why do you weep, Amma?’ she would ask again and again. ‘I will never leave you; why do you weep?’ Hearing her innocent words, the mother’s heart would tear apart even more. She would think, *O Lord, this is your great drama of life! The games you play by hurting others. This is what lunatics do. A man is sent to an asylum if he acts insane, but the insanity that you practise goes unpunished. What use is there of such a game that*

makes others cry and you laugh. People call you the Merciful. This is your mercy!

And what was Subhagi thinking? If only she had a cell full of money, she would keep it hidden. And someday she would quietly slip away to the market and buy nice clothes for her mother. And when her father would ask for the balance, she would immediately give him the money. How happy her mother and father would be!

2

When Subhagi came of age, people started pressing Tulsi Mahto to find her a home. 'It is not right for a young girl to roam around like this. And when our community does not condemn such a practice, why do you think so much about it?'

Tulsi said, 'Bhai, I am ready, but only if Subhagi also agrees. She just doesn't agree.'

Harihar tried to make Subhagi understand, 'Beti, we are talking about your own well-being. Your parents have grown old. Who knows what may happen to them! How long will you stay like this?'

Bowing her head, Subhagi said, 'Chacha, I do understand your advice, but I don't feel like settling down anywhere. I don't worry about comforts. I am ready to take on anything. And whatever you ask me to do, I'll do it with my heart and soul. But please don't ask me to get married. If you find me going astray, kill me. If I am the daughter of a virtuous father, I will keep my word. After all, it is God who is the saviour of one's honour. Who am I to say anything now!'

Ramu, uncouth as he was, said, 'If you think that *bhaiya* will be earning and you will have fun, then you are mistaken. Nobody here has taken your responsibility for life.'

Ramu's wife was even more outspoken than him. She said scornfully, 'We haven't taken any loan from anyone that we need to repay it all our life. You want the best food and the best clothes, and this is beyond our means.' Subhagi replied proudly, 'Bhabhi, I have never looked to you for

support, and God willing, I never shall. You better take care of yourself, don't be bothered about me.'

When Ramu's wife realized that Subhagi would not settle down in another home, she started troubling her even more. She always had some complaint or the other, as if she enjoyed making her cry. Poor Subhagi! She would get up before dawn and begin to grind the flour, and carry on with the kitchen chores, make cow-dung fuel and then go to work in the fields. Returning at noon, hurriedly she would cook and serve food to everybody. At night she would apply oil on her mother's head, sometimes massage her body. Tulsi was addicted to chillum smoking. She would offer chillum to him regularly. As far as possible, she wouldn't let her parents do any work. But yes, she wouldn't stop her brother from working. She thought, *He is a young man. If he doesn't work, how will the household run?*

But Ramu did not like this. He would think, *She doesn't let mother and father do any work at all, but she wants to grind me down with work*! And so one day he lost his temper and told Subhagi, 'If you love them so much, then why don't you live with them separately? Serve them then, and you will realize how sweet or bitter it is to serve. It is easy to earn praise at the cost of others. One who is self-reliant is really the brave one.'

Subhagi didn't reply, fearing that it would exacerbate the argument. However, her parents were within earshot. Mahto could not restrain himself. He said, 'What is this, Ramu? Why are you pestering the poor girl?'

Ramu came close and said, 'Why do you come in between? I am talking to her.'

Tulsi said, 'So long as I am alive, you can't say anything to her. Do whatever you want to when I am no more. You have made the poor girl's life miserable in this house.'

'If the daughter is so dear to you, then tie her around your neck. But I cannot tolerate this.'

'All right. If this is your wish, then it will be fulfilled. Tomorrow I will call the village people and divide the property. I can leave you, but not Subhagi.'

At night, when he retired to bed, that old memory came to Tulsi's mind: he had borrowed money to celebrate Ramu's birth, while he didn't spend a penny on Subhagi's birth even though he had money at home. He had considered the son a gem, and the daughter a punishment for the misdeeds of his previous life. Today, how cruel that gem had turned out to be, and how blissful this punishment!

3

The next day, Mahto gathered the village people and addressed them, 'Members of the panchayat, Ramu and I cannot get along any more. Whatever share you give me justly, I will take that and live separately. But I don't like petty squabbles day and night.'

The village head, Babu Sajan Singh, was a thorough gentleman. He called Ramu and asked him, 'So you want to live separately from your father? Don't you feel ashamed that at the behest of your wife, you are ready to separate from your parents? O God!'

Ramu said brashly, 'When it's difficult to live under one roof, it is better to separate.'

'What is your difficulty in living together?'

'There isn't one difficulty alone.'

'At least tell me something.'

'Sir, I just want to say that I can't live with them. That's it, and I don't know anything else.'

Saying this, Ramu went away.

Tulsi remarked, 'So you people saw how he behaves! You may give him three-quarters of the family assets, but now I will not live with this rascal. Unfortunately, God's curse befell my daughter, otherwise what use do I have for the land now! I could earn my living anywhere I lived! May God not give such a son even to my worst enemy! A daughter who brings honour to the family is better than a son.'

Suddenly, Subhagi stepped forward and said, 'Dada, all this family division is because of me. Why don't you cut me off? I will labour to earn

my living. I will serve you to the best of my abilities, but I will live separately. I can't see the family breaking up. I don't want to carry this stigma on myself.'

Tulsi replied, 'Beti, we can renounce the entire world but not you! I don't even want to see Ramu's face, let alone live with him.'

Ramu's wife said, 'If you don't wish to see our faces, then we too are not dying to worship you.'

Gnashing his teeth, Tulsi got up to beat his daughter-in-law, but the people held him back.

4

After the division, Tulsi and Lakshmi lived as though they were on pension. Earlier, despite Subhagi's protests, they used to do something or the other. Now, however, they enjoyed complete rest. Earlier they yearned for ghee and milk, but now Subhagi had bought a buffalo with her savings. For old people, food is everything. How'd they survive if they didn't get good food? The father, however, strongly protested and said, 'Isn't there enough work already in the house that you have invited a new hassle?' To please them, Subhagi would say, 'Dada, I don't relish my food without milk.'

Lakshmi said with a laugh, 'Beti, since when have you started telling lies? Forget eating, you don't even touch milk! You force all the milk on us.'

In the village, everyone had a word of praise for Subhagi. She was not a girl, but a goddess. Not only did she work as much as two men, but she also found time to serve her parents. Sajan Singh would call her a goddess from a previous birth.

However, Tulsi was probably not destined to enjoy this comfort for long.

It had been seven or eight days since Tulsi had been suffering from fever. He could not bear any clothes on his body. Lakshmi sat by his side, weeping. Subhagi was standing near her with water. Just a little while ago, Tulsi had asked for water, but before she could bring it, his heart sank and his hands and feet turned cold. Seeing his condition, Subhagi went to

Ramu's house and said, 'Bhaiya, please come and see what is happening to Dada. His fever has not subsided for the last seven days.'

Ramu continued to lie on his bed, and said, 'Am I a doctor or a hakim that I should go to see him? As long as he was well, you remained the apple of his eyes. Now that he is dying, you have come to call me!'

At that very moment, his wife came out and asked Subhagi, 'Didi, what has happened to Dada*?*'

Before Subhagi could say anything, Ramu spoke out, 'What has happened, he is not dying yet!'

Subhagi did not utter another word to him, and went straight to Sajan Singh. After she left, Ramu said to his wife laughingly, 'This is what they call women's wiles.'

'Where is the question of a woman's wiles here? Why don't you just go there?'

'I won't go. As he separated with her, let him continue to live with her. Even if he dies, I won't go.'

'If he dies, you will certainly go to light the pyre. Then where will you run?'

'Never! His darling Subhagi will do everything.'

'Why should she, when you are there?'

'Because he separated with her while I was there, why else?'

'No, this is not right. Let us go and see him. Whatever it is, he is our father. Otherwise, what face will you show to the village?'

'Shut up, don't preach!'

On the other hand, the moment Sajan Singh heard about Tulsi's condition, he came rushing with Subhagi. By the time they reached, Tulsi's condition had deteriorated further. He checked his pulse rate, it was very slow. He realized that Tulsi's days were over. The fear of death was pervasive. His eyes moist, he asked, 'Mahto Bhai, how are you feeling?'

As if roused from sleep, Tulsi said, 'I feel very fine, Bhaiya. It is time to leave. From now on you are Subhagi's father; I leave her to your care.'

Sajan Singh started weeping and said, 'Don't lose heart, Mahto Bhai, God willing, you'll get well. I have always considered Subhagi as my own

daughter, and will continue to do so as long as I live. You be at peace. So long as I am alive, no one will dare cast an evil eye on Subhagi or Lakshmi. If you have another wish, please state that too.'

Mahto said, with humility in his eyes, 'I have nothing else to say, Bhaiya. May God always keep you happy.'

'Let me call Ramu. Forgive him for his misdeeds.'

'No, I don't want to see the face of that villain.'

After this, they started preparing for *godaan*.

5

Everyone in the village tried to persuade Ramu to perform the last rites, but he didn't agree. He said, 'The father who refused to see my face even at the time of death is not my father, nor I his son.'

Lakshmi lit the funeral pyre. Everyone wondered how Subhagi managed to arrange for the money in those few days. When supplies for the thirteenth-day rituals started arriving, the villagers were astonished. Utensils, clothes, ghee, sugar, all the items were brought in abundance. Seeing all this, Ramu burnt with jealousy. And to make him jealous, Subhagi showed these things to everybody.

Lakshmi said, 'Beti, spend within your means. There is no one now to earn. We have to dig our own well to get water.'

Subhagi said, 'No matter what happens, Dada's last rites must be performed properly, Amma. He is not going to return. I want to show Bhaiya what a helpless woman can do. He must be thinking that these two can't do anything. I will shatter his pride.'

Lakshmi kept quiet. On the thirteenth day, a feast was arranged for Brahmins from eight villages. Everyone was full of praise.

It was late afternoon. People had left after having their food. Tired, Lakshmi had gone to sleep. Only Subhagi was busy clearing up, when Sajan Singh came and said, 'Beti, now you also take some rest. Finish this work tomorrow morning.'

Subhagi said, ‘Dada, I am not tired yet. Have you calculated the total expenditure?’

‘Beti, why do you want to know?’

‘No, just like that.’

‘It would amount to nearly three hundred rupees.’

Subhagi said hesitantly, ‘I owe you this amount.’

‘I don’t ask you for this amount. Mahto was a friend and a brother to me. I also have a duty towards him.’

‘Isn’t it kindness enough that you trusted me so much? Who would have given me three hundred rupees?’

Sajan Singh thought, *Is there any limit to the moral wisdom of this poor woman!*

6

Lakshmi was among those women for whom the death of the husband meant the end of life. After fifty long years of togetherness, this lonely life became unbearable for her. Now she felt as if she was deprived of everything, her wisdom, her strength and her good sense.

Several times, she had prayed to God that she should die before her husband, but He had not accepted this prayer. One has no control over death; does that mean one has no control over life either?

The same Lakshmi who was known for her wisdom throughout the village, who would counsel others, had now lost her mind, and couldn’t even talk normally.

Right from that day, Lakshmi virtually stopped eating. Though on Subhagi’s insistence, she would enter the kitchen, she wouldn’t be able to swallow a morsel. For fifty full years, there had not been a single day when she had eaten without her husband eating first. How could she break that practice now?

Finally, she started coughing. Soon weakness made her bedridden. What could Subhagi do now? In order to pay off Thakur Sahib’s debt, she had to work extremely hard. And her mother had fallen ill! If she went out,

Lakshmi would be left alone, and if she sat by her side, who would work outdoors! Seeing her mother's condition, Subhagi realized that soon she too would be summoned. After all, Tulsi too had suffered from the same fever.

Who else in the village had the time to run around? Sajan Singh used to visit twice a day. He would come, attend to Lakshmi, give her medicines and would console Subhagi. Lakshmi's condition, however, deteriorated, so much so that on the fifteenth day, she too left the world. Ramu came at the last moment, and wanted to touch her feet, but Lakshmi so snubbed him that he didn't dare to go near her. She blessed Subhagi, 'Having a daughter like you, my life has been blessed. Only you should perform my last rites. My only prayer to God is that even in the next life may He bless me with you in my womb.'

After her mother's death, Subhagi had only one mission in life—to pay back Sajan Singh's money. Three hundred rupees were spent on the last rites of her father; around two hundred rupees on her mother's. A debt of five hundred rupees, and she had to pay it off all by herself. But she didn't lose heart. For three years, Subhagi worked day and night. Seeing her determination and capacity to work, the people were amazed. After working in the fields all day long, she would grind mounds of flour at night. Every thirtieth day, she would go to Sajan Singh with fifteen rupees. She never missed it. As if that was the eternal law of nature!

Marriage proposals for Subhagi started pouring in from everywhere. Every household fancied her as their would-be bride. Whichever house Subhagi would go to, it would be their good fortune. Subhagi, however, would always reply, 'The day has not yet come.'

The day Subhagi paid the last instalment, her joy knew no bounds. That day her life's difficult pledge was fulfilled.

As she was about to leave, Sajan Singh said, 'Beti, I have a request to make. Tell me, should I say it or not? But promise me, you will accept it.'

Subhagi looked at him with gratitude and said, 'Dada, if I don't accept your word, whose word will I accept! Each cell of my body is indebted to you.'

‘If you think like this, I won’t say it. I did not say it until now because you considered yourself indebted to me. But today you have paid off the money. Now you are under no obligation, not the least. Should I say it?’

‘Command me.’

‘But please don’t say no. Or I won’t show you my face again.’

‘What is your command?’

‘It is my wish that you sanctify my house as my daughter-in-law. I believed in the caste system, but you freed me from all such shackles. My son is devoted to you, and you have seen him many times. Tell me, do you accept it?’

‘Dada, I will go mad with so much honour.’

‘Beti, God Himself is honouring you! You are the very incarnation of the goddess Bhagvati.’

‘I consider you as my own father. Whatever you will decide for me will be for my well-being. How can I ever say no to your command?’

Sajan Singh placed his hand on her head and blessed her, ‘Beti, may your married life be blessed. Who else in the world would be as fortunate as I am!’

Translated from the Hindi by Rajendra Parihar



Role Reversal

1

Mr Seth scorned everything Indian. His pretty wife, Godavari, despised all things foreign. But patience and tolerance are the ornaments of Indian women. Though Godavari forced herself to use every foreign product that her husband brought, in her heart she wept at her helplessness. The sight of women holding their heads high draped in khadi made her sigh in regret at her own inability to do so. She felt that no other woman on earth could be as ill-fated as her.

‘Can’t I serve my countrymen even in this way?’ she lamented.

On Mr Seth’s insistence, she went on outings but her head hung low in shame for being dressed in foreign cloth. Her eyes would light up on reading passionate newspaper articles by women; she would momentarily forget that she was bound in fetters.

It was eight o’clock on the day of Holi. A group of activists sold to the swadeshi cause gathered at the spacious grounds in front of Mr Seth’s house; the bonfire of foreign goods began. In misery, Godavari watched the proceedings from a window.

‘There they are to set the *holika* on fire with heads happily held high, intoxicated by the fervour of freedom. And here I am like a bird flapping its wings in a cage. How do I break these bars?’

She looked around the room she stood in; everything was foreign, there wasn't one swadeshi thread. These were the things being set on fire out there, and here they were locked up in trunks like the guilt in her heart. She felt an upsurge in her heart to dump all those things in that same fire and burn away her helplessness and guilt. But the fear of her husband's displeasure held her back. Suddenly, Mr Seth came in and said, 'Just look at these maniacs burning clothes. What is this, if not madness, obsession and rebellion? Someone has rightly said that Indians have no brains and will never have any. They don't do a thing right.'

'Are you not Indian?' Godavari asked.

Mr Seth replied hotly, 'Yes, but I will always regret being born in such an unfortunate country. I don't want anybody to consider or call me an Indian. At least in manners, thoughts, dressing and lifestyle I have altered so much that no one can accuse us of being Indian. Ask why we should buy coarse fabric when we can purchase a finer one at eight annas a yard. Everyone should have complete freedom in these matters to practise their will. I don't know why the government has allowed these wretches to gather here. I would have just packed them off to hell. That would set their minds right.'

Godavari answered with contempt, 'Don't you have the slightest concern for your countrymen? Is there any nation other than India which is under foreign rule? Even the smallest of nations do not wish to be enslaved by another country. Is it not a matter of shame for an Indian that he supports the government for his petty benefit and does injustice to his brothers?'

Seth raised his brows and replied, 'I do not consider them my brothers.'

'The salary that the government pays you comes from their pockets.'

'I do not care about which pocket my salary comes from. The hand that pays it to me is that of my master. I don't know what has got into the heads of these scoundrels. They say that India is a spiritual country. Does spirituality mean going against the will of God? When not even a leaf moves without the will of God, then how is it possible for an entire nation to be ruled by the British against God's will? Why do these fanatics not understand that no one can pluck a hair off the British unless God wills it?'

‘Then why do you work? Food will appear on its own, if God wills. And why do you rush to the vaidya when you fall sick? God only helps those who help themselves.’

‘Indeed, he does, but setting fire to your own house and its things is something God cannot approve of.’

‘So should people just sit quietly, doing nothing?’

‘No, they must wail. Wail like a child does for milk.’

Suddenly the pile of foreign goods was set on fire and the flames rose to the sky as though the goddess of freedom clad in fire was rising to embrace the gods in the skies.

Dinanath shut the window; the scene was unbearable for him.

Godavari stood like a cow at the butcher’s. Somebody outside began to sing:

> Watch for the country’s fate to change.

Godavari’s woeful heart felt a blow. She opened the window to look out. The holika was still burning and a blind lad sang as he played on his *khanjri:*

> Watch for the country’s fate to change.

‘Aye, wait there, boy!’ cried Godavari as he reached the window.

The boy stopped. Godavari opened the trunk, but it contained only one paisa. There were also some rupees and notes, but giving those to the blind beggar was out of question. She would surely have given three or four paise had there been any. But there was only that paisa, the one worn to such an extent that the Kahar had brought it back from the market because no shopkeeper had agreed to accept it. Godavari felt embarrassed to give that paisa to the beggar. She stood holding it hesitantly for a while, then called out to the beggar and gave it to him.

The beggar pleaded, ‘Mataji, please give me something to eat. I haven’t had anything to eat all day.’

Godavari said, ‘You beg all day and still don’t get anything to eat?’

Beggar: ‘What can I do, lady? Nobody gives me anything to eat.’

Godavari: ‘Buy something with this money and eat.’

Beggar: ‘I will, Mataji. May God keep you happy always. I shall go to sleep now.’

2

The Congress was organizing an open conference the next morning. Mr Seth brushed his teeth with a foreign toothpowder and a foreign toothbrush, showered with foreign soap, had foreign tea in a foreign teacup with foreign butter on foreign biscuits and drank foreign milk. Then he donned a foreign suit and headed to the flower show on his motorcycle with a foreign cigar in his mouth.

Godavari had not slept the entire night. Her heart was weighed down with dejection and despair. She felt as if a bitter pill was stuck in her throat. She tried in vain all the options that a woman could to bring Mr Seth under her influence. But all her coquetry, gentle smiles and silken voice had no impact on him. Let alone agreeing to wear swadeshi fabric, he did not even agree to get a khadi sari for her even when she promised never to ask for anything else.

Fury and guilt distorted her goodwill in the way that grime pollutes clear water. *Why should I do as he wants me to when he does not fulfil my smallest wish?* she thought. *Why should I be a slave to his commands? I have not sold my soul to him. Am I to be punished if he steals or commits fraud today? He should be the one blamed and punished for it. He is responsible for his words and actions and I for mine. Let him serve his government and let him rub his nose on the British rung. Why should I follow suit? It is not my fault if I don’t have devotion for a person who has no self-respect and has sold himself to greed. Is he an employee or a slave? There is a difference between a job and slavery. An employee meets the terms of his designated work as per certain regulations. The regulations apply to both the employee and the employer. If the employer uses foul*

language or insults the employee, then he is not constrained to bear with it. The slave has no such privilege, as his corporal bondage follows from his psychological bondage. When did the government ask him not to buy swadeshi products? All government tickets have 'Buy national goods' written on them, which means that the government does not prohibit the use of swadeshi goods. This mister, however, walks two steps ahead of the government in order to please it!

Mr Seth asked her hesitantly, 'Will you come to see the flower show tomorrow?'

'No,' replied Godavari with disinterest.

'It's a nice show.'

'I am going to the Congress conference.'

Mr Seth would not have been as flabbergasted had the roof fallen on his head or had he held a live wire. 'You will go to a conference of the Congress?' he asked her with eyes wide open.

'Yes, I will surely go.'

'I don't want you to go there.'

'It is not my duty to obey you if you don't care for me.'

Mr Seth's eyes blazed with rage. 'The consequences will be terrible.'

Godavari replied valiantly, 'I don't care, you are not my lord.'

Mr Seth got furious and muttered threats, then finally lay in bed with his back to her. He did not talk to Godavari before going to the flower show the next morning.

3

Thousands of men and women had gathered by the time Godavari reached the Congress conference. A minister had appealed for funds and some people were contributing to it. Godavari stood among other women to observe what people offered. Most people were only giving three or four annas. Who, after all, was so rich there? She shuffled her pockets and found a rupee. She thought that it would be sufficient. She stood waiting for the collection satchel to come to her so that she could contribute. Suddenly, the

blind beggar to whom she had given a paisa appeared from somewhere and put something into the satchel as soon as it was near him. All eyes turned to him in curiosity of what he could have given. He must have collected a paisa or two begging all day, which could not even fetch him a piece of bread. Rupees would be showered upon him had he been singing to an audience in concerts, but who would care about a blind beggar singing on the road!

The beggar walked away, dropping his paisa into the satchel, and began to sing at a distance:

> Watch for the country's fate to change.

The chairperson waxed, 'Look, friends, this is the paisa that the blind boy has contributed. In my eyes, this single paisa is worth more than a thousand rupees from a rich man. This is probably all that the poor man had. I do not have any doubts in the triumph of truth when we have the sympathies of such poor people with us. Why do we get to see so many beggars around us? It could be because nobody gives them work in society and it might be because of their loss of working ability due to poverty-bred diseases; or probably because beggary has left no strength in them. What else can lead to the salvation of these destitute if not Swaraj? Listen to him sing "Watch for the country's fate to change".' So much of sacrifice in a destitute! Can one still doubt who this voice belongs to? (He spoke raising the paisa in the air.) Which one of you can buy this gem?'

Curiosity filled Godavari's heart: 'Was it the same paisa that I gave him last night? Did he really not have anything to eat that night?'

She went closer to observe the paisa which had been placed on a table. Her heart skipped a beat. It was the same worn paisa.

Godavari was moved by the thought of the blind boy's condition and his sacrifice.

She spoke in a quivering tone, 'Give this paisa to me; I'll give you five rupees.'

‘A sister here wants to purchase the paisa for five rupees,’ the chairperson declared.

‘Ten rupees,’ another voice shot.

‘Twenty rupees,’ came a third voice.

Godavari looked at the last person to speak; his face was overflowing with pride as though silently challenging the presence of a competitor in the conference. Rivalry filled Godavari’s heart. *Come what may, he should not get the paisa. He thinks he can buy the whole world with twenty rupees.*

‘Forty rupees,’ Godavari announced.

The man immediately said, ‘Fifty rupees.’

A thousand eyes turned towards Godavari as if urging her to keep their honour.

Godavari looked at the man and said in a threatening tone, ‘A hundred rupees.’

‘A hundred and twenty rupees,’ the rich man countered.

People’s faces turned pale; they knew he would win.

Disappointed eyes turned towards Godavari, but as soon as she pronounced ‘A hundred and fifty rupees’, thunderous applause followed. It appeared as though an audience were celebrating the victory of their wrestler in a bout.

‘A hundred and seventy-five,’ the man said.

Godavari’s reply, ‘Two hundred’, was followed by another round of applause. The competitor thought it suitable to leave the competition.

Godavari looked humbled by her victory as people showered good wishes upon her.

4

When people came to know that she was Mr Seth’s wife, they had mixed feelings of both delight and pity. Mr Seth was at the flower show when a police officer relayed this fatal conversation to him. Mr Seth was dumbfounded to the extent that his entire body felt numb. He clenched his

fists, gritted his teeth, bit his lip and immediately left for home. His motorcycle had never raced that fast.

'Do you want to get my face blackened?' he asked with fiery eyes as soon as he entered home.

Godavari replied calmly, 'Will you speak clearly or just shoot abuse? Will my face not be blackened if yours is? Who will I turn to for support if you are uprooted?'

'The city is caught in a storm. Why did you give away my money?' Mr Seth asked.

Godavari kept calm and replied, 'Because I consider it to be my money as well.'

Mr Seth spoke through clenched teeth, 'Not at all, you have no right to spend my money.'

'I absolutely have as much right to spend your money as you do. However, I will have none once you have the divorce law passed.'

Mr Seth flung his hat on the table with such force that it bounced off the table and fell on the ground. 'I pity your brains. Do you know what the consequences your insolence can lead to? I will be held accountable. What will I answer? The Congress is an open enemy of the government and helping the Congress equates being against the government.'

'But you have not helped the Congress.'

'But you have!'

'Should you be punished for that or I? Would you be thrown into jail if I commit theft?'

'This is one matter and theft is another.'

'Is helping the Congress worse than theft and robbery?'

'Yes, it is worse than theft and robbery for a government employee.'

'I did not know.'

'If you did not know, then you have been under a wrong impression. You ask me this even after you read the newspapers every day. There are dozens of policemen in civil uniform to report every Congress activist speaking at a platform. Numerous informers are assigned to keep a close eye on every Congress member. Thieves are never treated with such gravity, which is

why so many robberies and murders are committed and nobody ever comes to know about them, nor do the police bother about them. But the efficiency of the police is worth seeing when they sniff political agenda in a case. Everyone from the inspector general to the constables put in all their efforts then. Thieves don't bother the government. The Congress challenges the government's authority, so the government does all it can to curb them. It is a natural thing to do.'

When Mr Seth left for office that day, his feet were heavy with foreboding. Unlike other days, he did not shout at the guards or reprimand the clerks. He quietly went straight to his seat. He felt a sword hanging over his head. His heart was in his mouth at the sound of the Sahib's car. Usually, he sat in his place when the Sahib arrived and went to him with files half an hour later. That day, he stood in the veranda and bowed low in salaam when the Sahib entered. But the Sahib turned his face away.

He did not lose courage though, and rushed forward to draw the curtain for the Sahib as he stepped into the room. Mr Seth turned on the fan but was anxious, wondering when the sword would fall on him. He leapt to place the matches and the cigar-box on the table as the Sahib sat in his chair.

It appeared as if the sky had burst all of a sudden when the Sahib bellowed, 'You are a traitor!'

Mr Seth looked at the Sahib as though he did not understand a word of what had been said.

The Sahib thundered again, 'You *are* a traitor!'

Mr Seth felt his blood boil. 'I believe that there cannot be a greater loyalist than me in the country.'

'You are a betrayer of salt!'

Mr Seth's face turned red as he replied, 'You are bad-mouthing for no reason.'

'You are impudent!'

'You are insulting me and I am not accustomed to hearing such language,' Mr Seth spoke with bloodshot eyes.

'Shut up, you bloody . . . ! The government does not pay you five hundred rupees so that you can make your wife fund the Congress. That is

not what the government pays you for!'

Mr Seth found an opportunity to explain himself. 'I request you to trust me that my wife gave away the money without my consent. I was at the flower show at that time and had bought Miss Frank's bouquet for five rupees. I was informed about it upon my return from there.'

'Are you trying to fool me?'

As soon as this idea hit the Sahib's head like an arrow of fire, his temper reached boiling point. How could an Indian have the audacity to fool him? Somebody trying to fool him—the ruler of India, who was salaamed by mighty landlords, whose servants received large presents from aristocrats? This was intolerable to him. He picked up the ruler and hurried forward.

But Mr Seth was a strong man. He was given to flattery but he could not tolerate this insult. He blocked the hand that held the ruler and planted a blow on the Sahib's face with such force that it beat the living daylights out of him. The Sahib was not prepared for this counterattack. He was accustomed to native men being peaceful, timid and patient, especially in front of Sahibs, with whom they were particularly mute. He sat back on his chair and began to wipe the blood running out of his nose. He did not have the courage to meddle with Mr Seth after that, but inside his head he thought of ways to exact revenge.

Mr Seth went back into his office and began to ponder over the situation. He was not the least bit regretful and felt pleased with his courageous act. 'Look at his impertinence to raise the ruler on me. The more I bowed, the more he pressed on me. The *mem* goes around with her lovers and he does not dare open his mouth, yet here he roars at me. He'll be running to the commissioner now and won't settle without having me dismissed. This is all happening because of Godavari. Our dignity is already lost; now we shall have to scrounge for our meals. Nobody is going to ask me anything and they will straight away send my suspension letter. Where can an appeal be made? The secretary is Indian, but more English than the English themselves. The Home member is Indian, but is a slave of the English; hearing about Godavari's donation will throw him into a fit. There is no hope of justice from anyone; moving out of here is the best option.

He immediately wrote a resignation letter and sent it to the Sahib, who wrote ‘Suspended’ on it.

5

‘How are you back so soon today?’ Godavari asked when Mr Seth returned home with a dull face that afternoon.

‘That which you had been working for has happened. Now cry and hold your head in your hands,’ Mr Seth replied with flaming eyes.

‘What has happened? Explain to me.’

‘This happened: He tried to throttle me; I slapped him and came back after handing in my resignation.’

‘What was the hurry to resign?’

‘Should I have waited for him to pull out my hair? If you continue to behave this way, then we’ll have to separate our ways soon.’

‘Anyway, what has happened was for a good reason. You too can join the Congress now.’

‘You rub salt over wounds without shame,’ Mr Seth said, biting his lip.

‘Why should I have shame? I am happy that you have been freed of your shackles.’

‘Think of how we shall make both ends meet.’

‘I have thought of everything. I will run things and show you. You’ll have to do as I say, though. I have been obeying you all this while; it is your turn to do so now. I never complained about anything, ate and dressed as you wanted me to. I would have stayed wherever you would have asked me to—be it in a palace or in a cottage. You’ll have to be like that now. You’ll have to do as I ask and watch how I make ends meet. Superiority is not in fine clothes and extravagance. He with a pure soul is lofty. You were my husband all this while; I am your husband from now on.’

Mr Seth looked at her lovingly and laughed.

Translated from the Hindi by Wafia Kissa



The Closed Door

Bringing up a child involves the same affection, glow, intoxication and brightness of the sun emerging from the horizon.

I was sitting in the veranda. The child peeped through the door. I called him with a smile. He came and sat on my lap.

His naughtiness began. Sometimes he would reach out for the pen, sometimes for the paper. I took him off my lap. He just stood there, holding on to one of the legs of the table. He didn't go inside the house. The door was open.

A bird hopped in and settled in the inner courtyard before us. It was a new object of amusement for the child. He rushed towards it. The bird wasn't scared in the least. The child thought that a feathered toy was at hand. He sat down and beckoned the bird with both hands. The bird flew away and the child began crying, disappointed. He didn't even look at the inner door. The door was open.

The fragrance of warm halva beckoned the child. His face lit up with desire. A hawker passed before him on the street. The little one looked at me with pleading eyes. As the hawker moved away, the pleading eyes turned indignant proportionately; when the hawker vanished round the corner of the street, his anger adopted the form of a complaint. But I don't allow children to eat anything from the market. The child's complaint had no effect on me. Taking the future into consideration, I became more

adamant. I can't say for sure whether the child felt the need of an appeal in the mother's court of law. Usually, infants make an appeal to their mothers in such situations. Perhaps he had postponed it for a while. He didn't proceed towards the door. The door was open.

I put my fountain pen in his hand with the intention of quietening him. The child felt as though he had received all the wealth in the world. This new problem engaged all his senses. Suddenly, the door slammed by itself; it was the wind. The sound of the door slamming reached the child's ears. He looked at the door. His preoccupation vanished immediately. He flung down the fountain pen and walked towards the shut door, crying, because it had been closed.

Translated from the Hindi by Shailendra Kumar Singh



Salvation

1

Dukhi, the cobbler, was sweeping the doorway. His wife, Jhuriya, was plastering the walls of the house with cow dung. Both had just finished their work when Jhuriya said, ‘Go now and request Pandit Baba before he leaves.’

Dukhi said, ‘Yes, I’m going. Where will we make him sit?’

‘We’ll find a string cot from somewhere, right? Get it from the *thakurain*.’

‘Sometimes you can be very annoying! The Thakur’s family will give us a string cot, indeed! They never give us even fire to light with, and you’re talking of a string cot. If you go to the bathroom and ask for a mug of water, they won’t give it. No one will give us a cot. They aren’t like our cow-dung cakes, wood or chaff, that whoever wants them can take them. Let’s wash our own small cot and use it. It’s the summer season; by the time Baba arrives, it’ll dry.’

‘He won’t sit on our small cot. Haven’t you seen how he lives—such restrictions!’

Dukhi said somewhat anxiously, ‘Yes, that’s right. I’ll make a plate with mahua leaves. That’ll be all right. Even big people eat from leaf plates. They’re pure. Give me the pole, I’ll pluck some leaves.’

‘I’ll make the leaf plate, you go. But we still have to give him some offerings. Shall I place them on my plate?’

‘Don’t even think about it, or our entire effort will be wasted. Baba will throw away the plate. He has a short temper. When he is angry, he doesn’t even spare his wife. Remember, how he beat up his son! The poor boy still goes around with broken arms. Give the offerings on the leaf plate, but you mustn’t touch it. Go to the shop with Jhuri Gond’s daughter to get all the material. See to it that there is a full tray of offerings. Take one *ser* of wheat flour, half ser of rice, 250 grams of dal, 125 grams of ghee, some salt and turmeric, and place four annas on one side of the plate. In case you don’t find the Gond’s daughter, get Bhurjin to go with you. You don’t touch anything, or else it will be disastrous.

After giving instructions, Dukhi picked up his stick and a huge bundle of grass for Panditji and went to meet him. How could he go to him with a request empty-handed? But what more could he afford as a gift except a bundle of grass? Baba would be greatly displeased if he went to him empty-handed.

2

Pandit Ghasiram was a devout soul. Every morning, he began religious rituals as soon as he woke up. By eight o’clock, he’d be done with the ablutions, and embark upon the activities of daily life. He’d first prepare bhang, then make sandalwood paste and, standing before the mirror, he’d draw the tilak—two horizontal lines of the sandal paste with a round, red dot in between. Thereafter, he’d make circles on his chest and arms with the paste, take out the idols, bathe them, smear them with sandal paste, make offerings of flowers, do the *aarti* and ring the bells. By ten o’clock he’d finish his puja, strain the bhang and come out. By that time a couple of his disciples would already be waiting at his door. He’d get an immediate reward for his service to God. This was his means of livelihood.

Today, when he came out of his puja room, he saw the cobbler Dukhi waiting for him with a bundle of grass. The minute he saw him, Dukhi

prostrated before him, and then stood up with folded hands. Seeing Panditji's resplendent face, his heart was filled with respect. What a divine figure! A short, rotund man with a bald head, puffy cheeks and a divine glow in his eyes! The red powder and sandalwood paste endowed him with a godlike aura. Seeing Dukhi, he said, 'How come you're here today, Dukhiya?'

With a bowed head, Dukhi replied, 'I'm getting my daughter engaged, Maharaj. I wanted to know about some auspicious moment. When will it suit you?'

Ghasi said, 'I'm not free today. No, I'll come in the evening.'

'Maharaj, if you could please make it earlier. Everything's ready. Where should I keep the grass?'

'Place it before the cow. Take a broom and sweep the doorway. This sitting room also has not been plastered with cow dung for some time. Do that too. Meanwhile, I'll have my meal. Then I'll take some rest and go with you. And yes, chop this piece of wood. Then there are four bundles of dried grass lying in the barn. Get them and keep them in the storehouse.

Dukhi immediately set to work. He swept the doorway and plastered the sitting room with cow dung. By then it was noon. Panditji went to have his meal. Dukhi had not eaten anything since morning. He felt the stab of hunger, but he didn't have anything to eat and his house was a mile away. If he went home to eat, then Panditji would get angry. Poor fellow! He suppressed his hunger and started chopping the wood. It was a hard trunk with a huge knot in the middle, on which many more like him had already tried their hand. But the trunk was still intact and could withstand many more such attempts. Dukhi was used to cutting grass and taking it to the market. He had no experience of chopping wood. He could cut the grass easily, but here, even though he hit the block with all his might, it made no dent on the wood. The axe bounced. Drenched in sweat and overcome by exhaustion, he sat for a while, panting, and then got up to strike again. His hands felt weak, his feet started trembling, he was unable to stand straight and he felt darkness descend before his eyes. He was dizzy, but he continued working. If only he could get a chillum and some tobacco, he

could muster some energy. But where could he get chillum and tobacco from? Only Brahmins lived in that area. *Brahmins do not smoke tobacco like we lowly people do*. Suddenly, he remembered that a Gond too lived in that village. He was sure to have tobacco and chillum. He immediately ran to his house. Well, his hard work paid off. The Gond gave him tobacco and chillum, but there was no fire. Dukhi said, 'Don't worry, brother. I'll ask Panditji for some. They're still cooking.'

So saying, he left with the tobacco and chillum. Standing before Panditji's doorway, he said aloud, 'Master, could I get some fire to light a chillum?'

Panditji was having his lunch. His wife asked, 'Who's this man asking for fire?'

'Oh, it's that fool Dukhiya, the cobbler. I told him to chop the wood. We do have fire, give it to him.'

His wife raised her eyebrows and said, 'You're so lost in books all the time that you've no sense of religion. Anyone can come to our house, be it a cobbler, a washerman or any other low-born man. It's more like an inn than a Hindu household. Tell him to go to the barber, or I'll scorch his face with the burning wood. How dare he ask for fire?'

Panditji tried to explain to her, 'If he has come inside the house, how does it matter? He has not touched anything. The earth is pure. Give him fire; after all, he's doing our work. If a woodcutter had been hired for the job, he'd have charged at least four annas for the same work.'

His wife roared, 'But why did he come inside the house?'

Panditji said in a resigned tone, 'It's his misfortune, what else!'

'All right, I'll give him fire, but if he dares to come inside the house again, I'll scorch his face.'

Dukhi heard this conversation. He now regretted visiting the pandit. *She's right—how could a cobbler come into a pandit's house? These people are very pure, that's why the world respects them. They aren't mere untouchables like us. I've grown up in this village, yet I didn't understand this!*

When Panditji's wife came out with the fire, he felt as though he had received a blessing from heaven. He folded his hands, touched his head to the ground and said, 'Mother, I've made a big mistake by entering the house. But it is a cobbler's sense! Had we not been so stupid, we wouldn't have been kicked around.'

Panditji's wife was holding the burning wood with tongs. Her face was covered in a veil. She threw the live fire towards Dukhi. A big spark fell on Dukhi's head. He quickly stepped back and started shaking his head. He said to himself: 'This is the punishment for polluting a holy Brahmin's sacred house.' How promptly God has punished him! This is why the world is so scared of pandits. People steal money, but never a Brahmin's. If they do, they'll be ruined; their body parts will begin to rot.

He came out, had his chillum and set to work. The sound of the axe hitting the trunk could be heard.

When the spark fell on Dukhi, the pandit's wife felt pity for him. When Panditji finished his meal, she asked, 'Should I give this cobbler something to eat? The poor fellow has been working for a long time. He must be hungry.'

Panditji gave the proposal some thought and asked, 'Is there any roti left?'

'Two or three must be left.'

'What use are two or three? He's a cobbler, he'll gobble up a lot of them, you'll need at least one ser of flour for that much.'

His wife covered her ears and said, 'Oh God! A ser of flour! Forget it!'

Panditji now said bravely, 'If there's some bran in the house, then mix it with flour and make two thick rotis for him. That'll fill his belly. Fine bread doesn't quench the hunger of these low-born people. They need coarse bread.'

His wife said, 'Leave it! Who's going to take all that trouble in this heat?'

Smoking had sent some energy into Dukhi's hands. For another half an hour, he continued to work the axe. After that, he sat down holding his head, completely exhausted.

Just then the Gond who had given him tobacco came there. He said, 'Why're you bent on killing yourself, old man? You won't be able to chop this knot. You're trying in vain.'

Dukhi wiped the sweat off his forehead said, 'I still have to carry a cart full of dried grass, brother.'

'Did you get something to eat? Or they know only how to get someone to work? Why don't you go and ask them?'

'What're you talking, Chikhuri? Can we digest a Brahmin's food?'

'You'll digest it all right. First, you should get some! He had his lunch, went off to sleep and ordered you to chop the wood. Even a landlord gives something to eat. Even a ruler gives some minimum wages when you're forced to work. He's worse than them all and yet pretends to be a holy man!'

'Softly, brother. If they hear, it'll be disastrous.'

Saying this, Dukhi took hold of the axe and began to strike the trunk once again. Chikhuri pitied him. He snatched the axe from Dukhi's hands and for around half an hour worked the axe with all his strength. But there wasn't even a single crack on the knot. Then he threw away the axe and left, saying, 'You won't be able to cut this, even if you give your life.'

Dukhi wondered why the knot was not giving way. *There isn't even a crack. How long can I go on hitting it without making any dent? There's a lot of work to be done at home, something or the other always crops up that requires one's presence. But what do they care? Well, let me go and carry the chaff. I'll tell him—Baba, I couldn't cut the wood today; I'll come tomorrow and finish the job.*

He picked up a basket and began to carry the chaff. The field was at least two furlongs away from there. Had he filled the basket to the brim, the work would have got over quickly. But who would've lifted it then? So, he carried the heap in small quantities. By the time he finished, it was already four o'clock. Panditji woke up. He washed his face and hands, shoved a

paan into his mouth and came out. He saw Dukhi sleeping with the basket of chaff on his head. Raising his voice, he said, 'Hey, Dukhiya, so you're sleeping, eh! The wood is still intact! What have you been doing all this while? You spent the entire day to carry a fistful of chaff! On top of it, you're sleeping. Pick up the axe and split the trunk. You can't even chop a little piece of wood! And you expect me to pick an auspicious moment for you? Don't blame me. That is why it is said, the moment a lowly person gets enough to eat he becomes spoilt.'

Dukhi picked up the axe once again. He forgot what he had planned to say. He was starving. He had not eaten anything since morning. He found it difficult to stand up. His heart was sinking, but he reasoned with himself and strove on. *He's a pandit; if he doesn't think of an auspicious moment, then all will be ruined. That's why he is held in such esteem. Everything depends on the auspicious moment. It can make or break anyone's life*. Panditji came and stood near the knot and egged him on. 'Yes, hit it hard, hit it some more, hit harder, oh, hit it with some more power, don't you have any strength in your hands—hit it, why do you just keep standing there, wondering? Look, it's about to split! Hit in the crack!'

Dukhi was not in his senses. Some unknown power was making his hands work. As if all that fatigue, hunger, weakness had vanished. He was surprised at his own strength. Every stroke of the axe was like a thunderbolt. He kept on working in that frenzy for another half an hour. So much so that the piece of wood split and the axe fell from Dukhi's hands. Overpowered by hunger and thirst, his tired body gave way and he collapsed.

Panditji called out, 'Get up and strike it some more. Cut it into small pieces.' But Dukhi did not get up. Panditji did not think it right to trouble him any more. He went inside, bathed and came out wearing the pandit's habit. Dukhi was still lying down. Panditji called out loud, 'Will you just keep lying here, Dukhi? Come, let's go to your house. I hope you've got all the stuff ready?'

Dukhi still did not get up.

Now Panditji began to have some doubts. As he went close, he saw Dukhi's body lying stiff. Panicking, he ran back and told his wife, 'Dukhi seems to have died.'

His wife was shocked and said, 'Wasn't he cutting the wood right now?'

'Yes, he died while cutting the wood. What'll happen now?'

His wife said calmly, 'What will happen? Send word to the cobblers. Ask them to take the body away.'

In a moment, the news spread throughout the village where only one household belonged to the Gonds. The way to the well was where the corpse was lying. People stopped passing that way. Who would go to the well passing an untouchable's body? An old woman told Panditji, 'Why don't you get the corpse disposed of? How can the people of the village draw water from the well? Meanwhile, the Gonds went to the cobblers' enclosure and told them, 'Beware! Don't go pick up the corpse! The police will investigate first. Is it a joke to take a poor man's life? Even though he's a pandit, it doesn't mean he can do anything and get away with it.'

When the Panditji arrived there, the cobblers were adamant that they would not pick up the corpse. Yes, both Dukhi's wife and daughter came mourning to Panditji's house and began howling. There were also about a dozen low-caste women with them; some cried, some consoled. But there was no low-caste man. Panditji threatened them, coaxed them but they were scared of the police. No one budged. Ultimately, he went back inside the house, disappointed.

4

The crying and howling continued till midnight. It was difficult for even the gods to sleep. But no one came to pick the corpse up and how could a high-caste holy man pick up an untouchable's dead body? That's not written in any religious text. Has anyone seen such a thing happen?

The pandit's wife was annoyed. 'These witches are giving me a headache. Aren't they tired of howling?'

Panditji said, ‘Let them cry as much as they want. When he was alive, no one had cared for him. Now that he’s dead, everyone has come to create a ruckus.’

‘But it’s inauspicious.’

‘Yes, highly inauspicious!’

‘The stench has begun to spread already.’

‘Wasn’t he a cobbler! They eat everything, without discrimination.’

‘Don’t they feel any repulsion?’

‘They’re rotten—one and all.’

Somehow the night passed. In the morning too, no cobbler came. The women had left after their lamentation. The stench began to spread now.

Panditji took out a piece of rope. He made a noose with it and slipped it around the corpse’s leg. Dawn was breaking. He caught the other end of the rope and started pulling the corpse, and took it outside the village. He returned immediately, took a bath, read the scriptures and sprinkled the holy water of the Ganga in his house.

Meanwhile, jackals and vultures, crows and dogs had pounced on Dukhi’s body. This was the reward for a lifetime of devotion, service and allegiance.

Translated from the Hindi by M. Asaduddin



Trident

1

The night was dark and it was pouring. The rain beat down on the windows. The blobs of rain could be seen against the light in the room. They appeared like long, sharp arrows falling on the ground. Right now, perhaps, I wouldn't dare to step outside even if the house were on fire. But there was a time when I would be out in the fields on such dark and terrifying nights, keeping watch with a rifle in my hand. Thirty years have passed since then. In those days, I used to serve in the army. Ah! How pleasurably those days would pass! They were the sweetest and most pleasant memories of my life. Looking at me today, like this—with me writing articles for newspapers in this small, dark room—who would think that this frail man with a bent waist and wretched personal circumstances was once an embodiment of passion, resolve and courage? What friends they were who always bore a smile on their faces! Can one ever erase the memories of the lion-hearted Ram Singh and the mellow-voiced Devidas from one's heart? That beat, rhythm and harmony—all of these are a mere dream for me today. If at all there is any reality, then it is this cramped room and the office of the newspaper agency.

Yes, that night was as dark, frightening and desolate as today. I stood in front of the barracks wearing a raincoat, and kept watch over the magazine.

There was a loaded rifle on my shoulder. A couple of soldiers could be heard singing in the barracks. When the lightning would flash intermittently, the high mountains and the trees before me would become invisible along with the green and luxuriant fields that stretched below. It was like the happiness that can be glimpsed in the big, black pupils of a child.

Slowly, the rain took on a stormy aspect. The darkness deepened, the noise of the thunder became even more terrifying and the flashes of lightning turned brighter. It seemed as though nature would devastate the earth with all its might.

Suddenly I felt as if some shadow-like thing passed before my eyes. At first, it seemed to be a wild animal, but one flash of lightning dispelled the thought. There was a man going that way; he was getting drenched despite covering his body. I wondered who could come out of the barracks in this torrential downpour. And why? I had no further doubt that he was a man. I held up my rifle and called out in accordance with the military regulation, 'Halt! Who goes there?' But there wasn't any reply. According to the rules, I would have to fire the rifle if I didn't receive an answer after the third challenge. So I took the rifle in my hands and shouted, 'Halt! Who goes there?' There wasn't a reply this time around either, but the shadow-like figure came and stood before me. Now I saw that it was a woman and not a man. Before I could ask any questions, she said, 'Sentry, for God's sake, keep quiet! I'm Louisa.'

My astonishment knew no bounds. I recognized her now. She was indeed Louisa, the daughter of our commanding officer. But where was she going, through this heavy downpour on this pitch-dark night? There were a thousand soldiers present in the barracks who could have carried out her orders. Then why did that delicate one step outside at this moment and where was she headed? I asked in a commanding tone, 'Where are you going at this hour of the night?'

Louisa replied in a pleading tone, 'Pardon me, Sentry, but I can't tell you that, and I beseech you not to speak to anyone about it. I shall always remain indebted to you for this.'

Saying this, her voice trembled like a pot filled with water.

I said in the same soldierly manner, ‘How can that be? I’m a humble soldier of the army. I have no such authority. I’m bound by the rules to take you to my sergeant and present you before him.’

‘But don’t you know that I’m the daughter of your commanding officer?’

I answered with a smile, ‘Right now, if I were to see even Commanding Officer Sahib in this condition, I’d have to treat him with the same severity. The rule is applicable to everyone and a soldier has no power to violate it.’

Hearing this cruel reply, she asked tenderly, ‘So what’s the plan?’

I felt pity for her but was bound by the shackles of the law. I wasn’t even afraid of the consequences. The thought of a court martial or a demotion or any other punishment did not occur to me. My conscience was clear. But how could I violate the regulation? I was standing there perplexed, when Louisa took a step forward, held my hand and said in an extremely pained and restless tone, ‘Then what should I do?’

It seemed as though her heart was melting with every passing instant. I could feel that her hands were trembling. For a moment I felt that I should let her go. What power could there be other than a lover’s message or the obligation to keep a promise that had compelled her to step out of the house in such a situation? Besides, why should I be an impediment in someone’s love affair? But the regulation again prevented me from speaking. I didn’t try to pull my hand away, turned my face to the other side and said, ‘There is no other expedient.’

Hearing my reply, her grip slackened as if there was no life in her body. But she didn’t withdraw her hand. Rather, she kept holding mine and said entreatingly, ‘Sentry, for God’s sake, have pity on me. Don’t let my reputation be sullied. I’m very unfortunate.’

Several warm teardrops fell on my hand. The heavy downpour hadn’t had the slightest effect on me but these few drops shook me from head to toe.

I was in quite a fix. On the one hand was the iron wall of regulation and duty, while on the other was the courteous insistence of a delicate maiden. I knew that if I entrusted her to the sergeant’s custody, then by morning this news would spread in the entire battalion. There would be a court martial.

The iron law of the Armed Forces wouldn't show any leniency even towards the daughter of the commanding officer. Its unsparing hands would strike her with the same mercilessness, particularly at a time when the war was on.

And if I let her go, the law would treat me with the same ruthlessness. My life would be reduced to dust. Who knew whether I'd stay alive or not tomorrow? There would be a demotion at least. Wouldn't my conscience reproach me forever even if the secret were to remain hidden? Would I ever be able to stand so boldly before anyone again? Wouldn't there always be a thief-like feeling residing in my heart?

Louisa said, 'Sentry!'

Not even a word of request issued forth from her mouth. She had reached that point of despair when a person's persuasiveness is restricted to words alone. I said in a sympathetic voice, 'It's a very difficult matter.'

'Sentry! Save my honour, Sentry. I'm ready to do for you whatever is in my capacity.'

I replied with a sense of self-esteem, 'Miss Louisa, don't tempt me. I'm not greedy. I'm helpless only because for a soldier violating the army law is the biggest offence in this world.'

'Isn't protecting a girl's honour an ethical law? Is the army law greater than the ethical one?' asked Louisa, a bit enraged.

What answer did I have to such a question? I couldn't think of an answer. The army law is impermanent, variable and subject to circumstances. Ethical law is inviolable, eternal and above all circumstances. I was convinced and said, 'Go, Miss Louisa, you are free now. You've left me short of answers. I'll violate the army law to carry out this moral duty. But my only request to you is that don't ever counsel any soldier about moral duty because even that constitutes an offence according to the army law. The most important law for a soldier in this world is the army law. The army doesn't care for any ethical, spiritual or godly law.'

Louisa held my hand again and said thankfully, 'Sentry, may God reward you for this.'

But she immediately feared that perhaps this soldier would reveal this secret on some other occasion. So she said, keeping in mind her greater assurance, ‘My honour is in your hands now.’

I said in a reassuring manner, ‘Rest assured from my side.’

‘Then you’ll never tell it to anyone?’

‘Never.’

‘Never?’

‘Yes, never, while I’m still alive.’

‘Now I’m assured, Sentry. Louisa won’t forget this kindness and favour of yours, even while going into the lap of death. Wherever you’ll be, this sister of yours will keep praying to God for you. Remember me whenever you’re in need. Louisa will be at your service even if she is at the other end of the world. From now on, I consider you as my brother. There are occasions in a soldier’s life when he needs a sister to serve him. God forbid that there should ever be such occasions in your life. But if at all there are, then Louisa will never lag behind in discharging her duty. Could I ask the name of my good-natured brother?’

Lightning flashed once again. I saw that Louisa’s eyes were filled with tears. I said, ‘Louisa, I’m grateful to you from the bottom of my heart for these morale-boosting words. But whatever I’m doing is only out of sympathy and morality. I don’t want any rewards. What will you do with my name?’

Louisa asked, complaining, ‘Is asking a brother’s name against the army law too?’

These words were filled with such truth, affection and kinship that my eyes unexpectedly brimmed with tears.

I said, ‘No, Louisa. I only want that not even a shadow of self-interest should intrude in this brother-like behaviour. My name is Srinath Singh.’

Louisa pressed my hands gently to express her gratitude, and said, ‘Thanks,’ and went away. Because of the darkness, I couldn’t see where she went, and even asking about it would have been inappropriate. I stood there, pondering over this sudden encounter. Wouldn’t a commanding officer’s daughter consider an ordinary soldier, and that too a black one, worse than a

dog? But today that same woman had established a sibling's relationship with me and could not contain her joy.

2

Many years passed by. Several revolutions took place in the world. Czarism in Russia was wiped out and the emperor of Germany took his leave forever from the world stage. The progress that democracy hadn't made in a century, it did within these few years. My life too witnessed many changes. I lost a leg in conflict, and from a soldier, I became a lieutenant.

One day, there was such a night again, full of lightning and thunder. I was sitting in the quarters with Captain Nox and Lieutenant Dr Chandra Singh, and discussing what had happened around a decade ago. Only Louisa's name had remained a secret. Captain Nox took an unusual interest in this discussion. He would repeatedly ask about every detail and tell me again and again to match the sequence of events. When I said at last that it had been just such a dark night, with a similar torrential downpour, Captain Nox rose from his seat and asked quite anxiously, 'Was that woman's name Louisa?'

I replied in surprise, 'How did you know her name?' I hadn't told him anything about it but Nox's eyes brimmed over with tears. Sobbing, he said, 'You'll get to know all about it in a while. But first, tell me, is your name Srinath Singh or Chaudhary?'

I replied, 'My full name is Srinath Singh Chaudhary. People call me only Chaudhary now. But no one knew me by this name then. They would call me Srinath.'

Captain Nox dragged his chair next to mine and said, 'In that case, you've turned out to be my old friend. Until now I was misled due to this change of names, otherwise I remember your name too well. Yes, I remember it so well that perhaps I won't forget it till my dying day because this was her last will.'

Saying this, Nox fell silent, closed his eyes and rested his head on the table. My astonishment grew by the minute. Lieutenant Dr Chandra Singh

too first looked at me and then at Captain Nox's face with interrogative eyes.

Captain Nox raised his head after a couple of minutes of silence, took a deep breath and said, 'Why Lieutenant Chaudhary, do you remember that time when a British soldier once slandered you severely?'

I answered, 'Yes, I remember it too well. He was a corporal. I had lodged a complaint against him and he had been court martialled. He was demoted from the rank of a corporal to that of an ordinary soldier. Yes, I remember his name too. It was something like Krip or Kroop . . .'

Captain Nox interrupted, 'Kirpin. Do you find any similarity between his face and mine? I am that same Kirpin. My name is K. Nox, Kirpin Nox. In those days, people called me Kirpin in the same way that they would call you Srinath.'

I recognized Nox now that I looked closely at him. Indeed he was Kirpin. I stared at him in surprise. But I failed to understand what relationship he could have had with Louisa.

Captain Nox resumed, 'I'll have to narrate the entire story today. Lieutenant Chaudhary, when I was demoted from a corporal to an ordinary soldier because of you and the humiliation remained unabated, the flames of jealousy and vengeance arose in my heart. I was always preoccupied with the thought of insulting you, of taking revenge for my humiliation. I would look at every act and word of yours with fault-finding eyes. In these ten or twelve years, your face has changed quite a bit. My eyesight too has weakened, because of which I couldn't recognize you. But your face always floated before my eyes then. At that time, the strongest desire of my life was to bring about your downfall. Had I got the opportunity, perhaps I wouldn't have refrained from killing you.'

Captain Nox fell silent again. Dr Chandra Singh and I looked at him fixedly.

Nox resumed his story. 'That night when Louisa was talking to you, I was sitting in my room and observing you from a distance. What did I know then that she was Louisa! I only saw that you were holding a woman's hand and talking to her while keeping watch. I can't express the roguish

happiness I felt then. I thought, *Now I'll humiliate him. The fellow has been trapped after many days. Now I won't spare him at any cost*. Having decided thus, I stepped out of my room and, getting wet in the rain, walked towards you. But Louisa had left by the time I came near you. Having no option, I returned to my room. But I wasn't without hope. I knew that you wouldn't lie and that when I'd complain against you to the commanding officer, you'd admit your fault. This assurance was enough to put out the flames of my heart. There was no doubt now about the realization of my desires.'

I smiled and said, 'But you didn't complain about me, did you? What happened? Did you feel pity for me afterwards?'

Nox replied, 'No, Sir, what censurable person ever feels pity? There was some other reason altogether for not lodging a complaint. The first thing I did the next morning was to go directly to the commanding officer. Maybe you remember that I was teaching horseriding to his elder son, Rogers, then. So, I never felt any hesitation or impediment in approaching him. When I reached, Rogers and Louisa were drinking tea. Seeing me so early that day, Rogers said, "Why so early today, Kirpin? It's not yet time for horseriding. You seem quite happy today, don't you?"

'I took a chair and said, "Today is really a blessed day in my life. Today I've got the opportunity to punish my old enemy. I suppose you do know that a Rajput soldier had complained to the commanding officer and got me demoted?"

'Rogers said, "Yes, yes, why wouldn't I know about it? But you had reviled him."

'I replied, somewhat embarrassed, "I didn't revile him. I'd only said 'bloody'. Such slanderous language is a common thing amongst soldiers. But that Rajput complained against me. Today I've caught him committing a serious offence. God willing, he too will be court martialled today. Last night, I saw him talking to a woman. That was exactly when he was on duty. He can't deny it. He's not such a scoundrel."

'The colour of Louisa's face changed. She looked at me with a strange frenzy, and said, "What else did you see?"

‘I replied, “Whatever I’ve seen is more than enough to humiliate that Rajput. He’s certainly having an affair with someone and that lady is not an Indian but a European. I can swear an oath that both of them were holding each other’s hands and talking like lovers do.”

‘Louisa’s face turned pale. Chaudhary, you can imagine how big a scoundrel I am. I want that you should call me a scoundrel and that you should curse me. I’m more monstrous than a wild beast of prey, more poisonous than a black cobra. She stood there and was looking at the wall when some friend of Rogers’s arrived. He left with him. When Louisa was alone with me, she looked at me with entreating eyes and said, “Kirpin, please don’t complain against that Rajput soldier.”

‘I asked in astonishment, “Why?”

‘Louisa bowed her head and said, “Because I’m the one you saw him talking to.”

‘I was even more surprised and said, “So are you two in . . . ?”

‘Louisa interrupted me and said, “Quiet! He’s my brother. The fact of the matter is that last night I was going someplace. I won’t hide it from you, Kirpin. Last night I had promised to meet my beloved whom I hold dearer than my own life. He stood waiting for me on the mountain slopes. How heartbreaking it would’ve been for him had I not gone there. As soon as I came near the magazine, that Rajput soldier checked me. He wanted to take me to the sergeant in accordance with the army regulations. But with my persistent entreaty, he agreed to violate the army regulation to protect my honour. Imagine how big a responsibility he had to shoulder. I’ve called him my brother and even he has accepted me as his sister. Just think what his situation will be if you complain against him. He won’t divulge my name. Of that I’m pretty sure. He won’t disclose my name even if you put a sword to his neck. I don’t want that he be rewarded in such a way for this virtuous deed. Don’t complain against me on any account. That’s my only request to you.”

‘I said harshly and in an unforgiving manner, “He has insulted me by complaining against me. I don’t want to let go of this wonderful

opportunity. If you are quite certain that he won't reveal your name, then let him go to hell."

'Louisa looked contemptuously at me and said, "Shut up, Kirpin. Don't talk to me like that. I'll never take it upon myself that he should become the object of humiliation and disgrace on account of my honour. If you won't agree to my request, then I'm telling you the truth, I'll commit suicide."

'I was only thirsty for revenge then. Now the passionate ghosts of lust swarmed in on me. For days I had been worshipping Louisa in my heart of hearts. But I hadn't been able to muster the courage to tell her about it. Now I had got the opportunity to keep her under my control. I thought that if she could be willing to sacrifice her life for that Rajput soldier, then certainly she wouldn't be displeased by my proposition. I replied in that same cruel and self-interested manner, "I'm extremely regretful but I can't let my prey go."

'Louisa looked at me with gloomy eyes and said, "Is this your final decision?"

'I replied with cruelty and shamelessness, "No, Louisa. This isn't my final decision. You can change it if you want. This is completely within your capacity. Perhaps you did not know until today how much I love you. But in these three years, you haven't been away from my heart even for an instant. If you can soften your heart for my sake, and can truly appreciate my love, then I'm willing to do anything. I'm a mere soldier today and perhaps you are laughing within on hearing this proposal from my lips. But one day, I too will become a captain and perhaps then there won't be such a gulf between us.'

'Louisa cried and said, "Kirpin, you are quite merciless. I never thought you would be so cruel. Why did God make you so stone-hearted? Don't you feel even a bit of pity for a forlorn woman?"

'I felt happy from within at her helplessness and said, "For someone who is herself stone-hearted, what right does she have to complain about the hard-heartedness of others?"

'Louisa replied solemnly, "I'm not merciless, Kirpin. For God's sake, act justly. My heart belongs to someone else. I can't live without him and

perhaps he too won't live without me. Even if I marry you against my will to comply with your proposal, to preserve the honour of that man who acted kindly towards me, what good will it come to? Love can't happen by force. I'll never love you . . ."

'Friends, my heart experiences severe distress as I expose my brazenness. Lust had turned me so blind then that I turned a deaf ear to her entreaties. I said, "Don't think like that, Louisa. Love will definitely produce its effect. You may not like me now, but it won't be long before my love brings about a change. You must be thinking I am a selfish scoundrel; do so by all means. Love is selfish, perhaps base too. But I'm sure that this hatred and displeasure won't last long. I'll have the maximum price that I can get to let my arch-enemy go."

'Louisa stood there for fifteen minutes, in a state of terrible mental distress. Whenever I remember her, I feel like jabbing my neck with a knife. Eventually she looked at me with tearful eyes and said, "Fair enough, Kirpin. If that's your wish, so be it. I promise to give you the price that you ask for. But for God's sake, go away now and let me cry to my heart's content."'

Saying this, Captain Nox burst into tears. I said, 'If you are having trouble narrating this painful story, then let it go.'

Captain Nox cleared his throat and said, 'No, brother, I'll have to complete the story. After that, I kept going to Louisa every day for about a month and tried to erase the thought of "my rival" from her heart. On seeing me, she would immediately come out of her room and talk to me happily. This continued, and I felt that she was in love with me. In the meantime, the European War broke out. Both you and I went to the war. You went to France while I went to Egypt with the commanding officer. Louisa stayed back here with her uncle. Rogers too was with her. I stayed on the front for three years. Letters from Louisa arrived regularly. I was promoted to the rank of a lieutenant and would've certainly become a captain had the commanding officer lived for a few more days. But because of my misfortune, he was killed in a battle. You all are quite familiar with what happened in that war. One month after his death, I took leave and returned

home. Louisa was still staying with her uncle. But alas, she had neither the same beauty nor that liveliness. She had become quite lean. Her condition caused me a lot of grief then. I discovered how true and profound her love was. She hadn't been able to prevail over her feelings despite her promise to marry me. Perhaps her condition was the result of her grieving over her sorrows. One day I said to her, "Louisa, I think that maybe you've not been able to forget your old lover. And if my assumption is correct, I free you from your promise. Go and marry him with pleasure. What will be adequate comfort for me is the fact that good sense has prevailed in me while there's still time. If you bear any grudges towards me, then cast them away."

'Tears fell from Louisa's big eyes. She said, "Kirpin, he's no more. Six months ago he was killed in France. My only regret is that I was the reason for his death. He had nothing to do with the army. He would've never enlisted himself had I not disappointed him. He got himself enlisted only to fulfil his death wish. But now that you've come back, I'll get well soon. Now I'm more capable of becoming your wife. There are no thorns in your side now and there are no regrets in my heart either."

'These words were filled with sarcasm and their implication was that I had been responsible for her lover's death. Who can deny its veracity? If at all atonement had a face, then it was that I should show such consideration and sympathy towards Louisa, and should devote myself to her in such a way that her heart may be relieved of this sorrow.

'A month after this incident we were to get married. After our wedding we returned home. Friends were invited to the banquet. Bottles of wine were passed around. I was unable to contain my joy at my good fortune. And why only me? Even my close friends were congratulating me on my good luck.

'But little did I know that destiny was holding out deceptive promises for me and that this was that path behind which the merciless hunter's trap was laid. Here I was engaged in entertaining and extending courtesy to my friends, while there Louisa was lying in her room, making provisions for her departure from this world. I was thanking a friend who had congratulated me when Rogers came and said, "Kirpin, come, Louisa is

calling you. Quickly. No one can make sense of her condition." The ground slipped beneath my foot. I went running to Louisa's room.'

Tears fell again from Captain Nox's eyes and his voice became heavy. He took a deep breath and said, 'When I went inside, I found Louisa lying on the couch. She was having convulsions. Her face was contorted. She looked at me and said, "Kirpin, come near me. I've fulfilled my promise by marrying you. I couldn't have given you anything more than this because I've already offered my love to someone else. Forgive me. I've consumed poison and am only a temporary guest in this world."

'Darkness fell before my eyes. It seemed as if my heart had been struck by a lancet. I knelt beside her. I said, crying, "Louisa, what have you done? Alas! Will you deceive me and pass away so quickly? Is there no other expedient now?"

'I ran at once to get a doctor. But alas! That goddess of loyalty, that true Louisa, had already deserted me forever by the time I arrived with the doctor. There was only a piece of paper at the head of her bed on which was written, "If you ever happen to see my brother Srinath, tell him that Louisa never forgot his favour even at the time of her death."'

Saying this, Nox took out a small velvet box from the pocket of his waistcoat. He pulled out a scrap of paper from it, showed it to me and said, 'Chaudhary, this is the only token of that short-lived fortune of mine; something that I've preserved more carefully than my own life till this day. Today, I've been acquainted with you. I'd thought that like the rest of my friends, you too must have been killed in the war. But thank God that you're still alive here—present, living and healthy. I entrust this deposit to you. Now shoot me if you feel like doing so, because I'm the killer of that heavenly being.'

Saying this, Captain Nox stretched out and lay on the chair. Both of us shed tears. But we soon remembered our immediate duty. I rose from my chair and went near Nox to console him. But as soon as I held his hand, my body shuddered. It had grown cold—as cold as it gets during one's final moments. I was frightened; I looked at his face and called out to Dr

Chandra. Doctor Sahib came immediately, placed his hands on Nox's chest and said in a pained voice, 'His heart has stopped beating.'

Right then, the thunder struck, *karr . . . karr . . . karr . . .*

Translated from the Hindi by Shailendra Kumar Singh



The Journey of War

1

Today, there had been excitement in the village since morning. The mud huts seemed to be smiling. Today a group of satyagrahis would come to the village. The doorstep of Kodai ‘chaudhuri’ was covered with a canopy. Atta, ghee, vegetables, milk and curd were being gathered. There was joy, courage and happiness on every face. The same Binda the cowherd, who used to hide his face when the governor stopped by on his rounds, had now left two pots each of milk and curd collected from his cowshed. The potter who would flee from his home had left a heap of earthen pots. The barbers and bearers of the village had come running of their own accord. If there was one being who was unhappy, it was Nohri the old woman. Sitting at the entrance of her hut, she was watching this event with regret, with her seventy-five-year-old shrunken eyes. What did she have that she could take to Kodai’s door and say, ‘I have brought this’? She was indebted to others for every grain.

But Nohri had seen better days. There was a time when she had wealth, kin, everything. She ruled the village. She had always oppressed Kodai. She was a man despite being a woman. Her husband would sleep at home; she would go to the fields to guard crops against marauding animals. She would look after legal matters. All the dealings were done by her. But all of that

was taken away by the Almighty; her wealth was lost, so were her kin—she alone was left to mourn their loss. She lost her eyesight, her hearing; she could hardly move. She was barely managing to pass her remaining days. And then there was Kodai, his fortunes rising. Now everyone asked after Kodai, he had clout.

Today, the event was taking place at Kodai's doorstep. Who would ask after Nohri now? This thought crushed her heart as though with a rock. Oh! If God hadn't reduced her to this helpless state, she would have whitewashed her hut today, there would have been drums beating at her doorstep, she would have put big pots on the stove, made puris, and when the villagers were fed, she would have given them fistfuls of coins as offering.

She recalled that day when she had travelled twenty *kos* with her old husband to pay a visit to the Mahatma. That excitement, that pure devotion, today resurfaced in her heart like the dusty clouds in the sky.

Kodai came and spoke with his toothless mouth—'Bhabhi, the Mahatma's supporters are coming today. You have to give an offering too.' Nohri looked at the chaudhuri with sharp eyes. The heartless man has come to mock me. He wants to humiliate me. She rose and replied—'Whatever I have to offer, I shall offer to those people. Why should I show it to you?'

Kodai smiled and said, 'I swear I will not tell anyone, Bhabhi! Take out that old handi! Which day is it waiting for? Nobody has given anything. How will the honour of the village be saved?' Nohri spoke with harsh bitterness—'Don't rub salt on my wounds, Devarji! If God had given me enough, you wouldn't have had to ask for it today. Travellers, mendicants, sadhus, governors and officials, all used to come to my doorstep once, but not every day passes the same way.'

Kodai was embarrassed. The lines on his face twitched. He said, 'You take offence at such trivial matters of jest, Bhabhi! I asked you so that later you wouldn't accuse me of not having told you anything.'

Saying this, he left. Nohri kept sitting there and staring at him. His joke appeared to be sitting there like an asp.

2

Nohri was still sitting when the din arose—The supporters have come! Dust was rising on the western horizon as though the earth were raining down its jewels to welcome those travellers. All the men and women of the village left their chores to welcome them. In a moment the tricolour was fluttering in the wind, as though freedom were sitting on a throne and blessing everyone.

The women began to sing. In a short while the group of travellers became clearly visible. There were rows of two. They wore khaddar kurtas, Gandhi topis on their heads, with bags slung over their shoulders, both hands empty as though wanting to embrace freedom. Their voices could then be heard. From their masculine throats came a patriotic song that emerged from warm, deep and enthusiastic hearts:

> There was a day when we were special in this world
> And today there is none as shameless as us
> There was a day when our honour was precious as life
> And today there is none as shameless as us.

The villagers stepped forward to welcome the travellers. Poor men had their heads covered in dust, their lips were dry and faces tanned, but their eyes were lit up as though with the light of freedom.

The women were singing, the children jumping with joy. And the men were fanning the travellers with their towels. Nobody's attention went towards Nohri in this gathering; she stood behind them holding her cane, the embodiment of benediction. Her eyes were brimming with tears, her face such a sight of pride as if she were a queen, as though this entire village was hers, all these youths her children. In her mind she had never experienced such empowerment, such progress and such exultation.

Suddenly she threw her cane and, tearing through the crowd, went and stood in front of the group, as if she had thrown away her old age and grief along with her cane. For a moment she kept gazing at the soldiers of freedom with her enamoured eyes as though filling herself with their

strength, and then she started dancing. She danced like a youthful beauty, dances steeped in love and joy. People took a few steps back making a small circle, and within that the old woman displayed her ancient skill. In this unearthly joyous celebration she forgot her grief and worries. Her body that was so derelict now suddenly became agile, flexible and energetic! At first people watched her with amusement, like children watch a monkey perform; then everyone was thrilled by this performance of purity and love. They felt as though nature were playing in the lap of a great encompassing dance.

Kodai said, 'Stop it, Bhabhi, stop!'

Nohri said while dancing, 'Why are you standing there, come, let me see how you dance!'

Kodai replied, 'How will I dance in this old age?'

Nohri paused and said, 'Are you old even today? My age has run away. Hasn't your chest puffed up with pride after seeing these bravehearts? It is to take over our grief and pain that they have taken this vow. I have beaten drums for mendicants with these hands, and have heard their slurs with these ears. Now that slavery and oppression will be destroyed—does our old age have to take over us now? The fire of our bellies has burnt us. Swear by your faith and speak, there are so many people here, has anyone eaten their fill even once in the last six months? Has anyone even smelled ghee! Have you slept your fill! The field for which we paid three rupees as tax, we now have to pay nine to ten rupees for the same. Will this earth yield gold? We have broken our backs working so hard. We are the ones who live even through this. If it were anyone else, they would either kill or get killed. Blessed are the Mahatma and his followers that they understand the grief of the poor, and work for their uplift. Everyone else only knows how to oppress us and extract our blood.'

The faces of the travellers shone, their hearts bloomed. Voices drenched in love emerged:

There was a day when this soil was an elixir,
And today there is none as helpless as us.

3

Lamps were burning at Kodai's doorstep. Men from many villages had gathered. After the travellers had their meal, the meeting commenced. The leader of the group stood up and said—'Brothers, the warm hospitality you extended to us has given us the hope that soon our chains will be broken. I have seen many nations of the East and the West, and I speak from experience that the simplicity, honesty, hard work and piety that you possess are not to be found in any other nation of the world. I want to say that you are not humans but gods. You are not concerned about the fruit, or about the gains; you just fulfil your duty and remain content with your situation. This is your ideal, but this very divine nature, your naivety is becoming harmful to your cause. Don't mind, but you don't deserve to live in this world. You should have received a place in heaven. The taxes on the fields are swelling like the drains in heavy rainfall, but you don't make a sound. Officials and clerks keep scavenging but you don't utter a word. The result of this is that people are plundering you with both hands, but you have no clue. All employment is being snatched from your hands, you are being destroyed, but you are not opening your eyes to see. Earlier lakhs of people used to spin cotton, weave cloth to earn their living. Now all cloth comes from abroad. Earlier lakhs of men used to make salt here. Now the salt comes from outside. Here, making salt is a crime. Your country has so much salt that the entire world can use it for 200 years, but you give seven crore rupees just for salt! There is abundant salt on your seashores and lakes, yet you cannot touch it. Maybe in a few days, a toll will be charged on your wells too. Will you continue to bear this injustice?'

A voice came, 'What are we capable of?'

The leader said, 'This is your illusion. Such a vast kingdom is balanced on your shoulders. You are the owners of these huge armies, these great officials; yet you starve and bear injustice. This is because you don't know your strength. Understand that one who cannot protect himself in this world will always fall prey to selfish and unjust people! Today the greatest man in the world is putting his life at stake. Thousands of soldiers are endangering

their lives to end your grief. Those who plunder you thinking you are helpless, why would they want their prey to be snatched from their mouth? They are meting out as much hardship to your soldiers as they can, but we are willing to bear everything. Now think, will you help us? Will you shield yourself from injustice like men, or keep cursing fate like cowards? Such an opportunity might never come again. If you miss the mark now, then you will always regret it. We are fighting for justice and truth; therefore we have to fight with the weapons of truth and justice. We need such brave men who can throw away violence and anger from their hearts and keep unwavering faith in God to bear everything for dharma! Speak, what help can you give us?'

Nobody stepped forward. There was silence.

4

Suddenly there was a commotion—'Police! The police are here!'

The police inspector, accompanied by a group of constables, came and stood before them. People looked at them with scared eyes and beating hearts, and began to look for places to hide.

The inspector ordered, 'Chase away these goons!'

The constables raised their canes but before they could hit anyone, everyone ran away! They ran helter-skelter. There was complete chaos. Within ten minutes, not a single man of the village was left. Yes, the leader was still standing in his place and the group was sitting behind him; only Kodai chaudhuri was sitting close to the leader and staring fixedly at the ground.

The inspector looked at Kodai chaudhuri with severe eyes and said, 'O Kodai! Why did you give shelter to these goons here?'

Kodai looked at the inspector with red eyes and drank his anger like poison. Today, if he did not have the baggage of his family, he would have answered this in the right measure. The household on which he had spent fifty years now appeared to bind his soul like a giant snake.

Kodai had yet to reply when Nohri came from behind and said, ‘Are you tongue-tied after wearing this red turban? Is Kodai your slave that you are calling out to him like that? You take our money and show us your anger? Aren’t you ashamed?’

Nohri was shivering like the afternoon sun. For a moment the inspector was astounded. Then he thought for a moment, deciding that answering a woman was beneath his dignity, and said to Kodai, ‘Who is this wicked woman, Kodai? If I didn’t fear God, I would wrench her tongue out.’

The old woman banged her cane on the ground, turned towards the inspector and said, ‘Why do you take God’s name and insult Him? Your gods are your officials whose feet you lick. You should have drowned in guilt by now! Do you know who these people who have come here are? They are those who are gods; you call them goons!’

Hearing Nohri’s sharp retort, many people who had disappeared returned. The inspector saw the crowd thicken, so he unleashed his whip on them. The people again dispersed. One strike hit Nohri. She felt as if a spark had run across her back. Everything grew dark before her eyes, but she gathered her remaining strength and shouted at the top of her voice, ‘Young men, why do you run? Did you come here for a feast? Is this a circus? It is because of your cowardice that these men have become lions. Till when will you tolerate this violence and name-calling?’

One of the constables held her by the neck and pushed her. The old woman was about to fall on her face a few steps ahead when Kodai grabbed her, steadied her and then said, ‘Why do you target an old woman? Has slavery made you less of a man? Attacking women, old and unarmed people is not a man’s way.’

Nohri spoke, still lying on the ground, ‘If they were men, why would they be slaves! Bhagwan! Can man be so heartless? If the white ruler treats us so heartlessly, it’s one thing. It is his rule. You are his servant, you will not get to rule, but you’re happy with your sycophancy! If somebody goads them, they will not hesitate even to slit throats.’

Now the inspector began scolding the leader. ‘On whose orders did you come to this village?’

The leader replied calmly, ‘On God’s orders.’

‘You disturb the peace of the people.’

‘If telling them their condition is disturbing their peace, then yes, we are doing it.’

The crowd paused again. Kodai looked at them with hopeless eyes and said shakily, ‘Brothers, right now there are people from several villages gathered here. The way the inspector has insulted us, will you be able to sleep in peace after that? Who will listen to our plea? Will the officials listen to it? Never. Even if we were to be killed today, nothing would happen. Is this our honour and position? Cursed is such a life!’

The crowd stood in silence. The smoke of fear that had clouded their hearts suddenly cleared. Their faces hardened. The inspector saw their reaction and instantly mounted his horse and ordered Kodai’s arrest. Two of his men stepped forward and held Kodai by the arms. Kodai said, ‘Why are you worried? I will not run. Let’s go, take me where you want to.’

As soon as Kodai began to go with the policemen, both his young sons, along with several men, lunged towards the policemen to free him. All the men gathered around the policemen in their formidable zeal.

The inspector said, ‘Step back, all of you. Or I will fire.’ The crowd responded to this threat with ‘*Bharat maata ki jai!*’ and closed in a few steps further.

The inspector could see he could not save his life now. He spoke politely, ‘Leader Sahib, these people are bent on riots. The result of this will not be good.’

The leader said, ‘No, as long as even one of our men is here, no one will raise a hand against you. We have no grudge against you. We are all crushed under the same foot. It is our misfortune that we are standing on opposite sides.’

Saying this, the leader explained to the village men, ‘Brothers, I have told you this is a fight for justice and dharma, and we have to fight with the weapons of justice and dharma. We will not fight with our brothers. We don’t have to fight anyone. If there was a white man instead of the inspector, we would guard him in the same way. The inspector has arrested

Kodai chaudhuri. I believe it to be chaudhuri's good fortune. Blessed are those who receive punishment in the struggle for freedom. This is not a matter to get upset or anxious about. Please step aside and let the police go.'

The inspector and his men began to take Kodai away. The crowd raised the cry of '*Bharat maata ki jai!*'

Kodai replied, 'Ram Ram, brothers, Ram Ram. Stand your ground in the battlefield. Don't worry. God is everybody's master.'

Both the young men returned with moist eyes and said in a hesitant tone, 'What are you saying to us, Dada?'

Kodai encouraged them, 'Don't abandon your faith in God, and do what men should do. Fear is the root of all evil. Remove it from your mind, then nobody can harm you. Truth never fails.'

The fearlessness Kodai experienced today amidst the policemen was something he had never felt before. Jail and the noose were no longer objects of fear but of pride for him. He saw the manifest form of truth today for the first time, as though it were guarding him like a shield.

5

The capture of Kodai appeared to be a matter of shame for the village. Their chaudhuri was taken away before their very eyes, and they could do nothing about it. How would they show their faces now? There was a sense of deep anguish, as though the village had been robbed.

Suddenly Nohri shouted, 'Why are all of you standing here in regret? Haven't you seen your wretched state, or is there still something left to be seen? You have seen today that we are being ruled by the lathi and not by law, haven't you? Today we are so shameless that even after such abjection we don't say anything. If we weren't so selfish, so cowardly, they wouldn't dare rain lashes on us. As long as you remain slaves, you keep serving them, they will keep feeding you. But the day you change your ways, they will begin beating you. For how long will you keep tolerating their beating? Till when will you lie like corpses and let those vultures claw at you? Show them that you too are alive and that you too care about your honour and

pride. When there is no honour left, what will you do with working the fields, saving your dharma? What will you live for? Will you live so that your children are also kicked around and trampled upon like this? Get rid of this cowardice! You will die on a string cot one day. Why not step into this battle of dharma and die like a braveheart! I am an old woman, I will not be able to do anything but at least I will sweep the place where these people will sleep, and fan them.'

Kodai's older son, Maiku, said, 'If you go while we are still alive, Kaki, then cursed is our life! We, your sons, are still alive. I will go there; the fields will be looked after by Ganga.'

Ganga was his younger brother. He said, 'Bhaiya! You are being unfair. You will not go while I am alive. When you're here, you will run the house. I won't be able to do anything. Let me go.'

Maiku said, 'Leave this to kaki. This way you and I will keep fighting. Let kaki decide; whoever she chooses will go.'

Nohri smiled with pride and said, 'Whoever bribes me will win.'

'Will that bribe work in your court too, Kaki? We thought the decision would be fair here!'

'Let it be. When I, a dying woman, have got this chance, I should earn something!'

Ganga said laughing, 'I will bribe you, Kaki! The next time I go to the bazaar, I will bring you eastern tobacco.'

Nohri said, 'Then victory is yours! You will go.'

Maiku complained, 'Kaki, you are not doing justice.'

'Two sides have never liked the court's decision, then why would you?'

Ganga touched Nohri's feet, embraced his brother and said, 'Tell Dada tomorrow that I am going.'

One man said, 'Write my name too, brother—Sevaram.'

Everyone cheered. Sevaram came and stood next to the leader.

A second voice came, 'Write my name—Bhajan Singh.'

Everyone cheered. Bhajan Singh went and stood next to the leader.

Bhajan Singh was famous in several villages for his wrestling skills. When he went to the leader's side with his broad chest puffed and his head

held high, it was as though new life had been infused into the pavilion.

Soon a third voice came, ‘Write my name—Ghoore.’

This was the village watchman. People raised their heads to see him. Nobody could believe Ghoore would sign up for this.

Bhajan Singh laughed and said, ‘What has happened to you, Ghoore?’

Ghoore said, ‘What happened to you, has happened to me too. After twenty years of slavery, I’ve grown tired.’

Then a voice came, ‘Write my name—Kale Khan.’

He was the zamindar’s bearer, tyrannical and fearless. People were again surprised.

Maiku said, ‘It seems you have filled your house with the loot.’

Kale Khan spoke in a serious voice, ‘If a man has gone astray, will you not let him take the straight path? Till now I obeyed the one whose salt I ate. I looted you and filled his house. I now realize that I was in grave error. I have harassed you a lot, brothers. Please forgive me now.’

All five embraced each other, leapt in the air and cried as though they had already attained Swaraj—and in reality, they had attained Swaraj. Swaraj is a mental state. As soon as the terror of slavery is removed from the heart, you achieve Swaraj. Fear is slavery, fearlessness is Swaraj. Administration and organization are secondary.

The leader addressed them: ‘Friends! Today you have joined the soldiers of freedom, I congratulate you on that. Do you know how we are going to fight? You will face different kinds of hardships, but remember, just as you have sacrificed desire and greed today, you must sacrifice violence and anger too. We are entering a battle of dharma. We will have to stay on the path of dharma. Are you prepared for it?’

All five said in unison, ‘We are prepared!’

The leader blessed them, ‘May God help you.’

6

It seemed as though enthusiasm pervaded that beautiful golden morning. There was zeal in the gentle breeze, in the soft rays of light. People were

raving in excitement. It seemed as though the goddess of freedom was calling upon them. The fields were the same, the gardens were the same, the men and women were the same but the blessing, the boon, the majesty in this morning was absent before today. Those same fields, gardens and men and women are today coloured in a new majesty.

Thousands of men had gathered before dawn. When the group of satyagrahis emerged, the intoxicated cries of the crowd echoed in the skies. The new soldiers were setting off, their winsome forbearance and courage, their parents' intense pride, the sight of the soldiers' retreat intoxicated the gathering.

Suddenly Nohri came and stood there, leaning on her cane.

Maiku said, 'Kaki, please bless us.'

Nohri replied, 'I am coming with you, *beta*, how many blessings can I give?'

Several men said in one voice, 'Kaki, if you go, who will stay here?'

Nohri spoke in a voice filled with good wishes, 'Bhaiya, it is almost time I went; if I don't go today, then I will in a few months. If I go now, my life's purpose will be fulfilled. If I went in a few months, lying on this string cot, my aspirations would remain in my heart. There are so many men; if I serve them I will feel exalted. May God show you happy days and I see your happiness in my lifetime.'

Saying this, Nohri blessed everyone and went to stand next to the leader.

People were standing and watching as the group left, singing—

> There was a day when we were special in the world
> And this is the day when there is none as shameless as us.

Nohri's feet wouldn't touch the ground, as though she were sitting on a plane on her way to heaven.

Translated from the Hindi by Ayesha Abrar



The Wine Shop

1

The question was raised at the Congress Committee: Who will go and stage a dharna at wine and toddy shops? The fifty members of the committee sat there with their heads held low. None of them dared speak a word. The issue was very delicate. It was not a problem if one got arrested by the police. Policemen know their duty well. One can come across good as well as bad fellows in every walk of life, but the police officers, with the exception of a few, are not so bereft of a sense of decorum and discipline that they will misbehave with guys who are ready to give their lives for the community and the country. But drunkards are highly unpredictable and irresponsible people. The majority of them will not be cowed unless threatened or admonished. Only a good beating will restore them to their senses, but peace-loving people will not take recourse to this option. Then who is to take the initiative? Who will stand the volley of abuses from the drunkards? The possibility of a scuffle too cannot be ruled out. No one can undergo the humiliation of being beaten up by a drunkard. The police will not sit inactive; they will add fuel to fire. With the backing of the policemen, these drunkards can go to any extent. For the peace lovers it cannot be tit for tat, and the community of drunkards is hard of hearing when it comes to pleadings and requests.

One of the members said, ‘In my opinion, the panchayat should come to power again in these communities. It is because of negligence that it has become dysfunctional. This is the only possible solution.’

The president said, ‘This may be one of the solutions. I will make a note of it. But staging a dharna is a must.’

Another gentleman came up with his suggestion, ‘What about visiting their houses in person and talking to them? That could be more effective.’

Caressing his bald head, the president said, ‘You made a good point. But we cannot quit the dharna.’

There was complete silence.

A woman in the last row was sitting silent. Whenever a member spoke, she would caste a glance at him and then lower her head again. She was a member of the Congress. Her husband, J.P. Saxena, was one of the active members of the party. He had died three years ago. For the past one year, Mrs Saxena had involved herself in the affairs of the Congress, and the committee had selected her as one of its members. She would go to the houses of the respectable families and advocate for swadeshi and khaddar. Whenever she spoke from the platform of the committee, her enthusiasm showed as if she wanted to fly in the sky. Her golden face would turn red with excitement. Her poignant eyes that seemed to be moist all the time would shine brightly. A woman of sweet temperament, she was fearlessly candid. She was like a spark hidden in ashes which would intensify with a gust of wind. Nobody knew how the ordinary words from her mouth acquired such magnetic appeal. Many members of the committee, who earlier would seldom attend the meetings, now started to come regularly. If she proposed something, there was no dearth of people seconding her. Her simplicity, her eagerness, her compassion and her sweet voice, all held the Congress in thrall. Everybody would respect her but her inherent humility would not allow her to take advantage of her resources. Whenever she entered the room people would stand up, but she would only take a seat in the last row.

Mrs Saxena asked the president, ‘Can women participate in a dharna at the wine shops?’

All eyes turned towards her. Everyone had a sense of what she was up to.

The president said timidly, ‘Mahatmaji is strongly in favour of this . . . but . . .’

Cutting him short Mrs Saxena said, ‘Then I volunteer to go.’

They looked at Mrs Saxena with searching eyes. How could this tender lady, with her soft body that could perhaps hardly bear the blow of the wind, prepare herself to walk through filthy alleys and go near the wine and toddy shops drowned in stench and squalor. How could she volunteer to face the blemished eyes and arms of those gone mad with intoxication?

A gentleman whispered into the ears of the other sitting next to him, ‘An extremely fearless lady!’

The man replied with sarcasm, ‘She wants to drag us through thorns. Nothing else! Do you expect the poor child to do picketing? She won’t be able to stand in front of the shop.’

The president said with his head down, ‘I appreciate your courage and eagerness, but I don’t think that our city is safe enough for me to allow a woman to do picketing. You have no idea how loose a mouth these drunkards have! They don’t know what entreaty is.’

Mrs Saxena said sarcastically, ‘So you are waiting for a time when these drunkards will turn into thorough gentlemen full of humility and compassion. The condition will prevail. It is not without any reason that Mahatmaji has considered women suitable for this job. I am not sure how much the chances of my success are, but I cannot shirk this duty.’

The president said hesitantly, ‘I don’t want to drag you into this but the choice is yours.’

With utmost humility, Mrs Saxena replied, ‘I won’t come to you complaining that there was one who roughed me up or called me names. But I know that if I succeed, there will be no dearth of women who will gladly take charge of this campaign fully.’

At this point, a young member said to the president, ‘With respect, I put forth my view that if Mrs Saxena is allowed this job, we will become the butt of ridicule.’ This man was Jai Ram. He had spent some days in prison for delivering a rabble-rousing speech. But at that point of time he was not a

householder, he was a student of law. Now he was a married man with three children. Although everything had changed, the restless energy, the enthusiasm and the spirit remained from his early days except that he was helpless in the face of his circumstances.

Turning towards Mrs Saxena, he pleaded, ‘For my sake, don’t involve yourself in this unpleasant job. Allow me a week’s time. Meanwhile, if any untoward incident or a riot takes place, you have every authority to turn me out.’

Mrs Saxena knew very well what kind of a man Jai Ram was. He was a man given to fellow feeling and sacrifice. It was his circumstances that did not let him come forward openly. But at the same time, she also realized that he lacked the degree of patience and tolerance required in the picketing job. Even in prison he had slapped the jailor when the latter had abused him and his sentence had been extended by three months.

She said, ‘You have the responsibility of your family. I don’t mean to be immodest but I consider myself more competent to do the job than you.’

Jai Ram continued in the same polite tone, ‘You are going by my old record. Perhaps you are not considering the fact that with advancing age one tends to attain maturity and become less arrogant.’

The president said, ‘I think Mr Jai Ram should take up this task.’

Jai Ram said, pleased, ‘I thank you from the bottom of my heart for this.’

Mrs Saxena was disappointed. She said, ‘Mr Jai Ram, you have been unfair to me. I will never forgive you for this. Today you people have proved that women are subordinate to men and they cannot serve their nation.’

2

The next evening, Jai Ram, accompanied by five volunteers, headed for the picketing at the Begum Ganj Wine Shop. The toddy and wine shops were adjacent to each other. They were run by the same proprietor. On the pavement in front of the shop and in the yard inside, packs of drunkards were busy trying to churn out nectar from poison.

All of them had left Plato far behind in wit and philosophy. One would boast of his heroic deeds, the other would share tales of his charity and generosity and yet another would be eloquent on his intellectual strides. Intoxication finds its best representation through unrestrained pride and haughtiness.

An old drunkard shared his musings, 'Bhaiya, life is uncertain. Really uncertain, I say. Pay heed to my words when I say life cannot claim any certainty. This eating and drinking is what will be with you. Money, land, property—you will leave it all behind.'

Two toddy drinkers were having another argument.

'We are the subjects, Bhai. How can we raise our head before the government? Sitting in your house, you could abuse the king but to do the same in the open is unthinkable. Talking of government, Bhaiya? People run away at the sight of the red turban.'

'The poor man with a full stomach considers himself the king. But one should always remember one's station.'

'You are right, Khan Sahib. One should be oneself. A king is a king, a subject a subject. How can they ever change places?'

In the midst of this, Jai Ram came and greeted them, 'Ram Ram, brothers!'

Seeing five to six people clad in khaddar, the drunkards looked at them with doubt and curiosity. The shopkeeper motioned to the servant and whispered something into his ears. The servant left the shop.

Erecting the flag on the ground Jai Ram said, 'Brothers, Mahatma Gandhi has urged you not to touch toddy or wine. Think of the money that you waste here. If you spend the same money on your family, nothing could be better. For a few moments of intoxication you starve your family to death, live in dirty houses and face humiliation at the hands of the moneylender. Just think for a moment. You can manage to live in comfort and joy if you do not let your money go to waste.'

An old drunkard said to his fellow, 'Bhaiya, I know it is a bad thing . . . it will ruin the house. But my entire life has gone into it. Now for the remaining few breaths, I cannot imagine quitting.'

His friend supported him, ‘Solid argument, Chaudhuri! When life we thus spent, now to think of parting from it! Hard to imagine!’

Jai Ram said, ‘What do you say, Chaudhuri? This is the right time to quit. Youth is the time of unbridled emotions. In that age every sin is pardonable.’

Chaudhuri did not say anything. But his friend who was a dark-complexioned, fat man with a big moustache, said with a note of mild objection in his voice, ‘If drinking is wrong, why do the English drink?’

Jai Ram was a lawyer. To argue with him was like stirring up a hornet’s nest. He said, ‘You asked a very good question, Bhai. Even the ancestors of the English were looters some hundred and fifty years ago. Our forefathers were saints and seers. Let the sons of robbers drink. They don’t have a code of conduct. Why should the sons of saints follow them? We are the sons of those great souls who taught the world and taught man how to be a man. We have forsaken our religion and as a result suffer as slaves. But now we have decided to break free from the manacles of slavery.’

As the discussion was going on, suddenly a police inspector, along with his five constables, reached the spot.

The inspector asked Chaudhuri, ‘Are these fellows threatening you?’

Chaudhuri stood up and said, ‘No, Huzoor, they are explaining certain things to us. And see with what love and affection . . . *wah!*’

The inspector said to Jai Ram, ‘If there are riots, you will be held accountable.’

Jai Ram argued, ‘I am responsible as long as you are not here.’

‘What do you mean? Have I come here to create trouble and to cause riots?’

‘I don’t mean to say that. But since you have come here, you are bound to display the power of the unparalleled English Empire. The crowd will get excited and you will beat down a good number of them, say ten or twenty at least. This is how it happens everywhere. Isn’t it so?’

Biting his lips, the inspector said, ‘I ask you to go away from here, otherwise I will have to make arrests.’

Jai Ram said in an unflinching tone, ‘And I request you to allow us to do our job. These are all my brothers. I have the right to talk to them as much as you have.’

By this time a hundred onlookers had gathered around. The inspector did not think it advisable to take any action before consulting his officers. Straightening himself, he went to the shop and, resting his leg on the chair, said, ‘These people will not easily give in?’

The shopkeeper said, ‘Huzoor, I will be doomed.’

‘Why don’t you hire some hooligans and get them thrashed? I will not intervene. Yes, but make sure you send me an excellent bottle. Yesterday you sent me some rotten stuff. It was tasteless.’

The inspector went away. Chaudhuri said to his friend, ‘You saw, Kallu, how angry the inspector was! The government wants us to drink a lot and there should be none to raise an objection, or ask us to mend our ways. The revenue collected through the sales of wine goes to the government, after all.’

Kallu philosophized, ‘They all draw money from us on every pretext.’

Chaudhuri said, ‘Then what do you say? There is no denying the fact that liquor is a bad thing.’

‘In fact, the worst thing, Bhaiya. If Mahatmaji has asked, it is better to stop drinking.’

‘Well, if it is so. From today if I ever touch wine, I am a hypocrite.’

Saying this, Chaudhuri tossed the bottle to the ground. Half the wine from the broken bottle spilled on the ground and dried up.

Jai Ram had never experienced such moments of happiness in his whole life. He started clapping vigorously and jumped up with joy.

This was the moment when the two toddy drinkers said ‘*Mahatmaji ki jai!’* and hurled their toddy pots. One of the volunteers rushed forward and garlanded the four men with flowers.

Many drunkards sitting on the pavement looked at the four men with helpless eyes expressing a lack of gall.

There was none who thought that life was unbearable without English wine, meat or toddy and that it was necessary to get addicted to these. All of them thought of intoxication as something evil. But since there were shops around, they would regularly come and drink. Seeing a hardcore drunkard and that too none other than Chaudhuri throw his bottle down, their eyes widened with wonder. A lean, bearded man approached Chaudhuri and patted him on his back. Chaudhuri pushed him back saying, 'Don't pat me. Better you go and break your bottle.'

The bearded man said, 'Excuse me for today, Chaudhuri. Allow me to have my fill. My Allah knows that I shall never again cross this way even by mistake.'

Chaudhuri said, 'Take money from me for the wine that you have with you. Go home and give sweetmeats to your wife and children.'

The bearded man flung his bottle down to the ground and said, 'Here you are! You will ever remember you met a man! Happy now . . . I suppose?'

'Promise you will never drink.'

'If you can abstain, I will follow suit. The day you touch it, don't stop me from it.'

Chaudhuri's zeal had shaken the foundation of stubbornness. There were some five or six more people outside. They were engaged in drinking with conscious shamelessness. Jai Ram addressed them, 'Brothers, you saw for yourself how five people from among you have destroyed their bottles. Will you prove yourselves losers by allowing them to outdo you in this regard?'

A dwarfish, dark-complexioned man who seemed to be the cook of an Englishman rolled his red bulging eyes and said, 'This is none of your business. If we drink, how does it affect you? Do we ever come and beg from you?'

Jai Ram realized that now the ball was in his court. When a misguided person enters a debate, it is an indication that he is ready to be convinced. An obvious shortcoming is easy to set right but a fault that is concealed is

like the slippery surface of a pitcher that will not allow anything to stay on it.

Jai Ram said, 'If I set fire to my house, will you not hold my hand at that time? I am sure you will not only hold my hand but also pull me out of a burning house.'

Chaudhuri looked at the cook with pleased eyes, as if to ask him what his answer would be, and said, 'Jamadar, on this point of argument, just throw down your bottle.'

The cook replied in a cutting manner as if he had sharpened his teeth to bite, 'Why should I toss my bottle? Have I not paid for it?'

Chaudhuri gave up and said to Jai Ram, 'Leave them to their fate, Babuji. These are hardcore slaves. Even if you lay down your life for them, they will not quit drinking. But of course, at a little scolding from the police they will never show themselves around here again.'

The cook looked at Chaudhuri with disgust as if to ask him why he thought of himself as a man and others as animals. Then he said, 'This has nothing to do with you. Why do you intervene? I am talking to Babuji. Who are you to talk to me like this? I am not like you to make a show of my virtue and earn applause. Today in front of everybody I give up wine and tomorrow I disgrace myself by ordering it at home. Once I quit drinking, it will be for ever. Even if someone offered me a lakh of rupees, I would not look at the money.'

Jai Ram said, 'You lived up to my expectations.'

Hitting out at the cook, Chaudhuri said, 'What do you think? I will come again tomorrow to have a drink?'

The cook said impudently, 'Yes, I am dead sure you will. This you can take from me in black and white.'

'Okay, you are a pious man and I am a sinner. You quit drinking forever and I quit it only for today and resume it the next day, fine! Just take it from me that you will give up drinking only when you are no longer there to drink. Not before that.'

'Can you read my mind?'

'I know. I have tolerated hundreds of your kind.'

‘You might have dealt with shameless people. Not the dignified ones.’ Saying this, he threw down the bottle and said, ‘If ever you find me loitering around this shop, you can rub ash on my face.’

Everyone started clapping. This is what a real man is!

The proprietor stepped out of his shop and said to the people who had gathered there, ‘Why don’t you people go to your respective shops? What show is going on here? I never go to anybody else’s shop.’

One of the onlookers said, ‘If I stand here, who are you to object? The road is not your property. You keep looting the poor. Their wives and children die of hunger but what difference does it make to your cosy life? (Turning to other drunkards) What do you say, chums? Still falling for bottles? Do you know who has asked us to quit it? Have some shame!’

Jai Ram said to the onlookers, ‘Please don’t gather here and form a crowd. Disperse and don’t be rude to anybody.’

But the crowd was swelling. There were still four or five people left who were helping themselves to *kulhar* after kulhar. A mischievous man went to them and picked up the bottle kept there, and was about to dash it to the floor when the four of them got up and started beating him. Jai Ram and his volunteers reached the table at once and tried to save the man. The four left the man and charged at Jai Ram. When the people gathered there realized that Jai Ram could get beaten up, many of them pounced on the drunkards and treated them to punches, kicks and blows. Jai Ram did not know how to stop the people. They did not give him any time to intervene. Manoeuvring his hands, he dodged their blows. The four of them were also madly hitting at the crowd with canes. Jai Ram was roughed up by both sides—the drunkards as well as the crowd. But he would not budge from there. If he would have slunk away from there to save his life, the crowd would have beaten the drunkards to a pulp. The Congress would have been held accountable for this. Being a representative, he was ready to lay down his life to preserve the honour of the Congress and save it from criticism. He did not want to give Mrs Saxena an opportunity to laugh at him. A heavy blow from a rod landed on his head and he buckled, cradling his head in his

hands. He could see butterflies dancing even though his eyes were screwed shut from the severe pain. Then he fell unconscious.

4

Jai Ram was unconscious throughout the night. The next day, when he regained his senses, his whole body ached. He felt his heart sinking from sheer weakness. As his eyes moved upwards, he saw Mrs Saxena sitting at the head of the bed. Seeing her, he tried to hoist himself up despite the volunteers asking him not to do so. He felt as if the pain and weakness had suddenly disappeared, and a sprightly wave ran through his body.

Placing her hand on his forehead, Mrs Saxena said, 'You are badly injured. I am to be blamed for this.'

Looking at her with an expression stemming from both devotion and gratitude, he said, 'The injury is light but has been heavily dressed by these people.'

Mrs Saxena said with a sense of guilt, 'I should not have let you go.'

Jai Ram replied, 'It wouldn't have been suitable for you to have gone there. My only request to you is that you never even think of going that way.'

As if to laugh away these restrictions imposed by Jai Ram, she said, 'I have got permission to start picketing there from today.'

'Please listen to my entreaty. It is an ordinary thing for those drunkards to pass offensive comments.'

'I care a fig for comments.'

'Then I will accompany you.'

Mrs Saxena looked at him with surprise. 'In this condition?'

'Believe me! I am all right.'

'This is impossible. Unless the doctor declares you fit, I will not allow you to join me. Not at any cost.'

'Then I will not let you go.'

Mrs Saxena said a little satirically, 'Like the rest of the men, you too are a selfish one. You want every glory to be reserved for you. You deprive

women of any opportunity to prove themselves. You should at least know whether or not I am capable of something!'

Agonized, Jai Ram said, 'As you wish.'

5

In the evening, Mrs Saxena, along with four volunteers, headed for Begum Ganj. Jai Ram lay on his bed, his eyes closed. He was startled by a noise and asked his wife, 'What is this din?'

His wife peeped out of the window and said, 'She is the same woman who came here yesterday. Walking alongside four men, she doesn't have even a bit of modesty.'

Jai Ram cast a forgiving look at her face and appeared lost in thought. Then he got up and said he too would join them.

His wife held his hand and said, 'Only yesterday you sustained such severe injuries and are thinking of going again?'

Jai Ram jerked his hand free and said, 'You call it a beating? I consider it a gift.'

She blocked his way and said, 'I say you are not well. Don't go. Why are you after my life? She is not studded with diamonds that you need to protect her from being snatched away.'

Jai Ram said in a pleading tone, 'Chammu, I am fine. If I am feeling somewhat low, I will get better by going out. Just consider that the lady has to go and picket among those drunkards while I sit here comfortably! My going there is very important. If some untoward incident takes place, at least I can intervene and talk to the people.'

Chammu said with a pang of jealousy, 'Why don't you say it is something else that draws you there?'

Jai Ram gave her a smile as if to say it was not her heart that felt this way but only her tongue that was unrestrained. Then he moved aside, avoiding her. Standing at the door, he said, 'The population of the city is approximately three lakh and there are thirty members in the committee but most of them are playing safe and proving themselves cowards. They have

got a good excuse that for staging dharnas at wine shops women are most suitable. Why are women considered fit to do this job? Is it because men turn mad and where compassion will do the job, they tend to take to agitation and violence? Should the ladies be thrown in the face of the foul and humiliating comments of the drunkards and be forced to put up with their indecent ogling? As for me, I cannot tolerate this.' He left the house, limping slightly. Chammu did not try to stop him this time. On his way he came across another volunteer. Together, they hailed a tonga and stopped at a lemonade ice shop a little distance from the wine shop. Jai Ram went inside and sent the volunteer to the wine shop.

Handing him a glass of lemonade, the shopkeeper said, 'Babuji, the hooligans who attacked you yesterday are here again. Had you not intervened and defended them, they would have been seen drinking tamarind and jaggery syrup instead of wine.'

Holding the glass, Jai Ram said, 'Had the crowd not started the scuffle, I would have set them right.'

The shopkeeper argued, 'No, Babuji, the four of them are hooligans of the highest order. I do not allow them to even stand in front of my shop. They have already served sentence for three years.'

Hardly twenty minutes had passed when a volunteer appeared. Jai Ram asked him worriedly, 'What is going on at the shop?'

The volunteer made an unpleasant face as he did not think it suitable to share the news, and gave a short reply, 'Madam is talking to people, trying to reason with them.'

Jai Ram cast a discontented look at him as if to say he already knew that.

After a moment, the volunteer spoke again, 'It is not proper for ladies to go amongst such scoundrels.'

Jai Ram asked desperately, 'Tell me everything clearly. What is the matter?'

The volunteer said hesitantly, 'Nobody is taking her seriously. It is really problematic for ladies to have come here.'

Jai Ram did not probe further; he took his cane and, rolling his red eyes, rushed towards the wine shop like lightning. He took Mrs Saxena by her

arm and, pushing her back, said to the drunkards, ‘If you misbehave with the lady or insult her in any way, it will not serve you well. The other day I saved your life and today I will make good use of the same cane and break open your skulls.’

The drunkards got nervous at the changed attitude of Jai Ram. They were about to say something. Right then, Mrs Saxena said seriously, ‘Why have you come here? I asked you not to move from your place. In fact, I didn’t ask for help.’

Jai Ram felt embarrassed and said, ‘I did not come here on purpose. I happened to cross the place as I had some business over here. When I saw the crowd, I could not stop myself. And I think now you should move from here. I will raise this question before the Congress Committee and ask them to send men for this job.’

Mrs Saxena said sharply, ‘So you believe only men to be capable of doing all the jobs in this world.’

Jai Ram replied, ‘I did not mean that.’

‘Then go back and relax, and let me do my duty.’

Jai Ram stood there with his head held low. Then he asked her, ‘What is the harm if I just stand here in a corner?’

Mrs Saxena said in a strict tone, ‘No, you please go away.’

Jai Ram walked away slowly like a loaded vehicle and came up to the lemonade shop again.

He felt thirsty and asked for a glass of lemonade. He set the glass down on the table and was lost in thought, but his eyes and ears were still drawn to the place he had left a moment ago.

Whenever anybody came to the shop, he would be alert and start looking in the same direction, worried that something might have happened. After half an hour the same volunteer came again, looking frightened. Trying to appear indifferent, Jai Ram asked him casually, ‘Is everything okay there?’

Covering his ears with his hands the man said, ‘I do not know anything. Do not ask me, please.’

Jai Ram sounded harsh as well as soft when he asked in a wavering tone, ‘Did the drunkards make any indecent advances?’

The volunteer replied, ‘No such thing, but one of them pushed her and she lost her balance and fell down.’

Jai Ram sat silent. But this moment of pause churned up a storm within. He said, ‘And what are the volunteers who accompanied her doing?

‘They are simply standing. The lady will not allow them to say anything or intervene.’

‘Was it a rough push?’

‘Yes, she hurt her knees. They sat there drinking. When they had emptied one bottle, one of them got up to fetch another. The lady obstructed his way and he pushed her down. He was the same fat, dark man. Again it is the doing of the four men who scuffled yesterday.’

Jai Ram stood up, furious, and ran towards the wine shop. Mrs Saxena sat there, holding her head between her hands, and the fat, dark man stood by the boundary wall of the shop. Around them was a crowd of over fifty people. Seeing him, Jai Ram seized him by the throat and pressed so hard that his eyes bulged out. It seemed as if his hands had turned as hard as iron.

Mrs Saxena caught him by his hands and, knitting her eyebrows, said, ‘Let go of him! Will you kill him?’

Jai Ram pressed even harder and said, ‘Yes, I will. This wicked fellow deserves nothing less than this.’

Mrs Saxena raised her head and said in an arrogant, authoritative tone, ‘You do not have the right to come here.’

One of the spectators said, ‘Press hard, Babuji, and keep on pressing till *saala* turns cold. He pushed the lady so hard that the poor creature couldn’t keep her balance. We have no power, otherwise we would have broken their bones.’ Jai Ram let go of the drunkard’s throat. He got back on his feet, nervous and defeated like a small bird freed from the talons of a hawk. Pushing him back, Jai Ram said to Mrs Saxena, ‘Why don’t you move out from here? You go away and I will take your place. If even an ounce of wine is sold, you can box my ears and take me to task.’ He was panting hard. His eyes grew dim. He couldn’t stand any longer, and sat down and wiped his face.

Mrs Saxena mocked Jai Ram and said, ‘You are not the Congress yourself that I should be forced to obey you. If you do not go away from here, I will do a satyagraha.’ Suddenly she turned harsh and said, ‘As long as the Congress has entrusted me with this responsibility, you have no right to intervene. You are insulting me. You will have to account for this before the Congress Committee.’

Her words hit Jai Ram hard. He did not say anything but headed for home with swift steps. But as he drew closer to home his pace slowed down, so much so that by the time he reached the other end of the market, he stopped dead in his tracks. He was at the end of his tether. It was impossible to move further. The unrestrained force which had brought him so far had lost its vigour. He could now smell the fragrance of care, affection and sympathy that the apparently harsh and sarcastic words of Mrs Saxena contained.

He was once again gripped by anxiety and wondered if everything was okay there. He wondered if the scoundrels had shown further wickedness or if the police had arrived.

He turned towards the market but, having taken two strides, stopped. Never had he been in such a dilemma. Suddenly he saw a volunteer running towards him. He himself rushed forward impatiently. Jai Ram asked panting, ‘Why are you running like this?’ The volunteer caught his breath and said, ‘As that black drunkard, having fetched his bottle, tried to walk out of the shop, the lady stood in between and wouldn’t let him go. He tried again and again to make his way out and avoid her but she sat obstructing his path. In the scuffle that ensued, she has sustained some injuries and even her clothes are torn . . .’

Before he could finish, Jai Ram ran towards the wine shop.

6

When Jai Ram reached the wine shop, he found the four volunteers of Mrs Saxena lying down in front of the shop and Mrs Saxena standing in a corner with her head down. Hesitant as Jai Ram was, he mustered up courage and

cast a glance at her face. When he noticed drops of blood on her *aanchal*, he lost control. The drops of blood turned into sparks and filled every pore in his body with madness. Fury overtook him and the blood in his veins boiled. He charged at them and started spinning his staff ferociously. For every drop of blood he wanted a pitcherful to flow. He never liked blood, but that blood could lead to such a fury was hitherto unknown to him.

He was moving his staff rapidly. He did not know when Mrs Saxena came and stood before him. It was only when she fell to the ground that he came to his senses. He flung the cane and stood there immobile, stunned and numb. His blood froze in his veins.

The four volunteers ran towards Mrs Saxena and started fanning her. The shopkeeper swiftly came with cold water. A man ran to call the doctor. Jai Ram stood there lifeless. He turned into a figure of disgust and hatred to himself. If anybody cut off both his hands and pierced both his eyes with red-hot iron now, he would not budge.

Agonized and drowned in deep shame he beat his head on the ground and fell unconscious.

Just then the fat, dark drunkard dashed his bottle to the ground and poured cold water on his head.

Another drunkard said to the wine licence holder, 'Your business will take so many lives. This is just the second day.'

The licence holder said, 'From tomorrow no more of this business. I will take up the business of swadeshi clothes. Hopefully it will earn me a good reputation and income with respect.'

The drunkard said, 'But you will suffer a loss.'

With a spirit of challenge and as if to approve of the course of destiny, the shopkeeper said, 'So what? Profit and loss are a part of life.'

Translated from the Hindi by Sarfaraz Nawaz



A Night in the Month of Poos

1

Halku came up to his wife and said, ‘Sahna has come. Go, get the money we’ve saved up. I’ll give it to him and get rid of him.’

Munni was sweeping the floor. She turned around and said, ‘There’s just three rupees in all. If you give it away, how will you get a blanket? Then how will you spend the chilly winter nights in the field? Tell him we’ll pay after the harvest, not now.’

For a moment Halku stood there, undecided. The month of Poos was around the corner and he could not go to the field without a blanket. But Sahna wouldn’t listen—he’d hurl abuse and threats. *If I die from the cold, so be it. At least I’ll get rid of this pest.* With this thought in mind, he moved his heavy body (which falsified his name) closer to his wife and said coaxingly, ‘Come on, give me the money and let me free my neck. I’ll find some other means to buy the blanket.’

Munni pulled away from him, rolled her eyes and said, ‘Enough of your means! Well, let me hear about them. Will someone give you a blanket out of charity? I don’t know how much the debt is and why it simply can’t be paid off. I say, why don’t you give up tilling land? You work yourself to death, if there is a good harvest all of it goes to repay the debt and that’s all. As if we’ve been born only to repay debt. It’s better to do day labour for

your livelihood. Let thunder and lightning fall on such a harvest! I shan't give you the money. Never!'

Halku felt sad and said, 'Then shall I listen to him calling me names?'

Munni, upset by his words, said, 'Why should he call you names? We aren't his subjects!'

However, as soon as she said this, her tense eyebrows slackened. The bitter truth hidden in Halku's words was staring her in the face like a wild animal.

She went and took out the money from the niche and handed it over to Halku. Then she said, 'You just stop tilling the land from now on. As a labourer, at least you'll eat your roti in peace. There won't be threats. Nice farming, this! To earn money through hard work, throw it into the furnace and on top of it put up with such threats!'

Halku took the money and went out so dejectedly that it seemed as though he was plucking out his heart and handing it over. He had scrounged to save three rupees from his wages with great difficulty. And now he was going to part with that money. With each step his head bent lower and lower with a sense of helplessness.

2

The night of Poos was pitch-black. Even the stars in the sky seemed to quiver. Halku sat under a canopy of sugar-cane leaves by his corn field and shivered in his old cotton wrap. Under the cot, his pet dog, Jabra, his sole companion now, hid his face in his belly and whined from the cold. Neither of them could sleep.

Halku pulled his knees close to his chest and said to the dog, 'Hey, Jabra, are you feeling cold? I told you to lie down on the straw at home but you insisted on coming with me. Now face the cold, what can I do? You thought I'll eat halva-puri here, so you came running ahead of me. Now face the music!'

Jabra lay there and wagged his tail. Then he emitted a long whine, yawned and became quiet. Perhaps he guessed that his whining was

preventing his master from sleeping.

Halku stretched out his hand, ran it over Jabra's cold shoulders and said, 'Tomorrow don't come with me, or you'll be cold. This bitch of a west wind has become icy cold. Let me get up and fill a chillum. I have to pass the night somehow. I've smoked eight chillums already. This is the fun of working the land! And there are those to whom the cold means nothing. Thick mattresses, quilts, blankets—they have every means to chase away the cold. The cold doesn't dare come near them. The irony is that we do all the work and others have all the fun.'

Halku got up, picked up an ember from the fire and filled his chillum. Jabra also sat up.

Halku smoked and said, 'You want a drag? It can't drive away the cold; it's just a means to distract the mind.'

Jabra gazed at him with wistful eyes dripping with love.

Halku said, 'Bear with the cold just for today. Tomorrow I'll lay some straw here. You can snuggle into it and won't feel the cold.'

Jabra put his front paws on Halku's knees and brought his mouth close to his. Halku could feel Jabra's warm breath.

Having smoked the chillum, Halku lay down again with the determination to sleep, come what may. But then his heart began to beat faster. He fidgeted and turned over. The terrible cold sat on his chest like a demon.

When he could not bear it any longer, he woke Jabra up gently, patted his head and made him lie down in his lap. The dog had a foul smell but he hugged him close and experienced a comfort he had not felt for the last several months. Jabra probably thought he was in heaven. And Halku's pure soul did not feel even a trace of aversion for the dog. He would have hugged his most intimate friend or brother like this. He was not sad about the helplessness that had driven him to this state. No! This unusual friendship seemed to open all the doors of his soul, and each particle of his being dazzled with light.

Suddenly Jabra sensed the presence of an animal. This injected him with new energy and the cold wind became trivial. He got up energetically, left

the shed and barked. Halku called after him a couple of times affectionately but he did not return. He circled around the field and barked. If he did return right away, he would run back to his position the very next moment. His sense of duty did not allow him to rest for a second.

3

Another hour passed. The night seemed to infuriate the chilly wind. Halku got up and buried his head in his knees which were pulled up close to his chest. Yet there was no relief from the cold. It seemed as though his blood had frozen, that instead of blood it was the chill that flowed in his veins. He peeped at the sky to gauge how much of the night was left. Saptarshi had not yet covered half of its course in the sky. Only when it came overhead would dawn begin to break. There was still more than a watch of the night left.

A stone's throw away from Halku's field was a mango orchard. Autumn had set in and the ground was strewn with fallen leaves. Halku thought of going there, gathering the leaves, setting them alight and warming himself by the flame. *If anyone saw me gathering the leaves at night they would think that I was a ghost*. There could also be some wild beast lurking there. But it was unbearable to stay put in that condition.

He went up to the lentil field nearby and pulled out a couple of plants. He made a broom out of them and, holding a burning cow-dung cake in one hand, advanced towards the orchard. As Jabra saw him coming, he went up to him and began to wag his tail.

Halku said, 'I can't bear it any more, Jabru. Come, let's gather leaves from the orchard and warm ourselves. When we feel comfortable, we'll come back and sleep. The night is yet long.'

Jabra whined to express his assent and began to walk ahead towards the orchard. It was pitch-dark in the orchard and the merciless wind swept over the leaves. Dewdrops were trickling down the trees making a tip-tap sound.

Suddenly a draught of wind wafted in bearing the scent of henna flowers.

Halku said, 'What a nice scent, Jabru! Do you also get the smell?'

Jabra had encountered a bone and was busy chewing it.

Halku put the burning cow-dung cake down on the ground and began to gather flowers. Soon, there was a huge pile. His hands were shaking, his bare feet seemed to be melting away. And he was making that massive pile. He would burn the cold in that bonfire and reduce it to ashes.

Some moments later the pile was lit up. The flames reached up to the tree above and were touching its leaves. In the restless light of the flame the massive tree seemed to carry the bottomless darkness on its head. In the bottomless sea of darkness, the flame seemed like a boat cruising gently on it.

Halku was warming himself sitting by the fire. After a little while, he took his wrap and put it under his arms. Then he stretched his legs as though he was throwing out a challenge to the wind to do its worst. Having vanquished the unbounded power of the cold, he was finding it difficult to control his pride of victory. He said to Jabra, 'Hey Jabra, I hope you're not feeling cold any more?'

Jabra whined as if to say, *Shall we bear with the cold always?*

'Why didn't we think of it earlier? It would've saved us from the terrible cold.'

Jabra wagged his tail.

'Now, come and jump over the fire. Let's see who can do that. If you burn yourself, son, I am not going to apply balm to your wound.'

Jabra stared at the bonfire with wistful eyes.

'Don't say anything to Munni tomorrow; she'll kick up a storm.'

Saying this, he leapt over the fire and landed safely on the other side. The flames barely licked his feet but that didn't matter. Jabra went around the fire and stood by his side.

Halku said, 'Come on, not like that. Jump over the fire.'

He jumped over it and crossed to the other side.

The leaves had been burnt. The orchard was again enveloped in darkness. Embers behind the ashes lit up with each gust of wind. And then in the next moment, it was dark again.

Halku covered himself with the sheet once again and, sitting by the hot ashes, hummed a song. His body was warm now, but as the chill intensified, he felt more and more lethargic.

Suddenly, Jabra began to bark loudly and ran towards the field. Halku suspected that a horde of animals had strayed into his field. Probably it was a group of antelopes. One could clearly hear them running all over the place. Then it seemed as if they were eating up the harvest. He could hear them chewing the cud.

He said to himself, 'No, while Jabra is around, no animal can enter the field. He will tear them to pieces. I must be dreaming. See, I can hear nothing now. How I got tricked!'

He called out loudly, 'Jabra, Jabra.'

Jabra continued to bark. He didn't come to him.

Once again Halku heard the animals chewing up the plants. He could no longer delude himself. He hated having to move from his place. How comfortably he was sitting there! To go to the fields and chase the animals in the freezing cold was unbearable. He didn't budge from his spot.

He called out louder, 'Liho, liho.'

Jabra barked once again. The marauding animals were destroying the field. The harvest was ripe and ready. What a good harvest it was! But these wicked animals were ruining it.

Halku made up his mind and took a couple of steps. But suddenly the cold blast of wind smote him like a scorpion's sting, and so he returned to the half-extinguished fire. He poked the ashes and stretched his limbs to warm them in the fire.

Jabra was now barking at the top of his voice. The antelopes had cleaned up the field and Halku was sitting peacefully by the hot ashes. Lethargy bound him like so many ropes from all sides.

He tied the wrap around him and lay down on the hot earth beside the ashes.

By the time he woke up in the morning, the sun was up in the sky and had lit up the place. Munni was saying, ‘Will you keep on sleeping today? You made yourself comfortable here and over there the entire harvest has been ruined.’

Halku got up and said, ‘Have you come from the field?’

Munni said, ‘Yes, the entire field has been ruined. And you’re sleeping like a log! What came of you building the shed?’

Halku made excuses. ‘I was dying, and you’re only thinking about the field. I had such a tummy pain that I could not think of anything else.’

Both went to the field together and saw the entire field pillaged. And Jabra was stretched on the earth under the shed. It seemed as though life had ebbed out of him.

Despair shadowed Munni’s face. But Halku was happy.

Munni said thoughtfully, ‘We’ll have to work as wage earners to repay the debt now.’

Halku said light-heartedly, ‘At least I’ll not have to lie down here in the chilly nights.’

Translated from the Hindi by M. Asaduddin



Maiku and the Congress Volunteer

1

When Qadir and Maiku arrived near the arrack shop, they saw Congress volunteers standing there with flags and surrounded by a large crowd of onlookers. It was late in the evening. On other evenings, the lane would be deserted. Respectable men would hesitate here; only small groups of drunken men would stagger past, while a few prostitutes would stand around the shop.

On seeing the crowd that evening, Maiku exclaimed with surprise, ‘So many people! Should be about two or three hundred!’

Qadir smirked as he said, ‘Are you scared of the crowd? Don’t worry, they’ll be gone soon, not one will stay. They’ve only come to watch the tamasha, not get beaten by the lathis.’

‘The police are also here!’ muttered Maiku with a hint of uncertainty in his voice. ‘The shop owner said he wouldn’t let the police interfere.’

Qadir said confidently, ‘The police will do nothing, so why are you scared? They only interfere where wealth or woman is involved. Otherwise they don’t bother. They’re actually here to support the shop owner. They get their share from him all year round. So if they don’t support him now, when will they?’

Maiku said, ‘Okay, let’s go in. We’ll get free liquor today and save some cash. But I heard several moneybags have joined the Congress lot. What if they hound us tomorrow?’

Qadir reassured him, ‘No, mate, they won’t hound us. What are you scared of ? These Congresswalas don’t harm anyone, even if you try to kill them. How else did those ten chowkidars thrash a force of ten thousand men? Four were laid cold but not one raised a hand to fight back! Their leader, the Mahatma, is a crazy fakir. He tells them not to fight back.’

Engrossed in their banter, the two men reached the entrance of the arrack shop. Then a volunteer stepped forward with folded hands and said, ‘Bhai Sahib! Liquor is forbidden in your religion.’

Maiku responded by slapping him hard on the face. The force of the blow made the volunteer stagger, while blood rushed into his eyes. Other volunteers ran forward to support him. Maiku’s fingers had left an imprint on the volunteer’s face but he remained standing with folded hands. Maiku ordered, ‘Move! Or do you want more?’

The volunteer replied gently, ‘If that is your wish, I will bow my head. Hit me as much as you want but, please, do not enter the shop.’

Having said this, the volunteer sat down on the ground and blocked Maiku’s way.

Maiku looked at the volunteer thoughtfully. The imprint of his fingers seemed to flare on the man’s face. On many occasions, Maiku had remained unmoved by the sight of men’s heads smashed by his lathi. Today, the sight of that livid mark on the man’s face pierced Maiku’s heart like a *panchshul*.

Qadir, who was standing with the chowkidars and smoking a cigarette, yelled at Maiku, ‘What are you waiting for? Give him another slap.’

Maiku spoke to the volunteer again, ‘Get up. Let me enter.’

‘You may walk over my body,’ replied the volunteer.

‘I ask you to get up and let me enter. I won’t drink any arrack. I have some other business.’

He spoke with such calm resolution that the volunteer got up and allowed him to pass through into the shop. Maiku looked at him with a smile. Then

the volunteer again joined his hands and pleaded, ‘Please don’t forget your promise.’

One of the chowkidars taunted the volunteer, ‘Even a ghost flees when it is kicked. One slap was enough.’

Qadir chuckled, ‘This fellow will remember Maiku’s slap all his life. It’s not easy to suffer our Maiku’s slaps.’

The chowkidar responded, ‘Give them such a beating today, they’ll never come back this way again.’

Qadir said, ‘God willing, they won’t come back again. But I must admit they’re very brave. They don’t mind risking their lives.’

2

As Maiku entered the arrack shop, he was greeted by the owner, ‘Come in, Maiku Miyan! Why did you stop at one slap? One is not enough. They’re a stubborn lot. Thrash them black and blue, but they don’t change. Break their limbs today so they will never return.’

Maiku asked, ‘But won’t others follow?’

The shop owner growled, ‘They’d be dead scared to.’

‘And what if the crowd thrashes me?’

‘Then the police will chase them. The field will be cleared in no time. Come now, a peg or two. Today I am offering drinks for free.’

‘To all customers?’

The shop owner shrugged. ‘What can I do? No one would come otherwise. It’s only when they heard it’s free today that they swarmed in.’

Maiku said, ‘I won’t drink today.’

The shop owner was astonished, ‘What, you won’t drink? Why, I got fresh liquor just for you!’

Maiku replied, ‘I don’t feel like drinking today. But give me a stick. I can’t hit with my hands.’

The shop owner immediately produced a stout lathi for Maiku and then moved towards the door to watch the fun. Maiku deliberated with the stick for a moment, then suddenly jumped up and brought it down on the shop

owner's back with such brute force that he collapsed. After that, Maiku turned his attention to the customers and started raining blows upon them. He looked neither left nor right; he just swung into action with the lathi, swiftly and mercilessly.

In an instant, the drunken customers were jolted out of their intoxication. They scrambled towards the door but the shop owner's body blocked it. So they retreated into the interior, but Maiku stood there waiting with the lathi. Completely overtaken by panic, they trampled over the shop owner's body and escaped through the door. Many of them were injured in the stampede; some broke their limbs, some their heads, while others injured their backs. It happened so fast that, within a minute, the arrack shop was deserted.

Soon after, the sound of earthen pots being smashed was heard. The volunteer peeped into the shop and saw Maiku smashing all the containers of liquor with the lathi. He pleaded, 'Bhai Sahib! O Bhai Sahib!' What madness is this? It would be better to vent your anger on me!'

With a few more swings of his lathi, Maiku smashed all the remaining pots and bottles, then gave a final kick to the shop owner lying on the floor as he strode out.

Qadir stopped him and asked, 'Hey, have you lost your mind? What did you come here for and what the hell have you done?'

Maiku glared at him and retorted, 'Yes, thank God I came here for something but did something else! If you have the guts, go and thrash the volunteers. I don't have the guts. That one slap was enough! I'm guilty now and will remain guilty. Only a mean, cowardly and impotent man would harm these volunteers who sacrifice their lives to save people from this evil. Maiku is a bully and a goonda, but he's not wicked or cowardly! Go, tell the police to arrest me if they want to.'

Some drunken men who were standing nearby stared at him with fear-stricken eyes. None dared speak to him. Maiku turned to them and said, 'I'll be back tomorrow. If I see any of you here, I'll tear you limb from limb. I'm not afraid of jail or hanging. Your welfare lies in staying away from this place. These Congresswalas are not your enemies. It's for you and your family's sake that they stop you from drinking. Spend this money on your

children, buy milk and butter for them. Your families are starving. Your wives are weeping at home. A curse on your drunkenness!'

Maiku flung the lathi to the ground. As he strode through the gathered crowd of people, they gazed at him with eyes full of awe and pride.

Translated from the Hindi by Ivy Imogene Hansdak



The Dream

I do not know about others, but I find such pleasure and joy in dreams that it is only there that I laugh to my heart's content. I weep heartily and play heartily too. There lies my golden gem, Jatil Mahal; there alone my wishes blossom and my words are my own. My pen is my own. My thoughts are my own. That world of mine is far more lucid, peaceful and energetic than this world of bondage and rules. Here, where is that devotion, passion, elevation and awakening that I experience there? But my lament is that such dreams are so rare. People want to wake up to the sight of a good person's face, but I want to fall asleep to such dreams.

I don't know whose blessed face I had seen before I fell asleep that I soon reached the kingdom of my dreams. I saw that my childhood had returned. Once again I was frolicking in the winds of freedom. My loving mother, that lovely sister, that childhood friend, the small house, that neem tree by the wall, everything appeared before my eyes. What shall I write of that excitement and joy! It is indescribable. I could clearly remember that just a while ago I was old. I was surprised at this transformation of my image. I remembered everything about my age. The memory of the mistakes, difficulties, disillusionments and failures of a lifetime made my childhood distant. There was maturity, there was insolence, there was exultation, there was the self, there was seriousness too, and playfulness. I climb trees, but in such a way that I don't fall. I stubbornly demand things

too, but not in a way that I wail and raise a ruckus for it. I play, but not in a way that I get hurt. I don't make excuses at school. I don't tattle. I don't shirk my work. I do not want to make this life a failure by repeating the mistakes of my earlier life.

Dreams have the power to transform months, years and epochs into timelessness, and yet the illusion of time remains intact. I dreamt that from school, I completed college. Neither is the college here nor are the pupils, but now I don't hold grudges against anyone. I remember that those whom I had thought to be inferior have gone far ahead of me. Now I do not condemn anyone. I remember that I used to read novels while the teachers lectured. When it was time for play, I would loiter in the markets. Would I make those mistakes again? That love of novels turned into an ache in my heart, the wanderings became chains on my feet. Now I do all my work on time. That slavery of fashion, the enthusiasm for ties and collars, the excitement of new suits, those countless things whose addiction pollutes our student life—I have no passion for any of those things now. The experiences of a lifetime were guarding me now. This same me, for whom the hockey stick was a naked sword and the football a bombshell, became disciplined in those sports. I remembered well the price I had paid for my lack of interest in physical exercise.

And what do I see next! The preparations for my wedding are taking place. Whatever I had seen until now could only give me hope for bettering my life. There was no cause for concern or fear. There was a kind of immaturity. Even if youth returned, there was nothing to lose. But if I were to get married now, that would mean having two wives. Imagine what a terrible problem that would be! I am in a fix as to whether I should marry or not. The thought of matrimony had awakened certain other memories of my past. I wondered if anybody here would believe I was already trapped in this crisis and that too with half a dozen burdens of different kinds. Even I do not know for sure what I am in reality—old or young. I am trapped in this doubt and here my kin are engrossed in my wedding preparations. There is Amma, whose feet don't touch the ground, as though the world's greatest event has happened; no one but her son has had this great fortune.

Dadaji too, who hates the market, calls it a waste of money and cringes at the mention of ornaments, has bickered with Amma a thousand times. Her attacks are like those of King Akbar's, but he faces them with the determination of Rana Pratap. Today he was happily visiting moneylenders. He took a round of the markets every now and then. And yet there wasn't a trace of a frown on his forehead. And here I was, doubting whether that youth was an illusion.

In some secret part of my memory this concern seems to be hidden that I have children, a wife and in-laws. I was worried, *What would people say when I went home with a new wife?* I have grown-up sons who consider marriage in old age to be the greatest sin in life. The woman with whom I have spent thirty years of my life is also there. How will I face all of them? Don't ask me why I would not go to my own home instead of my parents' with the new bride. I don't have a house of my own but here are the past memories, intact; some of their faded marks were clearly visible. And then dreams don't obey rules of justice, sequence or chronology. I wondered how my friends would mock me, 'O Sir, you were always vehemently against such marriages. What craziness has come over you now?'

My life was in trouble. I was anxious. What explanation would I give to my mother? What if people laughed at me thinking that I had lost my mind?

In the meantime the drums started beating. Amma came and said, 'You are strange. You are sitting with a long face as though something is bothering you. The entire household is singing with joy and you're making such a sad face. We are alive, why are you worrying? You can worry when we are dead. Get up now, the *baraat* is leaving; get dressed quickly.'

I could not reply. How could I tell mother that she herself had conducted my wedding once? I quietly got dressed. The women sang wedding songs. The barber, the washerman and so on were given *neochchawar*, and I left from home and sat in the palanquin dressed as a groom. The bearers raised the palanquin. Then I saw that I had reached the bride's doorstep. There was the same chatter where the baraat was staying. As is the tradition, after a while I was told that it was the auspicious time for the *paanigrahan* ceremony; it was time to go. Now I faced a grave test. The way I have been

obeying all orders until now . . . if I silently continue the same way, it will be disastrous! I will be chained and won't be able to escape. If this youth indeed turns out to be a mirage, then the rest of my life will not only be branded but also miserable. I will have nowhere to go. How do I save myself ? What excuse shall I make? People will laugh at my condition and think me to be insane. But if this youth melts like ice, it will be disgraceful for the young lady!

I rose and ran in a hurry, wearing my fine clothes and shoes. People ran after me. I ran for my life as though some savage beast were chasing me—until a river appeared before me and I jumped into it. Then I woke up. I saw that I was lying on the bed, but was panting heavily.

Translated from the Urdu by Ayesha Abrar



Sacrifice

1

Anand, settling down in a cushioned chair and lighting a cigar, said, ‘How could Vishambhar indulge in such idiocy today! Exams are approaching and he has opted to become a volunteer! If caught, he is bound to wash his hands of the examination. And I have a strong hunch that the scholarship too may be terminated.’

Sitting across from him, on the other bench, was Roopmani, reading a newspaper. Though her eyes were on the paper, her ears were tuned to what Anand was saying. She said, ‘This is unfortunate. Did you not reason with him?’

Anand said grimacing, ‘When someone starts considering himself another Gandhi, it is difficult to instil sense in him. He starts sermonizing me instead.’

Roopmani, gathering the newspaper and arranging her hair, said, ‘You didn’t tell me either. Perhaps I could have stopped him.’

Anand said irritably, ‘So what’s the problem now! He may be in the Congress office right now. Go and stop him.’

Anand and Vishambhar were both university students. Anand, in his share, had Lakshmi as well as Saraswati. Vishambhar had only his miserable fate. The professors, as a token of sympathy, had allotted a

meagre allowance that was his lifeline. Roopmani too had been their classmate just a year ago but had left college this year. Her health had gone somewhat downhill. The two young boys would often come to meet her. Anand would come and take her heart away, and Vishambhar would visit just like that. If ever he needed a break from studies or felt restless, he would come to her. Perhaps sharing the saga of his suffering with her gave him a sense of tranquillity. He lacked the courage to say anything in front of Anand. And Anand did not have a single word of compassion for him. He would rebuke him, abuse him and simply make a fool of him. Vishambhar had no capacity to argue with him. What is a lamp before the sun! Anand held a sort of psychological dominion over him. For the first time in his life Vishambhar had dared to disregard his sovereignty, and Anand had come to Roopmani to complain about him. For months Vishambhar had tried to mould the earnestness in his heart on the basis of logic and reason which Anand provided. But despite succumbing to his logic, Vishambhar's heart persistently continued to rebel. Most certainly this academic year would be wasted. His student life would possibly come to an end. Then all his efforts of fourteen to fifteen years would go down the drain. Neither would he find God nor would a communion with the beloved be fated! What good would leaping into the fire do? While studying at university too it is possible to work for the country. Anand managed to collect a fair number of donations in a month and also got undertakings in favour of swadeshi from other students. Anand offered the same suggestion to Vishambhar too. However, this logic may have won his mind but was incapable of winning over his heart. Today, after Anand left for college, Vishambhar took the route to Swarajya Bhavan. When Anand returned from college, he found Vishambhar's letter on his table. It said:

> Dear Anand
>
> I am aware that whatever I am endeavouring to do is not favourable for me but I don't know what power is pulling me in. I don't want to go, nonetheless I go—just like a man who has no wish to die but dies anyway, has no wish to cry but cries anyway. When all these people we lay our trust in have plunged headlong into challenges, for me too there's no other way. I

cannot further deceive my own conscience. It's a matter of honour and honour doesn't compromise in any way.

Yours,
Vishambhar

Having read the letter, Anand thought of advising Vishambhar and persuading him to return. He, however, was annoyed with his stupid deed and in that state of vexation he came to Roopmani. Had Roopmani pleaded with him and insisted, 'Go, bring him back,' he might have gone. But her saying 'I could have stopped him' was unbearable for him. In her answer lay anger, a sense of aloofness and perhaps some envy too.

Roopmani looked at him haughtily and said, 'All right, I'm going.'

A moment later she added hesitantly, 'Why don't you come along?'

Same mistake yet again. Had Roopmani pleaded, Anand would most certainly have accompanied her. But her question in the first instance had an element of doubt hidden in it—that Anand did not want to go. The self-righteous Anand could not possibly have gone like that. He said in a melancholic voice, 'My going there would be futile. Your insistence would have a more indelible impact. He had left this letter on my table. When he is indulging in such lofty thoughts about conscience, duty and moral values and also considering himself a man of high stature, my persuasion will have no effect on him.'

Taking the letter out of his pocket, he placed it in front of Roopmani. For a moment, the implication and sarcasm in his words did not allow Roopmani to look in his direction. This heartless attack on Anand's part had somewhat hurt her but hardly had a moment lapsed when a streak of rebellion arose in her. She read the letter again. She read it only for the sake of answering Anand's assault and, while reading, her face acquired an almost tangible glow that seemed to have hardened it, her neck straightened and a flame of rebellion lit up her eyes.

Keeping the letter back on the table she said, 'No, now it's futile even for me to go there.'

Anand said, gloating in his victory, ‘I had told you earlier, at this moment he is obsessed with his passion and no legitimate suggestion will have any impact on him. Only after grinding stones in prison for a year and coming out from there with tuberculosis or after having his bones broken from the atrocities of the police will good sense prevail. Right now he must be dreaming of adulation and exultant approbation.’

Roopmani was gazing at the sky. There was a vague vision in the azure sky—a feeble, emaciated, naked body, clad in a knee-length dhoti; smooth head, toothless face; a living image of devotion, sacrifice and honesty.

Anand said again, ‘If I know that my blood will salvage the nation, I’m willing to offer it today. But what would fifty or a hundred men like me be worth? I don’t foresee any productive outcome other than the loss of lives.’

Roopmani was still gazing at that image. The same image was smiling—an easy, appealing smile; the same one that had won over the world.

Anand said again, ‘The great men who were tormented by the ghost of examinations are now occupied with thoughts of uplifting the state of the nation. I ask them—You are incapable of any self-reformation; how can you possibly reform the country? The blows of rods on that side are still lighter than any failure on this side.’

Roopmani’s eyes were turned to the sky. The image had metamorphosed into a concrete one.

Suddenly Anand exclaimed, ‘Oh yes, there’s an interesting film today. Will you come? We’ll be back after the first show!’

With thoughts cascading from the sky, Roopmani said, ‘No, I don’t feel like it.’

Holding her hands gently, Anand inquired, ‘Are you feeling all right?’ Roopmani made no effort to free her hands from his clasp. She said, ‘Yes, what can possibly be wrong with me?’

‘So why don’t you come?’

‘I don’t feel like it today.’

‘Then I too will not go.’

‘Excellent. Donate the amount from the tickets to the Congress.’

‘This is a tricky condition but I accept it.’

‘Show me the receipt tomorrow.’

‘Don’t you have even an iota of trust in me?’

Anand left for the hostel. Soon after, Roopmani headed in the direction of Swarajya Bhavan.

2

When Roopmani reached Swarajya Bhavan, a contingent of *swayam-sevak*s was leaving to picket a warehouse of foreign clothes. Vishambhar was not in the group.

Another group was preparing to go to liquor outlets. Vishambhar was not there either.

Roopmani went to the secretary and asked, ‘Could you tell me where Vishambhar Nath is?’

‘The one who was inducted today?’ asked the secretary.

‘Yes. That one.’

‘Very courageous fellow. He’s taken up the responsibility to work for the villages. He must have reached the station. He’s leaving by the seven o’clock train.’

‘So will he be at the station right now?’

Glancing at his watch the secretary said, ‘Yes, you might find him at the station right now.’

Coming out from the office Roopmani accelerated the speed of her cycle. When she reached the station she found Vishambhar standing on the platform.

Seeing Roopmani, he leapt forward to meet her and said, ‘How come you are here? Did you meet Anand today?’

Gazing at him from head to toe, Roopmani said, ‘Look at your state! Is it anti-national to wear shoes?’

Vishambhar inquired anxiously, ‘Did Anand Babu say nothing to you?’

Roopmani said with feigned sternness, ‘Yes, he wondered what had come upon you to take such a step? He also feels that you will be thrown in jail for not less than two years.’

Vishambhar's face fell. He said, 'When you are aware of this, don't you have even two words of motivation for me?'

Roopmani's heart melted. She, however, could not shrug off her façade.

She asked, 'Do you consider me a friend or a foe?'

With tearful eyes, Vishambhar's asked, 'Why do you ask such a question, Roopmani? Can you not fathom the answer without me having to say it?'

'Then I insist, don't go.'

'This is not what a friend would suggest, Roopmani. I firmly believe that you don't mean it. What is the value of my life! Just ponder over it. Despite being an MA, a mere hundred-rupee job! Even if I progress further, it will not be beyond three to four hundred rupees. And what will it be here in lieu of all this, do you know? Freedom for the entire nation! Even dying for a cause so eminent is far nobler than this life. Now go. The train is arriving. Tell Anand Babu not to be cross with me.'

Till now Roopmani had only sympathized with this feeble-minded youth. This moment he had become a source of reverence for her. In sacrifice lies a strong power of attraction and it pulled Roopmani in with such a velocity that it somewhat blurred the discrepancy between their respective circumstances. All blemishes of Vishambhar began to shine like embellishments. Like a bird, she began to fly in search of shelter in the vast expanse of his heart.

Looking at him with restless eyes, Roopmani said, 'Take me along with you.'

As if in a trance Vishambhar said, 'Take you along! Anand Babu will not spare me.'

'I am not a slave in Anand's hands.'

'Isn't Anand a slave in your hands?'

Roopmani looked at him with rebellious eyes but didn't say anything. Circumstances at that moment seemed full of hindrances to her. Why couldn't she be self-willed like Vishambhar? The only daughter of affluent parents, born and brought up in luxury, she was no less than a captive right now. Her conscience wanted to break free of those shackles.

The train arrived. Passengers alighted and boarded. Roopmani asked with tearful eyes, ‘Won’t you take me along?’

Vishambhar said resolutely, ‘No.’

‘Why?’

‘I don’t want to answer this question.’

‘Do you think I am so used to luxury that I cannot live in a village?’

Vishambhar felt ashamed. This was a prosaic rationale too; nonetheless he denied it, saying, ‘No, it’s not that.’

‘Then what’s the matter? Is it the fear that Pitaji will disown me?’

‘If that’s a fear, then isn’t it worth pondering over?’

‘I don’t care a bit about him.’

Vishambhar noticed on Roopmani’s moonlike face a sense of strong fortitude. Her resolve made him shiver. He said, ‘Please accept my entreaty, Roopmani. I implore you!’

Roopmani reflected on her thoughts.

Vishambhar implored again. ‘For my sake, you will have to let go of this thought.’

Bowing her head Roopmani said, ‘If this is your command, I shall accept it, Vishambhar. You believe that in a fit of momentary excitement I am going to ruin my future. I will show you that this is not an ephemeral thought but an unshakable resolution. Go, but do pay heed to what I say. Come into the clutches of the law only when there is a blow to your self-conceit or principles. I shall keep praying to Ishwar for your well-being.’

The train whistled. Vishambhar boarded it. The train moved on, Roopmani stood there as if encompassing all the treasures of the world in her *aanchal*.

3

Roopmani had an old photograph of Vishambhar lying in a forgotten corner of her almirah. Today, after returning from the station, she took it out and set it up in a velvet frame on her table. Anand’s photo was removed from there.

Vishambhar had written two or three letters to her during college vacations. Roopmani had tossed them aside after reading them cursorily. Today she took those letters out and read them again. Those letters were so full of meaning today! They were locked carefully in the writing box.

The next day when the newspaper arrived, Roopmani devoured it. Seeing Vishambhar's name in it, she swelled with pride.

Her visit to Swarajya Bhavan had become a daily routine. She attended their functions regularly. One by one all forms of casual enjoyment were given up. Intricately embroidered saris were replaced with handloom ones. Weaving on the charkha too was encouraged. For hours she would sit at it, spinning. Her weaving gradually acquired finesse. She would get kurtas made for Vishambhar out of this handwoven cotton.

Those were the days for exam preparations. Anand could barely get time to lift his head from his books. Once or twice he visited Roopmani but couldn't stay for long. Perhaps Roopmani's weariness did not allow him to prolong his visits.

A month passed.

One evening Anand came to meet Roopmani. She was about to leave for Swarajya Bhavan.

Anand frowned and said, 'It's hard to even catch a few words with you now.'

Sitting on a chair Roopmani replied, 'You hardly get any rest from your books either. I didn't get any latest update today. At Swarajya Bhavan you get a daily dose of activities.'

In a tone of philosophical indifference Anand stated, 'Vishambhar, I've heard, is creating quite a stir in the villages. He has got work he's suitable for. He would be so tongue-tied here! There he must be roaring among the rustics. He is, however, a courageous man.'

Roopmani looked at him disdainfully with eyes that seemed to say—'For you this talk is pointless.' She remarked, 'If a man has this quality, then all his shortcomings take a back seat. Why would *you* get any free time to read the Congress bulletin! Vishambhar has spread such awareness in the villages that not a single thread from a foreign country can make its way to

the market and neither does anyone venture to the liquor shops. And the best thing is that no one needs to picket there. People are forming panchayats now.'

Anand said in an indifferent tone, 'Then you can take it that the time has come for him to be thrown into prison.'

Roopmani said emphatically, 'It's not easy to accomplish what he has done. Yesterday a massive rally of farmers had been scheduled. People from the entire district must have assembled there. I've heard these days no dispute in villages is lodged in courts. The lawyers are in a sorry state.'

Anand said bitterly, 'This is the charm of Swaraj that landowners, lawyers and merchants all die; only labourers and farmers remain alive.'

Roopmani realized that Anand was in a foul mood. She too rolled up her sleeves and said, 'So what do you want? That the landowners, lawyers and the bourgeoisie should suck the life out of the poor and, in a societal setup where such disparities are the order of the day, no voices of dissent should be raised against them? You are an expert in social sciences. Can this situation be called ideal in any sense? Can the three basic requirements of civilization be fulfilled even minimally in such a situation?'

Anand said heatedly, 'Knowledge and wealth have always been supreme, and so it will always be. Yes, its form may undergo a change.'

Roopmani said fervently, 'If, even after the establishment of the home rule, the sovereignty of wealth remains and an educated society continues to be selfish, I would say we are better off without such independence. The greed of the Englishmen and the self-interest of the educated are exploiting us today. Should we as subjects endorse the very drawbacks we are attempting to get rid of by risking our lives, just because they are indigenous and not foreign to us? At least for me this is certainly not what Swaraj means—that Govind should take the place of John. I want to see a societal setup where at least such a disparity does not find shelter.'

Anand replied, 'This would be your fantasy.'

'Ah! You have not yet read the literature of this agitation.'

'Neither have I read nor would I want to read.'

'It wouldn't be a big loss to the nation.'

‘Roopmani, you are not what you used to be. You have changed.’

Just then the postman came in and placed the Congress bulletin on the table. Roopmani opened it impatiently. A glance at the first heading blurred her vision. Her neck stiffened and an ethereal glow spread over her countenance.

Standing up agitatedly she said, ‘Vishambhar has been arrested and imprisoned for two years.’

Anand asked indifferently, ‘For which issue has he been imprisoned?

Looking at Vishambhar’s photograph with pride, Roopmani said, ‘There was a huge gathering of farmers at Raniganj. He was arrested there.’

Anand said, ‘I told you earlier that he would be in for two years. His life is ruined.’

Roopmani reproached him. ‘Does obtaining a degree define a man’s success in life? Are only books the epitome of all knowledge and skill? I believe what empirical knowledge of worldly and humanistic traits Vishambhar will gain in two years, you will never be able to acquire through your philosophy and law scriptures even in two hundred years! If the aim of education is strengthening of character, all the innumerable resources for morale-building in the national struggle surpass those needed in the struggle for eradicating hunger. I am willing to accept your point of view if you say that for us, catering to the issue of hunger is enough and that we are incapable of handling anything else, that we have neither courage nor sufficient strength, neither patience nor organization. But I cannot tolerate it when those who lay down their lives for the sake of humanity are befooled. Lakhs of people would lay their chests bare at Vishambhar’s behest. Do you have such courage to stand before the masses? You lust for degrees to serve those very people who trample you under their feet and consider you worse than dogs! You may consider them a symbol of honour, I do not.’

Anand was furious. He said contemptuously, ‘You have become a real revolutionary now!’

Roopmani replied zealously, ‘If in honest and straight talk you smell the scent of revolution, then I am not at fault.’

‘Today there is bound to be a commemoration to honour Vishambhar. Will you go there?’

Roopmani said enthusiastically, ‘I will certainly go, and speak up too, and tomorrow I will even go to Raniganj. The lamp that Vishambhar has ignited will not be extinguished as long as I am alive.’

Anand tried holding on to the last straw. ‘Have you asked your Amma and Dada?’

‘I shall ask them.’

‘And will they grant you permission?’

‘In matters of principle it’s the voice of the conscience that is supreme.’

‘Oh, this is a new learning for me!’

Saying this Anand got up and left the room without shaking hands. He was staggering, on the verge of collapsing.

Translated from the Hindi by Ghazala Siddiqi



The Lunatic Lover

1

Manhar's heart was overflowing with emotion as he said, 'All this is the culmination of your sacrifice, Vaagi, else I would be spending dark days inside a dark house in a dark lane all my life. I will always remember your service and favours; you have transformed my life for the better. You've made me a man.'

Vaagi, her head bowed, replied humbly, 'I would only consider this your goodness; otherwise how am I, a poor creature, capable of improving your life? Yes, I will also transform myself into a human being with you one day. You worked hard and were rewarded for that. God helps those who help themselves. If a boorish woman like me had been forced upon someone other than you, who knows what harm would have befallen me!'

Manhar, as if bent upon reinforcing his point of view in this debate, said, 'I can sacrifice one lakh dressed-up dolls and colourful butterflies for a boorish woman like you. You gave me the opportunity and time to work hard without which one cannot succeed at all. If you had also crushed me with demands like your other luxury-loving sisters with frivolous temperaments, I would never have got an opportunity to progress in life. You gave me freedom from worries in a way that I did not experience even in my schooldays. I pity my other colleagues when I look at them. Nobody

is able to make both ends meet. Their pockets are empty before half the month is over. One borrows from his friends, another writes to his folks for money. One is dying of worry over ornaments, another over clothes. One is perplexed looking for a servant, another is worried seeking a doctor. No one is at peace. Every other day, husbands and wives squabble. I cannot see anyone as lucky as me. I have all the joys of home life and no responsibilities. You always encouraged me and gave me the impetus to move forward. Whenever my courage failed me, you gave me comfort. I will always keep the memory of these services safe in my heart, Vaagi. And a day will come when you will reap the benefits of your sacrifice and devotion.'

Overwhelmed, Vaagi said, 'Your words are my greatest reward, Manu. I am not hungry for any other reward. I had never expected such appreciation for the little service I rendered you.'

At this moment, Manhar's heart overflowed with generous thoughts. Otherwise he was a dull person, a man of few words. Vaageshwari might have been unhappy about this. But right now, the intoxication of his success had given wings to his speech. He said, 'I was very apprehensive when negotiations for my marriage were on. I jumped to the conclusion that I had achieved whatever I had to achieve in life and now I would have to spend the rest of my life in fulfilling the wishes of this goddess I was getting married to. After going through the books of great English scholars, I had also started hating the institution of marriage. I had started looking at it as life imprisonment which closes doors to a person's spiritual and intellectual development, which makes a person a worshipper of selfishness, which narrows one's sympathies. But I realized my mistake within two to four months. I realized that a good wife is the greatest wealth of heaven, who makes a man complete and who is the main mantra for the soul's development. I realized that the purpose of marriage is not carnal pleasure but the development of one's soul.'

Vaageshwari's humility could not take it any more. She left the place on some pretext.

Three years had passed since Manhar and Vaageshwari got married. Manhar was a clerk in an office at that time. Like all ordinary people, he too was very fond of reading detective novels. Gradually he also developed an interest in being a detective. He collected a lot of literature on this subject and studied it thoroughly. After this, he himself wrote a book on the subject. He displayed such extraordinary analytical power in his book and his style was so interesting that people just lapped it up. This was the best treatise available on the subject.

Manhar's book elicited an enthusiastic response in the country. So much so that he received commendatory letters from countries like Italy and Germany and rave reviews were published in eminent journals dealing with this subject. At last, the government gave evidence of its being a connoisseur and gave him a stipend to go and practise the subject in England. All this was the result of Vaageshwari's inspiration.

Manhar wished that Vaageshwari could accompany him but Vaageshwari did not want to be an impediment in his progress. She considered it right to stay at home and serve her father and mother-in-law.

England was another world for Manhar, where a pretty wife was one of the main means to progress. If a wife is beautiful, lively, clever, has the gift of the gab, the husband is said to have got a gold mine and is sure to reach the pinnacle of progress—not on the basis of his mental prowess and dedication but because of his wife's influence and attractiveness. In this world, beauty was its own reward. If a person acquired a pretty woman, good fortune smiled on him. If your life partner was not a pretty woman, then all your hard work, your dexterity would be meaningless, nobody would ask how you are; therefore people looked at beauty from a commercial angle.

Within a year, contact with English society brought about a revolution in Manhar's mindset. Worldliness became such a priority in his temperament that there was no space for tender feelings. Vaageshwari was a companion in his academic pursuits but she could not have taken him to any lofty height of position and authority. Her sacrifice and service came to mean less and less in Manhar's eyes. Vaageshwari now appeared to be a useless object

to him because in his materialistic vision the value of everything depended on its probable profits. He found his early life ridiculous. Vaagi seemed like a trivial object compared to the lively, ever-smiling and humorous young Englishwomen. In this bright light, that lamp had become tarnished, so much so, that slowly, even its dim light had disappeared from view.

Manhar took a decision about his future. He too would attain his target through the beauty of a young woman. There was no other way.

2

It was nine o'clock at night Dressed to the nines, Manhar was sitting in a fashionable London restaurant. Looking at his complexion and demeanour, one could not make out that he was not an Englishman. Luck had favoured him even in London. He had solved many complicated cases of theft, and that is why he was getting both money and fame. He had now become a leading member of London's Indian society, well known and appreciated for its hospitality and courtesy by one and all. His diction and intonation were also very similar to those of the British. Across the table, a pretty woman was listening to him intently. Every pore of her body was bursting with youth. Her eyes were shining with joy as she heard Manhar's astonishing descriptions of India. He was trying to ensnare her.

Manhar said, 'It's a fantastic land, Jenny, really fantastic. You will not find five-year-old bridegrooms anywhere except in India. Red embroidered apparel, shining long headgear, a curtain of tasselled blossoms on the face, atop a horse! Two men holding umbrellas on both sides. Henna on both hands!'

'Why do they apply henna?'

'So that their hands turn red. Feet are also coloured. Toenails are painted red. It's a scene that's worth beholding.'

'This must be a thrilling scene indeed. Is the bride also adorned in a similar fashion?'

'Many, many times more. She is laden with gold and silver ornaments from top to toe. There is no part of her body that does not have two to four

ornaments.'

'You must have got married in a similar way. You must have enjoyed yourself thoroughly?'

'Yes, the same joy that you get from a ride on the merry-go-round. You get nice things to eat, nice clothes to wear. I watched a lot of dance and revelry and listened to the strains of shehnai. It's great fun when a bride leaves her parental home. The entire house is plunged into mourning. The bride hugs everyone present and wails as if she were in a state of mourning.'

'Why does the bride cry?'

'Because it is part of convention. Although everyone knows that she is not going forever, the entire household cries profusely as if she were being sent for life imprisonment.'

'I would laugh at such a spectacle!'

'Perhaps it is a matter worth laughing at.'

'Your wife must have cried too.'

'Don't even ask! She was swooning as if I was going to strangulate her. She was trying to run away from the palanquin but I forced her to continue sitting next to me. Then she rushed to bite me.'

Jenny burst into a boisterous laugh, doubling over in a fit of giggles. 'Horrible! Horrible! Does she still bite you?'

'She is not in this world now, Jenny. I got a lot of work out of her. When I slept, she massaged my body, oiled my hair and fanned me.'

'I can't believe this. She was totally foolish.'

'Don't ask! During the day, she would not talk to me in front of people but I continued to chase her.'

'Oh, naughty boy, you are very wicked. Was she pretty?'

'Yes, her face was like the back of your foot.'

'Nonsense! You would never have chased such a woman.'

'I was stupid at that time, Jenny.'

'Why did you marry such a stupid woman?'

'My parents would have poisoned themselves if I had not got married.'

'How did she start loving you?'

‘What else could she do? Who else was there for her? She could not step out of the house, but neither of us loved the other. Jenny, she could not satiate my soul and heart. When I remember those days, it’s like a horrendous dream. Uff, if that woman were alive today, I would have been slogging in an office somewhere. I learnt the truth about a woman’s position in the world, her responsibilities and how she can make a man’s life full of happiness—but this was only after I came to this country. The day I met you was the most blessed day of my life. Do you remember that day? Your countenance is still fresh in my mind’s eye.’

‘I must leave now. You have started flattering me.’

3

Lord Barber was the secretary of India’s Peasant Party, and Mr Coward was his secretary. Lord Barber was considered to be a true friend of India. When the Conservatives and the Liberals were in control, Lord Barber used to defend India vehemently. He used to aim such barbs at these ministers that the poor souls did not know how to respond! Once he had come to India and participated in the activities of the Congress. At that time, his generous lectures had spread a wave of joy in the entire country. After the Congress convention, wherever he went, people waited for him with bated breath, pulled his carriages and showered flowers on him. Everyone said that here was the man who would deliver India. People started believing that if, due to India’s good fortunes, Lord Barber was given the position, that would be a blessed day in the history of India.

But Lord Barber changed in a strange manner as soon as he got the office. His generosity, love of justice and sense of sympathy got lost in the quagmire of control. And now there was no distinction between him and his predecessors. He was doing exactly what his predecessors had done. It was a similar attitude of oppression, the same kind of racial pride and rigidity. This god had lost his godliness the moment he ascended the throne. During his two-year tenure, he had appointed hundreds of officers but not one of these was an Indian. Disappointed Indians had started calling him a money-

worshipper and priest of imperialism. This was an open secret that whatever was done was actually done by Mr Coward. Mr Barber had the intentions of a lion but his heart was weak. However, the results were the same in both cases.

Mr Coward was a great man—one of a kind. He had crossed forty but had not got married yet. Perhaps he thought that married life could not be enjoyed as long as one was in the field of politics. In reality, he was a seeker of new excitement. He sought ever-new joys and attractions, ever-new confidences and merriments. It was easier to be happy roaming around in a garden laid out by someone else than laying out one's garden oneself and getting hassled in tending and decorating it. From his pragmatic and materialistic point of view, the former was preferable to the latter.

It was afternoon. Mr Coward was smoking a cigar after breakfast when he heard of the arrival of Miss Jenny Rose. He checked his face in the mirror immediately, straightened his untidy hair, applied expensive perfume, came out of the room wearing a smile and a welcoming look, and shook hands with Miss Jenny.

As soon as she entered the room, Jenny said, 'Now I understand why no beautiful woman inquires about you! You do not know how to fulfil your promises.'

Mr Coward pulled a chair for Jenny and said, 'I am very sorry, Miss Rose, that I could not fulfil my promise yesterday. A private secretary's life is worse than that of a dog. Every time I wanted to get up and leave office, I'd get one call or the other and be forced to stay back. Please forgive me. I hope you enjoyed yourself at the ball.'

Jenny said, 'I kept looking for you. When I did not find you, I felt so disheartened. I did not dance with anyone else. If you did not wish to go, why did you send me an invitation?'

Coward offered a cigar to Jenny and said, 'You are making me feel ashamed of myself, Jenny! What could bring me greater joy than dancing with you? I can imagine that joy even though I am an old bachelor. You just understand that I yearned and yearned and did nothing.'

Jenny said with a hard smile, ‘You deserve to remain a bachelor. This is your punishment.’

Enthralled, Coward replied, ‘You are very cruel, Jenny! Not only you; all beautiful women are cruel. Whatever compulsion I might talk of, you won’t trust me. How I wish a pretty woman would appreciate my love and devotion.’

‘If at all you had love inside you! Pretty women do not encourage such pretenders!’

‘You called me a pretender again—why don’t you say helpless?’

‘I do not accept anyone’s helplessness. This cannot be a matter of joy and pride to me that when you get free from your official, semi-official and unofficial work, you trouble your soft feet for a minute so that my mind is at rest. I do not want to listen to office and work-related excuses. That is why you are still cribbing.’

Coward said in a serious manner, ‘You are being unfair to me, Jenny. Why am I still unmarried? Till yesterday, I did not know the reason myself. Only yesterday the reason occurred to me on its own.’

Jenny made fun of him and said, ‘All right! So you know the secret now? Then I must say you really possess self-knowledge. Let me also hear the reason.’

Coward said ardently, ‘I had not found a pretty woman who could bewitch me.’

Jenny said with wry humour, ‘I had thought such a woman had not even been born in this world—a woman who could intoxicate you. You only wish to intoxicate and not get intoxicated.’

‘You’re a tormentor, Jenny!’

‘Do you wish to give some proof of your intoxication?’

‘With all my heart, Jenny. I am waiting to grab the opportunity.’

That very evening, Jenny said to Manhar, ‘I congratulate you on your good fortune! You’ve got that position.’

Manhar sprang to his feet and said, ‘Really? Did you have a conversation with the secretary?’

Jenny said, ‘I did not have to say anything to the secretary. It’s all up to Coward. I led him up the garden path. He started making declarations of love. Fifty years old, he is going bald and his cheeks are wrinkled, but he is still obsessed with love. He thinks he is the only amorous person around. His old antics look so indecent but I have to tolerate everything for your sake. Anyway, my hard work has borne fruit. Tomorrow you will get the letter. Now we should get ready for the journey.’

Delighted, Manhar said, ‘You have done me a great favour, Jenny.’

4

Manhar got a high position in the Secret Services. National newspapers praised him no end, his photograph was published and he was congratulated on behalf of the nation. He was the first Indian to be honoured with this high position. The British Government proved that its sense of justice is higher than its racial pride and discrimination.

Manhar and Jenny got married in England. They spent their honeymoon month in France. From there they both came to India. Manhar’s office was in Bombay. They started living in a hotel there. Manhar had to travel frequently on his secret service missions. It was Kashmir sometimes, sometimes Madras and sometimes Rangoon. Jenny used to be with him constantly during these travels. There were new sights every day, new entertainment and new distractions. What could be a better source of delight for his novelty-seeking nature?

Manhar’s style of living was already English; now he had severed ties with his family as well. Let alone responding to Vaagi’s letters, he would not even open them to read. In India, he was forever apprehensive that his family might come to know his whereabouts. He wished to continue hiding his real position from Jenny. He did not even inform his family about his arrival in India. So much so that he met Indians very rarely. Most of his friends were officers in the police and the army. They alone were his guests. Eloquent Jenny was well-versed in the art of hypnotism. Playing with men’s love was her most pleasurable activity. She would make him jealous and

captivate his mind, and Manhar continued to be a victim of her guiles. She always kept him in a labyrinth of her own making. Sometimes she would draw close enough to bedazzle him, and she would never retreat so far that there could be an impediment in their union. Sometimes she was cruel and hard, and sometimes impatient and needy for love. She was a mystery that he could fathom at times and would be bewildered by at others.

Two years passed like this, and Manhar and Jenny drifted apart from each other like the two arms of an angle. Manhar could not get rid of the feeling that Jenny had a special duty towards him. This could be attributed to his narrow vision or his sense of respect for the traditions of the clan. He wanted to see Jenny under his control. Her liberal temperament was a matter of shame for him. He used to forget that Jenny's initial contact with him was itself based on selfishness. Perhaps he had thought that with time Jenny would become aware of her duties in life even though he knew that a house built on an uneven foundation would crumble to the ground sooner or later. There was a greater possibility of this happening as one reached higher.

On the contrary, Jenny's behaviour was totally in sync with the circumstances. She had considered Manhar an instrument for a life of fun and luxury and she was still stuck on that. In her mind, she could not accord this man the position of a husband, this statue made of stone could not be her deity. Becoming a wife was not a dream that she cherished, and therefore she did not accept any duty towards him. She never felt obliged to Manhar for laying his hard-earned money at her feet. Manhar was an image created by her, a tree she had planted. She considered it her sole right to enjoy its shade and fruit.

5

Their differences grew as time passed. Eventually Manhar stopped accompanying Jenny to parties and events but she continued to gallivant around as always, meeting friends, throwing parties and attending soirées. She did not feel any sorrow or disappointment at not going out with

Manhar; perhaps she felt happier at his indifference. Manhar did his best to drown his mental agony by drinking. He had started drinking when he was in England but now he would drink a lot more than before. There he used to drink for energy and joy, here he drank in order to lose his energy and joy. He was getting thinner day by day. He knew that liquor was consuming him but this was all that was left in his life.

It was summer. Manhar was camping in Lucknow for the investigation of a case. It was a serious matter. He did not get a moment's rest. His health was deteriorating but Jenny was engrossed in her travels. One day she declared, 'I am leaving for Nainital. I cannot stand this heat.'

Manhar rolled his eyes in anger and asked, 'What do you have to do in Nainital?' He was bent upon exerting his rights.

Equally determined to denigrate his rights, Jenny said, 'There is no social life here. All of Lucknow society has moved to Nainital.'

Getting ready to attack, Manhar said, 'As long as I am here, you have no right to go anywhere. You married me and not society. You can clearly see that I am sick, even then you cannot stop your pursuit of pleasure. I did not expect this from you, Jenny. I considered you to be a decent woman. I did not suspect even in my dreams that you would be so ungrateful to me.'

Jenny said, unwavering, 'So, did you think that I would also live as your servant like your Indian wife did, and caress your feet? I do not consider you to be so ignorant. If you do not know even this broad fact about English culture, then understand now that an Englishwoman does not obey anyone except her inclinations. You married me because you needed my help in getting honour and position. All men do this and you did the same. I do not call you bad but now that your purpose for which you married me is fulfilled, why do you expect more from me? You are an Indian and cannot be an Englishman, therefore neither of us has the right to make the other a slave to his wishes.'

Dumbfounded, Manhar sat listening to her. Each word went down his throat like poison. This was the hard truth. In his utter excitement of getting a position, in the torrential flow of his thirst for luxury, he had quite forgotten that there is such an element in life compared to which position

and luxury have no more value than toys of glass. He regretted having forgotten that truth at a crucial moment of his life but now he had to face its consequences.

Jenny left for Nainital in the evening. Manhar did not even lift his eyes to look at her.

6

Manhar did not step out of the house for three days. On closer scrutiny, all the jewels that he had proudly collected over the past five or six years of his life and had considered himself blessed that he got them were proving to be fake. His insulted, repentant, defeated soul found solace only in solitary wailing. Giving up his dilapidated hut, any golden-domed mansion that he had lunged to grab turned out to be a mirage. Now he again remembered the broken hut where he had drunk the nectar of peace, love and blessings. This life of ostentation began to bite him. Compared to that simple, soothing affection, all material comforts seemed insignificant. On the third day, he got up with a momentous resolution and wrote two letters. One was a letter of resignation from his job, the other was his final farewell to Jenny.

He wrote in his resignation letter:

> My health has declined and I cannot bear this burden.

In his letter to Jenny he wrote:

> Both of us made a mistake and we should correct it as soon as possible. I hereby free you from all bindings. You also grant me freedom. I have no relation with you. It is neither your fault nor mine. Times changed, for you as well as for me. I have resigned from my job. Now you have no claim over me. Whatever I have is yours. I am leaving all that behind. I was only an instrument, you were the lord and master. I salute that civilization from a distance, which does not accept the sanctity of any bonds over fun and sensuality.

He mailed the two letters by registered post and got ready to leave without waiting for a response.

7

Jenny smiled as she read Manhar's letter. She was so accustomed to ruling over his desires that this letter did not perplex her one bit. She was sure that she would be able to bring him round again by talking sweetly for a day or two. She thought, had Manhar not intended only to threaten her, had his heart been truly wounded, he would not have been around all this while; he would have left a long time ago. The fact that he had continued to stay here indicated that his was only an empty threat.

Jenny changed her dress in a calm and composed manner, and entered Manhar's room as though she had stepped on to a stage for a performance.

Manhar burst into laughter the moment he saw her. Jenny stepped back in terror.

There was no anger or revenge in this laughter. It was full of madness. A bottle and a glass were on a table in front of Manhar. No one knew how much liquor he had consumed in one day! It seemed as though blood was boiling in his eyes.

Jenny came closer and placed her hand on his shoulder, saying, 'Will you continue drinking the whole night? Relax and lie down, it's getting late. I have been waiting for you for hours. You were never so cruel.'

Manhar said in a resigned manner, 'When did you come, Vaagi? Look, I have been asking you for a long time. Come, let's go for a walk today. Sing me that sweet song on the riverbank, the song that makes me crazy. What do you say? Am I impolite? This is not fair, Vaagi. I swear, not a day passed when I did not cry remembering you.'

Jenny shook him by the shoulders and said, 'What nonsense are you muttering? Where is Vaagi? She is not here.'

Manhar looked at her without a hint of recognition and laughed loudly. 'I will not accept this, Vaagi. You will have to come with me. I will make a garland of flowers for you . . .'

Jenny understood that Manhar had drunk too much. He was delirious, mixing truth and imagination. There was no point in talking to him now. She left the room quietly. She had suspected this before, but now she was certain—a man who cannot control his tongue cannot control his desires.

From that moment on, Manhar started asking for his family incessantly. He would call out for Vaageshwari, sometimes for Amma and sometimes for Dada. His soul wandered in the past, a past on which Jenny's black shadow had not yet been cast, and where Vaageshwari spread her light in his life through her simple austerities.

The next day, Jenny went to him and said, 'Why do you drink so much? Don't you realize your condition?'

Manhar looked at her with wonder and asked, 'Who are you?'

'Don't you recognize me? Forgotten so fast?'

'I have never seen you before. I do not recognize you.'

Jenny did not say anything more. She had the liquor bottles removed from Manhar's room and instructed the servants not to give him even a drop of alcohol. She began to have misgivings. Manhar's condition was more precarious than what she had thought. Manhar's life and his health were essential for her survival. She could ride this horse and hunt. Without a horse, hunting was no fun.

But Manhar's condition did not change even after a week had passed. He did not recognize his friends nor his servants. His life of the past three years seemed to have been erased—as though it had been a dream.

On the seventh day, when Jenny appeared with a civil surgeon, Manhar was nowhere to be found.

8

After a gap of five years, Vaageshwari's lost conjugal joy returned.

Manhar's parents had turned blind shedding tears over their son's separation. Vaageshwari was still hopeful in her despair. Her parental home was prosperous, and invitations from there came repeatedly, beseeching her to return to them. Her father and brother even came by turns to persuade her, but this goddess of patience and austerity did not budge from her marital home.

When Manhar had returned to India, Vaageshwari heard that he had got a *mem* from England. Even then she hoped he would come, but her hope did

not materialize. Then she heard that he had converted to Christianity. When she heard that he had discarded his lifestyle and thinking, she cursed her destiny.

Conditions at home had deteriorated fast. The rains had ceased and the reservoirs had started drying up. The house was sold, and so was the little piece of land they owned. Now they were only dependent on the rains from heaven. Sometimes the kitchen fires burned; at other times the hearth remained cold.

One evening when she went to the well to fetch water, a tired, frail, crestfallen man came and sat on the parapet around it. Vaageshwari looked at him: it was Manhar! She drew her veil down immediately. Her eyes could not believe what she saw.

Even then her heart fluttered with joy and surprise. She left the rope and the vessel on the well, rushed home and told her mother-in-law, 'Ammaji, just go to the well and see who is there.'

Her mother-in-law said, 'Did you go to the well to fetch water or to see a spectacle? There is not a drop of water at home. Who has come to the well?'

'Why don't you come and see?'

'Must be a soldier from the army. Who else would come here except them? Are you sure it is not a moneylender?'

'No, Amma, why don't you come along?'

Entertaining various apprehensions, when the old woman reached the well, Manhar clung to her feet. His mother pressed him to her heart and said, 'Is this your condition, Manu? Are you sick? Where is your luggage?'

Manhar said, 'Let me eat something first, Amma! I am very hungry. I have been walking a long distance.'

News spread in the village that Manhar had arrived. People ran to see him, wondering what splendour he had brought along. After all, didn't he hold a high position and earn thousands of rupees? He must have come in style. Had the mem come with him or not?

But when they arrived on the scene, they saw that he had returned as a crestfallen man—his clothes were in shreds and his hair was dishevelled, as

if he had come back from prison.

There was a volley of questions: 'We had heard that you are holding a high position?'

Manhar tried to remember a forgotten tale, but without success. 'I! No, I have not held any high position.'

'*Wah*, didn't you bring a mem from *vilayat*?'

Manhar said in astonishment, 'England? Who had gone to England?'

'Arré, are you drugged? Didn't you go to England?'

Manhar laughed like a fool. 'What would I do in England?'

'Mister, didn't you get a scholarship? You went to England from here. Your letters arrived regularly. Now you say you did not go to England at all. Are you in your senses or are you making fools of us?'

Manhar looked at them with wide eyes and said, 'I had not gone anywhere. I don't know what you are saying.'

Now there was no room for doubt that he was not in his senses. He remembered everything that had happened prior to his departure for England. He recognized every person in the village and at home, he talked to everyone with humility and love, but whenever someone referred to England, or his English wife and high position, he gazed in bewilderment.

Vaageshwari began to observe an unnatural attachment in his love that she found artificial. She wished that his behaviour and character could be informal like before. She did not want a spectacle of love, but love itself. In five or ten days she realized that this special love was not due to artificiality or exhibitionism but because of a mental illness. Manhar had never respected his parents to this extent. But now he was not hesitant to execute even the grossest of chores. He who used to consider it an insult to fetch vegetables from the market now fetched water from the well and was praised for his service and humility not only in his home but throughout the locality.

Once there was a theft in the locality. The police tried very hard to track down the thieves but met with no success. Manhar, however, not only cracked the case but also recovered the lost property. His fame spread in the neighbouring villages and localities. If there was a theft, people would

come running to him and, most of the time, his hard work would pay off. This way, he managed a means of livelihood. He was now a slave to Vaageshwari's instructions. His days were spent in winning her heart and serving her. If there was any symptom of his aberration or disease, it was only manifested in this devotion to please her.

Vaageshwari was unhappy to see his condition, although in his sickness he was dearer to her than when he was healthy and not quite bothered about her.

9

One day, after six months, Jenny, who had been looking for Manhar, appeared in the village. Having squandered all that she had in her possession, she needed financial support. There was no one among her admirers who could help her with money. Perhaps she was a bit remorseful. She was ashamed of what she had done.

On hearing the car horn, Manhar came out and looked at Jenny as if he had never seen her before.

Jenny got out of the car and shook hands with him, and began to narrate her story: 'Why did you leave me without my knowledge? And then you did not write to me even once. After all, what harm had I done to you? If you had seen a flaw in me, you should have warned me. What did you gain by coming here without my knowledge? You had got such a good position and that too slipped through your fingers.'

Manhar stood like a wooden owl, bewildered.

Jenny said again, 'You'd be agitated if I told you the way I suffered after you left. I became sick with worry and pain. My life became meaningless without you. I consoled myself by looking at your photograph. Reading your letters from beginning to end was the most entertaining thing for me. You come with me now. I have spoken to a doctor, he is a psychiatrist. I hope you will benefit from his treatment.'

Manhar assumed a detached manner, as if he could not see or hear anything.

Suddenly, Vaageshwari came out. As soon as she saw Jenny, she guessed that this was her European co-wife. She invited her inside with respect and in a spirit of hospitality. Manhar followed them.

Sitting on the broken cot, Jenny said, 'He must have talked to you about me. Our marriage took place in London.'

Vaageshwari said, 'I understood this as soon as I saw you.'

Jenny asked, 'Did he never mention my name?'

Vaageshwari replied, 'Never. He does not remember anything. Finding your way here must have caused you a great deal of trouble.'

Jenny said, 'Only after months and months was I able to find his address. He left without saying anything or listening to anyone.'

'Do you know what his problem is?'

'He had started drinking too much. Have you consulted a doctor?'

'We have not consulted anyone.'

Jenny said scornfully, 'Why? Do you wish to keep him sick forever?'

Vaageshwari replied carelessly, 'For me, his sickness is better than his health. He had forgotten his soul then, now he has found it.' Then she added, with callous sarcasm, 'In my opinion, he was sick then and is healthy now.'

Irritated, Jenny said, 'Nonsense! He will have to be treated by a specialist. He is an expert detective. All his senior officers were happy with him. He can regain that position even now. He can reach the highest level in his department. I am confident that his disease is not incurable, although it is indeed strange. Are you his sister?'

Vaageshwari smiled and said, 'You are cursing me! He is my husband.'

For Jenny, it was like a thunderbolt. She discarded her affected humility and her hidden anger surfaced. The veins of her neck throbbed and her fists clenched. Frantically she said, 'What a treacherous man! He has deceived me. He had told me that his wife had died. What a great scoundrel! He isn't really mad. He is feigning madness. I will get him punished in a court of law!' She shuddered in anger. Then, crying, she said, 'I will teach him a lesson for his treachery. Oh! He has insulted me to this extent! No punishment is big enough for such an enormous breach of trust. With what

sweet words he had trapped me! I got him an important position in his career, he became a big man because of my efforts alone. I left my home, my country for him and he betrayed me like this!'

Jenny sat cradling her head in her hands. Then she got up in a rage and, reaching out for Manhar and dragging him close to herself, she said, 'I will destroy you. Who do you think I am?'

Manhar stood calmly, as if he had nothing to do with her.

Then she charged at Manhar like a lioness, dashing him to the ground, and mounted his chest to strike him. Grabbing her hand, Vaageshwari restrained her and said, 'Had you not been such a witch, would he have been reduced to such a state?'

Agitated, Jenny pulled a pistol out of her pocket and lunged towards Vaageshwari. Suddenly Manhar got up in a fury, grabbed the loaded pistol from her hand, threw it away and stood in front of Vaageshwari. Then his facial expression changed, as if nothing had happened.

At that very moment, Manhar's mother awoke from her afternoon siesta. Looking first at Jenny, she glanced at Vaageshwari with questioning eyes.

Vaageshwari said jokingly, 'This is your daughter-in-law!'

The old woman muttered, 'What sort of daughter-in-law is this? This monkey, is she worthy to be my daughter-in-law? Who knows what spell she has cast on my boy? And now she's come to torment me.'

Jenny glared at Manhar with bloodshot eyes for a moment. Then, quick as lightning, she picked up the pistol from the courtyard and turned to shoot Vaageshwari, when Manhar came in between, shielding her. Undaunted, he confronted Jenny, snatched the pistol from her hand and shot himself in the chest.

Translated from the Hindi by Neerja M. Chand

* The lunatic, the lover, and the poet
Are of imagination all compact.

William Shakespeare, *A Midsummer Night's Dream*, V.1.



Dhaporsankh

In Moradabad there's a friend of mine whom, in my heart, I consider a gem but whom I call Dhaporsankh, and he doesn't even mind. Had God given him even half the brains as he had given him heart, today he would have been someone else! I always found him short of money but he never begged anyone for it. He and I used to be classmates, so there was no formality between us, but despite knowing that it was no big deal for me to help him out with fifty-odd bucks and that I would be only too glad to do so, he never asked me for even a penny. If I gave the hesitating children a couple of bucks while saying goodbye, I would be saddled with double the worth of gifts of Moradabadi ware. That is why I have made it a rule that whenever I go to him, I give him as sound a blow as I can in those one or two days. I eat the most expensive of seasonal foods and keep demanding to be fed these. Yet he is so sentimental that if ever I try to slip by without meeting him, he rebukes me bitterly. Of late, I hadn't met him for two or three years. I longed to see him. In May, while on my way to Nainital, I stopped by to meet him. Small house, small family, small space. At the doorway I called out, 'Dhaporsankh!' He came out immediately and embraced me. Picking up my trunk from the tonga, he placed it on his shoulder, tucked my bedding under his arm and entered the house. I might have said, 'Let me carry my bedding,' but who would listen to me? The moment I stepped in, I

caught sight of Deviji, his wife. A small child came and touched my feet. That's all the family there is.

When I entered the room, I found that a veritable office of letters had been spread out. Surely, keeping letters so securely was not a habit of his? Who had written so many letters? Mystified, I asked, 'What's all this rubbish you've spread out? Put them away.'

Deviji smiled and said, 'Don't call it rubbish. Each and every letter is a literary masterpiece. You haven't been here lately. A new friend of his has been born. This is the prasad of those lotus-like hands.'

Dhaporsankh screwed up his small eyes and said, 'I just can't understand why you get so inflamed at his name? If he owes you a couple of hundred rupees, I am the one who lent them to him. He is still alive and kicking. Why do you consider anyone to be a fraud? Why can't you understand that he doesn't have the means now to repay? And besides, if a couple of hundreds are sunk by a friend, why cry over it? Agreed that we are poor and that a few hundred rupees are as valuable to us as a couple of lakhs but, after all, it is a friend who has used it!'

Deviji was as sharp-tongued as she was beautiful. She said, 'If these are the people you call friends, I wonder who you call an enemy.'

Dhaporsankh shot a conspiratorial glance at me to convey what he had in his mind—*Women have such closed minds!*

How could Deviji tolerate such an insult to the fairer sex? Her eyes spitting fire, she said, 'Instead of admitting that he has made a fool of you, you're trying to act high and mighty! It's no surprise that one claims to like dry food after the dal spills out. I know that money is of no importance. I also know that we get what's written in our destiny, but I will never accept that he was a gentleman or a man of principle or whatnot. Why don't you just accept that he was a parasite and a traitor? That's it. I have no quarrel with you.'

Getting agitated, Dhaporsankh said, 'I cannot agree with this.' Deviji got equally worked up and replied, 'You have to agree. Mahashayji has also come. I declare him the *panch*. If *he* says that that he was the very epitome of gentlemanliness, a principled man and a braveheart, then I will accept it

and never take his name again. And if his decision is in my favour, you will have to yield to him as you would to my brother!'

I said, 'I can't understand a thing. Who are you talking about? Who was he?'

Rolling her eyes, Deviji said, 'Ask him only who he was. His brother-in-law!'

Abashed, Dhaporsankh said, 'Oh, he was a literature buff by the name of Karunakar Joshi. The poor fellow was stuck here because of his circumstances! At that time she too would go about calling him Bhaiya, make halva to feed him, shed copious tears at his tales of woe, and now he is a traitor, a parasite and a useless fellow.'

Deviji said, 'That was for your sake. I used to think that you write, deliver discourses, have such deep insight into literature, surely you would be able to gauge people for what they are. But now I realize that it is one thing to move your pen and quite another to understand the pulse of a human being.'

I became eager to hear the details. Dhaporsankh was more than ready to narrate his woes. But Deviji said, 'Once we are through with eating and drinking, the panchayat can be convened.' I too agreed with this.

While going into the house, Deviji said, 'You must swear not to say a word about Joshi right now. Till I finish preparing the meal and you finish eating it, I impose Rule 144 upon both of you!'

Dhaporsankh winked and said, 'After eating your meal, he will surely take your side!'

This time the sentence didn't reach Deviji's ears. It had been spoken softly, else she would certainly have retaliated with something or the other. When Deviji had lit the stove and Dhaporsankh was sure she was busy, he told me, 'Till she's in the kitchen, shall I narrate the entire matter to you in brief ?'

Shielding myself under the pretext of ethics, I said, 'No, brother, I've been made the sarpanch and I won't hear anything about this matter now. Let her come.'

‘I’m afraid that your decision will be akin to hers and then she will make my life in this house impossible.’

I reassured him, ‘How can you predict what my decision will be?’

‘I know you too well. In your courtroom no man can win over a woman.’

‘So do you want me to take out a decree in your name?’

‘As a friend, don’t I have the right to expect even this much from you?’

‘Very well, you will win no matter how much I am cursed thereafter.’

By the time we finished with the meal, it was afternoon. I had been awake all night. I wanted to take some rest but Deviji wasn’t going to agree. She landed up after her meal. Dhaporsankh gathered his papers in a bundle and started narrating his tale.

Deviji warned, ‘Dare you utter even one lie, you will be fined.’

Dhaporsankh said gravely, ‘Only they whose side is weak lie. I have full faith in my victory.’

After this, the narration started.

‘More than two years ago, I got a letter one day in which, thanks to my literary forays, I was induced to write the preface for a play. It was Joshi’s letter. It was through this literary exchange that I was first introduced to him. The miserable condition of literary writers in our times is something I have experienced and continue to do so, and if it is limited to forewords, I have no hesitation in taking it on. I immediately sent a reply, Please send the play. The play arrived within a week but this time the letter not only asked me to write the preface but also begged me to find a publisher for it. I don’t get into the fray of publishers. The one odd time I did, some friends became my sworn enemies. I read the play, wrote the preface and sent back the handwritten manuscript. I had found the play to be good, so my preface commended it. I had written the preface for so many books. It was nothing new, but this time I was not free even after writing it. A week later, a piece of writing reached me, asking that it be published in my gazette. (Dhaporsankh was the editor of a gazette.) You may call it a virtue or a vice, but I tend to trust people very easily. And when it comes to literary writers, my instinct to trust them gets heightened. I have this friend who runs away from even the shadow of writers. He is himself an excellent writer, a

thorough gentleman, a live wire. After he got married, whenever he met me on the way he would say, "Your share of sweets is lying with me, I'll send them across." Till date I haven't got those sweets, but anyway I don't have any expectations from literary writers. These letters were so polite, so full of appeal, so full of devotion that I began to feel affection for Joshi despite not having met him in person. I got to know that he was the son of a rich man and had left home as his father's brother had wanted to marry him off for a large dowry, which he found unacceptable. At this his uncle threw him out of the house. He went to his father. The father was an exemplary devotee of his brother. He paid no heed to any appeal against the brother's decision. In such circumstances, what else can a young boy weighed down by his ideals do except run away from home? Wandering through the wild, plucking leaves, going haplessly from door to door, he had landed up in Gwalior. To top it all, he was a victim of dyspepsia, in the throes of fever from exhaustion. You tell me, wouldn't you feel sorry for such a man? Then if such a man addresses you as "Dear Bhai Sahib", opens his heart to you, doesn't let go of his patience or manliness even in such trying times, is ready to take on hard work, if you have even the slightest compunction, you will definitely help him.

'Okay, so now let's move on to the plot. After a long while, Joshi's letter came from Prayag. He had become the assistant editor of a monthly paper there. I can't express how satisfied and happy I felt on reading that letter. What an enterprising man he was! My affection for him grew even stronger. The chief editor of the paper was an extremely strict man—he would deduct a whole day's pay if one was even slightly late, he would rant at the most trivial of things—but this brave satyagrahi bore everything and stayed put at his work. How could he leave such an opportunity to shape his destiny? All these things are bound to increase one's love and trust. Who wouldn't feel proud of and admire a man confronting challenges!

'He was unable to stay for long at Prayag. He wrote to me, I am ready to bear everything, even to die of starvation but I can't allow my dignity to be sullied, I can't bear abusive language.

‘If such strength of character cannot have an impact on you, I will say that you are intelligent but heartless.

‘A week later another letter arrived from Prayag—This behaviour has become unbearable for me. Today I have handed in my resignation. Please don’t think that I left a ready source of income with a light heart. I did everything that should be done. In fact I even did a few things I oughtn’t to have done but I couldn’t murder my self-respect. Had I been able to do so, then I needn’t even have left home. I have made up my mind to go to Bombay and try my luck there. I have resolved firmly not to ask my family for money, I will not beg for alms of pity from them. I am ready to work like a coolie, carrying baskets on my head, but I cannot pollute my soul.

‘My respect grew deeper. This person was no longer like a character in a play for whom, despite our feeling joyful at his joys and sad at his sorrows, we remain spectators. He had come so close to my heart that were I to see him being wounded, I would be ready to save him; if I were to see him drowning, I would be ready to jump into the water for him.

‘I awaited his letter from Bombay with great eagerness. On the sixth day, the letter arrived. He was looking for work in Bombay, he wrote—There is nothing to worry about; I am ready to cope with anything. Thereafter a letter would come every two to four days. Like a brave warrior he had braced himself to face difficulties even though he had not had a square meal in three days.

‘Oh! What lofty ideals. What a noble character! I believe I was miserly at that time. My conscience smote me—This poor fellow is suffering so much and all you do is watch. Why don’t you send him some money? I didn’t follow what my heart said but I was certainly disturbed by my pitilessness.

‘After a few days of restless waiting, when I got the news that he had found a job in the editorial section of a weekly paper, I finally heaved a sigh of relief and thanked God with true gratitude.

‘Joshi’s articles began to appear in the weekly. I would feel proud on reading them. How alive, how thought-provoking his writing was! He asked me to write too but I had no time. Though I asked him to forgive me, I was really sorry at my inability to support him at that time.

‘But he was perhaps a blighted soul. The weekly had few readers. Work carried on through charity and donations. When money would come in, the employees would get bits of it, when it would not, they worked on sheer hope. The poor man must have spent three months in this condition. He hoped that when three months’ dues would be cleared, he would lay hands on a decent sum, but he didn’t see that money. The owner wrapped up the business, the weekly shut down and the workers had to leave empty-handed. There was no doubt that the editor was a man of honour but from where could he get the money! People could work on half a salary out of goodwill but how was it possible to work on an empty stomach? And on top of it, the cost of living in Bombay was high. Poor Joshi had to again bear the brunt. When I read the letter, I felt very bad. God had not made me capable enough, else why would this poor fellow have had to wander around for a living?

‘This time he didn’t have to wait long. He got a job in a mill to write numbers on the knots. It was a daily wage of one rupee. One rupee in Bombay was equivalent to twenty-five paise here. God alone knows how he managed.

‘After many days a long letter arrived. A German agency was ready to hire him but he would have to immediately deposit one hundred rupees as surety. The agency supplied shoes, cigars and soap to the army. If he were to be placed there, he would be able to live comfortably. He had written that he was now fed up with life. His courage failed him. Nothing but suicide seemed an option. It was only his mother he was worried about. She would die weeping—With my father around she has no dearth of material bliss, but she is tormented by her anguish for me. My only wish is that once I get a job, I will bring her over once, keep her with me and look after her. I have no other wish but where am I to get the surety from? Now I only have time until tomorrow. By the day after, some other candidate will have deposited the surety and got the job, and I’ll be left high and dry. The agent does want to keep me but what can he do about the rules of the workplace?

‘This letter captured even my miserly spirit. Where there is a will, there is a way. I decided to send the money. If a little help could go a long way in

improving a man's life, who could turn his face away? What better way to use money than this? It is difficult for such large sums of money to be produced by writers of Hindi but by chance I had some money in my kitty at that time. I am indebted to my miserliness for this. I took the advice of Deviji. She agreed very readily though she wants to dump the entire blame on my head now. A money order would take three days to reach. I immediately went to the telegraph office and ordered the money to be sent. Only one who has scrimped and scrounged over the years and is bound to see deprivation in the future can experience the pleasure I felt at that moment. Seth Amirchand would not have savoured such delight even after making a donation of ten lakh rupees. I had, of course, given it as a loan but it was for our friendship's sake. Recovering such money is a wasted dream.

'I will never forget the letter of gratitude that reached me on the fourth day. What honest outpourings! Each word was dripping with appreciation. I consider it a literary masterpiece.'

Deviji shot a barb, 'For a hundred rupees, one can get an even better letter.'

Dhaporsankh gave no reply. He was completely immersed in his narrative.

'He was living in some well-known locality of Bombay. Bearing just his name and the postbox number, letters would reach him. He wrote many letters from there. He was happy.'

Deviji said, 'Why wouldn't he be happy? A bird had been snared in the net.'

Dhaporsankh said resentfully, 'Either you let me tell the story or you take over. Don't speak in the middle.

'After quite a few days, a letter came from Bombay saying that the agency was so happy with his behaviour that they were transferring him to Kashi, and so he was going there. Over and above his salary, he would get an allowance. In Kashi he had an uncle who was a famous doctor but instead of landing up at his house, he stayed independently. This reflects his self-respect. But in one month he was tired of Kashi. Letters full of complaints began to arrive—From dawn to dusk one has to cater to the

whims of the military personnel. I leave in the morning and return at ten in the night. Finding the house deserted and dark at that time is heart-wrenching . . . Whom to talk to, whom to share a laugh with? I am sick of eating the puris sold in the market. I had thought that now I would spend a few days in peace, but it seems that I am destined to be struck down by fate. I cannot live like this. I keep crying through the night . . . These letters made me feel that he was falling short of his ideals. I tried to make him understand that he should not let go of a ready source of income, he should continue working. The answer came—I can't stay here any more. The behaviour of the *fauji*s is intolerable. And besides, the manager is sending me to Rangoon and there is no way I will be able survive there. I want to do some literary work. For some time, I want to work under your guidance.

'I was just about to reply to this letter when another one arrived—I am reaching tomorrow by Dehradun Express. He landed up the next day. A thin man, dark-complexioned, with a drawn face, big eyes, dressed in western attire, carrying with him a few leather trunks, a suitcase and a holdall. I was amazed to observe his style.'

Deviji piped up, 'Even then you didn't come to your senses.'

'I had imagined a dark-coloured kurta, sandals, at the most, a fountain pen kind of guy, but this gentleman turned out to be a regular sahib. I felt uneasy about keeping him in this tiny house.'

Deviji was unable to stop herself from speaking. 'As soon as he came, he laid his head at your feet; what more could you ask for?'

Dhaporsankh now smiled. 'Look, Shyama, don't keep interrupting me from time to time. Courtroom convention says that for the time being you must keep listening to me quietly. When your turn comes, you can say what you wish.'

The narrative started once more. 'He may have been skinny but he was very energetic, a glib talker—one sentence in English, one in Hindi and a mishmash of the two, pretty much the way people like you speak. Conversation started: "I was very keen to meet you. You are exactly how I imagined you would be. Really, I feel like a human being once more. For so long, I have felt like a prisoner."

‘I said, “So have you handed in your resignation?”

‘“No, I am on leave right now. I haven’t yet got my salary this month. I have given it in writing that they should send it at this address. The job itself is good but there’s too much work and I don’t get a chance to write.”

‘Anyhow, I made him sleep right in this room at night. The next day I arranged for a hotel. The hotel people take money in advance. Joshi had no money. I had to give thirty rupees. I thought, *His salary is on its way, I will recover it*.

‘I have a friend here—Mathur. I had mentioned Joshi to him as well. The moment he heard about Joshi’s arrival, he ran to the hotel. Both became friends. Twice or thrice a day and at least once at night, Joshi would definitely come and have lots to say. Deviji handled him with kid gloves. Sometimes she would make pakoras for him and sometimes halva. Joshi was multitalented. Skilled in singing, an expert harmonium player, he also excelled at magic tricks. He could even cook a fine dish. Deviji developed a desire to learn music. She made him her music teacher.’

Deviji turned red and said, ‘So was I supposed to be making halva, pakoras and paan, and feeding him for free?’

‘A month went by. Joshiji’s salary never came. I didn’t ask him either. I thought, in his heart of hearts he would assume that I wanted to recover the hotel money. He had started going here and there, to Mathur’s house as well. The pair would go out together, stay together. When Joshi came, he would praise Mathur and when Mathur came, he would praise Joshi. Joshi had an exclusive collection of experiences. He’d been in the forces. When his fiancée married another man, he left his army job out of grief. Who can count how many social experiences he could recall. And when he would mention his mother and father or aunt and uncle, his eyes would well up. Deviji would also cry with him.’

Deviji merely looked at him sideways. It was true.

‘One day, he spoke to me praising a play of his. It had been performed in Calcutta and the manager of Madan Company had congratulated him on it. He was carrying the play with him, and he read out a couple of acts. I really liked the play. He had sold it to a publisher in Kashi for a sum of twenty-

five rupees. I told him to get the play back. I would pay for it. Such a good play should be given to a good publisher or performed by a theatre company. After three or four days we got to know that the publisher would only return it at a cost of fifty rupees. He said that he had published a part of it. I said, "Get it back even at the cost of fifty rupees." The play came back by post. I paid the money.

'The month was coming to an end. The hotel people would ask for money when the next month commenced. I was in a state of great anxiety when Joshi came to me and said, "I will now live with Mathur. The poor man has no money. If I give him even twenty rupees, he will manage." I was very happy. The next day he installed himself at Mathur's house.

'Whenever he came, he would disclose some or the other secret about Mathur's family. This I knew that Mathur's financial condition was not good. The poor fellow used to be an employee at the railway office. He had lost that job. But I didn't know that he was on the brink of starvation. Sometimes the landlord would come and hurl abuse at him. Sometimes the milkman, sometimes the grocer and sometimes the clothier. The poor man was always trying to hide from them. With tears brimming over, Joshi would narrate his pitiful tale, "I always used to believe that I alone was stricken by fate. Seeing Mathur I have forgotten my own troubles. I only worried about myself, uncaring about others. At whichever door I knocked, I would get some relief, but Mathur had an entire family to take care of. A mother, two widowed sisters and a niece. Two nephews and a younger brother. For such a large family, fifty rupees would take care only of food. Mathur is a true hero, a God, for looking after such a large family." Now he was not sorry for himself, he was sorry for Mathur.'

Deviji interrupted him. 'That was when he was casting his net on Mathur's niece. How else could he reduce the burden of sorrow?'

Dhaporsankh got annoyed and said, 'Okay. You do the talking now.'

I reasoned with him. 'Come on, you get irritated at such trivial things. Do you think that these sparklers will make me stray from the path of justice?'

The story began again. 'One day he came and said, "Today I have found a solution to relieve Mathur. Another Mathur friend of mine is a barrister. I

am negotiating through letters with him regarding the marriage of Jaggo, Mathur's niece. I will send one of his widowed sisters to her in-laws along with both her children. The other widowed sister is ready to go to her brother-in-law. Finally there will be only three or four people left. Some of the money I will give, and that's how one will manage. But today he has to pay two months of house rent. The owner has been on dharna since morning. He says he will leave only when the rent is paid. If you have thirty rupees, then please give it. Mathur's younger brother will get his salary in a day or two; you will get your money back." One friend was in need and another friend was pleading his case. I didn't have the guts to refuse! Deviji had certainly screwed up her face but I didn't pay heed and gave the money.'

Deviji lashed out, 'Why don't you reveal the fact that my sister had sent that money for utensils to be bought and sent to her?'

Dhaporsankh swallowed his anger and said, 'Well, whatever. I gave the money. But I began to have misgivings that at this rate I would be squeezed dry. Mathur would have some or the other problem on his head every day. How far could I tackle them? Joshi too was after my life to get him a position somewhere. Coincidentally, at that time, there emerged a friend of mine from Agra. He was a member of the Council. Now he's in jail. He's interested in music, has written a play or two and knows some people in elite circles. He's a colourful man himself. This time when he came to meet me, I brought up Joshi. I narrated his play as well. He said, "Do put him in touch with me. I'll make him my private secretary. He can live in my house; he can stay like a member of the family. He can take thirty rupees a month from me for his expenses. He can write plays with me." I was thrilled. I told Joshi. Joshi got ready to go but before leaving, he needed some money. He couldn't possibly accompany a gentleman in such a shabby state, nor was it appropriate for him to reveal his need for money right from the first day. In spite of a lot of budgeting and cutting costs, forty rupees had to be spent. Shoes were broken, dhotis were torn and there were other expenses too which I can't remember right now. I didn't have any money, nor the courage to ask Shyama for it.'

Deviji said, ‘Oh! I, of course, had a pot of gold. You get so many thousands every month—a hundred-odd rupees must surely be getting saved.’

Dhaporsankh paid no attention to this jibe and continued with his narration. ‘After getting the money, Joshi dressed himself nattily and went along with Councillor Sahib. I went to drop him to the station. Mathur went along too. On returning it was as if a burden had been lifted off my chest.

‘Mathur said, “He’s a very affectionate man.”

‘I concurred. “Very much. For me, he’s like a brother.”

‘“I won’t like it at home any more. Everyone at home is in tears. It never felt as if he was a stranger. He used to talk to Amma as if he were a son, with the sisters like a brother.”

‘“He’s an ill-fated man, else why should one whose father earned two thousand rupees a month have to go from pillar to post!”

‘“His father has two houses in Darjeeling.”

‘“He’s the IMS.”

‘“Joshi wants to take me there as well. In a year or two he will surely go there. He says he will open a motor agency for me.”

‘Thus weaving many fanciful dreams, we came home.

‘At heart I was happy that at least for Joshi, things had worked out well. I also clung on to the hope that this time, when he got his salary, he would return my money. In four or five months he would clear the debt. When I calculated the amount, it turned out to be a pretty hefty sum. If I had tried to save this money, I would never have managed. In this way it had got saved one way or the other. I wondered if I should ask my friend to send me the money in advance. I could tell him that he could keep deducting the amount from his salary each month.

‘But hardly a week had gone by when one day I saw Joshi and Mathur walking along. I was afraid that Joshi might have left his job once again and returned. But suppressing my fears I said, “So brother, when did you come? All well?”

‘Joshi sat down and, lighting a cigar, said, “I’m just fine. My Babu Sahib is really a fine man. He has got a room vacated for me. I have my meals

with him. He treats me just like a brother. These days he's gone to Delhi for some work. I thought, What will I do whiling away my time out there? Till then I might as well meet up with you all. While leaving, Babu Sahib told me to get some Moradabadi utensils but maybe he forgot about giving me the money. I didn't think it right to ask him at that time. You give me fifty rupees. I'll be leaving the day after and the moment I reach, I'll send it to you. You are aware how particular he is about money."

'I said a bit brusquely, "At this moment, I don't have any money."'

Deviji added her bit here. 'Why are you lying? You said brusquely that there was no money?'

Dhaporsankh asked, 'So then did I say it sweetly?'

'Then why did you give him that money for the paper? Great brusque speaker!' Deviji parried.

Dhaporsankh said, 'Okay, Sir, I happily gave the money. There, now she's content. Well then, I felt bad all right but I was bound to my good friend. I owe him many favours. I had fifty rupees with me to buy paper for the gazette. I gave it to Joshi.

'In the evening Mathur came and said, "Joshi has gone back." He said that a telegram had come from Babu Sahib. "Such a large-hearted man. It never feels like he is an outsider. His nature is childlike too. He's trying to fix my niece's wedding. There's been no talk of dowry but I have to give some token amount at least. Barrister Sahib, with whom the marriage is being arranged, resides in Delhi. We will have to go there to give him the amount. Joshiji will go. I've even given him the money today. So a big burden is off my head."

'I asked, "Did you have ready money with you?"'

'Mathur said, "What money, Sahib! I took money on credit at an interest of two rupees per hundred from a moneylender on stamped paper."'

In an angry voice Deviji said, 'If ever I find that devil, I'll claw his face out. That demon didn't even spare the poor man.'

Dhaporsankh said, 'You are angry now. At that time you too thought that Joshi was the epitome of compassion and virtue.'

Deviji opposed this. ‘I never thought of him as any kind of epitome. Yes, I had to heed your wishes.’

Dhaporsankh continued. ‘So, Sir, in this way around two months passed, during which time Joshi came three or four times but he never asked me for anything. Yes, he did say a whole lot of things about his Babu Sahib, which gave me fodder for two or three stories.

‘It was the month of May. One day Joshi landed up early in the morning. On inquiring, I got to know that his Babu Sahib had gone to Nainital. He would have taken him along but he preferred to be with us and had come over.’

Deviji flung a firecracker. ‘What a self-sacrificing soul! He would rather forgo the climes of Nainital and offer his soul to this heat!’

Without paying any attention to her, Dhaporsankh said, ‘I asked, “Has anything new happened out there?”

‘Joshi laughed and said, “Destiny writes new challenges. How can one escape those? This time too a new problem landed on my shoulders. One could say your blessings saved me or perhaps by now I would be floating in the Yamuna River. One day I went for a walk along the shores of the Yamuna. There was a swimming competition going on. At some distance from me a gentleman was standing with a young lady. I began talking with them and I got to know that they were of the same stock as me. I also got to know that they were familiar with both my father and my uncle. They began to talk to me affectionately, ‘You have borne hardships for so long. Why don’t you go back to your father and mother? Agreed that their behaviour towards people may not be to your liking but parents have some rights over their son. Your mother must be feeling so sad.’

‘“Suddenly a young man came up from somewhere and, seeing the old man and young lady, he said, ‘Aren’t you ashamed of standing in this mela with your young daughter?’

‘“The old man’s face fell and the young lady immediately pulled her veil to cover her face and withdrew. It appeared that her wedding had been fixed with this young man. The old man was modern, a social thinker, not a slave of the veil. The youth, though young in years, was old-fashioned in his

views, rigidly in favour of the veil. For a while the old man spoke with a sense of guilt but the young man grew more agitated by the minute. Finally the old man lost his temper.

‘“The young man glared and said, ‘I consider it beneath my dignity to marry someone so shameless.’

‘“The old man was angry and replied in a quivering voice, ‘And I consider it a shame to marry off my daughter to a lumpen element like you.’

‘“The young man was provoked. He caught hold of the old man’s arm and pushed him. Unable to win with words, he wanted to use brute force to do so. The old man fell to the ground. I leapt and picked up the old man and scolded the young man.

‘“He left the old man and rounded up on me. I am no wrestler. He knew how to fight. To keep it short, he flung me down and gripped my throat. Quite a few people had gathered around. For as long as the wrestling continued, they enjoyed the show but when they saw that the situation had turned serious, they immediately intervened to rescue me. As he was leaving, the youngster told the old man, ‘If you want to display your daughter like a prostitute in the market, then go ahead. I no longer wish to marry her.’ The old man stood silent while the young lady wept. Brother, I couldn’t control myself any further. I said, ‘Sir, you are like my father and you know me. If you think me worthy enough, then I will consider myself blessed by making this lady the queen of my heart. You can see what my situation is, and it’s possible that my life will go on like this. But if devotion, care and love can make one’s life happy, then you will not find me lacking in these qualities towards the lady.’ The old man was overjoyed and embraced me. Immediately he took me to his house, fed me a meal and fixed the wedding. I wanted to meet the lady once for her consent. The old man readily agreed to it. On meeting the lady, I realized that she was a jewel among beauties. I was amazed by her intelligence. She completely matched the woman of my dreams and in that short span of time, I was convinced I would be content to spend my life with her. Now you must bless me. The young girl reads your gazette regularly and has deep respect for you. The wedding has been decided for June. I have said clearly, I will

get jewellery and clothes only as a token and I will not have any pomp and show. The old man said, 'I was going to say so myself. I don't want any preparations, nor do I desire any pomp and show.' When I took your name and said that you were like an elder brother to me, he was very happy. He reads your writing with great respect."

'I said resentfully, "All this is fine but at this point of time, you don't have the means to get married. If not anything else, you should have a stable income of at least fifty rupees."

'Joshi said, "Bhai Sahib, I think I will only get some relief once I get married. The reason for my leaving home was marriage and the reason for my return too will be marriage. When Pramila falls at my father's feet with folded hands, even his frozen heart will melt. He will realize that now that the wedding is over, why should the bride suffer? When he is reassured, he will surely call me. I had left home on the contention that I would marry according to my wishes and without any give and take, and this promise of mine is nearing fulfilment. Pramila is so smart that she will win over my family in minutes. I have made an estimate. A total of three hundred rupees will be spent and around three to four hundred rupees I will get from my in-laws. I have decided that I will get Pramila here first. From here itself she'll write a letter home and you will see that on the third day my uncle will land up with a casket of jewellery. Once the wedding takes place, he won't be able to do anything. That is why I haven't given any information about the wedding."

'I said, "But I don't have anything at all right now. From where will I get three hundred rupees?"

'Joshi said, "We won't need three hundred in cash. Around one hundred rupees will be the cost of the clothes. With one hundred rupees I will get a few bridal things made, and add another hundred rupees for say, travel. Their house is in Kashipur. We'll get married there. At your bidding the Bengali jeweller right here will give me the things I need on a promise of one week. The haberdasher will supply clothes. I'll need just a hundred rupees in cash which I'll return the moment I get back. The baraat will consist of you and Mathur. There'll be no third person. I don't want to

trouble you but you have always helped me like a brother, do so one more time. I was sure that you wouldn't object to such an auspicious task. That's why I have given my word. Now you have to help me.'"

Deviji butted in, 'I kept saying, don't give him the money. Say that we don't want to get involved with all the trouble of your wedding.'

Dhaporsankh said, 'Yes, you did try to reason then, but what could I do? Wedding plans were made and he had dragged me into the affair. My self-respect was at stake.'

Deviji showed some respect for me and became silent.

Now I won't extend the narrative further. In short, Joshi thrust the burden of a hundred rupees for clothes and a little over a hundred rupees for jewellery on Dhaporsankh's head. The poor man borrowed a hundred rupees from another friend and gave it to him for travel expenses. He was himself present at the wedding. The wedding was a particularly showy affair. The bride's father looked after the guests with love and respect. He was in a hurry and left the next day itself but Mathur stayed on with Joshi till all the wedding rituals were over. Dhaporsankh was hopeful that the moment Joshi got money from his in-laws, he would send it through Mathur's hand or bring it over himself. But Mathur returned the next day and brought the news that Joshi didn't get anything in hand from his in-laws. From Mathur he now got to know that the story about meeting the girl on the riverbank had been totally false. Joshi had been corresponding with this girl for very long. Then Dhaporsankh's ears pricked up. He asked Mathur, 'Really! Was all this just his imagination?'

Mathur replied, 'Yes, Sir.'

'Okay, so what happened to your niece's wedding?'

'Nothing so far.'

'But Joshi had been helping you out for some months.'

'What help could he give? Yes, twice a day he would have a meal.'

'The money he took from me in your name, surely that he would have given you.'

'Did he take some money in my name too?'

'Oh yes, the money he took to pay your house rent.'

‘Total betrayal. He never gave me a penny; rather, through another moneylender, he took money in my name on a stamped paper. How was I to know that he was playing false?’

By chance, just then the gentleman from Agra with whom Joshi had stayed for a few days came. He looked at Mathur and asked, ‘Okay! So you’re alive.’ Joshi had told him that Mathur was dead.

Mathur laughed and said, ‘I don’t even have a headache.’

Dhaporsankh asked, ‘Okay, has your Moradabadi brassware reached?’

Astonished, the friend from Agra said, ‘What Moradabadi brassware?’

‘Those that you had asked Joshi to get for you.’

‘I haven’t asked him anything of the kind. If I needed brassware, wouldn’t I have written to you directly?’

Mathur said laughingly, ‘So this money too has been consumed.’

The friend from Agra said, ‘From me too he had taken a hundred rupees on the pretext of your death. He has turned out to be a one of a kind swindler, *uff* ! He has fooled us all. This is the first time in my life that I have been made such a fool of. If I found the kid, I would send him behind bars for three years. Where is he nowadays?’

Mathur replied, ‘Right now he is with his in-laws.’

Dhaporsankh’s narrative came to an end. It was not only him; Joshi had stuck a knife into other poor folks such as Mathur and also into such cunning gentlemen as the Agra resident. And had the cat not been let out of the bag, there would be no counting how many more days he would have continued to twist the knife. Even I was taken aback at this unprincipled move of his. Truly, he is a master of his craft, a downright cheat.

Deviji said, ‘You heard the whole story.’

I said fearfully, ‘Yes, I have heard it all right.’

‘Okay, so what’s your decision?’ Gesturing to her husband, she said, ‘Don’t you agree that he did something idiotic? If a man who has to depend on others for every penny throws away five to six hundred rupees in this way, would you call this his gentlemanliness or his stupidity? Had he given the money knowing that he was casting it into the water, then I would have had no objection, but he remained under an illusion and forced me too to

fall prey to the same illusion that he was from a wealthy family and that not only would he return the money, he would also do many other beneficial things. The man whose father earned two thousand rupees a month, whose uncle got a monthly salary of a thousand rupees and who owns property worth one lakh, could take you for a tour of Europe, if not anything else. If I ever stopped you, you would get annoyed and preach to me about having a large heart. I acknowledge that in the beginning I too had been taken in, but later I had my misgivings. And at the time of the wedding, I had insisted that I wouldn't give a single penny. Ask him, am I telling lies or speaking the truth? And then about my being taken in . . . I am a sheltered woman and my falling into the trap can be justified. But he who is a writer and philosopher and preacher, why did he get trapped and, when I tried to reason with him, why did he think that he was the epitome of intelligence and refuse to pay no heed to what I said? Look, don't be biased or else I will sort you out. I want unbiased justice.'

Dhaporsankh looked at me with beseeching eyes, as if begging for salvation. Alongside were Deviji's eager, commanding and pride-filled eyes staring at me. One believed in defeat and the other in victory. One wanted support, the other true justice.

With profound gravity I declared my judgement, 'My friend has definitely acted sentimentally, but his gentlemanliness is unquestionable.'

Dhaporsankh jumped up and embraced me. Deviji looked at me with intense eyes and said, 'I always knew that birds of a feather flock together. The two of you are like peas in a pod. Till today I had an ounce of trust in men. Today, you have erased that. Today it's been decided that men are cheats, manipulative, treacherous and selfish. I don't accept this judgement. Forfeiting one's image for nothing is what this is. Had you taken my side, well and good, you would have got good food. Taking his side will fetch you nothing but rotten cigarettes. Anyway, I may have lost the battle, but now I know your true colours.'

Since that day I have run into Deviji two or three times, and each time I have been subjected to her reprimand. She neither seeks forgiveness, nor can she forgive.

Translated from the Hindi by Swati Pal



The Final Excuse

I do not have a strong memory, and though all the important dates of world history that I had learnt by burning the midnight oil and brain-teasing have been wiped away, the date of my marriage is embedded firmly in my mind, like a pillar on a level field. I have not forgotten it, nor will I ever. Every incident before and after this date has vanished from my mind and no trace of them remains. All the varied memories of my life have been moulded into one, which is my wedding date. I try to forget it, but a date which is remembered every day cannot easily be forgotten. And why do I remember it every day? Well, ask this of that poor soul who has no hope left in life except to turn to God.

But do I run away from my married life because I lack a romantic disposition and softness, or have I turned myself into a dull ascetic? Don't I want the queen of my heart to be with me when I go for walks? To go shopping with her and have the pleasure of fulfilling her desires like a true lover? I can very well imagine the pride, happiness and self-importance I would feel, just as the others do. But I am not cut out for such pleasures and playfulness.

Because I can very well see the other side of the picture. The more alluring one side is, the more dangerous and disheartening the other becomes. The sun goes down and you are in the queue for oil or gas, with your child in your lap. It's night and you pick up the bag of flour from the

grocers' and slink out of the lane, as if you have committed some theft. Come morning and you, holding your children in your arms, sit on a broken chair at a homeopathic doctor's chamber. Some hawker comes vending his wares and your child starts howling at the top of his voice and that puts you in a fix. I have also seen such fathers who buy peanuts or sweets while returning from office and try to eat them hurriedly, before the children at home can attack them. How despairing it is to see a child nagging his father for a toy at some fair, while the father expounds on the transient nature of toys.

One facet of the picture seems like a sweet dream to me, while the other is a painful truth. My courage fails when faced with the truth. All my originality and creativity have been used to save myself from the shackles of married life. I very well know that I have to step into the net, but I am aware that the more beautiful and tempting the net, the more dangerous and poisonous the catch. I see birds stuck in this net, flapping their wings in vain.

But for the past few days, my wife has been continuously pressing me to bring her to the place where I work. Earlier, when I went home for the holidays, my merely asking her, 'Where would you like to go?' was enough to satisfy her. Later, I pacified her by saying, 'It's too much of a hassle.' After that I convinced her with arguments that it would be an inconvenience to our settled married life. But for some time now, she appears to be unconvinced by my arguments. Even during the holidays, I stopped going home for fear of her demands to come with me. I keep making various excuses to stay away.

My first excuse drew on the extremely painful life of newspaper editors: Sometimes we get to sleep only by midnight and at other times we cannot go to sleep at all as we have to write throughout the night. During the day one has to wander here and there in an effort to be in the thick of things. On top of this, one is always under scrutiny. Who knows when I will be arrested and the need for bail will arise? Police spies are always looking for us. Whenever I pass through the market, people point their fingers at me and say, 'Here goes the "paperwala".' It is as if I am responsible for all the

divine, devilish, materialist and non-materialist hurdles in the universe, and as if my brain is a factory producing false news. The entire day is spent saluting officers and flattering policemen. I see constables and my heart begins to sink wondering what calamity might befall me. While I live in fear, the government officers seem to be nervous about me. For example, one day I accidentally passed by an Englishman's bungalow. Sahib asked, 'What do you do?'; 'I am a newspaper editor,' I replied with pride. Sahib quickly went inside and closed the door. Later, I saw *memsahib* and the children staring at me through the window as if I were a dangerous beast! Once, I was travelling in the train with some friends. To maintain the dignity of my post I had to buy a second-class ticket. While I was sitting there, a gentleman saw my name and profession written on my suitcase. He immediately opened his box and began loading his gun in order to show me that he was on his guard.

I have never discussed financial problems with my wife since I consider it beneath my dignity as a man to discuss such matters with women.

I was sure that my wife would no longer want to come to the town after reading this letter. But I was wrong. She continued to persist in her demand.

Then I thought of another excuse: Cities are full of epidemics. It's a cause for concern that all eatables might contain poison—poison in the milk, in ghee, in fruits, in vegetables, in the air and in the water too. Human life is like an image in water: this moment it's there but the next minute it's gone. In a fraction of a second one can have a heart attack, or leave home for work, get hit by a vehicle and meet his end. If someone reaches home alive and in one piece in the evening, he is extremely lucky. Even if we hear a mosquito buzz in our ears, our heart sinks and if we so much as see a fly, our hands and feet go numb. When a rat comes out of its hole, our life hangs by a thread! The Angel of Death reigns everywhere. If we are spared an accident by car or tram, then we fall victim to flies and mosquitoes. It is as if Death always hovers over one's head. One spends the entire night fighting with mosquitoes, and the entire day with houseflies. With so many troubles, how can I be safe? I breathe with caution so that bacteria causing tuberculosis do not enter my lungs.

Even then my wife refused to believe me. The next letter also contained the same demand. She wrote, ‘Your letter got me worried about your well-being. Write a letter every day, otherwise I won’t listen to your advice and will arrive there.’ I thought to myself that I had escaped easily this time.

But I was scared that any moment it might get into her head to come to the city. That’s why I thought of a third excuse: My friends make my life miserable here. They come to my house, sit and never leave—as if they have sold their own homes. Even if I am not there they come around uninvited and make themselves at home. And they order my servant to get things for them for which I have to pay. Some of them lie around in my house for weeks on end, refusing to leave. I have to play host to them by day and in the evening I take them to the movies. Till early morning we keep playing cards and chess. Some of them can’t live without alcohol. Most of the time they come home sick; in fact, often I have to call the doctor, take care of them throughout the night by fanning them. Often when I return home, I do not find my servant there. I look for him high and low for hours and get to know that one of my friends has sent him to the market to run an errand. Despite all this they accuse me of not looking after them properly. For months at a time I haven’t worn my wristwatch. This is because it’s attending parties with my friends. My trousers are lying with one friend and my blazer is with someone else. Some other friend has grabbed my shoes. I am stuck with an old blazer and torn shoes which I wear to office.

My dear friends keep an eye on everything I buy. If I buy something new I usually hide it. If anyone sees it, it’s gone forever. On the first of the month when I get my salary, I enter my house silently like a thief, fearing my friends who tell me that their need is greater than mine. I wonder why all their needs come up on the first of the month. Once I returned home at midnight after getting my salary and was astonished to see two of my friends waiting for me. I made several excuses to underscore my need, but all in vain. I told them that I have received a letter from home informing me that my mother has been taken seriously ill. They replied, ‘Old people don’t die so quickly. If she had to die she would have died long ago. She’ll be

fine in a few days.' I told them about the pressure to pay taxes. They responded that taxes are being abolished and that there was no need to pay them. And when I made an excuse regarding rituals at home, they replied, 'Don't be absurd. You don't need to be superstitious. To follow meaningless conventions is beneath your dignity!' They feel I'm extremely superstitious and that I should break away from such shackles. Finally, I gave up. No matter what I say or do, I am stuck with them.

I assumed that this excuse of mine would hit the mark. What woman would like to stay in a house completely overrun by friends? But I was proved wrong again. The letter she wrote in reply contained the same demand. The saving grace was that she stopped at merely writing the letter.

Then I thought of a fourth excuse. I told her that the houses in the city are like cages with no air and light. The stench is so overpowering that one's head begins to spin. So many people fall victim to diseases like typhoid, cholera and asthma just because of this stench. The house starts leaking the moment it rains. One often hears of houses caving in. You get up in the morning to see corpses under the debris. Come night and you feel scared. Most of the houses have resident spirits, giving people nightmares. You hear people screaming and weeping at night. Many are possessed by spirits. The moment tenants settle into a new house, the tension of locating yet another bothers them. One can see people moving in and out of the locality with their luggage stuffed in carts. Wherever you look, all you find are more and more carts loaded with luggage. Thefts happen so frequently that people thank their stars if a night passes without incident. As soon as midnight approaches, you hear people screaming, 'Thief! Thief! Run, run!'

People stand guard at their doors with wooden planks, walking sticks and shoes throughout the night, protecting their houses. But the thieves are so cunning that they still manage to break in. I have a close friend who used to visit me. In the dead of the night, I heard a noise in the kitchen which forced me to turn on the light. I was startled to see that the same gentleman was gathering together some utensils. Seeing me there, he let out a loud guffaw and said, 'I just wanted to scare you!' I understood inwardly—*If you had been able to run away with all the utensils, they would have been*

yours, but now that I have got out of bed and ruined your plans, you make it out to be a joke. How you entered my house is a divine secret! After playing cards till the wee hours of the morning and bidding me goodnight, you must have hidden yourself in the room downstairs.

One day a gentleman came to me asking for help in writing a letter. However, there was neither ink nor a pen in the room and I went upstairs to get them. When I came back, I found that he had disappeared with my watch.

Apparently, my wife was so fascinated by the glamour and glitter of city life that all these excuses were in vain. So she wrote in her reply, 'You're always making excuses. I'm not going to listen to you any more. You'd better come and take me with you to the town!'

Ultimately, I had to resort to a fifth excuse. And that had to do with the hawkers in the city. One barely gets out of bed when one hears weird sounds. Such noises must not have been heard even when the Tower of Babel was being built. This is the verbal duel of the hawkers. It would have been better had these hawkers utilized musical instruments to attract the attention of people. They should have trained themselves in the local music college for five years. But these brainless creatures of God do not understand this. The sound they produce can only be called satanic! The listeners get goosebumps. Children cling to their mothers. Even I get startled at night. Once, a terrible incident took place in my neighbourhood just as the clock struck eleven. A woman was feeding her child. All of a sudden, a hawker began yelling at the top of his voice. The woman screamed in horror and fell unconscious. It took months of medication and care to cure her. And now she sleeps with cotton wool in her ears. She was told that it was only a hawker's call, but she finds it difficult to believe. These things happen very often in the city. I have many friends who had brought their wives to town but these recurring noises drove them back to the country.

My wife regarded it as just another excuse I was making up and replied, 'Do you think I'll be frightened by the mere yelps of these hawkers when

I'm not scared by the howling of jackals and owls here? Don't try to frighten me with such stuff.'

In the end I wanted to think of an ultimate excuse, one in whose success I had full faith and which would make my wife detest city life forever. After pondering over it for several days, I hit upon one such excuse. Though there was some self-abasement involved in it, I wasn't as scared of self-abasement as I was of trouble.

So I wrote: The city is not meant for women of good character. The maids here are so rude that they reply to every question with abuse, and no one can compete with them in make-up and fine clothing. Women of a decent background feel ashamed when they see their standard of living. When they walk past loaded with gold, one feels as if a breeze of strong fragrance has wafted by. How can ordinary housewives afford such luxuries? They have so many other worries to take care of. These maids do not have any interest other than enhancing their looks. Every day they have something new to show off and they are spirited as if they have mercury instead of blood in their veins. Housewives feel embarrassed by their looks and coquetry. The maids are so brazen that they do not mind entering anybody's house on some pretext or another. Whichever way you look, you find this breed of women in groups and gangs. It is extremely difficult for decent men to escape their sight. Some of them come with a letter to be written and some with one to be read. But the truth is that their sole aim is to make housewives jealous of them. That's why very few decent women reside in the city.

God only knows what was there in the letter, for it made my wife come to town with our three offspring, chaperoned by an old Kahar.

I asked her in bewilderment, 'I hope everything is fine!'

My wife replied, unveiling her face, 'Is there some witch sitting in the house? I will cut off the nose of any woman who dares enter my house, unless you support her.'

Oh! Now the secret was revealed. I banged my head against the wall. How was I to know that my slap would return to sting me?

Translated from the Urdu by M. Asaduddin



The Accusation

Munnu the sweeper cleaned the courtyard and bathroom of Munshi Shyamkishore. After cleaning the house he came to the door and said, ‘Maaji, come and see, I have cleaned the whole place. Will I get to eat something today, if you please?’

Devi Rani walked towards the door and said, ‘It’s not even been ten days since I paid you. You’re asking so soon again?’

Munnu asked, ‘What can I do, Maaji? It’s difficult to meet expenses. A sole man, how do I manage both work and household?’

‘Then why don’t you get married?’ urged Devi.

‘You are young right now. For how long will you remain a bachelor?’ Devi asked, showing concern.

‘You have been taking such good care of me; with your blessings something good will happen. Will you help me?’ asked Munnu.

‘Yes, I will,’ responded Devi. ‘You find a girl first. I will do whatever I can.’

‘Your temper is very agreeable. You look after me so well. Mistresses in other houses don’t even listen or care to talk to us,’ Munnu said in a wheedling tone. ‘Allah has not only given you a lovely face but also a good heart. Only Allah knows, just by looking at you all my thirst and hunger melt away. I have come across many women from aff luent households, but they don’t even come close to your sole.’

‘You liar! As if I am that beautiful!’

‘Now what can I say to you! I see these rich and robust women of big houses, but apart from a fair complexion, they have nothing. They lack this charm, you see.’

‘Will one rupee be enough for now?’

‘Madam, see if you could spare two rupees.’

Devi gave him the money and said in a tone of dismissal, ‘All right, take this and go!’

‘Yes, Madam! If you don’t mind, can I ask you something?’ Munnu asked solicitously.

‘What is it, tell me? But quick, I have to go and light the hearth.’

‘Then you carry on, please. I will ask some other time,’ Munnu prepared to go.

Devi could not help asking, ‘No, no. Tell me, what is it? I am not in a hurry.’

Munnu asked her, ‘Do you have any relative staying in Dalmandi?’

‘No, nobody lives there,’ replied Devi.

‘Then it must be some friend,’ Munnu said rather nonchalantly. ‘I usually see your husband walking out of a bungalow.’

‘Dalmandi is the locality of prostitutes, no?’

‘Yes, Madam, a lot of prostitutes live there, but Sir looks like an innocent man. Does he come back late at night?’

‘No, he is back before evening and doesn’t go anywhere after that. Though sometimes he goes to the library . . .’ she said nervously.

‘All right, so that must be it, right?’ remarked Munnu. ‘If you get a chance, then caution him not to visit that place at night. No matter how pure a person is at heart, onlookers will always be suspicious.’

By then Babu Shyamkishore had arrived. Munnu greeted him, picked up his bucket and left.

Shyamkishore asked, ‘What was Munnu saying?’

‘Nothing, he was just going on about himself. He was asking for food. I gave him two rupees. He speaks quite cordially.’

‘You are extremely talkative! If you find no one else, then let it be this sweeper. How can you talk to this fool?’ Shyam hissed at her.

‘As if I like looking at his face! He’s a poor man. How can I turn my back if he starts crying about his fate?’ Devi hissed back.

Babu Sahib unfolded a garland of jasmine flowers from his handkerchief and put it around Devi’s neck, but there was no sign of joy on her face. She looked at him from the corner of her eye and said, ‘You like to stroll in Dalmandi quite often these days, isn’t it?’

Shyam asked surprised, ‘Who? Me?’

‘Oh yes, you. You make an excuse of going to the library here, but it’s all about the fun you have there!’

Shyam made a disgusted face, ‘All lies! Complete rubbish. Who told you all this? This Munnu?’

‘Munnu didn’t tell me anything; I am aware of all your whereabouts,’ she said defensively.

‘You don’t need to keep an eye on me. Suspicion is a great folly and if you get into this habit, major tragedies can befall. Why would I go to Dalmandi? Do I have someone better off in Dalmandi than you? I am a lover of your intoxicating eyes. Even if a nymph stands before me, I won’t care to notice her. Where is Sharda today?’

‘She has gone to play downstairs.’

‘Just don’t let her go outside. Cars and carriages are always on the move,’ his tone was a little thoughtful. ‘Who knows what can happen! Just today there was an accident at Ardali Bazar. Three boys were crushed.’

Devi exclaimed, scandalized, ‘Three boys! That’s catastrophic. Whose vehicle was it?’

‘That is not known yet.’ He added quickly, ‘God knows, these flowers look beautiful on you.’

Devi smiled coyly, ‘Come now, stop this flattery!’

After three days, Munnu said to Devi, ‘Madam, talks are on about my betrothal. I have full faith in you and I am going ahead with it.’

Devi asked, ‘Have you seen the girl? How is she?’

‘It will be as destined. At least I will get to eat home-made rotis now, otherwise I had to cook on my own,’ moaned Munnu. ‘Thankfully she has a gentle nature. Women in our community are quite frivolous, Madam! It’s hard to find a pious one in a crowd of hundred.’

‘You people don’t say anything to your women?’

‘What can we say, Madam! We are scared stiff as they complain to our bosses and get us dismissed. Babus keep an eye on these sweeper-women, Madam.’

Devi giggled, ‘You liar! Are the wives of babus much worse than these sweeper-women?’

‘Now, Madam, don’t make me say it,’ said Munnu. ‘I have not seen anyone who can match your impassioned speech. I am a small man, Madam, but had my wife been like the wives of these babus, then even I wouldn’t have felt like talking to them. I haven’t really come across anyone with a face like yours.’

‘Oh, you fibber, where did you learn all this sweet talk?’

Wondering if he had underestimated her, Munnu continued, ‘This is no sweet talk, Madam; I speak the truth. You were standing in front of the window one day. Raza Miyan’s glance fell upon you. He is the owner of a big shoe shop. Allah has bestowed him with wealth and heart alike! He lowered his eyes the moment he saw you. Today, while talking to me, he began to sing praises of your face. I said, “Allah has given her a face as beautiful as her heart.”’

Devi asked, ‘All right, is he that tall, dusky young man?’

Munnu confirmed, ‘Yes, Madam, that’s him. He said to me that if only he could get another glimpse of you, but I scolded him and said, “Don’t you dare speak to me like that. You don’t have a chance here.”’

‘You did the right thing. May that blockhead lose his eyes!’ cried Devi. ‘Whenever he passes by, his eyes are always on the window. Let him know that he better not raise his eyes here.’

Munnu reassured her, ‘I have already said that, Madam; now I should leave. Is there anything else to be cleaned? It’s time for sir to come home. If he sees me here, he will say, “What nonsense is he talking again?”’

Devi pleaded, ‘Take these rotis. This will save you from the effort of cooking today.’

Munnu went away murmuring, ‘May Allah keep you safe! I feel like staying close to this door and eating whatever crumbs come my way. Seriously, the moment I see you, my hunger and thirst disappear.’

Munnu was just leaving when Munshi Shyamkishore arrived upstairs. His last sentence reached his ears. As soon as Munnu left, Babu Sahib said to Devi, ‘I had asked you not to entertain Munnu, but you don’t listen to me. People like him take the news of one house to another; one should never talk to these people. What was that about hunger and thirst disappearing?’

Devi mumbled, ‘I don’t know, what hunger and thirst? There wasn’t any such talk.’

‘How is that so? I clearly heard it myself,’ he said sharply.

Devi replied in an exhausted voice, ‘I don’t seem to remember. Must be something. As if I sit and listen to everything he says.’

Shyam said reproachfully, ‘Then does he talk to the walls? Listen, there is a man who just passed by, looking towards the window. A Muslim lad from this neighbourhood. He runs a shoe shop. Why do you keep standing near the window?’

‘The shutters are drawn,’ cried Devi.

Shyam said impatiently, ‘Even if you stand behind the shutters, any man can clearly see you.’

‘I didn’t know that. Now I won’t open the window at all.’

‘Yes, what’s the use? Don’t let Munnu come inside,’ he pleaded.

Devi turned her head and asked, ‘But who will clean the bathroom?’

Shyam said, ‘Well, he can come but don’t talk to him much. A new theatre has come to town today. Let’s go and watch it. I’ve heard that the actors are quite good.’

At this moment, Sharda came running with a box of sweets. Devi asked her, ‘Hey, who gave you these sweets?’

‘Raja Bhaiya gave them to me. He says that he will buy me new toys,’ responded Sharda.

Shyam asked her, ‘Who is Raja Bhaiya?’

Sharda replied coolly, ‘The same man who just passed by.’

‘Is that man tall and dusky?’ Shyam hissed.

‘Yes, yes! That’s him. Can I go to his house every day?’ Sharda asked excitedly.

Devi asked, ‘Did you go to his house?’

Sharda said with a sudden grin, ‘He lifted me in his arms and took me to his place.’

Shyam snapped, ‘Don’t you play on the road downstairs. You will come under a car someday. Don’t you see, so many cars speed past!’

‘Raja Bhaiya says that he will take me for a ride in his car to get some fresh air.’

‘What do you do all day long? Can’t you keep an eye on your own girl?’ Shyam asked hotly.

Devi snapped at him, ‘A girl this big cannot be kept locked in a trunk.’

‘You are quick when it comes to answering back. Why don’t you admit that you don’t find the time because you keep talking all the while?’

‘Whom do I talk to?’ Devi looked at him scornfully. ‘There aren’t even any neighbours around.’

‘But there is Munnu,’ hissed Shyam.

Devi bit her lip and said, ‘Is Munnu my relative that I will sit and talk to him? He’s a poor man who cries about his fate. What am I supposed to say? I can’t chide him.’

‘Anyway, prepare the food, the performance will start at nine o’clock. It’s seven already,’ said Shyam.

‘You go and watch it,’ she announced. ‘I won’t go.’

‘You were the one who kept telling me for months that you wanted to watch the play. Now what’s wrong?’ cried Shyam. ‘Have you taken a vow that you will oppose whatever I say?’

Devi replied weakly, ‘I don’t know why you think this way. I do everything according to your wishes. If I go, you will end up spending more money and then say that your expenses have increased and badger me no

end. That's why I said it. If you want me to come, then I can. Who doesn't like to watch a play?'

At nine o'clock, Shyamkishore, along with Devi and Sharda, left for the theatre in a tonga. They had barely started when another tonga appeared from behind. Raza was in it. And next to him—yes, Munnu the sweeper who used to clean Babu Sahib's house was seated next to him. Devi lowered her head on seeing them. She was shocked to see that Raza and Munnu were such good friends that Raza took him in his tonga for a ride. Sharda saw Raza and cried at once, 'Babuji, look, that's Raja Bhaiya coming.' She clapped her hands and called out excitedly, 'Raja Bhaiya, look here, we are going to watch a play.'

Raza smiled, and Babu Sahib boiled with rage. He thought that these nasty people were here to follow him. *There was definitely some secret understanding between the two. Otherwise why would Raza bring Munnu along?* To put them off their pursuit, he said to his tonga driver, 'Be quick, we are getting late.' The tonga picked up speed. Raza's tonga also started racing ahead. When Babu Sahib asked the tonga driver to slow down, Raza too slowed down. Finally, Babu Sahib said in exasperation, 'Take the tonga towards the cantonment, we won't go to the theatre.'

The tonga driver looked at him questioningly and turned the tonga. Raza too took a turn. Babu Sahib was so filled with rage that he was about to challenge Raza, but he feared picking up a fight which would attract an unnecessary crowd and could turn serious. He controlled himself. He got irritated with himself for having chosen to watch the play. He had no clue that these devils would follow him. *I will get rid of Munnu tomorrow itself,* he thought. Raza's tonga turned in a different direction after going a certain distance, and Babu Sahib's anger slowly subsided, but it was too late to go to the theatre now. They rode back home from the cantonment.

Devi reached upstairs and hissed irritatedly, 'The tonga driver earned two rupees for nothing!'

Shyamkishore gave her a bloodshot stare and exclaimed, 'Talk to Munnu some more, enjoy looking at Raza from the window. What exactly are you up to?'

Devi raised her voice angrily, ‘Aren’t you ashamed to say such things? You are insulting me unnecessarily, this won’t be good for you. I don’t even consider anyone equal to the dirt on your feet, then who the hell is that sweeper? You think I am so low?’

Shyam replied curtly, ‘No, I don’t consider you so, but I do think you’re a fool. You should never have entertained this rogue at all. Now do you see what a rascal he is, or do you still have your doubts?’

Devi muttered under her breath, ‘I will get rid of him tomorrow itself.’

Munshiji lay down with an unsettled mind. He was in his office all day long. How could he know what Devi did behind his back? He knew that Devi was a devoted wife, but he also knew that women have a habit of showing off their beauty. Devi must be appearing at the window all decked up, and these scoundrels in the colony must be getting ideas in their heart of hearts. It was beyond him to stop this business. These rogues are clever at seduction. God forbid that their eyes fall upon the brides and daughters of respectable families! How to get rid of them?

After giving it careful thought, he decided to leave that house. He couldn’t think of anything else. He asked Devi, ‘So tell me, should we leave this house? I fear that they will sully my name if we stay amidst these rogues.’

Devi spoke in a challenging tone, ‘As you wish!’

Shyam asked her again, ‘You only tell me the way out.’

Devi sputtered, ‘What can I say? I don’t think we need to leave the house even if there were to be a lakh of such scoundrels, let alone one or two. Is one supposed to leave his house because of a few barking dogs?’

‘Sometimes, the dogs can bite too,’ Shyam warned her.

Devi didn’t respond to this remark. She was afraid that arguing over this would arouse her husband’s suspicion further. He was anyway suspicious by nature; who knows what he might think of her answer!

Shyam Babu left that house three days after the incident.

One day, a month after shifting into the new house, Munnu, with a bandage around his head, came limping with a stick and called out. Devi recognized

his voice, but did not reproach him. She opened the door. She was yearning to hear some news about her old house. Munnu came inside and said, 'Madam, ever since you've left that house, I swear, not once have I gone there. I feel like crying when I see that house. I wish I could come to this colony. I keep roaming here and there like a madman, Madam, I don't feel like doing anything. I keep thinking of you all the time. Who will look after me the way you did? This house is quite small.'

Devi replied firmly, 'We had to leave that house because of you.'

Munnu exclaimed in shock, 'Because of me? What did I do, Madam?'

'You were the one who was following us with Raza in the tonga. Anyone would be suspicious of such a man,' groaned Devi.

Munnu feigned pulling himself together and said, 'Oh, Madam, do not speak of that night. Raza Miyan had to meet a lawyer. He stays in the cantonment. He asked me to accompany him. His horse-wrangler had gone somewhere. Out of regard, we couldn't overtake you. You call him a scoundrel, but there isn't a kinder man in the entire colony. He prays five times a day, Madam, fasts for all thirty days. He has his wife and children at home. He dare not misbehave with anyone.'

'Anyway, must be. Why is your head bandaged?'

Munnu cried in an aggrieved tone, 'Don't ask me about it, Madam! My blood boils with rage when I hear people saying anything bad about you. The confectioner who stays next door was saying, "Babuji has yet to give me some money." I said, "He is not the sort of person who will keep your money with him." That's it, Madam. On that note, he picked up a fight with me. I was cleaning the drain beneath the shop. He came down and kicked me hard. I fell flat on the road. I got hurt, but I abused him so much that he will remember it for the rest of his life. The wound is healing now, Madam.'

Devi cried anxiously, 'Ram Ram! Why did you pick a fight for nothing? It was a simple matter. You should have said, "If he owes you money, then why don't you go and ask for it." We are in the same town; it's not like we have fled the country.'

'Madam, I cannot stand anyone speaking against you. I don't care if he is the owner of his house, how do I care?' Munnu said resolutely. 'Even if he

is a moneylender, he must be so in his own house. As if we eat from his share.'

Devi asked him, 'Has someone moved into that house yet?'

Munnu burst out in agony, 'Many people came to see the house, Madam, but a house in which you have stayed, how can someone else live there? We have told them to keep away from the house. Raza has not touched food and water ever since you've left, Madam. He cries thinking of your daughter. But why would you think of poor people like us?'

'Why wouldn't I? Am I not a human being?' Devi gave him a pitying look. 'Even animals don't eat for three to four days after leaving their old habitat. Take this money, go and buy something from the bazaar to eat, you must be hungry.'

Munnu said eagerly, 'With your blessings, there is no shortage of food. A person's heart is all that matters, Madam! Money has nothing to do with it. We eat because you feed us. Your temperament is such that a man can slave away without taking a penny from you. I will take your leave now, Madam. Sir must be on his way. He'll say, "The rascal has come here too."'

'He will take time to come,' responded Devi.

Munnu said quickly, 'Oh, I forgot to tell you this. Raza Miyan has given these toys for the little girl. I got so engrossed in the conversation that I totally forgot. Where is she?'

'She isn't back from school yet, but what was the need to send so many toys? Oh, what has Raza done! He should have sent toys worth two or three rupees if he wanted to. This doll alone must be worth at least four rupees. These toys are worth thirty to thirty-five rupees.'

'How would I know, Madam? I have never bought any toys. Even if there're worth thirty-five rupees, it's not a huge amount for him. He earns a daily profit of fifty rupees from his shop, Madam!'

'No, take them back, please,' Devi protested. 'What will she do with so many toys? Let me just keep this doll.'

Munnu tried cajoling her, 'Madam, Raza Miyan will be disappointed. He won't spare me. He's a very sentimental man, Madam. He becomes restless when his wife leaves for her hometown for even a day or two.'

All at once, Sharda returned from school and pounced on the toys as soon as she saw them. Devi scolded her and hissed, ‘What are you doing? Take the doll, what will you do with all others?’

Sharda could not contain her joy. ‘I will take all of them. I will keep the doll in the car and take her for a ride. The dog will run after them. I will cook for my doll in these utensils. Where did all this come from, Amma? Tell me.’

‘They haven’t come from anywhere. I had asked for them just to have a look. You choose any one of them,’ Devi said drily.

‘I will take all of them, Amma, please take all of them,’ pleaded Sharda. ‘Who has brought them, Amma?’

Devi raised her voice, ‘Munnu, you take the toys and leave! Let the doll remain.’

Sharda continued to lament, ‘Where have you brought these from, Munnu, tell me!’

‘Your Raja Bhaiya has sent them for you,’ said Munnu.

Sharda was overcome with joy. ‘Raja Bhaiya has sent them. Oh! (dances) Raja Bhaiya is very nice. I will show these to my friends tomorrow. No one has such toys.’

Devi said to Munnu, ‘All right, Munnu, you go now. Tell Raza Miyan not to send any more toys again.’

After Munnu left, Devi called Sharda, ‘Come, child, let me put the toys away. If Babuji sees them he will get annoyed about you taking these toys from Raza Miyan. He will break and throw all of them away. Don’t ever mention the toys to him.’

‘Yes, Amma, keep them away. Babuji will destroy them,’ Sharda said rather sadly.

Devi alerted her again, ‘Don’t ever let him know that Raja Bhaiya sent these toys, otherwise Babuji will hit Raja Bhaiya and will also box your ears. He will say that this girl keeps begging for toys from everyone.’

Sharda repeated, ‘Yes, Amma, keep them away. Babuji will break them.’

By then, Babu Shyamkishore came back from the office. He had a frown on his face. As soon as he entered, he howled, ‘That rogue Munnu has

started coming to this colony as well? I saw him today. Did he come here too?'

Devi said hesitantly, 'Well, yes.'

Shyam's face was distorted with anger, 'And you let him in? Didn't I ask you not to let him step inside the house again?'

'He started knocking on the door, what was I supposed to do?' said Devi.

'That rascal must have come with him too?' Shyam snapped.

'There was no one with him!' she said.

Shyam gave her a questioning glance. 'You did not tell him not to come here again, did you?'

'I didn't think of this. And why will he come here again?' she said meekly.

Shyam reminded her, 'For the same reason he came today. Why are you hell-bent on ruining my reputation?'

Devi spoke with attitude, rather annoyed, 'Don't you give me this nonsense, understand? Aren't you ashamed of yourself for speaking such filth? You had said something similar before. Today you're saying it again. If I hear this for the third time, it won't be good. I am warning you. You think I'm a whore?'

'I don't want him to come to my house,' protested Shyam.

Devi retorted, 'Then why don't you tell him yourself ? Do I stop you?'

Shyam hissed, 'Why don't you tell him?'

She could not bring herself to ignore this remark. 'Are you ashamed to tell him yourself ?'

Shyam said, 'It is pointless for me to tell him. Even if I ask him not to come, he will keep coming unless you ask him to stop.'

Devi bit her lip and said, 'All right, what is the harm if he keeps coming? Sweepers go to everyone's house.'

'If I see Munnu here again, it won't be good for you, I've warned you.'

Saying this, Shyamkishore went downstairs. Devi stood there, benumbed. She was hurt after facing this accusation, disgrace and mistrust. She began to cry. The thing which had hurt her most was the fact that her husband

considered her so lowly and salacious. He was suspecting her of something that even a whore wouldn't do.

The moment Shyamkishore entered the house, Sharda collected her toys and ran off lest he destroy them. She went downstairs and started looking for a place to hide them. She was in this quandary when one of her friends came to the courtyard. Sharda was impatient to show off her toys. She could not overcome this temptation. Babuji went upstairs, he will not come down so soon. Till then, why not show the toys to my friend? She called out to her friend and both of them got so engrossed in looking at the new toys that they didn't realize when Shyamkishore came downstairs. As soon as Shyamkishore saw the toys, he went to Sharda and asked, 'Where did you get these toys?'

Sharda choked at once. She started trembling with fear and couldn't utter a word.

Shyamkishore blustered and asked her again, 'Why don't you speak, who gave you these toys?'

Sharda started crying. Cajoling her, Shyamkishore said, 'Don't cry, I won't beat you. I am just asking you, where did you get these pretty toys?'

When he assured her thus three or four times, Sharda gained some courage. She told him the entire story. Catastrophe! It would have been better had Sharda stayed mum. In fact, way better if she had turned mute. Devi could have cooked up a story to avoid this situation, but who could avert the inevitable? Every inch of Shyamkishore was on fire. Leaving the toys behind, he went upstairs and, holding Devi by her shoulders, asked her, 'Do you want to stay in this house or not? Tell me clearly.'

Devi was still standing and sobbing. Hearing this ruthless question, her tears simply vanished. Fearing a new menace, she forgot about the previous accusations. It was like a patient running away from his sickbed upon seeing a slayer's sword. She looked at Shyamkishore with fear-stricken eyes, but couldn't say anything. Every mute cell of her body was asking him, 'What is the meaning of this question?'

Shyamkishore asked again, ‘You clearly let me know what you want. If you’re tired of living with me, then you are free to go. I don’t want to imprison you. You don’t have to lie to me or cheat on me. I am ready to dismiss you happily. If you have decided something, then so have I. You cannot live in this house any more; you don’t deserve to live here.’

Devi gained control of her voice and said, ‘What has happened to you these days that you keep spitting venom all the time? If you’re tired of me, then poison me. Why do you have to incinerate me? Talking to a sweeper was not that great a crime. When he called out, I went and opened the door. Had I known that this small thing would be blown out of proportion, I would have asked him to go back from afar.’

Shyam cried wildly, ‘I wish I could pull out your tongue from your mouth. It began with talking, then communicating through gestures, and now the gifts have also started coming. Now what else is left?’

Devi called out weakly, ‘Why are you behaving so ruthlessly? You won’t get anything by taking the life of a helpless woman.’

‘Am I lying?’ asked Shyam.

Devi said, ‘Yes, you are.’

Shyam burst out, ‘Where did these toys come from?’

Devi’s heart almost stopped beating. Her body wouldn’t bleed if dissected. She understood that the stars were not in her favour at the moment; devastation seemed likely. *At what inauspicious hour did these toys come in! Why did I take them? I should have returned them right then!* She tried parrying and said, ‘To hell with those toys! How could I stop the child, she didn’t listen to me! I kept saying, don’t take them, but she refused to listen. What else could have I done! But had I known that these toys would cost me my life, I would have snatched and thrown them away.’

Shyam asked gravely, ‘What else has come with them? Let me know for your own good.’

‘Whatever has come should be in the house. Why don’t you check for yourself? It isn’t that big a house that it should take you four days to search,’ Devi stood murmuring curtly.

Shyam's voice became aggressive. 'I don't have that much free time. It's better that you bring whatever has come. It's highly unlikely that no gift has been sent for you along with these toys. Even if you swore on the Ganga, I wouldn't believe it.'

'Then why don't you search the house?'

Shyamkishore clenched his fist and said, 'I've told you that I don't have the time. Just bring out all the things, otherwise I will strangle you this very moment.'

'Kill me if you want to; how can I show you things which have not come in the first place?'

Hysterically, Shyamkishore pushed her with such force that she fell flat on the ground. He placed his hands around her throat and yelled, 'Should I strangle you to death? Will you not show me the stuff ?'

'Fulfil all your wishes.'

'I'll drink your blood. Who do you think I am?'

'If that's what will make your heart contented, then drink it.'

Shyam bawled at her, 'Will you talk to that sweeper again? The next time I see Munnu or that rascal on my threshold, I will slit your throat.'

Saying this, Shyamkishore let go of Devi and walked out of the house. But Devi remained in that state for a long time. There was no trace of love for her husband at that moment. Her soul was uneasily seeking revenge. Perhaps she would have felt happy if someone, at that time, had beaten up Shyamkishore in the bazaar with shoes. After getting thwacked for so many days, this bitter wind had brought down the wall of love, and there was nothing left to console the heart. Today, there was only a thin thread of hesitation and worldly shame that could just break any moment.

When Shyamkishore left, Sharda also went outside the house with her toys. Babuji didn't say anything after seeing the toys, so what was there to worry about! Now, why wouldn't she show her toys to her friends? There was a sweet shop right across the road. The confectioner's daughter was standing next to the door. Sharda started to show her the toys. There was a road in the middle that was busy with traffic. Sharda was oblivious to the

world, unaware of its dangers. She ran in a childlike exuberance with her toys.

Little did she know that death was also approaching her to play the game of life and eternal rest. A car was coming from one side and a carriage from the other. Sharda ran, thinking that she would cross the road. The car honked; Sharda fled at her top speed to cross the road, but who could prevent fate! The car crushed her and sped away. She became a mangled piece of flesh, lying on the road, while the toys were left untouched. None of them had been broken! The toys were left behind, the one who played with them had gone. Who was mortal amongst the two, who was to decide!

People rushed in from all the corners. 'Oh, this is Babuji's daughter who stays on the first floor.' Who was to lift the corpse? A man leapt upstairs and called out, 'Babuji! Was your daughter playing down on the road? Please come and see.'

Devi looked down from her terrace. Sharda's body was lying on the road. She shrieked and rushed out to pick her up. Her legs were shaking. This bolt left her almost paralysed. She couldn't even shed a tear.

People in the colony began to ask, 'Where has Babuji gone? How to call him?'

What could Devi say? She was nearly unconscious. Taking the dead body in her lap, drenched with her daughter's blood, she looked up fixedly towards the sky, as if asking the Almighty, 'Am I to bear all the disasters?'

It was getting dark, but there was no news of Babuji. She didn't even know where he had gone. It was nine o'clock, but Babuji didn't return. He was never out for so long. Did he have to vanish today of all days? It was ten o'clock by then, and Devi began to cry. She was sadder at her helplessness than at her daughter's death. How was she supposed to cremate her? Who would go with her? Would anyone be ready to go with her at this late hour? If nobody came forward, then would she have to go on her own? Would the body remain here the whole night?

The darker it got, the more Devi began to fear. She regretted not having taken the body in the evening itself.

It was eleven o'clock. Suddenly someone opened the door. Devi stood up. She thought Babuji had come back. Her heart began to pound. Crying, she went out. However, it wasn't Babuji, but some policemen who had come to investigate the incident. The accident had occurred at five o'clock. The investigation was held at eleven. After all, the officer-in-charge was also a human being; he too went out for stroll in the evenings.

The inquiry went on for about an hour. Devi understood that diffidence wouldn't do. Whatever the inspector asked her, she replied nonchalantly. She didn't show any sign of shyness or fear. The officer-in-charge was also surprised.

When he was about to leave after recording her statement, Devi inquired, 'Will you be able to find out about that car?'

The constable replied nervously, 'It is highly unlikely that we will get any information about that car.'

'So there will be no punishment for the culprit?' Devi asked in a state of bewilderment.

The constable said, 'It's a constraint. Nobody knows the number.'

Devi probed further, 'Can't the government do something about it? Will the children of poor people continue to perish like this?'

The constable again conveyed his helplessness, 'What can be done? Cars won't just stop plying.'

'At least the policemen should ensure that vehicles don't speed at this rate in the city. But why will you people look into this?' Devi said sharply. 'You officers too sit in these cars. If you begin to stop these cars, then how will you continue to serve?'

The constable left, ashamed. When they reached the road, one of them said, 'This lady has quite an attitude!'

The other constable went on casually, 'Oh man, this woman has left me speechless. What a fine beauty she is! But I swear, I did not look at her. I couldn't pluck up the courage to stare!'

It was past midnight when Babu Shyamkishore came back, drunk. He had got the news on the way. He stepped inside the house crying. Devi was sitting, incensed. She had made up her mind, 'Whatever may happen, I will

rebuke him for sure.' But the moment she saw him crying, all her anger disappeared. She herself started crying. Both of them wept for a long time. This incident had drawn them closer than ever before. They felt that the old romance had been rekindled between them.

Early next morning, when people returned after the cremation, Shyamkishore looked at Devi lovingly and said in a melancholic tone, 'How will you spend your time alone now?'

Devi pleaded, 'Can't you take leave for five or ten days?'

Shyam assured her, 'This is what I was also thinking. I'll apply for leave.'

Shyam Babu went off to take leave from his office. Even during this hardship, Devi's heart was brimming with happiness. After losing her daughter, she had regained the love and trust of her husband, and this was enough to wipe away her tears. However, destiny had its own plans. Ah! Unlucky woman! Do not be happy. The final catastrophe is yet to strike, and you can't even imagine what that can be.

The next day, Babu Shyamkishore was at home when Munnu came and offered a salute. Shyamkishore asked him in a rather stern voice, 'What is it? Why do you come here often?'

Munnu said humbly, 'Sir, whoever hears about yesterday will be filled with sadness. I have been your slave, after all. So what if I don't work for you? I have been your loyal servant. Can that ever be forgotten? I have come to see if you are doing okay. I can't tell you how miserable I've been feeling ever since I heard about yesterday. Such a sweet girl she was, I forgot all my worries whenever I saw her. The moment she saw me, she would come out running and shout, "Munnu, Munnu"; when we as outsiders can feel this way, I can't even imagine what must be going through your mind.'

Shyam Babu softened a little and said, 'What can a man do against the will of God? My home is filled with darkness. I don't feel like staying here any more.'

Munnu asked, 'Madam must be feeling even more miserable.'

Shyam said drily, ‘She is. I used to play with Sharda sometimes but she used to be with her all day long. I can even manage to stop thinking in the midst of work. But how can she? It’s a lifelong misery for her.’

Hearing her husband talk to Munnu, Devi peered at the courtyard from the terrace. Seeing Munnu, her eyes welled with tears. She cried out, ‘Munnu, I have been devastated!’

Munnu expressed his sympathy, ‘Control yourself, Madam. What’s the use of crying? It’s because of all these misfortunes that one is compelled to deem Allah as cruel. People who are dishonest continue to thrive, even Allah fears them. However, people who are honest and innocent have to bear all the hardships.’

Munnu kept on consoling Devi. Shyam Babu was also rooting for all that Munnu was saying. When he left, Babu Sahib said, ‘He doesn’t seem to be a bad person.’

Devi echoed agreeably, ‘He’s an affectionate man. Had he not felt sad, why would he have cared to come?’

Fifteen days passed. Babu Sahib started attending office. Munnu didn’t come again. Till now, Devi would kill her time by talking to her husband, but now that he had resumed his duties, she would often miss Sharda. She usually spent her days crying. A few low-caste women staying in the same colony used to visit her sometimes but Devi couldn’t find any solace in them. They wanted to get something out of her after showing their false sympathies.

One day, around four o’clock, Munnu came again and called out from the courtyard, ‘Madam, it’s me, Munnu. Can you please come down?’

Devi asked him from upstairs, ‘What is it? Tell me.’

‘Please come.’

Devi came down and Munnu said, ‘Raza Miyan is standing outside. He is here to offer his condolences to you.’

‘Go and tell him it was all God’s wish.’

Raza was standing at the door. He heard this exchange clearly. He spoke from where he stood, ‘The Almighty knows, ever since I’ve heard this

news, my heart has been smashed to smithereens. I had gone to Delhi for some work. I came back today. Had this happened in my presence, what could have I done? But I wouldn't have spared that vehicle-owner, even if it had been a king. I would have scoured the whole city. Babu Sahib just gave up and slept over it; that's not done. Can anyone just run over someone and take his life! That cruel person has killed a delicate, sweet girl. Oh! Now who will call me Raja Bhaiya! I swear to God, I have brought a bagful of toys for her. But how would I know that this misfortune had happened here. Munnu, here, take this amulet and give it to madam. She can tie it in her bun. If God wills, she will be saved from all the dangers henceforth. She must be having nightmares, she mustn't be getting proper sleep, her heart must always be full and heavy. This amulet will ease her maladies. I have got it from a well-known dervish.'

For a long time Munnu and Raza did not budge from the door till they saw Babu Sahib coming their way. Shyamkishore saw them leaving. He went upstairs and asked sternly, 'Why did Raza come here?'

Devi replied meekly, 'He had come to offer his condolences; he has come back from Delhi today. He came here after hearing the news.'

'Men offer condolences to men, not women!' Shyam threw a curt remark.

Devi said, 'You weren't here, so he expressed his concerns to me and left.'

Shyam was again overcome with restlessness, 'So this means that if someone comes to meet me, he can meet you instead if I am not available. There is no problem in that, right?'

'I am not going to meet all of them,' Devi murmured sadly.

Shyam snapped at her, 'So is Raza my brother-in-law or my father-in-law?'

'Why do you become agitated by the smallest of matters?'

'Is this is a small matter? A woman from a respectable family talking to a rogue, is it a small matter? Then what is a big matter? Is it a small matter if I strangle you to death and be spared from the sin? I can very well see that

you're back to where it all began. You don't seem to realize even after getting such a huge punishment. Do you want to take my life now?'

Devi was lulled into silence. On the one hand, the grief of losing her daughter, and on the other, the bombardment of abuse and accusations! She felt dizzy. She sat down and began to cry. 'Death is far better than leading such a life!' She could only utter this.

Enraged, Babu Sahib said, 'Don't you worry, this is what will happen. If you want to die, then even I don't expect you to be immortal. It's better for you to die as soon as possible. At least my kin shall be saved from this disgrace.'

Devi said sobbing, 'Why do you misjudge a poor woman? Do you really feel nothing for me?'

'Shut up, I tell you!'

'Why should I shut up? Can you keep me tongue-tied?'

'Again you're going on and on! I will get up and smash your head.'

'Will you? Really?'

'All right then, let us see who your well-wishers are. Call them.'

Saying this, Babu Shyamkishore got up and slapped Devi several times and kicked her, but she didn't cry, nor did she shout or utter a single word. She simply kept staring at him with vacant eyes, as if to decide whether he was a man or something else.

When Shyamkishore had pulled away, Devi said, 'If you are not contented, then you can hit me again. Perhaps you will not get another chance.'

Shyamkishore answered, 'I will chop off your head! What do you think of yourself?'

Saying this, he went downstairs and banged open the door, clanged it shut and walked off. A river of tears started flowing from Devi's eyes.

It was ten o'clock, but Shyamkishore had not returned. Devi's eyes were swollen from all the crying. All her sweet memories had disappeared in the fury. It seemed to Devi that Shyamkishore had never loved her. Yes, he had sung praises of her beauty in the past few days, but that was all made up. It was to enjoy the bloom of her youth that he did all that sweet talk, that he

hugged her and laid her on his chest. It was all a façade, only playacting. She couldn't recall if she was ever truly loved by him. Now she did not have her beauty, or her youth or freshness. So why would he not treat her badly? *Now he is bored of me, otherwise why would he pounce on me for every little thing? He wants to get rid of me by blaming me for something or the other. If that is the case, then why should I stay in his house? Just to cook for him or become the victim of his wretchedness? When there is no love, there is no point in my staying here! If nothing else, at least I won't be treated like this in my own house. If he wants this, then so be it. I will think that I have become a widow*.

As night approached, Devi began to feel more terrified. She was worried that he would return and beat her again. He had left seething with anger. *Oh, my destiny! Does he think me to be so low that I will have affairs with sweepers and shoemakers? This man is not even ashamed to say such things! I don't know how he thinks of all this. It's just that he himself is a lowly creature, a typical, selfish person. One should behave in a lowly fashion with such lowly people. It was my fault to have put up with his rash behaviour. Where there is no respect, no limits, no love and no trust, it is worthless to stay in such a place. I've not been sold off to him that he can do anything with me, cut me or thrash me, and I will keep suffering in silence. If there were wives like Sita, then there were husbands like Ram too!*

Devi started feeling fearful that Shyamkishore would actually kill her when he came back, or stab her with a knife. She had read of such cases in the newspaper. There had been such incidents within the city too. She shuddered with fear. She felt that her life was in danger.

Devi packed her clothes in a small bundle and started thinking. *How do I get out of here? And then where do I go? If I knew where Munnu lived, that would have been of great help. He would have taken me to my house. She just wanted to reach her home. Then she would not think of coming back even if her husband cried or banged his head on the wall. He too would regret it! Why should she leave the money? So that he could make merry? I have saved this money with much difficulty. As if he has great savings. Had*

I spent all this, there would have been nothing left. I used to save up so much.

Devi went downstairs and locked the door. Then she took out all her jewellery and money, and placed them safely in her bundle. All the money was in notes, so it wasn't too heavy.

Suddenly, someone banged on the door. Devi was startled. She peeked from above, it was Shyam Babu. She couldn't muster the courage to open the door. Just then, Babu Sahib started banging on the door violently as if to break it open. The way he was banging was enough indication of his state of mind. Devi could not dare to face this danger.

In the end, Shyamkishore shouted, 'Damn it, open the door. You bloody . . . ! Open the door, right now!'

Devi lost whatever little courage she had. Shyamkishore was high on liquor. Had he come back sober, he would have softened a little. *I won't open the door, let him break it open. Now you won't find me in this house, so how will you hit me? I've seen your true colours.*

After shouting and banging on the door for another fifteen minutes, Shyamkishore began to talk nonsense. A few neighbours also shouted back at him, 'Despite being an educated man, you come home after midnight! After all, it is a matter of sleep; if she doesn't wake up, then what can be done? Go and sleep at a friend's place tonight, come back in the morning.'

After Shyamkishore left, Devi took her bundle and went downstairs with light steps. She stood near the door for a while to confirm that Shyamkishore had left. When she was sure he had left, she quietly opened the door and walked out. She wasn't angry or sad. She was only eager to run away from this place. She had no one she could trust or who could be of any help to her at this time of adversity. There was only the sweeper Munnu. All her hopes were now pinned on finding him. She would only be able to decide when she met him. Now she wasn't keen on going home. She was afraid that she wouldn't be able to get rid of Shyamkishore if she were to go there. On not finding her here, he would definitely go to her house and bring her back forcefully. She was willing to bear every torture and insult,

but did not want to see Shyamkishore again. Love, when slurred, turns into hatred.

There was a crossroads in the vicinity where many tongas were waiting. Devi hired one of them and asked the driver to go to the station.

Devi spent the night at the station. Early in the morning, she hired a tonga and reached the crossroads incognito. The shops had not opened yet, but she inquired about Raza Miyan's address. A boy was sweeping the floor of his shop. Devi called him and said, 'Go and tell Raza Miyan that Sharda's mother has come to see him. Ask him to come right away.'

Raza and Munnu arrived within ten minutes.

Devi spoke with tearful eyes, 'After you both went away, I had to leave my house. Your visit to my place last night has wreaked havoc in my life. I'll tell you later what has happened. Please arrange for a house for me. It should be such that Babu Sahib cannot find it. Else he won't leave me alive.'

Raza looked at Munnu as if to let him know how good their plan was. He said to Devi, 'Don't you worry at all, I'll find you a house which even Babu Sahib's father will not be able to find! You need not bother. We will shed our blood for your sweat. To tell you the truth, Madam, Babu Sahib never really deserved you.'

Munnu echoed the words of his partner-in-crime, 'You said it, brother. You are fit to be a queen. I used to tell you, Madam, that Babuji has a habit of going to Dalmandi, but you never believed me. I saw him stepping out of Gulabjaan's terrace last night. He was heavily drunk.'

Devi hissed, 'That's a lie! He has no such habit. He has a bad temper and loses his senses in a fury but he is not a bad person.'

Munnu tried coaxing her, 'Madam, why don't you believe me? All right, if I show you someday, then will you believe me?'

Raza interrupted him quickly, 'Show her later, right now you take her to my place. Take her upstairs. I'll go and arrange for a house in the meantime. It's going to be perfect for you.'

Devi asked, 'There must be a lot of women in your house?'

Raza replied courteously, ‘There is nobody, Madam, except an old aunt. She will arrange for a water-bearer for you. I’ll go and look for a house.’

Devi pleaded, ‘Take a look at my place too, see if Babu Sahib is back home.’

Raza said, ‘I am annoyed with Babu Sahib now. I might just pick up a fight with him if I see him. A man who cannot respect a beauty like you is not a man.’

Munnu agreed, ‘You’re absolutely right, brother. I don’t understand how he can rebuke an innocent woman like her! I’ve been serving Madam for years, but she has never raised her voice at me.’

Raza left in search of a house and the tonga proceeded towards Raza’s house.

Suddenly, Devi started harbouring doubts. *Are these two truly rogues? But how to find out?* It was true that Devi had abandoned her husband for a better life, but in that short span of time she had begun to regret this decision! How would she live alone in a house? What would she do alone? She wasn’t able to really make up her mind. She felt in her heart, *Why not go back home? God willing, he may not have come back yet.* She said to Munnu, ‘You run along and see if Babuji has returned.’

‘You go and rest, I’ll go and find out,’ encouraged Munnu.

Devi stood stiff, ‘I will not go inside.’

‘I swear to God, the whole house is empty. You doubt us! We are one of those who, at your command, can jump into fire,’ Munnu cajoled her.

Devi alighted from the tonga and went inside. The bird, now caught, flapped its wings, but could not gain its flight because its feet were stuck with birdlime, and the huntsman kept it in his bag. Will that helpless creature ever be able to fly again? Will she able to sit and chirp on the branches again?

When Shyamkishore returned home in the morning, his state of mind was peaceful. He was doubtful whether Devi would be at home. When he saw the door ajar, his heart stopped beating for a second. Open doors in the morning were not a good sign. He stood at the door for a moment and

looked inside. He couldn't hear a sound. He went to the courtyard; it had been left abandoned. Upstairs too, all was silent! The sight of an empty house was gnawing at him! Shyamkishore now started looking around a bit cautiously. There was no money in the trunk. The jewellery box was also empty. No doubt was left in his mind. When someone goes to take a dip in the holy Ganga, they don't take all the money with them. She had left for good. Now there was no doubt whatsoever. He also knew where she had gone. Perhaps she could be brought back this instant, but what would the world say? Shyamkishore sat down on the bed and started pondering over the matter calmly. He was sure that it was Raza and Munnu who had instigated her. After all, what else could Babuji have done? He left the old house, and constantly tried to explain things to Devi. What else could he have done? Was it wrong to have hit her? Even if it were to be deemed wrong for a second, was it right of Devi to have left the house in this manner? Had there been another woman who didn't have venom injected in her heart already, would she have left the house after being hit by her husband? Certainly, Devi's heart was blemished now.

Babu Sahib thought again, *The maid will come any minute. If she doesn't find her in the house, what will she think? The news will spread like fire in the colony. Oh God, what do I do?*

There was no regret or kindness in Shyamkishore's heart at the moment. If he could find Devi somehow, he wouldn't hesitate to kill her on the spot. Her decision to leave the house, even if in a state of frenzy, was unforgivable in his eyes. Anger can often lead to insensitivity. He began to hate the world. When one's own wife can cheat, then what is to be expected from others? The woman for whom he would live and die, for whom he was ready to compromise all at any minute—when she could not be his, then what could one expect from others? What had he not done to keep this woman happy? He had fought with his own family, severed ties with his brothers, so much so that they didn't even want to see his face any more. There was not a single wish of hers which he did not fulfil. Whenever she had even a minor headache, he would get worried. He used to look after her throughout the night. The same woman had betrayed him today, that too

after believing that rogue. She had sullied his face. But accusing that rogue was like consoling his own heart. How can someone be easily influenced if the heart is pure and clear? He thought, *If this woman has betrayed me, then there is no such thing as love and trust in this world. These emotions are merely a figment of the imagination of a few emotional creatures. Apart from sadness and hopelessness, there is nothing to imbibe from this world. All right, you wicked woman. You're a free spirit from now on; you can do what you want. Now there is no one to hold your hand. You have done this cruel injustice to the person whom you always called your 'beloved', you have been so insincere to him! I can drag you to court to get you punished, but then what's the use! God himself will punish you for your deeds.*

Shyamkishore went down the stairs quietly. He didn't say anything to anyone nor did he hear from anybody. Leaving the door unlatched, he walked towards the banks of the Ganga.

Translated from the Hindi by Shirin Bismillah



The Performance

Guru Prasadji is a light-hearted gentleman, incredibly fond of music and entertainment, of hosting parties and travelling. And with the same degree of passion, he is averse to the idea of accumulating wealth. Otherwise he isn't dependent on anyone; he seems like a good man and is nice too, but he can't stick to any job. He is still mawkish despite being as sweet as jaggery. He wanted to do something that would give him enough wealth so that he could remain carefree forever. He would get his half-yearly interests from the bank, eat sumptuously and rest without a care in the world. Someone suggested to him, 'Open a theatre company.' He became fixated on the idea. He wrote to his friends, 'I'm about to open a drama company. You all should start writing plays.'

The company's brochure was prepared. For several months, there was much discussion. A number of bigwigs promised to be stakeholders in it. However, no stakes were purchased; the company wasn't launched either. But yes, in his enthusiasm, Guru Prasadji had written a play and thought about giving it to a company. He already knew that people belonging to theatre companies were geniuses of their own kind. Moreover, every company had its own playwright. Why would he ever wish for an outsider to enter his company? He would find faults of various kinds and provoke the owner of the company as well. Thus it was settled that the company's proprietor should be impressed in such a way that his rival playwrights

would not be able to do anything about it. A committee consisting of five members was formed to this effect. The entire programme was decided in elaborate detail and the five members accompanied Guru Prasad the next day. The tongas arrived. The harmonium, the tabla and so on were loaded on to it since it was decided that the play would be performed today.

Suddenly Vinod Bihari said, 'Yaar, it will be quite an insult going there in a tonga. The owner will think that this gentleman is worse than ordinary. At this point we shouldn't worry about five or ten rupees. I am quite convinced of the advertising skills of the Britishers. Of a rupee, they use fifteen annas for it and do their job with the remaining anna. We should arrange for a couple of cars somehow.'

Rasik Lal joined in, 'But rented motor cars won't accomplish what you wish for. We should ask for the cars from someone wealthy, be it a Morris or an Austin.'

It was the truth. Appearances ensure alms. They began to consider from whom these could be sought. Good heavens! That one is very surly. You won't find water throughout the day if you utter his name in the morning. Anyway, how about going to the Sethji? Be reasonable, his cars are reserved for the officers. He doesn't even allow his own kids to sit in them. You think he'll give them to you! Then we should go to Kapoor Sahib. He has recently bought a new car. Oh dear! Don't even take his name! He will certainly make some or the other excuse—the driver is not here or the car has gone for repairs.

Getting impatient, Guru Prasad said, 'You all have unnecessarily created this difficulty. What is the harm if we go in a tonga?'

Vinod Bihari answered, 'You're out of your mind. Writing plays is one thing, coaxing favours is another. You'll be disappointed with your failure if your pages alone determine your price.'

Amarnath added, 'In my opinion, fawning on some king or aristocrat for the sake of cars is unnecessary in the first place. What will be truly commendable is that we go there on foot and leave a greater impact than what we would have managed with the cars.'

Vinod Bihari leapt with joy. All of them proceeded on foot. On their way, they would argue about how to initiate the conversation, how to build bridges out of encomiums and how to please the Dramatist Sahib.

These men reached the company's camp at two in the afternoon. There the proprietor, his actors and the playwright were already waiting for him. Paan, cardamom and cigarettes had been ordered.

As soon as he went up on the stage, Rasik Lal told the proprietor, 'Forgive us for our late arrival. We haven't come here in cars but on foot. It was agreed today that we would savour the hues of nature on our way here. As for Guru Prasadji, well, he's a worshipper of nature. If he had his way, he would have begged with tongs in his hands or else he would have listened to the twittering of birds under fig trees in some hilly village.'

Vinod went a step further, 'Moreover, we didn't take the regular route. I wonder about the places that we went looking for. It was as though our feet were under the influence of ominous stars.'

Amar added flavour to it, 'He is a complete *satjugi*. His servants ride in cars while he travels through the lanes and alleys on foot. He watches the beauty of daybreak when other gentlemen are busy enjoying their sweet slumber.'

Mast Ram chipped in, 'Being a poet is like shedding all worldly concerns. I wonder what he sees when he stares at a rose petal for hours together. The best poets of Europe have shot to fame only because of their devotion to nature. An elephant would've been dancing at his door had he been in Europe. One day he broke into tears when he saw a child crying. When I asked him the reason for it, he started crying even harder. Not a word issued forth from his mouth. He was only able to speak with much difficulty.'

Vinod said, 'Janaab! A poet's heart is a source of tender feelings, a repository of mellifluous music and a mirror of infinity.'

Rasik exclaimed, 'How wonderfully you've put it! Mirror of infinity! Splendid! Thanks to his company, you are becoming something of a poet yourself.'

Guru Prasad said politely, ‘I’m neither a poet nor do I claim to be one. You all are unnecessarily making a poet out of me. Poetry is that wonderful product of creativity which is fashioned not by the five elements but rather the nine rasas.’

Mast Ram said, ‘A thousand poems can be dedicated to this sentence alone. Did you listen to the poet’s glory Rasik Lalji? Memorize it, learn it verbatim.’

Rasik Lal replied, ‘Bhaiya, how much should I memorize! He talks in epigrams. And his humility is such that he doesn’t think anything of himself. This is the hallmark of greatness. Whoever thinks highly of himself is lost in oblivion or anonymity. (To the company’s proprietor) Now you’ll see for yourself, he has put his heart into this play. The gaiety that one finds in poets is completely missing in him. He must have read at least a thousand voluminous books to collect material for his play. You all know how much Wajid Ali Shah has been maligned by selfish writers. Only he could sift through such a heap of written material to extract elements of truth from it!’

Vinod said, ‘That is why he went to Calcutta with me and toiled in that ruined place for six months. He searched for a handwritten book by Wajid Ali Shah. In that, he himself had written about his life. An old woman had to be cajoled for six months before we could get that book.’

Amarnath said, ‘It’s not a book but a gem.’

Mast Ram added, ‘His situation had been like that of a lump of coal then, but Guru Prasadji turned it into a gold coin by putting the stamp of his theatrical authority on it. A play should be such that whosoever watches it should hold his breath in suspense throughout. Every sentence should get etched in his heart.’

Amarnath said, ‘He has read all the plays of world literature and has gone through hundreds of books on playwriting.’

Vinod quipped, ‘That is why the thing is unequalled.’

Amarnath resumed, ‘The proprietor of Lahore Dramatic Club stayed here for a week and begged him saying, Give this play to me. But he didn’t relent. When the actors themselves are not good, getting our play staged by them will be equivalent to ruining it. Good God! The actors of this

company are extremely talented and its dramatist is known all around. This play will create quite a stir in your hands.'

Vinod said, 'We already have a playwright who is even more popular than Satan himself. On top of it, we have the histrionic skills of these actors! The entire city will be euphoric.'

Mast Ram added, 'Every day people from some or the other company would insist on staging his play, but Babu Sahib wouldn't even talk to them directly.'

Vinod said, 'The heart remains restless only for the performances of this company. Otherwise, the plays that are staged by others are worthless. I have in fact stopped going to the theatre now.'

Guru Prasad spoke up, 'Writing plays is not child's play. You have to dedicate your life and blood to it. In my opinion, not even five years are enough to write a play. Rather, only one good play can be written in a lifetime. Although scribbling for the heck of it is a different matter altogether. The most prominent of critics conclude that a man can write only one play in his entire lifetime. I've read plays from every country—Russia, France, Germany—but there is some or the other fault in each one of them. Some of them have emotion but lack language, while the ones that have language fall short of emotion. If there is laughter, there are no songs and if there are songs, there is no laughter. But unless emotion, language, laughter and songs are present, it shouldn't be called drama in the first place. I'm quite an insignificant human being who has managed to acquire a bit of knowledge in the company of you people. Otherwise of what worth is my creation! But, God willing, you won't find such faults in my play.'

Vinod said, 'How can there be any faults when you are an expert on the subject yourself!'

Rasik Lal, 'For ten years you've just practised the art of music. You dedicated thousands of rupees from your home to your preceptors. It'll be really unfortunate if faults still remain.'

The Rehearsal

The rehearsal started and shouts of '*Wah!*', 'Oh, wow!', 'Wow!' continued without interruption. The actors, the proprietor and the playwright seemed to have woken up on hearing the chorus. The roles didn't impress them particularly but when the real thing appeared, it was as if their eyes had been opened! The stage had been set. The first scene began. The image of Wajid Ali Shah's court was recreated before their eyes. The repartee and the fluttering witticisms of the courtiers! Wah! Wah! What can one say! What sentence construction, what dexterity with words; how elegantly the rasas had been incorporated! The third scene was hilarious. People laughed so much that their ribs hurt. Even the portly frame of the proprietor, which was controlled and restrained, was shaken from its seat. The fourth scene was poignant. Pity after laughter was the lull after the storm.

Vinod had covered his eyes with his hands and was standing with a bowed head, as if in tears. Every now and then, Mast Ram would heave a sigh, while Amarnath simply gasped in astonishment. This way, scene after scene and act after act was performed, and by the time the rehearsal got over, the lamps had already been lit.

Until now, Sethji had been sitting there like a shrivelled piece of ginger. The play was over but not even an iota of his inner thoughts was carved on his face. He sat there, rooted to the spot. There was neither a smile nor any inquisitiveness, neither happiness nor anything else. Vinod Bihari asked, 'So? What does the gentleman think of this play?'

Sethji replied with the same detachment, 'I will address this matter tomorrow. As a matter of fact, you might as well have your food here. It won't be up to your standard but you could consider it as Vidur's insignificant offering and accept it.'

When the five of them came out like the Pandavas, they were extremely happy.

Vinod said, 'It's a sure bargain of five thousand rupees. I can sense it in every way.'

Amarnath quipped, 'I can't say whether it's five thousand or ten, but it created quite a stir.'

Rasik said, 'My guess is that it's worth four thousand rupees.'

Mast Ram retorted, ‘And I’m sure he won’t quote anything less than ten thousand rupees. I was looking attentively at Sethji’s face. I would’ve said it today itself but I was apprehensive lest they reject us. Although there wasn’t a smile on his lips, he was absorbed in it.’

Guru Prasad said, ‘Even I read it out with a lot of vigour.’

Vinod added, ‘It appeared as though your voice had been blessed by Goddess Saraswati herself. Everyone was left staring in wonder.’

Rasik said, ‘I’m slightly doubtful on account of his silence.’

Amar replied, ‘What can one say about your doubts! You doubt even God.’

Mast Ram said, ‘The dramatist too was very happy. It’s an earning worth ten thousand. Bhai, there should be a party today on account of this happiness.’

Guru Prasad replied, ‘But at least let me receive some money first.’

Mast Ram said, ‘We’ll have a grand function then. But today we’ll have a party.’

Vinod added, ‘You are favoured by fortune, Guru Prasad.’

Rasik said, ‘I’m of the opinion that the dramatist should be taken care of. His silence is intimidating me.’

Mast Ram remarked, ‘You are simply being foolish. He can try for all he’s worth, yet this deal will happen. Sethji can’t escape.’

Vinod added, ‘Our roles too were quite compelling.’

Amar quipped, ‘That’s what left an impression. Now he won’t have the courage to give a trivial amount.’

The Act

At night, there was a party at Guru Prasadji’s house for his friends. The next day, all five of them went to Sethji at six o’clock. Evenings are a good time for taking a walk. There was a ready-made pretext for not coming in a car today. Sethji looked extremely happy. The mournful face of yesterday had disappeared. He would talk boastfully and laugh at every opportunity as if he was some bigwig of Lucknow. Everything was ready for the party. Food

got picked up from the table. Grapes, oranges, bananas, dry fruits, sweets and jams of various kinds and liquor were arranged, and his friends partied quite indulgently. Embodying true hospitality, Sethji would go to every guest and ask, 'Should I order for some more? Have something else. How can food of your standard be prepared here?'

When they sat down after the meal, the matter was discussed again. Guru Prasad's heart trembled out of hope and fear.

Sethji said, 'Huzoor has written quite a beautiful play. How wonderful!'

The dramatist replied, 'Here people don't appreciate good plays, otherwise this play is splendid.'

Sethji retorted, 'People may not appreciate it if they don't want to. We really don't care about public opinion, not even one bit. On Babu Sahib's behalf alone, I'll spend forty thousand rupees on the preparations. When you've written something with such diligence then I too will advertise it with the same spirit. Isn't it a matter of great honour for us that a prominent writer like you has entered this field? This glory shall make you immortal.'

The dramatist added, 'I haven't seen such a play so far. I write as well and there are others who write too. But how can anyone match up to your prowess? At some places, you've even surpassed Shakespeare.'

Sethji said, 'That's what, Janaab, the thing that is written straight from the heart's impulse is incomparable just like this. Whatever Shakespeare wrote, he did it out of his greed for money.

'Our other playwrights too write for money. How can their work be of that standard, then? Why is Gosaiji's Ramayana immortal? Because it was inspired by devotion and love. Sadi's *gulistaan*s and Homer's works are classical because they were poets who followed their heart's impulse. The one who writes from the heart spends months together on every single line, every single word and every single maxim. The ones who write for money are only worried about completing one work quickly and moving on to the next.'

The dramatist seconded, 'You are absolutely right. Our literature's decline is only because we write either for name or for money.'

Sethji resumed, ‘Just imagine, he has spent ten years in the music academy alone. He must have given away lakhs of rupees to artists and singers. He searched for and collected his material from so many sources and with such diligence. He must have narrated it to so many kings and princes. Who can reward him for his diligence and dedication?’

The dramatist said, ‘It’s impossible. To think of rewarding such works is the same as insulting them. If at all there is some reward, then it is the contentment of his heart. That contentment is evident in every word of yours.’

Sethji agreed, ‘Indeed, you spoke the truth that such creations can only boast of the heart’s contentment as their reward. As far as fame is concerned, well, there are many creations that acquire it but are a real blot on great works of literature. Take the manuscript from him and divide the parts today itself. Within three months we’ll have to prepare it for the final performance.’

The dramatist picked up the manuscript that was kept on the table. Guru Prasad looked at Vinod with plaintive eyes. Vinod looked at Amar, while Amar looked at Rasik, but not a word issued forth from anyone’s mouth. It was as though their lips had been sealed by Sethji. The dramatist left with the manuscript.

Sethji grinned and said, ‘Huzoor will have to take some trouble. He’ll have to stay with the company for a few days once the play’s rehearsals begin. Most of our actors are Gujarati. They can’t pronounce Hindi words correctly. They give undue stress on some words. Your supervision will weed out all these imperfections. You entire effort will be compromised if the actors don’t play their parts well.’

Saying this, he called out to the boy, ‘Boy! Fetch some cigars for these people. The cigars were brought. Sethji rose from his seat. This was a goodbye message for the team of friends. The five of them too stood up. Sethji led them to the door. Then he shook hands with everyone and said, ‘Watch this poor company’s performance today. Who knows when such an opportunity will come again!’

Guru Prasad said as though from inside a grave, ‘I’ll come if possible.’

All four of them stepped out on to the road and started staring at each other's faces. Then all of them guffawed.

Vinod said, 'He turned out to be one step ahead of us.'

Amar agreed, 'He tricked us right under our noses.'

Rasik quipped, 'I was already apprehensive of his silence and had reckoned that he is remarkably astute.'

Mast Ram added, 'I have to acknowledge his brains. We'll never forget this loss throughout our lives.'

Guru Prasad didn't get involved in this condemnation. He walked with his head bowed as if he was still at a loss to understand what had happened.

Translated from the Hindi by Shailendra Kumar Singh



The Debt Collector

1

Seth Chetaram took a bath, offered prayers to Lord Shiva, chewed two small pieces of chilli, drank two lotas of water, picked up his stick and went on his way to collect his debts.

Sethji was around fifty. He had turned bald and his pate could be seen as clearly as if it were a barren field. His eyes were small but round. His protruding stomach began almost below his face, and his legs were right below his belly as if two pegs had been planted in a pontoon. But this was not an empty pontoon. It was full of life and driven by a sense of duty. Seeing the leaps and bounds, and the many changes of stance of this pontoon before a delinquent debtor, even a skilled acrobat would have been put to shame. How he would glare furiously! How he would shout! It'd attract quite a crowd. He couldn't exactly be called a miser because he would toss a coin to every beggar when he sat at the shop. Yes, he would show such displeasure then, his eyes would become so fearsome and his nose would become hooked in such a manner that no beggar would ever come to his shop again.

He was an incomparable devotee of the principle that the greatest of all profits is debt collection. After having his breakfast, he would collect debts without a break till evening. By doing this, he would save his ration on the

one hand, even as he had his fill of milk, puris and sweets at the expense of the tenants on the other. Saving a meal every day is not an ordinary thing! Even if one estimated an anna for every meal, then in his thirty years of life as a moneylender, he would have saved eight hundred rupees in this manner. On his way back, he would again receive milk, curd, oil and vegetables for his dinner, along with cow-dung cakes. Often he did not have to arrange for the evening meal either. So, he never failed to collect his debts. The sky could fall, there could be a rain-fire or a tempest but Sethji would unfailingly go out to collect his debts like an inviolable principle of nature.

His wife asked, 'What about your breakfast?'

Sethji shouted, 'No, I won't have it.'

'And your evening meal?'

'We'll see about it on my return.'

2

Sethji had loaned five rupees to a farmer. That wretch hadn't paid any interest in the past six months. He hadn't turned up with any gifts either. His house was no less than three miles away. So, Sethji had been postponing his visit. Today, he decided to visit that same village. He wouldn't rest without collecting his amount. He could cry and whimper as much as he wanted, but walking such a long distance was itself blameworthy. People would say, 'Big name and a small sight. Calls himself a seth and travels by foot.' So, he would walk at a sluggish pace, look hither and yon, and talk with the wayfarers so that people would think that he was out there on a walk, to have a whiff of fresh air.

Suddenly he saw an empty ekka going that way. The *ekkawala* asked him, 'Why, Lala, where do you want to go?'

Sethji replied, 'I don't have to go far; it's just a few steps away. But come, let me have a seat.'

The ekkawala looked at Sethji with piercing eyes. Sethji too stared at him with his round eyes. Each of them understood that the other was a hard nut

to crack.

The ekka started. Sethji struck the first blow: ‘Where do you live, Miyan Sahib?’

‘Where do I live? My home is wherever I go. My house was, when it was. Now I’m homeless, without any worth, and the biggest thing is that even fate has made me helpless. It has left me tailless. My grandfather was an administrator and collector of revenues of a brothel during the Nawabi period. Huzoor, he was the proprietor of seven districts. He would’ve blown up anyone in front of the canon or would have had anyone hanged to death. Huzoor, he would donate lakhs of rupees even before the sunrise. Nawab Sahib treated him like his own brother. Those were the days then, and these are the days now, when we are serving you. It’s just a matter of a change in fortunes.’

As soon as he shook hands, Sethji knew that he was a confirmed braggart, a seasoned campaigner. It would be difficult to get the better of him. But now the brawl had been fixed; he had entered the arena. He said, ‘Then why don’t you simply say that you come from a noble family? Your very face bears witness to that. Brother, it’s only a question of time; all days never turn out to be the same. At our place, Lakshmi is considered flighty and is always on the move; today to my house, tomorrow to yours. Your grandfather must have left you quite a bit of money?’

The ekkawala replied, ‘Arré, Sethji, there was no accounting for that wealth! I don’t know how many basements were filled with it. Gold and silver were stacked in sacks while the jewels were lumped into baskets. The glitter was such as would outshine the lamps. But fate too is something, isn’t it? Here my grandfather passed away, there the Nawabi was destroyed. The entire treasure was ransacked. People loaded their carts with jewels and went away. Still there was so much left that my father lived his whole life in luxury—the luxury that a fool can only dream of. He would go out in a palanquin carried by sixteen attendants. Servants with staves in their hands would scamper around him, both in front and behind. Still he left quite a bit for my subsistence. Had I lived prudently, I would’ve been well off today. But a rich man’s son will always live like one. I would get out of bed only

after consuming a bottle of liquor. For nights together, there would be gatherings with courtesans singing and dancing. Who knew that I'd suffer for it in this way?'

Sethji said, 'Thank the Almighty, brother, that you at least look after your family with honesty. Otherwise there are so many of our brothers who commit misdeeds day and night and still they want for every grain of food. Religion should be upheld, else everyone is able to live out his days. What difference does it make if you spend them eating milk and bread or chewing dry grams? Religion is the bigger thing. As soon as I saw your face I knew that you were a man of true and noble intentions. When people are unscrupulous, it's written all over their faces.'

The ekkawala said, 'You are right, Sethji, that everything is in order if religion is upheld. I get four paise from people like you with which I feed my family. Huzoor, just look at the other ekkawalas; someone is afflicted with a sickness of one kind, while someone else is beset with a disease of another kind. But I've repented. Why should we do such a thing as can lead us to trouble? I've a big family. Huzoor, there is my mother, my children, several widows and all my earnings come from this ekka. Still, the good Lord looks after us somehow or the other.'

Seth: 'He orchestrates everything, Khan Sahib. There will always be plentifulness in your earnings.'

Ekkawala: 'I just need the generosity of people like you.'

Seth: 'You need God's generosity. It's good that I met you. I am very scared of ekkawalas but now I know that there are good as well as bad people everywhere. I've never seen as honest and religious a person as you until now. What a pure disposition you've got. I truly appreciate it.'

Hearing Sethji's flattering words, the ekkawala understood, *This gentleman is a past master at talking. He only wants to cheat me through flattery. Now I should use some other angle to serve my ends. It's difficult to get anything out of his generosity; perhaps I'll be able to get something out of his fear*. He said, 'But Lala, don't think that I'm as righteous and straightforward as I appear to be. I'm righteous only with the good samaritans but with the bad ones I am a veritable scoundrel. I can serve you

obsequiously. But when it comes to the fare, I don't allow any concessions to anyone. If I did, what would I eat?'

Sethji had thought that he had won over the ekkawala through flattery. Now the journey would smoothly come to an end and that too free of charge. But when he heard these words, his ears pricked up. He said, 'Brother, even I don't allow any concessions when it's a question of money. But sometimes, when it's a matter of friendship, one has to give in, no matter how reluctantly. You too must have been forced to cave in at times. Friends can't be treated harshly.'

The ekkawala dropped a brick. 'I'm not considerate towards anyone. No teacher ever taught me lessons in benevolence. I'm a stubborn one of my own kind. Who would dare to hold back even a paisa from me? What do I care about others when I don't even give my own wife a penny? The other ekkawalas cajole their moneylenders and wait for them at their doors. But I wouldn't even spare the moneylenders and would drive them away lightly. Everyone shudders when they hear my name. I borrow money from them and digest it, plain and simple. Now I'll see how you recover your debts, smart one! File a lawsuit if you want. What's there in the house anyway that you can cart off!'

Sethji felt as though he was coming down with fever. He understood, this devil won't let me off without getting his fare. Had he known that this trouble was close at hand, he wouldn't have set foot on the ekka even unwittingly. It wasn't as if his legs would've been fractured by walking such a short distance. If I'll have to shell out money like this every day, then this debt collection will be in a shambles.

Sethji was a devout being. From the time that he reached the age of reason, not a day went by when he didn't offer his prayers to Lord Shiva. Won't Lord Shiva, who is so fond of his devotees, come to my rescue on this occasion? Remembering his favourite deity, he said, 'Khan Sahib, you may not yield before anyone but one has to cave in before the police. They aren't benevolent towards anyone.'

The ekkawala burst out laughing and said, 'Never. On the contrary, I exact some amount or the other from them. Whenever I find a victim, I seat

him immediately at a lower rate and take him to the police station. I not only get a fare but my reward too. Who can dare to object? I don't even have a licence. But I merrily drive my ekka through the market. No bastard can utter even a word before me. I earn quite a bit at fairs and among big crowds. I pick out the best men and take them to the police station. Who is ever able to serve his interests at the police station? They can hold whosoever they want—for one day, two days, three days—how does it matter? There are twenty pretexts to do so. If it's a man, they claim it's suspected that he eloped with a certain woman, and if it's a woman, they contend that she has run away from her in-laws in a fit of anger. Who can say anything then? The Sahib too couldn't walk out of it if he wanted to. Don't think that I'm straightforward. I'm a son of a bitch of my own kind. I don't fix my fares beforehand. Rather, I exact twice the amount that is fair on reaching the destination. If they make so much as a squeak, I roll up my sleeves, change my tack and stand before them. Then who can dare to stand up to me?'

Sethji was appalled. True, he had a stick in his hand but he didn't have the nerve to use it. Today he had been trapped badly. Who knows whose inauspicious face he must have seen while leaving his house? Even now all was not lost—if he could step down here and save whatever he could, that would still be better. Like a wet cat, he said, 'Fair enough, Khan Sahib, stop now for we've reached my village. Tell me, how much should I pay you?'

The ekkawala whipped his horse once more and said, 'Brother, consider how much I've earned. Had I not seated you, I could have taken three passengers. All of them would've have given me four annas each, which makes it twelve. I'll settle with you for eight.'

Sethji was dumbstruck. In his entire life he had never paid so much for a ride. He could never pay such a fare for a short distance like this. There are occasions in a man's life when he doesn't care about the consequences. For Sethji, this was indeed such an occasion. Had it been a question of an anna or two, he would have given it, albeit reluctantly. But for eight annas, which is half a rupee, he was prepared for not only a dispute but even a scuffle. Having resolved thus, he kept sitting firmly in his place.

Suddenly they saw a hut at the edge of the road. The ekka stopped, Sethji stepped down, took out a two-anna coin from the knot in his dhoti and tossed it at the ekkawala.

The ekkawala looked at Sethji's gesture and understood that the situation had taken an unfavourable turn. The sweetness of his efforts had turned sour. He now clenched his teeth. Responding to Sethji in a similar manner was the only solace. He said politely, 'Take it as a present from me to buy sweetmeats for your kids. May God bless you.'

Sethji took out another anna and said, 'That's it. Don't wag your tongue any more. I won't give even a cowrie more.'

The ekkawala replied, 'No master, how will our poor children be fed if people like you say such things? Huzoor, we too can see through people.'

In the meantime, a woman wearing a pink sari, and with paan in her mouth, came out from the hut and said, 'You're quite late today.' Suddenly she saw Sethji and said, 'Oh, so this morning you had Lalaji as your passenger. Why should you be in such a mood, then? You must have got a coin. Give it to me right now.'

Saying this, she went near Sethji and said, 'Sit comfortably on the cot, Lala. It's our good fortune that we caught a glimpse of you early in the morning.'

A pleasant fragrance came from her clothes. Sethji's mind was rejuvenated. He winked at her. The woman was playful, curvaceous and quick-witted. The image of his wife appeared before him—hideous, portly and cloddish, with chilblain on her feet and her clothes reeking of a foul smell. Sethji wasn't of an amorous disposition in the least but now he had been defeated by his eyes. Trying to take his eyes off her, he sat on the cot. He was still a mile away from his destination but completely forgot about it.

The woman picked up a small fan and began waving it over Sethji. With every movement of her hand, a waft of fragrance would come and intoxicate him.

Sethji had never experienced such exuberance in his life. Often people would look at him with disgust. But today his entire body had been rejuvenated. He tried to snatch the fan from her hand.

‘You are having trouble. Come, give it to me. I’ll do the fanning.’

‘What are you saying, Lalaji? You’ve come to our house as a guest. Won’t you allow us to extend this hospitality towards you? What else are we capable of? Do you have to go far this way? It’s quite late now. Where will you go?’

Sethji turned away his evil eyes, restrained his roguish thoughts and said, ‘There is a village not far from here. I have to go there. I’ll return in the evening by this same way.’

Delighted, the beauty said, ‘In that case, you can stay here tonight. Where will you go anyway in the evening? For once you can enjoy outside your house. Who knows when we’ll meet again?’

The ekkawala came close and whispered in Sethji’s ears, ‘Give me some money so that I can arrange for some snacks.’

Sethji quietly took out an eight-anna coin and gave it to him. The ekkawala asked again, ‘Should I fetch some sweets for you? Though there won’t be any sweets here that can match your taste, they’ll be able to sweeten your mouth.’

Sethji replied, ‘There’s no need to get any sweets for me, though you can bring sweets for the children with this four-anna piece.’

Taking out a four-anna coin, Sethji threw it before the ekkawala as though it didn’t hold any value for him. He wanted to see the expression on the woman’s face but was apprehensive lest she think that he was giving the coin as though he was quoting someone’s price.

The ekkawala picked up the coin and was leaving when his wife said, ‘Return Sethji’s coin. You just grabbed it. Aren’t you ashamed? Take this rupee from me and get fresh sweets worth eight annas.’

She took out a rupee and tossed it on the floor. Sethji was buried in shame. How could he bear to see an ekkawala’s wife, who was not even worth a farthing, be so hospitable that she would part with a whole rupee? He said, ‘No, no, this can’t be. You keep your rupee.’ Satiating his lustful eyes, he said, ‘I’ll give a rupee. Take this and buy sweets worth eight annas.’

When the ekkawala left to arrange for the sweets and snacks, the woman said to Sethji, ‘He’ll be here in a while, Lala. Meanwhile, you can at least have this paan.’

Sethji looked hither and yon and said, ‘But there is no paan shop around here.’

The woman gave him a wounded look. ‘Will paan prepared by me be worse than those of the shops?’

Embarrassed, Sethji said, ‘No, no, it’s not that. You are a Muslim, aren’t you?’

The woman replied with playful insistence, ‘Now that you say so, I swear to God that I won’t rest till I’ve fed you a paan myself.’

Saying so, she took out a betel leaf from the paan box and advanced towards Sethji. For a minute Sethji pretended compliance. Then he stretched out both his hands, trying to push her away. Next he shut his lips tightly. But when the woman remained unrelenting, Sethji ran frantically to preserve his dharma. His forgot his stick on the cot. He stopped after having run about twenty steps, and said panting, ‘Look, you shouldn’t attack somebody’s dharma like that. Our dharma will be sullied if we so much as drink water served by you.’

The woman chased him again. Sethji too ran again. In these fifty years, he had never been forced to run like this. His dhoti came undone and started slipping off. But who had the leisure to tie it up again? The poor fellow was running with the burden of dharma on his shoulders. He didn’t realize when the money bag slipped from the knot at his waist. When he stopped again after another fifty steps and pulled up his dhoti, he realized that his purse was missing. He turned back and looked. The woman held the purse in her hands, showed it to him and beckoned to him to come back. But dharma was dearer to Sethji than money itself. He walked another couple of steps or so, but then stopped again.

Suddenly his religious discretion, or perhaps his common sense, chastised him, *You’re deserting your dharma for a few rupees.* He would collect a lot of money again. But where on earth would he find his dharma again?

Thinking so, he went on his way like a dog mauled amidst hostile adversaries, fleeing with its tail between its legs. Time and again, he would stop to turn back and see if those devils were coming after him.

Translated from the Hindi by Shailendra Kumar Singh

[1] By Umashankar Joshi, himself a Jnanpith Award–winning Gujarati writer and then president of the Sahitya Akademi, in a speech delivered on 31 July 1980 at the FICCI Auditorium, New Delhi.

[2] Namwar Singh, *Premchand aur Bharatiya Samaj* [in Hindi: Premchand and Indian Society] (New Delhi: Rajkamal Prakashan, 2010), p.113. (My translation)

[3] See Amrit Rai, *Premchand: A Life*, tr. from the Hindi by Harish Trivedi (New Delhi: People's Publishing House, 1982).

[4] Quoted in Rai, *Premchand*, p. 74.

[5] Quoted in Rai, *Premchand*, p. 104. For a fuller discussion, see Harish Trivedi, 'The Urdu Premchand, the Hindi Premchand' (1984); reprinted in *Literary Culture and Translation: New Aspects of Comparative Literature*, eds. Dorothy M. Figueira and Chandra Mohan (New Delhi: Primus, 2017).

[6] For dates and titles of Urdu and Hindi publications of Premchand I have throughout followed Kamal Kishore Goyanka, *Premchand ki Kahaniyon ka Kalkramaanusar Adhyayan* [in Hindi; Premchand's Short Stories: A Chronological Study], (Delhi: Nataraj Prakashan, 2012), pp. 108–94.

[7] John Keats to Benjamin Bailey, 22 November 1817, www.john-keats.com/briefe/221117.htm, accessed 8 November 2017.

[8] Premchand, 'Kahani-1' (The Short Story-1) and 'Upanyas' (The Novel), both in *Kuchh Vichar: Sahitya aur Bhasha Sambandhi* [in Hindi: Some Thoughts on Literature and Language] (Allahabad: Saraswati Press, 1973), pp. 38–50.

[9] Edward Said, *On Late Style: Music and Literature against the Grain* (New York: Pantheon Books, 2006).

[10] Both the stories are collected in Premchand, *Kafan* [in Hindi: The Shroud] (Allahabad: Hans Prakashan, 1973), pp. 32–47, 79–95.

[11] M. Asaduddin, 'Premchand in English Translation: The Story of an "Afterlife"', in *Premchand in World Languages: Translation, Reception and Cinematic Representations*, ed. M. Asaduddin (New Delhi: Routledge, 2016), pp. 40–41.

[12] Harish Trivedi, 'Premchand in English: One Translation, Two Originals', in *Premchand in World Languages*, ed. M. Asaduddin (New Delhi: Routledge, 2016), pp. 15–39.

[1] Harish Trivedi, 'Premchand's Art, the Purpose of Literature, and the Urdu–Hindi Middle Ground', the Sixth Munshi Premchand Memorial Lecture delivered under the aegis of the Premchand Archive and Literary Centre, Jamia Millia Islamia, 26 August 2015 (New Delhi: Jamia Millia Islamia Premchand Archive and Literary Centre, 2016), p. 7.

[2] The Urdu journals include *Zamana, Hamdard*, *Tahzeeb-e Niswaan*, *Kahkashan*, *Azad*, *Khateeb*, *Adeeb*, *Subh-e Ummeed*, *Baharistan*, *Shabab-e Urdu*, *Nuqqad*, and *Al-Nazeer*, among others. The Hindi journals include *Madhuri*, *Navnidhi*, *Saraswati*, *Bharatendu*, *Vishal Bharat*, *Mansarovar*, *Chand*, *Jagaran*, *Hans*, *Prema*, *Prabha*, *Swadesh*, *Srisharda*, *Luxmi*, *Maryada*, *Aaj*, *Veena*, *Matwala*, *Usha*, *Gyanshakti Patrika* and *Sahitya Samalochak*, among others.

[3] In establishing chronology, I have benefited from the works of four Premchand scholars: Madan Gopal, Jafar Raza, Kamal Kishore Goyanka and Azimushshan Siddiqui. In addition, the *Zamana* archive at the Zakir Husain Library, Jamia Millia Islamia, was of great help. Unlike Tagore, who dated each of his manuscripts meticulously, Premchand was not very particular about either dating or preserving his manuscripts. In the absence of original manuscripts, it is very difficult to establish the date of first composition and the version—Hindi or Urdu—unless there is reliable corroborative evidence available, as it is with a story like 'Kafan'. What, however, can be established from different sources is the first date of publication, which does not accurately indicate the date of composition. Thus, the chronology that has been worked out for this anthology indicates the date of publication and the version, Hindi or Urdu, in which the story was first published.

[4] 'Premchand ki Afsana Nigari', *Zamana*: Premchand Issue, February 1938; rpt. National Council for Promotion of Urdu (New Delhi, 2002), p. 173.

[5] '. . . He was also one of those who almost always took up social and political issues as central themes in his novels, stories, and plays. He was extremely sensitive to the political and social movements of his times and considered literature to be a potent medium for carrying, critiquing and analyzing prevalent ideas.' Shashi Bhushan Upadhyay, 'Representing the Underdogs: Dalits in the Literature of Premchand', *Studies in History*, Vol. 18, No. 1 (Sage Publications, 2002).

[6] 'In a letter, he told Nigam that sometimes he followed the style of Bankim Chandra Chatterjee, and at others, that of Shams-ul-Ulema Azad Dehlavi.

These days, Premchand added, "I have been reading the stories of Count Tolstoy, and I must admit that I have been deeply influenced by them."' Madan Gopal, *Munshi Premchand: A Literary Biography* (Bombay: Asia Publishing House, 1964), p. 98.

[7] Gordon C. Roadarmel, *The Gift of a Cow: A Translation of the Classic Novel* Godaan (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 2002), p. vi.

[8] Amrit Rai (ed.), *Vividh Prasang*, Vol. III (Allahabad, 1978), pp. 249–50.

[9] Geetanjali Pandey deals with Premchand's complex response to women's status in his fiction and non-fiction in her article, 'How Equal? Women in Premchand's Writings', *Economic and Political Weekly*, Vol. 21, No. 50 (Delhi: 13 December 1986), pp. 2183–2187. For additional insights, see Charu Gupta, 'Portrayal of Women in Premchand's Stories: A Critique', *Social Scientist*, Vol. 19, No. 5/6 (May–June, 1991), pp. 88–113.

[10] 'I am Chitra. No goddess to be worshipped/Nor yet the object of common pity/to be brushed aside like a moth with indifference/If you deign to keep me by your side/in the path of danger and daring/If you allow me to share the great duties/of your life/Then you will know my true self.' Sisir Kumar Das (ed), *English Writings of Rabindranath Tagore* (New Delhi: Sahitya Akademi, 2004), cited in Malashri Lal, *Tagore and the Feminine: A Journey in Translations* (New Delhi: Sage, 2015), 181.

[11] 'Dhikkar' and 'Naagpooja'. In 'Family Break-up', 'Mistress of the House' and 'Subhagi' there is just the hint of a widow marriage at the end of the story.

[12] Shailendra Kumar Singh, 'Premchand's Prose of Counter-Insurgency in Colonial North India', *South Asia: Journal of South Asian Studies*, 2016.

[13] A trenchant critique of this idyll has been provided in postcolonial India by Srilal Shukla in his Hindi novel, *Raag Darbari* (1968).

[14] First published in the Hindi journal *Pratap* (December 1925); reprinted in *India Today Sahitya Varshiki* (India Today Literary Annual, 1995).

[15] Alok Rai and Mushtaq Ali (eds.), *Samaksh: Premchand ki Bees Urdu–Hindi Kahaniyon ka Samantar Paath* (op cit.) and Kamal Kishore Goyanka in *Premchand ki Hindi–Urdu Kahaniyaan*, second edition, (Delhi: Prabhat Prakashan, 2017) have drawn attention to this aspect by reading several stories in both the versions. However, this is still a work in progress. They have left out several stories from the ambit of discussions, as has been demonstrated in the Notes sections in the four volumes of this anthology. This anthology seeks to fill that gap. Now that

the raw data has been made available, a new impetus in research in this area is expected.

[16] Amrit Rai (ed.) (in Hindi: '*Prastutkarta*' [Presenter], '*Gupt Dhan*' [Hidden Treasure]; *Premchand* (Allahabad: Hans Prakashan, 1962), p. 6.

[17] I am indebted to Harish Trivedi for this idea expressed in his essay, 'The Urdu Premchand, The Hindi Premchand', *The Jadavpur Journal of Comparative Literature* (1984), pp. 22–115.

[18] Letter to Imtiaz Ali Taj, 25 December 1919.

[19] The Hindi original is as follows: '*Aisa lagta hai ke kai baatein Hindi mein zyada swabhavik dhang se kahi ja sakti hai, aur koi Urdu mein. Is pratyaksh anubhav ki jad mein kya kya chhupa hua hai—itihaas, sanskritik-samajik purvagraha, sahityik parampara—ye shod ka vishay ho sakta hai*.' Alok Rai and Mushtaq Ali (eds), *Samaksh: Premchand ki Bees Urdu–Hindi Kahaniyon ka Samantar Paath* (Allahabad: Hans Prakashan, 2002), p. ii.

[20] The following table shows such changes in 'Hajj-e Akbar/Maha Teerth' ('The Greater Pilgrimage')

	Hindi Version	**Urdu Version**
Title of the story	Maha Teerth	Hajj-e Akbar
Husband	Munshi Indramani	Munshi Sabir Husain
Wife	Sukhada	Shakira
Child	Rudramani	Nasir
Maidservant	Kailasi	Abbasi
Place of pilgrimage the family intends to visit	Badrinath	Hajj (to Mecca)
Name for God	Khuda, Allah	Parmeshwar, Narayan

Apart from Hajj-e Akbar, similar changes can also be seen in stories like 'The Call of Dawn' ('Shankhnaad') and 'The Correction' ('Pashu se Manushya').

[21] The Hindi original is as follows: '*Adhdhyan hi ye bataayega ke kis parampara mein kaun si baat kahna zaroori samjha gaya, aur kaun ghair zaroori; kaun si baat kahi ja sakti thi, aur kaun si baat ankahi hi samajh li gayi. Us prarambhik daur mein ubharti mansikataon ke sanket in rupbhedaon mein luke chhipe hain, dekhe ja sakte hain*.' Alok Rai and

Mushtaq Ali (eds.), *Samaksh: Premchand ki Bees Urdu–Hindi Kahaniyon ka Samantar Paath,* p. ii.

[22] In a recent article in *Wasafiri*, Boyd Tonkin, former literary editor of the *Independent* and someone who has worked to give translation a place of honour in several international awards, reinforces this argument when he points out how translated works were profoundly transformative for him even though he did not know the original languages: 'I can recall the late teen-age and early twenties frenzy of excitement inspired by my discovery of writers such as Kafka and Proust, Tolstoy and Dostoyevsky. Except, of course, that what I discovered were the standard English translations they circulated by Penguin Classics and a couple of other publishers.' Boyd Tonkin, 'Labours of Love: Literary Translation Inside and Outside the Market Place', *Wasafiri*, Vol. 32, No. 1, (March 2017), p. 9.

[23] Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak, 'The Politics of Translation', in Lawrence Venuti (ed.), *The Translation Studies Reader*, second edition (New York & London: Routledge, 2002), p. 372.

[24] The recent works of Amitav Ghosh (particularly his Ibis trilogy), Amitabha Bagchi, Chandrahas Choudhury, Hansda Sowvendra Shekhar and others reveal how Indian words of cultural import and regional specificity have been normalized in the English that is being written in India, which embolden translators in English to be innovative and mould the English idiom to their own advantage.

[25] 'Premchand in English: The Story of an "Afterlife"' in M. Asaduddin (ed.), *Premchand in World Languages: Translation, Reception and Cinematic Representations,* (New Delhi: Routledge, 2016).

[26] Here, the case of Kamal Kishore Goyanka, a lifelong Premchand researcher who has written close to thirty books on different aspects of Premchand's life and art, is salutary. Goyanka unearthed a hitherto unavailable story in the Urdu version with the title 'Roo-e Siyaah' (Black Face), but he read it as 'Rooh-e Siyah' (Black Soul) and translated it in Hindi as 'Kalooshit Atma'. This story was first compiled in the collection, *Premchand ki Aprapya Kahaniyaan* (Delhi: Anil Prakashan, 2005), pp. 152–60. On the facing page the Urdu title page is given where the title 'Roo-e Siyah' is written in bold, clear Persian script. One cannot attribute this error to any other cause except for the inability to read the Persian script correctly. Now, how this error will impact the readers'

response to the story and falsify the intent of the author is anybody's guess. This is not intended to undervalue the work of Goyanka, an assiduous researcher, but to underline the fact that we should spare no efforts to eliminate avoidable errors, understand our own inadequacy and seek help where it is needed. Many scholars, including Premchand's son Amrit Rai, have rendered the Urdu versions of Premchand's stories into Hindi, as indeed some have rendered some Hindi versions into Urdu. It will be a valid subject of research to examine how accurately these versions have been rendered.

[1] Ghalib was a renowned nineteenth-century Indian poet who wrote in Urdu and Persian.

[2] Khus coolers are used in India. They are made of sweet-smelling herbs and hung like a screen or mat over windows and doors for natural cooling of air.

[3] Farhaad is the besotted lover of Shireen in the immortal tragic tale of their unfulfilled love.

[4] Khwaja Khizr is a saintly figure in the Koran, who possessed great wisdom and mystic knowledge.

[43] 1 maund or 1 *man* = about 40 kilograms

[1] '*Fateh*' means victory, while '*haar*' means defeat.

[1] Bhan stammers and hence what he actually means to say is that, ‘May our country’s flag fly high. The temple of Swaraj resides in my heart . . . Drinking toddy and wine is wrong.’

Notes

A Mentor's Advice

First published in Hindi as 'Guru Mantar' in *Prem Pratima* (1926), and later collected in *Mansarovar* 3 (1938). In Urdu it was included in the volume *Firdaus-e Khayaal* (1929) with the title 'Muridi'. Now available in *Kulliyaat-e Premchand* 12 (2003).

The Mantra

First published in Hindi as 'Mantra' in *Madhuri* (February 1926), and later included in *Mansarovar* 5 (1946). In Urdu, it was included in the volume *Khaak-e-Parwana* (1928) with the title 'Taalif'. Now available in *Kulliyaat-e Premchand* 12 (2003).

The Thread of Love

First published in Hindi as 'Prem Sutra' in the monthly *Saraswati* (April 1926), and later included in *Gupt Dhan* 2 (1962). Not available in Urdu. Transliterated from Hindi to Urdu for *Kulliyaat-e Premchand* 12 (2003) with the same title.

The Basis of Life

First published in Hindi as 'Aadhar' in the collection *Prem Pramod* (1926), and later included in *Mansarovar* 3 (1938). Not available in Urdu. Transliterated from Hindi to Urdu for *Kulliyaat-e Premchand* 12 (2003) with the same title.

Qazzaqi

First published in Hindi as ‘Qazzaqi’ in *Madhuri* (April 1926), and later included in *Mansarovar* 5 (1946). In Urdu it was published in *Prem Chaleesi* (1930) with the same title. Now available in *Kulliyaat-e Premchand* 12 (2003).

Disgrace

First published in Hindi as ‘Laanchan’ in *Madhuri* (August, 1926), and later collected in *Mansarovar* 5 (1946). Later published in Urdu as ‘Fareb’ and included in the collection *Zaad-e Raah* (1936). Now available in *Kulliyaat-e Premchand* 12 (2003).

The Tonga Driver’s Reflections

Published first in Urdu as ‘Tangewaley ki Barh’ in *Zamana* (September 1926), but not collected in any Urdu anthology. In Hindi, it has been collected in *Gupt Dhan* 2 (1962) with the same title.

Ramleela

First published in Hindi as ‘Ramleela’ in *Madhuri* (October 1926), and later included in *Mansarovar* 5 (1946). In Urdu, it is included in *Prem Chaleesi* (1930) with the same title. Now available in *Kulliyaat-e Premchand* 12 (2003).

An Invitation

First published in Hindi as ‘Nimantran’ in the journal *Saraswati* (November 1926), and later included in *Mansarovar* 5 (1946). Published later in Urdu as ‘Dawat’ in *Khaak-e-Parwana* (1929). Now available in *Kulliyaat-e Premchand* 12 (2003).

Violence Is the Supreme Religion

First published in Hindi as ‘Himsa Param Dharma’ in *Madhuri* (December 1926), and later included in *Mansarovar* 5 (1946). In Urdu, it was published in *Prem Chaleesi* 1 (1930) as ‘Deendari’. Now available in *Kulliyaat-e Premchand* 12 (2003).

The Excommunicated

First published in Hindi as ‘Bahishkaar’ in *Chand* (December 1926), and later included in *Mansarovar* 5 (1946). Not available in Urdu. Transliterated from Hindi to Urdu for *Kulliyaat-e Premchand* 12 (2003).

The Head Clerk

First published in Urdu as ‘Badey Babu’ in *Baharistan* (February 1927) and later included in *Khaak-e-Parwana* (1929). Now available in *Kulliyaat-e Premchand* 12 (2003). In Hindi, it is available in *Gupt Dhan* 2 (1962).

Why Do People Marry?

First published in Urdu as ‘Shadi ki Wajh’ in *Zamana* (March 1927), but not collected in any Urdu anthology. In Hindi, it was included in *Gupt Dhan* 2 (1962) with the same title.

Sati

First published in Hindi as ‘Sati’ in *Chandan* (March 1927), and later included in *Mansarovar* 4 (1939). In Urdu it was published in *Aakhiri Tohfa* (1934). Now available in *Kulliyaat-e Premchand* 12 (2003).

The Symphony of the Soul

First published in Urdu as ‘Naghma-e Rooh’ in *Nairang-e Kheyaal* (March–April 1927), and later included in *Khaak-e-Parwana* (1928). Now available in *Kulliyaat-e Premchand* 12 (2003). In Hindi, it was published in *Madhuri* (August 1927) as ‘Atma Sangeet’, and later included in *Mansarovar* 5 (1946).

The Tree of Love

First published in Hindi as ‘Kamna Taru’ in *Madhuri* (April 1927), and later included in *Mansarovar* 5 (1946). In Urdu, it was included in the collection *Khwaab-o Kheyaal* (1928) as ‘Nakhl-e-Ummeed’. Now available in *Kulliyaat-e Premchand* 12 (2003).

Soujan, the Devotee

First published in Hindi as ‘Soujan Bhagat’ in *Madhuri* (May 1927), and later included in *Mansarovar* 5 (1946). In Urdu, it was included in the collection *Merey Behtareen Afsaaney* (1933). Now available in *Kulliyaat-e Premchand* 12 (2003).

Temple

First published as ‘Mandir’ in the Hindi monthly *Chand* (May 1927), and subsequently included in *Mansarovar* 5 (1946). In Urdu it was published in *Prem Chaleesi* 1 (1930) with the same title. Now available in *Kulliyaat-e Premchand* 12 (2003).

The Borrowed Watch

First published in Hindi as ‘Maangey ki Ghadi’ in *Madhuri* (July 1927), and later collected in *Mansarovar* 4 (1939). In Urdu it was published in *Khaak-e-Parwana* (1929). Now available in *Kulliyaat-e Premchand* 12 (2003).

Babaji's Feast

Published first in Hindi as 'Babaji ka Bhog' in *Prem Pratima* (July 1927), and later included in *Mansarovar* 3 (1938). Not available in Urdu. Transliterated from Hindi to Urdu for *Kulliyaat-e Premchand* 12 (2003).

The Actress

First published in Hindi as 'Aiktress' in *Madhuri* (October 1927), and later included in *Mansarovar* 5 (1946). Not available in Urdu. Transliterated from Hindi to Urdu for *Kulliyaat-e Premchand* 12 (2003).

Trial by Fire

First published in Hindi as 'Agni-Samadhi' in *Vishal Bharat* (January 1928), and later included in *Mansarovar* 5 (1946). In Urdu, it was published in *Khaak-e Parwana* (1929) as 'Mazaar-e Atasheen'. Now available in *Kulliyaat-e Premchand* 12 (2003).

Moteramji Shastri

First published in Hindi as 'Moteramji Shastri' in *Madhuri* (January 1928). Not available in Urdu. Published in Urdu transliteration from Hindi for the first time in *Kulliyaat-e Premchand* 12 (2003).

The Spell

First published in Urdu as 'Mantar' in *Zamana* (February 1928), and collected in *Prem Chaleesi* (1930). Now available in *Kulliyaat-e Premchand* 12 (2003). It was published in Hindi as 'Mantra' in *Vishal Bharat* (March 1928), and collected later in *Mansarovar* 5 (1946).

The Disappointment of Moteramji Shastri

Published in Hindi as ‘Moteramji Shastri ka Nerashya’ in *Samalochak* (March–April 1928), and later included in *Aprapya Sahitya* 1 (1988). Not available in Urdu. Transliterated from Hindi to Urdu for *Kulliyaat-e Premchand* 12 (2003).

Foolish Friend

First published in Urdu as ‘Naadaan Dost’ in the volume *Khaak-e-Parwana* (1928). Now available in *Kulliyaat-e Premchand* 12 (2003). In Hindi, it is available in *Gupt Dhan* 2 (1962) with the same title.

Two Friends

First published in Hindi as ‘Do Sakhiyaan’ in *Madhuri* (February–May 1928), and later collected in *Mansarovar* 4 (1939). In Urdu it was published in *Prem Chaleesi* 2 (1930) with the same title. Now available in *Kulliyaat-e Premchand* 12 (2003).

A Tearful Holi

First published in Hindi as ‘Aansuwon ki Holi’ in *Matwala* (May 1928), and later included in *Mansarovar* 5 (1946). In Urdu, it was published in *Prem Chaleesi* 1 (1930) with the same title. Now available in *Kulliyaat-e Premchand* 12 (2003).

The Grinding Woman’s Well

First published in Hindi as ‘Pisanhari ki Kunwan’ in *Madhuri* (June 1928), and later included in *Mansarovar* 5 (1946). Not available in Urdu. Transliterated from Hindi to Urdu for *Kulliyaat-e Premchand* 12 (2003).

The Hindi version is divided into several sections while the Urdu version has no section breaks.

A Wedding That Turned into a Funeral

First published in Hindi as ‘Suhaag ka Shav’ in *Madhuri* (July 1928), and later included in *Mansarovar* 5 (1946). It was published in Urdu as ‘Suhaag ka Janaza’ in *Prem Chaleesi* 1 (1930). Now available in *Kulliyaat-e Premchand* 12 (2003).

The Policeman

First published in Hindi as ‘Darogaji’ in *Madhuri* (August 1928), and later published in *Mansarovar* 4 (1939). In Urdu, it was published in *Prem Chaleesi* 1 (1930) as ‘Ek Daroga ki Sarguzasht’. Now available in *Kulliyaat-e Premchand* 12 (2003).

Moteramji, the Editor

First published in Hindi as ‘Sampadak Moteramji Shastri’ in *Madhuri* (August–September 1928), and later included in *Aprapya Sahitya* 1 (1988). Not available in Urdu. Transliterated from Hindi to Urdu for *Kulliyaat-e Premchand* 12 (2003).

Selfhood

First published in Urdu as ‘Khudi’ in the volume *Khaak-e-Parwana* (1928). Now available in *Kulliyaat-e Premchand* 12 (2003). In Hindi, it is available in *Gupt Dhan* 2 (1962).

The Day’s First Sale

First published in Hindi as ‘Bohni’ in *Bharat* (October 1928), and later included in *Gupt Dhan* 2 (1962), and *Aprapya Sahitya* 1 (1988). In Urdu, it was published in *Nairang-e Khayaal* (December 1928) and *Prem Chaleesi* 1 (1930). Now available in *Kulliyaat-e Premchand* 12 (2003).

Desire

First published in Hindi as ‘Abhilasha’ in *Madhuri* (November 1928), and later included in *Mansarovar* 4 (1939). Not available in Urdu. Transliterated from Hindi to Urdu for *Kulliyaat-e Premchand* 12 (2003).

The Rebel

First published in Hindi with the title, ‘Vidrohi’ in *Madhuri* (November 1928), and later included in *Mansarovar* 2 (1936). In Urdu, it was published in *Prem Chaleesi* 1 (1930) as ‘Khaana Barbaad’. Now available in *Kulliyaat-e Premchand* 12 (2003).

Experience

First published in Hindi as ‘Anubhav’ in *Madhuri* (November 1928), and later included in *Mansarovar* 1 (1936). Not available in Urdu. Transliterated from Hindi to Urdu for *Kulliyaat-e Premchand* 12 (2003).

The Balance Sheet

First published in Hindi as ‘Aaga-Peecha’ in *Madhuri* (December 1928), and later included in *Mansarovar* 4 (1939). In Urdu, it was published in *Prem Chaleesi* 1 (1930) as ‘Husn o Shabaab’. Now available in *Kulliyaat-e Premchand* 12 (2003). In another Urdu version, it was published as ‘Kashmakash’.

Resignation

First published in Hindi as ‘Isteefa’ in *Bharatbandhu* (December 1928), and later included in *Mansarovar* 5 (1939). In Urdu it was compiled in *Prem Chaleesi* 1 (1930) with the same title. Now available in *Kulliyaat-e Premchand* 12 (2003).

Atonement

First published in Hindi as ‘Praayashchit’ in *Saraswati* (January 1929), and later included in *Mansarovar* 5 (1946). In Urdu, it was published in *Prem Chaleesi* 1 (1930) as ‘Kaffara’. Now available in *Kulliyaat-e Premchand* 12 (2003).

Nitpicker

First published in Hindi as ‘Khuchad’ in *Madhuri* (February 1929), and later included in *Mansarovar* 4 (1939). Not available in Urdu. Transliterated from Hindi to Urdu for *Kulliyaat-e Premchand* 12 (2003).

The Holi of Love

First published in Hindi as ‘Prem ki Holi’ in *Matwala* (March, 1929), and later included in *Kafan* (1937). Not available in Urdu. Transliterated from Hindi to Urdu for *Kulliyaat-e Premchand* 12 (2003).

In Memoriam

First published in Hindi as ‘Fatiha’ in *Vishal Bharat* (March 1929), and later included in *Mansarovar* 7 (1947). Not available in Urdu. Transliterated from Hindi to Urdu for *Kulliyaat-e Premchand* 12 (2003)

A Trip to the Hills

First published in Hindi as ‘Parvat Yatra’ in *Madhuri* (April 1929), and later included in *Gupt Dhan* 2 (1962). Not available in Urdu. Transliterated from Hindi to Urdu for *Kulliyaat-e Premchand* 12 (2003).

Mother

First published in Hindi as ‘Ma’ in *Madhuri* (July 1929), and later included in *Mansarovar* 1 (1936). In Urdu, it was published in *Vardaat* (1938). Now available in *Kulliyaat-e Premchand* 12 (2003).

Mourning

First published in Hindi as ‘Ghami’ in *Matwala* (August, 1929), and later included in *Aprapya Sahitya* 1 (1988). Not available in Urdu. Transliterated from Hindi to Urdu for *Kulliyaat-e Premchand* 13 (2003).

The Legal Eagle

First published in Hindi as ‘Qanooni Kumar’ in *Madhuri* (August 1929), and later included in *Mansarovar* 2 (1936). Not available in Urdu. Transliterated from Hindi to Urdu for *Kulliyaat-e Premchand* 12 (2003).

Holy War

First published as ‘Jihad’ in Hindi in the collection *Paanch Phool* (November 1929), and later included in *Mansarovar* 7 (1947). In Urdu, it was published with the same title in *Prem Chaleesi* 2 (1930). Now available in *Kulliyaat-e Premchand* 12 (2003).

Family Break-up

First published in Hindi as ‘Algojya’ in *Madhuri* (October 1929), and later included in *Mansarovar* 1 (1936). In Urdu, it was published as ‘Alhaidgi’ in *Zamana* (February 1930). Now available in *Kulliyaat-e Premchand* 13 (2003).

The Live-in Son-in-law

First published in Hindi as ‘Ghar Jamai’ in *Madhuri* (November 1929), and later included in *Mansarovar* 1 (1936). In Urdu, it was published in the collection *Zaad-e Raah* (1936) as ‘Khaana Damad’. Now available in *Kulliyaat-e Premchand* 13 (2003).

The Woman Who Sold Grass

First published in Hindi as ‘Ghaaswali’ in *Madhuri* (December 1929), and later included in *Mansarovar* 1 (1936). In Urdu, it was published with the same title in *Prem Chaleesi* 2 (1930). Now available in *Kulliyaat-e Premchand* 13 (2003).

A Narrow Escape

First published in Hindi as ‘Kavach’ in *Vishal Bharat* (December 1929), and later included in *Gupt Dhan* 2 (1962). In Urdu, it was published in *Prem Chaleesi* 2 (1930) as ‘Harz-e Jaan’. Now available in *Kulliyaat-e Premchand* 13 (2003).

Two Graves

First published in Hindi as ‘Do Qabrein’ in *Maya* (January 1930), and included later in *Mansarovar* 4 (1939). Later published in Urdu as ‘Mazaar-e Ulfat’ in *Prem Chaleesi* 2 (1930). Now available in *Kulliyaat-e Premchand* 13 (2003).

Prison

First published in Urdu with the title ‘Aashian Barbaad’ in *Chandan* (January 1930), and included in the collection *Zaad-e Raah* (1936). Later published in Hindi with the title ‘Jeil’ in *Hans* (February 1931), and included in *Mansarovar* 7 (1947).

The Servant of the Nation

First published in Urdu as ‘Qaum ka Khadim’ in the collection *Prem Chaleesi* 1 (1930). Now available in *Kulliyaat-e Premchand* 13 (2003). In Hindi, it was published as ‘Rashtra ka Sevak’ and compiled in *Gupt Dhan* 2 (1962).

The Goddess

First published in Urdu as ‘Devi’ in *Prem Chaleesi* 1 (1930). Now available in *Kulliyaat-e Premchand* 12 (2003). In Hindi, it is available with the same title in *Gupt Dhan* 2 (1962).

Shame

First published in Hindi as ‘Dhikkar’ in *Madhuri* (February 1930), and collected in *Mansarovar* 3 (1938). Not available in Urdu. Transliterated from Hindi to Urdu for *Kulliyaat-e Premchand* 13 (2003).

The Procession

First published in Hindi as ‘Juloos’ in *Hans* (March 1930), and later collected in *Mansarovar* 7 (1947). In Urdu, it was compiled in *Prem Chaleesi* 2 (1930). Now available in *Kulliyaat-e Premchand* 13 (2003).

Subhagi

First published in Hindi in *Madhuri* (March 1930), and later included in *Mansarovar* 1 (1936). Not published so far in Urdu. Transliterated from Hindi to Urdu for *Kulliyaat-e Premchand* 13 (2003).

Role Reversal

First published in Hindi with the title ‘Patni se Pati’ in *Madhuri* (April 1930), and later included in *Mansarovar* 7 (1947). Later published in Urdu with the title ‘Biwi se Shauhar’ in *Prem Chaleesi* 2 (1930). Now available in *Kulliyaat-e Premchand* 13 (2003).

The Closed Door

First publication date is unknown. It was published in Urdu as ‘Band Darwaza’ and included in *Prem Chaleesi* 1 (1930). Now available in *Kulliyaat-e Premchand* 13 (2003). It was published in Hindi in *Gupt Dhan* 2 (1962).

Salvation

First published in Hindi with the title ‘Sadgati’ in *Vishaal Bharat* (October 1931), and later included in *Mansarovar* 4 (1939). In Urdu, it was published in *Aakhiri Tohfa* (1934) with the title ‘Nijaat’. Now available in *Kulliyaat-e Premchand* 13 (2003).

Trident

First publication date unknown. It was published in Urdu as ‘Tirsool’ in *Prem Chaleesi* 1 (1930). Now available in *Kulliyaat-e Premchand* 13 (2003). In Hindi, it was published in *Gupt Dhan* 2 (1962) with the same title.

The Journey of War

First published in Hindi as ‘Samar Yaatra’ in *Hans* (April 1930), and later compiled in *Mansarovar* 7 (1947). Not published so far in Urdu. Transliterated from Hindi to Urdu for *Kulliyaat-e Premchand* 13 (2003).

The Wine Shop

First published in Hindi as ‘Sharab ki Dukaan’ in *Hans* (May 1930), and later included in *Mansarovar* 7 (1947). Later transliterated from Hindi to Urdu and published in the annual issue of *Nairang-e Khayaal* (1931). This version is now available in *Kulliyaat-e Premchand* 13 (2003).

A Night in the Month of Poos

First published in Hindi as ‘Poos ki Raat’ in *Madhuri* (May 1930), and later included in *Mansarovar* 1 (1936). Later published in Urdu with the same title and included in *Prem Chaleesi* (1930). Now available in *Kulliyaat-e Premchand* 13 (2003).

The endings of the stories in Urdu and Hindi are radically different from each other. Their implications have been explained in the Introduction to this anthology.

The Urdu story ends with the following paragraph which is missing in the Hindi one:

‘I’ll not pay the rent, I tell you. We till the land to live, not to die.’

‘Jabra is still sleeping. He never sleeps this much.’

‘Go and tell Sahna that the animals have eaten up the crop. We won’t give a paisa.’

‘The night was terribly cold.’

‘What I say and what you hear!’

‘You want Sahna to call me names again? What does he care about all this! Whether the animals eat up your crop, fire burns it or the hail kills it, he simply wants his money.’

‘Give up tilling, I say! We’ve had enough of it!’

Halku said despairingly, ‘I too feel the same way, that I should give up working the land. Really, I mean it. But my heart sinks when I think of becoming a day labourer. I’m a farmer’s son, I shan’t be a day labourer. I won’t do anything that will hurt the dignity of the land. Jabra, hey Jabra, will you keep sleeping? Come, let’s go home.’

Translated from the Urdu by M. Asaduddin

Maiku and the Congress Volunteer

First published in Hindi as ‘Maiku’ in *Hans* (June 1930), and later collected in *Mansarovar* 7 (1947). Not available in Urdu. Transliterated from Hindi to Urdu for *Kulliyaat-e Premchand* 13 (2003).

The Dream

First published in Hindi as ‘Swapan’ in the monthly *Veena* (July 1930), and later collected in *Aprapya Sahitya* 1 (1988). Not available in Urdu. Transliterated from Hindi to Urdu for *Kulliyaat-e Premchand* 13 (2003).

Sacrifice

First published in Hindi with the title ‘Ahuti’ in *Hans* (November 1930), and later collected in *Kafan* (1937). It was published in Urdu with the title ‘Jeil’ in *Chandan* (January 1931), and later collected in *Aakhiri Tohfa* (1935). Now available in *Kulliyaat-e Premchand* 13 (2003).

The Lunatic Lover

First published in Hindi as ‘Unmaad’ in *Madhuri* (January 1931), and collected in *Mansarovar* 2 (1936). Not available in Urdu. Transliterated from Hindi to Urdu for the first time for *Kulliyaat-e Premchand* 13 (2003).

Dhaporsankh

First published in Hindi as ‘Dhaporsankh’ in *Hans* (January 1930), and included in *Mansarovar* 4 (1939). Later published in Urdu in *Chandan* (March 1931). Collected for the first time in Urdu in *Kulliyaat-e Premchand* 13 (2003).

The Final Excuse

First published in Urdu with the title ‘Aakhiri Heela’ in *Chandan* (1930), and later collected in *Aakhiri Tohfa* (1935). Now available in *Kulliyaat-e Premchand* 13 (2003). It was published in Hindi in *Hans* in 1931, and later compiled in *Mansarovar* 1 (1936).

The Accusation

First published in Hindi with the title ‘Laanchan’ in *Madhuri* (February 1931), and later collected in *Mansarovar* 5 (1946). In Urdu, it was published in *Chandan* (July 1932), and collected in *Zaad-e Raah* (1936). Now available in *Kulliyaat-e Premchand* 13 (2003).

The Performance

First published in Hindi as ‘Dimanstrashun’ in *Prabha* (April 1931), and later included in *Mansarovar* 4 (1939). It was published in Urdu in *Humayun* (1932), and later collected in *Aakhiri Tohfa* (1935). Now available in *Kulliyaat-e Premchand* 13 (2003).

The Debt Collector

First published in Hindi as ‘Tagada’ and collected first in the volume *Prerna* (1931), and later in *Mansarovar* 4 (1939). Not available in Urdu. Transliterated from Hindi to Urdu for *Kulliyaat-e Premchand* 13 (2003).

Glossary

aanchal	end or corner of a sari
aarti	part of the ceremony of worship when the sacred flame is circled round the holy image
abeer/gulal	liquid colour
adharma	opposite of dharma; anti-religion
aerund	castor plant
Aghan	winter month in the Indian calendar corresponding to November–December
ahir	cowherd
akhada	wrestling ring
amama	special big and heavy turban
amavas	the night of the new moon
angeethi	stove that works on coal
angochha	shoulder cloth
angrakhan	buttoned-up coats and kurtas with delicate embroidery
Asarh	farming month in the rainy season corresponding to June–July
Ashtami	eighth day of the lunar fortnight
Ashwin	autumn month corresponding to September–October
atai	self-taught singer; tutor
atal	inflexible; unchangeable
auliya	protector, a person who has achieved sainthood
baari	maker of leaf plates
bahli	two-wheeled covered cart pulled by oxen
bahu	daughter-in-law
Baisakh	first Indian month, corresponding to April–May
bal kaand	part of the Ramayana dealing with the boyhood of Lord Rama
balushahi	sweetmeat
banjara	nomad
baraat	marriage party of the bridegroom, comprising family and friends
baradari	a structure with twelve gateways
bara maasa	poetic form describing the feelings of a beloved separated from her lover through all twelve months of the year
Bargada	deity
bhabhi	older brother's wife
bhabhoot	sacred ash
Bhadon	rainy month corresponding to August–September
Bhagat	person who abstains from meat and alcohol
biwi	wife
Brahmani	wife of a brahmin
brahmbhoj	ritualistic feeding of Brahmins to get their blessings
brata	religious practice to carry out certain obligations so one can achieve divine blessings for the fulfilment of one or several desires

chabutara	raised platform
Chait	hot and dry month corresponding to March–April
Chamar	tanner, cobbler
chamarin	tanner woman
charnamrita	literally, foot nectar; a mixture of milk, curd, ghee, sugar and honey, considered sacred, and used in the tending of idols and sacred objects
chatty	container
Chaudhuri	high-caste person
chaudhurain	wife of a chaudhuri
chaugan	polo
chauki	wooden stool or plank; bench
chaupai	quatrain
chaupal	village square; meeting place
chautal	'four claps', a particular style of singing
chela	disciple
chhakda	ramshackle cart
chopad	a game
chulha	earthen oven
chunri	dupatta; stole
churan	digestive
dadra	form of musical composition
Darbar-e Aam	court of public audience
Darbar-e Khaas	court of private audience
daroga	police inspector or superintendent of tolls or of municipal or government departments
dastarkhwan	cloth spread on the ground or a raised structure for laying out food
dhaam	pilgrimage site
Dhanvantari	physician of the gods
dharmatma	man of religion; spiritual guru
dharmayudh	holy war; crusade
dholi	bundle of about two hundred paan leaves
Diwan-e Aam	hall of public audience
Diwan-e Khaas	hall of private audience
doli	palanquin, litter
dom	cremation worker; scavenger
domni	woman singer or dancer belonging to a caste that converted to Islam from the Hindu *dom* caste
dona	cup made of dried leaves
Drupad	also known as Yajnasena, the king of southern Panchal
Durga Path	recitation of the holy book of Durga. Chanting her name is known to ward off evil

	spirits and ghosts
Ekadashi	eleventh day of the lunar fortnight; some pious Hindus observe a fast on that day
gajra	flower garland worn by women on festive occasions
garach	medicinal herb
garib	poor
gathborna	medicinal herb
gauna	the ceremony of a wife being taken to her husband's home
Gayatri Mantra	A hymn of twenty-four syllables chanted in the name of Goddess Savitri or Durga
ghunghat	veil
gilli-danda	Indian tip-cat
godaan	the Hindu practice of offering a cow to a Brahmin after the death of a family member. It was believed that by doing that the soul of the departed would find peace and go to heaven
*gopi*s	maidens of Vrindavan in love with Krishna
griha pravesh	house-warming
gurumata	wife of a teacher, treated like a mother
halvai	sweet vendor; confectioner
Hanuman Chalisa	forty verses in praise of Lord Hanuman
harira	concoction made from several ingredients such as ghee, jaggery, cumin nuts, turmeric powder and dry ginger powder. It is part of the postnatal diet of a woman which provides her wholesome nutrition
havan *kund*	sacred pit where sacrificial fires are lit
Ibn-e-Sina	Avicenna, a Persian polymath
idgah	prayer ground where Muslims gather for the Eid congregation
ilaka	region; estate
imarti	sweetmeat
Ism-e Aazam	Muslim prayer to ward off evil
jagir	feudal land grant under the *jagirdari* system to officials during the Mughal period. Tenants were supposed to be under the servitude of the jagirdar
jagirdar	holder of a jagir
janaab	sir
janeyu	sacred thread worn from adolescence by Hindu males of the upper three community groups
Janmashtami	festival that celebrates the birth of Krishna
janwasa	temporary dwelling for a marriage party
Jauhar	custom of collective self-immolation by Rajput women to save themselves from dishonour
Jeth, Jaishta	second month of the Hindu calendar corresponding to May–June
Kaachhi	community of market gardeners, a member of the Kaachhi community
kaans	*Saccharum spontaneum*, a perennial grass growing up to three metres in height with spreading rhizomatous roots

kachcha	raw
kachnar	a tree, also known as orchid tree, camel's foot tree and mountain ebony
Kahar	member of Hindu sub-caste whose duties include carrying palanquins and drawing water
kaharin	woman Kahar
kaka	uncle; near-and-dear acquaintance
Kaala Paani	lit. black water; Cellular Jail
kamandal	an oblong water pot made of a dry gourd, metal, wood or clay, usually with a handle and sometimes with a spout. Hindu ascetics often use it for storing drinking water
kanthi	ornament like choker
kanyadaan	ritual of giving away a daughter in marriage
karha	bangle
karhai	pan
Kayastha	members of the scribe caste, traditionally known as keepers of public records and accounts, writers, and administrators of the state
kesar	saffron plant
khaddar	homespun cloth, popularized by Mahatma Gandhi
khangar	member of a semi-tribal community who earned livelihood by carpentry
kharau	clogs; wooden footwear
khasdaan	portmanteau, betel dish or box with cover
khudkasht	land cultivated by owner
khus	fragrant grass; khus coolers made of sweet-smelling herbs and hung like a screen or mat over windows and doors for the natural cooling of air used in India
kolhu	oil press drawn by bullocks
kos	length of approximately three miles
Kshatriya	warrior caste
kulvadhu	housewife
kundan	fine gold
Kunwar	honorary title traditionally associated with feudal Rajputs, such as the son of a rana or thakur
Kunwar	month of Kartik in the Hindu calendar roughly corresponding to October–November
Kurmi	Hindu agricultural caste in India
lagaan	rent payable or accruing on land
lagan	auspicious moment for performing a sacred task; horoscope
lambardar	village headman who collects revenue and acts as a link between the government and the people
leela	inscrutable ways of God
lota	small round metal pot
Maagh	tenth month of the Hindu calendar roughly corresponding to January–February
maata	mother; goddess
mahtab	special kind of firecrackers
makoh	*Solanum nigrrum*

maktab	school
malida	sweets
malin	gardener's wife
malkin	mistress
mamu	maternal uncle (mother's brother)
mandap	temporary pavilion erected to conduct the marriage ceremony
mansabdar	member of the imperial bureaucracy of the Mughal empire in India. The mansabdars governed the empire and commanded its armies in the emperor's name
marsiya	an elegy
maryada	honour
mauza	site, place or village
Meghdoot	variation of *Meghadutam*, a play by Kalidasa
mehfil	lively assembly of people, get-together; musical soirée
mirzai	jacket of coarse cloth
mem	white woman
mistri	worker, generally a fitter
moha	longing for worldly attachments
mujra	nautch performance
mukhtar	pleader
mukhtar-e aam	representative who holds a general power of attorney of the zamindar
mundan	tonsure
munim	accountant
munna	little darling, children are commonly addressed as 'munna' (for a boy) or 'munni' (for a girl)
munn	precious gem found inside a snake. According to popular belief, a snake possessing the gem takes it out and goes sniffing around for food. On returning, it swallows the gem. Picking up the gem, which is a risky endeavour that might cost a person his life, will lead to being blessed with untold wealth
nagin	female cobra
nainsukh	fine muslin
na-mehram	a stranger before whom a Muslim woman is forbidden to appear unveiled
nazrana	offering
neochchawar	ward off evil
ojha	sorcerer
ood	aloe wood; emits fragrance when it burns
paanigrahan	marriage
pakwaan	special kind of fried sweets prepared on festivals
Panch Parameshwar ki jai	long live the panchayat
panditayin	female counterpart of a pandit; wife of a pandit
papiha	brain fever bird

pativrata	wife who attains spiritual status through devotion to her husband
pattal	leaf plate
Parvez	emperor of Persia
pasi	toddy extractors
patwari	village recorder
payis	measure of land
peshkaar	officer in the court
Phagun	eleventh month in the Hindu calendar roughly corresponding to February–March
phulka	plain roti
pind daan	religious ritual performed to bring salvation to the departed soul. Offering the ashes of the deceased into the Ganges and feeding the poor constitute essential components of this ceremony
pitambar	lit., yellow garment; used as another name of the Hindu gods Krishna and Vishnu because of their yellow clothing
pitra-paksha	when rites are performed in honour of ancestors
pooranmasi	full moon
Poos	winter month in the Hindu calendar corresponding to December–January
prakriti	raw nature
purohit	Hindu priest
purush	man
qurbani	ritual sacrifice of animals during Eid
Raghubansa	a variation of *Raghubansam*, a play by Kalidasa
Rathyatra	Hindu festival celebrating the life of Lord Rama
rukhsati	send-off of the bride from her parents' house to her husband's; bringing a wife to her husband's house when she hits puberty
Safeda	variety of mango
samdhi	father of a son-in-law or daughter-in-law; fem: *samdhan*
sandhya	ritual of worship and meditation performed three times a day by Hindus of the higher castes
sanjivani	lit. life-giving; the herb used to revive Lakshman when he fell unconscious in the Ramayana
sankranti	the day when the sun enters a new zodiac sign
sanyas	renunciation
sanskar	good upbringing
sarai	inn
Saraswati	the goddess of learning
sattu	gram powder
Satyanarayan *katha*	religious ritual recounting the story of the acts of kindness of a particular deity, Satyanarayan, representing a form of Lord Vishnu
satyug	the era of justice
saubhagyawati	status of being married and having a husband
saut	co-wife

sejgarhi	wagon often used for carrying small children
sendh	break-in
ser	measure of weight, approximately one kilogram
sethani	wife of a seth
sewaiyaan	sweets; Indian vermicelli
shaligram	sacred stone representing Lord Vishnu
shastras	Hindu holy books
shehnai	musical instrument played during weddings and other occasions
shodashi(n)	a girl of sixteen years, funeral ritual
shradh	in Hinduism, it is the ritual one performs to pay homage to ancestors, especially to dead parents
shuddhi	purification; part of worship in Hinduism; also refers to conversion to Hinduism
sipahi	soldier; constable
somwari amavas	night of the new moon that falls on a Monday
suhaag	auspicious state of being married
surma	kohl
swang	dramatic performance; jest, farce
taat	sackcloth
tehsildar	administrative officer in charge of a tehsil, i.e., subdivision.
talukdar	holder of a taluk, i.e., land estate; zamindar
tam-tam	one-horse carriage, meant to seat two people in front and two in the rear
tanzeb	muslin
tapasvini	female ascetic
tapasya	asceticism
tasmai	roasted vermicelli cooked in milk
Teej	festival where married women keep fasts for the long lives of their husbands
thakurain	wife of a thakur
tibbi	Greek system of medicine
Tiwari	sub-caste of Brahmins in north India
udan khatola	flying saucer
vakula	*Mimusops elengi*; tree with rich foliage
var raksha	engagement
vilayat	the West; Europe
wah-wah	bravo!
yagyopobit	ritual pertaining to sacred thread

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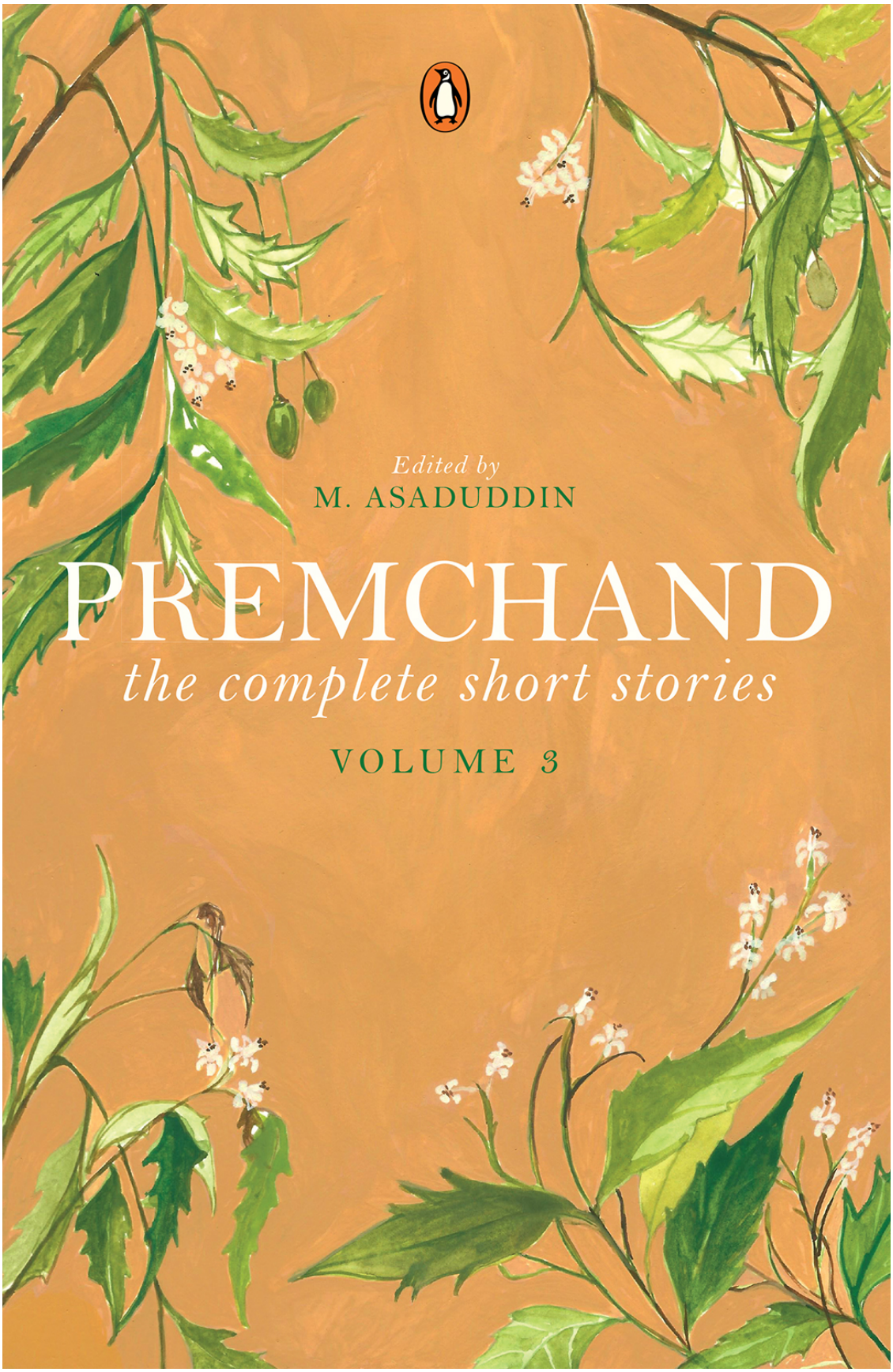
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